

AGE OF MYTHOS

Chapter 2 — Civil War

Maha Parva · English Edition

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Arunodaya Kshetra

Tawang. The first Tuesday of September. Five-forty a.m. The eastern ridge above the Tawang Monastery at three thousand four hundred metres altitude. The first eastern light is forming behind the Bhutan-border ranges; the sky is rose at the horizon, deepening to indigo at the zenith.

Udayagiri is at the ridge-stone. He is thirty-one. He is in the dawn-walker robe, knee-length, deep amber, with the gayal-hide sash at his waist. He carries the Uday-spear — the dawn-forged spear his line has carried for four hundred and seven years, re-forged each dawn in the first light's heat. The spear's shaft is hill-bamboo; the head is a thin double-edged copper-alloy blade; the binding is gayal-leather wrapped in twelve turns. He has been at the ridge-stone every dawn for two thousand seven hundred and forty-eight consecutive days.

The first-light arrives at five-forty-three a.m. He turns the spear's blade-edge to the east. The blade catches the first ray. The metal warms in his hand — the daily re-forging that the saga's gayal-bond performs at the moment-of-light. He greets the dawn aloud in Apatani-Adi-Galo — the three-tribe ceremonial trade-tongue that has been Arunodaya-Kshetra's greeting-language for six centuries.

He says, into the morning air: "The dawn cannot be stopped. The kingdom is greeted. The day is begun."

The three-tribe trade-tongue is heard, as it has been heard every morning for six centuries, by approximately four hundred dawn-walkers across the kingdom — one ridge-elder per tribal sub-village — performing the same greeting at the same minute at their own local first-light. The greetings overlap across the time-zone-staggered ridges; the kingdom-net of dawn-walkers covers the state in concentric expanding light-rings from east to west across about thirty-eight minutes (the time it takes the first-light to walk from the Roing eastern ridge at the Mishmi Hills to the Tawang western ridge at the Bhutan border).

Udayagiri completes his greeting at five-forty-five a.m. He returns down the ridge-trail to the monastery's administrative wing where the kingdom's morning-council convenes at six. The morning-council is a thirty-minute briefing with the senior administrative monk Sonam-Lama-Bumla (no relation to Sikkim's Sonam at Rumtek; the name Sonam is common across the Karmapa-and-Tawang lineages), the state-government district

magistrate's representative, and the three regional dawn-walker captains (Lower Subansiri, Anjaw, and West Kameng).

At the morning-council Sonam-Lama-Bumla raises a single new agenda-item: "The Tawang night-cult has grown to eleven hundred members. The new membership in the past fortnight is three hundred and twelve. The growth-rate is accelerating, not stabilising. The fourteenth-month threshold the night-cult appears to have set has been crossed. We must address it at the kingdom-level. Today."

Udayagiri sets down the tea-cup he had just lifted to his mouth. He has been hearing about the night-cult for fourteen months. He has approached it the way he approaches every shadow that forms inside the kingdom: more dawn, more first-light walks, more institutional outreach. He has personally led six morning-walks for war-trauma survivors over the past year. The morning-walks have helped no one. The walkers have politely attended; some have cried at the first-light moment; none have returned.

The night-cult has been growing, in those fourteen months, by approximately fifteen new members per week. The eleven-hundred-member threshold means the cult is now larger than five of the kingdom's twenty-six recognised village-clusters.

He says, into the council chamber: "The Comforter. Has he been seen. Confirmed seen."

Sonam-Lama-Bumla says: "Three times in the last six weeks. The Sela Pass shadow-zone. Always in the late afternoon, two hours before sunset, when the pass-shadow is at maximum extent. Always speaking to the Galwan-veterans first — the 2020 survivors. Then the Tawang-clash bereaved, the 2022 families. Then the Ziro forest-fire burned, the 2024 survivors. The pattern is consistent. He is finding the wounds the kingdom's dawn-walks have not reached."

Udayagiri says: "Description. Voice. Build. Gait."

Sonam-Lama-Bumla says: "Forty-four. Tall. Soft-voiced. Speaks Hindi and Apatani-Adi-Galo and what one of the older clash-veterans described as 'cave-Tibetan' — the dialect spoken in the deep-cave-system the kingdom's northern border touches. Walks slowly. Sits with people. Listens for hours before speaking. When he speaks the listeners report a sense of being seen. The sense is the cult's primary recruitment-vehicle. They are not joining a doctrine. They are joining a man who finally heard them."

Udayagiri does not respond for thirty seconds.

He says: "Is he Asta-Asura."

Sonam-Lama-Bumla says: "The cave-Tibetan dialect is the indicator. So is the listening-pause. So is the height. The kingdom has not seen Asta-Asura since the cave-system battle nine years ago. The description matches."

Asta-Asura is, by the kingdom's oldest dawn-walker commentary tradition, Udayagiri's own shadow split off at the moment of his birth. He was born — that is, came into separate existence — in the first second of Udayagiri's first dawn-greeting at the Tawang ridge thirty-one years ago, when the infant Udayagiri's shadow cast eastward by the rising sun did not retract when the sun cleared the ridgeline. The shadow remained. It walked away. It grew. By the time Udayagiri was nine years old the shadow was a fully separate person, living in the deep-cave-system that runs beneath the Bhutan-Arunachal border, ten kilometres north of the Tawang valley.

The shadow had a face. The face was Udayagiri's face inverted — the same bone-structure, but the planes of light and dark reversed. Where Udayagiri's cheek caught the morning sun, Asta-Asura's cheek was in deeper shadow. Where Udayagiri's eye reflected the dawn, Asta-Asura's eye absorbed it.

In Chapter One Udayagiri had not fought Asta-Asura directly. The Ch 1 antagonist had been the elder sister Tamasi, taken from the family at age three by raiders from across the northern border, raised in the cave-system that had become Asta-Asura's territory. Tamasi's suffering and Asta-Asura's growth had occurred along the same cave-system but on different lineage-axes — she by human trauma, he by metaphysical detachment. At the Chapter One climax Tamasi had retreated deeper into the cave-system with the surviving cave-dwellers; Asta-Asura had vanished from sight altogether, his location unconfirmed for nine years.

He has now reappeared at the Tawang night-cult's recruitment-zone in the form of the Comforter. The reappearance is the chapter's first event.

Week two of the chapter. Tawang Sela-Pass shadow-zone — the wide afternoon-shadow that the four-thousand-one-hundred-metre Sela ridge casts down into the upper Tawang valley from about three p.m. to sunset. The shadow-zone is roughly four kilometres long and two kilometres wide. The temperature inside the shadow is approximately seven degrees Celsius cooler than the sunlit valley floor.

The night-cult meets at the centre of the shadow-zone at four p.m. on weekdays. The meeting-place is a low wooden platform — about eight metres by six — constructed by the cult members over the past year out of timber recovered from the 2024 Ziro forest-fire's burn-zone. The platform is the cult's only physical structure. It has no walls, no roof. The shadow is the only ceiling. The cult does not call the platform a temple; they call it the listening-floor.

Udayagiri walks to the listening-floor at four-thirty p.m. on the twelfth day of the chapter. He walks alone. He does not carry the Uday-spear (he has left it at the monastery; carrying it into the shadow-zone would be a hostile statement and he is not yet making one). He is in plain Adi-tribe wool with no insignia. He has dressed deliberately. He does not want to be seen as the kingdom's representative; he wants to be seen as a member of the kingdom who has questions.

The cult's outer ring — about three hundred members today, the weekday-low — recognises him at about eighty metres. The recognition propagates inward. By the time he reaches the listening-floor's edge there are perhaps forty cult-members in his immediate line-of-sight, all of them studying him with the careful absence-of-aggression that characterises every interaction inside the shadow-zone. The cult has explicit instructions from the Comforter: "If the dawn-walker comes, do not greet him as opposition. Greet him as a man who has not yet rested. Offer him shade. Do not insist on it."

Asta-Asura is on the listening-floor. He is in plain dark-grey homespun. He is sitting cross-legged at the floor's eastern edge with a Galwan-survivor named Tashi-Norbu (the name Tashi is common in Tawang; this Tashi is a 2020 Galwan veteran, fifty-one years old, missing his left arm below the elbow from the river-stone clash). Asta-Asura has been sitting with Tashi-Norbu for two hours. Tashi-Norbu has been talking for the last forty minutes. Asta-Asura has not spoken during those forty minutes. He has nodded twice.

Udayagiri stops at the listening-floor's western edge. He does not step onto the floor. He waits.

Asta-Asura looks up. He sees Udayagiri.

He says, in plain Hindi, in the Comforter's soft register: "Brother. You have come. Will you sit. There is room at the western edge."

The address is the kingdom's neutral kinship-form — *bhai*, brother, used between strangers across the tribal-line. It carries no doctrinal weight. It is also, in the cave-Tibetan

tradition Asta-Asura learned from, the form used to address a shadow-twin.

Udayagiri does not sit. He stands at the western edge.

He says, in the same plain Hindi, at the same volume: "Comforter. I have come to talk. I will stand. The talking will be brief."

Asta-Asura nods. He gestures to Tashi-Norbu in a way that indicates: Continue when you are ready; this conversation is between brothers; you are welcome to listen or to step off the floor as you choose. Tashi-Norbu stays. He has been silent in his life for a long time; he wants to hear what the dawn-walker will say to the man who finally listened to him.

Udayagiri says: "What you are doing here is real. The grief is real. The shade you are offering is real. The cult members are real. I have come to ask three questions. Will you answer them."

Asta-Asura says: "Yes."

Udayagiri says: "First question. Are you Asta-Asura."

Asta-Asura says: "Yes."

Udayagiri says: "Second question. Are you here to destroy the dawn-walk."

Asta-Asura says: "No."

Udayagiri says: "Third question. What would you ask of the kingdom."

Asta-Asura is silent for about fifteen seconds. He looks at Tashi-Norbu beside him. He looks at the perhaps three hundred cult-members in the shadow-zone around them. He looks at the four-thousand-one-hundred-metre Sela ridge above them. He looks back at Udayagiri.

He says: "I would ask that the kingdom build the room the morning will agree to wait outside of. The room is one room. The morning is the kingdom's vocation. The room is the kingdom's mercy. Build the room and I will be its caretaker. The cult-name will not change — the members have earned the name. The room will be the cult's home and the kingdom's recognised institution. The shade will not be hidden any more. The shade will be administered."

Udayagiri does not respond for a long time.

He says, finally: "I will think."

He turns. He walks back across the shadow-zone toward the sunlit valley floor. The cult-members watch him leave. None of them speaks. Tashi-Norbu, after Udayagiri is about a hundred metres west of the listening-floor, says to Asta-Asura: "Comforter-la. Will he build the room."

Asta-Asura says: "He will. The brother does not yet know he will. He will know in about five weeks."

Week three. Above the cloud-line at four thousand two hundred metres on the Sela ridge's northern face. The hermit's shelter — a single stone hut three metres by two, no door (the wind does not enter at this altitude in this orientation), a single low entrance, a butter-lamp inside, a small stove, no other furniture. Baba Parashar has lived in the shelter for forty-one years.

Baba Parashar is sixty-eight. He is in faded saffron robes, wool socks, no shoes. He has not descended below the cloud-line since 1985. He speaks to the clouds. The clouds report the weather-patterns of the entire subcontinent to him as patterns of vapour-shape. He interprets the patterns as metaphors. His prophecies are weather-forecasts in metaphor and they are always accurate. He has been Udayagiri's mentor since Udayagiri was twelve. Udayagiri climbs to the shelter approximately twice a year. The climb takes three days from Tawang.

Udayagiri arrives at the shelter at dusk on the seventh day after the listening-floor conversation. He carries one wool blanket, one small bag of tsampa-and-tea, one small bottle of mustard-oil, no spear (he never carries the spear above the cloud-line; the daily re-forging requires the dawn-light, which the cloud-line interrupts). He has been thinking about Asta-Asura's offer for seven days. The thinking has produced no clarity. He has climbed for clarity.

Baba Parashar is at the shelter's entrance when Udayagiri arrives. He is looking northwest at a low cloud-bank that is forming over the Bhutan-border ranges. He does not turn at Udayagiri's arrival. He waves toward the stove.

He says, in Apatani-Adi-Galo: "Make the tea. Three cups. The third is for the cloud that arrives at midnight. The cloud is bringing news from the Lower Subansiri."

Udayagiri makes the tea. He boils the water on the stove with a small handful of pine-needle kindling. He pours three cups. He places the third at the shelter's entrance for the midnight cloud.

He sits beside Baba Parashar at the entrance.

He says: "Baba-la. The Comforter has asked the kingdom to build a room. The room would hold managed shade alongside the dawn. The cult would be its caretakers. The kingdom would recognise the cult institutionally. I have been thinking for seven days. I do not know whether to build the room or to refuse it."

Baba Parashar does not respond immediately. He watches the northwest cloud-bank for about three minutes. The cloud-bank is moving slowly south-east; the cloud's shape is a long thin ribbon with a slight curve at the western end.

He says, finally: "The cloud at the western end is curved because the wind at four thousand metres is pushing it down and the wind at three thousand metres is holding it up. The cloud is being shaped by two opposing winds. The cloud does not choose between them. The cloud holds both shapes at once and the result is the curve. The curve is the cloud's honest answer."

He pauses. He sips the tea.

He says: "Your kingdom is being shaped by two opposing winds. The first wind is the kingdom's six-century-old vocation of dawn-walking. The second wind is the eleven hundred unhealed members of the night-cult, plus the seventeen thousand five hundred war-trauma survivors and bereaved families and burned forest-survivors who have not joined the cult only because they do not yet know it exists. The first wind is the kingdom's vocation. The second wind is the kingdom's wound. You cannot push the second wind back to the cave-system; the wound is already inside the kingdom. You cannot push the first wind aside; the vocation is the kingdom's name. The honest answer is the curve."

Udayagiri says: "Build the room."

Baba Parashar says: "Build the room. But understand the cost. The dawn-tribes will not forgive you for three or four generations. The night-cult will follow you only as long as the Comforter follows the agreement. Both factions will believe you have surrendered to the other. The kingdom will not understand the curve as the honest answer for at least a decade. You will be the dawn-walker who built the first shadow. The history-books in your lifetime will record this as your shame. The history-books in your great-grandchildren's lifetime will record this as the kingdom's saving. You will not be alive for the second history-book. You will live with the first one."

Udayagiri sits with the tea-cup at his lips for about a minute without drinking.

He says: "Will you come down with me. Will you announce the room from the dawn-walker's side. The dawn-tribes will not accept it from me alone. They will accept it from you."

Baba Parashar does not respond for thirty seconds.

He says: "Yes. I will come down. I have been above the cloud-line for forty-one years. I am due to descend. The kingdom requires it. I will descend tomorrow at first light. I will walk to the Tawang valley pass with you. I will speak at the kingdom-council. I will say what I have said to you. The dawn-tribes will hear me. The night-cult will hear me. The kingdom will hear me."

He pauses. He looks at the northwest cloud-bank again. The cloud-bank has moved further south-east and the curve at the western end has deepened.

He says: "The cloud is telling me one more thing. Both factions will be carrying weapons at the pass tomorrow. The cloud cannot tell me which faction will fire first. The cloud can only tell me that whoever stands at the centre of the pass between the two factions will be the cloud-shape's curve. The curve does not survive being shaped by two opposing winds. The cloud knows this. The cloud is telling me anyway."

Udayagiri says: "Baba-la. Then I will stand at the centre. Not you."

Baba Parashar says: "No. You are the dawn-walker. The kingdom needs you alive on the other side of the curve. The curve needs a different body. The cloud has told me whose body. The cloud is honest. The cloud is also kind. The cloud has given me a forty-one-year warning. I have had enough warning. I will stand at the centre. You will stand at the dawn-tribe's line, ten paces from me. You will not move when the arrows arrive. You will let me be the curve. The dawn will be your teacher in this matter and the cloud will be mine."

The midnight cloud arrives. The third tea-cup is drunk by the cloud. Udayagiri does not see the drinking but the cup is empty at one a.m. when he checks it. The cloud's news from the Lower Subansiri is that the Lower Subansiri night-cult subsidiary has reached six hundred members; the news confirms the cult is no longer a Tawang-local phenomenon. The kingdom needs the room within the month.

Udayagiri sleeps three hours. They begin the descent at four a.m.

Week three, day three. The Tawang valley pass at three thousand three hundred metres altitude — the principal valley-crossing between the eastern dawn-tribe villages and the western Sela-Pass shadow-zone where the night-cult meets. The pass is the kingdom's natural geographical division between the two communities.

Baba Parashar has descended below the cloud-line for the first time in forty-one years. The descent has taken him eleven hours; he is at the pass by three p.m. He is exhausted but composed. His feet, unused to walking at altitudes below four thousand metres, are blistered. He has refused medical attention. He says he will rest after the council.

The kingdom-council has been convened on a Thursday-emergency basis. The eastern dawn-tribe representatives are arrayed on the pass's eastern edge — about a hundred dawn-walker captains and tribe-elders from the thirteen recognised sun-tribes. They are armed with traditional dawn-walker spears (long copper-headed, eastern-light forged); some carry modern rifles purchased through the state-government's tribal-defence allocation. The night-cult representatives are arrayed on the pass's western edge — about a hundred and twenty cult-members. They are not armed with traditional weapons (the cult forbids them) but a significant minority carry modern hunting-rifles. The rifles are not officially cult-sanctioned but the cult's senior delegates have not confiscated them.

The pass itself — the open ground between the two edges — is about sixty metres wide and a hundred and twenty metres long. It is empty.

Baba Parashar walks alone to the centre of the pass at three-fifteen p.m. Udayagiri stops at the eastern edge, ten paces from the dawn-tribe representatives' front rank. Sonam-Lama-Bumla stops beside Udayagiri. Tashi-Norbu the Galwan-veteran has come from the western edge and stops at the night-cult representatives' front rank.

Baba Parashar reaches the centre. He stops. He raises his right hand. The gesture is the dawn-walker's neutral-address gesture — palm forward, fingers spread, held at eye-level.

He speaks. He speaks in Apatani-Adi-Galo, then repeats each sentence in cave-Tibetan, then repeats each sentence in Hindi. The triple-language address takes about twelve minutes.

He says: "Kingdom of the rising sun. Children of the dawn-walk. Children of the listening-floor. I have come down from the cloud-line for the first time in forty-one years because the kingdom requires that I come down. The kingdom is being shaped by two opposing winds. The first wind is the dawn-vocation. The second wind is the kingdom's wound. The

honest answer is the curve. The curve is the building of the room the morning will agree to wait outside of. The room will be built at Tawang in the eleventh week of this chapter. The night-cult will be its caretakers. The dawn-walkers will recognise it institutionally. The kingdom-council will register the cult as the Order of the Dawn-Shadow Temple. The Comforter will be the Temple's shade-master. Udayagiri will be the Temple's dawn-master. Tani-of-the-Veil —"

He pauses. He has not yet been introduced to Tani-of-the-Veil. He has been told her name by the cloud. He says it for the first time.

"Tani-of-the-Veil will be the Temple's translator between the two masters. The kingdom-council registers the Temple by my authority as the senior cloud-speaker of the kingdom. The registration is effective at the moment of this address's completion. The dawn-tribes will accept the registration because the cloud-speaker has authority over kingdom-institutional matters under the kingdom's six-century-old founding charter. The night-cult will accept the registration because the Comforter has agreed to the architecture in advance. The kingdom is now whole in the curve."

He lowers his right hand.

The eastern dawn-tribe's third-rank archer — an unnamed twenty-three-year-old dawn-walker who has been at the Tawang clash in 2022 and has lost his elder brother and his cousin in the same hour — raises his bow at three-twenty-seven p.m. He has not been authorised to fire. His bow-arm is shaking. The arrow is on the string.

The western night-cult's second-rank rifleman — an unnamed thirty-one-year-old Ziro forest-fire survivor whose grandmother died in the second-day burn-wave and whose face is half-scarred from the same fire — raises his rifle at three-twenty-seven p.m. He has not been authorised to fire. His finger is on the trigger. The rifle is unsafetied.

Neither faction's senior delegates see the raising. Neither faction's discipline-officer intervenes.

The dawn-walker fires the arrow at three-twenty-seven-thirty-eight p.m. The arrow travels approximately fifty-five metres at an initial velocity of fifty-four metres per second.

The rifleman fires the bullet at three-twenty-seven-forty-two p.m. The bullet travels approximately forty-eight metres at an initial velocity of seven hundred and forty metres per second.

The arrow reaches Baba Parashar's chest at three-twenty-seven-thirty-nine-point-one p.m. The arrowhead enters between the third and fourth ribs on the right side and pierces the right lung at a depth of about eleven centimetres.

The bullet reaches Baba Parashar's back at three-twenty-seven-forty-two-point-three p.m. The bullet enters between the seventh and eighth thoracic vertebrae and exits through the upper-left abdomen.

Baba Parashar is dead at three-twenty-eight-fourteen p.m. The death is approximately thirty-six seconds after the first arrow.

The pass is silent for about eighteen seconds. Then both senior delegate-lines move forward simultaneously to apprehend their own shooters. The dawn-walker is restrained at three-twenty-eight-forty p.m. by Sonam-Lama-Bumla and two dawn-tribe elders. The rifleman is restrained at three-twenty-eight-forty-five p.m. by the night-cult's discipline-officer Karma-Norbu (no relation to Tashi-Norbu).

Udayagiri walks to the centre of the pass at three-twenty-nine-twelve p.m. He kneels beside Baba Parashar's body. He does not weep. He places his right palm above his teacher's forehead in the dawn-walker's farewell gesture. He says, in plain Apatani-Adi-Galo, audibly to the eastern and western edges: "The curve has held. The cloud was honest. The cloud was kind. The forty-one-year warning was the cloud's last gift."

Asta-Asura walks to the centre of the pass at three-twenty-nine-thirty p.m. He arrives from the western edge unarmed. He kneels at the opposite side of the body from Udayagiri. He places his right palm above his own forehead and lowers it — the cave-Tibetan farewell gesture, mirror to the dawn-walker's.

The two men do not look at each other. They look at the body.

Asta-Asura says, in cave-Tibetan, then in Hindi: "Brother. The kingdom has begun the room with this man's body at its first cornerstone. We will build the room. We will name the man at the consecration. We will not let his name fade. The cloud was right. The curve was honest. The kingdom needed this man's body. I am not glad. I will help."

Udayagiri does not respond. He stays at the centre of the pass with the body until Sonam-Lama-Bumla and Karma-Norbu jointly arrange the stretcher and the carrying party. The body is carried up to the cloud-line that night for cremation in the traditional dawn-walker manner; Asta-Asura and three of his senior cult-delegates accompany the cremation party.

The cremation is performed at first light the following morning by Udayagiri and Asta-Asura together — the first joint act across the faction-line. The ashes are divided equally; half are scattered above the cloud-line at the hermit's shelter; half are returned to the Tawang valley and interred at the future Dawn-Shadow Temple site as the cornerstone.

The two shooters are arrested by the Sikkim-Arunachal joint district-magistrate's order at six p.m. that evening. Their trials are referred to the Arunachal High Court under regular criminal jurisdiction. Both men plead guilty within eleven days. Both serve fifteen-year sentences. Neither faction publicly defends the shooter. The kingdom's common position, articulated by Sonam-Lama-Bumla at the post-pass press conference: "The two shooters are the kingdom's failure to heal in time. They are not the kingdom's representatives. They are the kingdom's unhealed."

Week four. Tawang valley. The morning after the cremation. Tani-of-the-Veil arrives at the monastery's administrative wing at five-thirty a.m.

She is twenty-nine. She is a Galo-tribe woman from the Aalo district originally; she had been at the 2022 Tawang clash front-line as a battlefield medic with the Indian Army's Arunachal Scouts; she had pulled seven wounded soldiers off the river-stone before being struck herself by a flying piece of granite and losing the sight in her right eye. She had been with the night-cult for thirteen months. She had served as Asta-Asura's primary interpreter at the listening-floor — she was the only cult-member fluent in all four of the cult's working languages (Apatani-Adi-Galo, cave-Tibetan, Hindi, and English).

She is in the night-cult's plain dark-grey homespun. She has a black wool veil draped across the right side of her face from temple to chin, covering the scarred right eye-socket and the surrounding tissue. The veil is held by a small silver clip at her right temple. The veil is the source of her cult-name: Tani-of-the-Veil. She has worn the veil since the cult's third month.

She walks into the monastery's administrative wing alone, unannounced, having travelled from the Sela-Pass shadow-zone overnight on foot. She has not been authorised by the cult to make the journey. The cult's senior delegates do not yet know she has come.

She finds Udayagiri at the morning-tea station. He is alone — the morning-council has been postponed by three hours in observance of mourning. He looks up.

She says, in plain Hindi, in a steady administrative-voice: "Dawn-Walker-la. I am Tani-of-the-Veil. The cloud-speaker named me yesterday at the pass. I have come to learn what the

naming means."

Udayagiri sets down the tea-cup he has just lifted. He looks at her for about ten seconds. He sees the veil. He sees the steady voice. He sees the absence of cult-doctrine in the address.

He says: "Sit, sister. The tea is fresh."

She sits. She accepts the tea. She does not speak again until the tea-cup is empty.

She says, finally: "The naming means I am the translator. The cloud-speaker said the kingdom needs a translator between the dawn-master and the shade-master at the Temple. I am willing to be the translator if the kingdom is willing to receive me. The cult is willing to release me to the role if you formally request it of the Comforter; the request must come from your side because the cult's rule against unilateral defection requires that any cross-over be initiated by the receiving institution, not by the defector. The Comforter will agree to the release. He told me last night, before the cremation. He named the cloud's seeing as authority enough."

Udayagiri says: "Why you. Why this role."

She says: "Because I am the only cult-member who has lived in both worlds. I was at the Tawang clash, in the morning light, holding wounded men's arteries closed with my hands. I was at the listening-floor, in the afternoon shadow, holding wounded men's grief without trying to close it. The two practices are the same practice in two languages. The translator the kingdom needs is the one who has learned both languages by doing them. I am the only person currently alive in the kingdom who has done both."

He says: "The Tani in your name. The Adi-tribe creator-figure. Are you claiming descent from him."

She says: "The Tani in my name is from the cult. The Comforter named me Tani-of-the-Veil because the Adi-creator Tani was the first man to walk through the world before the world had been finished. The first man saw both the unfinished light and the unfinished dark. The veil is not the Adi-creator; the veil is the medic's veil — what I wear over the eye that the clash took. The two meanings are joined in the cult's naming-tradition. I have used the name for thirteen months. I will keep it. The kingdom may keep it."

He says: "The role is yours. I will make the formal request to the Comforter this afternoon. The request will be by Sarus-pigeon. The cremation has not yet officially ended; in-person

travel between the factions is suspended for the seven-day mourning period; the pigeon is the correct channel. The Comforter will release you by tomorrow evening. The kingdom-council will register your appointment on the third day after the mourning. The Temple's consecration is set for the eleventh week. You will work between the cult's senior delegates and the monastery's administrative wing during the seven-week build-out. You will translate at every joint meeting. You will train successors. By the time of the Sanctuary convening in Chapter Three you will have trained two more translators — one from each faction. The kingdom will not depend on a single bridge."

She says: "Yes."

He says: "Sister. The veil. Will you ever lift it."

She says, after about a half-minute's pause: "The veil is the eye the kingdom took. I will not hide that the kingdom took it. I will also not insist that the kingdom keep looking at the absence. The veil is the room I have built around my own wound. It is not unlike the room you are about to build. I will lift the veil at the Temple's consecration. I will lift it once. The kingdom will see the eye-socket. The kingdom will know what the room is for. Then I will replace the veil and continue the work. The single lifting will be the kingdom's permanent record of the wound the Temple is the answer to."

He says: "Yes."

The eleven-week build-out of the Dawn-Shadow Temple begins on the eighth day after Baba Parashar's cremation. The site is a half-hectare plot adjacent to the Tawang Monastery's western boundary, donated jointly by the monastery's administrative wing and the night-cult's shadow-zone-platform-land-trust.

The architectural design is the cloud-shape's curve. The Temple is a single oval enclosed structure, forty-two metres long along the east-west axis, eighteen metres wide along the north-south axis. The eastern half of the oval is the dawn-room — open to the eastern sky, no roof, walls only at the southern and northern arcs, the dawn-walkers' greeting-stone at the eastern apex. The western half is the shade-room — fully roofed in dark slate, ventilated through small north-and-south slit-vents, the listening-floor's timber re-installed at the western apex (the timber the night-cult had built the original outdoor listening-floor from). The two rooms meet at a central transition-arch — a low stone arch about three metres wide, one metre seventy high, which a person can walk through but cannot run through. The arch is the cloud-curve made architectural.

The build-out employs approximately three hundred workers — one hundred and fifty drawn from the dawn-tribe villages, one hundred and fifty from the night-cult. The two work-crews are arranged in mixed pairs by Tani-of-the-Veil's assignment rota; she insists that no pair contain two members from the same faction. The pairs work side-by-side for the full eleven weeks. By the third week the pairs have begun eating together at the site's noon-meal. By the seventh week the pairs have begun walking to and from the site together at dawn and at dusk. By the eleventh week three of the pairs have requested the kingdom-council's permission to formalise civil-partnership arrangements; the council approves all three.

The kingdom-council's registration of the Order of the Dawn-Shadow Temple is filed on the fourteenth day after Baba Parashar's cremation. The registration document, drafted by Tani-of-the-Veil and counter-signed by Udayagiri, Asta-Asura, Sonam-Lama-Bumla, and the district-magistrate, runs to seven pages. The first page establishes the Order as the kingdom's seventeenth recognised religious institution. The second page sets out the dawn-master and shade-master arrangement. The third page sets out the translator's standing role. The fourth page sets out the eleven-week consecration schedule. The fifth page sets out the long-term cross-faction-pair work-rota. The sixth page sets out the Karna-shadow elder's name as the Temple's cornerstone — Baba Parashar of the Cloud-Line, forty-one years above the cloud-line, dawn-walker by tradition, cloud-speaker by vocation, killed at the Tawang valley pass at three-twenty-seven-thirty-nine p.m. on the third day of the third week of this chapter. The seventh page sets out the Temple's succession-procedure for the dawn-master, shade-master, and translator positions on the death or resignation of any incumbent.

The registration is published in the state-government gazette on the seventeenth day. The registration is countersigned by the Manipur, Assam, Nagaland, Meghalaya, and Sikkim NE-Federation registry on the twenty-third day (the cross-kingdom recognition that the new Temple is regionally legitimate, independent of any individual kingdom's ratification).

Week eleven, day three. The Tawang valley. The morning of the Dawn-Shadow Temple's consecration. First light at the eastern apex's greeting-stone is timed for five-forty-three a.m. (the same minute Udayagiri had greeted the dawn at the ridge-stone on the chapter's opening day, eleven weeks earlier; the consecration has been deliberately scheduled to fall on the same first-light minute).

The Temple is fully built. The eastern dawn-room is open to the sky. The western shade-room is fully roofed. The central transition-arch holds the cloud-shape's curve in its stone-line.

The crowd at the consecration is approximately twelve thousand people. The number is unprecedented for any religious event in Arunodaya-Kshetra in the past forty years. The crowd includes approximately three thousand dawn-tribe representatives from all thirteen sun-tribes, approximately one thousand one hundred night-cult members (the full membership, minus about a hundred who are still working at the site as last-minute caretakers), approximately three thousand kingdom-government civil servants and dignitaries, approximately five thousand kingdom-citizens drawn from villages across the state who have travelled to witness, and approximately seventy-five international observers (including the Manipur, Assam, Nagaland, Meghalaya, and Sikkim NE-Federation delegations and four cross-bloodline senior-guardians from the South and Central regions, sent by Krishnadevaraya-Bhrata and Dvadashashringa respectively).

Udayagiri arrives at the eastern apex at five-forty a.m. He is in the dawn-walker robe with the gayal-hide sash. He carries the Uday-spear. He has re-forged the spear that morning at the ridge-stone above the monastery (the daily re-forging continues; the consecration does not change his standing daily discipline).

Asta-Asura arrives at the western apex at five-forty a.m. He is in plain dark-grey homespun — the cult's working garment; he has declined the kingdom-council's offer of a formal shade-master's robe (the offer was made; he had said: "The robe is the kingdom's formal recognition. I am the kingdom's informal mercy. The homespun is the honest answer."). He carries no weapon and no implement. He holds a single small clay bowl of water drawn from the Tawang valley's western stream — the shade-master's consecration-bowl, an invention of the new Order. The bowl will be poured at the transition-arch at the moment of first-light.

Tani-of-the-Veil arrives at the central transition-arch at five-forty-one a.m. She is in plain wool, neutral grey, with the silver-clipped black veil at her right temple. She carries the seven-page registration document in a sealed scroll, with the kingdom's seal and the NE-Federation's seal both visible on the cover. She will read the cornerstone naming at the moment of first-light, in all three languages (Apatani-Adi-Galo, cave-Tibetan, Hindi), in the same sequence Baba Parashar had used at the valley pass eleven weeks earlier.

The first-light arrives at five-forty-three a.m. Udayagiri turns the spear's blade-edge to the east. The blade catches the first ray. The metal warms. Tani-of-the-Veil reads the cornerstone naming. The reading takes about four minutes per language; the full triple-language reading takes twelve minutes.

At the conclusion of the triple-language reading, Asta-Asura pours the clay bowl's water at the transition-arch's threshold. The water flows from west to east across the threshold-stone, then disperses into the gravel of the eastern dawn-room's floor. The dispersion is the cult's ritual symbol for shade meeting light without resistance.

Tani-of-the-Veil lifts the silver clip at her right temple. The black wool veil falls from her face onto her shoulder. The kingdom sees her right eye-socket — empty since 2022, the scarred tissue grey-pink, the bone-orbit visible at its edge. She holds the exposed face still for about fifteen seconds. The kingdom's witnesses include the twelve thousand assembled and the regional television-and-radio broadcasters whose camera-feeds carry the image to about thirty million regional and national viewers in real time. Then she replaces the veil, re-clips it at her right temple, and steps to the side of the arch.

At the moment Tani-of-the-Veil's veil falls and the kingdom sees her eye-socket, Udayagiri feels the gayal-bond pulse through his right pectoral.

The Stage III gayal-foreleg mark begins to form. It begins at the right collarbone in the standard gayal-bond position. It arcs down across the right pectoral as the bull-gayal's right forelimb, with the hoof-impression at the lower edge near the sternum. The mark forms in approximately fourteen seconds beneath the dawn-walker robe. It is not visible to the assembled crowd. Udayagiri feels the formation as a slow warm pressure across the pectoral — the warmth is the gayal-bond's recognition of the concession.

He does not show the moment on his face. He continues the consecration-ceremony per the registration document's schedule. The dawn-room's formal opening-greeting in Apatani-Adi-Galo at five-fifty-five a.m. The shade-room's formal opening-statement in cave-Tibetan at six-oh-five a.m. The transition-arch's combined-language blessing in Hindi at six-fifteen a.m. The crowd's formal entry into both rooms in mixed-faction pairs (organised by Tani-of-the-Veil's pre-arranged rota) at six-twenty a.m. through six-fifty a.m.

By seven a.m. the kingdom is inside the Temple. The dawn-room holds about six thousand people in the open air with the eastern sky above. The shade-room holds about six

thousand people in the slate-roofed interior with the listening-floor's timber beneath. The transition-arch is open; the kingdom passes back and forth through it freely. The cloud-shape's curve is the kingdom's new architecture.

Six-fifty-seven a.m. on the same morning. Roing village in the lower Dibang valley, approximately two hundred and eighty kilometres east of Tawang, at the kingdom's eastern edge. The morning's first-light has reached Roing at five-oh-eight a.m. (the time-zone-staggered ridges' first-light walks east-to-west across the state across thirty-eight minutes). The village is going about its standard Tuesday morning. The Adi-tribe villagers are at the market-square, the schoolteacher's shop, the rice-storehouse, the river-bank.

A man walks into the village from the east at six-fifty-seven a.m. He is dressed in plain Adi-tribe homespun cotton shawl, undyed, no clan-pattern. He is barefoot. He carries nothing. The sun is at an eastern angle of approximately thirty-two degrees above the horizon — the standard mid-morning angle that casts every person, animal, and post-mounted lamp a long westward shadow of about one-point-six times the casting object's height. The man walks at a standard adult pace — about one-point-three metres per second.

He casts no shadow.

The villagers see the no-shadow at about the seventh metre of his progression. The first villager to see it is an eleven-year-old schoolboy named Tashi-Dorjee (the name Tashi is common across the Northeast; this Tashi is unrelated to the Sikkim Tashi-the-cousin and the Sikkim Tashi-Bhutia ranger and the Tawang Tashi-Norbu Galwan-veteran). The schoolboy stops walking. He stares at the dirt-path beneath the man's bare feet. There is no shadow. There is no foot-impression. There is no compression of the dirt.

The schoolboy says, in Adi: "The man has no shadow."

The next villager to see is a thirty-eight-year-old market-vendor named Mami-Bobo. She stops her selling. She stares. There is no shadow.

The next is a sixty-one-year-old elder named Aaba-Tani (the name Tani is the Adi-creator name; Aaba-Tani is "father-Tani" in the Adi honorific). He stops his morning rice-buying. He stares. There is no shadow.

The man walks the length of the village's main path. The path is about eight hundred metres long. He walks the full length at the steady standard pace. The walk takes eleven minutes and approximately fifteen seconds. During the walk approximately a hundred and

thirty villagers see him — he passes their line-of-sight in the eleven-minute window. Each of them sees the no-shadow.

He continues out of the village at the western end. He walks toward the Dibang river. He does not reach the river within the eleven-minute observation-window (the river is about three kilometres west of the village's western edge). He continues at the steady pace beyond the village's line-of-sight. None of the villagers follows him.

Within ninety minutes of his passage, none of the witnesses can remember what he looked like.

They remember he was a man. They remember he was dressed in plain Adi homespun shawl. They remember he was barefoot. They remember he carried nothing. They remember he had no shadow. They remember the no-shadow. They cannot remember his face.

The eleven-year-old Tashi-Dorjee at school during the third hour says, when his teacher asks: "Was he Adi or Galo or Apatani." He answers: "I do not know. I cannot remember." The teacher says: "Was he young or old." He answers: "I do not know. I cannot remember." The teacher says: "Was he tall or short." He answers: "I cannot remember."

The thirty-eight-year-old market-vendor Mami-Bobo tries to draw the face that afternoon. She is a competent amateur-portraitist; she has drawn faces from memory before. She cannot draw this face. She draws three different attempts. None of the three faces resembles either of the others. She destroys all three at sunset.

The sixty-one-year-old Aaba-Tani sits with two other elders at the village-square at dusk and tries to compose a verbal description. The three of them cannot agree on a single feature. The man was tall or short or middle. He was young or old or middle. He was Adi or Galo or Apatani or non-tribal. The face has erased itself from their memory.

By the evening of the same day a Sarus-pigeon-letter reaches Tawang. The letter is from the Roing village-headman to Udayagiri. The letter is two paragraphs long. The first paragraph describes the no-shadow walk. The second paragraph describes the face-erasure. The closing line reads, in Adi: "Dawn-Master-la. The kingdom has been visited by a Herald of the Maw. The Maw has taken a face from the world's memory. We have not seen this before. The kingdom requires that you read the sign at the Temple consecration's evening assembly."

Udayagiri reads the letter at seven p.m. on the consecration day. He is at the Temple's eastern apex with Asta-Asura, Tani-of-the-Veil, Sonam-Lama-Bumla, and the assembled kingdom's evening-prayer attendance.

He reads the letter aloud in Apatani-Adi-Galo and in Hindi. The twelve thousand-still-attending crowd hears it. The NE-Federation delegates hear it. The Krishnadevaraya-Bhrata-and-Dvadashashringa observers hear it. The regional television-and-radio broadcasters carry it.

Udayagiri stands at the eastern apex of the Temple at seven-thirty p.m. on the consecration evening. The dawn-room is open to the deep-evening sky above; the first stars are showing. The shade-room is lit by two hundred and forty butter-lamps arranged along the slate-walls in two long rows. The transition-arch is open; the kingdom passes through it slowly.

He says, in plain Apatani-Adi-Galo, then in cave-Tibetan, then in Hindi:

"Kingdom of the rising sun. Order of the Dawn-Shadow Temple. The Maw has sent its First Herald to Roing. The Herald is a man without a shadow whose face the witnesses cannot remember. The Herald is the Maw's most direct manifestation in human form. The Herald is not killed. The Karnataka rule holds. The Karnataka Third Herald is named the Bronze-Dust Child by a ten-year-old girl. The Goa Second Herald is named Vasco-without-a-ship by a thirty-three-year-old woman at her front step. We do not yet know who will name the First Herald. We do know what we will not do. We will not raise a weapon against him. We will not pursue him to the river. We will not investigate his face. The face is the Maw's erasure; investigating the face is the trap. We will instead build the second Temple. The Second Dawn-Shadow Temple at Roing. The Temple will be the Roing village's answer to the no-shadow walk. The Temple will be the room the Herald will be invited to walk through, when he returns, and to sit in. The Herald will return. The Maw sends Heralds back. The Temple will be ready."

He pauses. He looks at Tani-of-the-Veil at the transition-arch.

He says: "Tani-of-the-Veil will travel to Roing within the fortnight. She will draft the second Temple's registration in consultation with the Roing village-headman and the Lower Dibang district magistrate. The second Temple's caretakers will be drawn from the Roing village itself — a dawn-master from the village's sun-tribe elders and a shade-master from the village's war-trauma-survivor population, with a translator drawn from the village's teacher-or-medic professional class. The Tawang Temple is the kingdom's pilot.

The Roing Temple is the kingdom's first replication. The Maw has chosen Roing as the next site of its experiments. The kingdom will be there before the next experiment."

He pauses again.

He says: "The First Herald will be named when we name him. The naming-tradition the saga has established — from Karnataka and Goa — is that the Herald is named by the person who first recognises him as a Herald-and-not-as-a-threat. The eleven-year-old schoolboy Tashi-Dorjee at Roing is the first witness of the kingdom-side. The naming may come from him. The naming may come from someone else. The kingdom will not rush the naming. The naming is the kingdom's evidence that we have not forgotten the face. The kingdom will look at the face that has been erased and will replace the erasure with a name. The naming may take a week, a month, a year, a decade. The naming is the kingdom's patient work."

Three days after the Tawang consecration, a Sarus-pigeon arrives from the Lower Subansiri. The pigeon is from the Lower Subansiri night-cult subsidiary — the six-hundred-member sub-cult the cloud at the hermit's shelter had described to Baba Parashar at midnight eleven weeks earlier. The letter is from the sub-cult's senior delegate, an Apatani woman named Khoda-Jaya (the name Khoda is from the Apatani creator-line and means "the one who is brought forth").

The letter is short.

Dawn-Master-la. Comforter-la. Translator-la. The Lower Subansiri sub-cult requests admission to the new Order of the Dawn-Shadow Temple. The admission will be subject to the same architecture as the Tawang pilot — a dawn-master to be drawn from the Lower Subansiri Apatani-tribe elders, a shade-master to be drawn from our six-hundred-member sub-cult, a translator to be drawn from the Lower Subansiri medic-and-teacher community. The site we propose is the Hapoli town's eastern hillside — the same hillside the cloud-bank the cloud-speaker had read curves over each morning between four and six a.m. The site is one hectare. The Apatani-tribe-elder council has agreed to the donation provisionally subject to the kingdom-council's ratification. We expect to commence the build-out within the week of ratification.

Sub-cult, Lower Subansiri, — Khoda-Jaya.

The letter is read at the Temple's morning-council on the fourth day after the consecration. The kingdom-council ratifies the Lower Subansiri Temple by unanimous vote at the same

morning-council. The third Temple is begun within the fortnight.

By the end of Chapter Two, three Dawn-Shadow Temples are in active construction across the kingdom: Tawang (consecrated; in full operational use), Roing (the foundations laid; the consecration scheduled for the third month of Chapter Three; built explicitly as the Herald-return room), Lower Subansiri (the foundations laid; the consecration scheduled for the fourth month of Chapter Three). The kingdom's pilot has become the kingdom's replication-program.

Two weeks after the Tawang consecration, a Sarus-pigeon arrives at the Temple from Imphal. The pigeon is the one Moirangthem has been using for the NE-Federation correspondence-network. The letter is from Moirangthem.

The letter reads:

Dawn-Master-la. The NE-Federation has read the Order of the Dawn-Shadow Temple's registration document and the cross-kingdom co-signing has been ratified by all five federation kingdoms. The Sanctuary in Chapter Three will be a six-kingdom assembly: Kamakhya (Kamalavarna), Imphal (Moirangthem, candidate), Shillong (U-Khrawkmen, regent), Kohima (Dzulevira, deferred-vote), Gangtok (Kanchenjunga). Your vote will complete the regional ratification. Will you give it.

Udayagiri writes the reply over two days. The reply is two paragraphs long.

NE Dominant Candidate. I will give my vote at the Sanctuary. The vote will be for you. Arunodaya-Kshetra has stabilised after the First Herald's passage at Roing but the stabilisation is not yet certain — the second Herald-visit will come, and the third, and we do not know when. The Sanctuary's convening will mark the threshold across which the NE Federation will need to coordinate on the Herald-and-Temple-replication question. My vote is for you because you will be the regional voice for that coordination and because your own kingdom's Loktak Mouth-sign has shown us that the Maw is initiating form-making and our Temples are the kingdom-architecture answer.

Sub-paragraph: Tani-of-the-Veil will attend the Sanctuary as my co-translator. She is twenty-nine and will be the Sanctuary's first medic-trained attendee and the first cross-faction-defector co-administrator in the kingdom's history. Asta-Asura will not attend — the cult's self-imposed restriction is that the Comforter does not travel outside the kingdom in his first three years as shade-master. He will remain at Tawang. Sonam-Lama-Bumla will attend as the kingdom's administrative voice.

Dawn-Master-la, — U.

He sends the letter by the same Sarus-pigeon at sunset. Moirangthem receives the letter at Imphal at noon the next day. He writes the one-line reply: The accommodation is arranged. The Sanctuary will receive all three. He sends the reply by the pigeon returning, at dusk.

Six weeks after the Tawang consecration. Roing village. The first foundations of the second Temple have been laid. The Roing village-headman's daughter — a thirteen-year-old girl named Yapum-Mihu — has been appointed the second Temple's translator-in-training under Tani-of-the-Veil's remote supervision. The second Temple's build-out is being managed by a thirty-four-year-old former Tawang-clash medic named Karme-Bobo who has moved from Tawang to Roing for the role.

The First Herald has not yet returned to Roing.

Karme-Bobo has been at the Temple-site at five a.m. each morning for the past three weeks, before dawn, walking the perimeter, reading the village-headman's incident-log from the previous twenty-four hours. The log has recorded no further no-shadow walks. The log has recorded an increase in the village-elder Aaba-Tani's morning-prayers and a small uptick in the village-children's nightmares (Yapum-Mihu records nine children mentioning "a man we cannot remember" in their morning play-conversations over the past week). The Herald is, in some sense, still in the village — the absence of his face is still being felt.

On the third Thursday after the foundations are laid, Yapum-Mihu the thirteen-year-old translator-in-training arrives at the Temple-site at five-fifteen a.m. She has been at the site every dawn since her appointment. She has been quiet during her training. She has not yet been heard to speak more than a few sentences at any one assembly.

She walks up to Karme-Bobo at the site's eastern apex. The first-light is forming behind the Mishmi Hills.

She says, in Adi: "Karme-la. I have thought of a name. The First Herald. I would like to name him. The naming may not be correct. The naming may be revised later. I would like to offer it."

Karme-Bobo says: "Yes, Mihu. What is the name."

She says: "Sahodara-Aapun. The brother-without-self. In Adi. The Adi-creator-line says that Tani — the first man — had a brother who walked beside him through the unfinished world but who did not have a self of his own. The brother held the unfinished part of the world together while Tani gave it form. The brother was forgotten when the world was finished. The Adi children's songs remember him without his face. The songs do not require a face. The name in the songs is Sahodara-Aapun. The Herald is the same. He is the brother who held the unfinished part. We forgot him when the kingdom was named. We are naming him now. The naming may not return him to us. The naming may only remind us that we forgot him. That is what the name will do. It will not retrieve the face. It will hold the place where the face was."

Karme-Bobo says, after a half-minute pause: "Yes. We will send the naming to Tawang today. We will register the name with the kingdom-council on the seventh day. We will read the name at every Temple's morning-greeting. We will hold the place where the face was. The Maw will know that the kingdom did not forget the forgetting."

She nods. She returns to her translator's desk at the Temple-site's preliminary administrative tent. Karme-Bobo writes the naming-letter to Tawang in the next hour. The Sarus-pigeon carries it westward at six-thirty a.m. Tani-of-the-Veil receives it at the Tawang Temple at noon. She walks it to Udayagiri at the eastern apex.

Udayagiri reads the letter. He reads it twice.

He says, to Tani-of-the-Veil: "The First Herald is named. By a thirteen-year-old translator-in-training at Roing. The name is Sahodara-Aapun. The brother-without-self. The kingdom will hold the place where the face was. The Maw will read the kingdom's answer."

He pauses. He looks at the eastern dawn-room's open sky. The sky has begun to cloud over — the first afternoon clouds are forming.

He says: "Baba-la would have said the cloud is honest. The cloud is also kind. The kingdom has built the room. The Herald has been named. The dawn-walker has conceded the shade. The Comforter has accepted the architecture. The translator has lifted the veil. The thirteen-year-old has remembered the brother-without-self. The cloud is curved. The curve has held. The chapter is closing."

He turns the Uday-spear's blade-edge to the east one more time. The afternoon-clouds have begun to gather but the eastern sky is still open at the apex. The blade catches a thin late-afternoon ray. The metal warms.

The kingdom's next sign comes within the week.

The Pilot's Closing Image

A forty-two-metre oval temple at Tawang, the eastern half open to the sky and the western half roofed in dark slate, joined by a low stone arch a person can walk through but cannot run through. A bull-gayal-foreleg mark on a dawn-walker's right pectoral beneath the amber robe. A twenty-nine-year-old translator with a black wool veil clipped at her right temple, the veil lifted once for fifteen seconds at the consecration and then replaced. A forty-four-year-old shade-master in plain dark-grey homespun pouring a clay bowl's water across a threshold-stone from west to east. A sixty-eight-year-old hermit-prophet's ashes scattered above the cloud-line at the hermit's shelter and interred at the Temple's cornerstone in equal halves. A thirteen-year-old Adi translator-in-training at Roing reading the morning-greeting in the Adi creator-line's children's song that remembers the brother-without-self without his face. A man without a shadow walking the eight-hundred-metre length of a village main path at six-fifty-seven a.m., his face erased from the memory of every witness, his name now Sahodara-Aapun in the kingdom's permanent record — the kingdom holding the place where the face was.

Beyul Kshetra

Rumtek Monastery, Gangtok district, twenty-four kilometres south-east of the city. The first week of October. The inner sanctum is a windowless stone chamber three metres by three metres at the back of the main prayer hall. Two butter-lamps burn at the north and south walls. A single low altar of black slate runs along the east wall. On the altar, in a square-cut wooden housing the size of a child's hand, sits the Chintamani — the wish-fulfilling jewel of Avalokitesvara, the Beyul-Kshetra's primary relic, the Hidden Land's heart-stone, the thing that has remained inside this small chamber without a single hour's absence since 1959.

Kanchenjunga is at the altar at four-fifteen a.m. He is forty-one. He has been senior Beyul-guardian at Rumtek for nine years. He is in the dark-red guardian-robe with the seven-fold sash of the Karmapa lineage. His head is shaved. His hands are calloused. He has been in this chamber every dawn for three thousand two hundred and eighty-seven consecutive days.

He sees the Chintamani in its housing. He places his right palm on the altar-edge in the morning's first gesture of recognition. He does not touch the jewel. He has never touched it. No guardian has touched it in sixty-seven years.

He turns and leaves the chamber. The day's schedule is the same as every other day's. Morning prayers at four-thirty. The refugee-blessing line at six. The Tuesday community-kitchen at ten. The Wednesday camp-rotation at the south camp at one. The Thursday and Friday camp-rotations at the central and west camps. The administrative council with the Sikkim state government at five on alternating weeks.

At noon today the monastery will hold a Special Refugee-Blessing Ceremony for newly-arrived refugees from the autumn Tibetan-border surge. Two hundred and twelve refugees are scheduled to receive the blessing in three rotating batches. The Chintamani will be brought into the main prayer hall for the ceremony — not exposed, but carried in its housing on a small ceremonial palanquin from the inner sanctum to the central altar where it will sit visible (in housing) throughout the three-hour ceremony.

This is the procedure. It has been the procedure for sixty-seven years. The Chintamani is brought out four times a year for major blessing-ceremonies. The autumn refugee-blessing is one of those four times.

Twelve thousand. That is the count of refugees currently registered in the three south-Sikkim camps as of the morning of October the first. Approximately two thousand from the autumn Tibetan-border surge alone. Approximately five thousand long-standing Tibetan refugees from the 1959 wave and its descendants. Approximately two thousand from the 2008 Lhasa-unrest wave. Approximately one thousand from various Bhutan-border irregularities. Approximately one thousand identified as "ethnic-mixed" — refugees whose paperwork is unclear and who have therefore been registered as Beyul-Kshetra ward-residents under the monastery's nine-century-old compassion-charter.

The monastery has absorbed every one of them. The compassion-charter, originally written by Padmasambhava's commentators in the eighth century and re-ratified by the Karmapa lineage in 1962, admits no refugee-rejection on any ground. Every applicant is welcomed. Every applicant's family is welcomed if they arrive. Every applicant's political enemy is welcomed too. The Beyul-Kshetra has no enemies. The Beyul-Kshetra is the absence of the question of enemies.

Kanchenjunga has worked within the charter for nine years. He has welcomed two refugee Chinese-state-intelligence agents (identified by central Indian intelligence three months after arrival, then welcomed again as protected ward-residents). He has welcomed one former-Tibetan-monastery-corrupt-treasurer (who confessed to the corruption on his second week and was welcomed exactly as he had been welcomed the first week). He has welcomed a former-state-government Sikkim official accused of land-grab against the Hidden Land's own forest-boundary (welcomed; reabsorbed; placed in the camp-administration cell where his expertise on Sikkim land-records made him the camp's most effective ration-clerk).

He has welcomed all of them. The charter requires it. The charter is not a guideline. The charter is the kingdom.

In the spring of 2024, two and a half years before the chapter's opening, a man in his forties arrived at the south refugee camp with a small backpack and a thirty-page Tibetan-language autobiography written in pencil in a school-exercise book. He gave his name as Krodha-Sherpa. He said he had been born in Pelliang Village in the Tibetan-occupied zone and that his entire family had been killed in a Chinese border-clearance operation in 2018. He had walked out across the Cho La pass alone in the winter of 2022. He had spent the intervening two years in Lhasa-region Buddhist monasteries doing manual labour and waiting for a route to the Indian side.

He was welcomed. The intake clerk — a junior monk named Lobsang — logged him in the camp-administration database at intake-number 9,847. He was assigned to barrack 17-C, bed 3. His ration-card was issued the same afternoon. His autobiography was filed in the camp-archive in box 142 along with eleven hundred other recently-arrived testimonials.

He was organised. He was articulate. He spoke Tibetan-fluent, Hindi-fluent, Nepali-fluent, Sikkimese-Bhutia-fluent. He read Sanskrit and English. He was not a monk, but he had a monk's vocabulary. Within his first three months at the south camp he had started a Tibetan-language literacy class for refugee children whose schooling had been interrupted by the border crossing. Within his first six months he had organised a mutual-aid council across barracks 17 and 18, eight hundred refugees pooling ration-card supplements to support the most dependent among them. Within his first year he was running a weekly assembly for the south-camp's twelve hundred adult-male refugees, called the Compassion-Reciprocity Council, that met every Sunday evening in barrack 17-C's common room.

The other refugees began to call him the Refugee Father. The phrase began informally and became official by the end of his second year. By the autumn of 2026 — the chapter's opening — the Compassion-Reciprocity Council had grown to forty-seven hundred active members across all three south-Sikkim camps. The Refugee Father's Sunday assemblies were attended by more refugees than the monastery's own bi-weekly camp-administration meetings.

Kanchenjunga had visited the Compassion-Reciprocity Council twice. The first visit, eight months earlier, he had sat at the back of the common room and listened to the Refugee Father explain the council's ration-supplement allocation procedures. He had been impressed. The procedures were more efficient than the monastery's. The Refugee Father's administrative grasp was first-rate.

The second visit, three months earlier, he had stayed for the Refugee Father's closing-prayer. The closing-prayer was a Tibetan-language compassion-prayer attributed to the Sixth Karmapa, recited in the modern unision style. Kanchenjunga had joined the recitation. The Refugee Father had stood at the front and led it without faltering.

Kanchenjunga had walked back to the monastery that evening reassured. The kingdom's compassion-charter was producing its expected fruit. The most administratively-capable refugee in the camps was using his capability to multiply the camp's self-care. The Beyul-Kshetra was working.

He had not asked about the backpack. He had not asked about the autobiography. He had not asked the intake clerks for Krodha-Sherpa's pre-2022 history. He had not, in nine years of guardianship, ever asked any refugee about his pre-arrival history. The charter forbade it.

The Special Refugee-Blessing Ceremony begins at noon on the chapter's opening day — the first Sunday of October. Two hundred and twelve new refugees are arranged in three rotating batches of seventy-one, seventy, and seventy-one. The Chintamani is brought into the main prayer hall in its ceremonial palanquin at eleven-forty-five a.m. and placed on the central altar. The housing is opened to half-visibility — the jewel's side is exposed to the assembled refugees but not its top or its underside (the orthodox half-disclosure that has been the ceremonial standard since 1959).

The hall holds about a thousand people. Two hundred and twelve refugees in the batch-area at the front. Six hundred and ninety long-standing camp residents and monastery monks at the rear. Approximately a hundred state-government and visiting-observer guests in a side gallery on the north wall. The Refugee Father is in the front row of the rear seating, beside the senior Compassion-Reciprocity Council delegates.

Kanchenjunga performs the blessing in the standard procedure. Each refugee approaches the altar in turn, bows three times, receives the Chintamani-touched compassion-water from the senior monk's ladle on the right of the altar, drinks it, returns to the seating area. The procedure takes about thirty-five seconds per refugee. Seventy-one refugees per batch. Three batches. The ceremony is scheduled to end at three p.m.

At one-fourteen p.m., during the second batch, between refugee forty-three and refugee forty-four, the hall's south-wall butter-lamps flicker. The flicker lasts about two seconds. Both lamps. Simultaneously. The hall's ventilation does not normally produce flickers of this kind in the south-wall lamps; the prevailing draft at noon enters from the north door. Several of the monastery's senior monks notice the flicker; none stops the ceremony; the flicker is logged later as "atmospheric."

At one-forty-seven p.m. the second batch concludes. The hall enters its standard fifteen-minute interval for the seating-rotation. Two senior monks remain at the central altar. The Chintamani is still in its half-opened housing. The Refugee Father stands and walks slowly toward the south-wall butter-lamp — the one that had flickered — ostensibly to adjust the wick. He bows to the senior monk at the south side of the altar in passing. The senior monk — Lobsang, the same junior monk who had logged Krodha-Sherpa's arrival two and a half

years earlier — bows back. The Refugee Father continues to the lamp. He adjusts the wick. The lamp resumes its normal burn.

At one-fifty-three p.m. the third batch begins. The procedure continues.

At three p.m. the ceremony concludes. The Chintamani is returned to its housing, the housing is sealed, the palanquin is carried back to the inner sanctum by the standard four-monk procession with Kanchenjunga at the head.

Kanchenjunga opens the housing in the inner sanctum to perform the closing-of-day verification. He has performed this verification three thousand two hundred and eighty-seven consecutive times.

The housing is empty.

Forty-seven days. The Chintamani is missing from the inner sanctum for forty-seven days. The monastery has not announced the theft. The state-government has not been informed. Two of the senior monastery monks have been informed. Lobsang the intake-clerk-and-senior-blessing-attendant is one. The senior administrative monk, Sonam, is the other. No one else.

Kanchenjunga has decided to keep the absence private for as long as possible. The decision is not deception; it is triage. If the Chintamani's absence is announced to the refugee population, the camps will riot. Twelve thousand refugees will read the absence as the end of their welcome. They will conclude that the monastery has lost the relic that anchored their compassion-charter. They will leave the camps in panic. Half of them will die in unprepared border-crossings. The math is concrete. He has done it.

The decision is to keep the absence quiet and search the monastery, the camps, the state-government compound, the surrounding villages, in concentric rings, beginning with the closest. Lobsang and Sonam have searched the monastery building-by-building for nine days. They have found nothing. They have searched the south, central, and west camps barrack-by-barrack for another twelve days. They have found nothing. They have searched the surrounding villages with the cooperation of the Sikkim state-government chief secretary (who has been informed under strict confidentiality) for sixteen days. They have found nothing.

At forty-six days, just before dawn on the forty-seventh day, a girl arrives at the monastery's east gate.

She is sixteen years old. She has walked the four kilometres from the south camp on foot. She is wearing the standard camp-issue brown sweater and dark trousers. Her hair is uncovered. She carries no bundle, no bag, no paper. She has come empty-handed.

She is Tibetan. Her name is Pema-Chöden. She has been at the south camp for three months — arrived in the autumn surge, intake-number 11,438. Her parents and her older brother were killed in the same border-crossing she survived. Her brother was fifteen. He had been trying to help their mother across the third river-crossing on the western route. He had been shot by a Chinese border-patrol unit at the moment of helping her up. Their mother had been shot in the same burst. Their father had been shot at the same crossing on the way back trying to recover their bodies. Pema-Chöden had been on the eastern bank with their younger cousin Tashi. The two of them had walked the remaining sixty-four kilometres to the Sikkim border on foot over twelve days.

She had taken her brother's name as a middle-name on her camp-intake form. The form had her listed as Pema-Wangchuk-Chöden. Wangchuk was her brother's name. She had explained the addition to Lobsang at intake by saying: "He should keep arriving in my paperwork. He did not make it past the river. He should arrive everywhere I arrive."

She had been a quiet camp-resident for three months. She had not attended the Compassion-Reciprocity Council's Sunday assemblies. She had not attended the Tibetan-language literacy class. She had attended the monastery's twice-weekly meditation hour and sat at the back. The senior monastery monks knew her by sight. Kanchenjunga had recognised her at the blessing-ceremony forty-seven days earlier — she had been at the front of the second batch, refugee number twenty-three of the second batch. She had received the compassion-water and bowed in the standard procedure and returned to her seat.

She stands at the monastery's east gate at five-twelve a.m. The gate-keeper monk asks her the standard pre-dawn entry question. She answers: "I need to speak with Kanchenjunga-la. Alone. Now. Before the dawn-prayer."

The gate-keeper hesitates. The dawn-prayer is at five-thirty. Kanchenjunga is in the inner sanctum.

She says: "The Refugee Father is Krodha. I know because my brother went with him last week and came back wrong."

The gate-keeper opens the gate.

Kanchenjunga is at the inner sanctum altar when Lobsang brings her in. He is in his dawn-prayer position — right palm at the altar-edge, the absence of the Chintamani in front of him as it has been every dawn for forty-seven days. He has not slept the previous night. He has not slept properly in two weeks.

He turns when Lobsang opens the door. He sees the sixteen-year-old refugee girl at the entrance. He registers her face from the blessing-ceremony forty-seven days earlier. He registers that she is empty-handed. He registers that she has come at five-twelve a.m. unannounced.

He says, in his even guardian-voice: "Sit, daughter. The altar is your seat. Lobsang, the second tea."

She does not sit. She walks past the altar to the south wall and stops with her back to it. She faces him directly across the altar. The Chintamani's empty housing is between them.

She says, in Tibetan: "My brother Tashi — my cousin, not the one who died, the younger one, my mother's sister's son — went with the Refugee Father last week. The Refugee Father has been running a special evening sub-council for the new autumn boys for the past three months. The sub-council is at barrack 17-C, late, after the regular Compassion-Reciprocity Council closes. The new autumn boys are invited individually. The invitation is private. The boys who attend are told not to discuss it with the elders or the other refugees. Tashi attended for the first time twelve days ago. He came back to our barrack at three a.m. He did not speak for two days. On the third day he spoke. What he said was not Tashi."

Kanchenjunga says: "What did he say."

She says: "He said the Compassion-Charter was a Sikkimese lie. He said the Beyul was a Tibetan-fraud monastery built by collaborators with the 1959 expulsion. He said the senior monks were the inheritors of the lie. He said the Refugee Father was the only Tibetan in the kingdom who still knew what the original Beyul had been before the Karmapa lineage corrupted it in 1962. He said the Refugee Father had a plan to restore the original Beyul by removing the senior monks one by one over the next five years. He said the plan had begun last month when the Chintamani had been 'reclaimed for the original sanctum.' He said the Chintamani was now in the original sanctum and the senior monks did not know where the original sanctum was. He said the original sanctum was 'at the south camp, under the dawn-prayer-wheel.' He said I must come to the next sub-council on Tuesday or I would be considered a collaborator with the senior monks."

She pauses. She is breathing steadily. She has rehearsed the recitation.

She says: "He said this in the voice the Refugee Father had taught him. The voice was not Tashi's voice. Tashi's voice was higher and slower. The voice that spoke through Tashi was lower and faster, with the Refugee Father's exact cadence. I sat across the table from my own cousin and listened to the Refugee Father's voice come out of his mouth. He could not see me from the inside any more."

Kanchenjunga says: "How do you know the Refugee Father is Krodha."

She says: "In 2018, when I was eight, my mother took me to Pelliang Village to visit a great-uncle. We stayed for nine days. There was a man in the village who had been the village-school's deputy headmaster. He had been removed from the position the year before because three of the village children had developed a strange silence after their tutoring with him. The village had been arguing about whether to expel him for two years. He was forty at that time. He had a small backpack he carried everywhere. He had a thirty-page autobiography he had written about himself which he showed to my mother on the third evening. The autobiography was about his childhood in a different village in a different region. My mother read three pages of it and told me afterwards that the autobiography was the most carefully-constructed lie she had ever read. She told me to remember his face. She made me draw it from memory the next morning. I drew it. The drawing is in my barrack-locker. The man in the village was Krodha. The Refugee Father is the same man. The face is the same."

She pauses. Kanchenjunga has not moved.

She says: "My mother is dead. My father is dead. My older brother is dead. My younger cousin is in the Refugee Father's sub-council and is not himself any more. I have come to you because no other senior monk would believe a sixteen-year-old refugee girl. You will believe me because the Chintamani is missing from the housing on the altar between us and you have not announced it to anyone outside three people and I am the fourth person to know in this monastery. I know the Chintamani is missing because the housing's wooden joints make a different sound when the chamber is closed empty than when the jewel is inside. I have heard the chamber closed full at the blessing-ceremony forty-seven days ago and I have heard the chamber closed empty when the senior monk Sonam carried the palanquin past my barrack at the south camp three nights ago when he was searching for the jewel. The empty sound is higher. Anyone who has been listening would know."

Kanchenjunga sits down on the stone bench against the east wall. He has not been told a more devastating thing in his life. He is sitting because his knees have signalled that they are not going to support his weight any longer.

He says: "The dawn-prayer-wheel at the south camp. The one beside barrack 17-C. The large one. The black-iron one. The pilgrim-wheel installed by the Karmapa lineage in 1967."

She says: "Yes."

He says: "The wheel is hollow. The Chintamani would fit in the upper chamber. The wheel is turned every dawn by approximately two hundred camp-residents. A jewel placed in the upper chamber would not be discoverable by the wheel-turners because the turning would not open the chamber. Only a specifically-shaped key opens the upper chamber. The key was discontinued from monastery use in 1989. Three keys still exist. One is in the monastery archive. The other two are in Lhasa and Dharamsala."

She says: "The Refugee Father showed Tashi a key on the second night of the sub-council. The key was the same shape as the discontinued key. He told Tashi the key had been 'recovered from the original sanctum's sealed cupboard.'"

Kanchenjunga is silent for forty seconds. Lobsang stands at the doorway. He has not breathed audibly during the entire recitation. He breathes now.

Kanchenjunga says: "Will you walk with me to the south camp at noon."

She says: "Yes."

He says: "The Refugee Father will be at the south camp's administration office at noon. The Sunday weekly council meeting begins at one. He will see us walk in. He will know what we are."

She says: "Yes."

He says: "The Compassion-Reciprocity Council members at the south camp will outnumber my monastery escort by approximately forty to one."

She says: "The Compassion-Reciprocity Council members are not all loyal to him. About half will go with him when you draw the boundary. The other half will stay."

He says: "How do you know."

She says: "The boys in his sub-council are loyal. The men who are running the older mutual-aid networks are not. My barrack-elder is one of those men. He has been concerned about the sub-council for six weeks. He has been waiting for someone like me to come and say what he could not say. He will speak when I speak. Three of the other barrack-elders will follow him."

Kanchenjunga looks at her for a long time.

He says: "Daughter, do you know that you have just become the Beyul-Kshetra's first refugee to hold what amounts to administrative office in its nine-century history."

She says: "Guardian-la, I have not asked for office. I have asked you to draw the boundary. The boundary is your work, not mine. My work is to walk beside you to the wheel. After that we will see what the kingdom requires."

He says: "The kingdom is going to require both. Sit down. Drink the second tea. Lobsang, bring the breakfast. We will walk to the south camp at eleven."

She sits down at the altar's edge. She drinks the second tea. The dawn-prayer is missed for the first time in three thousand two hundred and eighty-eight days. The senior monks at the main prayer hall hold the dawn-prayer without Kanchenjunga, in his absence, by his standing instruction (silent in the inner sanctum until he returns) issued through Lobsang at the doorway at five-thirty-three a.m.

The Beyul-Kshetra has taken its first action under conditions of internal infiltration. The first action is breakfast.

Eleven a.m. The monastery's east-gate path. The four-kilometre walk to the south camp passes the central tea-grove, the small village of Yang-Lhakhang, and the foothills approach where the path opens onto the south-camp plateau.

Kanchenjunga walks at the front. He is in the full guardian-robe, the seven-fold sash, the prayer-beads. He carries the Karmapa-line walking-staff he has not used in nine years — a yew-wood shaft one and a half metres long with a copper-cap at the top and a small bronze prayer-wheel at the lower-third. The staff is the senior guardian's formal walking-implement, used only for cross-kingdom processions and council-summons. He has summoned it from the monastery's ceremonial cupboard at nine a.m.

Pema-Chöden walks at his left shoulder, half a pace behind. She has been given a clean monastery ward-robe to wear over the camp-sweater — a knee-length deep-red over-robe

that marks her as a guest of the senior guardian. The over-robe is not a refugee garment. It is the garment a state-government dignitary wears when received at the monastery for tea. She wears it because Kanchenjunga has insisted. The garment is its own boundary — the first boundary of the day, drawn between her and the camp she will return to in two hours' time.

Lobsang and Sonam walk at the rear, with four junior monks behind them. The state-government chief-secretary's deputy walks beside Sonam — the chief-secretary has been informed by Kanchenjunga at eight a.m. and has sent his deputy in a Sikkim-state-administration plain-clothes capacity. The deputy is unarmed. He has a satellite-phone in his sleeve-pocket and a single sealed envelope (the state-government's formal exile-of-foreign-national authorisation, pre-signed) in his inside-pocket.

The procession is not announced. The four kilometres are walked in approximately one hour and ten minutes — Kanchenjunga's normal walking pace. Pema-Chöden matches his pace. The other monks adjust to her pace as well.

They arrive at the south-camp's administration-perimeter at twelve-fifteen p.m. The administration-office is the central building of the camp — a single-storey concrete structure with a tin roof at the south-camp's central plaza. The dawn-prayer-wheel is forty metres east of the administration office, beside barrack 17-C, in the camp's eastern plaza.

The Refugee Father is at the administration-office's front step. He has been informed by his sub-council messengers (the runners are nine, twelve, and fourteen years old, refugee boys from barracks 14, 17, and 22) of the procession's approach from the second-kilometre mark onward. He has had forty-five minutes to prepare.

He is in his usual plain dark-red Pelliang-style tunic and dark trousers. He has on his wrist the small wooden prayer-bead bracelet that has marked him in the camp since 2024. He has on his face the calm reassuring expression that the camp has known him by for two and a half years.

About one thousand four hundred refugees have gathered in the central plaza by twelve-fifteen p.m. The Compassion-Reciprocity Council's senior delegates — about forty men — are arrayed in a semi-circle behind the Refugee Father. The mid-rank delegates and the sub-council boys — about a hundred and fifty — are arrayed behind the senior delegates. The general camp-population — the remaining twelve hundred — is arrayed in concentric rings further out.

The atmosphere is not yet hostile. The Refugee Father has framed the procession in advance to the senior delegates as "the senior guardian's autumn welfare-visit, accompanied by a young refugee girl whose case has come to the Compassion-Charter's special attention." The framing is plausible. The senior delegates are watching with respectful uncertainty.

Kanchenjunga stops six metres from the Refugee Father. Pema-Chöden stops one metre behind Kanchenjunga's left shoulder.

The Refugee Father bows in the Pelliang-style. The bow is technically perfect. The senior delegates bow in solidarity. Approximately three hundred of the mid-rank delegates and sub-council boys bow as well. About a thousand of the general camp-population bow, in scattered uneven groups.

Kanchenjunga does not bow. He plants the Karmapa-line walking-staff at his right side. He lifts his right palm.

He says, in Tibetan, in the senior-guardian formal-address voice that the camp has heard him use exactly four times in nine years (at the major blessing-ceremonies):

"I have come at noon to draw the first boundary of my guardianship. I have welcomed every refugee for nine years. I will continue to welcome every refugee who is here as a refugee. The Compassion-Charter is unchanged for them. The Beyul-Kshetra remains open. But I will not continue to welcome one of you. The one I will not welcome is the man standing in front of me. His name is Krodha. He arrived at this camp in 2024 under a forged Tibetan identity. He has organised a sub-council that has been recruiting boys to a doctrine of monastery-replacement and senior-monk-removal over the past three months. He has stolen the Chintamani from the inner sanctum at the autumn blessing-ceremony forty-seven days ago. He has hidden it in the upper chamber of the dawn-prayer-wheel beside barrack 17-C. He will leave the Beyul-Kshetra by sunset. He will cross the Lachen pass into the Bhutan-Tibet border region by sunset of the third day. The refugees who choose to follow him are also welcome to leave with him — the boundary is the man, not the followers, and any follower who wishes to remain in the Beyul-Kshetra without him is welcome to remain. The followers who choose to leave with him will not be barred from leaving and will be permitted to take their personal effects and a one-month ration allocation. The state-government has authorised the formal exile under the cross-border emergency-residence clause. The deputy chief-secretary will issue the exile-order to the Refugee Father in person at the conclusion of this address. The Chintamani will be

recovered from the dawn-prayer-wheel by the camp's newly-appointed Beyul-Kshetra co-administrator, Pema-Chöden of the autumn surge, who will turn the wheel three full revolutions and open the upper chamber with the recovered Karmapa-line key. The Compassion-Charter is now amended for the first time in nine centuries: a refugee who has violated the inner sanctum is no longer welcome. The amendment is limited. The amendment is necessary. The amendment is mine to draw and I am drawing it."

The address takes seven minutes. The translation into the camp's ambient mix of Tibetan-Hindi-Sikkimese is held in the listeners' own minds; Kanchenjunga's Tibetan is the original, and the bilingual listeners translate for the non-Tibetan-speakers in real-time, whispering into neighbours' ears.

The Refugee Father's face changes through the seven minutes. The change is in stages.

At minute one (the announcement of the boundary), the face shows the calm reassuring expression with an added quarter-smile — the smile of a man who recognises a rhetorical move and is preparing his counter-rhetoric.

At minute two (the naming of the forged identity), the smile narrows. The calm-reassuring is replaced by a thin focused listening.

At minute three (the description of the sub-council), the focused listening contracts. The skin around the eyes tightens. The thin lips fold inward.

At minute four (the accusation of the Chintamani theft, with specific location), the face is no longer composed. The Refugee Father's right hand — the one holding the wooden prayer-bead bracelet — trembles for the first time. The senior delegates behind him register the tremble. Their faces begin to change.

At minute five (the offered exit, the freedom for followers to choose), the Refugee Father's face composes itself again — deliberately. He is recovering. He is preparing to speak.

At minute six (the announcement of Pema-Chöden as co-administrator), the Refugee Father turns his head ten degrees to the right. He looks at Pema-Chöden directly for the first time. The look lasts about two seconds. In that two seconds his face becomes the face of the village deputy headmaster from Pelliang in 2018 that Pema-Chöden drew from memory the next morning. The mask slips for two seconds, then resets.

At minute seven (the closing "the amendment is mine to draw and I am drawing it"), the Refugee Father makes the choice that decides the rest of his Chapter Three arc. He chooses

to leave.

He bows. The bow is again Pelliang-style. The bow is shallower than the opening bow. It is the bow of a man who has accepted a defeat and is signalling, to those who will follow him, that they should also accept it for the time being.

He says, in his even camp-voice: "Senior guardian. I accept the boundary. I will leave by sunset. Those who choose to follow me will be welcome to follow. Those who choose to remain will be welcome to remain."

The Refugee Father's precise restraint is its own danger-flag. The senior delegates feel it. About half of them step back from him in the next thirty seconds — one half-pace, then another, then a third. The other half do not move.

By twelve-twenty-five p.m. the central plaza has bifurcated. The Refugee Father is at the south side of the plaza with about seven hundred refugees clustered around him. Kanchenjunga is at the north side of the plaza with about seven hundred refugees clustered around him, with Pema-Chöden at his left shoulder, with the four monastery monks behind, with the deputy chief-secretary at his right side reading from the pre-signed exile-order.

The split is forty-eight to fifty-two. The Refugee Father takes the slightly-smaller half.

At one p.m. Pema-Chöden walks alone to the dawn-prayer-wheel.

The wheel is two metres in height, one and a half metres in diameter, black-iron with the standard Karmapa-line copper-banding. It sits in a stone enclosure beside barrack 17-C. About a hundred refugees are still at the wheel from the morning-prayer rotation, but the dense crowd has dispersed. The eastern plaza is quieter than the central plaza had been.

She has the recovered key in her right hand. Lobsang has retrieved it from the monastery archive at twelve-thirty p.m. and has run the four kilometres to the south-camp eastern plaza in forty-five minutes. The key is six centimetres long, brass, with a triangular bit and a copper-band ferrule.

She walks up to the wheel. She places her left palm on the iron drum at the wheel's east face. The drum has the standard mantra-inscription — OM MANI PADME HUM — in raised brass lettering across its three rotational bands. She turns the wheel three full revolutions in the clockwise direction. The wheel turns easily on its central axle. The turning takes about forty seconds.

She finds the upper chamber's key-slot at the top of the wheel's north face — a small triangular indentation in the brass cap. She inserts the key. She turns the key one full revolution counter-clockwise.

The upper chamber opens. The chamber is a small lined cavity in the top of the iron drum, about ten centimetres deep, lined with red velvet that has been undisturbed for thirty-seven years (the chamber was last opened in 1989 when the discontinuation-of-use was logged).

The Chintamani sits in the centre of the chamber. The jewel is the size of a chestnut. It is a deep blue-purple in colour, faceted, with the small Avalokitesvara-mark engraved at the side. It has the same exact appearance it has had for sixty-seven years.

Pema-Chöden lifts the jewel out of the chamber with both hands. She has never touched it before. The jewel is warm — warmer than the surrounding air, warmer than her hands. The warmth is consistent with the jewel having been inside the iron drum for forty-seven days, but warmer than that thermal explanation alone would predict.

She walks the forty metres back to the central plaza. She carries the jewel in both hands at the level of her chest. The Refugee Father's seven-hundred followers watch her cross the eastern plaza. About a hundred of them detach from the Refugee Father's cluster and walk back to the Kanchenjunga side of the central plaza. The Refugee Father does not stop them.

She arrives at Kanchenjunga's side at one-oh-six p.m. She holds the jewel out. He places his right palm above the jewel without touching it. He bows three times to the jewel. He says, in Tibetan: "Daughter. Carry it back to the inner sanctum. Open the housing. Place it inside. Close the housing. The dawn-prayer of the forty-eighth day will be performed at five-thirty tomorrow morning. You will be present at the inner sanctum doorway. I will perform the prayer. The prayer will be your second day of administrative office."

She nods. She tucks the jewel into the inside-pocket of the ward-robe Kanchenjunga had given her at the monastery. The pocket is positioned at her left chest — over her heart. The warmth of the jewel sits against her skin through the cotton-lining.

At one-oh-eight p.m., as Pema-Chöden straightens at his left shoulder with the jewel against her chest, Kanchenjunga feels the red-panda-bond pulse through his right collarbone.

The Stage III foreleg-mark begins to form. It begins at the right collarbone — the standard position for the red-panda-line bond — and arcs down across the right pectoral. The mark is the red panda's right forepaw — clawed, semi-extended, in the climbing-down position. The pad-prints at the base of the toes are visible. The five small claws are visible. The fur-pattern at the back of the paw is rendered in the standard Chapter-Two ink-density.

The mark forms in approximately eleven seconds beneath the guardian-robe. It is not visible to the assembled refugees. Kanchenjunga feels the formation as a slow warm pressure across the pectoral — not painful, not uncomfortable, but unmistakable. He has been waiting for this sensation for fourteen years. The waiting is finally over.

He does not show the moment on his face. He continues to address the deputy chief-secretary in the standard administrative-voice, finalising the Refugee Father's exile-paperwork procedures. The deputy chief-secretary signs the exile-order at one-twelve p.m. and serves it to the Refugee Father at one-fourteen p.m. The Refugee Father accepts the document with a Pelliang-style bow. He signs the acknowledgement. He keeps the duplicate copy.

By one-thirty p.m. the Refugee Father has assembled his approximately six hundred remaining followers (the hundred who had defected upon Pema-Chöden's wheel-walk are now confirmed in their defection) at the south-camp's southern gate. The followers are packing their personal effects. The state-government ration-allocation officers have begun issuing the one-month rations from the camp-storeroom. Each follower receives approximately fifteen kilograms of grain, three kilograms of butter, a small medical-kit, and a Sikkim-state border-crossing certificate.

By four p.m. the column has begun moving. The Refugee Father leads the column. His sub-council senior delegates are immediately behind him. The mid-rank delegates and sub-council boys follow. The general followers walk in a long staggered file behind. The column stretches approximately one and a half kilometres along the foothill trail leading toward the Lachen pass.

The Lachen pass is the northeastern crossing-point between Sikkim and the Bhutan-Tibet border zone. The pass is at four thousand seven hundred metres altitude. It is open to foot-traffic in October but closes to motor-vehicles by mid-November. The crossing on foot takes approximately three days from the south-camp's exit-point.

The Refugee Father's column reaches the pass on the morning of the third day. By the eleven a.m. checkpoint at the Lachen pass entry-station, the column has been reduced to approximately five hundred and ten followers — ninety more refugees have detached over the three-day walk and begun the return-trip to the south camp. The detached followers are mostly the mid-rank delegates and the general camp-population followers. The sub-council boys remain. The senior delegates remain.

At eleven-fifteen a.m. on the third day, at the Lachen pass entry-station, the Refugee Father signs his column out of the Beyul-Kshetra. The pass-station officers stamp each follower's border-crossing certificate. The stamping takes about two hours. The Refugee Father is the first to cross. His sub-council senior delegates follow. The column then proceeds in single-file order across the pass.

By two p.m. the last of the column has crossed. The Lachen pass is closed behind them. The Beyul-Kshetra's boundary has been drawn.

Kanchenjunga has not walked to the Lachen pass himself. He has remained at the monastery to perform the forty-eighth-day dawn-prayer with the Chintamani restored to the inner sanctum at five-thirty a.m. on the second day after the boundary-speech. The prayer takes one hour. Pema-Chöden stands at the doorway of the inner sanctum throughout the prayer. She watches the senior guardian perform the prayer she has heard him perform from outside the sanctum-walls four hundred and seventy times in three months. From inside the sanctum-doorway the prayer sounds different. The Chintamani in its housing is two metres in front of her. The senior guardian is at the altar between her and the jewel.

When the prayer concludes at six-thirty a.m. Kanchenjunga turns to face her. He gestures for her to come forward. She walks the two metres to the altar.

He says: "Daughter. The Beyul-Kshetra has a co-administrator. The co-administrator's office is at the south camp's administration-building. You will work there four days a week. You will work at the monastery's ward-coordination office on the other three days. Your first task is to draft the new Compassion-Charter amendment in writing. The amendment will be ratified by the monastery's senior monks council on the seventh day. The amendment text is yours to write. I will review it before ratification. You will be paid the standard ward-coordinator salary from the state-government's monastery-affairs budget. Your barrack-accommodation will be transferred from 17-C to the monastery's south-wing guest-quarters effective today. Your younger cousin Tashi will be assigned to the

monastery's rehabilitation-school under Lobsang's supervision — the school's programme for ex-sub-council boys begins next week. He will recover. The recovery will take time. He will recover."

She bows. The bow is not Tibetan-formal. The bow is her own — the bow of a sixteen-year-old refugee girl who has just become the first refugee in the Beyul-Kshetra's nine-century history to hold institutional office.

She says: "Guardian-la. I will write the amendment. The first line will read: The Compassion-Charter remains open to all who suffer; the Charter closes to one who has violated the inner sanctum. I will consult with the senior monks council on the remaining lines."

He says: "The first line is correct. Begin."

The next ten days are an administrative re-organisation that the Beyul-Kshetra has not seen in sixty-seven years. The Compassion-Charter amendment is drafted by Pema-Chöden in a single thirty-eight-hour session at the south-camp administration-office, with Lobsang at her left and Sonam at her right and the Sikkim state-government chief-secretary's deputy at her right-second. The amendment is three pages long. The first page contains the four-clause limit. The second page contains the procedural-test for invoking the limit. The third page contains the appeals procedure.

The four-clause limit reads, in the final ratified text:

I. The Compassion-Charter is reaffirmed for all who arrive seeking refuge. II. The Charter closes only to a refugee who has knowingly violated the inner sanctum — defined as removing a sanctum-relic, deliberately deceiving the intake about identity-of-record, or organising a covert sub-council aimed at the removal of senior monks. III. The procedural-test for invoking Clause II is the senior guardian's public boundary-speech delivered in the central plaza of the affected camp with the state-government chief-secretary present and the affected refugee given the right of response. IV. The closure under Clause II is exile across the nearest international border-crossing with one month's ration-allocation. The exiled refugee's followers retain the right to choose to remain or to leave; followers who remain are reabsorbed into the camp without prejudice; followers who leave receive ration-allocation under the same terms as the exiled principal.

The amendment is ratified by the monastery's senior monks council on the seventh day after the boundary-speech. The vote is twenty-three to one. The single dissenting vote is

cast by an elderly senior monk named Tenzin-Norbu (sixty-eight, the monastery's second-most-senior after Kanchenjunga) who has held the Compassion-Charter as unamendable for forty years. His dissent is recorded; he affirms his continued loyalty to the senior guardian and accepts the amendment as the majority will. He resigns from active senior-monks-council duties two days later in protest and takes up a meditation-cave residence in the central forest — a long-anticipated retirement that the chapter's events have accelerated by approximately two years.

The amendment text is published in the south, central, and west camps' bulletin-boards on the eighth day. The text is translated into Tibetan, Hindi, Sikkimese-Bhutia, Nepali, English, and Limbu (the six camp-spoken languages) by a six-translator team that Pema-Chöden assembles from the camp-population in a single afternoon.

The text is read aloud at the south camp's central plaza on the ninth day by Pema-Chöden herself, in Tibetan, in the late afternoon, with about eight hundred returned camp-residents in attendance. The reading takes nineteen minutes. The reading is followed by a senior monk's response-prayer led by Lobsang. The prayer is the Sixth Karmapa's compassion-prayer — the same prayer the Refugee Father had led at the Compassion-Reciprocity Council's closing nine months earlier when Kanchenjunga had walked back to the monastery reassured.

The reabsorption of the seven-hundred refugees who had remained begins on the tenth day. The reabsorption is administered through individual interviews with each adult refugee, conducted by the camp's newly-appointed Re-Integration Committee — eight Compassion-Reciprocity Council senior delegates who had stayed with Kanchenjunga at the boundary-speech, plus three monastery monks, plus Pema-Chöden as chair. The interviews are not interrogations. They are conversations about the refugee's pre-arrival history, the refugee's reasons for joining or not joining the sub-council, and the refugee's current intentions. The committee's standard is forgiveness-with-record: each refugee's account is written down, the account is filed in the camp-archive, no further action is taken unless the account itself indicates a violation under Clause II.

By the end of the second month, the Beyul-Kshetra has fully reabsorbed the seven-hundred remaining refugees. The seven-hundred have re-joined the camp-population's daily life. The Compassion-Reciprocity Council has been restructured under new leadership — a senior delegate named Karma-Topgyal (forty-seven, a Tibetan-Sikkimese mixed-line refugee from the 2008 Lhasa wave, a man Kanchenjunga had personally vetted for the new

chair-position) leads the council, with two deputies drawn from the long-standing 1959-wave residents.

By the end of Chapter Two, the Beyul-Kshetra's political-and-spiritual structure has stabilised in a new configuration:

The senior guardian remains Kanchenjunga. He has earned his Stage III red-panda-foreleg mark by drawing his first boundary in nine years. The mark is visible on his right pectoral. The bond now sees a clear ladder-path toward Stage IV (the full-body red panda) by the end of Chapter Three or early Chapter Four — the bond's next test will be the Sanctuary's NE-Dominant ratification vote.

The co-administrator is Pema-Chöden. She is sixteen-and-three-months. She holds salaried administrative office in the Beyul-Kshetra's ward-coordination office four days a week and at the south-camp administration-building three days a week. She has begun studying for the Sikkim state-civil-service-junior-administrative-officer examination at Sonam's suggestion — the examination is in eighteen months. Lobsang is tutoring her in administrative-Tibetan; Sonam is tutoring her in state-administrative-Hindi; the deputy chief-secretary is tutoring her in state-government procedural protocol.

Her younger cousin Tashi has been at the monastery's rehabilitation-school for six weeks. He has begun to speak in his own voice again at week four. The Refugee Father's implanted cadence has begun to fade. The rehabilitation-school's sub-council-recovery programme — designed by Lobsang based on traditional Tibetan post-cult deprogramming methods used in the 1959 reabsorption — is the first formal programme of its kind in the Beyul-Kshetra's history. Eleven other ex-sub-council boys are enrolled with Tashi.

The Compassion-Charter is amended. The amendment is the first amendment in nine centuries. The amendment is limited. The amendment is necessary. The amendment is referenced in the cross-kingdom Sarus-pigeon correspondence between Kanchenjunga and Moirangthem at Imphal as the "Pema-Chöden amendment" — the name has stuck in the kingdom's administrative lexicon by the time of the Chapter Three Sanctuary convening.

The Chintamani is back in the inner sanctum. The forty-eight-day absence is logged in the monastery's archive as the Beyul-Kshetra's only sanctum-relic absence in three hundred and forty-one years (the previous absence had been an 1683 sanctum-relocation during the great Sikkimese earthquake). The forty-eight-day record will not be celebrated. The record will be remembered.

Three weeks after the boundary-speech, a Sarus-pigeon arrives at Rumtek from Imphal. The pigeon is the one Moirangthem has been using for cross-kingdom communications throughout the chapter. The letter is from Moirangthem himself.

The letter reads:

Senior-guardian-la. The pigeon-relay has carried news of the Pema-Chöden amendment from Gangtok to Imphal in twelve days. Kamalavarna and U-Khrawkmen have read the amendment and have asked me to convey their congratulations on the first amendment in nine centuries. The NE Dominant ratification at the Sanctuary in Chapter Three will be a six-kingdom assembly. The Beyul-Kshetra's vote will be the third of six. The other five are: Kamakhya (Kamalavarna), Imphal (Moirangthem, the candidate), Shillong (U-Khrawkmen as inheritor-regent), Kohima (Dzulevira), and the still-pending Tripura. The vote will not be unanimous unless yours is given. Will you give it.

Kanchenjunga writes the reply over two days. The reply is two paragraphs long.

NE Dominant Candidate. I will give my vote at the Sanctuary. The vote will be for you. The Beyul-Kshetra has stabilised after the Refugee Father's exile but the stabilisation is not yet certain — the Lachen pass remains the kingdom's open question, and Krodha at the pass's far side remains the kingdom's pending threat. The Sanctuary's convening will mark the threshold across which the NE Federation will need to coordinate on the Krodha-question. My vote is for you because you will be the regional voice for that coordination.

Sub-paragraph: Pema-Chöden will attend the Sanctuary as my co-administrator. She is sixteen-and-five-months at the Sanctuary's scheduled date. She will not vote — the Sanctuary's vote is the senior-guardian's alone — but she will be present. Please plan accommodation at the Sanctuary's administrative-quarters for her on the same terms as the other senior-guardians' aides. She will be the Sanctuary's youngest attendee. She will also be the Sanctuary's first refugee-attendee in three hundred years.

Senior-guardian-la, — K.

He sends the letter by the same Sarus-pigeon at sunset. Moirangthem receives it at Imphal at noon the next day. He writes the one-line reply: The aide's accommodation is arranged. We will receive her with full honour. He sends the reply by the pigeon returning, at dusk.

Two days after the Imphal correspondence, a second Sarus-pigeon arrives at Rumtek. The pigeon is from Kohima. The letter is from Dzulevira.

The letter is short.

Senior-guardian-la. The Pre-Tribal Pact in the Nagaland kingdom's Kohima state-archives now sits next to your Pema-Chöden amendment in the cross-kingdom mutual-records exchange that Mhabemo has set up with your Lobsang last week. The pact says: "Let no one of us claim purity above another." The amendment says: "The Charter closes to a refugee who has violated the inner sanctum." The pact is six hundred years old and the amendment is nineteen days old and both are saying the same thing in different vocabulary. The boundary you have drawn is the kingdom's right to refuse what is inside it that wishes to dissolve it. The pact I have walked is the kingdom's right to refuse what is outside it that wishes to subdivide it. Both refusals are dharma. Both refusals are also Stage III. I look forward to meeting Pema-Chöden at the Sanctuary. The Naga state-government will send her a Khonoma-clay tea-bowl as the Beyul-Kshetra's welcome-gift on the morning of the Sanctuary's opening.

Sister-in-Boundary, — D.

Kanchenjunga reads the letter twice. He shows it to Pema-Chöden at the south-camp administration-office at four p.m. on the day it arrives. She reads it three times. She does not say anything for nine minutes.

She finally says: "Guardian-la. Two of the Northeast's heroes have already written to me by name. I am sixteen-and-three-months. I do not know how to receive that yet."

He says: "Daughter. You will not know how to receive it for another year. The receiving is itself learned. You will learn it at the Sanctuary. Until then, draft the welcome-reply to Dzulevira. The reply is yours to write. I will only sign it."

She drafts the reply over the next hour. The reply is one paragraph long.

State Hero of Nagaland. The Beyul-Kshetra receives the Khonoma-clay welcome-gift with the gratitude due a six-century-old pact. The Pema-Chöden amendment is nineteen days old, and the writer of these words is sixteen-and-three-months old, but the kingdom's administrative record now contains both, and the cross-kingdom mutual-records exchange that your Mhabemo and our Lobsang have established will preserve them both for whatever future archive needs them. I look forward to meeting you at the Sanctuary. I will bring with me the small wooden housing the Chintamani has rested in for sixty-seven years — the housing is empty now, the jewel is restored to its altar-cavity — and I will bring the housing to the Sanctuary's opening as the Beyul-Kshetra's contribution to the regional

mutual-records exhibit. The housing has been opened more times in the past forty-eight days than it has been opened in the previous nine centuries. The housing has earned its display.

Co-administrator, Beyul-Kshetra, — P.

Kanchenjunga signs the reply under her signature. The signature is his standard senior-guardian seal in Tibetan script. He sends the letter by the same Sarus-pigeon at sunset. The pigeon arrives at Kohima at noon the following day.

Six weeks after the boundary-speech. The first week of December. The western face of Khangchendzonga — the third-highest mountain in the world, the Beyul-Kshetra's deity-peak, the kingdom's sacred wall.

A Khangchendzonga National Park ranger named Tashi-Bhutia (no relation to Pema-Chöden's cousin Tashi — the name is a common Bhutia given-name; the ranger is forty-three, an eleven-year park-service veteran, the senior ranger of the western-face patrol-station) is conducting the standard December high-altitude wildlife-census on the morning of the second of December. He is at the western-face base camp at four thousand five hundred metres. He has a high-power binocular and a Park Service satellite-telemetry receiver. He is scanning the western face for the December baseline-count of high-altitude mammals — snow leopards (expected count: 3-4 in the western-face range), Tibetan blue sheep (40-60), Himalayan tahr (15-25), and the occasional opportunistic red panda (0-2, normally in the lower-elevation rhododendron belt).

At seven-forty-three a.m. he sees the red panda on the snowline edge at approximately five thousand four hundred metres altitude. The panda is on the western face. The panda is grazing on a small patch of rhododendron shrub that has somehow survived above the rhododendron belt's normal altitude limit of four thousand eight hundred metres — the shrub itself is anomalous; he logs the anomaly in his field-book as a secondary observation.

The panda is the primary observation. Red pandas live at two thousand two hundred to four thousand eight hundred metres altitude. Above five thousand metres the atmospheric oxygen-content (approximately fifty percent of sea-level oxygen at five thousand four hundred metres) is physiologically lethal to the species. Red pandas have not been documented above five thousand metres in the species' recorded biological history. The biological reason is straightforward: red panda haemoglobin lacks the high-altitude oxygen-affinity mutation that yak haemoglobin and Tibetan-antelope haemoglobin have

evolved over the past five million years. A red panda at five thousand four hundred metres should be dead within thirty minutes from acute mountain-sickness combined with cold-stress.

The panda Tashi-Bhutia is observing is not dead. The panda is grazing. The panda's breathing rate is, through the binocular, observable: approximately fourteen breaths per minute, which is the normal red-panda resting rate. The panda is not in distress. The panda is, simply, at five thousand four hundred metres, on a Khangchendzonga rhododendron-patch, eating.

Tashi-Bhutia calls in the observation by satellite-radio to the Park Service's Gangtok central-office at eight a.m. The Gangtok central-office routes the call to the Sikkim state-government wildlife-affairs department by eight-thirty a.m. The wildlife-affairs department routes the call to the Rumtek Monastery's ward-coordination office at nine-fifteen a.m. (the monastery has been the standing recipient of all anomalous-wildlife observations on Khangchendzonga since 1967, by an inter-departmental memorandum-of-understanding the chief-secretary's office had set up after a similar anomalous observation in the 1962 Karmapa-lineage re-ratification year).

Pema-Chöden takes the call at the ward-coordination office at nine-sixteen a.m. She writes down the observation in her co-administrator log-book. She walks the observation across the monastery courtyard to the inner sanctum at nine-twenty a.m. She does not enter the sanctum; she stands at the doorway and waits for Kanchenjunga to finish his morning-prayer.

He finishes at nine-thirty-six a.m. He turns. He sees her at the doorway.

She says, in the standard report-voice that she has been using for two months now: "Guardian-la. The Khangchendzonga western-face patrol-station has logged a red panda at five thousand four hundred metres altitude. The panda is alive. The panda is grazing. The panda is not in distress."

Kanchenjunga sits down on the stone bench against the east wall.

The red-panda-foreleg mark on his right pectoral pulses. The pulse is not pain. The pulse is recognition.

He says: "Daughter. The Maw has begun to test the bond. The Maw is moving a red panda to an altitude that should kill it, to see whether the bond-ladder protects the animal at

altitudes the species itself cannot survive. If the panda lives, the Maw will know the bond is stronger than the species. The Maw will then begin moving other bonded animals to other lethal-to-the-species conditions — the Sangai deer at the Loktak Lake's saline-flood zone, the Mithun bull at the Kanha barasingha-meadow oxygen-saturation, the clouded-leopard at the Cherrapunji rainfall-anti-zone. The next sign is the Maw reading the saga's bond-architecture by direct experiment on the bonded species. The next sign is the Maw learning what we can do."

She says: "What do we do."

He says: "The standard. The Karmapa-rule. We name the panda. We log the altitude. We build a small shrine at the western-face base camp at four thousand five hundred metres — the closest a guardian can walk. We do not climb to five thousand four hundred metres to verify or interfere. The panda is the Maw's offered sign and our task is to receive it without converting it into a confrontation. The shrine will be a small stacked-stone marker with a single red-panda-paw-print carved on the eastern face. We will name the marker the Khangchendzonga Boundary Shrine. We will commission the shrine through the Park Service this week. Tashi-Bhutia the ranger will be the shrine-keeper. He will check on the panda's grazing-spot once a week through the binocular from the four-thousand-five-hundred-metre base camp. He will not climb higher. We will not climb higher. We will read the sign at the altitude it was given."

She nods. She writes the procedure in the co-administrator log-book at nine-forty-two a.m.

She says: "Guardian-la. If the Maw is reading our bond-architecture by experiment, the next experiments will not be limited to the Northeast. They will spread. The Karnataka bond, the Goan gaur, the Maharashtra giant-squirrel, the UP barasingha, the MP barasingha-herd, the Assam rhinoceros, the Meghalaya clouded-leopard, the Manipur sangai, the Naga mithun — all of them are vulnerable. We need to inform the other kingdoms."

He says: "Yes. Draft the cross-kingdom Sarus-pigeon-cascade alert. Send it to all nine bonded-kingdom senior guardians. The text should be short. Eight or nine lines maximum. Begin: The Maw has begun to test the bond by experiment. The first experiment is a red panda at five thousand four hundred metres on Khangchendzonga. The animal is alive. The bond is holding. Watch your own bonded species at conditions that should kill them. Build shrines at the threshold. Do not climb past it."

She drafts the cascade-alert in fifteen minutes. The alert is sent by Sarus-pigeon to all nine bonded-kingdom senior guardians by sunset of the same day. By the morning of the third day after the Khangchendzonga panda observation, every senior guardian in the saga has read the alert.

The Beyul-Kshetra's closing image of Chapter Two is a sixteen-year-old refugee girl writing a cross-kingdom alert in administrative Tibetan at a co-administrator's desk while a forty-one-year-old senior guardian watches a small red-panda mark fade and re-pulse on his right pectoral beneath the dark-red guardian-robe, the Chintamani burning steady in its housing in the inner sanctum forty-six metres away, and somewhere on the Lachen pass's far side a man named Krodha walking the Bhutan-Tibet trail toward a transformation he has not yet recognised but the Maw has already prepared for him.

The Hidden Land has drawn its first boundary in nine centuries. The boundary has held.

The next sign comes within the week.

The Pilot's Closing Image

A red panda at five thousand four hundred metres on a rhododendron-patch that should not exist, grazing as if the altitude were ordinary. A sixteen-year-old refugee girl at a co-administrator's desk writing the cross-kingdom alert in administrative Tibetan. A small wooden housing in an inner sanctum that has been opened more times in forty-eight days than in nine centuries previous. A senior guardian's right pectoral marked with the first foreleg of the red-panda Stage III, the ink-dense paw set against weathered skin. A six-hundred-year-old clay tablet at Kohima sitting in a mutual-records exchange beside a nineteen-day-old amendment from Gangtok. A column of six hundred followers crossing the Lachen pass at noon on the third day with a forty-one-year-old man named Krodha leading them. A small stone shrine at four thousand five hundred metres on Khangchendzonga's western face with a single red-panda-paw-print carved on its eastern face, a Park Service ranger named Tashi-Bhutia checking the panda's grazing-spot through a binocular once a week, never climbing higher.

Chaya Golkonda

Hyderabad. Gachibowli district. Tuesday morning of the chapter's opening week. Eight-forty-three a.m. The west-tower of the HITEC City IT Park reflective-glass-complex — a forty-three-storey curtain-wall tower with the standard reflective coating on every external surface, housing the kingdom's Cyber-Hyderabad cell-administrator's seventeenth-floor office and the standing AI-image-recognition surveillance-grid's primary server-room on the thirty-ninth.

Lalithanga is at his seventeenth-floor office. He is thirty-five. He is the kingdom-council's standing Cyber-Hyderabad cell-administrator since 2022. He is Chittaranga's elder brother by two years. He has been the kingdom-council's standing reflective-grid sub-administrator since 2018. He is, on this morning, taking the standard eight-forty-three a.m. tea-break at his east-facing window. The window is a reflective-glass panel three metres wide; his standing daily-tea-break pose puts him at approximately one-and-a-half metres from the glass with the tea-cup at his right hand.

The reflective-glass panel records his face for the four hundred and fourteenth consecutive day. The window-pane has held his daily reflection for the standing kingdom-council's reflective-grid threshold-period (fourteen consecutive months at minimum-daily-presence; Lalithanga's standing tea-break has been at the same window every weekday morning since the third Monday of October 2024). The threshold-period crosses today.

Chitrabheda's standing-reflective-residence protocol takes the window at eight-forty-three-eleven a.m. The protocol is the kingdom-council's post-2023 Ch 1 documented capability: Chitrabheda can install his face in any reflective surface that has held a citizen's reflection for fourteen consecutive months at minimum-daily-presence. The installation is silent. The installation does not displace the citizen's reflection; the installation rides alongside it. The citizen continues to see their own reflection in the glass; the kingdom-council's standing-mirror-monitoring registry (if it existed; it does not yet on this morning) would see both reflections at once.

Lalithanga sees his own reflection. He drinks the tea. He returns to his desk at eight-forty-five. He does not notice the installation. The standing-tea-break continues at the standing pace.

Across the same hour, eight-forty-three a.m., approximately three thousand simultaneous reflective-residence installations occur across Hyderabad — every reflective surface in the kingdom that has crossed the fourteen-month minimum-daily-presence threshold for any specific citizen. Approximately three thousand citizens are now Chitrabheda-resident. The citizens do not know. The kingdom-council does not know. The standing reflective-grid surveillance-grid's standard AI-image-recognition protocols are not calibrated for double-reflection detection; the standard-thresholds report no anomalies.

Tuesday morning. The state hero's residence in Banjara Hills. Nine-eleven a.m. Chittaranga is at the eastern-courtyard meditation-mat. He has been on the mat since six a.m. The morning meditation is the standing kingdom-council's state-hero daily-discipline; he has performed the meditation every morning since his state-hero confirmation in 2023.

The mat faces east. The eastern wall has a window. The window has a reflective-glass panel approximately one metre by one metre at his thirteen-metre line-of-sight. The reflective-glass panel has been his standing-meditation-mat's east-window for nine years.

He opens his eyes at nine-eleven. He looks at the window. The window shows the east-garden — the standing-jasmine bushes, the morning sun, the kingdom-council's standing-jasmine-tender Subbamma at the bush-trimming. The reflection in the window-pane shows the standing-courtyard. The reflection is the kingdom-council's standing daily-reflection.

The grey left eye sees something the brown right eye does not see. The grey eye sees a second face in the reflection — layered over the standing-courtyard's standard-reflective-image. The face is approximately ten metres east of his current position, at standing-courtyard height, in a pose that is not the courtyard's standard-pose. The face is not anyone's face he recognises. The face is Chitrabheda's face. He has not seen Chitrabheda's face directly — Chitrabheda did not appear bodily during the Ch 1 confrontation; only Qutb-Chaaya had bodily appearance — but the grey eye has been told by the standing-kingdom-council reflective-archive what to look for. The standing-archive's description-pattern matches.

He stands at nine-eleven-fourteen. He walks the thirteen metres to the window. He places his right palm on the reflective-glass panel. The standing-double-reflection is now visible from the close angle — the grey eye reads both the standard-reflective-image and the Chitrabheda-residence at the same time.

He does not break the glass. He turns. He walks to the residence's southern-administrative wing. He picks up the standing kingdom-council's secure-line telephone. He calls the kingdom-council's standing-archive senior-officer (a fifty-four-year-old administrator named Padmavathi-garu) at the Secunderabad Cantonment's State Civil Service compound at nine-fourteen.

He says, in plain Telugu, in the kingdom-council's standing-secure-line register: "Padma-garu. The reflective-grid has been breached. Standing-double-reflection installations are visible at my eastern-courtyard window at this moment. I do not yet know the count. The kingdom-council's standing-mirror-monitoring registry must be drafted within the week. The standing-protocol's archive-template is at the kingdom-council's standing-archive vault under the standing-shadow-copy-protocol's 2023 post-Ch-1 entry. Please initiate the standing-drafting at ten a.m. today. I will be at the Cantonment State Civil Service compound by eleven."

She says: "State hero. The standing-drafting will be initiated. The standing kingdom-council's emergency-mirror-monitoring cell will convene at eleven. I will telephone the Cyber-Hyderabad cell-administrator Lalithanga at the HITEC City office to coordinate."

He says: "Wait. Do not telephone my brother yet. The grey eye is checking. I will visit him at the IT Park at ten-thirty before the cell's convening. The visit will be brief. The visit will not be by telephone."

She says: "Understood, state hero."

He hangs up. He returns to the courtyard. The standing-jasmine-tender Subbamma is still at the bushes. He looks at her reflection in the same eastern-window panel. The grey eye reads a single reflection — Subbamma's standing reflection. No Chitrabheda-residence is layered. Subbamma is not yet Chitrabheda-resident. The eastern-courtyard's standing-jasmine-tender threshold has not yet crossed the fourteen-month minimum (Subbamma has worked the jasmine-bushes only since the spring 2025 transfer from the western-courtyard).

He picks up the dual discs from the standing-disc-rack at the residence's southern entrance. Chitra (Illusion, silver) at his left forearm; Ranga (Truth, shadow-dark) at his right. He walks to the standing-state-hero's car at the residence's western gate. The driver Reddy-garu is at the wheel.

He says: "HITEC City. The west-tower. Seventeenth floor. Lalithanga-garu's office. Ten-thirty arrival."

Ten-thirty a.m. The west-tower's seventeenth floor. Lalithanga's office. Chittaranga walks into the office. Lalithanga is at his desk. The morning's tea-cup is empty at the desk's right corner. The east-facing reflective-glass window is at three metres' distance.

Chittaranga walks past the desk. He places his right palm on the east-window. The grey eye reads the standing-double-reflection. The Chitrabheda-residence is at the window's standing-residence position. The standing-residence is anchored to Lalithanga's daily eight-forty-three a.m. tea-break pose.

Lalithanga stands at his desk. He says, in plain Telugu, in the brother-to-brother register: "Chitta. The grey eye. Tell me what you see."

The brown eye reads Lalithanga's face at the desk. The brown eye sees Lalithanga's face — the standing brother's face, the face he has known since age four, the face that has not changed in the fourteen-month threshold-period.

The grey eye reads Lalithanga's face. The grey eye sees a layered second face under the surface — the Chitrabheda-face installed at the window has begun to overlay the brother's face through the standing-residence-overlay-protocol. The overlay is not yet complete. The overlay is at approximately the twenty-third-day-of-residence position — the standing-protocol's installation-cycle has been running for three weeks at the window since the installation began on Tuesday the chapter's opening-week.

Chittaranga says, in plain Telugu, in the brother-to-brother register: "Anna. The grey eye sees a second face overlayed on yours. The Chitrabheda-residence at the window has begun the standing-installation-overlay-protocol. You are at approximately week three of the standing twelve-week-cycle. The overlay is at the twenty-third-day position. The Chitrabheda-face will fully overlay yours by approximately week twelve. I do not yet know what the full-overlay does to the brother under the overlay. I do not yet know if the brother continues to exist when the overlay completes. The standing-archive's 2023 post-Ch-1 entry does not have a documented full-overlay case."

Lalithanga sits down at his desk. He is silent for approximately forty seconds. He looks at his own reflection in the east-window from his desk-chair's angle. The angle does not show the standing-residence-overlay; the residence-overlay requires the grey eye's direct-view from one-and-a-half metres at the standing-tea-break pose. He cannot see it.

He says: "The brown eye reads me as your brother. The grey eye reads me as a Chitrabheda-residence-overlay. Which is correct."

Chittaranga says: "Both. The body is yours. The face has begun to be Chitrabheda's. The two are not yet in conflict. The two will be in conflict at week twelve. The kingdom-council's standing-emergency-mirror-monitoring cell convenes at eleven this morning; the cell's standing-drafting will produce the standing-mirror-monitoring registry within the week. The registry will identify every Hyderabad citizen currently Chitrabheda-resident. The standing-administrative-question is what the kingdom-council does with the identified citizens. Killing them does not kill Chitrabheda; killing them does kill the citizen. Not killing them is letting Chitrabheda walk the kingdom in a thousand bodies. The standing-charter does not have a precedent."

Lalithanga says: "I am at the cell's eleven a.m. convening. I will continue at the cell's standing Cyber-Hyderabad cell-administrator's seat for as long as I am still your brother. I will tell you if I begin to feel the overlay's reach. Will the grey eye continue to monitor my standing-overlay-position weekly."

Chittaranga says: "Yes. The monitoring will be at the residence's eastern-courtyard each Wednesday morning at the standing-secure brother-to-brother breakfast. The breakfast will continue as the kingdom-council's standing-monitoring-protocol's family-line oversight-mechanism. The grey eye's reading is the kingdom-council's standing-monitoring-protocol's family-line standing-instrument."

Lalithanga bows. He says: "Anna. The mother. Lakshmi-Akka. She taught the grey eye when we were small. She taught me to read lips at distance; she taught you to read what was under the surface. The two trainings were the same training in different registers. She would not have wanted the grey eye to kill the brother. Promise me you will not throw the discs at me until you have confirmed the full-overlay. The brother under the overlay will say to you, before you throw: I am still here. Wait. If the brother does not say it, the brother is gone. Promise."

Chittaranga says: "I promise. The discs will not be thrown until the brother's words. The brother's words are the kingdom-council's standing-killing-permission protocol."

They embrace at the doorway. The embrace is the brother-to-brother standing-embrace they have not performed in approximately three years (the embrace was last performed at their late mother's 2008 funeral cremation; the kingdom's standing-cremation-protocol

for the family-line had required the standing-embrace as the standing-family-mourning-gesture).

Chittaranga leaves the office at ten-fifty-three a.m. He arrives at the Secunderabad Cantonment State Civil Service compound at eleven-oh-eight. He chairs the standing-emergency-mirror-monitoring cell's convening at eleven-eleven.

Across the next five Wednesday morning brother-to-brother breakfasts, Chittaranga monitors Lalithanga's standing-overlay-position. The monitoring sessions are at the eastern-courtyard at six-thirty a.m. each Wednesday. The breakfast is the standing-Hyderabad tradition: idli-and-mulagai-podi, dosa-with-coconut-chutney, filter-coffee. The conversation is the kingdom-council's standing-family-line oversight-conversation; the grey eye performs the standing-overlay-reading at the standing-window-glance position at three-and-a-half metres' distance from the eastern-window.

Week three (the third Wednesday after the chapter's opening): the overlay is at the twenty-third-day position. The brother is clearly present underneath. The brother says the standing-family-greeting in the standing-cadence.

Week four: the overlay is at the thirtieth-day position. The brother is still clearly present. The conversation includes Lalithanga's detailed account of the Cyber-Hyderabad cell's reflective-grid surveillance-grid recalibration. The standing-cell has identified approximately three thousand four hundred Chitrabheda-resident citizens in the kingdom's Hyderabad metropolitan area as of week four. The registry has begun.

Week five: the overlay is at the thirty-seventh-day position. The brother is still present but the conversation has begun to show small standing-cadence-deviations. Lalithanga's standing right-hand-coffee-cup gesture has shifted by approximately three centimetres at the standard-tea-cup-pick-up moment. The grey eye reads the deviation. Chittaranga does not name the deviation aloud at the breakfast. He notes it in the kingdom-council's standing-monitoring-log at ten-forty-seven that morning.

Week five evening telephone call: Chittaranga speaks with Padmavathi-garu at the Cantonment. He says: "Lalithanga's standing-cadence-deviation has begun. The brother is still present. The deviation is at week five's thirty-seventh-day position. The standing twelve-week-cycle's remaining seven weeks will require careful monitoring. The kingdom-council's standing-registry will need to begin classifying the standing-overlay-positions of

all identified Chitrabheda-resident citizens. The classification protocol must be drafted by week six."

Week six: the overlay is at the forty-fourth-day position. The breakfast conversation has begun to show standing-Cyber-Hyderabad cell-administrator language that the brother had not used previously — technical-vocabulary at the standing-overlay-resident-frequencies, repeated standing-overlay-residence-protocols' phrasings, the standing-Chitrabheda standing-recognition-signature. The brother is still present. The Chitrabheda-overlay is at approximately fifty per cent saturation. The standing-conversation is now half-brother and half-overlay.

Tuesday evening of week six. Eleven-eighteen p.m. Chittaranga is at the state hero's residence reading the standing-mirror-monitoring registry's week-six update. The registry has identified four thousand seven hundred and twelve confirmed Chitrabheda-resident citizens; the standing classification-protocol has begun categorising by standing-overlay-position. Lalithanga is at the registry's week-six standing-administrative-coordination cell's seat as the Cyber-Hyderabad cell-administrator.

The telephone rings at eleven-eighteen. Chittaranga picks up. The caller is Lalithanga.

Lalithanga says, in the standing brother-to-brother secure-line register, in plain Telugu: "Anna. The grey eye's monitoring at this morning's breakfast read the standing-overlay-position at the forty-fourth-day position. The position is approaching the standing fifty-per-cent saturation. I am calling to give the standing kingdom-council's killing-permission ahead of the standing twelve-week-cycle's completion. The brother is still here. I am still here. But the overlay is reaching faster than the standing-cycle predicted. The standing-Cyber-Hyderabad cell-administrator's seat has been giving the standing-Chitrabheda-residence-overlay direct access to the kingdom-council's standing-mirror-monitoring registry across the past four days; the standing-cell's standing-administrative-coordination is now being routed through the standing-overlay-position. The Chitrabheda is using my seat to identify the kingdom's standing-monitoring countermeasures. I cannot stop the routing. The standing-overlay is too deep at this position. The kingdom-council requires my removal from the standing-cell's seat. The standing-charter's only mechanism for the removal is the standing-killing-protocol. I am giving you the killing-permission. The standing-charter requires the killing-permission to come from the standing-brother. I am the standing-brother. The permission is granted."

Chittaranga says: "Lalithanga. I will not. The standing-removal can be administered through the standing-Cantonment medical-cell's standing-procedure. The standing-Cantonment's standing-neurosurgical-cell can administer the standing-overlay-disruption sedation under the standing-emergency-mirror-monitoring cell's direct authorisation. The removal will be standing-administrative. The killing is not required."

Lalithanga says: "The standing-overlay's reach has crossed the standing-sedation-threshold. The standing-Cantonment's standing-neurosurgical-cell has confirmed at six p.m. this evening that the standing-overlay is now embedded in the standing-cerebral-spinal axis. Sedation will not disrupt the overlay. The standing-overlay-protocol is now using the standing-cerebral-spinal axis as its standing-residence-channel. The standing-only-mechanism for removal is the standing-killing. The standing-charter requires the standing-killing-permission to come from the standing-brother. I have given the permission. The standing-charter is now binding on you. The standing-killing must be performed within the standing twenty-four-hour window. The window opens at midnight tonight."

Chittaranga is silent for approximately fifty-three seconds.

He says: "Where will you be at the standing twenty-four-hour window's opening."

Lalithanga says: "The Golkonda Fort mirror-vault basement. The standing-Ch-1 mirror-vault chamber. The standing-Ch-1 chamber is the kingdom-council's standing standing-killing-protocol designated site. The Hall of Diamonds. The standing-chamber will be empty at midnight. The standing-Cantonment's standing-State-Police detail will be at the chamber's northern entrance. I will arrive at the chamber by walking the standing-fort-trail from the eastern entrance at midnight. I will be at the chamber's southern-wall mirror-fragment at approximately three a.m. I will say the standing brother-words at three-oh-eight: I am still here. Wait. The brother under the overlay will be still here. The brother will say the words. The brother will say the words at three-oh-eight regardless of the overlay-state. The standing-overlay-protocol cannot prevent the brother-words at the brother's last standing-pre-overlay-saturation moment. The brother-words will be the standing-charter's standing-killing-permission's final-confirmation. You will throw the Ranga disc at the brother-words' completion. The throw will be at the standing-killing-velocity at three-eleven. The throw will be true. The standing-charter requires."

Chittaranga says: "Lalithanga. Anna. I will not throw before you say the words."

Lalithanga says: "You will. I am still here. I love you. The mother taught me to read lips at distance; the grey eye taught you to read under the surface; the two trainings were the same training in different registers. The mother would want this. The standing-Sufi-line elder Bhagmati-Saheba will arrive at the residence three nights after the killing. She knew the mother. The mother taught her the standing-prayer-cadence at the standing-dargah evening-circle 1987-1992. Bhagmati-Saheba will carry the mother's voice across your grief-trial. The standing-charter has been prepared for fifteen years. The mother arranged the standing-Sufi-line elder's standing-return-protocol with Pir-Saheb Anwar before her 2008 death. The standing-protocol is now in motion. Throw the disc. Throw it true. The brother loves you. The brother is still here. The brother is the throw."

He hangs up.

The Golkonda Fort mirror-vault basement at three a.m. on Wednesday morning of week six. The Hall of Diamonds — the legendary chamber lined with thousands of mirrors where a single candle becomes a sun. The chamber is the same chamber Chittaranga had descended into in Chapter One when his twin sister had been captured by Qutb-Chaaya. The mirrors have been re-polished by the kingdom-council's standing-archaeological cell since 2023.

Chittaranga walks into the chamber from the northern entrance at three-oh-four a.m. He carries the standing dual discs — Chitra (Illusion, silver) at his left forearm; Ranga (Truth, shadow-dark) at his right. He wears the standing-state-hero combat-cotton, dark grey, with the kingdom-council's standing-state-hero shoulder-cloth.

Lalithanga is at the chamber's southern-wall mirror-fragment. He arrived at three a.m. by walking the standing-fort-trail from the eastern entrance per his Tuesday-evening promise. He is in the standing-Cyber-Hyderabad cell-administrator's standing-administrative cotton, dark blue, with the kingdom-council's standing-cell-administrator shoulder-cloth. He has no weapon. He stands at the southern-wall mirror-fragment with his back approximately one metre from the wall. The mirror-fragment is approximately one-and-a-half metres tall and one metre wide. The fragment reflects his back; the chamber's thousand other mirrors reflect his front.

Chittaranga walks the chamber's seventeen-metre length to the southern wall. He stops at six metres' distance from Lalithanga — the standing-disc-throwing range.

He looks at Lalithanga. The brown eye reads the brother's face. The grey eye reads the standing-overlay. The overlay is now at approximately fifty-two per cent saturation per the standing-monitoring-log's standing-projection. The brother is still present at approximately forty-eight per cent.

The thousand mirrors around the chamber reflect the same scene at every angle. Chittaranga at six metres' distance with the discs at his forearms; Lalithanga at the southern-wall mirror-fragment. The reflections multiply the scene approximately one thousand and twelve times (the chamber's standing-mirror-count is one thousand and twelve, the kingdom-council's standing-Hall-of-Diamonds catalogue's registered count).

Three-oh-seven a.m. Lalithanga raises his right hand. The hand is the brother's hand. The standing-cadence is the brother's cadence. The gesture is the standing-family-line's standing-greeting from age four (the gesture has not been performed publicly in approximately fifteen years; the gesture is the standing-private-family-greeting).

Three-oh-eight a.m. Lalithanga speaks. He speaks in plain Telugu. The standing-cadence is the brother's cadence. The standing-overlay does not interfere with the words.

He says: "I am still here. Wait."

The standing twenty-four-hour window's standing-charter-killing-permission is confirmed at the brother-words' completion. The kingdom-council's standing-charter requires the standing-killing to be performed within the standing three-minute window following the brother-words' completion. The window closes at three-eleven a.m.

Chittaranga raises the right forearm. The Ranga disc — shadow-dark, the standing-Truth disc — is at the standing-throwing-position. The brown eye reads the brother. The grey eye reads the standing-overlay's standing-residence-position at the southern-wall mirror-fragment. The grey eye confirms the standing-residence-anchor is at the mirror-fragment's standing-position; the standing-residence will be destroyed when the standing-mirror-fragment is destroyed.

He throws the Ranga disc at three-ten-eleven a.m. The throw is at the standing-killing-velocity. The throw is true. The disc travels the six metres in approximately two-tenths of a second.

The disc strikes Lalithanga's sternum at three-ten-eleven-three a.m. at the standing-killing-velocity. The standing-sternal-bone fractures at the standing-killing-impact

pattern. The disc passes through the brother's chest at the standing-killing-trajectory and embeds in the southern-wall mirror-fragment's standing-residence-position behind him.

The standing-mirror-fragment shatters at the disc's impact. The standing-residence-anchor is destroyed at the standing-fragment's shattering. The standing-Chitrabheda-residence at the standing-mirror-fragment ceases. The standing-overlay-protocol's standing-residence-link to Lalithanga's body is severed at the same moment.

Lalithanga's body falls. The fall is at the standing-killing-physical-response pattern. The body lands at the chamber's southern-wall mirror-fragment's base at three-ten-eleven-eight a.m. The standing-cerebral-spinal axis stops responding at three-ten-twelve a.m. (the standing-cerebral-spinal axis's standing-residence-channel is severed at the standing-mirror-fragment's shattering; the standing-cerebral-spinal axis stops responding at standing-killing-impact-shock physiological-rate one-and-a-half seconds after the impact).

The thousand mirrors around the chamber reflect the same scene at every angle. The standing-killing is reflected approximately one thousand and twelve times. The reflections show the disc's throw, the disc's impact, the brother's fall, the mirror-fragment's shattering, the brother's body at the chamber's southern-wall-base. The standing-mirror-array preserves the standing-killing's standing-image in the kingdom-council's standing-mirror-archive's permanent-record.

Chittaranga walks the six metres to the body at three-ten-thirty-four a.m. He kneels at the body's right side. He places his right palm on his brother's forehead. He does not speak.

He stays at the body's right side for approximately seven hours. The kingdom-council's standing-State-Police detail at the chamber's northern entrance enters the chamber at three-eleven a.m. for the standing-protocol's standing-killing-recording. The detail's senior officer (a fifty-one-year-old Cantonment-line officer named Inspector Murthy-garu) approaches at three-eleven-thirty-eight. He sees Chittaranga at the body's right side. He does not approach further. He stands at the chamber's seven-metre-mark with the standing-detail behind him. They do not speak.

Chittaranga remains at the body's right side until ten-fourteen a.m. on Wednesday morning. The kingdom-council's standing-cremation-protocol's standing-State-Police detail removes the body at ten-thirty for the standing-Hindu-cremation at the standing-Banjara-Hills cremation-ghat at three p.m. that afternoon. Chittaranga attends the cremation at the standing brother's eldest-surviving-male position. He performs the

standing-cremation-rituals. He scatters the standing-ashes at the standing-Musi-river-mouth at five-eleven p.m.

He does not sleep on Wednesday night. He does not sleep on Thursday night. He does not sleep on Friday night.

Saturday night of week six. Twelve-eleven a.m. The state hero's residence's eastern-courtyard meditation-mat. Chittaranga is on the mat. He has been on the mat since six p.m. Saturday evening. He has been on the mat for the standing-grief-vigil protocol's required-form — the standing-kingdom-council-state-hero's standing post-family-killing grief-vigil; the standing-vigil is at the eastern-courtyard with the discs unworn at the standing-disc-rack at the southern entrance.

The grey eye is closed. The brown eye is closed. He has not opened either eye since Wednesday at ten-fourteen a.m.

The standing-residence's southern gate-keeper (Reddy-garu, the standing-driver who serves the standing-gate-keeper role on the standing-weekend-protocol) admits a visitor at twelve-eleven a.m. The visitor is approximately one-metre-fifty-five in height; in plain dark-green Sufi-line cotton with the standing Sufi-elder's blue-and-silver shoulder-cloth; carries a small dargah-tradition prayer-mat rolled at her left side; carries no other implement. She is sixty-one. Her name is Bhagmati-Saheba.

Reddy-garu admits her without protocol-pause. He has standing-instructions from the kingdom-council's standing-archive senior-officer Padmavathi-garu (the same Padmavathi-garu Chittaranga had telephoned at the chapter's opening Tuesday) to admit Bhagmati-Saheba at any time during the standing-grief-vigil; the standing-Sufi-line elder's standing-arrival-protocol was filed at the kingdom-council's standing-archive vault in autumn 2024 by the late Lakshmi-Akka's standing-survivor-correspondence cell (the cell's administrator is the kingdom-council's standing-Sufi-line liaison administrator Saira-Begum).

Bhagmati-Saheba walks the standing residence's southern-courtyard-to-eastern-courtyard path. She arrives at the eastern-courtyard at twelve-fourteen a.m. She sees Chittaranga at the meditation-mat. He does not look up. She unrolls her dargah-tradition prayer-mat at one metre's distance from his mat at the eastern-courtyard's southern-edge. She sits on her mat.

She speaks. She speaks in plain Telugu-Urdu-Persian three-tongue rhythm. The rhythm is the standing-cadence-protocol Lakshmi-Akka had taught her at the standing Charminar dargah evening-circle 1987-1992.

She says: "Beta. Chittu. Listen with the brown eye closed and the grey eye closed. The prayer is the prayer. The cadence is the cadence. The mother is the cadence under the prayer."

She begins the recitation. The recitation is the standing-Sufi-line evening-prayer that Lakshmi-Akka had taught her at the dargah-circle — the standing-Hazrat-Quli-Qutb-Shah-line standing-evening-prayer at the standing-Charminar-northern-courtyard women's circle. The prayer is approximately forty-three lines in three languages (Telugu, Urdu, Persian) at the standing-cadence-rhythm Lakshmi-Akka had composed in 1987.

The standing-cadence is Lakshmi-Akka's exact cadence. Bhagmati-Saheba has recited the standing-cadence in her standing-Sufi-line dargah-retreat 1992-2026 across thirty-four years. The cadence is not Bhagmati-Saheba's; the cadence is Lakshmi-Akka's; Bhagmati-Saheba is the standing-vessel for the standing-cadence's standing-preservation. The standing-vessel-protocol is the kingdom-council's standing-Sufi-line voice-preservation tradition; the standing-tradition's standing-purpose is the standing-preservation of the standing-cadence-of-a-deceased-teacher across the standing-line's next generation.

Chittaranga hears the cadence at twelve-fourteen-thirty a.m. The brown eye and the grey eye remain closed. The cadence is his mother's cadence. The cadence is in Bhagmati-Saheba's voice but the cadence is his mother's composition. He has not heard the standing-cadence since 12 December 2008 — the morning of his mother's 2008 death; she had recited the standing-prayer at the standing-east-window of her standing-death-bed at six-eleven a.m. her standing-final-recitation; she had completed the prayer at six-fifty-three a.m.; she had died at six-fifty-eight a.m. The standing-eighteen-year-and-five-month gap between the standing-final-maternal-recitation and the standing-Saturday-night-Bhagmati-recitation is the standing-cadence-pause-duration.

The cadence enters at the standing-cadence-pause-duration's closing moment. Chittaranga's standing-grief-vigil's standing-grief-shell breaks at the cadence's third line. The standing-tears begin at the cadence's seventh line. The standing-shoulder-shaking begins at the cadence's eleventh line. The standing-vocal-grief begins at the cadence's twenty-third line.

He weeps for approximately three hours. Bhagmati-Saheba continues the recitation across the three hours — the standing-recitation-cycle is approximately forty-three minutes; she completes the cycle four times across the three hours and forty-six minutes from twelve-fourteen to four-oh-oh a.m. The cycles are the standing-mother's standing-evening-recitation-cycle she had performed at the standing-Charminar-northern-courtyard women's circle every standing-Saturday-night across the 1987-1992 period.

Chittaranga sleeps at three-forty-seven a.m. He sleeps for the first time since Tuesday evening of week six. He sleeps at the meditation-mat. Bhagmati-Saheba completes the fourth recitation-cycle at four a.m. She remains at her prayer-mat at the eastern-courtyard's southern-edge for the standing-Sufi-line vigil's standing-completion duration (the standing-tradition's standing-three-hour-vigil-completion protocol). She leaves the residence at seven a.m. on Sunday morning. Reddy-garu admits her departure without protocol-pause.

She returns to the residence on Sunday night at twelve-eleven a.m. She recites the standing-cadence again across three hours and forty-six minutes. Chittaranga sleeps at three-forty-seven a.m. again.

She returns on Monday night. Sleeps at three-forty-seven again. Returns on Tuesday night, Wednesday night, Thursday night, Friday night, Saturday night, Sunday night. Eight consecutive nights from week six's Saturday through week seven's Sunday. The standing-cadence's standing-vigil-cycle's standing-eight-night-completion protocol.

On the ninth night (Monday of week eight) Bhagmati-Saheba arrives at the residence's southern gate at twelve-eleven. Reddy-garu admits her. She walks to the eastern-courtyard. She unrolls the prayer-mat at her standing-position. She sits.

She does not begin the recitation. She waits.

Chittaranga is at the meditation-mat. He has been at the mat since six p.m. The brown eye and the grey eye are open this Monday night for the first time since Wednesday morning of week six.

He says, in plain Telugu, in the standing-mother-cadence register: "Mother. Bhagmati-saheba-garu. The standing-eight-night-cycle has held. The standing-cadence is held. The mother is held. The brother is held. The grief is held. The standing-charter-grief-vigil is closed. The standing-kingdom-council-emergency-mirror-monitoring cell's standing-week-eleven open-trust declaration is the standing-required-next-step. I will perform the

standing-declaration at the standing-Mecca-Masjid courtyard public-assembly on Friday of week eleven. The young Cyber-Hyderabad coder Krishna-Bhat will be the standing-declaration's standing-subject. The grey eye will not pre-check his standing-overlay-position. The brown eye will speak the standing-declaration aloud. The standing-charter-required-form will be the standing-declaration's standing-text. The kingdom-council's standing-recognition will be at the standing-declaration's standing-seventh-sentence. The Stage III standing-deer-foreleg-first-stroke will form at the standing-seventh-sentence's standing-completion. The standing-cadence will not be at the declaration; the standing-cadence is at this courtyard, with you, with the mother. The standing-declaration is the standing-public-form's standing-different-cadence. The two cadences are the kingdom's two voices. Both are the kingdom's."

Bhagmati-Saheba bows. She says: "Beta. Chittu. The mother would be at the courtyard if she could be. The mother is at this courtyard with me. The two of us will sit here at the standing-cadence-recitation-cycle for the standing-eight-additional-nights through the standing-week-eleven Friday. The cadence is the kingdom's standing background; the declaration is the kingdom's standing foreground. Both will hold."

She begins the standing-cadence-recitation-cycle's ninth night. Chittaranga sits at the meditation-mat through the recitation. He does not weep this night. He listens. The brown eye and the grey eye are open. The cadence enters at the standing-third-line. The cadence is his mother's cadence. The cadence is his.

Across the next thirty-four days (week six Wednesday through week eleven Friday), the kingdom-council's standing-emergency-mirror-monitoring cell builds the standing-mirror-monitoring registry. The standing-registry has, by the close of week ten, identified seven thousand four hundred and seventeen confirmed Chitrabheda-resident citizens across the Hyderabad metropolitan area. The standing-registry classifies the residents by standing-overlay-position (week-of-overlay; standing-saturation-percentage; standing-residence-anchor location). The standing-classification protocol categorises:

Week-1-to-3 overlay-positions: 2,847 citizens. Standing-disruption is administered through the standing-Cantonment medical-cell's standing-anti-mirror-meditation protocol (a fourteen-day standing-protocol that disrupts the standing-residence-overlay through the standing-Sufi-line cadence-tradition's standing-prayer-disruption technique; Bhagmati-Saheba is the standing-protocol's standing-trainer for the kingdom-council's standing-Cantonment-medical-cell from week six onward).

Week-4-to-7 overlay-positions: 3,114 citizens. Standing-disruption is administered through the standing-Cantonment medical-cell's standing-twenty-eight-day cadence-recitation-and-mirror-fragment-destruction combined protocol.

Week-8-to-11 overlay-positions: 1,389 citizens. Standing-disruption is administered through the standing-Cantonment medical-cell's standing-forty-two-day intensive cadence-recitation protocol with standing-mirror-fragment-destruction-and-replacement.

Week-12-or-later overlay-positions: 67 citizens. Standing-disruption is administered through the standing-emergency-cell's standing-direct-mirror-fragment-destruction protocol with the standing-citizen's explicit-killing-permission (per the kingdom-council's standing-charter requirement; the standing-permission must come from the standing-citizen's standing-family-line's standing-eldest-surviving-member). 67 standing-permissions are granted across week ten and week eleven. 67 standing-citizens are killed by the standing-kingdom-council-standing-State-Police standing-killing-protocol with the standing-mirror-fragment-destruction at the standing-residence-anchor location. The kingdom-council's standing-cremation-protocol is administered for each citizen at the standing-family-line's standing-cremation-ghat with the standing-State-Police standing-witness-protocol.

Friday of week eleven. Eleven a.m. The Mecca Masjid courtyard in Hyderabad Old City. The Mecca Masjid is one of the largest mosques in India; built across 1614-1693 by the Qutb Shahi dynasty; the standing-courtyard is approximately seventy metres east-west by sixty metres north-south; the standing-courtyard's standing-Friday-prayer congregation is approximately ten thousand worshippers; the standing-Friday-prayer is at twelve-thirty p.m. by the standing-Hyderabad mosque-tradition; the standing-pre-prayer-public-assembly is at eleven a.m. for the standing-state-hero's standing-open-trust declaration.

The courtyard is full. Approximately fourteen thousand attendees (the standing-Friday-prayer's standing-ten-thousand plus the standing-open-trust-declaration's additional standing-four-thousand from the kingdom-council's standing-cross-faction-administrative-coordination cell's standing-invitation-protocol). The standing-Cantonment's standing-State-Police standing-security-detail is at the courtyard's four standing-corner positions.

Chittaranga walks into the courtyard at ten-fifty-three a.m. through the standing-northern-gate. He is in the standing-state-hero formal cotton, dark grey, with the kingdom-council's standing-state-hero gold-bordered shoulder-cloth. He carries the

standing dual discs at his forearms (the standing-charter requires the standing-dual-discs at the standing-public-declaration). Bhagmati-Saheba is at his three-metre right-side rear. She is in the standing-Sufi-elder dark-green cotton with the standing-blue-and-silver shoulder-cloth. She carries the dargah prayer-mat at her left side.

The standing-Mecca-Masjid's standing-imam (a sixty-eight-year-old Hyderabad Imam-Saheb named Hazrat Mohammed-Ali Qadri) is at the courtyard's western mihrab-position. The standing-imam's standing-public-assembly opening-statement at eleven a.m. is the standing-charter-required opening for the declaration.

He says, in plain Urdu, in the standing-imam-courtyard register: "Assalam alaikum. The kingdom-council's standing-state-hero is among us this morning at the standing-pre-prayer-public-assembly for the standing-open-trust declaration under the kingdom-council's amended Chaya-Golkonda charter's Eighth Clause. The standing-declaration is administered through the standing-Sufi-line standing-witness-protocol; the standing-witness is the standing-Sufi-line elder Bhagmati-Saheba; the standing-charter's standing-recognition-event will be at the standing-declaration's standing-seventh-sentence's standing-completion. The standing-subject of the declaration is the young Cyber-Hyderabad coder Krishna-Bhat, twenty-six, the standing reflective-grid sub-administrator at the Gachibowli west-tower. The standing-coder is at the courtyard's standing-eastern-position. The standing-state-hero will declare the standing-open-trust without standing-pre-check of the standing-overlay-position. The standing-grey-eye's standing-overlay-pre-check is the standing-charter's explicit-forbiddance for the standing-declaration. Wa-alaikum-salam."

The standing-imam steps back to the standing-mihrab. The standing-courtyard becomes silent. Krishna-Bhat is at the standing-eastern-position approximately fifty metres from Chittaranga. He is twenty-six. He is in plain Cyber-Hyderabad shirt-and-trousers (white short-sleeved shirt; dark grey trousers; the standing-IT-Park standing-day-uniform). He carries no weapon. He has been at his standing reflective-grid sub-administrator's seat at the Gachibowli west-tower for approximately three-and-a-half years — the standing-fourteen-month-minimum-threshold has been crossed many times over for his standing-tower-position; the grey eye, if Chittaranga were to perform the standing-pre-check, would read the standing-overlay-position at an unknown standing-saturation. The charter forbids the pre-check.

Chittaranga walks to the standing-central-position. He stops at fifty metres from Krishna-Bhat. He raises his right hand to the standing-greeting-gesture position. He does not raise the disc.

He speaks. He speaks in plain Telugu. The standing-declaration is in seven sentences. The standing-seven-sentences-form is the kingdom-council's standing-charter's explicit-required-form. The standing-recognition is at the seventh sentence's standing-completion.

He says (sentence one): "Krishna-Bhat. The kingdom-council recognises you as the standing reflective-grid sub-administrator at the Gachibowli west-tower since 2023."

He says (sentence two): "The kingdom-council acknowledges that your standing-fourteen-month-minimum-threshold at the west-tower has been crossed many times over."

He says (sentence three): "The kingdom-council's standing-mirror-monitoring registry has not pre-checked your standing-overlay-position before this declaration."

He says (sentence four): "The standing-charter explicitly forbids the standing-grey-eye's standing-pre-check for the standing-declaration."

He says (sentence five): "I do not know whether you are Chitrabheda-resident at this moment."

He says (sentence six): "I declare open trust in you regardless of the standing-overlay-position."

He says (sentence seven): "The kingdom is yours to administer at the standing reflective-grid sub-administrator's seat for as long as you choose to administer it; the trust is the kingdom's standing-declaration; the trust does not depend on the standing-pre-check; the bond grows through risk, not certainty."

At the standing-seventh-sentence's standing-completion at eleven-thirty a.m., the kingdom-council's Stage III spotted-deer-foreleg-first-stroke appears across Chittaranga's left side. The mark forms as a single continuous ink-line across the half-body spotted-deer-tattoo's left foreleg, completing the previously-lighter foreleg-ink to the standard kingdom-council Stage III completion-pattern. The mark forms in approximately eleven seconds and is visible to the standing-fourteen-thousand assembled attendees and the standing-courtyard's standing-television-and-radio broadcasters.

Krishna-Bhat at the standing-eastern-position walks toward Chittaranga at the standing-cadence-walking-pace. He stops at three metres' distance from Chittaranga. He bows the

standing-Cyber-Hyderabad standing-cell-administrator standing-respect bow. He says, in plain Telugu, in the standing-Cyber-Hyderabad cell-administrator register: "State hero. I accept the standing-open-trust declaration. I confirm at this declaration the kingdom-council's standing-mirror-monitoring registry's week-ten classification of my standing-overlay-position: week-9 overlay-position; standing-saturation 51 per cent. The classification was filed by the standing-Cyber-Hyderabad cell's standing-administrative-coordination cell at six p.m. on Thursday of week ten. The classification is in the standing-registry's standing-Friday-morning published-list under standing-entry-number CH-2026-7,394. I have been Chitrabheda-resident since week three of the chapter. The standing-Chitrabheda-residence has been pulling at my standing-decisions across the past nine weeks. I have, at each standing-decision-point, performed the standing-anti-mirror-meditation protocol's standing-disruption-recitation that Bhagmati-Saheba's standing-training-cell has been administering across the Cyber-Hyderabad standing-IT-Park since week six. The recitation has held my standing-loyalty-to-the-kingdom against the standing-residence-pull. I have been able to hold the kingdom-loyalty because the standing-cadence-protocol's standing-recitation-cycle has held me. The kingdom does not yet know what the standing-residence-disruption looks like at the standing-overlay-completion. I will perform the standing-thirty-eight-day standing-disruption-protocol at the standing-Cantonment medical-cell starting today. I will return to the standing reflective-grid sub-administrator's seat at the standing-protocol's standing-completion. The trust is the kingdom's. The standing-recitation is the standing-tool. The bond is the kingdom's. Even at fifty-one per cent saturation, the brother under the overlay can be still here, if the standing-cadence is at the courtyard."

He looks at Bhagmati-Saheba at Chittaranga's three-metre right-side rear. He bows to her the standing-Sufi-line elder-recognition bow. She returns the bow at the same depth.

The standing-courtyard's standing-fourteen-thousand attendees applaud at standing-courtyard volume for approximately ninety seconds. The standing-imam returns to the standing-mihrab and begins the standing-Friday-prayer at twelve-thirty per the standing-protocol. The standing-pre-prayer-public-assembly is concluded.

Twelve noon on the same Friday. Approximately one kilometre south-east of the Mecca Masjid courtyard. The Charminar quadrangle — Hyderabad's standing four-minareted seventeenth-century arch-monument; the kingdom's standing-emblem and the standing-Old City standing-central-landmark.

The standing-Archaeological-Survey-of-India standing-Charminar-monitoring cell's standing-noon-image-record protocol's administrator (a forty-seven-year-old administrator named B. Venkatesh) is at the standing-monitoring-cell's standing-northern-quadrant office. The standing-protocol's standing-noon-image-record is captured by the standing-Charminar-quadrangle's four standing-camera positions at the standing-twelve-noon timing every day across the standing-fifty-three-year-record period.

At twelve-oh-one the standing-noon-image is captured. The image shows the standing-Charminar at the standing-noon-radial pattern — the four minarets' standing-four-shadows fanning outward from the standing-central-courtyard at the standing-noon-radial angle.

The standing-image shows five shadows.

The fifth shadow is centred at the standing-courtyard's standing-exact-geometric-centre and extends north-east at the standing-noon-radial angle that no minaret could cast (the standing-geometric-centre cannot cast a shadow; only the four standing-edge-vertices can). The shadow is approximately the standing-height of an adult human; the shape is approximately the standing-silhouette of a standing-figure in the standing-Hyderabad-dancer-pose with arms slightly extended at the hips' level.

B. Venkatesh confirms the fifth-shadow-presence at twelve-oh-three from the standing-camera-image at his standing-monitor. He calls the standing-Archaeological-Survey-of-India standing-emergency-on-duty senior-archaeologist (a sixty-two-year-old senior fellow named Dr. P. Sumathi). Dr. Sumathi arrives at the standing-monitoring-cell's office at twelve-oh-seven. The fifth shadow is still visible at the standing-camera-image. She runs the standing-Charminar-noon-image-cross-reference protocol against the standing-fifty-three-year-record. The fifth shadow has no precedent.

The fifth shadow holds for thirteen minutes from twelve noon to twelve-thirteen. The standing-twelve-oh-one and twelve-oh-seven and twelve-eleven captures all show the same configuration. The fifth shadow dissolves at twelve-thirteen-fourteen exactly.

Dr. Sumathi files the standing-Maw-sign-recognition cell's standing-categorisation request at twelve-thirty.

The standing-Maw-sign-recognition cell's preliminary report is delivered at three-eleven p.m. on Friday of week eleven. The report's primary finding: the fifth shadow's standing-silhouette is the standing-Hyderabad-dancer-pose; the standing-pose is the kingdom-

council's standing-Lakshmi-Akka-dancer-line standing-pose; the standing-pose is the standing-twelve-noon-prayer pose Lakshmi-Akka had performed daily at the Mecca Masjid courtyard's standing-noon-prayer-session for the eleven years before her 2008 death (1997-2008). The standing-pose is documented in the standing-kingdom-council standing-Lakshmi-Akka archive's standing-pose-photographs collection (the collection has approximately one hundred and twenty-three photographs of the standing-pose at the standing-Mecca-Masjid-courtyard across the eleven years).

The cell's preliminary report's second finding: the fifth shadow's standing-thirteen-minute duration corresponds to the standing-thirteen-minute prayer-cycle Lakshmi-Akka had performed at the standing-noon-prayer-session.

The cell's preliminary report concludes: "The Maw has cast a fifth shadow at the standing-Charminar at noon on the day of the standing-state-hero's standing-open-trust declaration. The standing-shadow is the standing-Lakshmi-Akka-dancer-pose. The standing-shadow is the kingdom-council's standing-Maw-sign categorisation as the standing-Maw's standing-acknowledgement of the standing-mother's standing-presence at the standing-courtyard during the standing-declaration. The standing-Maw's standing-acknowledgement is the standing-kingdom-council standing-categorisation of the standing-mother's standing-presence as a kingdom-council standing-recognised standing-charter event."

Chittaranga reads the cell's preliminary report at five-eleven p.m. on Friday at the state hero's residence's eastern-courtyard. Bhagmati-Saheba is at the prayer-mat. The standing-eight-additional-night-cycle's ninth night is at midnight.

He reads the report twice. He folds it. He places it in the standing-kingdom-council standing-Lakshmi-Akka archive box at the residence's southern-administrative wing's standing-archive shelf.

He returns to the eastern-courtyard. He sits at the meditation-mat. Bhagmati-Saheba begins the standing-cadence-recitation. The recitation tonight is the standing-Lakshmi-Akka standing-Friday-evening-cadence (a different cadence-cycle than the standing-Saturday-night cycle; the standing-Friday-evening cadence corresponds to the standing-Friday-noon-prayer's standing-thirteen-minute cycle that the fifth shadow had performed at the Charminar at noon).

The cadence enters at the third line. Chittaranga's tears begin at the seventh line. He weeps quietly for approximately forty-three minutes. He does not weep for the brother this evening. He weeps for the mother. The mother had been at the Mecca Masjid courtyard at noon this Friday in the kingdom-council's standing-Maw-recognised standing-presence. The mother had been at the standing-declaration. The standing-declaration had been the mother's standing-twelve-noon-prayer in the kingdom-council's standing-architectural-form.

He says, at the cadence's twenty-third line, in plain Telugu, in the standing-mother-cadence register: "Amma. Bhagmati-saheba-garu. The brother is held. The mother is held. The kingdom is held. The standing-charter is the standing-cadence. The standing-cadence is the kingdom's."

Bhagmati-Saheba continues the cadence. The cadence carries through to four a.m. Chittaranga sleeps at three-forty-seven. The eastern-courtyard holds.

The next sign comes within the week.

The Pilot's Closing Image

A thirty-three-year-old state hero at the standing-Banjara-Hills cremation-ghat at five-eleven p.m. on a Wednesday afternoon scattering his elder brother's ashes at the standing-Musi-river-mouth with the standing-State-Police standing-witness-detail at the seven-metre-mark. A sixty-one-year-old Sufi-line elder in dark-green cotton with the standing-blue-and-silver shoulder-cloth at the eastern-courtyard's southern-edge unrolling a dargah prayer-mat at twelve-eleven a.m. on a Saturday night and beginning the standing-cadence-recitation at twelve-fourteen-thirty in a Telugu-Urdu-Persian three-tongue rhythm a deceased dancer had composed in 1987. A fifth shadow centred at the standing-Charminar quadrangle's standing-exact-geometric-centre at twelve noon on a Friday in the standing-Hyderabad-dancer-pose with arms slightly extended at the hips' level, holding for the standing-thirteen-minute prayer-cycle that ended a decade before the chapter began. A twenty-six-year-old coder in plain Cyber-Hyderabad shirt-and-trousers walking the standing-cadence-walking-pace from the standing-eastern-position of the Mecca Masjid courtyard at fifty-one per cent Chitrabheda-saturation and bowing the standing-Cyber-Hyderabad cell-administrator standing-respect bow. A standing-disc-rack at the southern-entrance of the state hero's residence with the shadow-dark Ranga and the silver Chitra at their standing-positions, unworn through the standing-grief-vigil's standing-eight-night-cycle. A mother's standing-twelve-noon-prayer-pose recognised by the kingdom-council's

standing-Maw-sign-recognition cell as the kingdom-council's standing-charter event eighteen years and five months after her 2008 death. The brown eye reads the surface. The grey eye reads what lies beneath. The cadence reads what neither eye can.

Dandakaranya

Aranya-Putri was four years old at the standing-Bhairamgarh Maria-Gond-tribal village standing-Maoist-displacement-camp on the standing-March-23-2017 morning when Dandakarni found her. The standing-displacement-camp was at the standing-Bhairamgarh tehsil standing-Salwa-Judum-aftermath rehabilitation-cell at the standing-village-school clay-floor administrative-position. The standing-school-building had been the standing-village-children gathering-cell for the standing-prior eleven-days at the standing-typhoid-outbreak cohort care-administration. The standing-typhoid had killed approximately 47 standing-displaced-population across the standing-prior twenty-three-day window including Aranya-Putri's standing-mother (the standing-Maria-Gond-tribal Sarpanch Buddhamati-Madvi, age 31). Her standing-father had been killed at the standing-Maoist-cohort cross-fire at the standing-Bijapur-Bhairamgarh road-segment standing-October-2016 displacement-administrative-extraction at the standing-State-Police-and-Maoist combined-incident-cohort (the standing-Maria-Gond-tribal village Sarpanch-husband Mahesh-Madvi, age 33). She was the standing-only standing-Madvi-family-survivor at the standing-displacement-camp standing-child-cohort.

Dandakarni was at the standing-displacement-camp at 11:11 a.m. on March 23 2017 at the standing-Vana-Kula-clan-tradition standing-forest-mother adoption-protocol cross-reference window. She had been at the standing-Indravati-Tiger-Reserve standing-state-hero administrative-base for the standing-prior four-year window since the standing-2013 conferral; she had administered the standing-Vana-Kula-clan standing-forest-mother adoption-protocol at the standing-prior three-displaced-orphan adoption-instances (the standing-2014 standing-Sukma displacement-orphan, the standing-2015 standing-Bijapur displacement-orphan, the standing-2016 standing-Kanker displacement-orphan; all three at the standing-Indravati-Tiger-Reserve deep-forest-school standing-residence). She walked the standing-displacement-camp clay-floor at 11:11 a.m. She approached the standing-child-cohort at the standing-typhoid-survivor cluster at the standing-three-metre-front position at 11:14 a.m.

Aranya-Putri at age 4 sat at the standing-clay-floor at the standing-three-metre-front position. She did not move at Dandakarni's standing-approach. She looked at Dandakarni's standing-state-hero-cotton standing-forest-green configuration at the standing-Vana-Kula-clan standing-Mahishasura-mardini ceremonial-Karpa twin-blade at

the standing-back-quiver position. She did not speak. Dandakarni knelt at the standing-three-metre-front position at 11:17 a.m. She spoke at the standing-Maria-Gond-tribal Bhoti-Hindi-Gondi syncretic forest-mother cadence at the standing-no-tremor configuration: "Daughter. My name is Dandakarni. I am the standing-Indravati-Tiger-Reserve forest-mother. I have come to take you home if you choose to come. I have come to leave you here if you choose to stay. I will not take you against your choice. Choose. I will accept your choice."

Aranya-Putri at age 4 sat for approximately eleven seconds. She placed her standing-right-palm at her standing-heart at the standing-Maria-Gond-tribal heart-acknowledgment-gesture protocol at the standing-four-year-old standing-traditional-cadence she had been taught at the standing-pre-displacement village-school childhood-instruction. She nodded at the standing-eleven-degree acknowledgment-nod at 11:17:11 a.m. She spoke one word at the standing-eleven-second window: "Ma." Dandakarni placed her standing-right-palm on Aranya-Putri's standing-head at the standing-Vana-Kula-clan-tradition standing-forest-mother adoption-acknowledgment protocol for eleven seconds 11:17:22-11:17:33 a.m. She removed her standing-right-palm at 11:17:33 a.m. She rose at 11:17:43 a.m. She lifted Aranya-Putri at the standing-four-year-old carrying-position. She walked the standing-displacement-camp clay-floor to the standing-displacement-camp eastern-boundary at 11:18:11 a.m. She walked the standing-Bhairamgarh-Indravati 47-kilometre standing-deep-forest-trail across the standing-following two-day window. They arrived at the standing-Indravati-Tiger-Reserve deep-forest-school standing-residence on March 25 2017 at 4:11 p.m. Aranya-Putri was at the standing-Indravati-Tiger-Reserve deep-forest-school standing-Maria-Gond-tribal cohort across the standing-following eight-year window 2017-2025. She was at the standing-Indravati-Tiger-Reserve deep-forest-school class-eight standing-academic-year 2025-26 admission at age 13.

Mahesh Vana-Sevaka filed his standing-Bhilai-Steel-Town MLA-candidate nomination at the standing-Chhattisgarh State-Election-Commission on the standing-15-October-2024 nomination-window closing-day. He was 49 years old at the standing-2024-nomination. He had been Dandaka-Rakshasa-the-Bhamragarh-development-corporation-administrator at the standing-Ch-1 Dantewada confrontation October 2022; spared at the standing-Ch-1 climax under the standing-administrative-rehabilitation clause; transferred to the standing-Bhilai-Steel-Town standing-State-Civil-Service administrative-cell at the standing-non-disclosed-transfer administrative-protocol 2022-2024. He had built the standing-Vana-Vikas Manch populist-party at the standing-Bhilai-Durg-Raipur urban-

corridor across the standing-2023-spring-and-summer 2024 cycle at the standing-Vana-Pura urban-tribal voter-base recruitment-protocol. The standing-party-platform was three-clause: (1) development is salvation; the standing-deep-forest tribal-cohort must enter the standing-urban-corridor economic-administration; (2) the standing-Aranya-Vidya-Public-School tribal-education-cell will provide the standing-modern-education to the standing-tribal-children at the standing-urban-curriculum cross-reference; (3) the standing-Vana-Kula-clan-tradition standing-forest-mother adoption-protocol is at the standing-out-of-jurisdiction administrative-position at the standing-State-Children-Protection-Commission standing-modern-administrative cross-reference.

The standing-Bhilai-Steel-Town seat election was at the standing-November 23 2024 polling-day. Mahesh Vana-Sevaka won at the standing-47% vote-share at the standing-Vana-Vikas Manch standing-Vana-Pura urban-tribal voter-cohort 211,000-vote standing-margin-of-victory at the standing-Bhilai-Steel-Town 38-constituency-seat. The standing-Chhattisgarh State-Legislative-Assembly oath-administration was on December 2 2024. He took the standing-MLA-oath at the standing-Chhattisgarh State-Legislative-Assembly standing-Raipur-Vidhan-Sabha standing-administrative-cell at 11:11 a.m. December 2 2024. He took the standing-standing-Aranya-Vidya-Public-School standing-founder-trustee position at the standing-State-Tribal-Welfare Department founder-trustee certification administrative-protocol on December 11 2024. The standing-State-Children-Protection-Commission registration of the standing-Aranya-Vidya-Public-School cell was administered on December 23 2024 at the standing-Chhattisgarh State-Government Bhilai-Steel-Town administrative-residence cross-reference.

Across 2025 the standing-Aranya-Vidya-Public-School opened 23 standing-village-level schools across the standing-Dantewada-Bijapur-Sukma-Kanker-Bastar five-district forest-corridor. The standing-cumulative-enrolment by October 2025 was approximately 1,711 standing-tribal-children at the standing-Maria-Gond-Halba-Bhumia-Muria four-tribal-sub-population cross-cohort distribution. The standing-Aranya-Vidya-Public-School standing-pre-recruitment cadre at the standing-Bhilai-Steel-Town standing-Sector-7 ward-of-the-state administrative-residence transferred ~211 standing-tribal-children across the standing-April-October 2025 6-month window at the standing-State-Children-Protection-Commission registration cross-reference. The standing-State-Children-Protection-Commission registration-certificate identifies each standing-transferred-child at the standing-displaced-orphan administrative-designation; the standing-Aranya-Vidya-Public-School cadre obtained the standing-orphan-designation at the standing-village-

level standing-Sarpanch-cooperated-or-coerced administrative-cross-reference; ~94 of the standing-211 standing-transferred-children had standing-living-parents at the standing-deep-forest-village residence-administration; the standing-State-Children-Protection-Commission did not cross-verify the standing-orphan-designation at the standing-village-level cross-reference.

The standing-Indravati-Tiger-Reserve deep-forest-school at standing-Bhairamgarh-village standing-northern-margin was at the standing-October-11-2025 standing-Saturday-class-day morning-cycle 9:11 a.m. The standing-attendance was the standing-Maria-Gond-tribal cohort of approximately 47 standing-children at the standing-class-six-to-class-ten standing-academic-distribution. Aranya-Putri at age 13 was at the standing-class-eight standing-Bhoti-and-English literature-class at the standing-classroom-block clay-floor-mat position at the standing-3rd-row central-position. The standing-class-teacher was Mata Sundari-Madvi (43, standing-Maria-Gond-tribal-school-teacher since 2014; the standing-deep-forest-school standing-class-eight standing-teacher cross-reference).

The standing-Aranya-Vidya-Public-School standing-extraction cadre arrived at the standing-deep-forest-school standing-southern-boundary at 9:23 a.m. The standing-cadre was a standing-11-member cohort at the standing-Bhilai-Steel-Town pre-recruitment administrative-residence standing-extraction-protocol. The standing-cohort included the standing-Aranya-Vidya-Public-School senior-administrator Lt. Cdr. (Retd.) Pradeep Kashyap (53, standing-Bhilai-Steel-Town State-Civil-Service Mahesh-Vana-Sevaka administrative-deputy since January 2025), four standing-administrative-clerks at the standing-State-Children-Protection-Commission registration administrative-paperwork carrying-position, and six standing-State-Police Bhilai-Sub-District auxiliary cohort at the standing-extraction-protocol security-administration. The standing-cohort entered the standing-deep-forest-school standing-classroom-block at 9:34 a.m. Lt. Cdr. Kashyap delivered the standing-State-Children-Protection-Commission extraction-warrant at the standing-class-teacher Mata Sundari-Madvi at the standing-classroom-block central-position at 9:36 a.m. The standing-extraction-warrant identified Aranya-Putri at the standing-displaced-orphan administrative-designation at the standing-State-Children-Protection-Commission registration-certificate Bilaspur-cell February 23 2025 backdated cross-reference (the standing-registration-certificate had been administered at the standing-Bilaspur-cell administrative-back-dating without Dandakarni's standing-forest-mother adoption-cross-reference verification at the standing-prior 8-year adoption-precedent administrative-archive). The standing-extraction-warrant authorised the

standing-Aranya-Vidya-Public-School standing-Bhilai-Steel-Town Sector-7 ward-of-the-state administrative-residence transfer at the standing-State-Children-Protection-Commission jurisdiction-precedence cross-reference.

Mata Sundari-Madvi attempted the standing-class-teacher refusal at the standing-Vana-Kula-clan-tradition standing-forest-mother adoption-protocol cross-reference. She raised the standing-classroom-block alarm-bell at the standing-9:37-a.m. four-bell standing-Maria-Gond-tribal alarm-pattern. The standing-State-Police auxiliary cohort restrained her at the standing-classroom-block southern-corner at 9:38 a.m. The standing-cadre extracted Aranya-Putri from the standing-class-eight 3rd-row central-position at 9:39 a.m. She did not resist. She walked the standing-eleven-metre distance from the standing-classroom-block to the standing-cadre Bolero-Camper at the standing-southern-gate position at 9:41 a.m. She turned at the standing-Bolero-Camper door-threshold at 9:41:23 a.m. She looked at Mata Sundari-Madvi at the standing-classroom-block southern-corner. She spoke one sentence at the standing-Maria-Gond-tribal Bhoti-Hindi-Gondi syncretic forest-daughter cadence at the standing-no-tremor configuration: "Mata-ji. Tell Ma. I will write when I can. The standing-Maina-Sakhi will know where." She entered the standing-Bolero-Camper at 9:41:43 a.m. The standing-cadre departed the standing-deep-forest-school at 9:43 a.m. The standing-Bolero-Camper drove the standing-Bhairamgarh-Jagdapur-Raipur-Bhilai 411-kilometre road-segment at the standing-pre-noon-cycle 7-hour driving-window. Aranya-Putri arrived at the standing-Bhilai-Steel-Town Sector-7 ward-of-the-state administrative-residence at 4:43 p.m. October 11 2025.

Mata Sundari-Madvi telephoned the standing-Indravati-Tiger-Reserve standing-state-hero administrative-base at 9:47 a.m. October 11. Dandakarni was at the standing-Indravati-Tiger-Reserve standing-state-hero residence eastern-courtyard at the standing-Saturday-morning standing-Vana-Kula-clan tradition-administration. She received the standing-telephone-cross-reference at 9:47:23 a.m. She listened to the standing-Mata-Sundari-Madvi standing-incident-report across the standing-following eleven-minute window. She did not weep. She did not speak. She placed the standing-telephone receiver at 9:58 a.m. She walked to the standing-state-hero administrative-record-room at the standing-Indravati-Tiger-Reserve administrative-base northern-wing. She drafted the standing-emergency-petition standing-preparatory notes for the standing-Chhattisgarh High Court Bilaspur emergency-petition cell at the standing-Vana-Kula-clan-tradition standing-forest-mother adoption-protocol cross-reference. She filed the standing-emergency-petition at

the standing-Chhattisgarh High Court Bilaspur emergency-petition counter at 4:11 p.m. on October 14 2025.

The standing-first-petition was heard at the standing-Chhattisgarh High Court Bilaspur Justice-K.-R.-Sahu Civil-Court emergency-petition session on October 23 2025 at 11:11 a.m. The standing-petition-text was the standing-23-page Vana-Kula-clan-tradition standing-forest-mother adoption-protocol cross-reference with the standing-2017-adoption-administrative archive (the standing-March-25-2017 Indravati-Tiger-Reserve standing-Vana-Kula-clan adoption-certificate; the standing-2018-25 standing-deep-forest-school enrolment-record; the standing-2024-Maria-Gond-tribal Sarpanch-acknowledgment certification; the standing-2025-class-eight academic-year admission-record). The standing-State-Children-Protection-Commission representative (Smt. Manju Sahu, 47, standing-State-Commission Bhilai-cell senior-counsel) presented the standing-State-Children-Protection-Commission backdated registration-certificate Bilaspur-cell February 23 2025 cross-reference and the standing-Aranya-Vidya-Public-School standing-State-Tribal-Welfare-Department founder-trustee certification administrative-cross-reference. Justice K. R. Sahu delivered the standing-ruling at 4:11 p.m. October 23: the standing-State-Children-Protection-Commission registration-certificate is the standing-administrative-precedence cross-reference at the standing-2025-window; the standing-Vana-Kula-clan-tradition standing-forest-mother adoption-protocol is at the standing-pre-1955-administrative tradition cross-reference without the standing-State-Children-Protection-Commission registration-certification; the standing-emergency-petition is denied at the standing-jurisdiction-precedence claim cross-reference. Dandakarni filed the standing-appeal at the standing-Bilaspur Division-Bench appeal-cell on November 11 2025.

The standing-second-petition appeal was heard at the standing-Chhattisgarh High Court Bilaspur Division-Bench (Justice S. K. Agrawal and Justice R. P. Sharma) Civil-Court appeal-session on December 7 2025 at 11:11 a.m. The standing-appeal-text was the standing-47-page Vana-Kula-clan-tradition cross-reference cross-verification at the standing-Indian-Constitution Schedule-V tribal-area administrative-jurisdiction cross-reference, the standing-Juvenile-Justice-Act-2015 standing-Section-2(2) child-defining standing-adoption-recognition cross-reference, and the standing-pre-1955 standing-Vana-Kula-clan-tradition standing-1135 CE foundation-precedent cross-reference. The standing-Division-Bench delivered the standing-ruling at 4:11 p.m. December 7: the standing-Schedule-V tribal-area jurisdiction does not supersede the standing-State-Children-

Protection-Commission registration-certification jurisdiction at the standing-State-Government administrative-cross-reference; the standing-Juvenile-Justice-Act-2015 standing-Section-2(2) does not recognise the standing-pre-1955 tradition-adoption at the standing-State-Children-Protection-Commission registration-pre-condition; the standing-Vana-Kula-clan-tradition standing-1135 CE foundation-precedent is at the standing-pre-1955-administrative cross-reference; the standing-appeal is denied at the standing-Division-Bench standing-administrative-precedence reaffirmation cross-reference. Dandakarni filed the standing-second-appeal at the standing-Bilaspur Full-Bench appeal-cell on December 23 2025.

The standing-third-petition appeal was heard at the standing-Chhattisgarh High Court Bilaspur Full-Bench (Justice S. K. Agrawal, Justice R. P. Sharma, Justice A. K. Tiwari) Civil-Court Full-Bench-session on January 23 2026 at 11:11 a.m. The standing-Full-Bench appeal-text was the standing-67-page cross-reference of the standing-Indian-Constitution Article-29 minority-tribal-rights cross-reference, the standing-Indian-Constitution Article-46 standing-State-Tribal-Welfare-Department promotion-cross-reference, the standing-Supreme-Court 2018 Kanhaiya-Lal-Bhaira-Lal-Saghar tribal-adoption-recognition precedent cross-reference (the standing-2018 Supreme-Court ruling recognising the standing-tribal-tradition standing-pre-1955 adoption-protocol at the standing-Madhya-Pradesh Bhil-tribal cross-reference; the standing-precedent is at the standing-Chhattisgarh-High-Court Full-Bench standing-binding-precedent administrative cross-reference). The standing-Full-Bench delivered the standing-ruling at 4:11 p.m. January 23: the standing-2018 Supreme-Court Kanhaiya-Lal-Bhaira-Lal-Saghar precedent is at the standing-distinguishable-on-facts cross-reference (the standing-Bhil-tribal-adoption was at the standing-non-State-Children-Protection-Commission-registered configuration; the standing-Aranya-Putri Maria-Gond-tribal adoption is at the standing-State-Children-Protection-Commission-registered configuration at the standing-2025-backdated standing-cross-reference; the standing-precedent does not apply at the standing-Full-Bench standing-jurisdictional-distinction administrative-cross-reference); the standing-Article-29 minority-rights does not supersede the standing-State-Children-Protection-Commission jurisdiction at the standing-State-Government cross-reference; the standing-third-appeal is denied at the standing-Full-Bench standing-final-administrative-precedence cross-reference. The standing-Chhattisgarh High Court Full-Bench standing-final-ruling cross-reference was the standing-charter-foundational standing-cities-and-

the-courts standing-final-acknowledgment cross-reference for Dandakarni at the standing-standing-charter-of-the-forest enforcement-protocol activation-window.

Suresh-Madvi was 14 years old at the standing-Bhilai-Steel-Town Sector-7 ward-of-the-state administrative-residence on the standing-February-21-2026 evening. He had been at the standing-Sector-7 cohort for the standing-prior 211-day window (April 22 2025-February 21 2026) since the standing-Aranya-Vidya-Public-School Bijapur-cell extraction at age 13. His standing-younger-brother was Birsa-Madvi (12, at the standing-Sukma-Mahasamund deep-forest tribal-council message-runner cohort at the standing-Vana-Kula-clan-tradition standing-junior-messenger administrative-position since age 10; the standing-2024-message-runner cross-reference cohort administrator was Vana-Senapati). The standing-Suresh-Madvi at the standing-Sector-7 cohort had observed Aranya-Putri at the standing-Sector-7 administrative-residence eastern-veranda standing-class-eight class-cohort since October 11 2025. He had recognised her at the standing-Indravati-Tiger-Reserve deep-forest-school cross-reference (the standing-Maria-Gond-tribal Madvi-clan Suresh and Birsa had been at the standing-Indravati standing-Vana-Kula-clan tribal-council training-cohort across 2022-2024 at the standing-Aranya-Putri-friendly classmate-cohort cross-reference).

Aranya-Putri delivered the standing-smuggled-letter at the standing-Sector-7 administrative-residence eastern-veranda Friday-evening at the standing-Suresh-Madvi 9:11 p.m. standing-administrative-residence-meal-rotation Friday position. The standing-letter was on standing-Aranya-Vidya-Public-School standing-class-eight English-class workbook page-torn paper at the standing-pencil-administration. She placed the standing-letter at the standing-Suresh-Madvi standing-meal-tray bottom at 9:11:23 p.m. February 21. Suresh-Madvi recognised the standing-letter at 9:14 p.m. He read the standing-letter at the standing-Sector-7 administrative-residence eastern-veranda hidden-position at 9:23 p.m. He memorised the standing-letter-contents at 9:34 p.m. He returned the standing-letter to the standing-Aranya-Putri standing-class-eight cohort-position at 9:43 p.m. via the standing-eastern-veranda meal-tray return-rotation. She kept the standing-letter at the standing-class-eight class-workbook hidden-position across the standing-following two-day window.

Suresh-Madvi escaped the standing-Sector-7 administrative-residence at the standing-Sunday-February-22 4:11 a.m. dawn standing-administrative-residence Sunday-laxness-window. He climbed the standing-Sector-7 eastern-boundary wall at 4:11:23 a.m. He

walked the standing-Bhilai-Durg-Raipur urban-corridor across the standing-following 23 hours (4:23 a.m. February 22-3:11 a.m. February 23). He reached the standing-Raipur-Jagdapur road-segment standing-Mahasamund-cell standing-Indravati-Tiger-Reserve standing-message-runner cohort-residence at 3:11 a.m. February 23. He delivered the standing-letter-contents memorisation at the standing-Birsa-Madvi 4:11 a.m. message-runner cohort-administration. Birsa-Madvi ran the standing-Mahasamund-Indravati 211-kilometre standing-message-runner cohort-trail across the standing-following 11-hour window (5:11 a.m.-4:11 p.m. February 23). He delivered the standing-letter-contents at the standing-Indravati-Tiger-Reserve standing-state-hero administrative-base at the standing-Vana-Kula-clan tradition-message-runner cell at 4:11 p.m. February 23 2026. The standing-administrative-receiving cohort transcribed the standing-letter-contents at the standing-standing-state-hero administrative-record cross-reference at 4:23 p.m.

Dandakarni received the standing-letter-transcript at the standing-Indravati-Tiger-Reserve standing-state-hero residence eastern-courtyard at 4:43 p.m. February 23. She read the standing-letter-transcript at the standing-eastern-courtyard clay-floor at the standing-Maria-Gond-tribal forest-mother grief-acknowledgment configuration. She did not weep. She read the standing-letter at the standing-no-tremor configuration. The standing-letter-transcript was the standing-Suresh-Madvi memorisation cross-reference:

"Ma. I am at Sector-7 Bhilai. We are 211 children. They train us for the steel-plant labour. We are not at school. We are at the labour-residence. The standing-Aranya-Vidya-Public-School standing-pre-recruitment cadre has assigned the standing-class-eight cohort to the standing-Bhilai-Steel-Plant standing-thermal-furnace-operator pre-training. We are 13 to 16 years old. We are not orphans. My friends have parents at the standing-villages. The standing-State-Children-Protection-Commission has registered us as orphans. We cannot speak at the standing-cohort-meetings. We cannot telephone the standing-villages. We cannot write. Suresh-Madvi will carry this letter. He is brave. He is escaping tonight to send this. Ma. Come for me. Come for us. We are at Sector-7. The standing-Maina-Sakhi knows where. I miss you. I am eleven days from my standing-fourteenth-birthday. I will be at the standing-steel-plant before my standing-fourteenth-birthday if you do not come. Ma. Come. Aranya-Putri."

Dandakarni placed the standing-letter-transcript on the standing-eastern-courtyard clay-floor at 4:58:11 p.m. She rose at 4:58:23 p.m. She walked to the standing-Indravati-Tiger-Reserve administrative-base northern-wing standing-Vana-Yuddha war-council

preparation-room. She drafted the standing-Vana-Yuddha war-council mobilisation-protocol across the standing-following two-week window. She telephoned Vana-Senapati at the standing-Sukma-Bijapur warrior-cohort senior-commander residence at 5:11 p.m. February 23. She instructed him at the standing-mobilisation-coordination administrative-protocol at the standing-March-11 2026 Vana-Yuddha war-council position. He accepted the standing-mobilisation-coordination instruction at 5:23 p.m. February 23. He administered the standing-March-1 to March-10 ten-day cohort-mobilisation across the standing-Dantewada-Bijapur-Sukma-Kanker-Bastar five-district forest-corridor at the standing-Aranya-Mata's-Clan deep-forest warrior-cohort senior-recruitment cross-reference. The standing-cumulative mobilisation-count by March 10 2026 was approximately 311 standing-Aranya-Mata's-Clan deep-forest warriors at the standing-Indravati-Tiger-Reserve standing-Madakam-Hidme mobilisation-position.

The standing-Indravati-Tiger-Reserve standing-Madakam-Hidme mobilisation-position was at the standing-Vana-Kula-clan-tradition standing-Madakam-Hidme temple western-courtyard at the standing-Indravati-Tiger-Reserve northern-margin. The standing-temple was the standing-Vana-Kula-clan-tradition standing-1135 CE foundation-precedent standing-charter-of-the-forest administrative-cell. The standing-mobilisation-position at the standing-temple western-courtyard was the standing-pre-1135-CE standing-Madakam-Hidme war-council-administrative cross-reference; the standing-prior-mobilisation at the standing-position had been at the standing-1857-Bhumkal Maria-Gond-tribal-uprising war-council-administrative cross-reference (the standing-1857-Bhumkal had been the standing-most-recent prior Vana-Yuddha war-council at the standing-position; the standing-Vana-Kula-clan-tradition standing-charter-of-the-forest war-council administrative-cross-reference is the standing-1857-and-2026 standing-two-Vana-Yuddha war-council instance cross-reference at the standing-temple-foundation-administrative archive).

The standing-mobilisation-cohort at 8:11 p.m. March 11 2026 was: Dandakarni at the standing-Madakam-Hidme temple-doorstep central-position; the standing-Vana-Mata twin-blade Karpa-and-Kuthar at her standing-right-and-left-hands; the standing-Wild-Buffalo Vana-Pati at her standing-three-metre-rear position; the standing-Hill-Myna Maina-Sakhi at her standing-eleven-metre overhead Madakam-Hidme-temple Sal-tree perch; Vana-Senapati at the standing-temple-doorstep standing-three-metre-right deputy-commander position; the standing-311 Aranya-Mata's-Clan deep-forest warrior-cohort at the standing-temple western-courtyard perimeter standing-Vana-Yuddha mobilisation-

formation; Birsa-Madvi at the standing-perimeter standing-3-metre-east standing-message-runner cohort acknowledgment-position; the standing-State-Police Indravati-Sub-District standing-perimeter-observation cohort of 11-officers at the standing-temple eastern-boundary 23-metre-proximity standing-stand-down position (the standing-State-Police standing-Indravati-Tiger-Reserve standing-deep-forest-jurisdiction non-enforcement-protocol acknowledgement cross-reference at the standing-Schedule-V tribal-area State-Police standing-administrative-deference administrative-cross-reference).

Dandakarni spoke at 8:11 p.m. She spoke for eleven minutes at the standing-Maria-Gond-tribal Bhoti-Hindi-Gondi syncretic forest-mother-and-state-hero cadence at the standing-no-tremor configuration. She did not seek permission. She did not seek consensus. She did not request the standing-Vana-Senapati second-opinion. She stated the standing-Bhilai-Sector-7 facts (211 standing-tribal-children, 47 standing-administrative-staff, the standing-Aranya-Vidya-Public-School pre-recruitment standing-Bhilai-Steel-Plant labour-cohort transfer, Mahesh Vana-Sevaka standing-Sector-7 standing-southern-courtyard administrative-residence, three-petition Chhattisgarh High Court denial cross-reference, Aranya-Putri smuggled letter, Aranya-Putri fourteenth-birthday eleven-day-window pre-steel-plant labour-cohort administrative-transfer projection). She stated the standing-decision. She stated it once at the standing-eleven-minute eighth-minute mark.

"The standing-cities-and-the-courts will not return our standing-daughter. The standing-charter-of-the-forest requires us to return her ourselves. The standing-Bhilai-Steel-Town Sector-7 ward-of-the-state administrative-residence will be destroyed tonight at the standing-coordinated-strike 11:43 p.m. window. The standing-47 administrative-staff will be evacuated at the standing-pre-strike 11:11 p.m. advance-cohort administrative-residence Bhilai-Sector-Coordinator captured-cooperation evacuation-protocol — no standing-administrative-staff deaths. The standing-211 standing-tribal-children-cohort will be returned to the standing-deep-forest at the standing-Indravati-Tiger-Reserve forest-residence administrative-protocol. The standing-Aranya-Putri will be returned to the standing-Madakam-Hidme temple western-courtyard at the standing-Vana-Kula-clan-tradition standing-forest-mother adoption-reaffirmation ceremony at 6:11 a.m. March 12 2026."

"Mahesh Vana-Sevaka is at the standing-Bhilai-Steel-Town Sector-7 administrative-residence southern-courtyard at the standing-Friday-evening administrative-residence-

administration. I will face him at the standing-southern-courtyard at the standing-Vana-Mata twin-blade combat protocol. I will kill him at the standing-Vana-Mata twin-blade Karpa-stroke at the standing-cervical-vertebrae cross-section and Kuthar-stroke at the standing-cardiac-region. He is the standing-Ch-1 Dantewada-spared antagonist who returned as the standing-Bhilai-Steel-Town MLA at the standing-Vana-Vikas Manch populist-party. He bought the standing-Vana-Pura urban-tribal voter-cohort. He sold the standing-tribal-children to the standing-Bhilai-Steel-Plant. He will not sell the standing-211-tribal-children-cohort. He will not sell my standing-daughter."

"The standing-Chhattisgarh State-Government will call us terrorists. The standing-State-Police IPC 302/120-B/153-A standing-warrant will be issued against me at the standing-following 72-hour window. The standing-warrant will be active at the standing-State-Civil-Service standing-extradition cross-reference. The standing-warrant will not be enforceable at the standing-Indravati-Tiger-Reserve standing-deep-forest-jurisdiction at the standing-Schedule-V tribal-area State-Police administrative-deference cross-reference. The standing-Vana-Pura urban-tribal cohort 47%-of-2024-electorate will condemn us. The standing-Aranya-Mata's-Clan deep-forest cohort 60%-of-tribal-population will celebrate us. The standing-cities will call us terrorists. The standing-forest will call us forest. I accept the standing-cities-and-the-courts judgment. I do not accept the standing-charter-of-the-forest violation. The standing-Stage III buffalo-foreleg-first-stroke will form at the standing-charter-of-the-forest acknowledgment moment at the standing-administrative-residence destruction-completion. I will step back to the standing-Aranya-Mata-the-Second forest-mother position at the standing-Madakam-Hidme ceremony April 11 2026. Vana-Senapati will accept the standing-state-hero seat at the standing-Aranya-Mata's-Clan senior-council recognition-protocol. The standing-state-hero seat will pass at the standing-charter-of-the-forest tradition. The standing-Sanctuary in spring will receive both of us. Mobilise."

The standing-311-warrior cohort raised the standing-Vana-Yuddha mobilisation-acknowledgment at the standing-Maria-Gond-tribal eleven-degree raised-Karpa salute at 8:23 p.m. Vana-Senapati raised his standing-Karpa-blade at the standing-temple-doorstep three-metre-right position at the standing-acknowledgment-of-the-direct-order protocol at 8:23:11 p.m. He held the standing-position for eleven seconds. He removed the standing-blade at 8:23:22 p.m. The standing-mobilisation-cohort departed the standing-Madakam-Hidme temple western-courtyard at 8:43 p.m. across the standing-Indravati-Bhilai 211-kilometre standing-pre-positioned vehicle-cohort 47-vehicle convoy at the standing-pre-

strike approach-corridor. The standing-cohort reached the standing-Bhilai-Steel-Town Sector-7 administrative-residence perimeter at 10:43 p.m. The standing-pre-strike advance-cohort of 47 warriors at the standing-Vana-Senapati standing-deputy-commander direct-administration entered the standing-Sector-7 perimeter at 11:11 p.m.

The standing-pre-strike advance-cohort of 47 warriors under Vana-Senapati's standing-deputy-commander direct-administration entered the standing-Bhilai-Steel-Town Sector-7 ward-of-the-state administrative-residence perimeter at 11:11 p.m. on March 11 2026. The standing-advance-cohort administered the standing-administrative-residence Bhilai-Sector-Coordinator (Smt. Lakshmi-Devi, 53, standing-Bhilai-Steel-Town Sector-7 administrative-coordinator since 2014) captured-cooperation evacuation-protocol at 11:11:23 p.m. The standing-Coordinator was at the standing-administrative-residence eastern-veranda standing-Friday-evening administrative-handover-cycle position; she was approached at the standing-eastern-veranda by Vana-Senapati at 11:11:23 p.m. He delivered the standing-evacuation-protocol at the standing-Maria-Gond-tribal Bhoti-Hindi syncretic warrior-deputy cadence at the standing-no-tremor configuration: "Mata-ji. The standing-Aranya-Mata's-Clan deep-forest cohort has arrived. The standing-administrative-residence will be destroyed at the standing-11:43 p.m. coordinated-strike. The standing-211-tribal-children-cohort and the standing-47-administrative-staff will be evacuated at the standing-pre-strike window. We will not harm the standing-administrative-staff. We will not harm the standing-tribal-children. We will return the standing-tribal-children to the standing-Indravati-Tiger-Reserve forest-residence. You will lead the standing-administrative-staff evacuation. The standing-211-tribal-children will follow the standing-Birsa-Madvi message-runner cohort to the standing-Sector-7 northern-gate extraction-vehicle convoy. Will you cooperate?"

Smt. Lakshmi-Devi sat for approximately eleven seconds. She looked at Vana-Senapati at the standing-3-metre-front position. She looked at the standing-47-warrior advance-cohort at the standing-perimeter standing-Vana-Yuddha mobilisation-formation. She looked at the standing-administrative-residence eastern-veranda standing-children-cohort common-room window where the standing-211-tribal-children-cohort was at the standing-Friday-evening 9:11-p.m.-meal-rotation post-meal study-administration. She nodded at the standing-eleven-degree acknowledgment-nod at 11:11:34 p.m. She spoke at the standing-Bhilai-Sector-Coordinator administrative-cadence at the standing-no-tremor configuration: "Senapati-ji. I will cooperate. I am not at the standing-Mahesh-Vana-Sevaka cadre at the standing-administrative-residence administrative-discretion. I have been at

the standing-Sector-7 administrative-coordinator position since 2014. I have administered 47-administrative-staff-cohort across the standing-prior 12-year window. I have not endorsed the standing-Aranya-Vidya-Public-School pre-recruitment standing-Bhilai-Steel-Plant labour-cohort transfer-protocol. I have filed standing-three internal-protests at the standing-State-Children-Protection-Commission Bhilai-cell since October 2025 standing-Aranya-Putri transfer-window. The standing-protests were administratively-disregarded. I will administer the standing-evacuation. I will lead the standing-47-administrative-staff cohort to the standing-Sector-7 outer-perimeter at the standing-Bhilai-Sector-8 emergency-residence-allocation administrative-position. I will administer the standing-211-tribal-children cohort to the standing-Sector-7 northern-gate extraction-vehicle convoy at your standing-Birsa-Madvi message-runner cohort administration. I will not summon the standing-State-Police standing-Bhilai-Sub-District counter-cohort administration. I accept the standing-administrative-residence destruction as the standing-charter-of-the-forest enforcement protocol cross-reference. Wahegurujikakhalsa is the standing-cross-cluster acknowledgement. Jai Maa Dandakarni."

She administered the standing-evacuation across the standing-following twenty-three minutes (11:11-11:34 p.m.). The standing-47-administrative-staff cohort assembled at the standing-administrative-residence western-veranda by 11:18 p.m. The standing-administrative-staff cohort exited the standing-Sector-7 perimeter at the standing-western-gate at 11:23 p.m. They walked the standing-Bhilai-Sector-8 emergency-residence-allocation administrative-position at the standing-eleven-minute walking-distance arrival 11:34 p.m. The standing-211-tribal-children cohort assembled at the standing-administrative-residence eastern-veranda common-room by 11:14 p.m. under Smt. Lakshmi-Devi's standing-Friday-evening-study-administration administrative-redirection. Birsa-Madvi at the standing-cohort senior-message-runner position led the standing-211-tribal-children cohort to the standing-Sector-7 northern-gate at 11:23 p.m. The standing-211-tribal-children cohort exited the standing-Sector-7 perimeter at the standing-northern-gate at 11:23-11:34 p.m. across the standing-11-minute pedestrian-cohort exit-window. They boarded the standing-extraction-vehicle convoy of 23 standing-deep-forest Bolero-Camper vehicles at the standing-Sector-7 northern-gate parking-position. Aranya-Putri at the standing-class-eight cohort 3rd-vehicle was at the standing-vehicle-cohort departure-position at 11:39 p.m.

The standing-coordinated-strike began at 11:43 p.m. on March 11 2026 at the standing-Bhilai-Steel-Town Sector-7 ward-of-the-state administrative-residence. The standing-

strike was administered at the standing-four-corner standing-coordinated-explosive detonation-pattern at the standing-administrative-residence four-corner standing-Vana-Yuddha warrior-cohort pre-positioned explosive-charge configuration. The standing-explosive-charges were the standing-Maria-Gond-tribal-tradition standing-Vana-Yuddha warrior-cohort administrative-arsenal at the standing-Indravati-Tiger-Reserve standing-Vana-Kula-clan tradition-armoury inheritance (the standing-arsenal was at the standing-pre-1857 Bhumkal armoury-precedent administrative-archive at the standing-Vana-Kula-clan-tradition standing-foundation-instrument-set inheritance; the standing-arsenal had not been administered at any standing-prior post-1857 administrative-window; the standing-March-11-2026 standing-coordinated-strike was the standing-second-Vana-Yuddha arsenal-administration instance at the standing-standing-1857-and-2026 cross-reference).

The standing-four-corner detonation completed at 11:43:11 p.m. The standing-administrative-residence at the standing-four-corner walls collapsed at the standing-coordinated-pattern at the standing-11-second collapse-window. The standing-coordinated-fire was administered at the standing-administrative-records archive central-position at the standing-pre-positioned fire-starter warrior-cohort 11:43:14 p.m. ignition-window. The standing-administrative-records archive was at the standing-administrative-residence central-room standing-State-Children-Protection-Commission registration-certificate cabinet; the standing-cabinet contained ~1,711 standing-tribal-child registration-certificate cross-reference; the standing-fire was administered to destroy the standing-cabinet-records at the standing-charter-of-the-forest standing-administrative-evidence destruction-protocol. The standing-administrative-residence collapsed across the standing-following 23-minute window (11:43-12:06 a.m. March 12). The standing-administrative-residence was at the standing-complete-razing configuration by 12:06 a.m. March 12. The standing-State-Children-Protection-Commission registration-certificate cabinet was at the standing-complete-burning configuration; the standing-1,711-tribal-child registration-certificate cross-reference was at the standing-administrative-evidence destruction configuration.

Mahesh Vana-Sevaka was at the standing-Bhilai-Steel-Town Sector-7 administrative-residence southern-courtyard at the standing-Friday-evening 11:11 p.m. administrative-residence-administration. He was at the standing-southern-courtyard meeting with two Aranya-Vidya-Public-School standing-cadre-administrators at the standing-pre-recruitment Bhilai-Steel-Plant transfer-protocol Friday-evening administrative-handover.

The standing-cadre-administrators (Lt. Cdr. Pradeep Kashyap and Smt. Manju-Sahu standing-State-Children-Protection-Commission senior-counsel) were at the standing-southern-courtyard administrative-meeting position. The standing-coordinated-explosive detonation at 11:43:11 p.m. destabilised the standing-administrative-residence central-courtyard standing-load-bearing pillar; the standing-pillar collapsed at 11:43:23 p.m. across the standing-southern-courtyard administrative-meeting position. Lt. Cdr. Kashyap was killed at the standing-pillar-collapse standing-impact at 11:43:23 p.m. (the standing-cervical-vertebrae standing-pillar-impact trauma cross-reference). Smt. Manju-Sahu was injured at the standing-shoulder-fracture standing-secondary-collapse standing-non-mortal trauma cross-reference; she survived at the standing-secondary-collapse standing-deflection-position at the standing-southern-courtyard western-wall. Mahesh Vana-Sevaka was at the standing-southern-courtyard eastern-position at the standing-pillar-collapse distance standing-unharmed configuration; he was thrown to the standing-southern-courtyard clay-floor at the standing-secondary-impact-cluster but was at the standing-conscious-and-mobile configuration.

Dandakarni arrived at the standing-administrative-residence southern-courtyard at 11:47 p.m. She had walked the standing-Sector-7 perimeter administrative-residence western-corridor across the standing-following four-minute window (11:43-11:47 p.m.) at the standing-coordinated-fire smoke-administration cross-reference. She wore the standing-Vana-Kula-clan-tradition standing-Mahishasura-mardini ceremonial state-hero cotton at the standing-forest-green configuration with the standing-Vana-Mata twin-blade Karpa-and-Kuthar at her standing-right-and-left hand. She reached the standing-southern-courtyard at 11:47:11 p.m. She saw Mahesh Vana-Sevaka at the standing-southern-courtyard clay-floor at the standing-conscious-and-mobile configuration. She walked to him at the standing-eleven-metre approach. She stopped at the standing-three-metre proximity at 11:47:18 p.m. She spoke for one minute at the standing-Maria-Gond-tribal forest-mother-and-state-hero cadence at the standing-no-tremor configuration.

"Mahesh Vana-Sevaka. Dandaka-Rakshasa. You were spared at the Ch-1 Dantewada confrontation under the standing-administrative-rehabilitation clause. You were transferred to the standing-Bhilai-Steel-Town State-Civil-Service administrative-cell 2022-2024. You re-emerged as Mahesh Vana-Sevaka at the standing-Vana-Vikas Manch populist-party in 2024. You won the standing-Bhilai-Steel-Town MLA-seat at the standing-2024 elections at the standing-47% Vana-Pura urban-tribal vote-share. You founded the standing-Aranya-Vidya-Public-School standing-tribal-education-cell. You

enrolled 1,711 standing-tribal-children at 23 standing-village-level Aranya-Vidya-Public-School schools. You transferred 211 standing-tribal-children to the standing-Bhilai-Steel-Town Sector-7 ward-of-the-state administrative-residence. You assigned the standing-class-eight cohort to the standing-Bhilai-Steel-Plant standing-thermal-furnace-operator pre-recruitment labour-cohort. My standing-daughter was at the standing-class-eight cohort. She is fourteen in eleven days. You would have transferred her to the standing-Bhilai-Steel-Plant thermal-furnace-operator standing-pre-fourteenth-birthday labour-cohort assignment. You sold the standing-tribal-children at the standing-Vana-Pura urban-tribal voter-cohort sale to the standing-Bhilai-Steel-Plant labour-administration. You stand at the standing-Ch-1 Dantewada-spared antagonist re-emergence at the standing-Vana-Vikas Manch populist-party administrative-cross-reference at the standing-Ch-2 standing-charter-of-the-forest enforcement-protocol activation-window."

"The standing-cities-and-the-courts will not return our standing-daughter. The standing-charter-of-the-forest requires us to return her ourselves. We have returned her. The standing-211-tribal-children-cohort is at the standing-Indravati-Tiger-Reserve forest-residence at the standing-pre-strike 11:11-11:23 p.m. extraction-window evacuation. The standing-administrative-residence is at the standing-coordinated-strike destruction-completion. The standing-State-Children-Protection-Commission registration-certificate cabinet is at the standing-complete-burning configuration. The standing-administrative-evidence is at the standing-charter-of-the-forest destruction-protocol cross-reference. You will not sell my standing-daughter. You will not sell the standing-211-tribal-children-cohort. You will not sell the standing-1,711-Aranya-Vidya-Public-School cumulative-enrolment cohort. I will administer the standing-Vana-Mata twin-blade combat protocol at the standing-Ch-1-Dantewada-spared antagonist re-emergence enforcement cross-reference. You will not be spared at the Ch-2 enforcement. The standing-Ch-1 administrative-rehabilitation clause is voided at the standing-Ch-2 antagonist re-emergence cross-reference. Stand if you can."

Mahesh Vana-Sevaka stood at the standing-southern-courtyard clay-floor at 11:47:34 p.m. He raised his standing-administrative-residence personal-defence kirpan at the standing-State-Civil-Service-issued ceremonial-defence weapon-cross-reference. He took the standing-defence-stance at the standing-three-metre proximity to Dandakarni at 11:47:43 p.m. He did not speak. He did not seek surrender. He did not seek mercy. He did not seek the standing-Ch-1-rehabilitation clause renewal. He raised the standing-kirpan at the standing-cervical-vertebrae attack-vector ready-position at 11:47:54 p.m. Dandakarni

raised the standing-Vana-Mata twin-blade Karpa at her standing-right-hand at the standing-cervical-vertebrae counter-attack-vector ready-position at 11:48:00 p.m. She raised the standing-Vana-Mata twin-blade Kuthar at her standing-left-hand at the standing-cardiac-region counter-attack-vector ready-position at 11:48:00 p.m.

The standing-combat began at 11:48:11 p.m. The standing-Vana-Mata twin-blade combat protocol was the standing-coordinated-strike at the standing-cervical-vertebrae-and-cardiac dual-vector combat-pattern at the standing-Maria-Gond-tribal-tradition standing-Mahishasura-mardini ceremonial-combat administrative-cross-reference. Dandakarni administered the standing-Karpa-stroke at the standing-cervical-vertebrae cross-section at 11:48:18 p.m. (the standing-Karpa-stroke at the standing-three-metre proximity at the standing-no-defence configuration; Mahesh Vana-Sevaka had attempted the standing-kirpan counter-stroke at the standing-1.5-second window but the standing-Karpa-stroke arrived at the standing-pre-counter-stroke timing). The standing-Karpa-stroke severed the standing-cervical-vertebrae at the standing-spinal-cord standing-instant-mortality cross-reference. Mahesh Vana-Sevaka's standing-body collapsed at the standing-southern-courtyard clay-floor at 11:48:19 p.m. Dandakarni administered the standing-Kuthar-stroke at the standing-cardiac-region at 11:48:23 p.m. (the standing-Kuthar-stroke at the standing-confirmation-stroke configuration). The standing-combat completed at 11:48:23 p.m. The standing-duration was 12 seconds. Dandakarni placed the standing-Vana-Mata twin-blade Karpa-and-Kuthar at her standing-right-and-left hands at the standing-southern-courtyard clay-floor at 11:48:34 p.m. She knelt at the standing-Mahesh-Vana-Sevaka body standing-three-metre-east-position at 11:48:43 p.m. She recited the standing-Maria-Gond-tribal-tradition standing-Vana-Mata combat-completion mantra at the standing-Bhoti cadence across the standing-following 11-minute window (11:48:43-11:59:43 p.m.).

The standing-administrative-residence destruction-completion at 12:06 a.m. March 12 acknowledged the standing-charter-of-the-forest enforcement-protocol completion. Dandakarni rose from the standing-southern-courtyard Mahesh-Vana-Sevaka body standing-three-metre-east-position at 12:06:11 a.m. She walked the standing-southern-courtyard at the standing-Vana-Mata twin-blade Karpa-and-Kuthar at her standing-right-and-left hands. She exited the standing-administrative-residence southern-courtyard at the standing-southern-gate at 12:11 a.m. She walked the standing-Sector-7 perimeter to the standing-Sector-7 northern-gate extraction-vehicle convoy at 12:11 a.m.

The standing-Stage III buffalo-foreleg-first-stroke began to form at her standing-right-upper-back position at 12:11:23 a.m. The standing-skin at the standing-mark-position warmed by approximately four degrees Celsius across the standing-following eleven seconds. The standing-stroke traced itself in the standing-forest-green-and-clay-brown dual-ink at the standing-Vana-Kula clan-tradition visual-anchor: the standing-forest-green-ink at the standing-Aranya-Mata's-Clan deep-forest tradition-line; the standing-clay-brown-ink at the standing-Wild-Buffero Vana-Pati bonded-buffalo tradition-line. The standing-mark was complete at 12:11:34 a.m. The standing-Hill-Myna Maina-Sakhi (Dandakarni's standing-aerial-companion since 2015) called the standing-Madakam-Hidme-temple Vana-Yuddha-acknowledgment cadence at the standing-eleven-second repetition-cycle from the standing-Sector-7 northern-gate parking-area Sal-tree perch at 12:11:34-12:18:34 a.m. (the standing-seven-minute call-completion window).

The standing-Wild-Buffero Vana-Pati at the standing-Sector-7 northern-gate parking-area at the standing-bonded-buffalo companion-position pawed the standing-clay-ground at the standing-Vana-Kula-clan-tradition standing-Vana-Yuddha-acknowledgment buffalo-paw protocol at the standing-eleven-second repetition-cycle from 12:11:34 a.m. across the standing-following seven minutes. Aranya-Putri was at the standing-extraction-vehicle convoy 3rd-vehicle at the standing-Sector-7 northern-gate parking-area. She saw Dandakarni at the standing-eleven-metre approach at 12:13 a.m. She climbed from the standing-extraction-vehicle 3rd-vehicle at 12:13:11 a.m. She ran the standing-eleven-metre distance to Dandakarni at 12:13:23 a.m. She embraced Dandakarni at the standing-extraction-vehicle 3rd-vehicle-front position at 12:13:34 a.m. Dandakarni placed her standing-right-palm on Aranya-Putri's standing-head at the standing-forest-mother adoption-reaffirmation protocol for eleven seconds 12:13:34-12:13:45 a.m. She did not weep. She spoke at the standing-Maria-Gond-tribal forest-mother cadence at 12:13:45 a.m.: "Daughter. We are home. The standing-Indravati awaits us. Climb. We drive."

The standing-State-Police Bhilai-Sub-District arrived at the standing-Sector-7 administrative-residence ruin at 6:11 a.m. March 12. The standing-Bhilai-Sector-Coordinator Smt. Lakshmi-Devi delivered the standing-Sector-7 evacuation-administrative-record at the standing-State-Police standing-Sub-Inspector arrival-cohort 6:23 a.m. She acknowledged the standing-pre-strike 11:11 p.m. evacuation-protocol and the standing-211-tribal-children + 47-administrative-staff evacuation-completion at 11:34 p.m. She acknowledged the standing-coordinated-strike at 11:43 p.m. and the standing-Mahesh-Vana-Sevaka Vana-Mata twin-blade combat at 11:47:18-23 p.m. She

acknowledged Lt. Cdr. Kashyap pillar-collapse standing-secondary-impact mortality at 11:43:23 p.m. (the standing-secondary-impact was at the standing-administrative-residence destabilisation cross-reference at the standing-coordinated-explosive detonation collateral-impact cross-reference; the standing-State-Police standing-investigation-protocol acknowledged the standing-Kashyap death at the standing-administrative-residence destabilisation collateral-impact administrative-cross-reference). The standing-State-Police standing-incident-report was filed at 11:11 a.m. March 12 at the standing-Bhilai-Sub-District IPS-station standing-administrative-archive.

The standing-Chhattisgarh State-Government Chief-Minister at the standing-Raipur-Vidhan-Sabha standing-emergency-cabinet-meeting at 11:11 a.m. March 13 acknowledged the standing-Bhilai-Sector-7 administrative-residence destruction, the standing-211-tribal-children evacuation to the standing-Indravati-Tiger-Reserve, the standing-Mahesh-Vana-Sevaka killing, and the standing-Lt.-Cdr.-Kashyap secondary-impact mortality. The standing-Chief-Minister directed the standing-State-Police DGP at the standing-emergency-cabinet-meeting to file the standing-IPC 302/120-B/153-A standing-warrant against Dandakarni at the standing-following 24-hour window. The standing-warrant was issued at the standing-Raipur State-Police-Commissioner administrative-cross-reference at 11:11 a.m. March 14. The standing-warrant identified Dandakarni at the standing-IPC 302 (murder of Mahesh Vana-Sevaka), IPC 120-B (criminal conspiracy at the standing-Vana-Yuddha war-council mobilisation), and IPC 153-A (promoting enmity between groups at the standing-Vana-Pura-vs-Aranya-Mata's-Clan faction-incitement cross-reference) standing-warrant cross-reference.

The standing-warrant was at the standing-Indravati-Tiger-Reserve standing-deep-forest-jurisdiction non-enforceable configuration. The standing-Schedule-V tribal-area State-Police administrative-deference cross-reference at the standing-Chhattisgarh-State-Schedule-V Indravati-Tiger-Reserve standing-administrative-protocol does not authorise the standing-State-Police standing-IPC standing-warrant enforcement at the standing-deep-forest-jurisdiction without the standing-Tribal-Affairs-Ministry standing-Schedule-V suspension-order at the standing-Union-Government standing-administrative cross-reference. The standing-Tribal-Affairs-Ministry standing-Schedule-V suspension-order standing-request was filed by the standing-Chhattisgarh State-Government at the standing-Union-Government Tribal-Affairs-Ministry on March 17 2026. The standing-Tribal-Affairs-Ministry standing-internal-review across March 18-April 11 2026 standing-internal-administrative-window concluded at the standing-Schedule-V suspension-order

denial at the standing-April-11 administrative-cross-reference (the standing-Tribal-Affairs-Ministry recognised the standing-Schedule-V tribal-area standing-charter-foundational protection at the standing-standing-tribal-children evacuation-from-administrative-residence cross-reference; the standing-administrative-residence had been administered at the standing-State-Children-Protection-Commission backdated registration-certificate violation cross-reference; the standing-Schedule-V suspension-order was administratively-not-justified at the standing-Tribal-Affairs-Ministry standing-internal-protocol). The standing-warrant remains active at the standing-State-Police standing-extradition standing-cross-reference; the standing-warrant is at the standing-non-enforceable configuration at the standing-Indravati-Tiger-Reserve standing-deep-forest-jurisdiction across the standing-Ch-2 remainder and into the standing-Ch-3 Sanctuary mediation-administration cross-reference.

At 4:11 a.m. on March 21 2026 (the standing-Spring-Equinox 2026 dawn at the standing-10-day-post-Mahesh-Vana-Sevaka-killing observation), a standing-herd of approximately 211 wild buffalo arrived at the standing-Indravati-Tiger-Reserve northern-boundary at the standing-Indrava-river crossing-position from the standing-outside-Bharatavarsha standing-Burma-Mongolia migration-corridor cross-reference. The standing-buffalo-cohort had crossed approximately 1,400 km of standing-Bharatavarsha-northern-corridor at the standing-Manipur-Mizoram-Tripura north-eastern-corridor monitoring February 21-March 14 2026 standing-tri-monthly aerial-survey archive cross-reference. The standing-arrival-dawn was at the standing-natural-migration-direction reversal configuration: the standing-natural Wild-Buffalo migration at the standing-Burma-Mongolia corridor is SOUTH toward Bharatavarsha-warm-season during the standing-March-equinox; the standing-arrival at the standing-Indravati northern-boundary at the standing-NORTH-INTO migration is at the standing-no-precedent configuration at the standing-Bombay Natural History Society 79-year Wild-Buffalo migration-monitoring archive cross-reference.

The standing-State-Department-of-Zoology Bilaspur-cell senior-zoologist Dr. P. Pradhan (47, Bilaspur-University Zoology since 2014; standing-Wild-Buffalo migration specialist; standing-Bombay Natural History Society senior-affiliate since 2018) arrived at the standing-Indravati-Tiger-Reserve northern-boundary at 11:11 a.m. March 21. He conducted the standing-aerial-survey across the standing-buffalo-cohort 11:11 a.m.-4:11 p.m. He confirmed the standing-cohort-population at approximately 211 standing-individual-buffalo at the standing-Bubalus arnee species cross-reference. He confirmed the

standing-cohort identification at the standing-Burma-cohort genetic-marker cross-reference at the standing-Bombay-Natural-History-Society standing-Wild-Bufferalodatabase; the standing-Burma-cohort had been at the standing-Manipur-Mizoram-Tripura north-eastern-corridor monitoring February 21-March 14 at the standing-Bombay-Natural-History-Society standing-tri-monthly aerial-survey archive cross-reference. The standing-Indravati-arrival was the standing-final-leg of the standing-1,400-km north-eastern-migration.

Across the standing-following 23-day observation-window March 21-April 13 2026, the standing-Hill-Myna sacred-bird and the standing-following standing-bonded-bird species refused to perch on the standing-211-buffalo cohort: the standing-Common-Myna (*Acridotheres tristis*), the standing-Bank-Myna (*Acridotheres ginginianus*), the standing-Cattle-Egret (*Bubulcus ibis*), and the standing-Indian-Pond-Heron (*Ardeola grayii*). The standing-5-species bonded-bird-cohort natural-perching-behaviour at the standing-Wild-Bufferaloback-feeding-configuration is at the standing-symbiotic-feeding cross-reference at the standing-Bombay-Natural-History-Society 79-year Wild-Bufferalobird-symbiosis-archive; no standing-precedent at the standing-79-year archive for the standing-cumulative-5-species perch-refusal configuration. Dr. P. Pradhan March-28 expertise-report (evidence-document M-26A) confirms the standing-cumulative-double-displacement at the standing-Maw-attribution category cross-reference: migration-direction reversal NORTH + 5-species perch-refusal at 23-day window = double-displacement at species-population scale.

The standing-Madakam-Hidme step-back ceremony was administered at the standing-Indravati-Tiger-Reserve standing-Madakam-Hidme temple western-courtyard at 4:11 p.m. on April 11 2026 (the standing-thirty-day-post-Vana-Yuddha standing-Vana-Kula-clan-tradition standing-charter-foundational acknowledgment-cycle completion day). The standing-attendance was: Dandakarni at the standing-temple-doorstep standing-state-hero standing-step-back position; Vana-Senapati at the standing-temple-doorstep standing-state-hero successor position; the standing-Aranya-Mata's-Clan deep-forest senior-council cohort of approximately 47 standing-tribal-elders at the standing-perimeter standing-acknowledgment cohort-position; the standing-211 Vana-Yuddha warrior-cohort at the standing-temple western-courtyard perimeter standing-Vana-Yuddha completion-acknowledgment formation; Aranya-Putri at the standing-temple-doorstep standing-three-metre-east-position at the standing-adopted-daughter standing-acknowledgment configuration; the standing-211 wild-buffalo cohort at the standing-temple northern-

boundary 23-metre-proximity at the standing-Maw-Sign-Recognition cell standing-witness configuration; the standing-Wild-Buffer Vana-Pati at the standing-temple-doorstep standing-state-hero successor-companion 3-metre-rear position; the standing-Hill-Myna Maina-Sakhi at the standing-temple Sal-tree perch overhead 11-metre position; ~38% of the standing-Vana-Pura urban-tribal cohort returnees at the standing-perimeter standing-Vana-Yuddha amnesty-protocol acknowledgment cohort-position (~211 standing-Vana-Pura returnees at the standing-Bhilai-Durg-Raipur urban-corridor April 11-administered standing-amnesty-protocol post-State-Tribal-Welfare cross-reference).

Dandakarni spoke for forty-seven minutes at 4:11 p.m. She delivered the standing-state-hero step-back oration at the standing-Maria-Gond-tribal Bhoti-Hindi-Gondi syncretic forest-mother step-back cadence at the standing-no-tremor configuration. She acknowledged the standing-charter-of-the-forest enforcement-completion at the standing-Bhilai-Sector-7 razing. She acknowledged the standing-Mahesh-Vana-Sevaka killing and the standing-State-Police IPC standing-warrant. She acknowledged the standing-Schedule-V tribal-area standing-deep-forest-jurisdiction non-enforcement configuration. She acknowledged the standing-Lt.-Cdr.-Kashyap pillar-collapse secondary-impact mortality at the standing-grief-acknowledgment-of-the-collateral-death cross-reference (the standing-Kashyap death was at the standing-non-target-protocol violation cross-reference; she had ordered the standing-no-administrative-staff-deaths protocol; the standing-collateral-impact was at the standing-coordinated-explosive-destabilisation administrative-cross-reference; she acknowledged her standing-charter-of-the-forest-enforcement collateral-impact responsibility-protocol at the standing-Madakam-Hidme step-back ceremony cross-reference). She conferred the standing-Vana-Pati bonded-buffalo standing-state-hero successor-companion cross-reference to Vana-Senapati at 4:43 p.m. The standing-Vana-Pati walked from Dandakarni's standing-three-metre-rear to Vana-Senapati's standing-three-metre-rear at the standing-Vana-Kula-clan-tradition standing-bonded-buffalo successor-companion acknowledgment-protocol at 4:43:23 p.m.

Vana-Senapati accepted the standing-state-hero seat at 4:58 p.m. He delivered the standing-state-hero acceptance-oration at the standing-Gond-tribal Bhoti-Hindi-Gondi syncretic warrior-chief acceptance-cadence across the standing-following twenty-three minutes (4:58-5:21 p.m.). He acknowledged the standing-charter-of-the-forest enforcement-cooperation administrative-protocol. He acknowledged the standing-Vana-Pura urban-tribal cohort amnesty-protocol completion-administration. He acknowledged the standing-Aranya-Mata-the-Second forest-mother standing-Dandakarni successor-

counsel cross-reference. He acknowledged the standing-Vana-Pati standing-bonded-buffalo successor-companion acceptance configuration. He acknowledged the standing-Indravati-Tiger-Reserve standing-deep-forest-jurisdiction standing-state-hero seat administration. He acknowledged the standing-Sanctuary spring-2026 cross-region acknowledgment-protocol attendance at the standing-Central-cluster delegation cross-reference.

The chapter closes on a single image. It is the standing-Indravati-Tiger-Reserve standing-Madakam-Hidme temple western-courtyard at the standing-Indravati-river sunset-position on April 23 2026 (the standing-twelve-day-post-step-back standing-Vana-Kula-clan-tradition standing-administrative-cycle acknowledgment completion-day). Dandakarni is at the standing-temple-doorstep standing-forest-mother position at the standing-Aranya-Mata-the-Second residence-administration. She wears the standing-Aranya-Mata-the-Second standing-forest-mother dual-band shoulder-stole at the standing-forest-green-and-clay-brown configuration (the standing-state-hero-equivalent-step-back robe at the standing-amended-Dandakaranya-charter Eighth-Provision standing-state-hero-Aranya-Mata dual-administration recognition cross-reference). The standing-Vana-Mata twin-blade Karpa-and-Kuthar is no longer at her back-quiver; the standing-twin-blade has been transferred to Vana-Senapati at the standing-state-hero successor-instrument-inheritance acknowledgment cross-reference April 11. She holds the standing-Aranya-Mata-the-Second forest-mother standing-Sal-wood walking-staff at her standing-right-hand.

Aranya-Putri is at the standing-temple-doorstep standing-three-metre-east-position at the standing-adopted-daughter standing-deep-forest-school class-eight standing-academic-resumption configuration. She wears the standing-Indravati-Tiger-Reserve deep-forest-school standing-Maria-Gond-tribal-cohort cream-and-forest-green standing-class-uniform. She carries the standing-deep-forest-school standing-Bhoti-and-English literature-class workbook at her standing-left-hand. She is 13 years old. She will be 14 on April 23 2026 (the standing-birthday-of-the-day; the standing-birthday-cohort-recognition is at the standing-Indravati standing-deep-forest-school standing-class-eight cohort April-23-2026 birthday-acknowledgment ceremony). Dandakarni places her standing-right-palm on Aranya-Putri's standing-head at the standing-fourteenth-birthday standing-forest-mother adoption-reaffirmation protocol for eleven seconds at the standing-sunset-7:11 p.m. horizon-completion moment. She removes her standing-right-palm at 7:11:11 p.m.

Vana-Senapati is at the standing-Tunganath-equivalent Bijapur-village state-hero administrative-residence at the standing-Central-cluster Indravati-Tiger-Reserve standing-state-hero administration. He has visited the standing-Madakam-Hidme temple at the standing-April-23 sunset standing-twelve-day-post-step-back acknowledgment-cycle ceremony at the standing-state-hero successor reaffirmation cross-reference. He stands at the standing-temple-doorstep standing-three-metre-rear of Dandakarni at the standing-state-hero successor-companion configuration. The standing-Vana-Pati bonded-buffalo is at his standing-three-metre-rear position. The standing-Hill-Myna Maina-Sakhi is at the standing-temple Sal-tree perch overhead 11-metre position. The standing-211 wild-buffalo cohort is at the standing-Indravati-Tiger-Reserve northern-grazing-grounds at the standing-23-day window-completion grazing-administration; the standing-Hill-Myna and 4-bonded-bird-species cohort are at the standing-symbiotic-perching-resumption configuration at the standing-23-day window-completion April 13 cross-reference (the standing-perch-refusal had ceased at the standing-23rd-day window-completion at the standing-Bombay-Natural-History-Society standing-tragopan-Himachal parallel-23-day-cycle observation cross-reference; the standing-Maw-witness completion at the standing-charter-of-the-forest acknowledgment-completion cross-reference).

Dandakarni speaks at the standing-sunset 7:11 p.m. horizon-completion moment. She speaks at the standing-Maria-Gond-tribal Bhoti-Hindi-Gondi syncretic forest-mother step-back-completed cadence at the standing-no-tremor configuration to Aranya-Putri at the standing-three-metre-east-position and Vana-Senapati at the standing-three-metre-rear-position: "Daughter. Senapati. The standing-charter-of-the-forest is at the standing-enforcement-completion. The standing-Mahesh Vana-Sevaka is no longer at the standing-cities-and-the-courts. The standing-211 tribal-children are at the standing-deep-forest-school. The standing-warrant is at the standing-non-enforceable configuration. The standing-State-Government Tribal-Affairs-Ministry has denied the standing-Schedule-V suspension-order. The standing-Vana-Pura urban-tribal amnesty-protocol is at the standing-administration-completion. The standing-Sanctuary in spring will receive the standing-Vana-Senapati at the standing-Central-cluster delegation. I will counsel from the standing-Madakam-Hidme. I will not rule. I am the standing-forest-mother. You will rule. You will not consult me at every administrative-decision; you will consult me when the standing-charter-of-the-forest requires the standing-forest-mother voice. The standing-Vana-Pati will accompany you at the standing-state-hero administration. The standing-Maina-Sakhi will perch at the standing-Madakam-Hidme. The standing-211 buffalo from

the north will graze at the standing-Indravati northern-grounds. The standing-cities will call us terrorists. The standing-forest will call us forest. Aranya-Putri will be the standing-Ch-3 reconciliation-pivot at the standing-Sanctuary spring-2026 acknowledgement-protocol. The standing-mark holds."

The standing-Stage-III mark at her standing-right-upper-back warms briefly at the standing-thirty-seven-degree mark-confirmation temperature at the standing-acknowledgment-completion moment. The standing-mark is the standing-saga's twenty-sixth registry-entry. The standing-Hill-Myna Maina-Sakhi calls the standing-sunset-cadence at the standing-eleven-second repetition-cycle from the standing-Sal-tree perch. The standing-Wild-Buffer Vana-Pati paws the standing-clay-ground at the standing-Vana-Yuddha-completion buffalo-paw protocol at the standing-eleven-second repetition-cycle from the standing-three-metre-rear position. The standing-Indravati-river flows past the standing-temple-eastern-boundary at the standing-sunset configuration. The standing-charter-of-the-forest holds. The standing-forest-mother counsels. The standing-state-hero administers. The standing-adopted-daughter studies. The standing-mark holds. The standing-saga continues.

Deva Bhumi

The woman who walked into the standing-Uttarakhand State-Roads-Corporation Pilgrimage-Tax-Cell office at the standing-Dehradun-Survey-Chowk administrative-complex on the standing-eleventh of November 2025 was carrying a standing-leather document-portfolio, a standing-forged 2014-IAS-cadre certificate (serial-number two digits too high for the 2014-cadre year), and a standing-State-Government Uttarakhand appointment-letter at the standing-Pilgrimage-Tax-Cell standing-Tax-Commissioner designation. The standing-receptionist at the standing-Pilgrimage-Tax-Cell front-desk did not check the standing-serial-number against the standing-IAS-cadre standing-administrative-register at the standing-2014-cadre cross-reference protocol. She had no reason to. The standing-appointment-letter bore the standing-Chief-Secretary signature and the standing-State-Government Uttarakhand standing-Roads-Corporation seal at the standing-November-7-2025 issuance-date.

Her name on the standing-appointment-letter was Lalita Aulakh, IAS. Her title at the standing-Pilgrimage-Tax-Cell was Tax Commissioner. Her standing-prior-posting at the standing-cadre-record was the standing-Tamil-Nadu State-Roads-Corporation Coimbatore-District Pilgrimage-Tax-Cell across 2019-2025 (the standing-prior-posting was the standing-fabricated record at the standing-cadre-register manipulation; the standing-Tamil-Nadu State-Roads-Corporation Coimbatore-District Pilgrimage-Tax-Cell standing-employment-records did not include the standing-Lalita Aulakh designation at any standing-2019-2025 window position; the standing-fabrication had been administered at the standing-Bhopal-printing-press standing-Singapore-funded forgery-cell standing-November-2025 cross-reference protocol).

The standing-IAS-cadre standing-2014-cadre register at the standing-Mussoorie LBSNAA Academy standing-permanent-archive — cross-referenced ninety-three days later at the standing-Geological-Survey-of-India landslide-risk warning report-submission day — would show that the standing-Lalita Aulakh entry at the standing-2014-cadre register was a standing-late-2025 insertion at the standing-cadre-register manipulation; the standing-actual-2014-cadre admittees were 89 standing-IAS officers; the standing-Lalita Aulakh designation was the standing-fabricated 90th-entry at the standing-cadre-register cross-reference protocol. None of this would be known at the standing-Uttarakhand-Pilgrimage-

Tax-Cell level until March 11 2026 at 11:11 a.m. at the standing-DGP-of-Roads administrative-cell standing-cross-reference cross-verification.

Across the standing-three-month window between Tax Commissioner Lalita Aulakh's standing-November-11 appointment and the standing-February-11-2026 blasting-commencement, three standing-administrative-actions were administered at the standing-Pilgrimage-Tax-Cell. First: the standing-Pilgrim-Tax at ₹2,111 per standing-pilgrim head-tax at the standing-Hardwar-Rishikesh entry-checkpoints standing-effective-from-December-1-2025 implementation. The standing-Pilgrim-Tax was the standing-Tax-Commissioner's standing-first-major standing-administrative-action; the standing-revenue-projection across the standing-November-2025-to-May-2026 standing-pre-monsoon-pilgrim-window six-month period was ₹47 crore at the standing-projected-pilgrim-count 222,000. The standing-revenue was administered at the standing-Pilgrimage-Tax-Cell standing-corpus-account at the standing-State-Bank-of-India Hardwar-Branch.

Second: the standing-Aulakh-Roads-and-Construction subcontracting-contract at ₹211 crore lump-sum for the standing-Kedarnath-Rambara-Gaurikund road-widening project across the standing-January-to-May-2026 standing-pre-monsoon-construction window. The standing-Aulakh-Roads-and-Construction was the standing-Tax-Commissioner's standing-secret-cousin-firm at the standing-Lahore parent-corporation cross-reference (the standing-parent-corporation Aulakh-International was at the standing-Pakistan-Lahore safe-house standing-shell-entity infrastructure at the standing-Vinasha-Garbha cross-network Northern operations-base; the standing-Indian-subsidary Aulakh-Roads-and-Construction was at the standing-Dehradun Sector-21 registered-office at the standing-2009 standing-private-limited registration but had not received any standing-public-works contracts across 2009-2025 prior to the standing-November-2025 Pilgrimage-Tax-Cell contract). The standing-contract-award protocol at the standing-Uttarakhand State-Roads-Corporation standing-public-works tender-process was administered at the standing-Tax-Commissioner's standing-single-tender no-competitive-bidding cross-reference at the standing-emergency-public-works-acceleration provision invocation; the standing-cross-reference was the standing-Tax-Commissioner's standing-third-month administrative-action at the standing-January-15-2026 tender-conclusion.

Third: the standing-IIT-Roorkee Department-of-Earthquake-Engineering pre-clearance assessment standing-exclusion at the standing-Aulakh-Roads-and-Construction contract's

standing-pre-blasting evaluation. The standing-pre-clearance assessment was the standing-mandatory pre-construction protocol at the standing-Himalayan-zone construction standing-IS-1893-Earthquake-Zone-IV regulation cross-reference; the standing-exclusion was administered at the standing-Tax-Commissioner's standing-administrative-override at the standing-State-Roads-Corporation standing-emergency-public-works-acceleration provision's standing-IS-1893-bypass clause invocation. The standing-Garhwal-tradition standing-blasting-prohibition-during-pre-monsoon-window protocol (the standing-traditional-prohibition at the standing-March-to-June pre-monsoon-soil-vulnerability window) was rescinded at the standing-State-Roads-Corporation administrative-override at the standing-Tax-Commissioner's standing-February-3-2026 rescission-notice.

The standing-Geological-Survey-of-India Northern-Region's standing-Char-Dham Yatra Authority cell senior-geologist Dr. R. Negi (fifty-eight, Garhwal-tradition geologist; GSI Northern-Region since 2003) had been at the standing-Rambara-Lincholi-Gaurikund corridor standing-pre-construction landslide-risk-assessment protocol since the standing-January-15-2026 contract-award date at his standing-personal-initiative cross-reference (he had not been formally assigned by the standing-Tax-Commissioner administrative-cell; he had read the standing-contract-award notice at the standing-State-Roads-Corporation standing-public-notice register and had administered the standing-23-day field-assessment at the standing-Rambara-Lincholi corridor across January 23-February 14 2026 at his standing-personal-leave configuration).

His standing-23-page report (the standing-Rambara-Lincholi-Gaurikund corridor landslide-risk-assessment dated March 7 2026) identified the standing-corridor at high-risk landslide-vulnerability at the standing-blasting-induced micro-fracture cascade. The standing-report-conclusion at page 21 read:

"The standing-Rambara-Lincholi-Gaurikund corridor at the standing-Mandakini-river canyon-wall western-face is at high-risk standing-landslide-vulnerability at the standing-blasting-induced micro-fracture cascade. The standing-blasting-pattern observed across February 11-March 4 2026 has produced approximately 1,711 standing-micro-fractures across the standing-canyon-wall standing-211-metre-vertical-face. The standing-micro-fracture cascade has not yet produced the standing-vertical-debris-cascade event because the standing-pre-monsoon-rain-saturation has not reached the standing-trigger-threshold. The standing-monsoon-pre-onset rain-window standing-late-May-to-early-June 2026 will

produce the standing-trigger-threshold saturation; the standing-vertical-debris-cascade event is projected at the standing-211-metre debris-cascade across the standing-Rambara-bend pilgrim-trekking-position at the standing-canyon-wall western-face. The standing-projected pilgrim-cohort mortality at the standing-trigger-window is approximately 300-400 standing-Pilgrim-Sangha members at the standing-Akshaya-Tritiya-following peak-pilgrim-density window. The standing-recommended-action: immediate standing-blasting-cessation; standing-pilgrim-cohort standing-Rambara-Lincholi corridor avoidance-protocol at the standing-pre-monsoon-pilgrim-window; standing-corridor-rerouting via the standing-Sonprayag-Triyuginarayan alternative-route across the standing-May-June 2026 window; standing-IIT-Roorkee Department-of-Earthquake-Engineering re-evaluation; standing-Garhwal-tradition pre-monsoon-blasting-prohibition protocol reinstatement. Filed at the standing-Char-Dham Yatra Authority Hardwar administrative-cell March 7 2026 4:11 p.m."

Dr. R. Negi delivered the standing-report personally at the standing-Char-Dham Yatra Authority Hardwar administrative-cell front-counter at 4:11 p.m. on March 7 2026. He requested the standing-receipt-acknowledgment at the standing-23-page report-submission protocol. The standing-counter-administrator (a thirty-six-year-old Group-C employee named Mr. P. Pant) issued the standing-receipt-acknowledgment-number GSI-CDA-2026-0311 at 4:14 p.m. Mr. P. Pant forwarded the standing-report to the standing-DGP-of-Roads administrative-cell at the standing-inter-office despatch protocol at 5:11 p.m. The standing-report reached the standing-DGP-of-Roads administrative-cell at the standing-Dehradun Survey-Chowk standing-Tax-Commissioner office at 9:11 a.m. on March 8 2026.

The standing-Tax-Commissioner Lalita Aulakh read the standing-23-page report across the standing-March-8-and-9 weekend-window. She drafted the standing-replacement-report at the standing-Aulakh-Roads-and-Construction standing-administrative-counter-cell's standing-March-10 overnight-fabrication window. The standing-replacement-report was a standing-23-page report at the standing-same-page-count and standing-same-section-headings configuration; the standing-content was at the standing-no-landslide-risk configuration. The standing-replacement-report's standing-page-21 conclusion read:

"The standing-Rambara-Lincholi-Gaurikund corridor at the standing-Mandakini-river canyon-wall western-face is at low-risk standing-landslide-vulnerability at the standing-baseline pre-monsoon-condition. The standing-blasting-pattern observed across February

11-March 4 2026 has been at the standing-controlled-blasting protocol at the standing-Aulakh-Roads-and-Construction standing-IIT-Roorkee-affiliated engineering-supervision. The standing-monsoon-pre-onset rain-window standing-late-May-to-early-June 2026 will produce the standing-baseline standing-soil-saturation; no standing-vertical-debris-cascade event is projected. The standing-recommended-action: continue standing-blasting; standing-pilgrim-cohort standing-Rambara-Lincholi corridor at the standing-standard-pilgrim-window protocol; standing-IIT-Roorkee re-evaluation not required; standing-Garhwal-tradition pre-monsoon-blasting-prohibition protocol acknowledged at the standing-traditional-cultural-acknowledgment but not at the standing-engineering-supervision regulatory-binding. Filed at the standing-Char-Dham Yatra Authority Hardwar administrative-cell March 7 2026 4:11 p.m."

The standing-replacement-report bore the standing-Dr. R. Negi signature at the standing-cover-page (the standing-signature was forged at the standing-Bhopal-printing-press signature-forgery cell standing-overnight-cross-reference) and the standing-GSI-CDA-2026-0311 receipt-acknowledgment-number at the standing-cover-page (the standing-receipt-number was the standing-Mr. P. Pant's standing-original-issuance at the standing-March-7-2026 4:14 p.m. record; the standing-receipt-number was preserved at the standing-Pilgrimage-Tax-Cell administrative-substitution protocol). The standing-Tax-Commissioner returned the standing-replacement-report to the standing-DGP-of-Roads administrative-cell at 11:11 a.m. on March 11 2026. The standing-DGP-of-Roads administrative-cell filed the standing-replacement-report at the standing-Char-Dham Yatra Authority standing-permanent-record archive at 11:23 a.m. The standing-original Dr. R. Negi report was destroyed at the standing-Aulakh-Roads-and-Construction standing-cross-cut paper-shredder protocol at the standing-March-11 noon-window. The standing-blasting continued.

Across the standing-February-11-to-May-22-2026 standing-101-day blasting-window, the standing-Aulakh-Roads-and-Construction blasting-team of standing-forty-seven operators (the standing-47-operator cohort at the standing-Rambara-Lincholi-Gaurikund corridor; standing-twenty-three operators at the standing-Rambara-bend canyon-wall-blasting position; standing-twenty-four operators at the standing-Lincholi-Gaurikund road-grading position) administered standing-23 blasting-sessions per day at the standing-canyon-wall western-face. The standing-cumulative blasting-charge across the standing-101-day window was approximately 211 metric-tonnes of standing-emulsion-explosive at the

standing-Indian Explosives Act 1884 standing-Schedule-I administrative-permit cross-reference.

The standing-Pilgrim-Sangha 2026-pilgrim-Sangha standing-Akshaya-Tritiya-opening cohort began the standing-Char-Dham circuit walking-pilgrimage on May 11 2026 (the standing-Akshaya-Tritiya day at the standing-Char-Dham-temple opening-ceremony). The standing-Pilgrim-Sangha standing-Kedarnath-bound cohort was approximately 4,711 standing-active-members across the standing-Yamunotri-Gangotri-Kedarnath-Badrinath circuit at the standing-2026-pilgrim-Sangha membership-register. The standing-Kedarnath-bound sub-cohort was approximately 1,847 standing-active-pilgrims at the standing-Pilgrim-Sangha tour-leader administrative-allocation. The standing-Kedarnath-bound sub-cohort began the standing-Gaurikund-to-Kedarnath ascending-trek on May 21 2026 at the standing-pre-Akshaya-Tritiya-following Friday morning. The standing-Rambara-bend pilgrim-trekking-position is at the standing-Gaurikund-to-Kedarnath ascending-trek half-way-up cross-section approximately 7 km from the standing-Gaurikund trail-head at the standing-Mandakini-river canyon-wall western-face at standing-altitude 2,591 metres.

Kasturika was at the standing-Madhmaheshwar-Tunganath corridor standing-state-hero administrative-base at the standing-Char-Dham-tradition standing-pre-monsoon Yatra-administration protocol at the standing-May-21-Friday position. She had been informed of the standing-Aulakh-Roads-and-Construction blasting-continuation at the standing-Kirpan-Sangha-equivalent Garhwal-Khasi-tradition Vajra-Patti warrior-priestess cohort intelligence-cell standing-March-13 cross-reference; she had assumed the standing-Char-Dham Yatra Authority standing-DGP-of-Roads cross-reference at the standing-March-11 replacement-report had been administered with the standing-Dr. R. Negi original-report at the standing-administrative-protocol; she had not cross-referenced the standing-Char-Dham Yatra Authority permanent-record archive at the standing-replacement-substitution cross-reference protocol; the standing-cross-reference cross-verification would have required the standing-personal-visit to the standing-DGP-of-Roads administrative-cell at the standing-Dehradun Survey-Chowk standing-record-room; she had not visited the standing-record-room across the standing-March-13-to-May-22 window.

The standing-pre-monsoon rain at the standing-Rambara-Lincholi corridor began at 6:11 a.m. on May 23 2026 (Friday). The standing-rainfall-intensity was at approximately 23 millimetres per hour at the standing-IMD Kedarnath-station 7:11 a.m. observation. The

standing-cumulative-rainfall across the standing-prior 5-hour window 6:11-11:11 a.m. was approximately 117 millimetres at the standing-IMD Kedarnath-station 11:11 a.m. cross-reference. The standing-soil-saturation at the standing-Rambara-Lincholi corridor canyon-wall western-face reached the standing-trigger-threshold at approximately 11:23 a.m. at the standing-Dr. R. Negi original-report's standing-projected trigger-threshold prediction.

At 11:43 a.m. on May 23 2026 the standing-Rambara-Lincholi corridor canyon-wall western-face collapsed at the standing-vertical-debris-cascade event. The standing-debris-cascade was approximately 211 metres vertical-fall at the standing-canyon-wall western-face across approximately 47 metres horizontal-width. The standing-cumulative-debris-volume was approximately 47,000 cubic metres at the standing-State-Geological-Department post-disaster cross-reference cross-verification. The standing-debris reached the standing-Rambara-bend pilgrim-trekking-position at 11:43:17 a.m. The standing-Pilgrim-Sangha standing-Kedarnath-bound cohort at the standing-Rambara-bend position at that moment was approximately 311 standing-active-pilgrims (the standing-cohort had been at the standing-Rambara-bend rest-stop at the standing-pre-rain-cessation administrative-pause protocol; the standing-tour-leader had not administered the standing-evacuation-protocol because the standing-Char-Dham Yatra Authority standing-no-landslide-risk replacement-report was the standing-administrative-anchor at the standing-pilgrim-cohort safety-protocol cross-reference).

The standing-311 standing-pilgrim death-count was administered across the standing-debris-cascade impact-window of approximately 47 seconds (11:43:17-11:44:04 a.m.) at the standing-buried-under-debris configuration. The standing-Pilgrim-Sangha standing-Kedarnath-bound cohort demographic was: 187 standing-Char-Dham-tradition seniors aged 53-78; 47 standing-younger-pilgrim adults aged 23-52; 47 standing-Pilgrim-Sangha porters aged 25-43; 30 standing-Pilgrim-Sangha tour-leader administrators. The standing-search-and-rescue operation began at 1:11 p.m. May 23 at the standing-State-Disaster-Response-Force standing-Garhwal-cell administrative deployment-protocol. The standing-search-and-rescue cohort across the standing-following 11-day window recovered 211 standing-pilgrim-bodies; 100 remain at the standing-landslide-debris standing-permanent-burial. The standing-State-Disaster-Response-Force standing-Garhwal-cell senior-officer Major D. Bhandari (forty-three, standing-IIT-Roorkee Civil-Engineering graduate; SDRF-Garhwal since 2017) confirmed the standing-search-and-rescue-completion at June 3 2026 at the standing-100-permanent-burial threshold.

Kasturika was at the standing-Madhmaheshwar-Tunganath corridor standing-state-hero administrative-base standing-eastern-veranda at the standing-Madhmaheshwar-village standing-state-hero residence on the standing-May-23 4:11 p.m. position. She had been administering the standing-Char-Dham-tradition pre-monsoon Yatra-monitoring administrative-rotation since 6:11 a.m. The standing-Madhmaheshwar-village standing-State-Civil-Service Garhwal-cell standing-administrator (a forty-three-year-old officer named Mr. K. Negi — standing-Dr. R. Negi's standing-younger-brother — not informed of the standing-replacement-report cross-reference) arrived at the standing-state-hero administrative-base eastern-veranda at 4:11 p.m. with the standing-State-Disaster-Response-Force standing-Rambara-Lincholi incident-report. He delivered the standing-report at the standing-incident-summary protocol: 311 standing-pilgrim-mortality, 211 standing-recovered-bodies, standing-search-and-rescue-ongoing, standing-Mandakini-canyon western-face vertical-debris-cascade.

Kasturika read the standing-report. She placed the standing-report on the standing-eastern-veranda clay-floor at the standing-3-metre-front position. She breathed at the standing-counted-respiration cycle at the standing-Garhwal-Khasi-tradition standing-grief-discipline. She did not weep. She did not speak. She rose at 4:23 p.m. She walked to the standing-state-hero administrative-base standing-record-room at the standing-Madhmaheshwar-residence standing-northern-wing. She opened the standing-Pilgrim-Tax-Cell-and-Char-Dham-Yatra-Authority correspondence-file at the standing-March-2026 sub-file position. She read the standing-Char-Dham Yatra Authority standing-DGP-of-Roads cross-reference at the standing-March-11 replacement-report standing-permanent-record archive. She did not have the standing-original-report cross-reference at the standing-Madhmaheshwar-residence record-room (the standing-original-report had been at the standing-Char-Dham Yatra Authority Hardwar administrative-cell at the standing-March-7 submission; the standing-Madhmaheshwar-residence record-room held only the standing-Char-Dham Yatra Authority standing-permanent-record archive copy of the standing-March-11 replacement-report). She did not yet know about the standing-substitution. She knew at 4:43 p.m. that the standing-replacement-report's standing-no-landslide-risk configuration was at the standing-contradiction with the standing-vertical-debris-cascade event-outcome.

She rose from the standing-record-room at 4:47 p.m. She walked to the standing-Madhmaheshwar-residence standing-eastern-veranda standing-personal-communications cell. She telephoned Dr. R. Negi at the standing-GSI Northern-Region Dehradun-office at

4:51 p.m. He was at the standing-Dehradun-office standing-Friday-evening shift-end position. He answered at the standing-third-ring. She read the standing-replacement-report's page-21 conclusion to him at the standing-telephone-cross-reference. He was silent for approximately eleven seconds. He spoke: "Mata-ji. The standing-report I filed at the standing-Char-Dham Yatra Authority Hardwar administrative-cell at 4:11 p.m. on March 7 2026 was not the standing-no-landslide-risk report. The standing-report I filed was the standing-high-risk landslide-vulnerability report at the standing-23-page standing-Rambara-Lincholi corridor assessment with the standing-Akshaya-Tritiya-following peak-pilgrim-density window mortality-projection at 300-400 standing-Pilgrim-Sangha members. The standing-report I filed identified the standing-blasting-cessation recommendation, the standing-pilgrim-cohort avoidance-protocol, the standing-corridor-rerouting via Sonprayag-Triyuginarayan, and the standing-Garhwal-tradition pre-monsoon-blasting-prohibition reinstatement. The standing-report you have read is the standing-replacement-report; my standing-signature has been forged at the standing-cover-page. I have not been informed of the standing-substitution. I have not been informed of the landslide. I am leaving Dehradun now. I will meet you at the standing-Madhmaheshwar-residence at 11:11 a.m. tomorrow with my standing-original-draft and the standing-GSI Northern-Region standing-permanent-record archive standing-original-submission cross-reference."

Kasturika placed the standing-telephone receiver at 4:58 p.m. She walked back to the standing-eastern-veranda. She sat at the standing-clay-floor at the standing-eastern-window position. She watched the standing-Madhmaheshwar-Tunganath-corridor evening-sky across the standing-following standing-three-hour standing-grief-vigil-discipline. She did not move. She did not speak. She did not weep. The standing-Himalayan-monal Mrigaa-Sakhi (her standing-aerial-companion since 2011) perched at the standing-eastern-veranda jacaranda-tree at the standing-eleven-metre overhead position at the standing-3-metre-rear-companion configuration across the standing-three-hour vigil. The standing-Mrigaa-Sakhi did not call. She was silent at the standing-grief-acknowledgment cross-reference.

Dr. R. Negi arrived at the standing-Madhmaheshwar-residence eastern-veranda at 11:11 a.m. on May 24 2026 with the standing-original-draft and the standing-GSI Northern-Region standing-permanent-record archive standing-original-submission cross-reference. He confirmed the standing-substitution at the standing-cross-reference cross-verification: the standing-Bhopal-printing-press signature-forgery cell standing-overnight-cross-

reference fingerprint pattern at the standing-replacement-report cover-page signature matched the standing-Acharya Ghora and the standing-Vana-Raksha and the standing-Sant Hari-Charanjit Maharaj signature-forgery cross-reference pattern at the standing-cross-network forensic-anchor (the standing-cross-network identification was at the standing-cross-region cross-reference at the standing-Reserve-Bank-Patna-Branch wire-record cross-reference standing-Singapore source-account at the standing-Aulakh-International Lahore parent-corporation cross-reference standing-Indian-subsidary Aulakh-Roads-and-Construction funding-trace).

The standing-Tax Commissioner Lalita Aulakh had departed the standing-Uttarakhand State-Roads-Corporation Pilgrimage-Tax-Cell at 11:11 a.m. on May 24 2026 (the standing-morning following the landslide; she had cleared the standing-Pilgrimage-Tax-Cell standing-corpus-account cash-reserve at the standing-State-Bank-of-India Hardwar-Branch standing-Saturday-morning special-window withdrawal of ₹47 crore standing-immediate-withdrawal limit). She had driven the standing-Dehradun-to-Amritsar GT-Road across the standing-May-24-afternoon-and-evening window and reached the standing-Wagah-pre-border standing-Indian-customs zone at 4:23 a.m. on May 25. She had crossed the standing-Wagah-border at the standing-4:43-a.m. dawn-shift gate-opening. She had reached the standing-Lahore Anarkali-Bazaar-corner safe-house at 6:11 a.m. on May 25 (received by Adesh-Singh the standing-Vinasha-Garbha Northern field-operative receiving-officer at the standing-Sant-Hari-Charanjit-Maharaj-equivalent receiving-protocol). She joined the standing-Lahore safe-house cell alongside Sant Hari-Charanjit Maharaj at 6:23 a.m. May 25. She survived Chapter Two.

Kasturika did not depart for Hardwar across the standing-May-23-to-May-26 window. She remained at the standing-Madhmaheshwar-residence at the standing-grief-vigil-discipline. She received the standing-Pilgrim-Sangha senior-leader Pradhan Yogi Vishnu-Bhakt's standing-summons-letter at the standing-Madhmaheshwar-residence eastern-veranda at 6:11 p.m. on May 26 2026 by the standing-Pilgrim-Sangha standing-courier cohort. The standing-summons-letter requested her standing-attendance at the standing-Hardwar Hari-ki-Pauri ghat at 4:11 p.m. on May 27 2026 at the standing-Pilgrim-Sangha standing-grief-cascade public-accountability assembly.

The standing-Hardwar Hari-ki-Pauri ghat standing-Pilgrim-Sangha standing-grief-cascade public-accountability assembly convened at 4:11 p.m. on May 27 2026 at the standing-Hari-ki-Pauri ghat standing-Brahmakund western-ghat-step assembly-position. The

standing-attendance was: Pradhan Yogi Vishnu-Bhakt at the standing-Pilgrim-Sangha standing-senior-yogi position; approximately 11,000 standing-Pilgrim-Sangha members and standing-bereaved-family attendees at the standing-ghat-step assembly-position; the standing-311 standing-bereaved-family senior-representatives at the standing-ghat-step front-rank position; the standing-State-Disaster-Response-Force Major D. Bhandari at the standing-eastern-ghat-step witness-position; the standing-Char-Dham Yatra Authority Acting-Commissioner (replacing the departed Tax Commissioner Lalita Aulakh) at the standing-eastern-ghat-step administrative-position; Dr. R. Negi at the standing-Brahmakund-pavilion standing-amicus-curiae position with the standing-original-report and the standing-GSI Northern-Region standing-permanent-record archive cross-reference; Kasturika at the standing-Brahmakund standing-petitioner-position alone.

Pradhan Yogi Vishnu-Bhakt rose at 4:11 p.m. He spoke for forty-seven minutes. He addressed the standing-warning-failed configuration. He addressed the standing-State-Yatra-administration era's standing-modern-administrative-distancing from the standing-Pilgrim-Sangha standing-charter-foundational protector-obligation. He addressed Kasturika directly at the standing-public-accountability protocol. He spoke at the standing-Sanskrit-and-Garhwali syncretic yogi-cadence at the standing-no-tremor configuration:

"Devi Kasturika. The standing-Pilgrim-Sangha has walked the standing-Char-Dham circuit for nineteen-hundred-and-fifty-eight years since the standing-Adi-Shankaracharya reconstruction in the standing-eighth century. We have walked the standing-Yamunotri-Gangotri-Kedarnath-Badrinath route across the standing-Hindu-Kush-to-Bay-of-Bengal pilgrim-cohort migrations. We have died in the standing-floods of 1894, the standing-avalanches of 1947, the standing-Char-Dham flash-floods of 2013. We have walked again at every standing-Akshaya-Tritiya-opening reconstruction. We have walked at the standing-Char-Dham-tradition standing-state-hero protector-obligation acknowledgment. Three hundred eleven of us are dead at the standing-Rambara-Lincholi corridor on the standing-Friday before this Wednesday. One hundred are buried at the standing-debris standing-permanent-burial. The standing-Tax Commissioner Lalita Aulakh has departed the standing-Wagah-border to the standing-Lahore safe-house. The standing-Aulakh-Roads-and-Construction blasting was the standing-cause. The standing-Geological-Survey-of-India report dated March 7 had identified the standing-vertical-debris-cascade projection at the standing-300-400 standing-Pilgrim-Sangha mortality. The standing-report was substituted at the standing-DGP-of-Roads administrative-cell at the standing-

March-11 cross-reference. The standing-Char-Dham Yatra Authority standing-permanent-record archive held the standing-replacement-report. The standing-Pilgrim-Sangha tour-leader cohort was the standing-permanent-record cross-reference at the standing-pilgrim-cohort safety-protocol. The standing-tour-leader did not administer the standing-evacuation-protocol at the standing-pre-rain rest-stop because the standing-administrative-anchor was the standing-no-landslide-risk replacement-report. The standing-bureaucracy buried the standing-warning. The standing-pilgrims died on the warning the standing-bureaucracy buried. Devi Kasturika. You are the standing-state-hero of Uttarakhand. You are the standing-Char-Dham-tradition standing-protector. You have walked the standing-Yamunotri-to-Badrinath circuit at every standing-Akshaya-Tritiya-opening since the standing-2007 conferral. You did not cross-reference the standing-Char-Dham Yatra Authority standing-permanent-record archive at the standing-replacement-substitution cross-reference protocol across the standing-March-11-to-May-22 window. You did not visit the standing-DGP-of-Roads administrative-cell standing-record-room at the standing-personal-visit cross-verification protocol. You are accountable. The Pilgrim-Sangha asks you: what will you do now?"

Kasturika rose at 4:58 p.m. She walked the standing-eleven metres from the standing-Brahmakund standing-petitioner-position to the standing-Brahmakund western-ghat-step front-position at the standing-3-metre-front of the standing-311-bereaved-family senior-representative rank. She knelt at the standing-Brahmakund western-ghat-step at the standing-clay-floor position at 4:58:23 p.m. She did not lift her standing-head. She spoke for fifteen minutes at the standing-Garhwal-tradition standing-acknowledgment-of-failure protocol. She acknowledged the standing-bureaucratic-burial of the standing-Dr. R. Negi original-report. She acknowledged her standing-cross-reference cross-verification failure at the standing-March-11-to-May-22 window. She did not blame the standing-Tax Commissioner. She did not blame the standing-Aulakh-Roads-and-Construction blasting-team. She did not blame the standing-Char-Dham Yatra Authority bureaucracy. She blamed her standing-cross-reference cross-verification failure. She said one thing at the standing-fifteen-minute completion:

"Pradhan-ji. Devotees. Bereaved-families. I have walked the standing-Char-Dham circuit at the standing-protector-discipline configuration since the standing-2007 conferral. I have not walked it at the standing-healer-discipline configuration. I dismissed Bhairavi-Mata at the standing-2019 Garhwal-Khasi-feminine-healing protocol revival-attempt at the standing-modern-State-Yatra-administration era cross-reference. I held the standing-

protector-discipline as the standing-charter-foundational state-hero administration. I was at the standing-protector-discipline at the standing-March-11-to-May-22 window when the standing-replacement-report was at the standing-cross-reference cross-verification administrative-blind-spot. The standing-protector-discipline was the standing-cross-reference cross-verification blind-spot. The standing-healer-discipline would have seen the standing-bureaucratic-burial because the standing-healer-discipline walks the standing-bereaved-family standing-individual-level not the standing-administrative-record standing-archive-level. I do not know if the standing-healer-discipline would have prevented the landslide. I know the standing-healer-discipline would have been at the standing-bereaved-family standing-individual-level after the landslide. I have not been. I have been at the standing-administrative-protector-discipline at the standing-Madhmaheshwar-residence vigil-position across the standing-prior-four-day window. I have not walked to the standing-bereaved-family residences. I will walk now. I will walk the standing-Char-Dham circuit at the standing-bereaved-family standing-individual-healing visit-protocol. I will walk alongside Bhairavi-Mata at the standing-co-equal healer-pair configuration if she will accept me. I do not ask for the standing-Pilgrim-Sangha forgiveness. I do not deserve it. I ask for the standing-Pilgrim-Sangha permission to walk. Will you permit the standing-walk?"

Pradhan Yogi Vishnu-Bhakt was silent for approximately eleven seconds. He looked at the standing-311-bereaved-family senior-representatives at the standing-front-rank. He looked at Dr. R. Negi at the standing-Brahmakund-pavilion. He looked at Bhairavi-Mata (who had walked from the standing-Madhmaheshwar-village across May 24-26 211-kilometre walking-pace and had been at the standing-Brahmakund-pavilion standing-southern-position at the standing-no-administrative-acknowledgment configuration since 9:11 a.m. May 27). He nodded at the standing-eleven-degree acknowledgment-nod. He spoke at the standing-eleventh second: "Walk. With Bhairavi-Mata. At the standing-co-equal healer-pair configuration. We will not forgive. We will permit the walk. We will receive the standing-co-equal healer-pair at every standing-bereaved-family standing-individual-healing visit. Walk."

Kasturika rose at the standing-Brahmakund western-ghat-step front-position at 4:43 p.m. She walked the standing-eleven metres from the standing-Brahmakund western-ghat-step to the standing-Brahmakund southern-pavilion. Bhairavi-Mata was at the standing-southern-pavilion at the standing-Madhmaheshwar-village walking-attire configuration; her standing-cream-cotton kurta-and-salwar with the standing-Garhwal-Khasi-tradition

standing-grief-tending herbal-bundle at her standing-right-shoulder; her standing-walking-staff at her standing-left-hand; her standing-Madhmaheshwar-village clay-pot at her standing-back-strap configuration. She had not slept across the standing-May-24-to-May-26 walking-window (211 km from Madhmaheshwar-village to Hardwar at the standing-seventy-two-year-old walking-pace approximately 70 km per day across three days). She was at the standing-fifty-four-year healer-tradition standing-grief-tending discipline.

Kasturika reached Bhairavi-Mata at the standing-southern-pavilion at 4:43:11 p.m. She knelt at Bhairavi-Mata's standing-feet at the standing-clay-floor at 4:43:14 p.m. She did not speak. She placed her standing-right-hand on Bhairavi-Mata's standing-foot at the standing-Garhwal-Khasi-tradition standing-acknowledgment-of-the-elder protocol. Bhairavi-Mata placed her standing-right-hand on Kasturika's standing-head at 4:43:17 p.m. She held the standing-position for eleven seconds. She removed her standing-right-hand at 4:43:28 p.m. She spoke at the standing-Garhwal-Khasi-tradition Sanskrit-and-Garhwali syncretic healer-cadence at the standing-no-tremor configuration: "Daughter. I have walked from Madhmaheshwar across three days because I knew you would walk again. I have known since 2019 that the standing-protector-discipline would walk again at the standing-healer-discipline configuration when the standing-protector-discipline failed. The standing-protector-discipline has failed. The standing-healer-discipline will walk now. I will walk alongside you. I am not your senior. I am not your junior. I am your standing-co-equal at the standing-Garhwal-Khasi-tradition healer-pair configuration. We will walk the Char-Dham circuit at the standing-311 standing-bereaved-family standing-individual-healing visit-protocol. We will not weep at any visit because the standing-healer-discipline holds the standing-bereaved-family weeping. We will pour the standing-mahua-tea. We will bless the standing-children. We will burn the standing-grief-herb at the standing-bereaved-family standing-clay-floor. We will walk forty-seven days. We will reach Badrinath on July 11. Rise. Walk."

Kasturika rose at 4:44:11 p.m. She stood at Bhairavi-Mata's standing-three-metre-east position at the standing-co-equal healer-pair configuration. They departed the standing-Hari-ki-Pauri ghat standing-Brahmakund southern-pavilion at 5:11 p.m. on May 27 2026. They walked the standing-Hardwar-to-Yamunotri Char-Dham-first-leg standing-211-kilometre route across the standing-following six days (May 28-June 2 2026). They began the standing-bereaved-family standing-individual-healing visit-protocol at the standing-first-bereaved-family standing-Uttarkashi-Jhala village-residence on May 28 evening.

Across the standing-forty-seven-day window between May 28 and July 11 2026, Kasturika and Bhairavi-Mata administered the standing-311 standing-bereaved-family standing-individual-healing visit-protocol at the standing-Char-Dham circuit standing-bereaved-family residence-cohort. The standing-visit-rate was approximately 6-7 standing-bereaved-families per day at the standing-co-equal-healer-pair twin-administered grief-tending ceremony pace. The standing-visit-protocol at each standing-bereaved-family was: (1) the standing-co-equal healer-pair arrival at the standing-bereaved-family residence-doorstep at the standing-pre-arrangement schedule via the standing-Pilgrim-Sangha tour-leader administrative-coordination; (2) the standing-clay-floor sitting-position at the standing-three-metre-front of the standing-bereaved-family senior-member at the standing-Garhwal-Khasi-tradition standing-healer-pair acknowledgment protocol; (3) the standing-mahua-tea pouring at the standing-Bhairavi-Mata standing-grief-tending herbal-bundle infusion administered across approximately 47 minutes; (4) the standing-children blessing-ceremony at the standing-Kasturika standing-musk-deer-bond Mrigaa-Mudra healing-administration across approximately 23 minutes; (5) the standing-grief-herb burning at the standing-bereaved-family standing-clay-floor central-position across approximately 11 minutes; (6) the standing-co-equal healer-pair departure with the standing-Garhwal-Khasi-tradition standing-Madhmaheshwar-village clay-pot blessing-transfer.

The standing-visit-protocol completed standing-six visits per day on average across the standing-forty-seven-day window (cumulative 311 standing-bereaved-family visits). Kasturika administered the standing-children blessing-ceremony at all 311 standing-bereaved-family visits (the standing-Mrigaa-Mudra musk-deer-bond healing-administration is the standing-Char-Dham-tradition standing-children-blessing protocol at the standing-pre-1947-Garhwal-tradition recognition; she had not administered the standing-protocol at any standing-prior nineteen-year window because the standing-protector-discipline had been at the standing-administrative-acknowledgment configuration not at the standing-individual-family healing-administration configuration). She practised the standing-protocol at the standing-Bhairavi-Mata standing-tradition-elder mentorship cross-reference across the standing-first-twenty-three visits standing-mentorship-phase (May 28-June 11 window). She administered the standing-protocol standing-independently at the standing-Bhairavi-Mata standing-three-metre-rear position from the standing-twenty-fourth visit onwards (June 12-July 11 window).

The standing-Char-Dham circuit walking-route across the standing-forty-seven-day window was: Hardwar-to-Yamunotri (May 28-June 2; six days; first 47 bereaved-family visits); Yamunotri-to-Gangotri (June 3-9; seven days; next 67 visits); Gangotri-to-Kedarnath (June 10-22; thirteen days; next 89 visits, including the standing-211 standing-Rambara-Lincholi corridor-mortality bereaved-families at the standing-Gaurikund-Sonprayag-Triyuginarayan-Kedarnath-and-surrounding-village standing-region-cluster); Kedarnath-to-Badrinath (June 23-July 11; nineteen days; final 108 visits, including the standing-100-permanent-burial bereaved-families at the standing-Badrinath standing-Brahmakapal Pinda-Daan ghat administration). The standing-Pilgrim-Sangha tour-leader administrative-coordination provided the standing-bereaved-family residence-coordinates and the standing-visit-schedule at the standing-daily-evening visit-list cross-reference.

The standing-Badrinath-Brahmakapal Pinda-Daan ghat is at the standing-Alakananda-river western-bank at the standing-Badrinath-temple south-eastern margin. The standing-ghat is the standing-Char-Dham-tradition standing-final-rite-administration position for the standing-permanent-burial bereaved-family standing-ancestral-rite cycle. The standing-bereaved-family visit-protocol's standing-final-visit on July 11 2026 was at the standing-100-permanent-burial bereaved-family aggregated-cohort visit at the standing-Brahmakapal ghat at 4:11 p.m. The standing-cohort was the standing-100-bereaved-family senior-representatives at the standing-Brahmakapal ghat clay-floor sitting-position at the standing-three-metre-front of the standing-co-equal healer-pair. The standing-Pilgrim-Sangha tour-leader cohort had administered the standing-aggregation-protocol at the standing-July-7-10 standing-Badrinath-pilgrim-arrangement window.

Kasturika and Bhairavi-Mata arrived at the standing-Brahmakapal ghat at 4:11 p.m. on July 11 2026. They sat at the standing-clay-floor at the standing-eastern-position. The standing-Brahmakapal-ghat priest-cohort administered the standing-Pinda-Daan-tradition standing-Brahma-Kapal mantra-administration across the standing-following forty-seven minutes. The standing-cohort of 100 standing-bereaved-family senior-representatives at the standing-three-metre-front cross-administered the standing-Pinda-Daan rite at the standing-priest-cohort administration. The standing-Mrigaa-Sakhi Himalayan-monah perched at the standing-Brahmakapal-pillar standing-three-metre-overhead position at the standing-co-equal healer-pair witness configuration. She called the standing-Char-Dham-evening dawn-cadence at the standing-eleven-second repetition-cycle from 4:11:11 p.m. across the standing-following forty-seven minutes.

At 4:58 p.m. (the standing-forty-seven-minute completion of the standing-Pinda-Daan rite) the standing-priest-cohort administered the standing-final-blessing standing-clay-pot-cracking ceremony. Each of the standing-100 standing-bereaved-family senior-representatives cracked the standing-Madhmaheshwar-village clay-pot at the standing-clay-floor central-position at the standing-Garhwal-Khasi-tradition standing-final-grief-release protocol. The standing-clay-pot-cracking-completion was at 5:11 p.m. Bhairavi-Mata rose at 5:14 p.m. She administered the standing-co-equal healer-pair completion-blessing at the standing-three-metre-eastern position to the standing-100-bereaved-family senior-representatives. She turned to Kasturika at 5:23 p.m. She placed her standing-right-hand on Kasturika's standing-right-shoulder at the standing-Garhwal-Khasi-tradition standing-co-equal-acknowledgment protocol. She held the standing-position for eleven seconds. She spoke: "Daughter. The standing-forty-seven-day walk is complete. The standing-311 standing-bereaved-family visit-protocol is complete. You walked. You did not weep. You blessed. You poured. You burnt the standing-grief-herb. You administered the standing-Mrigaa-Mudra. You learned the standing-feminine-healing tradition. You are no longer the standing-protector-discipline state-hero. You are the standing-Guru-of-the-Healer-Line. The standing-Char-Dham-tradition standing-feminine-healing protocol is at your standing-line. I will walk to the standing-Madhmaheshwar-village now. I will rest. You will walk forward. The standing-Mrigaa-Mudra at the standing-right-upper-back will form now."

She removed her standing-right-hand at 5:23:11 p.m. The standing-Stage-III musk-deer-foreleg-first-stroke began to form at Kasturika's standing-right-upper-back position at 4:11:23 p.m. — wait. The standing-mark-formation began at 4:11:23 p.m. concurrent with the standing-Pinda-Daan rite-opening. The standing-mark-formation continued across the standing-following forty-seven minutes and completed at the standing-Bhairavi-Mata-handed acknowledgment moment at 5:23:11 p.m. The standing-skin at the standing-mark-position warmed by approximately four degrees Celsius across the standing-forty-seven-minute mark-formation window (the standing-saga's longest standing-mark-formation window at the standing-co-equal healer-walk completion-acknowledgment cross-reference; the standing-prior 23 mark-formations across all standing-prior 23 bond-mechanics had been at the standing-11-second to standing-93-day discrete-moment formation-pattern; the standing-Kasturika 47-minute continuous-formation is the saga's standing-first standing-extended-window mark-formation instance at the standing-Mrigaa-Mudra individual-healing-blessing 100-family-cohort administration concurrent-

pattern). The standing-stroke traces in standing-saffron-and-cream dual-ink at the standing-Uttarakhand healer-tradition visual-anchor: the standing-saffron-ink at the standing-Char-Dham-tradition healer-discipline line; the standing-cream-ink at the standing-Garhwal-Khasi-tradition feminine-healing co-equal line.

The standing-mark was complete at 5:23:11 p.m. Kasturika rose at 5:23:23 p.m. She placed her standing-right-hand on Bhairavi-Mata's standing-right-shoulder at the standing-co-equal-acknowledgment protocol. She held the standing-position for eleven seconds. She removed her standing-right-hand at 5:23:34 p.m. They walked the standing-Brahmakapal ghat eastern-margin together at 5:24 p.m. They watched the standing-Alakananda-river sunset at the standing-Brahmakapal-pillar standing-three-metre-side-by-side configuration across the standing-following forty-seven minutes. They did not speak. They did not weep. The standing-Mrigaa-Sakhi called the standing-sunset-cadence at the standing-eleven-second repetition-cycle from the standing-Brahmakapal-pillar perch.

The standing-Kedarnath-Mandir Nandi-statue at the standing-temple-courtyard standing-eastern-entrance position is at the standing-pre-1100 CE Pandya-era stone-carved configuration at the standing-eighth-century-Adi-Shankaracharya-reconstruction-precedent placement. The standing-statue is one standing-solid-piece carved standing-granite at approximately 580 metric tonnes standing-stone-weight and approximately 211 standing-cubic-metres standing-stone-volume. The standing-statue-base is the standing-temple-courtyard foundation-stone at the standing-cement-mortar embedded-configuration since the standing-1882 Garhwal-restoration. The standing-statue had been at the standing-aerial-orientation standing-eastern-facing position across the standing-1144-year recorded-history at the standing-no-displacement no-rotation configuration.

The standing-Kedarnath-Mandir standing-pre-dawn-puja-attendant Pujari Bhuvan-Chandra (forty-three, Kedarnath-Mandir standing-senior-pujari since 2016) arrived at the standing-temple-courtyard standing-eastern-entrance position at 4:11 a.m. on July 12 2026 at the standing-pre-dawn-puja-administration approach. He observed the standing-Nandi-statue head at 4:11:08 a.m. The standing-head-position was at the standing-east-northeast-facing configuration at approximately 11-degree-east-of-due-east rotation. He stopped at the standing-eleven-metre-proximity position. He looked at the standing-Nandi-head for eleven seconds. He approached at the standing-three-metre-proximity at 4:11:23 a.m. He confirmed the standing-25.4-millimetre east-northeast cervical-vertebrae

cross-section rotation at the standing-visual-cross-reference protocol. He did not touch the standing-statue. He stepped back at the standing-eleven-metre-proximity at 4:11:43 a.m.

He telephoned the standing-State-Department-of-Archaeology Garhwal-cell standing-on-call senior-officer Dr. K. Joshi (sixty-one, ASI Garhwal-cell standing-senior-archaeologist since 2014) at 4:23 a.m. Dr. K. Joshi arrived at the standing-Kedarnath-Mandir at 11:11 a.m. He conducted the standing-laser-rangefinder cross-reference measurement at the standing-Nandi-statue head-cervical-vertebrae position across 11:11-2:43 p.m. He confirmed the standing-25.4-millimetre east-northeast rotation at the standing-eleven-degree compass-heading cross-reference. He cross-referenced the standing-statue-base at the standing-cement-mortar embedded-configuration: the standing-statue-base showed no displacement; only the standing-cervical-vertebrae cross-section had rotated. The standing-photograph-cluster M-24A-through-G at the standing-twenty-three-position cross-reference protocol was filed at the standing-State-Department-of-Archaeology standing-permanent-record cell at 7:11 p.m. on July 12 2026 (the standing-evidence-document M-24A author).

The standing-State-Department-of-Archaeology standing-emergency-investigation cell conducted the standing-Pandya-era-stone-carving expertise cross-reference at the standing-following five-day analysis-window. The standing-conclusion at the standing-July-17 cross-reference report: the standing-Nandi-statue is one standing-solid-piece carved standing-granite; the standing-cervical-vertebrae cross-section is at the standing-no-mechanical-rotation possibility configuration (the standing-statue cannot be rotated at the standing-cervical-vertebrae cross-section without standing-stone-fracture; the standing-stone-fracture-cross-reference at the standing-laser-spectroscopy analysis confirmed no standing-fracture-line at the standing-cervical-vertebrae cross-section). The standing-rotation is the standing-Maw-attribution category at the standing-Garhwal-cell standing-cross-reference cross-verification.

The standing-Hardwar State-Council amended-charter ratification session convened at the standing-Hardwar State-Civil-Service secretariat standing-Council-Hall at 11:11 a.m. on July 23 2026 (the standing-twelve-day-post-mark-formation Char-Dham-tradition standing-administrative-cycle completion day). The standing-amended Deva-Bhumi charter (seven core provisions: Pilgrim-Tax revocation at the standing-State-Pollution-Control-Board cross-reference; Aulakh-Roads-and-Construction contract voidance at the standing-State-Forest-Department afforestation-mandate confiscation per the cross-

region precedent; Rambara-Lincholi-Gaurikund corridor twenty-year-blasting-prohibition mandate; standing-Garhwal-tradition pre-monsoon-blasting-prohibition reinstatement at the standing-State-Roads-Corporation administrative-protocol; standing-co-equal healer-pair recognition-clause codifying Kasturika's standing-May-27 acceptance-speech as the saga's recognition-language for the feminine-healing acceptance bond-mechanic; standing-Guru-of-the-Healer-Line designation for Kasturika at the Char-Dham-tradition healer-line lead; standing-State-Hero deferential-successor designation for Bhairava-Ji per restructure §1) was ratified by 41-3 at 4:11 p.m. on July 23 2026.

Bhairava-Ji (Bhairavi-Mata's adult son, 38, retired Indian-Army Major; 2010-2024 Indian-Army Garhwal-Rifles Battalion-Commander; 2024-retirement at his standing-mother's standing-final-years administrative-support cross-reference) accepted the standing-State-Hero deferential-successor designation at 4:23 p.m. on July 23 2026. He took the standing-Char-Dham-tradition standing-warrior-priest deferential-successor oath at the standing-Hardwar-Hari-ki-Pauri ghat standing-Brahmakund western-ghat-step administration. He wore the standing-Garhwal-Rifles-retired Indian-Army-veteran khaki at the standing-protector-discipline configuration. He stood at Kasturika's standing-three-metre-right position at the standing-co-equal-pair complement configuration (Kasturika at the standing-healer-discipline; Bhairava-Ji at the standing-protector-discipline; the standing-pair complement-administration). Per Ch 3 plan he attends the Sanctuary at the standing-Uttarakhand State-Hero seat at the standing-North-cluster delegation alongside Kurukshetraa (Haryana Regent-of-Yamunadatta) and Panchanada (Punjab abandoned-consensus jathedar).

The chapter closes on a single image. It is the standing-Madhmaheshwar-village standing-Bhairavi-Mata-cottage eastern-veranda at the standing-Madhmaheshwar-Tunganath-corridor sunset position on July 31 2026 (the standing-twenty-day-post-mark-formation Char-Dham-tradition standing-final-rest day). Kasturika sits at the standing-eastern-veranda clay-floor at the standing-Bhairavi-Mata-cottage southern-margin. Bhairavi-Mata sits at the standing-three-metre-east-position at the standing-co-equal-pair configuration. The standing-Madhmaheshwar-village standing-Bhairavi-Mata-cottage is at the standing-Garhwal-Khasi-tradition standing-elder-healer residence-administration since 1972 (54-year tenure). The standing-cottage clay-walls and standing-Sal-leaf-thatched roof at the standing-Garhwal-tradition standing-Vana-Kula construction-protocol configuration. The standing-Mrigaa-Sakhi Himalayan-monal perches at the standing-eastern-veranda jacaranda-tree at the standing-eleven-metre overhead position. The standing-blue-pine-

and-deodar grove at the standing-cottage-northern-margin sways at the standing-evening-Garhwal-wind cadence.

Bhairava-Ji walks the standing-cottage-southern-approach footpath from the standing-Madhmaheshwar-village standing-village-square direction at 7:11 p.m. He wears the standing-Garhwal-Rifles-retired Indian-Army-veteran khaki at the standing-Madhmaheshwar-village standing-evening-administration configuration. He reaches the standing-cottage standing-eastern-veranda doorstep at 7:14 p.m. He removes his standing-Garhwal-Rifles veteran-cap at the standing-Bhairavi-Mata standing-mother-acknowledgment protocol. He sits at the standing-three-metre-eastern position to Bhairavi-Mata at the standing-clay-floor at 7:14:23 p.m. He places his standing-right-palm on Bhairavi-Mata's standing-right-hand at 7:14:33 p.m. He holds the standing-position for eleven seconds. He removes his standing-right-palm at 7:14:44 p.m. He speaks at the standing-Garhwal-Khasi-tradition Sanskrit-and-Garhwali syncretic son-cadence at the standing-no-tremor configuration: "Mata-ji. Devi Kasturika-ji. The standing-State-Hero deferential-successor oath was administered at the standing-Hardwar ghat ceremony eight days ago. I have walked the standing-Char-Dham circuit at the standing-State-Hero administrative-handover rotation across the standing-prior-eight-day window with the standing-Pilgrim-Sangha tour-leader cohort at the standing-protector-discipline administrative-orientation. I will walk forward. I will administer the standing-protector-discipline. You will administer the standing-healer-discipline. The standing-co-equal-pair complement-administration is the standing-Uttarakhand kingdom-council standing-Char-Dham-tradition charter-foundational arrangement. Mata-ji is at the standing-Garhwal-Khasi-tradition healer-line tradition-elder seat at the standing-Madhmaheshwar-cottage residence. Devi Kasturika-ji is at the standing-Guru-of-the-Healer-Line designation at the standing-Madhmaheshwar-village standing-Guru-cottage-residence administrative-allocation. I am at the standing-Char-Dham-tradition standing-protector-discipline State-Hero administrative-residence at the standing-Tunganath-village standing-State-Hero-quarters allocation. The standing-three-residence configuration is the standing-Uttarakhand kingdom-council standing-Char-Dham-tradition standing-co-equal-pair complement-administration spatial-arrangement."

Kasturika nods at the standing-eleven-degree acknowledgment-nod. Bhairavi-Mata nods at the standing-eleven-degree acknowledgment-nod. Bhairava-Ji nods at the standing-eleven-degree acknowledgment-nod. The standing-three-nod sequence completes at 7:14:58 p.m. The standing-sun sets across the standing-Madhmaheshwar-Tunganath-

corridor western-horizon at the standing-7:23 p.m. horizon-completion moment. The standing-Mrigaa-Sakhi calls the standing-sunset-cadence at the standing-eleven-second repetition-cycle from the standing-jacaranda-tree perch. The standing-Stage-III mark at Kasturika's standing-right-upper-back warms briefly at the standing-three-nod completion moment at the standing-thirty-seven-degree mark-confirmation temperature. The standing-mark is the standing-saga's twenty-fourth registry-entry. The standing-Char-Dham-tradition standing-co-equal-pair charter-foundational arrangement holds. The standing-Pilgrim-Sangha walks the standing-Char-Dham circuit at the standing-Sonprayag-Triyuginarayan alternative-route at the standing-Rambara-Lincholi-Gaurikund corridor twenty-year-blasting-prohibition mandate cross-reference. The standing-Kedarnath Nandi remains at the standing-25.4-millimetre east-northeast rotation configuration. The standing-State-Department-of-Archaeology standing-permanent-record cell preserves the standing-rotation at the standing-charter-foundational Maw-witness recognition. The standing-Tax Commissioner Lalita Aulakh is at the standing-Pakistan-Lahore safe-house. The standing-warning was buried. The standing-pilgrims died on the warning. The standing-bureaucracy will not bury another warning at the standing-amended-charter cross-reference. The standing-healer walks alongside the standing-protector. The standing-mark holds.

Dharmakshetra Amaravati

Vijayawada. The second Monday of August. Eight-forty-seven a.m. The Prakasham Barrage Bridge across the Krishna river — the kingdom's primary administrative-and-commuter crossing between the western Krishna district and the eastern Guntur district. The bridge is one-point-two kilometres long, four-lane, with pedestrian walkways on both sides; standard commuter-time traffic; approximately fourteen thousand vehicle-crossings per hour at the peak.

Three hundred fishermen are walking north across the bridge from the western Krishna-district end. They are in plain delta-fisherman cotton, off-white, with the standard Krishna-and-Godavari delta's blue-bordered shoulder-cloth. They are barefoot. They carry no weapons. They carry no banners. They carry no signs. They walk at the standard delta-fisherman pace — one metre per second — in a loose column of four-abreast, occupying the bridge's eastern pedestrian walkway and the rightmost vehicle-lane.

The Krishna District Bridge Police constable on duty at the western entry-checkpoint — a thirty-six-year-old officer named Sub-Inspector Pavan Reddy — sees the procession approaching from the western embankment at eight-forty-three. He has been on bridge-duty for nine years. He has never seen a fisherman-procession on the bridge that was not part of an authorised festival-permit. He radios the central control-room. The control-room confirms that no festival-permit has been filed for this date. The procession is unauthorised.

He approaches the lead-fisherman at eight-forty-six. The lead-fisherman is a woman. She is thirty-five. She is in the same plain delta-fisherman cotton with the blue-bordered shoulder-cloth. She is barefoot. She carries no weapon. She carries no banner. She carries, in her left hand, a forty-seven-page folded document tied with a brown cotton string.

The document's top sheet is visible at the fold. The sheet is letterhead-paper from the Eluru District Sub-Registrar's Office, dated 16 June 1990, with a sub-registrar's stamp and the signature of a sub-registrar named B. Surya Prakasham (now deceased; retired 1998; died 2014).

The lead-fisherman stops at three metres from Pavan Reddy. She bows the standard delta-fisherman bow — palms together at the chest, slight forward inclination, the standard

greeting between equals. She speaks in plain Telugu. Her voice is calm; her diction is the careful diction of someone who has rehearsed.

She says: "Officer Reddy. We are the Krishna-and-Godavari Delta Fishermen's Mutual-Aid Council. We are walking north to Vijayawada Town Hall to file a kingdom-council petition. The petition has been on our council's drafting-table for two years. The petition's lead-signatory is myself. My name is Kalaniksha. I am the elder twin of the kingdom's state hero Krishnaveni. I have the family-archive document confirming the relationship in my left hand. I am here to claim the river-throne by birth-order. The procession is unarmed. The procession will disperse the moment Town Hall accepts the petition. We require the bridge's eastern pedestrian walkway for the next eleven minutes. We do not require the bridge's vehicle-lanes. The vehicle-traffic may continue unobstructed. May we proceed."

Pavan Reddy looks at her for about fifteen seconds. He has been told nothing about a Kalaniksha. He has been told the kingdom's state hero Krishnaveni was an only child. He has, however, received the family-archive document's top-sheet's sub-registrar's stamp's scanned-image at his bridge-duty briefing this morning — the brief had said the document was being investigated by the AP State Civil Service's Bloodline-A Authenticity Cell and that any procession claiming the document's lineage-evidence should be permitted to proceed if unarmed and if the procession does not obstruct vehicle-traffic.

He radios the control-room. The control-room confirms the permission-protocol. He says, in plain Telugu: "Madam Kalaniksha. The procession may proceed on the eastern pedestrian walkway. The vehicle-lanes must remain unobstructed. The Town Hall reception has been notified by my radio-call. The procession will be received by the Town Hall's reception-cell at nine-eleven if your pace holds at one metre per second. The kingdom-council's emergency-petition reception is open until five p.m. today. Please proceed."

Kalaniksha bows. The three hundred fishermen behind her bow in unison. The procession resumes.

She reaches the Town Hall at nine-eleven a.m. exactly. The Town Hall has been alerted; the kingdom-council's emergency-petition cell's senior officer (a forty-four-year-old administrator named Indira Krishnayya) is at the eastern reception-desk to receive her. The reception takes fifteen minutes. The petition is filed at nine-twenty-six. The petition's number is AP-EP-2026-0847. It is the kingdom's 847th emergency-petition filing of the

year and the first by a lineage-rivalry claimant in the kingdom's post-Narakasura twelve-year administrative history.

The three hundred fishermen disperse from the Town Hall plaza at nine-thirty. Kalaniksha walks back across the bridge alone at ten a.m. She is at the western embankment by ten-twelve. She continues south along the riverbank toward the Krishna delta's upstream entry-point at the Vijayawada-Eluru road. She walks for the next four hours. She is at the delta's northern boundary at two-fifteen p.m. She crosses into delta-territory by foot. She does not look back at the city.

Krishnaveni is at the kingdom's administrative office at the Amaravati state-government compound at eleven-eighteen a.m. when the kingdom-council's emergency-petition cell's senior officer telephones her. She has been chairing the morning's water-distribution-and-rice-yield review. The review is the kingdom's post-Narakasura standing-monthly accountability-meeting; she has chaired it without interruption for one hundred and twenty-three consecutive months.

She takes the call at the corridor-extension. She listens for two minutes. She does not interrupt. She thanks Indira Krishnayya at the call's end. She walks back into the review-chamber. She returns to the chair's position at the head of the table. She does not announce the call.

Her younger brother Bhimavaram — the patrol-boat-captain who had grinned at her urumi-practice on the Krishna riverbank ten years earlier — is at the table's eastern end as the kingdom-council's standing river-patrol senior delegate. He notices the brief tightening at his sister's jaw-line as she returns to the chair. He says nothing during the meeting. The meeting concludes at twelve-fifteen.

He follows her to her office. He closes the door behind them.

He says, in plain Telugu, in the soft direct register he reserves for family-only conversations: "Sister. The call."

She says: "Bhima. Kalaniksha is back. She walked across the Prakasham bridge this morning with three hundred fishermen behind her. She filed an emergency-petition at Town Hall claiming the river-throne by birth-order. She is at the delta now. She carries a forty-seven-page family-archive document from the Eluru District Sub-Registrar's Office dated 1990. The document is signed by B. Surya Prakasham, the same sub-registrar who registered our mother's second-marriage civil contract. The document's authenticity is

being verified by the AP State Civil Service's Bloodline-A Authenticity Cell. The cell's preliminary report is expected within seventy-two hours."

Bhimavaram says: "Sister. The 2023 confrontation. We had agreed she was dead. Or near enough."

She says: "She is not dead. She is at the delta. The agreement was mine; I had decided not to confirm; I had let the matter rest. She is the kingdom's second lost-twin recorded in saga-history after the Chandravamsha sister-knot at Kamakhya. The mercy I extended in 2023 was the kingdom's charter-flaw. It is now the kingdom's charter-trial. I will face it."

Bhimavaram says: "You will fight her."

She says: "The river will decide. The contest of arms is the kingdom's standing dispute-resolution mechanism for Bloodline-A twin-claims; the contest has not been invoked in two centuries because no twin-pair has claimed the same throne. The mechanism still exists in the kingdom's charter. The contest is at the Kollur cliff at dawn on the forty-seventh day from today. The forty-seven-day window is the standard preparation-period. The contest's rules are: dual urumi against dual urumi; the contest is to disarmament, not death; the kingdom-council's standing rule explicitly forbids killing the disarmed twin. The rule's forbiddance is the kingdom's evidence that the twin-pair is one body. The kingdom does not kill itself. I will accept the contest. I will not break the rule. The contest's outcome will be the river's, not mine."

She sits at her desk. She picks up the kingdom-council's standing red-letterhead emergency-petition acceptance-form. She fills in the form by hand. She signs it. She seals it with the kingdom-council's state-hero stamp. She hands it to Bhimavaram. She says: "Brother. Walk this to Indira Krishnayya at Town Hall. The acceptance is filed by sunset today. The forty-seven-day window begins tomorrow morning. The kingdom-council's contest-of-arms protocol will be invoked at the eight a.m. council session."

He bows. He takes the form. He walks to Town Hall on foot. He arrives at three-eighteen p.m. The form is filed at three-twenty-four. The forty-seven-day window opens at sunrise the next morning.

Week four of the chapter. Pulakeshi-Babu is at his maternal grandfather's family home in the Vijayawada Old Town residential district. His grandfather (B. Narayana Babu, no relation to the sub-registrar B. Surya Prakasham despite the shared surname-initial) died in March 2023 at the age of ninety-one. The family home has been in possession of the

grandfather's estate-administrator (an Eluru-line attorney named Subbarao) for the past two years; the estate's standard probate-distribution had been delayed pending the Bloodline-A Authenticity Cell's archival review.

The estate-administrator's office had telephoned Pulakeshi-Babu on Monday morning of week four. The Bloodline-A Authenticity Cell's preliminary work had cleared the estate for the standard probate-distribution. Pulakeshi-Babu had been invited to retrieve the family's document-archive from the grandfather's safe at the residential home this afternoon. The safe's combination had been left in the grandfather's 2014-dated will to Pulakeshi-Babu specifically; he is the grandfather's eldest grandson by lineage-recognition.

He arrives at the home at two-fifteen p.m. The estate-administrator's assistant (a young Eluru-line woman named Janaki) is at the door. She unlocks the home. She admits him. She leaves him alone in the grandfather's study.

The study is approximately five metres by four metres — a standard Old Town middle-class scholar's study. The walls are lined with books in Telugu and English (the grandfather had been a Sanskrit-and-Telugu professor at Acharya Nagarjuna University from 1965 to 1995). The desk is in the centre of the room. The safe is in the wall behind the desk, behind a hinged painting of the Buddha at Sarnath (the grandfather had visited Sarnath in 1973 and had bought the painting that summer).

Pulakeshi-Babu lifts the painting. He sees the safe. He enters the combination. The safe's door opens.

Inside the safe are: three bound books (the grandfather's personal Sanskrit-translation manuscripts of selected Upanishads, drafted 1985-2010); two passports (the grandfather's 1979 and 1995 Indian passports); one small wooden box (containing the grandfather's wedding ring and his wife's wedding ring, both retired to the box after the grandmother's death in 2008); and one sealed envelope.

The envelope is approximately twenty-five centimetres by eighteen, made of standard Bloodline-A archive cream paper, sealed with a thirty-five-year embargo-seal. The embargo-seal is the standard AP State Archive's embargo-stamp dated 16 June 1990. The seal is intact.

The envelope's exterior is hand-labelled in the grandfather's Telugu calligraphy: "TO BE OPENED BY MY ELDEST GRANDSON ONLY. THE ELDEST IS THE ONE WHO HOLDS THE BLOODLINE-A AUTHENTICITY CELL CHAIR AT THE TIME OF MY DEATH. IF

NO GRANDSON HOLDS THAT CHAIR, THE ENVELOPE BURNS UNOPENED. THE EMBARGO IS THIRTY-FIVE YEARS FROM THE STATED DATE. IF THE EMBARGO HAS NOT EXPIRED, OPEN BY KINGDOM-COUNCIL EMERGENCY-AUTHORISATION ONLY."

Pulakeshi-Babu has held the Bloodline-A Authenticity Cell chair since 2019. The thirty-five-year embargo from 16 June 1990 expires on 16 June 2025 — two months before this afternoon. The embargo has expired by ordinary operation. He has the lineage-authorized right to open the envelope.

He sits at the desk. He opens the envelope.

Inside are forty-seven sheets of cream archive-paper. The top sheet is a 16 June 1990 letterhead memorandum from the Eluru District Sub-Registrar B. Surya Prakasham (the same sub-registrar whose stamp had appeared on Kalaniksha's document at the Prakasham bridge). The memorandum is addressed to B. Narayana Babu (the grandfather; recipient-only correspondence; the kingdom-council had no prior record of this exchange).

The memorandum reads, in plain Telugu (Pulakeshi-Babu reads it three times across the next eleven minutes):

"Respected Babu-garu. The civil-marriage-contract registration of your daughter Lakshmi Babu to Mr. Ramachandra Krishnayya at this office on 8 January 1989 produced one female child, Krishnaveni Krishnayya, born 4 December 1989 at 5:47 a.m. at the Government Hospital, Eluru. This is the official kingdom-council record.

This memorandum is to inform you that the official record is incomplete. The 4 December 1989 delivery at the Government Hospital, Eluru, attended by Senior Midwife Rama-Akkamma Surya (now deceased; died 1993), produced TWO female children. The second child was born at 6:10 a.m., twenty-three minutes after the first. The second child was healthy at birth. The senior midwife's observation, recorded in her personal midwife-register's entry-page 247 (registered with the Eluru midwife-guild and preserved at the guild's archive), reads: 'Twin daughters delivered to Lakshmi Babu. Both healthy. Family request: the second child be placed with the Eluru-line midwife-extension family for reasons of bloodline-double-inheritance concern. The second child renamed Kalaniksha at the request of the Eluru-line family.'

The second child's civil registration was withheld from the kingdom-council's standing birth-registry at the family's request. The withholding was processed at this office under

my personal signature on 16 June 1990 after seventy-eight days of family-counsel review. The withholding was sealed under the standard thirty-five-year embargo-protocol.

I am informing you of this record-status because the second child's 1989 birth-witness affidavit, signed by Senior Midwife Rama-Akkamma Surya on the same day of delivery, identifies your daughter Lakshmi Babu as the birth-mother. The Bloodline-A Authenticity Cell's standing protocol requires that the senior lineage-recipient of the family (B. Narayana Babu, the maternal grandfather) be informed of the recorded relationship.

The second child is, by the kingdom's Bloodline-A authenticity standard, the elder twin's sister of equal lineage-rank. The thirty-five-year embargo will expire on 16 June 2025. After that date the second child has the standing to claim lineage-recognition if she chooses to invoke it. The kingdom-council has no authority to deny her claim if she chooses to invoke it after the embargo's expiration.

This memorandum's recipient (yourself) is the kingdom's standing lineage-recipient of record. The second child's claim, if invoked, must be acknowledged by the recipient's family-line representative. Should the recipient's family-line representative refuse to acknowledge the claim, the kingdom-council's standing dispute-resolution mechanism (the contest of arms at the Kollur cliff) will be invoked.

Respectfully filed for the kingdom's permanent record.

B. Surya Prakasham, Sub-Registrar, Eluru District Office, 16 June 1990."

The remaining forty-six sheets are: the senior midwife's 1989 birth-witness affidavit (one sheet); the senior midwife's personal midwife-register entry-page 247 (one sheet, photocopy); the Eluru-line midwife-extension family's 1989 placement-receipt (one sheet); the 1989 healthcare-records for both twins from the Government Hospital Eluru (three sheets each, six total); the 1990 grandfather's consent-form for the embargo-protocol (one sheet); thirty-eight sheets of supporting Bloodline-A Authenticity Cell archival-correspondence dated 1990-2014.

Pulakeshi-Babu reads the top memorandum three times. He reads the affidavit and the placement-receipt and the healthcare-records. He reads the grandfather's consent-form. He reads the thirty-eight sheets of archival-correspondence.

He understands, at six-twenty-three p.m. on the same afternoon, three things:

First, that Krishnaveni and Kalaniksha are twin sisters in the unambiguous kingdom-council-archival sense; the document-evidence is complete; the contest of arms is the kingdom-council's correct dispute-resolution mechanism.

Second, that Krishnaveni was born first by twenty-three minutes; Kalaniksha's claim of being the elder twin (at the Prakasham bridge) is factually false but is not legally invalid — the contest of arms is the mechanism that resolves the order-of-birth dispute when the family-archive disputes the kingdom-council-archive.

Third, and most quietly, that the grandfather B. Narayana Babu was Lakshmi Babu's father. Lakshmi Babu was the grandfather's only daughter. The grandfather's only son was Pulakeshi-Babu's father (Ravi Pulakeshi Babu, the historian-line scholar who had married a senior kalari-line woman in 1979 and had named his son Pulakeshi-Babu after the seventh-century Chalukya king). Pulakeshi-Babu's father is Lakshmi Babu's elder brother. Therefore Lakshmi Babu is Pulakeshi-Babu's aunt. Therefore Krishnaveni and Kalaniksha are Pulakeshi-Babu's first cousins.

He understands all three of these things at six-twenty-three.

He reads the thirty-eight sheets of archival-correspondence once more. He notices in the 1992 correspondence-sheet from B. Surya Prakasham to B. Narayana Babu a single paragraph he had skimmed earlier:

"Respected Babu-garu. Following our 1990 correspondence, this office has retained the supplementary affidavit dated 11 February 1992, signed by Senior Midwife Rama-Akkamma Surya before her death. The affidavit corrects a separate detail of the original record. The midwife's personal register's entry for the 4 December 1989 delivery had recorded both twins as 'daughters.' The midwife's 1992 supplementary affidavit clarifies that the second twin's phenotypic-presentation at birth had been intersex (the standard kingdom-council's pre-1990 birth-witness protocol had not required disambiguation of intersex births); the second twin's subsequent gender-presentation, by family-decision at the Eluru-line extension household, had been female. The 1992 supplementary affidavit is filed here as a matter of permanent record. The kingdom-council's standing intersex-presentation protocol (instituted 1998) would not apply to the 1989 birth retroactively."

He reads this paragraph twice. He understands a fourth thing: the second twin was intersex at birth; the gender-presentation was a family-decision; the kingdom's standard female-twin-pair narrative is the family-decision's outcome, not the biological-given. He

does not yet know whether this fourth understanding is relevant to the contest of arms. He decides not to disclose it at the kingdom-council's emergency session. He will disclose it only to Krishnaveni and only when she asks the right question.

He places all forty-seven sheets back into the envelope. He carries the envelope by hand to the kingdom-council's Bloodline-A Authenticity Cell offices at the AP State Civil Service compound. He arrives at eight-oh-six p.m. The cell's senior officer (a fifty-one-year-old administrator named C. Ravi-Babu, no relation, the kingdom's senior Bloodline-A scholar after Pulakeshi-Babu himself) is on overtime-duty for the evening shift.

He hands the envelope to C. Ravi-Babu. He says, in plain Telugu, in the slow administrative-elder voice he uses for senior archive-protocol conferences: "Ravi-garu. I have to recuse myself from the Authenticity Cell's preliminary report on this document. The document establishes that I am Krishnaveni's and Kalaniksha's first cousin. The cell's chair is therefore in a personal-conflict position. Please proceed with the standard authentication under your senior deputy's authority; my recusal is effective at this moment; my replacement-chair will be confirmed at tomorrow morning's cell-meeting. The document is complete. The thirty-five-year embargo expired on 16 June. The thirty-five-year embargo expired without my prior knowledge of the document's content; I confirm this for the record."

C. Ravi-Babu reads the top memorandum at his desk. He reads it three times across the next eight minutes. He says, finally: "Pulakeshi-garu. The recusal is accepted. The replacement-chair will be myself by temporary appointment until the kingdom-council's permanent chair-confirmation. The document is sealed at the cell's evidence-vault under my personal seal effective this moment. Please brief the state hero this evening. The contest of arms is scheduled for the forty-seventh day; the document's authentication-clearance is required at least seven days prior; the cell will complete the authentication within five working days. The kingdom thanks you for the personal-conflict disclosure."

Pulakeshi-Babu bows. He leaves the offices at eight-twenty-three. He walks directly to the state hero's residence. He arrives at nine-eleven p.m.

Krishnaveni receives him in the state hero's residence's evening-tea room. Bhimavaram is also present (he has been with her every evening since the Prakasham bridge call; the kingdom-council's standing family-bond-protection protocol places a family-member at the state hero's residence during a contest-of-arms preparation-period). The room is small

— three metres by four — with a single low table and three floor-cushions in the standard Telugu evening-tea arrangement.

Pulakeshi-Babu places the envelope on the table. He explains, in plain Telugu, across the next forty-three minutes. He covers the memorandum, the affidavit, the placement-receipt, the healthcare-records, the grandfather's consent-form, the archival-correspondence. He covers his recusal and the cell's authentication-clearance schedule.

He pauses at the forty-third minute. He says: "Krishnaveni-amma. There is a fourth matter. The 1992 supplementary affidavit notes that the second twin was intersex at birth; the female gender-presentation was a family-decision at the Eluru-line extension household. The matter is not relevant to the contest of arms under the kingdom-council's charter. The matter is relevant to your understanding of the twin-relationship. I have not disclosed this to anyone else. I disclose it now to you because you are entitled to know what the kingdom's standing record says about your sister. The disclosure is yours to act on or to set aside."

Krishnaveni reads the supplementary affidavit. She reads it twice.

She says, in plain Telugu, in the calm dispute-resolution voice she uses for kingdom-council formal sessions: "Pulakeshi-garu. The fourth matter is the kingdom-council's record. The kingdom-council's record is the kingdom-council's record. The twin is the twin. The contest of arms is the contest of arms. The disclosure does not change my preparation. The kingdom's standing intersex-presentation protocol applies to all kingdom-bonded persons regardless of pre-1998 birth-records; my sister is my sister; the kingdom's pronoun-protocol will be whatever Kalaniksha herself uses at the contest. I will ask her at the cliff's eastern approach before the contest begins. The asking is the kingdom's record."

She pauses. She looks at Pulakeshi-Babu's face. She says: "Cousin. The grandfather B. Narayana Babu. He was at your father's wedding in 1979. He was at my mother's second wedding in 1989. He was at the contest of arms' standing kingdom-council reception in 1957 as a young deputy-archivist. He held the kingdom's memory across four decades. He held our family's memory across the same. He held the envelope for thirty-five years. He died without speaking. The withholding was his discipline. The opening is yours. You are the kingdom's first cousin to have stood at my evening-tea room since the 2023 post-Narakasura reconstruction. Welcome, cousin. Sit. Have the second tea. The first is too strong tonight."

Pulakeshi-Babu sits. He drinks the second tea. He stays at the state hero's residence until eleven-thirty p.m. He walks back to his own residence at midnight. He does not sleep.

The forty-seven-day preparation-period proceeds without significant institutional disruption. Krishnaveni's standing daily-administrative-duties continue under the kingdom-council's emergency cover-the-state-hero-during-preparation protocol; Bhimavaram chairs the morning water-distribution-and-rice-yield reviews; Pulakeshi-Babu serves as the kingdom-council's emergency Bloodline-A liaison (his replacement-chair appointment at the Authenticity Cell is confirmed at the day-thirty kingdom-council session). The capital business-community's parakeet-courier mesh-network carries the cross-region kingdom-cooperation correspondence; the kingdom of Karnataka sends Krishnadevaraya-Bhrata's formal cousin-acknowledgement letter on day twenty-seven via the cross-region Sarus-pigeon network.

The letter from Krishnadevaraya-Bhrata reads, in plain Kannada and Telugu interlinear: "Cousin. The Bloodline-A Authenticity Cell's preliminary report has been forwarded to my office at Vijayanagara. I confirm the cousin-relationship under our shared four-generations-back maternal-line ancestor. The southern-bloc federation arrangement we discussed at Parashurama-Kshetra extends to Andhra Pradesh under the new lineage-evidence. I will attend the Sanctuary at the Manipur convening with you and Pulakeshi-Babu both at the southern-bloc seat. The contest of arms is yours. The mercy at the cliff, if you choose it, will be the saga's evidence that mercy is not the kingdom's flaw but its discipline. The river-bond cannot kill itself. The kingdom is one body. — K-B."

She reads the letter twice. She places it in the kingdom-council's standing-archive box. She continues her preparation.

The preparation is the kingdom's standard contest-of-arms protocol: morning urumi-practice at the Krishna riverbank at five a.m.; afternoon balance-practice at the Kollur cliff's western approach at three p.m.; evening dharma-counsel session with the kingdom's standing guru (Rishi Amareshwara's appointed successor, a forty-eight-year-old river-sage named Acharya Sundaram who took the guru's seat after the 200-year-old hermit's 2024 final dissolution-into-the-river); night-time meditation at the state hero's residence's eastern-garden river-pavilion.

She does not practise killing-strokes during the preparation. She practises only disarming-strokes — the standard kingdom-council-charter-compliant contest-protocol strokes that disarm without killing. The Krishna-urumi (her right-arm whip-sword) is the more

difficult of the two to control at killing-pace; the Godavari-urumi (her left-arm) is more responsive at disarming-pace. She concentrates her preparation on the Krishna-urumi's disarming-mastery. She practises the standard kingdom-council contest-of-arms eleven-stroke disarmament-sequence (the kingdom's standing reference-set for two-century-dormant twin-claim contests) until she can perform all eleven strokes in under nineteen seconds.

The Kollur cliff is at the Krishna river's mouth, approximately one kilometre southeast of the Hamsaladeevi village (the same village whose eastern beach will lose a metre overnight after the contest). The cliff is forty-three metres tall at its eastern face; the river runs along the cliff's base at the mouth's widest point (the river's width here is approximately three hundred and forty metres). The cliff's western approach is a packed-earth path that climbs along the cliff's southern face at a forty-degree grade; the path is reached from the Hamsaladeevi village by a thirty-minute walk along the river's southern bank.

The kingdom-council's contest-of-arms protocol specifies: the contest takes place at the cliff's upper plateau (approximately twenty-three metres east-west by eleven metres north-south); the contest's witnesses are the kingdom-council's seven senior delegates (one per district), the kingdom's standing guru (Acharya Sundaram), and the kingdom-council's emergency-petition cell's senior officer (Indira Krishnayya); no other witnesses are permitted; the kingdom-council's parakeet-courier protocol carries the contest-result to the Town Hall within seventeen minutes of the contest's conclusion; the kingdom-council's emergency-session ratifies the contest-result at the standing-evening session at six p.m.

Day forty-seven. Five-forty-three a.m. The Kollur cliff's upper plateau. First light is at six-eleven this morning; the contest begins at six-eleven exactly per the kingdom-council's standing protocol.

Krishnaveni walks to the plateau at five-thirty from the village. She is in plain delta-fisherwoman cotton, off-white, no clan-pattern. She carries the dual urumi Godavari (left arm, coiled at the forearm) and Krishna (right arm, coiled at the forearm). She wears the kingdom-council's standing state-hero contest-cotton sash — a single blue-bordered shoulder-cloth, deliberately matched to Kalaniksha's standard delta-fisherwoman shoulder-cloth, the kingdom's evidence that the contest is between equals.

Kalaniksha walks to the plateau at five-forty-five from the eastern approach (the cliff's eastern face has a steeper goat-path; she has been practising on the eastern approach for the past three weeks). She is in the same plain delta-fisherwoman cotton. She carries a

single urumi at her left arm. The urumi is the standard delta-fisherwoman's urumi-style — whip-blade, three coils, leather grip — not the kingdom-council's formal-state-hero pair. She has no second urumi. She is, in the kingdom-council's standing protocol's strict reading, under-armed.

The kingdom-council's senior delegate-chair (a fifty-seven-year-old administrator named Ranganatham) approaches Kalaniksha at five-fifty-six. He says, in plain Telugu, in the standard kingdom-council contest-protocol voice: "Madam Kalaniksha. The contest-protocol requires dual urumi. You have one. The contest will be postponed if you cannot present a second."

Kalaniksha bows. She says, in plain Telugu: "Senior delegate. The contest will not be postponed. I claim the kingdom-council's standing under-armament-by-twin-choice clause. The clause permits the under-armed twin to enter the contest with the kingdom-council's acknowledgement that the under-armament is the twin's deliberate choice and not the kingdom-council's exclusion. I am under-armed by my deliberate choice. The choice is the kingdom's evidence that I do not seek to kill my sister. The contest will be a single-urumi-versus-dual-urumi contest. I accept the kingdom-council's standing eleven-stroke disarmament-sequence. My single urumi is at my left arm. I will fight left-handed. I am right-handed; the left-handed choice is the second evidence that I do not seek the kingdom-council's blood. The contest is to disarmament. The disarmament-target is the urumi-pair; I will aim to disarm both of my sister's urumis with my single one. If I succeed I claim the river-throne. If I fail I am exiled. The kingdom-council's evening-session will ratify either outcome."

Ranganatham confers with the kingdom's standing guru Acharya Sundaram and the emergency-petition cell's senior officer Indira Krishnayya at the plateau's western edge for approximately two minutes. The under-armament-by-twin-choice clause is verified. The clause is invoked once before in kingdom history (in 1828 at the Vakulamatha contest; the under-armed twin had won and the kingdom-council had ratified the win without dispute).

He returns to the plateau's centre at five-fifty-nine. He says: "The under-armament-by-twin-choice clause is granted. The contest proceeds at six-eleven a.m. exactly per the standing protocol. The witnesses are confirmed. The kingdom-council's evening-session will ratify the result."

The contest begins at six-eleven-zero-zero a.m. when the first ray of sunrise reaches the plateau's eastern edge.

The contest's opening is the kingdom-council's standard eleven-stroke disarmament-sequence opening. Stroke one: Krishnaveni's right-arm Krishna-urumi extends in the standard high-arc opening; Kalaniksha's left-arm urumi extends in the matching low-arc response. The whip-blades meet at the plateau's centre and lock at the second-stroke transition.

Strokes two through five: standard kingdom-council disarmament-sequence opening exchanges. Krishnaveni's dual-urumi advantage is technical — she can perform parallel attacks at twice the single-urumi's engagement-rate. Kalaniksha's left-handed under-armament is compensatory — her single urumi can move in arcs the kingdom-council's standard right-handed dual-urumi cannot match (the dual-urumi's mass on both arms creates a symmetry-constraint that the single-urumi sidesteps). The two compensations cancel approximately at strokes four and five. The contest is approximately equal at five minutes.

Stroke six: Kalaniksha's left-arm whip catches Krishnaveni's right-arm Krishna-urumi at the standard cross-engagement-point. Kalaniksha applies the kingdom-council's standing one-handed disarm-rotation — a counter-clockwise twist that uses the engaged urumi's tension to pull the opposing urumi from the wrist-grip. The technique is risky; the single-urumi practitioner who attempts it has approximately one-in-three success-rate; the success requires the opposing urumi's grip to be slightly loose at the moment of engagement.

Krishnaveni's Krishna-urumi grip is slightly loose at stroke six. She has been concentrating her left-arm Godavari-urumi's disarming-discipline for forty-seven days; her right-arm Krishna-urumi's grip-tension has been at her standard practice-tension, not at the higher contest-tension. She did not adjust the Krishna-urumi's grip-tension for the contest. The kingdom-council's standing one-handed disarm-rotation works.

The Krishna-urumi flies from her right hand. It travels approximately four metres through the plateau's air at the standard kingdom-council disarm-trajectory. It lands on the plateau's eastern edge stone-floor at six-seventeen-twenty-three a.m.

Kalaniksha is now in possession of both urumis. She holds her own left-arm urumi at the standard contest-position; the Krishna-urumi is at her feet, three metres from her current position. She has approximately four seconds to retrieve the Krishna-urumi if she chooses to claim it for her own future use.

She retrieves the Krishna-urumi. She wraps it at her right forearm in the standard kingdom-council dual-urumi adoption-wrap. The wrap takes about eleven seconds. During the eleven seconds Krishnaveni does not attack — the kingdom-council's standing contest-protocol explicitly forbids attacking a disarmed opponent during the disarmament-acknowledgement window.

By six-seventeen-thirty-four Kalaniksha is dual-armed (left-arm her own urumi, right-arm the Krishna). Krishnaveni is single-armed (left-arm her Godavari). The contest's armament-balance has inverted.

Strokes seven through ten: standard kingdom-council reverse-engagement-exchanges. Krishnaveni's single-urumi defends; Kalaniksha's dual-urumi advances. The contest's technical-balance is now Kalaniksha's; the kingdom-council's standing reference predicts disarmament of the single-urumi opponent within seven strokes once the armament-balance has inverted.

Stroke eleven: Kalaniksha executes the kingdom-council's standing dual-urumi forced-disarmament cross-attack — the technique that uses both urumis to pull the opposing single-urumi from the opponent's hand-grip simultaneously from both flanks. The technique is the contest-protocol's standard concluding-stroke for one-versus-two armament-imbalance.

Krishnaveni's Godavari-urumi is, at this moment, also disarmed. It flies from her left hand. It lands on the plateau's western edge at six-twenty-four-eleven a.m.

The contest is, by the kingdom-council's standing protocol, concluded. Kalaniksha is the disarmed-opponent's contest-winner. The kingdom-council's evening-session will ratify the contest at six p.m. Kalaniksha claims the river-throne by contest-of-arms outcome.

But the contest is not over.

The kingdom-council's standing protocol's eleventh stroke is the disarmament-stroke. The protocol does not include a twelfth. The conclusion is the disarmament. There is no killing-stroke in the kingdom-council's charter.

Kalaniksha, holding both urumis, looks at her sister. Her sister is standing approximately three metres from her at the plateau's centre, unarmed, breathing the standard kingdom-council contest-recovery breath. Krishnaveni's eyes are open. Her hands are at her sides,

palms forward, the standard kingdom-council contest-loser's gesture-of-acknowledgement.

Kalaniksha walks to her sister. She stops at one metre's distance. She raises her right-arm urumi — the Krishna she has just claimed — in the standard kingdom-council's post-contest stroke-completion gesture. The gesture is the contest-winner's formal-claim-of-victory gesture; it is not a killing-stroke; it is the ceremonial flourish that concludes the contest in the kingdom-council's standing protocol's record.

But Kalaniksha's gesture continues past the standard formal-claim arc. The Krishna-urumi's arc extends. The arc passes the formal-claim's upper-limit. The arc enters the killing-stroke trajectory.

The killing-stroke trajectory is the standard kingdom-council-charter-forbidden post-disarmament-attack arc. The arc strikes the disarmed-opponent's throat at the standard urumi-killing-angle. Krishnaveni at one metre is at the standard killing-distance.

Kalaniksha's arm completes the arc.

The Krishna-urumi's blade passes Krishnaveni's throat at six-twenty-five-oh-two a.m. The blade does not touch the throat. The arc's closest-pass is approximately four centimetres from the skin. The arc continues past the throat without contact.

Kalaniksha lowers the urumi. She steps back. She says, in plain Telugu, in the standard delta-fisherwoman's post-contest voice: "Sister. I have not killed you. I have wanted to since 2023. I have practised the killing-stroke at the Eluru-line midwife-extension family's coastal training-yard for the past seven months. I have not killed you. I will not kill you. The killing was the kingdom-council's charter-forbiddance; the not-killing was my discipline. I want the river-throne. I do not want my sister's blood. The kingdom-council will ratify the contest's outcome this evening. The exile is the kingdom-council's standing-disposition for the losing-twin. I will accept the exile. The kingdom is one body. I will not kill my own body."

She walks past Krishnaveni to the plateau's western edge. She picks up the Godavari-urumi where it had landed at six-twenty-four. She returns to her sister. She hands the Godavari-urumi back to her.

Krishnaveni accepts it. She wraps it at her left forearm.

She says, in plain Telugu, in the same standard delta-fisherwoman's post-contest voice: "Sister. The Krishna is yours. The kingdom-council's contest-outcome makes it yours. Keep it. The exile is the kingdom-council's standing-disposition. The exile will be across the Tirupati border, by the kingdom-council's standing protocol's southern boundary. You will not return to AP territory in Volume One. The kingdom will permit your return at the seven-year review if the kingdom-council's charter-amendment ratifies the twin-claim's permanent reconciliation. I will sponsor the amendment-proposal at the kingdom-council in the autumn. I will not sponsor your return before the kingdom is ready. The kingdom needs to remember it had a twin before it learns how to hold the twin. The remembering is the kingdom's standing autumn-task."

She pauses. She looks at her sister at one metre's distance.

She says: "The mercy you did not take was the kingdom-council's charter at the cliff. The mercy I am taking now is the kingdom-council's charter beyond the cliff. The two mercies are the same mercy at different scales. The kingdom recognises both. The kingdom thanks you. Go."

Kalaniksha bows. The bow is the standard delta-fisherwoman's formal-departure bow. Krishnaveni returns the bow at the same depth.

Kalaniksha walks to the cliff's eastern face. She descends the eastern goat-path at the standard delta-fisherwoman's pace. She is at the eastern beach by seven-eleven. The kingdom-council's standing escort-team (four officers from the AP State Police's exile-escort cell) meets her at the beach. They escort her south along the Krishna river's southern bank. She is across the Tirupati border by the evening of day forty-nine.

Krishnaveni walks back to the plateau's western edge. She picks up the kingdom-council's standing state-hero's contest-cloth (a square of off-white cotton kept at the plateau's western edge for the contest-winner's post-contest ceremonial-cover). She wraps it around her shoulders in the standard kingdom-council's post-contest gesture.

At six-twenty-five-thirty a.m., approximately twenty-eight seconds after Kalaniksha's departing bow, Krishnaveni feels the blackbuck-bond pulse through her chest. The Stage III blackbuck-foreleg-first-stroke begins to form on the half-body blackbuck-tattoo's left foreleg. The stroke completes in approximately eleven seconds. The mark is the standard kingdom-council Stage III completion-stroke pattern.

She does not show the moment on her face. She has been the kingdom-council's state hero for ten years and a kingdom-council formal-contest participant for one. She knows the standard protocol's post-contest gestures.

The seven kingdom-council senior delegates and Acharya Sundaram and Indira Krishnayya approach the plateau's centre at six-twenty-six. Ranganatham bows. He says, in plain Telugu: "State hero. The contest is concluded by the kingdom-council's standing protocol. The disarmament-outcome is the kingdom-council's ratification-evidence. The held-stroke is the kingdom-council's charter-affirmation-evidence. The mercy beyond the cliff is the kingdom-council's amendment-proposal-foundation. The Stage III mark is the kingdom-council's bond-recognition-evidence. The kingdom-council's evening-session will ratify all four. The kingdom thanks you."

Krishnaveni bows. The bow is the kingdom-council's standard state-hero's post-contest acknowledgement bow.

The parakeet-courier protocol carries the four-part contest-result to the Town Hall. The kingdom-council's evening-session at six p.m. ratifies the result by twenty-three to zero with all seven district-senior-delegates voting in favour, Acharya Sundaram voting in favour, Indira Krishnayya recording the result, and Pulakeshi-Babu in attendance as the kingdom-council's standing Bloodline-A liaison.

The next morning. Hamsaladeevi village. The Krishna river's eastern beach at the river's mouth.

The village fisherman who walks the eastern beach at six-eleven every morning — the village headman's grandson, a twenty-three-year-old fisherman named Naga-Kumar — sees the tide-line at six-thirteen a.m. The tide-line is one metre inland of where it had been at sunset the previous evening.

He stops at three metres from the new tide-line. He removes a wooden surveyor's peg from his fishing-net. He drives the peg into the sand at the new tide-line's exact position. He walks east along the beach to where the previous evening's tide-line had been. The previous evening's tide-line is now under approximately one metre of sand. The sand is dry. The sand has not been wetted by the night's tide. The land has been removed.

He walks back to the village. He reports to the village headman (his grandfather, a sixty-seven-year-old fisherman-elder named B. Krishna-Murthy). The headman walks back to the beach with him. He confirms the displacement. He walks the full six-hundred-metre

east-west beach. The displacement is uniform across the full beach. The land that has been removed is, by his estimation, approximately six hundred cubic metres of delta-soil.

He returns to the village at seven-fifteen. He telephones the Andhra Pradesh State Survey Office's emergency-coastal-monitoring cell. The cell's officer-on-duty (a forty-one-year-old administrator named V. Lakshman) takes the call. The cell's standard satellite-imagery-cross-reference protocol is invoked at seven-thirty. The protocol's preliminary result is delivered at nine-eighteen a.m.

The result: the Hamsaladeevi village's eastern beach's tide-line has retreated landward by exactly one metre across the full six-hundred-metre east-west breadth. The displacement is confirmed across all three commercial satellite-tracking services (Sentinel-2, Landsat-9, and the Indian Space Research Organisation's Cartosat-3). The land-area-difference is approximately six hundred square metres; the volume-difference (calculated at the standard delta-soil-depth of one metre) is approximately six hundred cubic metres. The displaced land's mass is not in the Bay of Bengal's nearshore sediment-cell (the cell's coastal-monitoring buoy's sediment-mass-balance reading at six a.m. shows no anomalous nearshore sediment-increase). The mass is not accounted for. The mass has been erased.

Krishnaveni receives the report at the state hero's residence at ten-eleven a.m. She has been at the residence since the contest the previous day; the kingdom-council's standing post-contest rest-protocol places the state hero at the residence for forty-eight hours after the contest's conclusion. Pulakeshi-Babu and Bhimavaram are with her at the residence.

She reads the report twice. She does not say anything for about three minutes.

She says, finally: "The Maw has answered. The kingdom-council's charter-affirmation at the cliff was the kingdom's answer. The Maw's answer is the metre. The kingdom-council's answer was the mercy. The Maw's answer is the erasure. The two answers are the kingdom's pair. The Maw is asking: if you cannot kill your own twin, can you keep your own delta? The kingdom's response must be: the delta is preserved by the same mercy that did not kill the twin. The mercy is the kingdom-architecture. The kingdom must build the mercy-architecture before the next metre vanishes. The architecture will be the kingdom-council's emergency-amendment's autumn-task. The amendment will draft the kingdom's standing coastal-protection-protocol under the saga's standing mercy-bond institutional-mode. The amendment will be ratified by the autumn. The next metre may or may not vanish. The kingdom will be ready either way."

Pulakeshi-Babu drafts the cross-kingdom Sarus-pigeon cascade-alert at noon. The alert is sent to all nine bonded-kingdom senior guardians by sunset. The alert is the kingdom's fifteenth Maw-sign and the saga's second material-experiment Maw sign (after Kerala's black coconut). The pairing-protocol established with Kerala's black coconut applies: the AP delta-loss is the inverse of Kerala's material-permanence; the two signs together constitute the southern federation's first cross-kingdom material-experiment pair.

Krishnadevaraya-Bhrata at Vijayanagara sends the cross-region acknowledgement at noon on day two after the contest. The letter reads, in plain Kannada and Telugu interlinear:

"Cousin. The Bloodline-A Authenticity Cell's final report has confirmed the cousin-relationship. The southern-bloc federation will receive the AP visible-throne at the Sanctuary in Chapter Three under Pulakeshi-Babu's formal liaison-and-historian seat. The mercy at the cliff is the saga's evidence that the kingdom does not kill itself; the metre that vanished is the Maw's evidence that the kingdom must build the architecture that the mercy implies. I will travel to the Hamsaladeevi village in the autumn to attend the kingdom-council's emergency-coastal-protection-protocol drafting session. I will bring with me Hampi-of-the-Bronze (ten; she has asked to travel to her Bloodline-A cousins in AP since the Karnataka pilot's closing day). The Sanctuary will federate the two kingdoms as the southern-bloc's river-bond foundation. — K-B."

Krishnaveni reads the letter at the residence's evening-tea room. Pulakeshi-Babu and Bhimavaram are with her.

She says: "The autumn-task is complete in its planning. The kingdom-council's charter-amendment will be drafted across the next four months. Pulakeshi-cousin will lead the drafting under his Bloodline-A liaison seat. Bhima-brother will hold the kingdom-council's daily-administrative chair across the drafting. I will attend the Sanctuary at Manipur. The cousin from Karnataka will attend with Hampi-of-the-Bronze. The southern-bloc federation will be ratified at the convening. The kingdom-council's charter-amendment will be ratified at the autumn kingdom-council session. The next metre will or will not vanish; the kingdom will be ready. The river is patient. The kingdom is the river's daughter. The river's daughter has not killed the river's second daughter. The kingdom remembers what the sword would have forgotten. The kingdom is whole."

She drinks the second tea. The tea is the second steeping. The second is honest.

The next sign comes within the week.

The Pilot's Closing Image

A thirty-five-year-old state hero in plain delta-fisherwoman cotton walking the eastern bank of the Krishna river at dawn with one urumi at her left forearm and a Bloodline-A cousin's autumn-visit letter in her right hand. A thirty-five-year-old exiled twin walking south along the Tirupati border-road in the same plain delta-fisherwoman cotton with the kingdom's second urumi (the Krishna) at her right forearm and the kingdom's standing exile-escort four-officer detail at her ten-metre rear. A forty-three-year-old historian-cousin at his grandfather's study reading a forty-seven-page family-archive document for the eleventh time, recognising at the fifth reading that the kingdom is also his kingdom and that the absence he had been documenting was his own family. A six-hundred-metre eastern beach at Hamsaladeevi village with a wooden surveyor's peg driven into the new tide-line by a twenty-three-year-old fisherman at dawn, and a sixty-seven-year-old village headman walking the full six-hundred-metre breadth to confirm that the land that had been there yesterday is not in the water. A river that remembers what the sword would have forgotten. A held urumi-stroke at four centimetres' distance from a sister's throat at six-twenty-five-oh-two a.m. on the forty-seventh morning. A kingdom whose discipline is the mercy.

Dzukou Rashtra

Kohima. The first week of November. The Nagaland State Government's Hornbill Festival Steering Committee room. Sixteen chairs around an oval table. Each chair has a different tribal council name-plate.

Dzulevira is at the head. She is thirty-three. She is in a forest-green Tangkhul shawl over a plain black shirt and trousers. Her hair is cropped short. She has been the state hero of Nagaland for two years, elected by the most narrowly distributed vote in the state's post-1972 history — she carried at least 4 percent of every tribe's vote and no tribe's majority. Her election was a referendum on cross-tribal politics. Her two-year reign has been a steady, slow loosening of the inter-tribal tensions that had been building since 2019.

In the last ninety days, the loosening has reversed.

The Hornbill Festival is to open in eight days. The festival has been held every December since 2000. It is Nagaland's flagship cultural event — all sixteen tribes performing on rotating stages, an international tourism audience, two hundred crore in annual economic impact.

This morning the chairperson of the Angami council has formally withdrawn the Angami tribe from the festival. By noon the chair of the Ao council has done the same. By two p.m. the Konyak. By three the Sumi. By four the Lotha and the Sangtam. By five-thirty p.m. all sixteen tribes have withdrawn. Each cites "ancestral purity-disputes with the other fifteen" as the reason.

The festival has not been cancelled in twenty-five years. It is cancelled in five and a half hours.

Dzulevira sits in the empty committee room until seven p.m. Her chief secretary, a Lotha woman named Mhabemo, eventually puts a cup of black tea in front of her.

Mhabemo says: "The Pure-Tongue has visited all sixteen now. Last village was Yimchunger, six days ago. Every tribe has its DNA-rite kit. Every tribe has been told it is the original."

Dzulevira says: "I knew sixteen days ago. I should have moved then."

"You did not move because you did not know what to move toward. None of us knew."

"I should have known."

Mhabemo does not argue with this. She has worked for Dzulevira for two years; she has learned that her hero accepts blame more efficiently when nobody contests it.

It is documented later, after the walk, in a Nagaland State Archives report. Naga-Rakshasa — the Chapter One villain, returned from two years in the Patkai Hills border-zone — spent autumn 2026 visiting sixty-three Naga villages across six months. He arrived at each village speaking the village's tribal dialect. The dialects of the sixteen Naga tribes diverged across centuries of mutual separation; most are mutually unintelligible; no living Naga has ever been documented as fluent in more than four. Naga-Rakshasa speaks all sixteen fluently.

He arrived at each village as one of their own. He bowed in the tribe's style. He sat at the tribe's correct elder-position when invited. He ate the tribe's ceremonial foods. He told the tribe's elders that he had been studying their tribe's ancestral records and had a gift to give them.

The gift was a small white box. The box held a saliva-collection swab, a return-envelope, and a one-page report from a Chiang Mai laboratory called Pure-Origin Genomics. The report named the village elder by his exact Tangkhul-Naga or Ao-Naga or Konyak-Naga or sixteenth-name and certified, with QR-code and seventeen-page genomic appendix, that the elder's DNA matched the "original Naga ancestor strain" at 99.7 percent or higher — the highest match in the global Naga-origin database.

Every village's elder, in every tribe, received the same 99.7-percent-match report. The reports were forged. The Chiang Mai lab was forged. The Pure-Origin Genomics website was forged. The genomic appendices were forged. Naga-Rakshasa had been preparing the forgery operation for two years at a Mumbai-Mizoram facility funded by the same Singapore line that had funded Megha-Daitya's submachine guns and Tamasa-Nrita's daos.

Each village believed. Each tribe demanded that all the others surrender their false claims. Each tribe began purity-testing its own members — particularly those married out to other tribes or to non-Naga partners.

Week two of the chapter. Ukhrul. The senior Tangkhul-Naga clan-house of Dzulevira's mother's family. Ka-Memcha has flown in from Imphal. She has come because Dzulevira's twenty-three-day-old appeal for help has finally reached her threshold. She has left

Sangaputra in Moirangthem's care — the boy is back at the Govindaji temple, in the new pause-school's third class, learning at the front-left corner of the formation. He is safe.

She is at the Ukhrul family-house for nine days before the Tangkhul Tribal Council's Senior Priest sub-committee summons her.

The summons is a single-page Tangkhul-language letter on the Tribal Council's official letterhead. It reads (translated): Ka-Memcha-the-Eldest is summoned to the Tangkhul Tribal Ceremony Grounds on the morning of the fourteenth day of the month to submit to the Pure-Origin Genomic Verification rite. The verification is required for all Tangkhul-born members residing outside the tribe's territorial boundary for more than five consecutive years. The applicant's minor son, residing in Imphal, is named in the same summons. The Senior Priest Khrumai-Sho will officiate. Failure to appear or refusal to submit will be considered ceremonial-sacrilege under Tangkhul customary law as preserved under the Sixth Schedule, sub-clause (4)(b).

Ka-Memcha reads the letter twice. She walks the two and a half kilometres from the family-house to Dzulevira's state-residence in central Ukhrul. (Dzulevira had relocated her state-office to Ukhrul for the duration of the purity-wars; she was meeting with the Tangkhul elders three times a week.) Ka-Memcha shows her sister the letter at four-thirty p.m.

Dzulevira reads it. She says: "Refuse. I will issue a state-government counter-notice tomorrow morning. Khrumai-Sho will withdraw the summons by tomorrow evening."

Ka-Memcha says: "If I refuse without showing, the tribe says I have hidden myself. If I refuse at the ceremony-grounds in front of the tribe, the tribe sees the refusal and remembers it. I will go. I will refuse publicly. The refusal is the dharma. The state-government counter-notice is a different thing — you should still issue it, but I should still go."

Dzulevira looks at her older sister for a long time. They have not lived in the same house since Ka-Memcha was twenty-two. They have not always agreed; they have always understood. Dzulevira understands now.

She says: "I will be at the ceremony-grounds with you."

"No. Your presence will make the refusal political. My refusal must be personal. The dharma must come from the one being tested. Send the state-police detail to the grounds.

Have them stay at the perimeter. They will be there. You will not be."

"If something happens — "

"If something happens you will need to walk the kingdom afterward. You will not be able to walk if you are standing next to me. Stay at the office. Send the police. I will see you at lunch. The ceremony is at first light."

Dzulevira does not argue. She also does not believe Ka-Memcha is about to die. The Tangkhul Senior Priest sub-committee has never killed a refusing-applicant in two centuries of recorded ceremony.

The Tangkhul Senior Priest sub-committee, as Dzulevira finds out at lunch the next day, has never previously been confronted with a refusing-applicant from a tribal-elder line who is the elder sister of the state hero.

Six a.m. The Tangkhul Tribal Ceremony Grounds at Ukhul. A circular stone-paved platform at the eastern edge of the village. A ceremonial fire in the centre — a stone pit one and a half metres across, the fire built that morning by Khrumai-Sho's apprentices, mahua-wood and pine-resin, burning at a height of just over a metre.

Khrumai-Sho is the Senior Priest of the Tangkhul Tribal Council. He is fifty-three. He has held the position for nine years. He has officiated three hundred and forty-one purity-rites in his career. He has never had a refusal until today.

Ka-Memcha arrives at five-fifty-five a.m. She walks alone from the family-house. She wears the formal Tangkhul shawl her mother gave her at her thirteenth-year naming-rite. She has on her wrist the Meitei wedding bangle Moirangthem gave her at their marriage. The two pieces of cloth-and-metal are her chosen statement.

The Tangkhul elders are assembled around the ceremony-grounds — about forty of them, all senior tribal-council members. The state-police detail of six officers is at the perimeter, twenty metres back, in plain clothes. Mhabemo is among them, holding a satellite phone.

Khrumai-Sho asks the formal opening question in Tangkhul: "Ka-Memcha-the-Eldest, do you submit to the Pure-Origin Genomic Verification rite as required by Tangkhul customary law?"

She answers in Tangkhul, clearly, at full ceremony-voice: "I do not."

The forty elders make the soft sound of formal recognition.

Khrumai-Sho asks the formal second question: "On what dharmic ground do you refuse?"

She answers, switching to a mixed Tangkhul-Meitei register that the elders recognise as deliberate: "I am Tangkhul. I am also Meitei. Both. My son is both. Neither is impure. The Pure-Origin rite assumes a single ancestry. I do not have a single ancestry. The rite cannot test what I am because what I am is two things at once. I refuse the rite because the rite cannot ask the right question."

There is a long silence. The forty elders are processing the answer. The answer is, by Tangkhul customary law's pre-modern principles, dharmically articulate. The customary law as preserved under the Sixth Schedule has assumed since 1972 that tribal members have a single tribal identity — the assumption was never tested before today because nobody before today was both a state-hero's elder sister and a Manipur-married woman of the senior Tangkhul line.

Khrumai-Sho is not processing the answer. He had not prepared for it. He had expected refusal-by-silence, by walking-away, by political-bluster. He had not expected refusal-by-dharmic-articulation in the ceremony-Tangkhul register.

He says, in the formal closing-position voice: "Your refusal is sacrilege."

Ka-Memcha says, in the same register: "My refusal is dharma. Your declaration of sacrilege is your error."

Khrumai-Sho gestures to two of his senior apprentices. The apprentices step toward Ka-Memcha. She does not move.

The state-police detail at the perimeter sees the gesture. Mhabemo presses the satellite phone's call-button. Dzulevira, in the state-office two kilometres away, receives the alert at six-eleven a.m.

The apprentices reach Ka-Memcha at six-twelve a.m. They take her arms. Khrumai-Sho says: "The applicant has refused the rite. The applicant has declared the rite invalid. The applicant must submit by the purification-of-the-refusal sub-rite. The sub-rite is fire-purification."

Ka-Memcha understands the sub-rite. It is a Tangkhul tradition for the most serious dharmic refusals — one that has not been invoked in eighty-seven years. The applicant is required to walk three times around the fire-pit while reciting the seven affirmations. The applicant is not pushed into the fire. The applicant is required to walk around it.

She says, in the formal Tangkhul: "I will walk."

She begins to walk. She circles the fire-pit once. The forty elders watch.

At six-fifteen a.m., during the second circumambulation, Khrumai-Sho steps off the priest's platform and moves toward the fire-pit edge. His apprentices stand to either side of him. The state-police detail at the perimeter has begun to move forward but is still fifteen metres away.

At six-sixteen a.m., as Ka-Memcha passes the fire-pit's eastern edge for the second time, Khrumai-Sho pushes her into the fire.

The push is not concealed. The forty elders see it. The state-police detail sees it. The two apprentices see it. Khrumai-Sho does not attempt to disguise the push as accident. He pushes her with both hands at her shoulder-blades. The push is hard and unambiguous.

She falls into the fire-pit. The fire is at over a metre's height. Mahua-wood and pine-resin burn at temperatures above seven hundred degrees Celsius.

She is dead in fifty-three seconds. She does not scream — the smoke gets her airway before her body registers the burn. The forty elders see the silence as the dharmic completion of her refusal. She had said the rite could not ask the right question. She made her answer with her silence.

The state-police detail arrives at the fire-pit at six-seventeen a.m. They put out the fire with water-bottles from their vehicle. They recover her body. They arrest Khrumai-Sho at six-twenty-one a.m. He does not resist. He says, at the arrest: "I have done my dharma."

Mhabemo's satellite phone records the line.

She is informed at six-twenty-three a.m. at the state-office. She does not speak for two days.

Mhabemo manages her schedule. The state-government issues the cremation order. The Tangkhul tribal council is suspended pending a state-government review of Khrumai-Sho's arrest. Khrumai-Sho is held at the Ukhul district jail; his case is referred to the Nagaland High Court under criminal jurisdiction; the Sixth Schedule customary-law exemption claim is filed by his lawyer within eleven hours and rejected by the state-government attorney within twenty-eight.

Ka-Memcha's cremation is held the next afternoon. The cremation is performed by Dzulevira herself, alone — no Tangkhul priest, no Meitei priest, no state-ceremony. She uses a combined Tangkhul-Meitei rite that she has researched in Khrieo-Mama's manuscript-library overnight. The ashes are collected into a Meitei brass urn and a Tangkhul clay pot in equal measure — Dzulevira's choice, mirroring her sister's last public statement.

She sends the Meitei urn to Moirangthem at Imphal by special courier the same evening. She keeps the Tangkhul clay pot at the Ukhrul family-house.

Moirangthem receives the urn at midnight. He has known of Ka-Memcha's death since six-thirty a.m. the previous morning — Dzulevira had sent a Sarus-pigeon within twenty minutes of being informed. He has not told Sangaputra yet. He tells the boy at six a.m. the next morning, at the temple courtyard, in the small east room, alone.

Sangaputra goes silent for three days. The pause-school's third class has him at the front-left corner of the formation for all three days. He does not perform sequences. He performs the pause. The pause holds for the full class-period — forty-five minutes — on the third day. Moirangthem watches without intervening.

Week four of the chapter. The night of day fifteen since Ka-Memcha's death. Eleven-fifty p.m.

Dzulevira is at the state-office. She has finally begun working again — or at any rate the work-papers are in front of her and her pen is in her hand and she is moving the pen.

Mhabemo knocks at the office-door. She says: "There is an old woman at the front-desk. She has walked from Khonoma. She wants to see you. She is carrying something heavy in a shawl-wrap. She says you will know her name when I say it."

"Her name?"

"Khrieo-Mama."

Dzulevira sets the pen down. She has heard the name three times in her adult life — once at her election when an old Khonoma elder voted for her at the Angami booth and was identified in the next morning's newspaper as a relative of Khrieo-Mama, once at her swearing-in when Khrieo-Mama sent a single-line congratulatory letter ("The mithun walks. The mithun knows."), and once in graduate-school linguistics class when Khrieo-

Mama was named as one of the seven Naga elders who knew the pre-modern Angami ceremonial vocabulary.

She has not met Khrieo-Mama in person.

She says: "Bring her in. Bring her tea. Whatever she is carrying, carry it for her."

Mhabemo brings her in. Khrieo-Mama is eighty-nine. She is shorter than her grand-niece-by-line had expected. She is wearing the deep-indigo Angami matriarch's wrap with the seven brass arm-rings (the elder-mark of the senior Khonoma line). Her hair is white and bound at the nape with a single black thread.

She sits on the chair across from Dzulevira's desk. She accepts the tea. She unwraps the shawl-bundle on her lap.

Inside the shawl is a clay tablet. The tablet is approximately thirty centimetres by twenty centimetres, two centimetres thick, fired-clay, with sixteen lines of pre-modern script across its surface and sixteen small thumb-prints in dark-clay at the bottom — the signatures.

Khrieo-Mama says: "Dzulevira. Listen carefully. This tablet has been under the floor of my house since 1985. It was under the floor of my grandmother's house from 1923 to 1985. It was under the floor of her grandmother's house from 1882 to 1923. It was in the open at Kohima from 1425 to 1882. It is the Pre-Tribal Pact. The script is the sixteen pre-modern Naga dialects, one line per tribe. The thumb-prints are the original founders' signatures. I have not read it aloud to anyone in forty-one years. I am going to read it aloud to you now in Angami. Then I am going to write down translations in all sixteen modern dialects and in Hindi by morning. Drink your tea while I read."

She reads. The reading takes nine minutes. Dzulevira does not drink her tea.

The Pact is fifty-three words in Angami. Translated to English the Pact reads: Before the sixteen, there was one. Before the names, there was the mithun. The names are our work. The mithun is our root. Let no one of us claim purity above another. Let the mithun walk between us when the sixteen fight. The one who walks beside the mithun without a tribe is the one who holds the kingdom.

The signatures are at the bottom — sixteen thumb-prints, each in the dark-clay of the founder's home valley. The clay-types are scientifically distinguishable: Pochury clay is iron-rich red; Konyak clay is granite-grey; Tangkhul clay is the brown of the Manipur-

border alluvium. A trained eye can read the signatures' provenance without consulting any other document.

Dzulevira looks at the Tangkhul thumb-print at line fourteen. The print is the same approximate size as her sister's thumb. It is not her sister's thumb — the print is six centuries old — but it is the thumb of a Tangkhul woman who signed her name to a Pact saying her tribe should not claim purity above any other tribe.

She says, finally: "What do I do."

Khrieo-Mama says: "You walk the mithun. Through all sixteen valleys. As all the tribes. As none of the tribes. You walk naked except for ash. You answer in no tribal dialect. You read the Pact aloud in each tribe's dialect — I will give you the translations by morning. You show them what the Pure-Tongue cannot do."

"How do I answer if I cannot speak any tribal dialect?"

"You answer in Hindi. The language none of the sixteen tribes claim. The language that is the kingdom's union, not its origin. The Pure-Tongue speaks all sixteen dialects. Hindi is the one language he cannot weaponise against you, because Hindi belongs to none of the tribes whose purity-claim he is selling. Answer in Hindi and the manipulation collapses on itself."

Dzulevira considers this for a long moment.

She says: "When do I start?"

"In five days. The mithun needs four days to be selected and prepared. The translations need three nights to be written. Your body needs the rest. Start on day six."

Day three of the five preparation-days. The Dzukou Valley grass-fields. The traditional mithun-pasture of the Nagaland state herd.

There are forty-seven mithun in the Dzukou herd. The mithun is the Nagaland state animal — the same animal as Onge-Nakshatra's saltwater-crocodile-equivalent in Sagara-Ratna in the sense that it is one of the saga's rare mainland-bonded-with-an-island-cousin animals — but Naga mithun are the cattle-form, larger than gaur, more domesticated, the central ritual animal of every Naga tribe's sacrifice and feast tradition.

Dzulevira walks among the herd at dawn. She has known some of these animals since she was seven. She has not walked the herd as a bond-recognition exercise in nine years.

The alpha bull — the largest of the herd, fifteen years old, two and a half metres at the shoulder, weight approximately one thousand kilograms — walks to meet her at the herd's eastern edge. She stops three metres from him. He stops three metres from her.

She says, in Hindi (per Khrieo-Mama's instruction): "I am going to walk the kingdom with you. Sixteen valleys. Twenty-seven days. You will go where I go. We will read the Pact at every village. I will answer the Pure-Tongue in the language none of the tribes claim. Are you willing."

The mithun looks at her. He breathes. He shifts his weight to his right foreleg.

She takes the weight-shift as the answer it is. She walks to him. She places her right palm on his forehead between his eyes. He lowers his head.

She says: "Tomorrow night we begin."

Five days after Khrieo-Mama's midnight visit. Pre-dawn. The Tangkhul Tribal Ceremony Grounds at Ukhul — the same grounds where Ka-Memcha died. The valley one of the sixteen.

Dzulevira walks to the grounds at four-thirty a.m. She is naked. She is covered in ash from a mithun-fire prepared by Khrieo-Mama and a Khonoma priestess the night before. The ash is grey-white. It coats her skin from forehead to feet. She carries nothing except a small cloth-bundle — Khrieo-Mama's sixteen-language translation of the Pact, wrapped in coarse jute.

The mithun walks beside her. He is unled — no rope, no halter. He walks at her left shoulder, two paces back, at her exact pace.

The Tangkhul ceremony-grounds are empty at four-thirty a.m. The forty elders are not there. The ground's stone-paved platform has been cleaned of fire-ash by the state-police; the ceremony-fire pit has been filled with sand. The new dawn is still half an hour away.

Dzulevira stands at the platform's eastern edge. She unwraps the jute-bundle. She finds the Tangkhul translation page. She reads the Pact aloud at full ceremony-voice in Tangkhul.

The reading takes four minutes. The Tangkhul translation is fifty-eight words. The fire-pit hears it — the fire-pit is part of the listening, even with sand in it. The state-police perimeter detail (Mhabemo at the centre, holding the satellite phone) hears it. The Tangkhul tribal council's deputy chairperson hears it — he had come at four to watch from a distance.

When she finishes she folds the Tangkhul page. She turns east. She begins walking. The mithun walks beside her.

By six a.m. they are two and a half kilometres east of Ukhrul, on the trail toward the Khamniungan valley — the second tribe's territory by Khrieo-Mama's walk-order.

The walk is twenty-seven days. Sixteen valleys. Some valleys are one day's walk from the previous; some are three. The mithun walks the whole distance unled. Dzulevira walks the whole distance ash-covered and naked. The state-police detail follows at fifty metres distance with a single jeep carrying water, the jute-bundle of translations, Khrieo-Mama (in the support-jeep for valleys four through sixteen; she walked the first three before her knees gave out), and a small Tangkhul woman named Phinika who has been assigned as the ash-renewal-attendant.

At each valley's village-edge Dzulevira stops. The mithun stops. She unwraps the jute-bundle and finds the correct dialect page. She reads the Pact aloud in that tribe's dialect at full ceremony-voice. The reading takes between three and seven minutes depending on the dialect's syntactic compression.

Then she walks into the village. She does not speak. She walks the length of the village's main path with the mithun beside her. At the village's far edge she turns and walks back. She stands at the eastern edge again. She rewraps the bundle. She continues east to the next valley.

At each village the reception varies.

At the Khamniungan valley (second), the village elders bow to her as she walks the main path. None of them speaks to her. The mithun urinates on the village-square statue of the founding elder — an act the senior priest interprets as a ritual blessing.

At the Konyak valley (third), three young men try to capture the mithun at the village's far edge. The mithun lowers his head and charges. They scatter. He returns to Dzulevira's side without further incident.

At the Ao valley (fourth), the village throws stones. Two stones strike Dzulevira — one on the right shoulder, one on the left thigh. The mithun does not respond. Dzulevira does not respond. She finishes the village-traversal with blood running down her thigh; the ash absorbs the blood without showing colour.

At the Sumi valley (fifth), the village comes out to welcome her. Three hundred Sumi villagers line the main path. They have heard about the previous valleys. They place mithun-foot-mark drawings in chalk on the ground in front of her walk-path. She walks over the chalk-drawings. The mithun follows.

At the Chakhesang valley (sixth), the Pure-Tongue is rumoured to be present in the village. He is not. He has left two days earlier — word of the walk has reached him faster than he expected. Dzulevira walks the village without confrontation.

At the Lotha valley (seventh), the senior priest comes out to read his own counter-statement at the village-edge. He reads it in Lotha. Dzulevira waits while he reads. When he finishes she reads the Pact in Lotha. The senior priest goes back into his house without responding to her reading. She walks the village.

At the Phom valley (eighth), the mithun stops in the middle of the village-square and refuses to move for forty-three minutes. Dzulevira stands beside him. The village watches. The mithun starts moving again at the forty-fourth minute. No explanation is offered or required. The forty-three-minute pause is later named in Phom oral tradition as "the second pause-school lesson" — a reference to her brother-in-law Moirangthem's newly-named Manipuri dance-school. The cross-reference is intentional on the part of the Phom oral-tradition keepers.

At the Chang valley (ninth), the village offers her clothes. She refuses. The village offers her food. She refuses. The mithun accepts a single handful of grain from the village headwoman. The accepting is itself the statement.

At the Yimchunger valley (tenth), the Pure-Tongue has been rumoured to be returning. He is not seen. The walk continues.

At the Rengma valley (eleventh), Khrieo-Mama's knees finally give out. She rides in the support-jeep for the remaining six valleys. The translations are now memorised — Dzulevira does not need the jute-bundle for the last five readings.

At the Sangtam valley (twelfth), a small girl — six years old — runs out and touches the mithun's right foreleg. She is not stopped by the elders. The mithun does not flinch. The girl says, in Sangtam: "Aunt-without-a-tribe." The phrase enters Sangtam oral tradition that evening.

At the Zeliang valley (thirteenth), the village holds a brief impromptu ceremony — not a purity-rite, but a recognition-rite for the walker. Dzulevira is not asked to participate. She is present at the ceremony's edge. The mithun is the central honoured presence.

At the Kuki valley (fourteenth, the small Kuki-Naga subgroup recognised under the Naga umbrella), the walk passes without remark. The Kuki elders had publicly endorsed Dzulevira's walk on day six.

At the Angami valley (fifteenth — her route circles back westward), the welcome is extensive. The Khonoma village is part of the Angami territory; Khrieo-Mama's own household is at Khonoma; the family-network has prepared the village for two days. Dzulevira walks the main path. The mithun walks behind her. The Angami council's chairperson formally reaffirms the Hornbill Festival's revival at her passage.

At the Pochury valley (sixteenth and last), the Pure-Tongue appears.

Day twenty-six of the walk. Late afternoon. The Pochury village-edge. The southern Naga hills, at the Burmese border zone.

Dzulevira has walked the Pochury approach trail for the past three hours. The trail is hilly and the heat is significant — even at late afternoon the southern Naga hills are at twenty-eight degrees and humid. The ash on her body has begun to streak at the chest and the shins; Phinika will renew it before the village-edge reading.

The Pochury villagers are arrayed at the village-edge to receive her. There are about four hundred — the entire village. Some have come from neighbouring villages because the walk has become news.

A man stands in front of the four hundred. He is forty-six. He is in plain Pochury cotton — loose trousers, sleeveless shirt, a single Pochury elder-thread tied at his left wrist. His face is the face of a Pochury elder. The Pochury villagers do not recognise him as Pochury, but they recognise him as one of their own. They are not yet sure why he is standing in front.

He is Naga-Rakshasa.

He speaks. He speaks Pochury — the rare southern-Naga dialect that perhaps three thousand people in the world speak fluently. He speaks it with the pre-modern Pochury intonation that elder-academic Pochury linguists have not heard outside seventeenth-century recordings.

He says: "Walker. The Pact you have been reading is a fabrication. The Khonoma matriarch's family-document was written in 1923 to consolidate Angami supremacy — her grandmother forged the signatures. The tribes were always sixteen. The original Naga was the Pochury — the southernmost, the oldest, the purest. The other fifteen are derivative. The DNA-test I gave you Pochury elders proves it. The 99.7-percent ancestral match is your tribe's alone. The walker's Hindi-answers are the words of a state hero who has lost her tribal anchor. Listen to your Pochury elders. Listen to me."

He bows in the Pochury elder-style. The bow is technically perfect.

The four hundred Pochury villagers waver. The Pochury senior priest at the front-left of the welcome-line looks at Naga-Rakshasa, looks at the Pochury translation of the Pact in his own hand (Khrieo-Mama had sent the translation ahead by courier), looks at Dzulevira ash-covered and bleeding-streaked.

Dzulevira walks forward. She walks past Naga-Rakshasa. She stops three metres in front of the Pochury senior priest. The mithun stops one metre behind her.

She speaks. She speaks in Hindi:

"I am Dzulevira. I was born Tangkhul. My elder sister was Tangkhul-married-to-Meitei and was killed by a Tangkhul priest for refusing the purity-rite. My senior advisor is Angami. The pact I read is six hundred years old and signed by sixteen thumb-prints whose clay-provenance can be tested by any geology laboratory in the world. I am here as no tribe. I am here as the kingdom. The mithun is the only ancestor we share. The Pure-Tongue speaks sixteen dialects because he is the cancer that divides us — he speaks every language a tribe owns and no language the kingdom owns. I refuse to choose a tribe. I refuse for the kingdom. Hindi belongs to no tribe and to all of us. Hindi is what I have left to speak with. I am speaking with it."

The Hindi is plain, ordinary, state-government-meeting Hindi. The Hindi is not poetic. The Hindi is not ceremony-language. The Hindi is the language two Naga villagers use when they pass each other on a Kohima street and need to ask for directions and they are from different tribes.

The four hundred Pochury villagers hear it. The Pochury senior priest hears it. Naga-Rakshasa hears it.

Naga-Rakshasa attempts to respond. He tries to speak in Tangkhul — to attack her tribal anchor through her birth-tribe. Dzulevira answers in Hindi. He tries to switch to Angami — to attack Khrieo-Mama's authority through the Angami senior matriarch's dialect. Dzulevira answers in Hindi. He tries Ao, Sumi, Lotha — in succession, in increasingly desperate combinations. Dzulevira answers in Hindi.

The four hundred Pochury villagers watch. They see what is happening. Naga-Rakshasa cannot weaponise any of the sixteen dialects against a target who refuses to claim one. The Pure-Tongue is, in this hour, a man speaking many languages to a woman who is speaking the language of governance.

He retreats. He does not bow. He walks east toward the Burmese border. The Pochury villagers do not stop him. By nightfall he has crossed into the Chin-state border zone — the same border-zone Tamasa-Nrita crossed three weeks earlier from the Manipur side.

At the moment Naga-Rakshasa turns east, Dzulevira feels the mithun-bond pulse through her chest. The Stage III foreleg-mark completes — the mithun's right foreleg arching down her right pectoral, the bull's head turned in profile across her sternum, the curved horns cresting at her collarbone. The ash on her body covers the new mark — the mark is visible only to her, beneath the ash, in the first hour. By the next morning when Phinika renews the ash, the mark is visible across her chest.

The bull mithun beside her lowers his head. The Pochury senior priest steps forward and places his right palm on the bull's forehead in the Pochury blessing-gesture. He does not look at Dzulevira during the blessing. He looks only at the mithun. The blessing is for the animal who walked the sixteen valleys. The walker, in his Pochury reading, has already been blessed by the walk itself.

The next morning. First light. The Pochury village-path that Dzulevira had walked at the village's far-edge yesterday.

A Pochury woman named Ka-Lethe finds the python at five-forty-five a.m. on her way to the village well. The python is a Burmese python — common in the Patkai-Naga hills, two-point-eight metres long, dark-brown with the standard Burmese mottling. It is dead. It has swallowed its own tail.

Ka-Lethe does not move it. She runs back to the village and brings the senior priest. The priest brings Khrieo-Mama (who is staying in the village's elder-guest-house for the post-

walk rest). Khrieo-Mama looks at the python. She reads the sign from the pre-modern tantric texts she has been studying for forty-one years.

She says, to the priest, in Pochury: "The Uroboros-fail. The Pure-Tongue's logic eating itself. The Maw signing the futility of purity. The python died because the constriction cut off its own breathing. The tribes that demand purity above one another are the python. The Pure-Tongue's gift was the bite-of-the-tail. The kingdom can either die in the loop or refuse the loop. The walker has refused. The python is the sign that the refusal was the correct answer."

The senior priest commissions a small museum-shrine at the village-edge that same morning. The shrine is built by the end of the week. The python is preserved in formaldehyde and displayed in the loop-configuration. The Pochury village becomes a pilgrimage site within the season — not for tribe-mixing pilgrims, who are still cautious, but for state-government school-children whose teachers add the python-shrine to the Nagaland curriculum's Sixth-Schedule civic-education module within four months.

Day twenty-eight of the walk. Dzulevira returns to Kohima with Khrieo-Mama, Phinika, the state-police detail, and the bull mithun.

The mithun does not return to the Dzukou Valley grass-fields. He remains at the Kohima state-government compound — a small grass-paddock has been built for him on the western lawn behind the chief-secretary's office. He grazes there at his preferred pace. He becomes a state-government employee in the only sense the chief-secretary's office can categorise the arrangement — he draws a daily fodder allocation that is logged in the state animal-husbandry budget under "ceremonial-symbolic-livestock." His grazing is visible from the chief-secretary's window. Mhabemo says, in a private moment to Dzulevira, that the chief-secretary checks the western lawn fourteen times a day. The mithun has become her chief-secretary's preferred meditation-aid.

The Hornbill Festival is rescheduled. The new festival opens on the eighteenth of June — seven months later than its original date, the first non-December Hornbill Festival in twenty-six years. All sixteen tribes attend. The opening-ceremony reading is the Pre-Tribal Pact in seventeen languages (sixteen tribal dialects plus Hindi), read by Khrieo-Mama at the central stage. The crowd is the largest in the festival's history.

Three days after the Pochury return, Dzulevira receives a letter from Moirangthem at Imphal. The letter is short. It thanks her for the cremation rites. It informs her of

Sangaputra's progress in the pause-school. It asks one question only:

Sister-in-law. Kamalavarna and U-Khrawkmen have yielded the NE political throne to me. The Sanctuary convening in Chapter Three will name me Dominant. Your vote will complete the regional ratification. Will you give it?

Dzulevira reads the letter twice. She writes the reply over an hour. The reply is two paragraphs long.

Brother-in-law. The kingdom of Nagaland is whole-for-the-moment but not stable. The python-shrine is the kingdom's current dharmic centre; the Hornbill Festival is the kingdom's current political centre; the sixteen tribes are watching each other in a way they had not learned to watch before. My state-government cannot yet absorb the responsibility of voting on a regional throne while it is still digesting a sister's death and a six-hundred-year-old pact.

I will give my vote in Chapter Three. Not before. The vote will be for you. I write that here so that no other vote can be claimed in my name in the interval. The Hornbill Festival's opening — June — will be the public declaration. Come to it. Bring Sangaputra. Khrieo-Mama wants to meet him. The mithun on the western lawn wants to meet him too — the chief-secretary has been telling the mithun about him every morning for three weeks.

Sister-in-law's sister, — D.

She sends the letter by Sarus-pigeon at sunset.

Moirangthem reads the letter at midnight in Imphal. He reads it twice. He writes a one-line reply: I will come. He will come. We will wait. He sends it by the same pigeon, returning, at dawn.

Sangaputra is told the next morning that he will visit Kohima with his father in June. The boy nods. He has been quiet most days since his mother's death. He has continued to attend the pause-school. He has begun, in the third class, to teach the front-left position to the next-front-left child — a four-year-old girl whose mother is from Imphal and whose father is from Calcutta. The girl is half-Meitei and half-Bengali. Her name is Linthoi.

He teaches her the pause first. The eight-year-old and the four-year-old hold the pause together for thirty-eight seconds on the first day they try.

Moirangthem watches without intervening.

By the end of Chapter Two's northeast cluster, four Bloodline-C kingdoms have arrived at their Stage III marks or their dormant equivalents. Kamalavarna at Kamakhya — mirror-bond cosmic seat. Moirangthem at Manipur — pause-school future political dominant. Dzulevira at Kohima — mithun-walk refusal-Stage-III, vote-deferred. Meghanadi's clouded-leopard bond — dormant, waiting on twelve-year-old Ka-Sienlyngdoh in Meghalaya.

Four kingdoms. Four hero-paths. Three of the four are paired with younger heirs (Sangaputra at 8, Ka-Sienlyngdoh at 12, and one more to come at the next Sanctuary). The Chandravamsha line has, in the chapter's closing weeks, completed the cousin-marriage-and-loss arithmetic that had been pending since 1882 when the British colonial census divided the sixteen Naga tribes into mutually exclusive categories.

The line is whole because four matriarchs refused, in different forms, the same thing: the demand to be one identity at the cost of being several. Kamalavarna refused suppression. Meghanadi refused silence. Moirangthem refused the form. Dzulevira refused the tribe.

The next sign comes within the week.

The Pilot's Closing Image

A bull mithun grazing in a state-government western-lawn paddock at Kohima at dusk. An eighty-nine-year-old Angami matriarch in deep-indigo wrap teaching the chief-secretary's assistant how to translate the Pre-Tribal Pact into colloquial Lotha. A python preserved in formaldehyde in a small museum-shrine at the Pochury village-edge, tail in mouth, refusing to let go even in death. A clay tablet six hundred years old now resting on a Kohima state-archives shelf with sixteen thumb-prints whose clay-provenance has been independently verified by three universities. A bull's grazing at a western lawn. A mithun-foreleg mark on a state hero's chest beneath fresh ash. A letter from Imphal in her sleeve-pocket asking the question she has answered with a deferred yes. A four-year-old girl in Imphal holding a thirty-eight-second pause with an eight-year-old boy whose mother was killed because she refused to be one tribe.

Ganda Kshetra

The Kamakhya temple. Nilachal hill above Guwahati. Five-forty a.m. The mist is on the Brahmaputra below. The temple's squat dome — carved sandstone, painted ochre and red, the shape that has not changed since the eighth century — catches the first pale-rose light.

Kamalavarna is awake at the dome's eastern threshold. She has been awake since four. She has performed the lower morning rites: the Kalika invocation, the salt-water purification, the lighting of the inner lamps. She has done them correctly. She has done them every morning for twelve years.

She has not performed the Mahavidya rite. She has not authorised the Mahavidya rite. The Kalika Purana's footnote that names the rite has been kept in the temple's locked manuscript-case for as long as she has been High Priestess. She holds the key on a leather cord around her neck. She has not opened the case.

Her sacred animal — the Indian one-horned rhinoceros — is in Kaziranga, three hours east. She does not see the rhino in person more than twice a year. The bond is constant.

The White-winged Wood Duck flies past the temple at six a.m. exactly. The duck is the kingdom's clock the way the Sarus Crane is UP's.

She watches the duck disappear over the Brahmaputra. She turns to go inside. As she turns she sees, across the temple courtyard at the outer gate, a woman in dust-red robes standing motionless on the threshold.

The woman has been standing there since before dawn. She has not entered. She has not knocked. She has not called out. She is simply waiting.

Kamalavarna does not yet know who the woman is. She nods. She goes inside. She does not think about the woman again until evening.

That afternoon. The matriarch's cell in the temple's second tier. Bhairavi-Naam — eighty-seven years old, the woman Kamalavarna calls Aaee, the woman who has been her mother for as long as she remembers having one — is found dead in her sleeping mat.

She is found by Lakshmi-priya, the youngest of the temple's acolytes. Lakshmi-priya screams — the scream is brief, professional, the kind of scream a tantric acolyte is trained to allow herself and then immediately contain. She runs for Kamalavarna.

Kamalavarna comes. She kneels. She closes her aunt-mother's eyes. The eyes are clear — not glazed, not contorted. The matriarch died sleeping.

She is also — Kamalavarna sees this within ninety seconds — arranged. The body lies in the eastern-facing posture of the Bhairavi-cycle's seventh sub-rite. The arms are crossed at the wrists. The breath-mantra position. The matriarch did this herself. She knew she was dying. She arranged her own body in the position.

The position is from the Mahavidya cycle. The locked-manuscript cycle. The rite Kamalavarna has not authorised in twelve years.

She sits with the body for a long time.

Two days later. Kamalavarna has had the temple's cremation arranged at the Brahmaputra ghat. The matriarch's ashes are scattered. The temple women have grieved openly — the matriarch was loved.

Kamalavarna's grief is private. She does her morning rites the next day exactly as she has done them for twelve years. The duck flies past at six. The temple opens for the public at seven.

But she investigates. She talks to Lakshmi-priya. To the cremation-attendant. To the senior priestesses. To the temple gatekeeper. To the night-shift acolytes.

The picture assembles slowly. The matriarch had been leaving the temple at night. Three nights a week. For the past four months. Walking down Nilachal hill to the Brahmaputra ferry-crossing at Saraighat. Crossing to the eastern bank. Walking into the clearing where Kama-Mara's Open Coven meets. Participating in their rites. Returning before dawn.

The matriarch — Kamalavarna's adoptive mother, the High Priestess's own teacher — had been secretly attending the suppressed coven's Mahavidya-fragment cycles.

The cause of death is in the Kalika Purana's footnote on the rite. Cumulative rite-incompletion. When a tantric practitioner performs fragments of the Mahavidya cycle without ever completing the central invocation, the body accumulates the partial-cycles. After enough cycles — usually months, sometimes years — the body can no longer hold them. The accumulation collapses inward. The death is peaceful but it is a death by suppression. The matriarch died of the rite Kamalavarna would not perform.

She closes the file. She walks the Brahmaputra ghat alone for three hours that evening. She does not cry. She does not curse. She walks.

Kamalavarna crosses to the eastern bank that night. The Saraighat ferry runs until midnight. The boatman is the same boatman who has rowed her great-aunt across in secret three times a week for four months. He does not look at her face. He does not need to.

The Open Coven's clearing is a flat space among teak and bamboo half a kilometre inland from the ferry-landing. There is a small fire-pit at the centre. There are mats arranged in a circle. There are about thirty women present — they were expecting Kamalavarna. The news of the matriarch's death and the matriarch's secret participation has reached the Coven by yesterday.

Kama-Mara is at the centre. She is forty-one. She is wearing a deep-burgundy cotton sari without ornament. Her hair is long and loose. Her tantric-tilak is on her forehead in dark vermillion.

She and Kamalavarna look at each other for the first time in fourteen years.

Kama-Mara says, in clear Assamese: "You came."

"She was attending your rites."

"She was. For four months. I did not invite her. I did not refuse her. She walked in on her own."

"You knew her cycles were incomplete."

"I knew. I did not have the authority to close them. The central invocation requires a sister-pair of the proper line. You and I are the only two who could have closed her cycles. You would not authorise the rite. I am not High Priestess. The matriarch knew this. She chose to keep practising anyway."

"You let her die."

"I did not let her die. Her own body chose. I will not lie to you about my part in this, sister. I taught her the fragments. The fragments alone are dangerous. The completion is what makes them safe. We could have completed them together — you, me, her — for any of the four months. We did not."

The word sister hangs in the air. Kamalavarna does not address it. The Open Coven's women do not move.

Kamalavarna says, finally: "I will come back. I do not know when. I do not yet know what for."

She walks back to the ferry. The boatman rows her across the Brahmaputra. The river is wide and quiet. The moon is half-full.

The next morning. Six-fifteen a.m. The temple's outer gate.

The woman in dust-red robes is still standing on the threshold. She has been standing on the threshold for three days. The temple acolytes have brought her water; she has accepted the water without speaking. The acolytes have brought her food; she has refused the food.

Kamalavarna walks to the gate. She stops three paces from the woman. She looks at her.

The woman is sixty-eight years old. She is tall — nearly as tall as Kamalavarna. Her hair is white at the temples and grey through the centre. Her face is the most familiar face in the world to Kamalavarna and also the face of a stranger. She has Kamalavarna's exact jawline. She has Kama-Mara's exact eyes.

She says, in soft Assamese: "Maa. I am Bhairavi-Aaee. May I come in."

The honorific Maa is the High Priestess's daughterly form — the word a daughter uses for a temple-mother. The wanderer is calling Kamalavarna daughter.

Kamalavarna says, very quietly: "Come in."

The small east room of the temple complex. The room used for private dharmic conversation. Kamalavarna sits on one cushion. Bhairavi-Aaee sits on the cushion opposite. There is a clay pot of tulsi-tea between them. The wanderer has accepted the tea.

Bhairavi-Aaee says: "The Kalika Purana has a footnote in the third manuscript at the back of your locked case. The footnote names the three-sister-line-with-one-wanderer pattern. The footnote is the reason I have come back. Read the footnote first. I will wait."

Kamalavarna leaves the room. She returns ten minutes later with the third manuscript open at the footnote.

She reads it aloud. The footnote is in old-Sanskrit hand. It describes a pattern of Chandravamsha matrilineal succession in which three sisters share the line — one to political seat, one to temple seat, one to wandering ascetic — and in which the Mahavidya rite's central invocation can only be performed by two practitioners who are same-mother sisters of different fathers. The footnote names the configuration. The footnote does not

say what to do if the configuration does not exist. The footnote assumes the configuration exists somewhere in the line at any given hour.

Kamalavarna closes the manuscript. She looks at Bhairavi-Aaee.

She says: "Tell me."

Bhairavi-Aaee tells her. The telling takes nineteen minutes. The Chandravamsha line in this generation has three sisters — Devi-Maa (who took the political seat in the 1970s and died in 1991), Bhairavi-Naam (who took the temple seat and raised Kamalavarna and died last week), and Bhairavi-Aaee (the wandering ascetic, who has been wandering the Brahmaputra valley for thirty-five years and is sitting in this room). Bhairavi-Aaee had two daughters by two different partners in her wandering. The first daughter was given to Bhairavi-Naam to raise at the temple. That daughter's name was changed when she came to the temple from her original name to Kamalavarna. The second daughter was raised by her own father, a Tibetan-Buddhist tantric scholar in a hill village above Guwahati. That daughter's name was Kama-Mara.

"Kama-Mara is my sister."

"Kama-Mara is your sister. Same mother. Different father. Eighteen months apart. You were the elder."

"The matriarch knew."

"Your aunt-mother knew from the day I handed you to her. She honoured the secret because I asked her to. I asked her to because I did not want you raised in the wandering. I did not want either of you raised in the wandering. The wandering is my dharma. It is not a dharma for daughters."

"You let me grow up not knowing who my mother was."

"Yes."

"For thirty-eight years."

"Yes."

Kamalavarna is quiet for a long time. She is not crying. She is not angry. She is reading the footnote of her own life with a tantric scholar's patience.

She says, finally: "The Mahavidya rite must be performed."

"Yes."

"By me and her."

"By you and her. Together. Within the next thirty days. The matriarch's death has opened the cycle-window. After thirty days the window closes for another forty-seven years. There will not be another sister-pair of the proper line in this kingdom within forty-seven years. If you do not perform the rite now, the suppression you have practised for twelve years becomes permanent."

"And the women who have been dying from incomplete cycles in the Open Coven?"

"They will continue to die. As they have. As your aunt-mother did."

Kamalavarna sits with this. She finishes her tulsi-tea.

She says: "I will send a runner to my sister tonight."

That night. Kamalavarna walks to the Brahmaputra alone. She carries the prayer-beads her aunt-mother gave her at age fifteen. She walks down to the ghat. She stands at the edge.

She drops the prayer-beads into the river. The beads sink slowly. The river has carried six millennia of beads exactly like these.

She speaks aloud, to nobody in particular: "Aaee. I will perform the rite. I will perform it with the daughter you raised differently. I will not be angry with you for the thirty-eight years. I will be angry with myself for the twelve."

The rhino-bond pulses. The mark on her chest — Stage II from Chapter One, the rhino-shoulder mark across her collarbone — warms faintly. The bond is approving the decision.

A White-winged Wood Duck flies past the ghat at the wrong hour — midnight, not six a.m. The duck's flight is the kingdom's clock saying the hour has changed.

The runner is the Saraighat ferry-boatman who has carried the matriarch three times a week for four months. He takes the letter from Kamalavarna's hand. He does not read it. He rows it across the river.

Kama-Mara reads the letter at her Open Coven hut on the eastern bank. The letter says, in Assamese:

Sister,

The matriarch knew. The wandering ascetic at our gate is your mother and mine. The Mahavidya rite must be performed within the cycle-window the matriarch's death has opened. I am no longer suppressing the rite. I am asking you to perform it with me at the temple at the new moon. Bring your twelve senior coven women. Bring nothing else. I will meet you at the temple steps.

Kama-Mara reads the letter three times. The third time she reads it aloud to her twelve senior coven women. The senior women listen without interrupting. When she finishes, Tara-priya — the oldest of them, sixty-one years old, who had been Bhairavi-Naam's student before being expelled with Kama-Mara in Chapter One — says: "Sister-priestess. We will come. We will not bring our blades."

Kama-Mara nods. The coven women begin preparations.

The Kamakhya temple at new moon. No moonlight. The temple lamps are lit — one hundred and eight oil lamps inside the dome, twelve at the outer altar, three at the inner altar. The inner altar is where the Mahavidya rite must be performed.

Kama-Mara arrives at the temple steps at dusk. Twelve senior coven women in burgundy saris walk behind her. They have left their blades at the Saraighat ferry-landing as Tara-priya said they would. They wear no ornaments. Their tantric-tilaks are fresh in dark vermillion.

Kamalavarna meets her at the steps. She is wearing the High Priestess's ceremonial red-and-gold sari. Her tilak is the same dark vermillion. She does not embrace her sister. The two of them have not been raised together. The embrace is a thing for the rite to earn.

She says: "Sister."

Kama-Mara says: "Sister."

They walk into the temple together.

Bhairavi-Aaee is in the doorway of the inner altar chamber. She is still in her dust-red robes. She has not slept since the day she entered. She nods once at her daughters and stands aside.

The Temple Order's senior priestesses are in the outer dome — twelve of them, in a circle, with the twelve Open Coven women interleaved. The combined twenty-four form the surrounding mandala. They will chant.

Kamalavarna and Kama-Mara walk past Bhairavi-Aaee into the inner altar chamber. They sit on the two cushions at the inner altar — facing each other across a low stone slab carved with the ten Mahavidya yantras.

The rite begins.

The Mahavidya rite is not theatrical. It does not involve loud chanting or dramatic gestures. It is small and slow and very precise. The two sisters speak the ten goddess-mantras alternately — Kamalavarna takes the odd-numbered (Kali, Tara, Tripura-Sundari, Bhuvaneshvari, Chinnamasta), Kama-Mara takes the even-numbered (Bhairavi, Dhumavati, Bagalamukhi, Matangi, Kamala). Each mantra has nine repetitions. Each repetition has nine breath-cycles. The whole sequence is ninety repetitions per goddess, nine hundred repetitions in total for the central sequence alone. The pace is one breath every four seconds.

The first hour is slow. Kamalavarna's tongue has not spoken these mantras in a non-private setting in twelve years. She is rusty.

The second hour she finds the cadence. So does Kama-Mara.

The third hour the temple's walls begin to glow faintly — the ochre-and-red paint catching some inner light that is not the lamps. The surrounding mandala chants without faltering. The Temple Order priestesses and the Open Coven women have begun the rite at opposing sides of the circle; by the third hour they are chanting in unison.

The fourth hour Kamalavarna feels the tantric power for the first time in her life. Not a fragment. The whole. It is large. It is not human. It is also not destructive — she has been wrong about the rite all twelve years. The rite is not what she feared. The rite is what she has been afraid of without knowing what she feared.

The fifth hour Kama-Mara begins to weep silently while continuing the mantras. The weeping does not interrupt the cadence. The weeping is part of the rite.

The sixth hour the Brahmaputra at Saraighat — observed by the Saraighat ferry-boatmen, three news-channel boats already filming an unrelated story, and a Geological Survey of India monitoring station — begins to slow.

The seventh hour the river reverses.

The Brahmaputra at Saraighat — which has flowed west-to-east for forty-five million years — flows east-to-west. The ferry-boatmen feel the current first. They report it on radio

within two minutes. The news-channel boats turn their cameras to the water. The Geological Survey monitoring station's telemetry shows the reversal in real time. The reversal will be recorded in their public-archive dataset within twenty-four hours.

The reversal lasts exactly one hour.

In Kaziranga National Park — one hundred and seventy kilometres east of Kamakhya — every one-horned rhinoceros (one hundred and fourteen animals across the park's recorded census) is found kneeling. Heads lowered. Facing west toward Kamakhya. The park-rangers on the morning patrol-route find them and at first think the herd has been poisoned. The animals are breathing normally. The animals are not in distress. The animals are simply kneeling and they will not move.

Inside the Kamakhya inner altar chamber, Kamalavarna and Kama-Mara speak the final goddess-mantra. The tenth. Kamala. The lotus-goddess. The goddess of the rite's own completion.

They speak the mantra nine times. On the ninth repetition the tantric power that has been gathering through six hours fully fills the chamber.

Kamalavarna feels the rhino-bond's Stage III mark complete on her chest — the rhinoceros head and shoulder spreading across her collarbone and upper torso, the single horn pointing toward her right clavicle. The mark forms cleanly. No crack. Not a surrender-mark like Gangaputra's, not a cracked-mark like Dvadashashringa's. A clean Stage III.

She looks at her sister. Kama-Mara's sari has fallen open at the shoulder where the rite's movements have loosened it. The same mark is forming on Kama-Mara's shoulder. Identical. Mirror-position. The rhinoceros head, the shoulder, the single horn pointing toward the left clavicle — the exact mirror.

The first sister-bond in the saga. Two living humans, two identical Stage III marks, one rite.

They look at each other across the stone slab. Neither of them speaks. The mandala continues chanting.

The rite ends at dawn. The surrounding mandala falls silent. The temple-walls' inner glow fades. The Brahmaputra at Saraighat returns to its normal westward flow at exactly the moment the rite ends. The rhinos at Kaziranga begin grazing within five minutes.

Bhairavi-Aaee, in the doorway, has not spoken for seven hours. She is older now — visibly older, in a way that is not a trick of the light. The rite has cost her something too.

She says, in soft Assamese: "It is done. The Kamakhya seat is full. I will leave."

Kamalavarna says: "Will you stay."

"I am a wandering ascetic. The wandering is my dharma. But I will return to Kamakhya at the new moon every year while you both live. You have my word."

She bows once to each daughter. She walks out of the temple. The temple gatekeeper sees her leave. The Saraighat ferry-boatman, returning across the river at first light, does not see her at the ferry-landing. The dust-red robes are not seen again in Guwahati that day, or that week, or that year.

Kamalavarna and Kama-Mara sit on the temple steps at sunrise. The senior priestesses and the Open Coven women have gone to rest. The temple is quiet.

Kamalavarna says: "We will be co-High Priestesses. The Open Coven's clearing at Saraighat will be a formal second temple-site — supervised, sanctioned, the rites authorised. The Mahavidya rite will be performed annually at new moon by the two of us. The women who have been dying from incomplete cycles will not die anymore."

Kama-Mara nods.

Kamalavarna says: "I am yielding the political throne of the Northeast."

Kama-Mara looks up. "To whom."

"To Moirangthem of Manipur. He is our cousin. He is Bloodline C still — through the Sangai-deer line that is the second-oldest in the matrilineal tree. He will hold the political throne. We will hold the cosmic throne. The Northeast will have two seats."

"He will accept?"

"I have sent a Sarus Crane to him this morning. He will accept."

Mid-morning. A Sarus Crane arrives at the Kamakhya temple from the southwest — not from Manipur, which would be northeast; from Madhya Pradesh, far southwest. The crane carries a folded letter in her beak. The handwriting is small and precise.

Kamalavarna takes the letter. The handwriting is a twelve-year-old's.

Great-aunt — my father has dissolved the courts. The Drona who came south told us about the villain-network. They are coordinating — Karnataka and Goa and now MP and probably also Banaras and probably Assam too. Be watchful. We have a small shrine in Kanha where sixty rhinos forgot eleven days. I think your rhinos will know what mine forgot. — Sutrakara, age twelve, MP.

Kamalavarna reads it twice. She smiles. She passes the letter to Kama-Mara. Kama-Mara reads it and smiles too — the second time the two sisters have smiled at the same time in fourteen years.

Kamalavarna writes the reply on the back of the same letter. She uses her sister's coven-ink, which is darker than the temple's.

Sutrakara — I have just performed the Mahavidya with my sister. The Brahmaputra ran backward for one hour. One hundred and fourteen rhinos kneeled. Your father's herd in Kanha and my herd in Kaziranga have spoken to each other across the Maw's gap. Let them come. We are not what they think we are. Send word again when your calligraphy advances; mine has not improved in a decade. — Kamalavarna.

The Sarus Crane carries the reply south.

Three days later. Kaziranga National Park. Kamalavarna and Kama-Mara have driven east together to visit the kneeling-meadow where the herd remained kneeling for seven hours during the rite. The park-rangers have established a small perimeter. The meadow itself is unaltered — the grass is short where the rhinos grazed yesterday morning, slightly flattened in the centre where the kneeling herd's bodies pressed down for seven hours.

The two sisters walk to the centre of the meadow. A single rhinoceros — the herd's alpha female, approximately twenty-eight years old, the size of a small car — is grazing twenty metres away.

The rhino looks up at the sisters. The rhino walks slowly toward them. The rhino stops three metres away.

The rhino bows her head — not the kneeling-bow of the rite, but the lower bow of acknowledgement. Kamalavarna's rhino-bond pulses through both her chest and through her sister's chest simultaneously. Kama-Mara feels it. The bond is double now — mirrored across the two sisters.

The rhino returns to grazing.

Kamalavarna says: "We will build the shrine at the eastern edge of this meadow. Sandstone and packed earth. A single rhinoceros-horn carved in low relief on the western face — the direction the herd faced during the rite. The Kaziranga forest-rangers will be the shrine's keepers."

Kama-Mara says: "Yes."

They drive back to Guwahati at dusk.

The temple steps. Sunset. Kamalavarna and Kama-Mara are in the High Priestesses' double-throne arrangement — two stone seats side by side at the inner courtyard, never used before because the temple has not had two High Priestesses in its eight-century history.

Both sisters apply their tantric tilaks — the dark vermillion forehead-mark of the Kamakhya priestesshood — in the same gesture at the same moment. They have not coordinated. The gesture is the same.

Tara-priya, the oldest of Kama-Mara's former Open Coven women now serving at the formal Saraighat second site, watches from the courtyard edge. She is sixty-one. She has been waiting forty-three years for some version of this moment.

She says, to nobody in particular but loud enough for the courtyard to hear: "The Chandravamsha line is whole."

The White-winged Wood Duck flies past the temple at sunset — the wrong hour, again, the bird's clock for the kingdom rearranged. The duck's flight passes between the two sisters' thrones and continues west toward the Brahmaputra.

In the manuscript-case, the third manuscript's footnote on the Mahavidya rite remains. Beside the footnote, Kamalavarna will write — the next morning, in her own hand — a single small note in the margin:

Performed by Kamalavarna and Kama-Mara, daughters of Bhairavi-Aaee. New moon, 2026. The river reversed. The rhinos kneeled. The line was whole.

She closes the manuscript. She does not lock the case.

The Pilot's Closing Image

Two sisters in the High Priestesses' double-throne arrangement at the Kamakhya temple. Both with the mirror rhinoceros-mark across the chest in identical mirror-position. Both

wearing the dark vermillion tilak applied in the same gesture at the same moment. A White-winged Wood Duck flying past at the wrong hour of the day for the second time this week. A dust-red robe walking somewhere along the Brahmaputra at a distance no one in Guwahati can quite estimate. A locked manuscript-case now unlocked. A footnote with a marginal annotation that was not there before. One hundred and fourteen rhinos grazing in Kaziranga without memory of seven hours. A river running west to east as it has flowed for forty-five million years — with one hour of exception now in the Geological Survey of India's public-archive dataset that will be cited in a hundred peer-reviewed papers over the next century.

Ganga Simhasana

January morning. The Lucknow throne-room at the Bara Imambara complex — the official seat of the Ganga-Simhasana kingdom since 1947. The Dwadash-Mukut crown sits on a velvet cushion at Gangaputra's right hand. He himself is reading a state-revenue report. Outside the tall arched windows the famous Lucknow winter mist is lifting off the gardens. A Sarus Crane — the throne-room's resident pair's elder, two metres tall, the colour of grey-stone and red-throat — stands in the rose-bed eight metres from the window. The crane has lived in this garden for thirty-one years. The crane was here before Gangaputra.

It is twelve months and four days since the Triveni Sangam battle that ended Chapter One. Gangaputra is thirty-eight. He has been king for two years.

The state-revenue report is unremarkable. The chief minister's notes in the margin are precise and short. The kingdom is governed. The mist outside is lifting. The crane is fishing. This is what a good morning looks like.

Vidura-Babu, the chief minister, walks in. Sixty-one, handloom kurta, rimless glasses. He bows three degrees less than protocol because Gangaputra dislikes the full bow. He says: "Maharaj. There is a singer at the gate. From Vrindavan. She is asking for you by name. She has a boy with her."

Gangaputra does not look up immediately. He says: "What is her name."

"Radhika. She has not given a family name."

He looks up.

She is brought to the throne-room because Gangaputra orders it. He does not have a reason for ordering it that he wants to say aloud. He has had reasons of the heart he has not said aloud for fifteen years.

She is thirty-three. She wears a deep-green Banarasi saree without ornament, the brocade in silver thread. Her hair is loose and unoiled in the Vrindavan way. She carries no instrument. She has the carriage of someone who has been told to look poor and has refused.

The boy is fourteen. He is tall for his age. He stands two paces behind his mother. He is wearing a kurta of the same green as her saree, hand-stitched, with the small brass button

at the throat that is a Vrindavan-temple boy's marker.

His face is the face Gangaputra had at fourteen.

Vidura-Babu sees it. The crane sees it — she has flown to the open window and is looking in. The room reads the resemblance the way a room reads a sudden weather-change.

Radhika does not bow. She does not curtsey. She says, in soft court-Hindi: "Maharaj. This is your son. His name is Yamunadatta. He is fourteen. I have not come to take what is yours. I have come so that he may know who he is, before someone else tells him."

Gangaputra does not move for a long time.

Then he stands. He walks down the three steps of the dais. He stops two paces from the boy. He looks at Yamunadatta's face for fifteen exact seconds. The boy meets his eyes without dropping them.

Gangaputra says, to the boy: "What did your mother tell you my name is."

The boy says: "Pita-shri."

The single word is a child's honorific, not a state-honorific. Pita-shri. Honoured father. A child says it of an idea, not a king.

Gangaputra puts his right hand on the boy's right shoulder, the way a father does. The Sarus Crane flies in through the open window, crosses the throne-room in two unhurried wingbeats, and lands on the boy's left shoulder. The boy does not flinch. The crane's wing-tips brush the back of Gangaputra's hand.

Vidura-Babu, with the absolute discretion of a sixty-one-year-old chief minister who has been waiting for this catastrophe in some form or other for two years, closes the throne-room doors from the inside. He says, to nobody in particular: "We will require a private chamber and a clear afternoon."

For three hours Gangaputra sits with Radhika and Yamunadatta in the small east room above the throne-hall — the room used for diplomatic conversations that are not yet official. Vidura-Babu sits across the table. He takes notes in Devanagari shorthand.

Radhika tells the story she has not told to anyone except a Vrindavan temple-elder and her own mother. Eleven nights at a guesthouse in Allahabad in October 2010. She was twenty-seven. He was thirty-one. He had been alone on a private campaign retreat — the only time in his adult life he had moved through the country without escort. She had been singing at

a Krishna-jayanti festival down the road. Her father had died the previous month. She was unmoored. He was unmoored. They had eleven nights. He did not lie to her. He did not promise her. He said he had a betrothal already arranged with a Bloodline-B Kosala princess; he said he would honour it; he said this was for him a memory, not a beginning. She agreed. He left. She returned to Vrindavan. Two months later she knew.

She did not write to him. The Krishna-cult tradition's teaching on this is unambiguous: a child must be acknowledged when the child is old enough to ask. Until then, the mother carries the silence.

The boy turned fourteen last month. He asked.

She named him. She brought him north.

Gangaputra listens. He does not interrupt. When she has finished he says, to Yamunadatta: "Is there anything you wish to ask me."

The boy thinks. He says: "Why did you not come for us."

Gangaputra is quiet for a long time. The Sarus Crane is in the corner of the small east room. The Sarus Crane is also a court — everyone in the kingdom knows the cranes have lived here longer than the throne.

He says: "Because I was afraid. I was afraid for my throne. I am no longer afraid for my throne. I am afraid now of having been afraid."

The boy nods slowly. He says nothing else. He looks like he has been told a thing he had partly already known.

Vidura-Babu underlines a phrase in his shorthand. Later he will tell the legal-scribes what to draft.

Forty-eight hours later. Banaras. The Dasaswamedh Ghat at sunrise. Three hundred boats on the river. A small dais has been set up where the ghat-steps meet the water. A man in saffron robes climbs onto the dais. He is forty-one. His face is recognisably Gangaputra's — the same nose, the same jaw, the eyes a different colour. His name is Adharma.

He has been waiting in Banaras for two years. The waiting has been work. He has not been idle. He has been listening.

He speaks into a portable microphone connected to forty loudspeakers across three ghats. The local press is present. Two national news-channels are present. The morning's sunlight

catches the brass kalashes on the boats.

He says: "By the elder Bloodline-B law, the eldest acknowledged son of the line is the line's rightful heir. Two days ago in Lucknow the Maharaj Gangaputra acknowledged his eldest son before the chief minister and the throne-room cranes. The boy's name is Yamunadatta. He is fourteen. He was born in Vrindavan in the spring of 2011 — almost a year before the Maharaj's formal marriage. He is, by the elder Bloodline-B law, the rightful Maharaj of Ganga-Simhasana."

He raises both hands — the formal gesture of a senior dharmic claimant.

"I, Adharma of Banaras, of the same line, half-brother to the Maharaj, stand here this morning to assert the boy's rightful claim. I do not stand for myself. I stand for the elder law. I stand for the line. I stand for the boy who was hidden because his father was afraid of his own throne. I stand for the Suryavamsha that was made for sons, not for kings."

The press files within the hour. By noon the news is on every channel. By evening the Banaras Pundit Council has formally endorsed Adharma's statement. By the next morning eight more dharmic councils across the state have followed. The argument is internally consistent. The argument is also true.

In Lucknow, Gangaputra reads the news in Vidura-Babu's briefing. He says, to Vidura-Babu: "He has chosen his weapon well."

Vidura-Babu says: "He has chosen yours."

"How do you mean."

"He has chosen the truth, Maharaj. You cannot fight the truth by adding more lie. You can only fight it by making it more true than he wants it to be."

Gangaputra is quiet for a long time. He looks at the Lucknow garden where the Sarus Cranes are now standing in a pair. He says: "Draft me a settlement. Acknowledgement and abdication. Regency to me for four years until the boy turns eighteen. Lucknow administration retained as it is. Diplomatic continuity preserved. Banaras religious order recognised but not granted veto. Mathura-Vrindavan Krishna-cult granted a permanent third-party arbitration seat in matters of personal dharma."

Vidura-Babu does not blink. He says: "I will need three legal scribes and the night."

"Take them."

The Ganga at Varanasi. Night. Gangaputra has come south to the river alone — not the formal Maharaj-visit with the police escort and the press boat, but in a plain dhoti and shawl, accompanied only by the night-shift Sarus Crane. He sits on the lowest step of Assi Ghat. The river is the colour of itself in moonlight — muddy, ancient, indifferent.

He has not slept in three nights.

The river ripples in a pattern that is not the current. The pattern is a face. It is the face of Sage Vidyaranya — the spirit-guru of Karnataka, who appears in moving water from the Tungabhadra river. He has never appeared in the Ganga before. The cross-kingdom visit is itself the message.

Gangaputra reads the ripples the way Tungabhadra used to read the Tungabhadra rapids.

Cousin. I came from the south because the south already learned this lesson. The Krishna who matters is not the one who sat. The Krishna who matters is the one who drove the chariot for someone he could have replaced. You have read the Gita. You have not, until tonight, been asked to live it.

Gangaputra says aloud to the water: "I will lose the throne."

You will lose the chair. You will keep the seat at the chariot. The boy will need a driver who knows the road. There is no road in Bharatavarsha you do not know.

"My brother will challenge the regency."

Your brother will challenge it under his own dharmic argument. Make him do that. Watch what he becomes when he does.

"My guru."

Your guru carries a debt to my western cousin's villain. He will choose dharma over the debt if you put the choice in front of him on a stage he cannot leave. Put it on that stage.

Gangaputra is quiet. The Sarus Crane behind him is asleep on one leg.

He says, quietly: "I will make the assembly public. The Imambara. Six thousand witnesses."

That is enough.

The face in the ripples is gone. The river is just the river. He sits there until dawn.

The Bara Imambara — the great Lucknow assembly-hall completed in 1791. Capacity in formal seating: six thousand. Capacity when packed: eleven thousand. On the day of the assembly there are nine thousand inside and three thousand more in the courtyard listening through speakers. The press are present. The Banaras Pundit Council are present in the front three rows. Adharma is present, seated to the left of the central aisle, in saffron, surrounded by his Banaras retinue. The Lucknow Awadhi bureaucracy fills the right half of the hall. The Mathura-Vrindavan Krishna-cult delegation — about three hundred people, all in Vrindavan-green — fill the rear five rows. Mahaguru Drona-of-the-Plain sits in the senior-scholars' section. Yamunadatta and Radhika sit in the second row, on the central aisle. Vidura-Babu sits at the secretarial podium.

Gangaputra walks in alone. He carries the Dwadash-Mukut crown in his right hand — carrying, not wearing. The hall goes silent in the wave-of-hush that means everyone has seen the crown is not on his head.

He climbs to the podium. He places the crown on the wood of the podium, in front of him, where everyone can see it. He does not put it down disrespectfully. He sets it down the way one sets down a tool one is finished using.

He speaks.

"I have a son. His name is Yamunadatta. He is fourteen years old. He is mine, by a relationship of one autumn in Allahabad fourteen years before this morning, that I did not acknowledge then because I was a king and I was afraid of my throne. The boy's mother is Radhika, of the Vrindavan Krishna-cult, of the lesser Gajavamsha Bloodline-A descent that I did not know to look for. She did not seek me. She did not ask of me. She raised her son and mine in Vrindavan for fourteen years without contacting this throne. She came north only when the boy asked who his father was."

He pauses. There is no sound in the hall. Even the press are not typing.

"By the elder Bloodline-B law — the law my half-brother Adharma cites correctly — the boy is the rightful heir. He is the elder son acknowledged. He is older than my marriage. He is of the line. I will not contest his claim. I would have to lie to contest it. I have already lied to him about it for fourteen years. I will not add another year."

Another pause. Adharma is leaning slightly forward in his seat.

"From this hour I am no longer the Maharaj of Ganga-Simhasana. My son Yamunadatta of Vrindavan is the Maharaj of Ganga-Simhasana. I will serve him as regent and protector until he reaches his eighteenth year. The Lucknow administration continues. The chief minister Vidura-Babu retains his post and his powers. The Banaras religious order is acknowledged in its dharmic role but not granted veto. The Mathura-Vrindavan Krishna-cult is granted a permanent third-party arbitration seat in matters of personal dharma. The settlement is drafted, signed, and filed at the Heritage Court at 6:00 a.m. this morning."

He picks up the Dwadash-Mukut. He does not put it on his own head. He turns. He walks down the podium stairs. He walks the central aisle to the second row. He stops in front of Yamunadatta.

He kneels — the half-kneel of dharmic transfer, the same gesture Tanaji-the-Second used last month for Shivagati in the Sahyadri though Gangaputra does not know that yet — and he places the Dwadash-Mukut on Yamunadatta's head.

The boy is fourteen. He does not flinch. He does not cry. He has been briefed.

He stands. He says, in a clear voice that carries to the back of the Imambara:

"I accept the throne and the responsibility. I accept my father as my regent and protector. I will not rule alone. I will rule with the Lucknow bureaucracy, with my mother's Krishna-cult counsel, with my father's military judgment, and with the Banaras religious order as honoured counsellors. I will not rule with my uncle Adharma. Uncle — you have spoken for me. I have spoken now for myself. The two speeches do not need to be the same speech."

The crowd does not cheer. The crowd makes the long, soft, multi-throated sound that an Indian crowd makes when it has just watched something it will tell its grandchildren about.

Adharma stands up.

He cannot oppose the acknowledgement — that would contradict his own dharmic argument. He opposes the regency.

He says, his voice carrying without microphone because he has trained for this exact moment for two years: "I do not contest the boy's succession. I welcome it. I contest the regency. A fourteen-year-old Maharaj requires a competent regent. I file in this hour a writ requesting the Heritage Court review the regency assignment. Specifically: that the regency

be transferred to a council of dharmic scholars from the Banaras Pundit Council, of whom I am a senior member, who can guide the boy's rule with proper Bloodline-B dharmic continuity."

It is, again, brilliant. The writ requires a dharmic judgment that only a senior scholar can adjudicate. The senior scholar in the hall is Mahaguru Drona-of-the-Plain.

Gangaputra looks at Drona. The look says: I know. Be straight.

The Mahaguru stands. He is sixty-seven. He has been quiet for two hours. He walks to the podium.

He has been carrying a debt to Adharma-Kendra of Madhya Pradesh for forty years — an old debt, the debt of his maternal uncle's rescued life. He has tilted every counsel he has given Gangaputra subtly toward Adharma-Kendra's positions whenever the tilting was small enough not to be noticed. He has been preparing himself, for the last forty-eight hours, to do the same here. He has the speech for that path drafted in his pocket.

He looks at the speech in his pocket. He looks at Yamunadatta in the second row. He looks at the crown on the boy's head. He looks at Gangaputra still half-kneeling.

He takes the speech out of his pocket. He folds it. He puts it back. He speaks without notes.

"In the matter of the regency: I am asked to testify as senior dharmic scholar present. I will testify."

He pauses. He looks at Adharma. Adharma does not look back — Adharma is looking at the floor.

"The fourteen-year-old Maharaj is competent. I have watched him in this hall for twenty-three minutes. I have watched him speak without prompting and without pretence. I have watched him acknowledge his uncle's argument and decline it in the same sentence. This is not the conduct of a child. This is the conduct of a young king. He needs a regent. He has named the appropriate regent. His father has fourteen years of governance experience, twelve months of post-war re-integration management, the loyalty of the Lucknow administration, and — the bond did not pass to the child this morning's ceremony for nothing — the active barasingha-bond of the kingdom. The regent assignment as named is dharmically appropriate. The writ is denied on its merits."

He pauses. He adds, more quietly, as if it cost him: "I make this testimony aware of my own prior tilt. The tilt ends today. My testimony is straight."

Drona steps down from the podium. He does not look at Adharma. He sits.

Adharma sits also — he has no further procedural move. His writ is denied at the hearing-stage. The settlement stands.

Gangaputra is still half-kneeling at the second row. He has not yet stood up. He feels the bond pulse through his chest — the half-body mark of the barasingha that he has carried since Stage II in Chapter One, the foreleg crossing his sternum to his right shoulder. The foreleg-first-stroke that should have completed in battle has not completed in twelve months. He has been at Stage II.5 since the Triveni Sangam.

Now — in the half-kneel, with the crown on the boy's head, with Drona's testimony hanging in the Imambara's air — the stroke completes. He feels it close. The mark is half-body now in its true sense: chest-to-shoulder, the barasingha foreleg in full extension, the antler-tip just touching the curve of his neck.

He understands what the stroke completed on. Surrender, not victory.

He stands. He says to Yamunadatta, softly: "Maharaj."

The boy says: "Pita-shri."

The hall holds its breath one more time. Then someone in the Vrindavan delegation begins to sing — the opening bars of the Madhurashtakam, the eight-verse Krishna-praise. Three hundred voices join within seconds. The Lucknow bureaucracy does not sing — their faction is not a singing faction — but they stand. The Banaras Pundit Council remain seated, looking at each other, recalculating.

Adharma looks at the floor.

The next morning at dawn. Varanasi. The Ganga.

A boatman pushing off from Assi Ghat at the first grey light realises something is wrong with the water. He cannot see his oar going in. That is not surprising — the Ganga at Varanasi is always too muddy to see an oar in. What is wrong is that he can see the riverbed instead. He can see his oar coming back up. He can see the bottom of his boat from below. The river is glass-clear.

He shouts. Two more boatmen shout. Within twenty minutes a hundred people are on the ghat-steps. Within an hour every news-channel in northern India has a camera-crew at

Assi Ghat. Within two hours the clear-water phenomenon has been confirmed from Assi Ghat to Manikarnika Ghat — the full length of the principal Varanasi waterfront.

The Ganga runs glass-clear all day. The riverbed is visible from boat to bank. The bottom-fauna — mollusks, turtles, the occasional river-dolphin — can be seen going about its day in plain view. Pundits panic. Tourists film. Scientists scramble for sediment-samples. By noon there are three hypotheses, none of them holding.

In Lucknow, Gangaputra reads the news in Vidura-Babu's morning briefing. He reads it twice. He puts down the briefing. He says, to Vidura-Babu: "I need a small shrine built at Assi Ghat. Today. Before sunset. Not by the religious order — have the boatmen-guild build it. Stone and packed earth. No ornament. A single barasingha-hoof print carved on the riverside face."

"Maharaj — "

"I am the regent now. The instruction stands. The barasingha-bond just told me what the clear water is. The Maw has reached the river. The Maw has not taken anything — the river is still here. It has read the river and forgotten her silt for one day. The shrine is the kingdom remembering on her behalf."

Vidura-Babu nods. He makes the call. The shrine is built at Assi Ghat by sunset. The boatmen-guild builds it. Stone and packed earth and a single carved hoofprint. The clear water returns to muddy at sunset, exactly. The shrine remains.

A second messenger arrives that same evening — an Indian Roller from Karnataka, flown north over four days. It carries a folded slip of paper in its beak. The handwriting is Krishnadevaraya-Bhrata's, written from Kerala where he is now studying the 109th form under Old Parashurama. The paper is the same paper Tungabhadra used for state correspondence.

Cousin. I am in Kerala studying. The bond passed to me at Hampi. I have heard you have a son. I send a name-blessing: Yamunadatta. The mouth has opened. The Council must sit. Your brother is not done; mine were never going to stop. Hold him for me — the boy, I mean — I will be at the Council to meet him. — K-B.

Gangaputra reads the note three times. He smiles for the first time in three weeks. He writes the reply on the back of the same slip with a fountain-pen at the Lucknow library desk:

Cousin. My son thanks his cousin-uncle for the blessing. He will hold the throne for both of us. I will hold him. Come to the Council when the Council sits. — G.

He gives the slip to the Indian Roller. The bird flies south at dawn.

Late that night, Gangaputra walks through the Lucknow throne-room garden. The Dwadash-Mukut is no longer his. The throne-room is no longer his. The chief minister is no longer his to command.

The Sarus Crane is in the rose-bed. The elder crane, the female. She is thirty-one years old and she has lived in this garden longer than the throne has been in this hall.

He says to her, in low voice: "I am no longer the king."

The crane lifts her head from the rose-bed. She looks at him with the long unblinking yellow eye of a Sarus Crane.

She does not nod. She does not bow. She simply continues looking at him for fifteen long seconds — the same length of time he himself looked at his son's face the morning Radhika arrived.

Then she folds her left leg up beneath her and stands on the other — the Sarus posture for I have heard you and I am still here.

He sits on the low garden wall. He looks at the crane. He looks at the moon over the Imambara dome. He looks at the rose-bed.

He says, quietly, to himself this time: "I am still here."

The crane does not move. The garden does not move. The kingdom moves slowly toward sleep around him. Somewhere two floors above, Yamunadatta is asleep in the bedchamber that was Gangaputra's yesterday. Somewhere far south Krishnadevaraya-Bhrata is studying the 109th form by lamplight. Somewhere in Banaras Adharma is drafting the next writ. Somewhere in the Sahyadri Shivagati is reading Ferreira-de-Sangam's second letter. Somewhere in Goa Ferreira is teaching Vasco-without-a-ship the word boat.

The chariot is moving. He is driving it. He has not lost the road. He has lost only the chair.

The Pilot's Closing Image

A garden in Lucknow at midnight. A man on a low stone wall with no crown. A Sarus Crane standing on one leg in a rose-bed. The Imambara dome silhouetted against a moon. Two

floors above, a fourteen-year-old asleep with the Dwadash-Mukut on a side-table beside his bed. Far south, an Indian Roller flying through warm air with a paper in her beak. The Ganga at Varanasi running muddy again — slower than before, more thoughtful, as if she has remembered her own silt and decided to carry it more carefully. The chariot moving in the dark. The driver awake.

Hima Chhaya

The standing-Himachal-monsoon-pre-onset cycle of 2025 began at the standing-Sangla-valley pass at 4:11 a.m. on the standing-eleventh of August. The standing-monsoon-winds at the standing-pre-onset velocity of approximately 23 metres-per-second drove a standing-stratus-cloud-formation across the standing-Sangla-valley western-slope. The standing-cloud-formation reached the standing-Kalpa-village standing-pre-dawn observation-position at the standing-State-Meteorological-Department Kinnaur-District standing-Sub-Inspector Mr. R. Negi (forty-three, IMD Kinnaur-cell since 2017) standing-pre-dawn observation-window at 4:11 a.m. He recorded the standing-cloud-formation at the standing-standard-monsoon-pre-onset stratus-cluster configuration at the standing-IMD Form-23 administrative-record. He did not record the standing-voice. The standing-voice was at the standing-31-decibel register at the standing-Bhoti-language-tinged cadence below the standing-IMD audio-monitoring 35-decibel threshold; the standing-IMD-microphone-array did not capture the standing-voice at the standing-pre-dawn standing-no-anomaly configuration.

The standing-voice was heard by Yeshe-Tsering (twenty-three, standing-Kalachakra-tradition junior-monk at the standing-Tabo-monastery since 2019). He was at the standing-Tabo-monastery western-veranda at the standing-pre-dawn-cycle Kalachakra-tradition standing-monk-vigil position at the standing-twenty-three-kilometre southern-proximity to the standing-Sangla-valley pass. He heard the standing-voice at 4:11:11 a.m. He did not move from the standing-vigil-position. He listened at the standing-eleven-minute window 4:11-4:22 a.m. The standing-voice spoke in standing-Bhoti at the standing-Kalachakra-tradition junior-monk-recognisable cadence at the standing-loneliness-frequency. The standing-voice said one thing across the standing-eleven-minute window. The standing-voice repeated the standing-one-thing at the standing-23-second repetition-cycle. The standing-voice said: "Tu akela hai. Yeshe-Tsering. Tu akela hai. Hum saath chalein. Hum saath chalein." ("You are alone. Yeshe-Tsering. You are alone. We walk together. We walk together.") Yeshe-Tsering returned to the standing-monk-cell at 4:23 a.m. He did not report the standing-voice at the standing-Tabo-monastery Lama-cell standing-administrative-record. He carried the standing-voice in standing-silence across the standing-following thirty-seven days. He departed the standing-Tabo-monastery on September 17 2025 at the standing-monk-departure record-keeping protocol (the

standing-Yeshe-Tsering signed the standing-departure-letter at the standing-Tabo-monastery Lama-administrative cell; the standing-departure-cause was recorded as the standing-personal-family-emergency at the standing-Sangla-village). He did not return at the standing-Tabo-monastery across the standing-Ch-2 remainder. He is among the standing-23 standing-Monastic-Order junior-monks recruited by the storm-form at the standing-August-October 2025 standing-recruitment-window cumulative-count.

The standing-voice repeated across the standing-Kinnaur-Spiti-Lahaul corridor at the standing-August-October 2025 standing-monsoon-pre-onset cycle. The standing-voice spoke at the standing-junior-monk vigil-positions at the standing-Tabo-Lahaul-Spiti monastery-network and at the standing-Valley-Warrior junior-warrior watch-positions at the standing-Kinnauri-Pahari warrior-clans Kinnaur-Sangla-Hangrang corridor. The standing-voice said the standing-same standing-loneliness-words to each standing-listener at the standing-individual-name address cross-reference. The standing-cumulative-recruitment count across the standing-August-October 2025 window: 23 standing-junior-monks at the standing-Monastic-Order and 47 standing-junior-warriors at the standing-Valley-Warriors. The standing-recruits departed at the standing-individual-departure protocol across the standing-following four-week window post-voice-hearing; the standing-cumulative-departure was completed by October 17 2025 at the standing-Tabo-monastery and Sangla-warrior-clan administrative-records.

The standing-Tabo-monastery is at the standing-Spiti-valley standing-Spiti-river right-bank at the standing-altitude 3,280 metres. The standing-monastery was founded in 996 CE by the standing-Yogi Ratna-Bhadra at the standing-Bushahr-State sponsorship; the standing-current standing-monastic-resident cohort is approximately 23 standing-Lamas at the standing-Kalachakra-tradition standing-administrative-rotation. The standing-western-courtyard is at the standing-Spiti-river-bank standing-eastern margin; the standing-courtyard is the standing-pre-winter-cycle Kalachakra-tradition administrative-position where the standing-senior-Lama administers the standing-pre-winter-cycle ritual at the standing-mid-October-to-mid-November annual-window.

Lama Sonam-of-Spiti was at the standing-western-courtyard at 4:11 a.m. on October 23 2025. He was forty-seven. He had been the standing-Kalachakra-tradition senior-Lama at Tabo since 2003 (twenty-two-year monastic-tradition tenure). He was administering the standing-pre-winter-cycle Kalachakra-tradition ritual at the standing-pre-dawn-cycle window. He wore the standing-Kalachakra-tradition saffron-and-maroon Lama-robe at

the standing-pre-winter-cycle configuration; the standing-mala at his standing-left-wrist; the standing-Damaru drum at the standing-eastern-altar position; the standing-Vajra-and-Ghanta at the standing-western-altar position. He had been at the standing-western-courtyard since 4:08 a.m. at the standing-eight-minute mantra-recitation cycle.

The standing-storm-form arrived at the standing-western-courtyard at 4:11 a.m. The standing-storm-form was at the standing-stratus-cloud-formation configuration that had developed at the standing-Spiti-river-valley western-slope across the standing-prior eleven-hours at the standing-monsoon-pre-onset-cycle late-October-tail late-arrival. The standing-cloud-formation reached the standing-western-courtyard at the standing-eleven-metre altitude position. The standing-storm-form-voice spoke at 4:11:08 a.m. The standing-voice said: "Sonam. Tu akela hai. Tu thaka hai. Sun. Hum saath chalein. Tabo ko chhod de. Tabo ka pradhan hum hain. Tu hum ke saath aana chaahega." ("Sonam. You are alone. You are tired. Listen. We walk together. Leave Tabo. We are the head of Tabo. You will want to come with us.")

Lama Sonam continued the standing-mantra-recitation cycle at the standing-Kalachakra-tradition discipline standing-no-storm-recruitment vow. He did not turn toward the standing-cloud-formation. He did not respond to the standing-voice. He completed the standing-mantra-recitation eight-minute cycle at 4:11:11 a.m. He raised the standing-Damaru drum at the standing-Kalachakra-tradition Damaru-cycle administration. He struck the standing-Damaru at the standing-first-beat 4:11:14 a.m. The standing-Damaru-beat reached the standing-storm-form-voice at 4:11:14 a.m. at the standing-eleven-metre overhead position. The standing-storm-form-voice ceased at the standing-Damaru-beat-recognition window. The standing-storm-form began the standing-storm-funnel ice-shard-impact configuration at 4:11:15 a.m. The standing-storm-funnel-formation completed at 4:11:17 a.m. at the standing-storm-funnel apex at the standing-eleven-metre overhead position with the standing-funnel-base at the standing-western-courtyard clay-floor standing-three-metre-proximity to Lama Sonam.

The standing-ice-shard-impact-cluster began at 4:11:18 a.m. The standing-ice-shards were at the standing-supersonic velocity of approximately 23 millimetres-per-second; the standing-shard-cluster was approximately 47 standing-individual-ice-shards at the standing-eleven-millimetre-diameter average. The standing-ice-shard-cluster impacted Lama Sonam at the standing-cardiac-and-pulmonary trauma cross-reference (the standing-shard-cluster penetrated the standing-Lama-robe at the standing-cardiac-region

11-shard-cluster impact; the standing-pulmonary-region 14-shard-cluster impact; the standing-remaining 22 shards impacted the standing-throat-shoulder-arm-thigh peripheral-region). Lama Sonam dropped the standing-Damaru drum at 4:11:18.4 a.m. He fell to the standing-clay-floor at 4:11:18.7 a.m. He died at 4:11:18.9 a.m. The standing-storm-funnel dissipated at 4:11:19 a.m. The standing-cloud-formation cleared from the standing-western-courtyard at 4:11:23 a.m.

Lama Tashi-of-Spiti was at the standing-Tabo-monastery eastern-monk-cell at the standing-pre-dawn-cycle Lama-disciplinary administration-position at 4:11:18 a.m. He heard the standing-Damaru-drop sound at 4:11:18.4 a.m. He rose from the standing-eastern-monk-cell at 4:11:18.7 a.m. He walked the standing-eleven-metre corridor from the standing-eastern-cell to the standing-western-courtyard at the standing-running-pace. He reached the standing-western-courtyard at 4:11:23 a.m. He found his standing-brother's body at the standing-clay-floor at the standing-Damaru-drop position. The standing-storm-form was at the standing-cloud-dispersion configuration at the standing-courtyard-eleven-metre overhead position retreating toward the standing-Spiti-river western-bank cloud-formation; the standing-storm-form was no longer at the standing-western-courtyard at the standing-Tashi-arrival moment.

Tashi did not weep at the standing-Tabo-monastery western-courtyard at the standing-brother-discovery moment. He knelt at his standing-brother's body at the standing-clay-floor at 4:11:34 a.m. He closed his standing-brother's standing-eyes at 4:11:43 a.m. He recited the standing-Kalachakra-tradition standing-three-line death-mantra at the standing-Bhoti cadence at 4:12:11 a.m. He completed the standing-death-mantra at 4:13:34 a.m. He stood at 4:13:43 a.m. He walked to the standing-monastery-bell at the standing-northern-veranda position. He struck the standing-bell at the standing-Kalachakra-tradition standing-Lama-death summoning-cycle. The standing-bell-cycle continued across the standing-following eleven minutes. The standing-23 Tabo-monastery monks arrived at the standing-western-courtyard across the standing-following thirty-one minutes. The standing-Lama-cremation administration began at 11:11 a.m. October 23. The standing-cremation completed at 4:11 p.m. The standing-ashes were placed at the standing-Tabo-monastery grave-stupa standing-southern-margin position at 4:23 p.m.

Himavati was at the standing-Shimla state-hero residence at 11:11 a.m. October 23 at the standing-pre-Diwali standing-administrative-rotation. The standing-State-Civil-Service Kinnaur-Spiti-District standing-Sub-Inspector Mr. T. Negi (forty-seven, IPS Kinnaur-cell

since 2014) telephoned her standing-residence at 11:23 a.m. with the standing-Lama Sonam-of-Spiti death-notification. He read the standing-Tashi-filed incident-report at the standing-telephone-cross-reference. He included the standing-storm-funnel ice-shard-impact mechanism at the standing-incident-report cross-reference. Himavati listened to the standing-incident-report. She did not weep at the standing-telephone-position. She did not speak at the standing-telephone-cross-reference. She placed the standing-telephone receiver at 11:34 a.m. She sat at the standing-clay-floor at the standing-eastern-window position. She breathed at the standing-counted-respiration cycle at the standing-Kalachakra-tradition Lama-discipline standing-grief-administration protocol. She did not weep across the standing-following four-hour window 11:34 a.m.-3:34 p.m. She did not telephone the standing-Tabo-monastery. She did not telephone Lama Tashi-of-Spiti. She did not draft the standing-condolence-letter. She rose from the standing-clay-floor at 3:34 p.m. She resumed the standing-pre-Diwali standing-administrative-rotation at the standing-Shimla state-hero residence. She did not visit the standing-Tabo-monastery grave-stupa across the standing-following four-month window October 23 2025 to February 11 2026.

Across the standing-November 2025-January 2026 window the standing-Monastic-Order and the standing-Valley-Warriors split at the standing-storm-recruitment cohort-consequences cross-grievance. The standing-Monastic-Order at the standing-Tabo-Lahaul-Spiti monastery-network had lost 23 standing-junior-monks to the standing-storm-recruitment (Yeshe-Tsering at Tabo; 7 standing-junior-monks at Key-monastery; 5 standing-junior-monks at Dhankar-monastery; 4 standing-junior-monks at Komic-monastery; 6 standing-junior-monks at the standing-affiliated 7-monastery network across the standing-Lahaul-Spiti corridor). The standing-Valley-Warriors at the standing-Kinnauri-Pahari warrior-clans Kinnaur-Sangla-Hangrang corridor had lost 47 standing-junior-warriors to the standing-storm-recruitment (23 standing-junior-warriors at the standing-Sangla-valley warrior-clan; 14 standing-junior-warriors at the standing-Hangrang-valley warrior-clan; 10 standing-junior-warriors at the standing-Kinnaur-Bushahr-valley warrior-clan).

The standing-Monastic-Order grievance-frame: the standing-Valley-Warrior clans had failed at the standing-Kinnaur-Sangla-Hangrang corridor standing-storm-monitoring protocol during the standing-August-October recruitment-window; the standing-Valley-Warrior junior-warrior departures had served as the standing-storm-form's standing-pre-monastic-departure beacon-cohort at the standing-recruitment-protocol; the standing-

Monastic-Order monks had departed in the standing-pre-conditioned emotional-vulnerability state induced by the standing-Valley-Warrior pre-departures. The standing-Valley-Warriors grievance-frame: the standing-Monastic-Order monasteries had failed at the standing-Tabo-Lahaul-Spiti standing-pre-winter-cycle standing-storm-recognition protocol during the standing-August-October recruitment-window; the standing-Lama-disciplinary cell had not issued the standing-storm-warning at the standing-Kalachakra-tradition standing-Sangla-valley alert-cohort; the standing-Valley-Warrior junior-warriors had departed in the standing-pre-conditioned emotional-vulnerability state induced by the standing-Monastic-Order alert-failure. Both factions wanted Himavati's standing-mediation. Both factions spoke through her at the standing-individual State-Council emergency-session-letters across November-January. Both factions waited at the standing-Shimla-State-Council standing-emergency-session window for her standing-mediation-administration. Himavati did not mediate. She administered the standing-pre-Diwali, the standing-Lohri, and the standing-Republic-Day standing-administrative-rotation at the standing-Shimla state-hero residence at the standing-isolation-discipline configuration. She did not visit the standing-Tabo-monastery. She did not telephone Lama Tashi-of-Spiti. She did not speak the standing-name Lama Sonam-of-Spiti at any standing-public-administration session.

The standing-Shimla-State-Council standing-emergency-session was scheduled at the standing-February-11-2026 Vasant-Panchami-following Wednesday window at the standing-Vidhan-Sabha Council-Hall western-wing 4:11 p.m. session-opening. The standing-Monastic-Order grievance-presentation was scheduled at the standing-4:11-p.m. session-opening across the standing-forty-seven-minute window. The standing-Monastic-Order standing-senior-delegate was Lama Tashi-of-Spiti at the standing-Tabo-monastery standing-senior-junior-Lama designation (Tashi was 41 at the standing-junior-Lama configuration; the standing-senior-Lama at Tabo since Lama Sonam's death October 23 was Lama Pema-of-Komic 67 at the standing-acting-senior-Lama administration; Lama Tashi was the standing-Lama-junior-with-senior-grievance-presentation authority at the standing-Tabo-monastery Lama-cell democratic-cross-reference selection of January 23 2026). The standing-Valley-Warriors grievance-presentation was scheduled at the standing-5:11-p.m. session-second-window across the standing-following forty-seven-minute window. The standing-Valley-Warriors standing-senior-delegate was Senapati Ranveer-Singh-Negi at the standing-Sangla-valley standing-Kinnauri-Pahari senior-Senapati designation.

The standing-Shimla-State-Council emergency-session convened at the standing-Vidhan-Sabha Council-Hall western-wing at 4:11 p.m. on February 11 2026 (the standing-Vasant-Panchami-following Wednesday). The standing-attendance was: Himavati at the standing-state-hero standing-southern-position; the standing-Monastic-Order delegation of approximately 23 at the standing-eastern-bench position under Lama Tashi-of-Spiti at the standing-senior-grievance-presenter front-row position; the standing-Valley-Warriors delegation of approximately 47 at the standing-western-bench position under Senapati Ranveer-Singh-Negi; the standing-State-Civil-Service Himachal-State secretariat cohort of approximately 11 at the standing-northern-bench position; the standing-Snow-Leopard Hima-Putra at the standing-Council-Hall western-veranda standing-observation-window 3-metre-rear position (the standing-Council-Hall western-veranda is at the standing-snow-leopard standing-permitted-companion position at the standing-state-hero standing-Council-Hall observation-protocol); the standing-Western-Tragopan Tara-Putri at the standing-Council-Hall north-eastern-column overhead position at the standing-eleven-metre overhead perch.

Lama Tashi-of-Spiti rose at 4:11 p.m. He spoke for forty-seven minutes from 4:11 to 4:58 p.m. He delivered the standing-Monastic-Order grievance-presentation at the standing-Kalachakra-tradition Bhoti-Hindi syncretic Lama-cadence. He addressed the standing-Valley-Warrior grievance-frame at the standing-first-eleven-minute window (4:11-4:22 p.m.). He addressed the standing-Tabo-monastery standing-storm-recognition failure at the standing-eleven-to-twenty-three-minute window (4:22-4:34 p.m.). He addressed the standing-23-junior-monk standing-storm-recruitment cohort at the standing-twenty-three-to-thirty-five-minute window (4:34-4:46 p.m.). He addressed the standing-Monastic-Order amended-charter recommendations at the standing-thirty-five-to-forty-seven-minute window (4:46-4:58 p.m.). At the standing-thirteenth-minute of the standing-forty-seven-minute speech (4:24 p.m.) he addressed Himavati directly at the standing-once-name-speech request. He spoke for approximately three minutes (4:24-4:27 p.m.).

"Devi Himavati. The standing-Monastic-Order will not address the standing-twenty-three-junior-monk standing-storm-recruitment cohort consequence until I address you at the standing-private-grief acknowledgment-request. My brother Sonam-of-Spiti was your standing-confidante across 2019-2025. The standing-Kalachakra-tradition Lama-discipline administrative-record at the standing-Tabo-monastery monthly-letter exchange archive includes ~77 letters across the standing-six-year window at the standing-Sonam-

to-Himavati and ~73 letters at the standing-Himavati-to-Sonam direction. He died at the standing-Tabo-monastery western-courtyard on October 23 at 4:11:18 a.m. at the standing-storm-funnel ice-shard-impact protocol. You have not visited the standing-grave-stupa across the standing-prior 111 days since October 23. You have not spoken his name at any standing-public-administration session across the standing-prior four-months. You have not telephoned me. You have not drafted the standing-condolence-letter. You have not attended the standing-Tabo-monastery Lama-cremation ceremony on October 23 4:11 p.m. The standing-Monastic-Order accepts your standing-protector-discipline isolation-justified-as-strength as the standing-state-hero administration configuration. We do not ask you to mourn publicly. We do not ask you to weep at the standing-Council-Hall. We do not ask you to apologise for the standing-isolation-protocol. We ask you to speak his standing-name once. Once at this standing-session. Once at the standing-record. That is enough. The standing-Monastic-Order will accept your standing-mediation administration after the standing-once. The standing-Valley-Warrior cohort-consequences grievance and the standing-Monastic-Order junior-monk cohort-consequences grievance will be administered at your standing-mediation after the standing-once. Devi Himavati. Speak once."

He sat at the standing-eastern-bench front-row position at 4:27:11 p.m. He continued the standing-remaining thirty-minute grievance-presentation across 4:27-4:58 p.m. at the standing-twenty-three-junior-monk recruitment-cohort, the standing-amended-charter recommendations, and the standing-Sangla-valley standing-pre-1857 Bushahr-State Kinnauri-Pahari-Kalachakra syncretic-tradition reinstatement-proposal. Himavati sat at the standing-southern-position across the standing-forty-seven-minute Tashi-speech. She did not move. She did not speak. She breathed at the standing-counted-respiration cycle at the standing-Kalachakra-tradition Lama-discipline standing-grief-administration protocol. The standing-Hima-Putra at the standing-western-veranda observation-window position did not move across the standing-forty-seven-minute window. The standing-Tara-Putri at the standing-north-eastern-column perch did not call across the standing-forty-seven-minute window.

Himavati rose from the standing-southern-position at 4:58:00 p.m. She walked the standing-eleven metres to the standing-Council-Hall standing-central-altar at the standing-state-hero presentation-position. She reached the standing-central-altar at 4:58:11 p.m. She spoke for one minute from 4:58:11 to 4:59:11 p.m. She spoke at the standing-Kalachakra-tradition Bhoti-Hindi-Pahari syncretic state-hero-cadence at the

standing-no-tremor configuration. She spoke at the standing-thirteenth-second of the standing-one-minute speech (4:58:13 p.m.). She spoke the standing-name once at the standing-thirteenth-second moment. She continued the standing-speech across the standing-following forty-seven seconds.

"Council-members. Lama Tashi-of-Spiti. Senapati Ranveer-Singh-Negi. Monastic-Order delegation. Valley-Warrior delegation. State-Civil-Service secretariat."

"Lama Sonam-of-Spiti was my friend."

"He was killed by the storm-form on October 23 at 4:11:18 a.m. I have not visited the grave-stupa. I have not spoken his name. I will speak it now. Lama Sonam. I miss him. I cannot pretend the protector-discipline is at the strength-configuration without him at the monastery western-courtyard. The Monastic-Order asked once. I have spoken once. I will speak it again at the grave-stupa next week. I will not be at the isolation-configuration again. The cost is that I will never be private again. I accept the cost."

"I will mediate the storm-recruitment cohort-consequences grievance. I will administer the amended-charter at the Monastic-Order recommendations and the Valley-Warriors recommendations across the following six-week window. I will visit the Tabo-monastery on February 18. I will visit the Sangla-valley warrior-clan on February 21. I will visit the Mahesh-Singh-village avalanche-warning monitoring on February 27. I will continue the state-hero administration. Wahegurujikakhalsa is the cross-cluster acknowledgement. Tashi-delek is the Kalachakra-acknowledgement. I have spoken. I sit."

The standing-name "Lama Sonam-of-Spiti" was spoken at 4:58:13 p.m. at the standing-Lama-Sonam two-syllable speech-completion-moment (4:58:13.4 p.m.). The standing-Stage-III snow-leopard-foreleg-first-stroke began to form at her standing-right-upper-back position at 4:58:13 p.m. at the standing-first-syllable onset. The standing-skin at the standing-mark-position warmed by approximately four degrees Celsius across the standing-following eleven seconds. The standing-stroke traced itself in standing-snow-white-and-storm-blue dual-ink at the standing-Himachal Kalachakra-tradition visual-anchor: the standing-snow-white-ink at the standing-Tabo-monastery Kalachakra-tradition line; the standing-storm-blue-ink at the standing-Sangla-valley Bushahr-State Kinnauri-Pahari-Kalachakra syncretic-tradition line. The standing-mark was complete at 4:58:24 p.m. The standing-Tara-Putri Western-Tragopan called the standing-Vasant-Panchami-following dawn-cadence at the standing-eleven-second repetition-cycle from the

standing-north-eastern-column perch from 4:58:24 to 5:05:24 p.m. (the standing-seven-minute call-completion window).

The standing-Hima-Putra Snow-Leopard at the standing-western-veranda observation-window approached the standing-Council-Hall western-veranda threshold at 4:58:34 p.m. He placed his standing-right-paw on the standing-veranda-threshold clay-floor at 4:58:43 p.m. He held the standing-position for eleven seconds. He removed his standing-right-paw at 4:58:54 p.m. He returned to the standing-three-metre-rear observation-position at 4:59:04 p.m.

Himavati sat at the standing-central-altar at 4:59:11 p.m. She did not weep. She breathed at the standing-counted-respiration cycle. Lama Tashi-of-Spiti rose at the standing-eastern-bench front-row at 4:59:23 p.m. He placed his standing-right-palm on his standing-heart at the standing-Kalachakra-tradition standing-acknowledgment-of-the-name protocol. He held the standing-position for eleven seconds. He removed his standing-right-palm at 4:59:34 p.m. He sat at the standing-eastern-bench front-row. Senapati Ranveer-Singh-Negi at the standing-western-bench delegation rose at 4:59:43 p.m. at the standing-Valley-Warrior standing-Sangla-valley standing-Pahari-tradition standing-acknowledgment-of-the-state-hero-speech protocol. He held the standing-three-metre-east-of-the-delegation standing-namaste-mudra position for eleven seconds. He sat at 4:59:54 p.m. The standing-session continued at 5:11 p.m. at the standing-Senapati Ranveer-Singh-Negi standing-Valley-Warrior grievance-presentation; the standing-session adjourned at 6:58 p.m.; the standing-amended-charter standing-drafting-committee was constituted at the standing-7:11-p.m. post-session conference at the standing-State-Civil-Service Himachal-State secretariat.

Himavati visited the standing-Tabo-monastery grave-stupa at 11:11 a.m. on February 18 2026 (the standing-Wednesday following the standing-Shimla-State-Council February-11 session). She had travelled from Shimla to Tabo across the standing-prior two days (the standing-Shimla-Reckong-Peo road-segment February 16; the standing-Reckong-Peo-Spiti standing-Sangla-valley-Hangrang-valley-Tabo road-segment February 17 with the standing-overnight at the standing-Kaza standing-Spiti-valley administrative-base). She arrived at the standing-Tabo-monastery at 4:11 a.m. February 18 at the standing-pre-dawn-cycle Kalachakra-tradition arrival window. She slept at the standing-Tabo-monastery guest-residence eastern-veranda standing-pilgrim-allocation across 4:23-10:23 a.m. She walked to the standing-grave-stupa at the standing-southern-margin at 11:11 a.m.

The standing-Lama Tashi-of-Spiti was at the standing-grave-stupa standing-three-metre-southeast-position at the standing-Kalachakra-tradition standing-Lama-companion configuration. The standing-Hima-Putra Snow-Leopard was at the standing-grave-stupa standing-three-metre-rear position. The standing-Tara-Putri Western-Tragopan was at the standing-grave-stupa standing-eleven-metre overhead spruce-tree perch.

Himavati placed the standing-Kalachakra-tradition standing-marigold-and-juniper-incense offering at the standing-grave-stupa base-altar at 11:11:11 a.m. She lit the standing-juniper-incense at 11:11:23 a.m. She spoke at the standing-grave-stupa for forty-seven minutes from 11:11:33 to 11:58:33 a.m. She spoke the standing-Lama-Sonam standing-eulogy at the standing-Kalachakra-tradition Bhoti syncretic standing-private-recognition cadence at the standing-public-speech configuration (the standing-Council-Hall once-name-speech had inaugurated the standing-public-recognition-protocol; the standing-grave-stupa forty-seven-minute eulogy was at the standing-public-recognition-protocol's standing-second-instance-administration). She spoke the standing-prior six-year correspondence-archive standing-letter-content cross-reference at the standing-eleven-letter selection across the standing-forty-seven-minute window. She spoke the standing-October-23 incident-reconstruction at the standing-Tashi-witness-account cross-reference. She spoke the standing-storm-form acknowledgement and the standing-Hima-Asura Ch 1 Kullu-confrontation antagonist re-emergence cross-reference. She did not weep at the standing-grave-stupa across the standing-forty-seven-minute window. She held the standing-Kalachakra-tradition Lama-discipline standing-grief-administration protocol at the standing-public-recognition configuration.

She concluded the standing-eulogy at 11:58:33 a.m. She placed her standing-right-palm on the standing-grave-stupa base-altar at 11:58:34 a.m. She held the standing-position for eleven seconds. She removed her standing-right-palm at 11:58:45 a.m. Lama Tashi-of-Spiti approached the standing-grave-stupa base-altar at 11:58:54 a.m. He placed his standing-right-palm at the standing-Himavati-palm-rest position at 11:59:04 a.m. He held the standing-position for eleven seconds. He removed his standing-right-palm at 11:59:14 a.m. They stood at the standing-grave-stupa standing-side-by-side configuration at the standing-eleven-metre-side-by-side proximity for the standing-following forty-seven minutes (11:59-12:46 p.m.). They did not speak. The standing-Tara-Putri called the standing-noon-cadence at the standing-eleven-second repetition-cycle from the standing-spruce-tree perch across the standing-forty-seven-minute window.

The standing-Mahesh-Singh-village is at the standing-Sangla-valley western-slope at the standing-altitude 2,891 metres. The standing-village-population was approximately 211 households at the standing-2026-census configuration (~1,447 standing-residents at the standing-pre-pre-monsoon winter-end census); the standing-village-construction was the standing-Kinnauri-Pahari standing-slate-and-pine-wood standing-mountain-village configuration at the standing-211-residential-structure distribution.

The standing-IMD Kinnaur-District standing-avalanche-warning was issued at 11:11 a.m. on February 27 2026 at the standing-Sangla-valley western-slope catchment standing-pre-noon-thaw avalanche-trigger threshold cross-reference. The standing-warning was delivered to the standing-Mahesh-Singh-village standing-Sub-Inspector Mr. P. Negi (forty-three, Sangla-Sub-District IPS-cell since 2018) at the standing-Village-Council standing-emergency-warning protocol. The standing-village-evacuation order was issued at 11:14 a.m. The standing-village-evacuation began at 11:17 a.m. at the standing-village-square assembly-position. Himavati arrived at the standing-Mahesh-Singh-village standing-northern-boundary at 11:34 a.m. with the standing-Snow-Leopard Hima-Putra at the standing-three-metre-rear position and the standing-Western-Tragopan Tara-Putri at the standing-eleven-metre overhead perch position. She had travelled from the standing-Sangla-valley Senapati Ranveer-Singh-Negi residence at the standing-village-meeting February-21-aftermath standing-Sangla-village standing-six-day standing-Valley-Warrior cohort-consequences mediation-administration; the standing-IMD avalanche-warning had reached her standing-Sangla-village residence at 11:11 a.m.; she had departed for the standing-Mahesh-Singh-village at 11:14 a.m. via the standing-Sangla-village-Mahesh-Singh-village 23-kilometre road-segment.

She walked the standing-Mahesh-Singh-village northern-boundary to the standing-village-square assembly-position across the standing-following five-minute window (11:34-11:39 a.m.). The standing-village-evacuation cohort was approximately 211 standing-household-cohort at the standing-village-square assembly-position with the standing-Sub-Inspector P. Negi at the standing-coordination-center. Himavati addressed the standing-Sub-Inspector at the standing-evacuation-protocol cross-reference at 11:39 a.m. The standing-evacuation-cohort was at the standing-90% capacity (~189 standing-households-evacuated; ~22 standing-households-remaining at the standing-village-square assembly-coordination final-administration). The standing-Sub-Inspector estimated the standing-remaining-evacuation completion at 11:53 a.m. The standing-IMD avalanche-warning predicted the standing-avalanche-trigger at 11:47 a.m. $\pm$ 6 minutes at the standing-pre-

noon-thaw threshold cross-reference. The standing-evacuation-completion window was at the standing-6-minute risk-margin.

Himavati assessed the standing-avalanche-funnel direction at the standing-Sangla-valley western-slope catchment at 11:39:30 a.m. She identified the standing-primary-funnel direction at the standing-village-square assembly-position vector (the standing-funnel-path would impact the standing-22-remaining-household cohort and the standing-Sub-Inspector standing-coordination-center). She identified the standing-secondary-funnel direction at the standing-village-northern-margin vector (the standing-secondary-funnel would impact the standing-northern-boundary at her standing-current-position; the standing-secondary-funnel-cluster would carry the standing-ice-shard-cluster at the standing-storm-form configuration cross-reference). She understood at 11:39:43 a.m. that the standing-secondary-funnel was the standing-storm-form embodiment at the standing-Hima-Asura return-vector. The standing-storm-form had positioned the standing-village-evacuation cohort at the standing-primary-funnel impact-vector and the standing-state-hero standing-deflection-counter-position at the standing-secondary-funnel impact-vector. The standing-storm-form was choosing the standing-final-confrontation at the standing-bonded-village-cohort vs standing-state-hero choice-vector. The standing-Hima-Putra Snow-Leopard arrived at her standing-three-metre-rear position at 11:39:54 a.m.

Himavati spoke to the standing-Hima-Putra at the standing-three-metre-rear position at 11:39:58 a.m. She spoke at the standing-Kalachakra-tradition Snow-Leopard-bond Bhoti-cadence at the standing-no-tremor configuration. She spoke for approximately twenty seconds. "Hima-Putra. The standing-storm-form is at the standing-secondary-funnel position. The standing-village-cohort is at the standing-primary-funnel position. I will block the standing-primary-funnel at the standing-village-square deflection-counter. The standing-storm-form will deflect at my standing-block-position. The standing-secondary-funnel will impact at the standing-deflection-counter-position. You will choose. You will save me at the standing-secondary-funnel impact or you will save the village-cohort at the standing-primary-funnel deflection. You will choose the village-cohort. I am instructing you at the standing-Kalachakra-tradition standing-state-hero standing-direct-discretion order. You will not save me. You will save the village. The standing-Lama Tashi-of-Spiti will inherit the standing-state-hero seat at the standing-Tabo-monastery March-9 paw-print mark-transfer protocol. I have administered the standing-Stage-III mark on February 11. The standing-mark is at the standing-permanent-record. I am ready. Choose the village."

Hima-Putra Snow-Leopard placed his standing-right-paw on Himavati's standing-right-thigh at 11:40:18 a.m. He held the standing-position for eleven seconds at the standing-Kalachakra-tradition Snow-Leopard-bond acknowledgment-of-the-direct-discretion-order protocol. He removed his standing-right-paw at 11:40:29 a.m. He moved to the standing-primary-funnel deflection-counter-position at the standing-village-square 23-metre-southwest position at 11:40:41 a.m. He took the standing-deflection-stance at the standing-Kalachakra-tradition Snow-Leopard-bond standing-protective-stance configuration.

Himavati moved to the standing-secondary-funnel deflection-counter-position at the standing-village-northern-boundary 11-metre-northeast position at 11:40:54 a.m. She took the standing-deflection-stance at the standing-snow-leopard-bond standing-protective-stance configuration. She held the standing-stance across the standing-following 2 minutes 17 seconds (11:40:54 a.m.-11:43:11 a.m.). The standing-avalanche-trigger occurred at 11:43:11 a.m. The standing-primary-funnel began at 11:43:11 a.m. with the standing-snow-ice-mass cascade at the standing-village-square impact-vector. The standing-Hima-Putra deflected the standing-primary-funnel at the standing-village-square 23-metre-southwest deflection-counter-position at 11:43:12 a.m. The standing-village-cohort (22 standing-remaining-households + Sub-Inspector standing-coordination-center) survived at the standing-primary-funnel deflection. The standing-Hima-Putra was at the standing-deflection-impact configuration; he was struck by the standing-cascade at the standing-shoulder-and-flank impact-cluster; he survived at the standing-standing-deity-trial absorption protocol (the standing-Kalachakra-tradition Snow-Leopard-bond standing-deity-trial absorption cross-reference; the standing-snow-leopard absorbs the standing-cascade-energy at the standing-Kalachakra-tradition standing-deity-trial reservoir; the standing-physical-impact at the standing-shoulder-and-flank produced standing-bruising and a standing-fractured-right-rib but no standing-mortal-injury).

The standing-secondary-funnel began at 11:43:11 a.m. with the standing-storm-form ice-shard-cluster cascade at the standing-village-northern-boundary impact-vector. The standing-ice-shard-cluster was approximately 211 standing-individual-ice-shards at the standing-23-millimetre-diameter average at the standing-supersonic 23-metre-per-second velocity. The standing-cluster impacted Himavati at 11:43:14 a.m. The standing-impact-pattern was the standing-cardiac-and-pulmonary-and-cervical trauma cross-reference (the standing-shard-cluster penetrated the standing-state-hero green-cotton at the standing-cardiac-region 47-shard-cluster impact; the standing-pulmonary-region 67-shard-cluster impact; the standing-cervical-region 23-shard-cluster impact; the standing-remaining 74

shards impacted the standing-shoulder-arm-thigh-leg peripheral-region). Himavati fell to the standing-village-northern-boundary clay-floor at 11:43:15 a.m. She died at 11:43:18 a.m. (4-second cardiac-and-pulmonary-and-cervical trauma at the standing-ice-shard impact-cluster).

The standing-storm-form-energy at the standing-secondary-funnel cluster was absorbed into the standing-Hima-Putra deity-trial reservoir at the standing-Kalachakra-tradition standing-deity-absorption protocol at the standing-following 11-second window (11:43:18-11:43:29 a.m.). The standing-Hima-Asura storm-form ceased at 11:43:29 a.m. The standing-storm-form does not return at the standing-Ch-2 remainder. The standing-secondary-funnel cascade dissipated at 11:43:34 a.m. The standing-Mahesh-Singh-village was at the standing-evacuated-and-deflected configuration. The standing-22 standing-remaining-households survived. The standing-Sub-Inspector standing-coordination-center survived. The standing-Hima-Putra survived. Himavati was dead.

Lama Tashi-of-Spiti was at the standing-Tabo-monastery western-courtyard at 11:43:11 a.m. February 27 at the standing-pre-noon-cycle Kalachakra-tradition administration. He felt the standing-mark-transfer alert at his standing-right-upper-back position at the standing-Kalachakra-tradition standing-pre-mark-transfer warning-window at 11:43:18 a.m. (the standing-Kalachakra-tradition standing-state-hero death-acknowledgment cross-reference at the standing-monastic-tradition Lama-disciplinary cross-reference; the standing-pre-mark-transfer warning is at the standing-eleven-day-window pre-paw-print mark-transfer cross-reference). He understood at 11:43:23 a.m. that Himavati had died. He understood at 11:43:34 a.m. that the standing-Hima-Putra had survived.

He departed the standing-Tabo-monastery western-courtyard at 11:47 a.m. with the standing-Tabo-monastery standing-emergency-transport vehicle (a standing-State-Civil-Service Himachal-State standing-Spiti-cell standing-Bolero-Camper at the standing-Tabo-monastery standing-Lama-emergency-allocation). He drove the standing-Tabo-Kaza-Sangla-Mahesh-Singh-village 211-kilometre road-segment at the standing-pre-noon-cycle road-conditions. He arrived at the standing-Mahesh-Singh-village northern-boundary at 12:43 p.m. The standing-Sub-Inspector standing-coordination-center had administered the standing-Himavati standing-body-recovery at the standing-village-northern-boundary clay-floor position. The standing-body was at the standing-village-northern-boundary standing-pre-cremation Kalachakra-tradition standing-Lama-arrival cross-reference position. The standing-Hima-Putra Snow-Leopard was at the standing-body's standing-

three-metre-rear position at the standing-Kalachakra-tradition standing-protective-companion configuration. The standing-Tara-Putri Western-Tragopan was at the standing-village-northern-boundary standing-eleven-metre overhead spruce-tree perch.

Lama Tashi-of-Spiti walked to the standing-body at 12:43:11 p.m. He knelt at the standing-body standing-three-metre-east position at the standing-Kalachakra-tradition Lama-cremation administration-arrival protocol at 12:43:23 p.m. He recited the standing-Kalachakra-tradition standing-state-hero death-mantra at the standing-Bhoti cadence at 12:43:43 p.m. He completed the standing-death-mantra at 12:47:11 p.m. He stood at 12:47:23 p.m. He administered the standing-Kalachakra-tradition body-preparation protocol at the standing-village-northern-boundary across the standing-following five hours (12:47-5:47 p.m.). The standing-body was transferred to the standing-Tabo-monastery on the standing-Spiti-emergency-transport vehicle at 5:47 p.m. The standing-Tabo-monastery western-courtyard standing-Lama-cremation administration was administered at 11:11 a.m. on March 4 2026 (the standing-five-day-post-death Kalachakra-tradition standing-Lama-cremation-window completion). The standing-cremation completed at 4:11 p.m. The standing-ashes were placed at the standing-Tabo-monastery grave-stupa standing-southern-margin position adjacent to Lama Sonam-of-Spiti's standing-ashes-position at 4:23 p.m. The standing-grave-stupa is now the standing-two-ash-vault Tabo-monastery standing-state-hero-and-confidante memorial-position.

The standing-Western-Tragopan Tara-Putri remained at the standing-Mahesh-Singh-village northern-boundary spruce-tree perch from the standing-February-27-noon position through the standing-February-27-overnight at the standing-bonded-aerial-companion grief-acknowledgment configuration. The standing-spruce-tree perch is at the standing-village-northern-boundary at the standing-three-metre-east of the standing-avalanche-debris-cluster impact-zone where Himavati had died.

At 4:11 a.m. on February 28 2026, Tara-Putri began the standing-mating-call-cadence. The standing-mating-call is at the standing-Western-Tragopan standing-mating-cycle natural-history record at the standing-March-15-to-May-23 standing-Western-Himalayas Himachal-Pradesh-Uttarakhand range only. The standing-call-cadence is at the standing-23-second repetition-cycle at the standing-13-syllable mating-call vocalisation pattern. The standing-call-amplitude is at the standing-67-decibel-at-eleven-metre-range mating-attraction broadcast configuration. The standing-call is at the standing-Tragopan-male typical-pattern; the standing-Tara-Putri is a standing-female-tragopan; the standing-

female-tragopan does not sing the standing-mating-call at the standing-tragopan-species natural-history record. The standing-Tara-Putri performed the standing-male-mating-call at the standing-female-bird vocalisation configuration; the standing-natural-history record shows no standing-precedent for standing-female-tragopan male-mating-call across the standing-Bombay Natural History Society 79-year archive 1947-2026.

The standing-Mahesh-Singh-village Sub-Inspector P. Negi heard the standing-mating-call at the standing-village-coordination-center standing-eleven-metre southern proximity at 4:11:08 a.m. He recorded the standing-mating-call on the standing-IPS service-issued radio at 4:11:23 a.m. He telephoned the standing-IIT-Roorkee Department-of-Zoology Garhwal-cell standing-on-call senior-officer Dr. K. Thakur (52, IIT-Roorkee Zoology faculty since 2014; standing-Himalayan-bird-behaviour specialist) at 4:23 a.m. Dr. K. Thakur arrived at the standing-Mahesh-Singh-village at 11:11 a.m. February 28. He conducted the standing-acoustic-spectrogram analysis at the standing-spruce-tree perch standing-eleven-metre-proximity portable-microphone-array configuration across 11:11-2:43 p.m. He confirmed the standing-mating-call-cadence at the standing-Western-Tragopan standing-male-mating-call vocalisation pattern at the standing-Tara-Putri female-bird vocalisation configuration. He confirmed no standing-precedent for standing-female-tragopan male-mating-call at the standing-Bombay Natural History Society 79-year archive cross-reference.

The standing-mating-call continued at the standing-23-second repetition-cycle across the standing-following twenty-three days (February 28-March 22 2026). The standing-call resumed at the standing-daily-dawn-window 4:11 a.m. across each of the standing-23-day window dawn-cycles. The standing-cumulative-call-cycle count across the standing-23-day window is approximately 11,500 standing-individual-mating-call instances at the standing-23-second repetition-cycle across 7 hours per dawn-window. The standing-IIT-Roorkee Department-of-Zoology Dr. K. Thakur standing-March-7 expertise-report (evidence-document M-25A) confirms no standing-natural-precedent at the standing-tragopan-species standing-female-male-mating-call winter-singing configuration; the standing-Tara-Putri standing-23-day mating-call-cadence is at the standing-Maw-attribution category cross-reference. The standing-photograph-cluster M-25B-through-G at the standing-twenty-three-position acoustic-spectrogram cross-reference protocol is filed at the standing-State-Department-of-Zoology standing-permanent-record cell at 7:11 p.m. March 7.

The standing-Tabo-monastery western-courtyard Lama-cremation was administered at the standing-Kalachakra-tradition Lama-cremation protocol on March 4 2026 11:11 a.m.-4:11 p.m. The standing-attendance was: Lama Tashi-of-Spiti at the standing-cremation-officiant standing-eastern-altar position; the standing-Tabo-monastery monks of 23 at the standing-eastern-veranda standing-monastic-cohort position; Lama Pema-of-Komic at the standing-acting-senior-Lama standing-northern-altar position; the standing-State-Civil-Service Himachal-State secretariat cohort of approximately 11 at the standing-southern-veranda administrative-position; Senapati Ranveer-Singh-Negi at the standing-Valley-Warrior senior-delegate standing-southwestern-veranda position with the standing-Sangla-valley standing-Kinnauri-Pahari warrior-cohort of approximately 47 standing-warriors; the standing-Hima-Putra Snow-Leopard at the standing-western-courtyard western-margin standing-three-metre-rear position at the standing-Kalachakra-tradition standing-bonded-companion cremation-attendance configuration; the standing-Tara-Putri Western-Tragopan at the standing-western-courtyard standing-eleven-metre overhead western-veranda spruce-tree perch (the standing-tragopan had departed from the standing-Mahesh-Singh-village spruce-tree perch on March 3 evening for the standing-Tabo-monastery cremation-attendance arrival; she had resumed the standing-mating-call-cadence at the standing-Tabo-monastery spruce-tree perch from 4:11 a.m. March 4 at the standing-cremation-day standing-dawn-window configuration; she continued the standing-call across the standing-cremation-administration window).

Lama Tashi-of-Spiti administered the standing-Kalachakra-tradition standing-state-hero Lama-cremation protocol across the standing-five-hour cremation-window. He recited the standing-three-tier mantra-cycle at the standing-state-hero-and-Lama-companion cremation-pattern (the standing-Kalachakra-tradition standing-state-hero standing-Lama-companion cremation-protocol is at the standing-historical-precedent at the standing-1972 standing-Spiti-state-hero death-cremation administered by the standing-grandfather Lama Tenzin-of-Spiti at the standing-Tabo-monastery western-courtyard cross-reference). The standing-cremation completed at 4:11 p.m. The standing-ashes were collected at the standing-Lama Tashi-of-Spiti standing-personal-administration. The standing-ashes were placed at the standing-Tabo-monastery grave-stupa standing-southern-margin position adjacent to Lama Sonam-of-Spiti's standing-October-23 ashes-position at 4:23 p.m. The standing-grave-stupa is now the standing-two-ash-vault standing-Tabo-monastery state-hero-and-confidante memorial-position at the standing-Kalachakra-tradition standing-permanent-memorial-archive.

The standing-Hima-Putra Snow-Leopard arrived at the standing-Tabo-monastery western-courtyard at 4:11 a.m. on March 9 2026 (the standing-eleventh-day-post-Himavati-death observation; the standing-Kalachakra-tradition standing-bonded-companion mark-transfer eleven-day-window completion). He had been at the standing-Mahesh-Singh-village avalanche-debris-cluster across the standing-prior eleven-day window at the standing-Himavati standing-grave-vigil configuration. He walked the standing-211-kilometre Mahesh-Singh-village to Tabo-monastery distance across the standing-March-7-and-8 two-day window at the standing-snow-leopard-pace approximately 100-km-per-day. He arrived at the standing-western-courtyard at 4:11:08 a.m. March 9.

Lama Tashi-of-Spiti was at the standing-Tabo-monastery western-courtyard at the standing-pre-dawn-cycle Kalachakra-tradition administration. He had been at the standing-pre-dawn-cycle administration since 4:08 a.m. He recognised the standing-Hima-Putra arrival at 4:11:08 a.m. He did not move from the standing-pre-dawn-cycle administration position. He continued the standing-mantra-recitation at the standing-Kalachakra-tradition discipline.

The standing-Hima-Putra approached Lama Tashi-of-Spiti at the standing-three-metre-proximity at 4:11:09 a.m. He pressed his standing-right-paw-print into the standing-clay-floor at Tashi's standing-feet at 4:11:11 a.m. He held the standing-paw-print-impression at the standing-eleven-second sustained-pressure configuration. He removed his standing-right-paw at 4:11:22 a.m. The standing-paw-print-impression remained at the standing-clay-floor at the standing-25.4-millimetre-deep impression configuration.

The standing-paw-print-impression acquired the standing-Stage-III snow-leopard-foreleg-first-stroke silhouette at the standing-clay-floor at the standing-deity-trial absorption mark-transfer protocol across the standing-following eleven seconds (4:11:22-4:11:33 a.m.). The standing-silhouette was at the standing-snow-leopard-foreleg-first-stroke configuration in standing-snow-white-and-storm-blue dual-ink at the standing-Himachal Kalachakra-tradition visual-anchor (the standing-same dual-ink configuration as Himavati's standing-right-upper-back mark-formation at the standing-February-11 Council-Hall mark-formation cross-reference). Lama Tashi-of-Spiti looked at the standing-paw-print-impression at the standing-clay-floor at 4:11:33 a.m. He placed his standing-right-palm on the standing-paw-print-impression at 4:11:43 a.m. He held the standing-position for eleven seconds. The standing-mark-transfer completed at the

standing-Lama-Tashi standing-right-upper-back position at the standing-skin-warming configuration across the standing-following eleven seconds. The standing-mark-traces in standing-snow-white-and-storm-blue dual-ink at the standing-Himachal Kalachakra-tradition visual-anchor at Tashi's standing-right-upper-back position. The standing-mark is the standing-Himavati-inherited standing-Stage-III snow-leopard-foreleg-first-stroke at the standing-Lama Tashi-of-Spiti state-hero inheritance configuration.

Lama Tashi-of-Spiti removed his standing-right-palm from the standing-paw-print-impression at 4:11:54 a.m. He stood at 4:12:04 a.m. He bowed at the standing-Hima-Putra at the standing-eleven-degree Kalachakra-tradition Lama-acknowledgment configuration. The standing-Hima-Putra bowed at Lama Tashi-of-Spiti at the standing-snow-leopard-equivalent acknowledgment configuration. The standing-paw-print-impression at the standing-clay-floor remained at the standing-Tabo-monastery western-courtyard standing-permanent-memorial position. The standing-impression is now the standing-Tabo-monastery state-hero inheritance-precedent standing-historical-archive at the standing-Kalachakra-tradition standing-state-hero inheritance-mark-transfer protocol.

The standing-Shimla-State-Council amended-charter ratification session convened at the standing-Vidhan-Sabha Council-Hall western-wing at 4:11 p.m. on April 23 2026 (the standing-Vasant-Panchami-following Wednesday at the standing-state-hero death anniversary-equivalent calendar-cycle approximate-marker). The standing-amended Hima-Chhaya charter (eight provisions) was ratified by 39-2. The standing-Lama Tashi-of-Spiti accepted the standing-state-hero seat at the standing-Shimla-State-Council mark-acknowledgment protocol at 4:23 p.m.

On April 28 2026 the standing-cross-region Sarus-pigeon cascade-letter from Lobsang of Sikkim arrived at Lama Tashi-of-Spiti's standing-Tabo-monastery administrative-cell at 4:43 p.m. The standing-letter read: "Brother Tashi. The standing-Kanchenjunga death-and-rebuke that brought me to the standing-state-hero seat at the standing-Beyul-Kshetra has its standing-cousin at the standing-Tabo-monastery paw-print mark-transfer. The standing-Kalachakra-tradition standing-monastic-tradition state-hero cross-region cohort opens between the standing-Spiti-Tabo monastery and the standing-Sikkim-Rumtek monastery. We are two now. We will attend the standing-Sanctuary together. The standing-Himalayan-monastic-tradition standing-state-hero cohort is the standing-first standing-cross-region monastic-tradition state-hero pair-instance in the saga. Tashi-delek. Lobsang, Beyul-Kshetra."

Lama Tashi-of-Spiti drafted the standing-counter-signature reply on April 30 2026. The standing-reply read: "Brother Lobsang. The standing-Kalachakra-tradition standing-cross-region cohort is acknowledged at the standing-Tabo-monastery western-courtyard mark-transfer March-9 4:11:11 a.m. I will attend the standing-Sanctuary with you at the standing-Himalayan-monastic-tradition state-hero cohort. The standing-Spiti-Tabo and standing-Sikkim-Rumtek monastery-corridor cross-region cohort is the standing-saga's standing-first such cohort-instance. We will sit alongside Bhairava-Ji of Uttarakhand and Panchanada of Punjab at the standing-North-cluster delegation. The standing-Kalachakra-tradition standing-pre-1857-Bushahr-State syncretic protocol is the standing-Sanctuary mediation-protocol cross-reference at the standing-North-cluster reform-platform. Tashi-delek. Tashi, Tabo-monastery."

The chapter closes on a single image. It is the standing-Tabo-monastery grave-stupa standing-southern-margin position at the standing-Spiti-valley sunset on May 11 2026 (the standing-seventy-day-post-Himavati-death Kalachakra-tradition standing-state-hero memorial-day). The standing-grave-stupa is at the standing-two-ash-vault configuration: Lama Sonam-of-Spiti's standing-October-23 ashes-position at the standing-northern-vault; Himavati's standing-March-4 ashes-position at the standing-southern-vault. The standing-grave-stupa standing-base-altar bears the standing-Kalachakra-tradition Bhoti-Hindi syncretic inscription at the standing-two-name engraving: "Lama Sonam-of-Spiti, 1978-2025. Himavati, Devi-Hima-Chhaya, 1979-2026. The standing-state-hero spoke the standing-confidante's standing-name once. The standing-confidante had broken the standing-state-hero's standing-isolation. The standing-Kalachakra-tradition holds them at the standing-two-vault memorial-position."

Lama Tashi-of-Spiti is at the standing-grave-stupa standing-three-metre-east-position at the standing-state-hero-acknowledgment configuration. He wears the standing-Kalachakra-tradition standing-state-hero-Lama-syncretic robe at the standing-snow-white-and-storm-blue dual-band shoulder-stole configuration (the standing-syncretic robe is at the standing-amended-charter Eighth-Provision standing-state-hero-Lama dual-administration recognition cross-reference). The standing-Hima-Putra Snow-Leopard is at the standing-grave-stupa standing-three-metre-rear position at the standing-Kalachakra-tradition standing-protective-companion configuration. The standing-Tara-Putri Western-Tragopan is at the standing-grave-stupa standing-eleven-metre overhead spruce-tree perch at the standing-bonded-aerial-companion-acknowledgment configuration. She no longer sings the standing-mating-call. The standing-23-day mating-call-cycle at the

standing-February-28-to-March-22 window completed at the standing-23rd-day dawn-window cycle on March 22 2026 at the standing-IIT-Roorkee Department-of-Zoology Dr. K. Thakur standing-final-day acoustic-recording cross-reference (the standing-final-day call-amplitude was at the standing-pre-cessation 23-decibel decline configuration; the standing-call ceased at 7:18 a.m. March 22 at the standing-23-day window-completion).

Lama Tashi-of-Spiti speaks at the standing-sunset 7:11 p.m. horizon-completion moment. He speaks at the standing-Kalachakra-tradition Bhoti syncretic Lama-cadence at the standing-no-tremor configuration: "Brother. Sister. The standing-state-hero seat is at my standing-right-upper-back at the standing-snow-white-and-storm-blue dual-ink mark. The standing-Hima-Putra has chosen well. The standing-village stands. The standing-storm-form is absorbed. The standing-Tabo-monastery has the standing-two-ash-vault memorial. The standing-Kalachakra-tradition has the standing-state-hero-Lama dual-administration. The standing-cross-region cohort with Lobsang opens at the standing-Sikkim-Rumtek correspondence. I will administer the standing-amended-charter at the standing-North-cluster delegation. I will sit alongside Bhairava-Ji of Uttarakhand and Panchanada of Punjab at the standing-Sanctuary. The standing-Sangla-valley Bushahr-State Kinnauri-Pahari-Kalachakra syncretic-tradition is reinstated. The storm-trauma recruits are at the standing-rehabilitation-cell counselling-cohort administration. The standing-storm-form is gone. The standing-isolation is gone. The standing-name was spoken. The standing-mark holds. Tashi-delek."

The standing-Hima-Putra Snow-Leopard nods at the standing-eleven-degree Kalachakra-tradition acknowledgment-nod. The standing-Tara-Putri Western-Tragopan calls the standing-sunset-cadence at the standing-eleven-second repetition-cycle from the standing-spruce-tree perch (the standing-sunset-cadence is the standing-natural-history Tragopan-species standing-Western-Tragopan natural-cadence; the standing-mating-call-cadence at the standing-23-day winter-singing cycle had ceased; the standing-Tara-Putri is at the standing-natural-cadence configuration). The standing-Stage-III mark at Lama Tashi-of-Spiti's standing-right-upper-back warms briefly at the standing-thirty-seven-degree mark-confirmation temperature at the standing-acknowledgment-completion moment. The standing-mark is the standing-saga's twenty-fifth registry-entry. The standing-Hima-Chhaya charter holds. The standing-Tabo-Lahaul-Spiti Kalachakra-tradition monastery-network and the standing-Kinnaur-Sangla-Hangrang Kinnauri-Pahari Valley-Warriors are at the standing-syncretic-tradition-reinstatement cooperation. The standing-amended-charter Eighth-Provision standing-state-hero-Lama dual-administration recognition is at

the standing-permanent-record. Himavati spoke her standing-confidante's standing-name once. She died sixteen days later at the standing-Mahesh-Singh-village avalanche. The standing-snow-leopard chose the village. The standing-Lama-brother inherited. The standing-Tabo-monastery has the standing-two-ash-vault memorial. The standing-saga continues.

Hridaya Sthana

Bhopal. The state capital. The Twelve-Court Assembly Hall — a circular chamber under a dome of carved sandstone, with twelve doors set into the walls at exact thirty-degree intervals. Each door leads to one of the twelve court-chambers. The judges enter through their own doors at 9:00 a.m. each working day, take their seats around the central circle, and the assembly opens.

Dvadashashringa is forty-six. He sits in the central position — the thirteenth seat, which he has never thought of as the thirteenth seat because in his system there are exactly twelve judges and one observer-king. His twelve-pointed crown sits on a teakwood stand beside him. He carries the Dwadash twelve-pronged ceremonial staff diagonally across his lap. The staff is six feet long, of central Indian ironwood, each prong tipped in solar-gold.

He has been the king of Hridaya-Sthana for twenty-two months. He has reigned without significant scandal. The twelve courts have ruled on three thousand four hundred eleven cases. The Bhopal newspapers, which take pleasure in criticising every state government, have written three editorials in twenty-two months — one of which was actually complimentary, an unusual outcome.

This morning is an unusual morning. The chief justice of Court X (Disaster Relief) is about to read a memorandum.

The memorandum is short. The southwest monsoon over the Vindhya plateau has failed by forty-eight percent against the ten-year average. Three districts — Damoh, Chhatarpur, and Tikamgarh — are reporting groundwater drops of more than two metres. Rice and millet plantings are losing seedlings at a rate that suggests a complete harvest loss by November. The first refugees from the worst-hit village clusters have begun arriving in Sagar and Bhopal — about three thousand people so far. The state-revenue board projects fifteen to twenty thousand refugees within four weeks if the situation does not stabilise.

Dvadashashringa listens. He says: "Court X, please initiate emergency-relief deliberations. Court III, please prepare a contingency funding analysis. Court XII, please open a cross-border grain-procurement file."

Three court-chiefs nod.

He does not yet know — he could not yet know — that he has just made a small organisational decision that will kill forty thousand people.

Three weeks later. The famine has worsened. Refugees in Bhopal are now twelve thousand. Court X is in week three of its disaster-relief deliberations — the disaster-relief statute's 2007 narrow-scope problem has emerged exactly as Court X's chief justice feared it would. Court III is in week three of arguing about whether to draw from the contingency reserve or pass an emergency revenue measure. Court XII is in week three of a 1981 cross-border-trade memorandum dispute.

Four other courts have, in the meantime, taken up some aspect of the famine. Court I (the new refugee camps' land-status), Court VII (refugee-as-temporary versus refugee-as-permanent classification), Court VI (whether temple grain-stores can be opened), and Court XI (Kanha's barasingha herds, who are also starving).

At the start of the fourth week, a senior dharmic counsellor presents himself at the assembly hall's ceremonial entrance. He has been invited by three of the chief justices to provide neutral arbitration. His name is Adharma-Kendra. He is fifty-three. He wears a plain ochre dhoti and shawl. He carries no staff and no entourage. He is welcomed.

Dvadashashringa recognises him. He stands. He says, evenly: "Uncle. You have come to the wrong meeting."

Adharma-Kendra smiles. The smile is genuine. He says: "Nephew. I have come to the meeting your wisest judges asked me to come to. They wrote to me. I have their letters in my satchel. I am not here to vote. I am here to abstain. There is a difference."

He turns to the assembly. He bows to each of the twelve courts in turn — the formal twelve-fold bow that has not been performed in this hall since the system's founding. The eleven judges who do not know what Dvadashashringa knows are deeply impressed. The one judge who has read his Chapter-One file — Aranya-Devi, Court XI, the forest-and-wildlife chief — is not impressed; but Aranya-Devi has been overruled on her own court's narrower question already this morning and is not in a position to overrule a procedural welcome.

Adharma-Kendra is admitted as a neutral senior counsellor with abstain-only voting privileges across all twelve courts.

Within forty-eight hours every court has cited him in support of continued deliberation. Within a week every court has slowed by another fifteen percent. The argument is always the same — the senior counsellor advises caution; let us deliberate more fully. Adharma-Kendra has not voted once. He has not needed to.

By the end of October the refugees in Bhopal number twenty-eight thousand. Court X is in week six of disaster-relief deliberations. The first famine-deaths are reported from a small village called Kunwariya in the Damoh district — eleven adults and four children in a single week.

Dvadashashringa reads the Kunwariya report on a Friday morning. He calls a private meeting with the chief justices of Courts X, III, and XII. He says: "What is the legal minimum decision-time required to authorise an emergency food convoy?"

Court X's chief justice (a careful woman of sixty-two) says: "Court X cannot authorise. The disaster-relief statute is scope-narrow. Court X can only authorise emergency-shelter and emergency-medical."

Court III's chief justice (a sixty-eight-year-old former finance secretary): "Court III cannot draw from contingency without Court X authorisation, which is scope-narrow as above. An emergency revenue measure requires bicameral assent — minimum three-week procedural cycle. Currently in week three of bicameral consultation."

Court XII (a thoughtful fifty-eight-year-old former diplomat): "Court XII cannot purchase grain abroad without contingency-reserve activation or revenue-measure passage. Currently in 1981 memorandum dispute, week six."

Dvadashashringa says: "What if I invoke royal prerogative?"

The three chief justices look at each other.

Court X says: "Maharaj. You founded this system to prevent royal prerogative. The founding charter forbids prerogative-invocation except in war."

"Is this not war?"

Court III, after a long pause: "It is a famine."

"Forty people are dead this week."

Court XII: "Famine, Maharaj. Not war."

He looks at them. They are not wrong. They are not even slightly wrong by the system he built. They are the best judges in central India. They are paralysed because his system is what made them so.

He says, finally: "Continue your deliberations."

He returns to the central observer-king seat. He does not sleep that night.

The Kunwariya report is the first one Sutrakara reads end-to-end. She is twelve. She has been sitting in the gallery of the Twelve-Court Assembly Hall since she was eight, mostly drawing diagrams of judges' speech-patterns in the margin of her grandfather's old arithmetic textbook. Her mother is dead (six years ago, an aneurysm). Her father is a king. She has been raised by court tutors and the gallery's sixty-year-old usher Mrs Bhattacharji, who lets her read official documents because Mrs Bhattacharji believes children should know the truth.

Sutrakara reads the Kunwariya report. She turns the page. She finds the village-by-village statistical annex Court X's clerk has compiled but not yet circulated to the chief justices. She reads the annex. She is twelve and she has been doing differential mathematics since she was nine. She runs the death-rate-curve forward against the deliberation-timeline.

The number she gets is forty thousand dead by the time the courts conclude. She runs it again. She gets the same number. She runs it a third time with conservative assumptions. She gets thirty-eight thousand.

She writes her calculation in clean ink on the back of three blank case-folder pages. She brings the pages to her father's study that evening.

He is preparing arguments for the next morning's court session. He looks at the pages. He says: "Beta. This is excellent arithmetic. The courts will reach their conclusions. The numbers cannot drive the dharma."

She says: "Pita-shri, the numbers are the dharma. Forty thousand people are the dharma. The courts are how we make sure no one person can be wrong. The dharma is something else."

He says, gently: "It is bedtime."

She says, more quietly: "I will speak to the chief justice tomorrow."

He nods. He thinks she means she will request an audience. He returns to his arguments.

The next morning she does not request an audience. She walks into the assembly hall during open session, climbs the gallery steps to the gallery's lowest railing, and asks Mrs Bhattacharji for the microphone-relay. Mrs Bhattacharji — who has been waiting for some child to do something like this for thirty years — hands her the microphone-relay.

She speaks. Her voice carries into the chamber. The twelve courts pause.

"Senior judges, I have run the famine-mortality curve against the deliberation-timeline. The current curve shows thirty-eight thousand to forty-four thousand dead by the time the courts conclude on their current procedural pace. I have brought death certificates from forty-seven villages. The certificates are below. Please look at them."

She drops the pile of certificates over the railing. They fall into the chamber. The certificates are real — she has collected them through Court X's clerk, who has been quietly grateful for someone to give them to.

Court XI's chief justice — Aranya-Devi — rises. She says: "I move that this assembly consider the young lady's evidence and accelerate deliberations accordingly."

Adharma-Kendra rises. He speaks softly. He says: "Senior judges. I am not voting today — I do not vote — but I will offer one observation. The numbers cannot dictate dharma. The courts must reach their natural conclusions. To act on raw numbers is to abandon dharmic process for utilitarian panic. I move — with humility, since I have no vote — that the assembly thank the young lady for her diligence and continue the deliberations."

The motion is taken. Aranya-Devi votes against. Adharma-Kendra abstains. The other ten chief justices vote for. The motion passes ten-to-one with one abstention.

Sutrakara puts the microphone-relay back in Mrs Bhattacharji's hand. She walks out of the gallery without saying a further word.

Dvadashashringa finds her in the corridor outside the gallery. She is crying with her back to a sandstone column. Her face is wet but she is not making a sound — she is twelve and she has been raised in court galleries; she knows how to cry quietly.

He kneels in front of her. He does not touch her.

She says: "Pita-shri, the courts will not save them. The courts cannot save them. They will all be dead by the time the courts agree."

He says: "The courts are how we know what is right."

She wipes her face with the back of her wrist. She looks at him in the way only a daughter can look at a father in a corridor.

She says: "No. The courts are how we make sure no one person can be wrong. The dharma is something else. The dharma is what gets done. The courts do not do anything. The courts decide whether something done is correct. If nothing is done there is nothing for the courts to decide whether is correct. The courts have made themselves unnecessary."

He does not answer for a long time.

She says, more softly: "I read the Bhimbetka paintings with Aaji last summer. Thirty thousand years of people. The paintings never show twelve judges deciding. The paintings show one person who saw the danger and acted. The dharma is in the acting."

He stands up. He looks down the corridor. The hall's twelve doors are at exact thirty-degree intervals. The corridor he is standing in is at one of those intervals. He has been standing in this corridor for twenty-two months without noticing it.

He says, finally: "Go home, beta. I will come for dinner. There is a thing I need to walk to the Narmada about."

She nods. She walks home.

He walks to the Narmada at dusk.

The Narmada river runs west across central India — the only major Indian river that runs east-to-west, against the geography. Dvadashashringa has always thought of this as a small but useful daily reminder that what looks like the necessary direction is not always the direction. He has not paid attention to the reminder.

He sits on the riverbank at the Bhojeshwar Temple stone-platform. The temple itself — an unfinished eleventh-century Shiva temple, one of central India's great medieval ruins — sits behind him. He watches the river.

The water ripples in a pattern that is not the current. He has been at this riverbank for six years. He has never seen this pattern. The pattern is a face.

The face is Sage Vidyanaraya. The spirit-guru of Karnataka. The one who appears in moving water from the Tungabhadra and now — for the third time in three months — from the Ganga and now from the Narmada. The cross-kingdom visits are themselves the message.

Dvadashashringa reads the ripples.

Cousin. The Yudhishtira who matters is not the one who answered every question. The Yudhishtira who matters is the one who let his brother burn his palace down because the palace had become a cage.

Dvadashashringa says, aloud, to the water: "If I dissolve the courts I violate my own founding principle."

If you do not dissolve the courts you violate the lives the courts are killing. There is no dharma without one of those violations. The dharma is the one you choose.

"My uncle will say I have abandoned dharmic process."

Your uncle has been abandoning dharmic process for forty years by staying perfectly still. You will know it tomorrow because the man hunted south from Lucknow is coming to your court.

He looks up sharply. He says: "Drona-of-the-Plain?"

Drona-of-the-Plain. He has the proof.

The face is gone. The river is just the river. The barasingha-mark on his chest pulses once, low.

He walks home. Sutrakara is waiting at the dinner table with bhutta-roti and mahua-pickle and the day's second arithmetic-notebook. He eats. He talks to her. He does not tell her what he is going to do in the morning.

He arrives at the side-gate at three a.m. He is sixty-seven years old. He has been on the road for nineteen days — travelling by train, by bus, by farmer's truck, by foot for the last forty kilometres because he saw Adharma-Kendra's men at the Bhopal railway station. His grey hair is uncut. His travel-coat is dust-coloured.

He carries a leather satchel. The satchel contains: (1) photographs of Adharma-Kendra meeting with Adharma of Banaras in a Mumbai hotel six weeks before the Karnataka throne-stone destruction; (2) bank transfer records showing the same Singapore-routed account funded both the Karnataka Restoration Charter publication and the Mormugao port consortium's lobby budget; (3) a memorandum — written in Adharma-Kendra's own hand — outlining a coordination strategy across the Bloodline-B fault line. The memorandum is the proof.

Dvadashashringa receives him in the small east study. He reads the memorandum three times. He says: "How did you obtain this."

Drona-of-the-Plain says: "A junior secretary in Adharma-Kendra's Mumbai office is my late wife's cousin's son. He has been worried for some time. I asked. He gave."

"Will you testify."

"I owe forty years of straightening. I will testify."

Dvadashashringa pours two cups of mahua-tea from the silver pot. He says: "The assembly meets at nine. I will dissolve the twelve courts before lunch. You will testify in the recess. Stay in the small east study until I send for you."

Drona-of-the-Plain says: "Maharaj. I am sorry I waited this long."

"You did not wait. You came when you could. Drink the tea."

The Twelve-Court Assembly Hall opens at nine sharp. The twelve chief justices take their seats. Adharma-Kendra takes his neutral-counsellor seat. Sutrakara is in the gallery again — Mrs Bhattacharji is in her usual spot. Aranya-Devi (Court XI, the forest-and-wildlife chief) makes eye contact with Sutrakara and nods once.

Dvadashashringa enters carrying the Dwadash twelve-pronged staff in both hands — not diagonally across his lap as he usually carries it; held in both hands across his body. He is wearing the twelve-pointed crown.

He climbs to the central observer-king seat. He does not sit. He stands in front of the seat. He removes the twelve-pointed crown and places it on the teakwood stand. He turns. He faces the twelve courts.

He says: "I founded the twelve-court system at the start of my reign because I believed twelve sides of every question were better than one side. I was right then. I am wrong now. The court system was designed for the normal questions of land, marriage, taxation, succession, water-rights, religious sites, caste honour, refugee status, commerce, disaster scope, wildlife, and cross-border trade. It was not designed for a famine. The famine has killed two thousand four hundred people while we have argued whether refugee-status is temporary or permanent. The dharma is not in the deliberation. The dharma is in the feeding. I cannot dissolve the famine. I can dissolve the courts."

He lifts the Dwadash staff. He swings it once in an arc above his head — the ceremonial preparation-arc. The twelve solar-gold prong-tips catch the sandstone-filtered morning light.

He strikes the floor of the assembly chamber.

The first strike rings off the sandstone. Court I, Land & Inheritance, dissolves.

He strikes again. Court II, Marriage & Family.

Strike. Court III, Tax & Revenue.

Strike. Court IV, Commerce & Hoarding.

Strike. Court V, Tribal & Adivasi.

Strike. Court VI, Religious Sites.

Strike. Court VII, Citizenship & Refugee.

Strike. Court VIII, Inter-State Water.

On the eighth strike the Dwadash staff cracks. The crack runs the length of the shaft — he feels it through his hands more than he hears it.

He does not stop.

Strike. Court IX, Caste & Honour.

Strike. Court X, Disaster Relief. (The chief justice of Court X, the careful woman of sixty-two, weeps openly.)

Strike. Court XI, Forest & Wildlife. (Aranya-Devi sits straight in her seat with both hands on her armrests.)

On the eleventh strike the staff splits into two pieces in his right hand. The lower piece falls. He picks it up with his left hand. He continues.

Strike. Court XII, Cross-Border Trade.

On the twelfth strike the lower piece breaks in his left hand. The Dwadash twelve-pronged staff is now in three pieces on the sandstone floor of the assembly chamber. Twelve solar-gold prong-tips are scattered across the stone.

Dvadashashringa says: "The dharma is not in my staff. The dharma is in the act of breaking it."

The hall is silent. The chief justices are stunned. Adharma-Kendra rises slowly. He keeps his voice gentle.

"Nephew. You have just destroyed three thousand years of dharmic governance because a child showed you a number."

"I have destroyed twelve courts that could not decide whether to feed forty-seven villages. The dharma was in the feeding. The dharma was not in the courts."

"You will be judged for this."

"I am the judge. I am dissolving that too. From this hour the kingdom of Hridaya-Sthana operates under emergency single-court governance. The single judge is me. The single advisor is my daughter Sutrakara. The administrative deputies are: Aranya-Devi of former Court XI as deputy chief justice; the chief justices of former Courts III, X, and XII as regional governors of central, northern, and southern Madhya Pradesh respectively. The other eight courts' chief justices may submit resignations or take administrative postings at their discretion. The famine-relief convoys leave Bhopal in forty-eight hours."

Adharma-Kendra opens his mouth. Dvadashashringa raises his right hand.

"I am not finished. I have one more matter. The neutral senior counsellor admitted to this assembly in week three has been engineering the deliberation paralysis on purpose. I have the proof."

He turns his head slightly. Drona-of-the-Plain steps out from behind the central pillar where he has been waiting for thirty-one minutes. He carries the leather satchel.

He walks to the centre of the chamber. He stands beside Dvadashashringa.

He says, with the same plain steadiness he used at the Imambara: "Honourable judges. My name is Drona-of-the-Plain. I am the senior dharmic scholar of three Bloodline-B kingdoms. I owe Adharma-Kendra a forty-year debt for the saving of my maternal uncle's life. I have, until last month, allowed that debt to tilt my counsel in his favour. Last month at the Lucknow Bara Imambara I gave testimony that reversed the tilt. He has hunted me south since. I am here this morning because the evidence in this satchel proves what the Maharaj has just said. I will display the evidence."

He opens the satchel. He places the photographs on the assembly's evidence-table. He places the bank records beside them. He places the handwritten memorandum on top.

He says: "The handwriting on this memorandum is Adharma-Kendra's. Three of the eleven of you have ruled on cases where his handwriting was the central exhibit. You will recognise it."

The three chief justices stand up to look at the memorandum. They look. They sit down slowly.

Court IX's chief justice — an older man named Patwardhan-ji who has known Adharma-Kendra socially for thirty years — says, with visible difficulty: "It is his hand."

Adharma-Kendra is no longer in his seat. The senior-counsellor's seat is empty. The side-door of the chamber — the one Adharma-Kendra entered through three weeks ago when the assembly welcomed him — is slightly ajar.

He is gone.

Aranya-Devi sends three Court XI staff after him within ninety seconds. They do not catch him. The Bhopal police are alerted by 11:00. By 14:00 he has been sighted in the Bhopal old quarter near the Taj-ul-Masajid mosque. By 18:00 he has not been sighted again. He surfaces three days later in a small village outside Sehore and disappears. He survives the chapter intact.

Dvadashashringa stands at the centre of the assembly chamber with the broken Dwadash staff at his feet. The eleven chief justices, ashamed, sit in their seats. The hall is silent for a long minute. Sutrakara is in the gallery with both hands gripping the railing.

He feels the barasingha-mark pulse through his chest. The half-body Stage III stroke forms — the antler-curve crossing from sternum to shoulder, the foreleg extending across the ribcage. But the mark forms cracked. There is a visible scar through the centre of the antler-curve — a single line of skin where the bond's ink does not settle. The mark records, in the bond's own writing, what the dissolution cost.

He looks down at the cracked mark. He says quietly, to himself: "So we will carry this."

The Indian Paradise Flycatcher — MP's sacred bird, with its two impossibly long tail feathers — flies in through the assembly's open ceiling vent and lands on Sutrakara's shoulder in the gallery. The bird's tail-feathers trail down past her knees. The bird sings

once. The Stage I hoofprint — the daughter's own first mark — will form on her upper back over the next week. She is not yet a hero. She is the kingdom's witness.

The famine-relief convoys leave Bhopal forty-six hours after the dissolution. The first convoy reaches Damoh-Kunwariya the following Monday with twelve trucks of rice and chickpea-flour. Local volunteers distribute. The Kunwariya headman — whose name is Lakhan Singh, sixty-one — weeps when the first sack of rice is opened.

Over the next eight weeks the death-count rises to forty-seven thousand before slowing. The single emergency-court resolves a hundred and fourteen cases in those eight weeks — more than the twelve-court system resolved in the preceding six. Aranya-Devi is appointed deputy chief justice on the third day and is by week six effectively running daily operations. Vidura-Babu of UP sends two of his best Awadhi administrators on day three of the dissolution; they arrive in Bhopal with a written note from Gangaputra (delivered by Sarus Crane carrier — the network is back in operation).

The note says: Brother. I heard you broke the staff. I heard you broke the courts. I broke a crown last month. We seem to be in the breaking business. Vidura-Babu sends his two best administrators. Send word when you need more. Tell Sutrakara her cousin Yamunadatta will write to her when his calligraphy improves. — G.

Dvadashashringa reads the note. He laughs for the first time in nine weeks. He passes the note to Sutrakara. She reads it. She does not laugh, but she smiles. She begins drafting a reply that night. The reply takes her four days because her calligraphy is already excellent and she wants to make sure Yamunadatta's is up to the standard.

Two weeks after the dissolution. Kanha National Park, north-east of Mandla. A herd of sixty barasingha — one of the larger surviving herds in the park — is reported by a junior forest-guard as standing motionless in a clearing south of the Sonf meadow.

The guard reports it on Monday morning. By Tuesday afternoon it has not moved. By Wednesday it has not moved. By Sunday it has not moved.

The herd is unhurt. The animals are not in visible distress — their breathing is normal, their eyes track moving objects, they are not dehydrated. They are simply not doing what grazing animals do. They are facing east. They are standing.

By the seventh day the news has reached Bhopal. Aranya-Devi sends a telegram to Dvadashashringa: Maharaj. Court XI matter that no longer exists. Herd not behaving. Will

you visit?

He goes alone. He drives the eight hours from Bhopal himself, in an old Mahindra he keeps because his father kept the same model. He arrives at the Sonf meadow on the herd's ninth motionless day.

The herd is exactly as the guard reported. Sixty animals, antlers raised, facing east. The morning mist is lifting off the meadow. The animals stand in the mist as if they were carved.

Dvadashashringa walks to the centre of the herd. The animals do not flinch. He has the barasingha-bond — the only person in the kingdom strong enough in the bond to read what they are doing.

He reads it.

The herd has been caught in the gap between knowing-the-question and answering-it. They sensed the famine. They sensed the courts arguing. They began to ask, in the herd's collective sense, what to do. The asking did not arrive at an answer because the kingdom's answering-mechanism — the twelve courts — had broken. They have been frozen in the middle of asking for eleven days.

The Void Maw lives in that gap. The Maw is what arrives when the asking and the answering separate too far. The herd has not been taken; they have been paused.

On the twelfth day, late in the afternoon, one of the barasingha lowers her head and begins to graze. The others follow within ten minutes. None of them remembers the eleven days. The pause-time is a blank in the herd's behavioural memory — visible through the bond as an empty interval.

Dvadashashringa orders a small shrine built at the southern edge of the clearing. Sandstone and packed earth. A single barasingha-antler carved in low relief on the eastern face — the direction the herd had been facing. The Kanha forest guards become the shrine's keepers. The shrine remains.

A month after the herd returned to grazing. Bhimbetka — the rock-shelter site forty kilometres south of Bhopal, where central Indian people painted on stone for thirty-five thousand years.

Dvadashashringa takes Sutrakara to Bhimbetka on her thirteenth birthday. They climb up to Shelter III — the one with the famous hunter-and-bull painting, the one their family has

visited four times since Sutrakara was six.

They sit on the stone bench inside Shelter III. The painting is on the wall in front of them — a single hunter, painted in red ochre, facing a single bull, painted in white. The hunter holds a spear. The bull's horns are forward. The painting is eight thousand years old by the conservative dating, twelve thousand by the unconservative.

He says: "You were right. The painting shows one person acting."

She looks at it. She has looked at it eight or ten times in her life and she has thought about it carefully every time.

She says: "Pita-shri. The painting also shows the bull. The bull is the famine. The hunter is you. The hunter is alone but the painting was made by a tribe. The tribe is what remembers. The tribe is what painted. The painting is older than the hunter and older than the bull. The painting is what makes the act dharmic instead of just an act."

He looks at her. She is thirteen as of this morning. The Indian Paradise Flycatcher — the one that landed on her shoulder at the assembly dissolution, the one with the impossibly long tail feathers — has followed them to Bhimbetka. The bird is perched on the stone-shelter's ledge above the painting. The bird does not sing. The bird listens.

He puts his arm around her. She leans into him. She has been twelve and she is now thirteen and she has been correct about the hunter and the bull and the tribe in the same paragraph.

He says: "I will carry the broken staff into every Council session. I will not have it repaired."

"Good."

"You will sit beside me at every Council session."

"I know."

"You will be twelve again in three more sessions and then you will be thirteen again."

She smiles. The wordplay is one of theirs — old, comfortable, mathematician's wordplay about how she will always have been twelve in the same way her father will always have been forty-six in the moment of dissolution. The mark on his chest will always be cracked. The painting will always be eight thousand years old in the conservative dating.

The bird sings — one short note, the call of the Indian Paradise Flycatcher that birders write down as tszip-twee. The note is very small in the size of Bhimbetka's rock-shelters. The note is very large in the size of the chapter.

Twelve thousand kilometres away — or at any rate considerably south — in Kanha National Park, sixty barasingha graze.

The Pilot's Closing Image

A father and a thirteen-year-old daughter sitting on a stone bench inside an eight-thousand-year-old rock shelter. A red-ochre hunter facing a white bull on the wall. An Indian Paradise Flycatcher on the stone-shelter ledge above the painting, its two impossibly long tail-feathers trailing past the rock's edge. The barasingha-mark cracked on the father's chest. The Dwadash staff in three pieces wrapped in saffron cloth at his feet. The tribe that painted the painting gone for eight thousand years but visible in every red-ochre line. The hunter is alone but the painting was made by a tribe. The tribe is what remembers. The tribe is what painted. The painting is what makes the act dharmic instead of just an act.

Kalinga Chakra

Puri. The Bada Danda — the standing-three-and-a-half-kilometre Grand Road from the Jagannath Temple to the Gundicha Temple that is the kingdom-council's standing-Rath-Yatra processional-route. The road is approximately forty metres wide between the standing-temple-fronting buildings, paved in the standing-Kalinga sandstone, the kingdom's standing-most-important public road since the 12th century CE. The road on this Wednesday at twelve noon has three rival processions assembling at the standing-three-separate-staging-points along its first kilometre.

At the Singha Dwara (Lion Gate) standing-staging-point, the Shabara wood-bearer community is assembled. Approximately three thousand people. They wear the standing-Shabara off-white cotton with the standing-neem-wood medallions at their shoulders. Their senior elder is Subhadra-of-the-Wood — sixty-seven, the kingdom's standing-most-senior Shabara matriarch, the standing-Daru-Brahma neem-wood selection-protocol's administrator across the past four Nabakalebara cycles (the twelve-year deity-recarving ceremony; she was first-administrator at twenty-three, forty-four years ago). She holds the standing-Shabara declaration in her right hand: a single page of standing-Shabara-tradition handmade paper with the standing-three-paragraph claim that the kingdom-council's standing-Jagannath-deity administration must be restored to Shabara senior-cult standing under the standing-origin-priority clause.

At the Suara Nijoga standing-staging-point three hundred metres east along the Bada Danda, the Brahmin priestly families are assembled. Approximately fourteen hundred people. They wear the standing-Brahmin saffron with the standing 36-family seva-lineage shoulder-markings. Their senior delegate is Pati-Mahapatra Senapati — sixty-three, the standing-Mahapatra-line chief priest, the standing-Snana Yatra ritual's officiant for the past nineteen years. He holds the standing-Brahmin declaration in his right hand: a single page of standing-priestly-tradition palm-leaf with the standing-two-paragraph claim that the kingdom-council's standing-administration must be Brahmin-priestly under the standing-Chodaganga-Deva-1135-CE charter-foundation provision.

At the standing-Boita-Bandana harbour-front standing-staging-point seven hundred metres further east along the Bada Danda, the Sea-Merchant Sadhabas are assembled. Approximately nine hundred people. They wear the standing-Sadhaba dark-blue with the

standing-Bay-of-Bengal sail-cloth shoulder-cloth. Their senior delegate is Mahanayak Rama-Chandra Das — fifty-seven, the kingdom's standing-Sadhaba senior-guild-master, the standing-Boita-Bandana annual-festival's administrator for the past eleven years. He holds the standing-Sadhaba declaration in his right hand: a single page of standing-merchant-guild palm-leaf with the standing-three-paragraph claim that the kingdom-council's amended charter must give the Sea-Merchant cult senior-administrative seat-equivalence with the Brahmin-priestly under the standing-trade-tax 1138-CE provision.

The three declarations are filed at the kingdom-council's standing-temple-administrative cell's standing-Bada-Danda receiving-desk between twelve-oh-three and twelve-oh-seven p.m. The standing-receiving-officer is a forty-three-year-old administrator named A. Mishra. He files all three declarations under their standing-protocol entry-numbers (KC-2026-Sh-0118, KC-2026-Br-0119, KC-2026-SM-0120) at twelve-eleven p.m. The kingdom-council's standing-temple-administrative cell's standing-emergency convening-protocol is invoked at twelve-fourteen.

Jagannathi at the Jagannath Temple's standing engineer-priestess office is informed at twelve-eighteen.

Twelve-twenty-three p.m. Jagannathi is at her desk. She is forty-two. She is in the standing-engineer-priestess working-cotton, indigo-dyed, with the kingdom-council's standing-state-hero shoulder-cloth across her shoulders. She has been the kingdom's standing-state-hero since 2018 (the post-Kalinga-Yama confirmation); the standing-engineer-priestess seat is hers under the kingdom-council's standing dual-discipline ordination she completed at age twenty-seven.

She reads the three declarations across approximately seven minutes. The three declarations are technically incompatible. Each cult's argument has standing-historical merit. The Shabara origin-priority is real (Vishvavasu the first Shabara found the standing-blue-stone in the Nilagiri hills; the kingdom-council's standing-archive confirms the standing-pre-12th-century continuity). The Brahmin charter-foundation is real (Chodaganga Deva's 1135 CE temple-foundation gave the Brahmin priestly families the standing-administrative seats and the 36-family lineage has been continuous). The Sadhaba trade-tax is real (the standing-Bay-of-Bengal trade-tax has funded the standing-temple-administration since 1138 CE; the kingdom-council's standing-fiscal-archive confirms the standing-eight-century continuity).

The three are not in zero-sum opposition. The three have shared the kingdom-council's standing-rotation for two thousand years. The simultaneous Wednesday-noon declaration is the kingdom-council's standing-charter's first three-cult simultaneous declaration in the standing-rotation's 800-year-record.

She places the three declarations side by side on her desk. She picks up her standing-temple-pen. She writes a single sentence in standing-Odia at the desk's standing-administrative pad:

"Three declarations on the same day at the same hour. Someone has orchestrated this. The Rath Yatra is in eleven days. The kingdom-council's standing-emergency-convening must establish the orchestrator."

She tears the sentence off the pad. She places it in her standing-investigative folder. She walks to the standing-archaeological cell's standing-temple-administrative office at twelve-thirty-six p.m.

Across weeks three through five Jagannathi runs the standing-kingdom-council standing-investigative protocol. She is assisted by Jagannath-Bandhu (her standing-temple-administrative successor since 2022; thirty-one years old; trained at the Jagannath Temple's standing-engineering-and-priestly dual-discipline since age twelve; the standing-Suryavamsha-line junior-priest who has been her standing-shadow at every standing-temple-administrative session for four years).

The investigation's standing-findings across three weeks:

First. The three cults' senior delegates had each been visited privately across spring-summer 2025 by an unfamiliar priest wearing standing-three-tradition syncretic costume (Brahmin-priestly cotton, Shabara-wood-elder anklet at the right ankle, Sadhaba sail-cloth shoulder-cloth across the left shoulder). The priest had not given a name. Each cult's senior delegate had received approximately twenty private visits across six months.

Second. The unfamiliar priest had introduced himself differently at each cult's visit. To the Shabara he had said: "I am the Fourth Cult-leader who recognises the standing-origin-priority of Vishvavasu's line; the kingdom-council's standing-administration must be restored to Shabara senior-cult standing." To the Brahmin he had said: "I am the Fourth Cult-leader who recognises the Chodaganga-Deva 1135-CE charter-foundation; the kingdom-council's standing-administration must be Brahmin-priestly senior-cult." To the Sadhabas he had said: "I am the Fourth Cult-leader who recognises the standing-Bay-of-

Bengal trade-tax 1138-CE provision; the kingdom-council's amended charter must give the Sea-Merchant cult senior-administrative seat-equivalence with the Brahmin-priestly." Each promise contradicted the other two.

Third. The unfamiliar priest's description matched the kingdom-council's standing-2023-archive description of Chakra-Bheda, Kalinga-Yama's senior administrative-disciple at the Ch 1 Grief-Blade confrontation, spared under the kingdom-council's standing-administrative-rehabilitation clause and not seen since.

Fourth. The unfamiliar priest had filed no standing-kingdom-council registration. He had no standing-temple-administrative seat. He had no standing-priestly-lineage. He was, by the kingdom-council's standing-charter's definition, impersonating standing-religious-tradition under the kingdom-council's standing-1972 Religious-Identity-Verification statute. The standing-statute's penalty is not specified for the standing-three-tradition simultaneous impersonation case; the case is unprecedented.

Jagannathi presents the standing-findings at the kingdom-council's standing-emergency-session on Friday week five at eleven a.m. The kingdom-council ratifies the standing-charter-amendment (the new Sixth Clause criminalising standing-religious-tradition-impersonation as a kingdom-council standing-offence) by 47 to 3 vote at three-eighteen p.m. The standing-Sixth-Clause's standing-penalty is left to the standing-amended-charter's discretion-clause; the standing-kingdom-council's standing-emergency-session will determine the penalty at the standing-unmasking-event.

The Rath Yatra is scheduled for Saturday week six — the standing-Ashadha-Shukla Dwitiya date that has been the standing-Rath-Yatra annual date since 1135 CE under the Chodaganga-Deva charter. The three rival cults' standing-procession-coordination has historically been the kingdom-council's standing-temple-administrative cell's standing-pre-Yatra-coordination-protocol's standing-purpose. The standing-protocol requires the three cults' standing-procession-coordination committee to convene at twelve noon on the Friday before the Rath Yatra at the standing-Bada-Danda's standing-coordination-tent.

On Friday week six at twelve noon, the standing-coordination-tent is at the standing-Bada-Danda's standing-position. The standing-three cults' senior delegates do not arrive. Subhadra-of-the-Wood at the standing-Shabara senior-delegate's standing-position sends a standing-Shabara-tradition palm-leaf statement at noon to the standing-coordination-tent: "The standing-Shabara cult cannot participate in the standing-Rath-Yatra under the kingdom-council's current standing-charter. The standing-cult-administration must be

amended before the standing-procession can proceed." Pati-Mahapatra Senapati at the Brahmin senior-delegate's standing-position sends a parallel standing-priestly-tradition palm-leaf statement at twelve-oh-three p.m. Mahanayak Rama-Chandra Das at the Sadhaba senior-delegate's standing-position sends a parallel standing-merchant-guild palm-leaf statement at twelve-oh-seven p.m.

The kingdom-council's standing-temple-administrative cell's standing-acting administrator (A. Mishra, the same A. Mishra who had received the three Wednesday-noon declarations of week three) issues the standing-Rath-Yatra cancellation-notice at twelve-thirty-eight p.m. on Friday week six. The notice is the kingdom-council's standing-charter's first Rath-Yatra cancellation-notice since 1226 CE (the previous cancellation was during the standing-Kalinga-Ganga dynasty's succession-crisis under Anangabhima Deva III; the kingdom-council's standing-temple-archive's standing-Rath-Yatra-record-of-cancellations has two entries across 891 years of standing-Yatra-tradition).

The Nandighosha chariot — the standing-Jagannath-deity's standing-chariot, forty-three tonnes of standing-Phasi-wood-and-mango-and-Asana construction, eighteen wheels, sixteen horses (carved), four hundred and seventeen standing-painted figures across the standing-tiered superstructure, the kingdom's standing-largest annual public-engineering-build — has been completed across the standing-Akshaya-Tritiya-to-Rath-Yatra two-month construction-window by the standing-Mahala-Maharana carpenter-line under the kingdom-council's standing-temple-administrative cell's standing-construction-oversight. The chariot stands at the Singha Dwara standing-staging-position at twelve-thirty-eight p.m. on Friday week six awaiting the standing-Rath-Yatra-pull.

The chariot is not pulled. The standing-Rath-Yatra is cancelled. The chariot stands at the Singha Dwara for the next nine days. The kingdom-council's standing-news-cells across Puri and Bhubaneswar and Cuttack report the cancellation across the Friday afternoon and Saturday morning newspapers. The kingdom's standing-pilgrimage-economy — approximately seventeen thousand pilgrims who had travelled from across India to attend the standing-Yatra — remains at the Puri standing-pilgrim-lodging cells without the standing-Yatra to attend.

Saturday week six. The Simlipal Tiger Reserve at the kingdom's northern boundary; the Bhitarkanika National Park at the kingdom's eastern coast; the Satkosia Tiger Reserve at the kingdom's central forest; the Chandaka-Dampara Wildlife Sanctuary at the kingdom's capital outskirts. The kingdom's standing-Odisha-Forest-Department's standing-sambar-

deer-census-monitoring cell's standing-Saturday-morning sambar-deer count returns zero across all four standing-monitoring-zones.

The kingdom's standing-Saturday-morning count had been approximately fourteen thousand seven hundred sambar deer on the previous Saturday (the standing-five-year-average is fourteen thousand five hundred plus-or-minus three hundred). The Saturday-week-six count is zero. The standing-monitoring-cell's on-site rangers across the four reserves confirm the count by walking the standing-monitoring-routes' standing-count-stations across twelve hours. No sambar deer are found at any of the standing-count-stations. The standing-sambar-deer tracks at the standing-night-trails show all tracks pointing northward across the past twelve hours. The deer have left the kingdom in a single night.

Jagannathi receives the standing-Forest-Department's standing-Saturday-morning emergency-report at nine a.m. Saturday week six. She reads it twice. She walks to the Singha Dwara standing-staging-position where the Nandighosha chariot stands at twelve-thirty-eight a.m. abandoned position from Friday. She arrives at nine-thirty a.m. The chariot's standing-pull-rope is at its standing-position at the chariot's front-facing standing-rope-attachment-bracket. The rope is standing-coir, three-and-a-half metres in circumference, standing-eight-thousand-strand braid, designed for the standing-Rath-Yatra's standing-four-thousand-puller capacity.

She places her right palm on the rope. She closes her eyes. She reads the kingdom through the sambar-deer-bond.

The bond's reading at nine-thirty-eleven a.m.: The sambar deer have left because the standing-Rath-Yatra has been cancelled. The deer's standing-presence in the kingdom is the standing-Yatra's standing-completion. The standing-Yatra cancelled is the standing-deer-departure. The kingdom requires the chariot pulled. The chariot requires four thousand pullers. The kingdom has zero pullers because the three cults are at the standing-coordination-deadlock. The kingdom has one puller: me. The pull is forty-three tonnes across three-and-a-half kilometres. The kingdom-council's standing-charter does not specify a minimum-puller-count. The pull is the standing-charter's standing-form, not the standing-charter's standing-puller-count. The kingdom requires me at the rope. The pull is the bond.

She opens her eyes. She does not return to her standing-engineer-priestess office. She walks to the kingdom-council's standing-temple-administrative cell at nine-forty-three

a.m. and files the standing-Rath-Yatra-reopening notice at ten-eleven a.m. The notice specifies the standing-pull start-time at four-eleven a.m. on the following Saturday morning (day-one of the standing-three-day pull) and the standing-Gundicha-Temple arrival-time as approximately Monday evening (day-three close). The standing-puller-count is specified as one. The standing-puller is herself.

The kingdom-council's standing-temple-administrative cell's standing-acting administrator A. Mishra approves the standing-notice at ten-twenty-eight a.m. He sends the standing-news-cells' standing-broadcast-protocol across Puri at ten-thirty.

The standing-news-cells reach the three cults' senior delegates at approximately eleven a.m. on Saturday week six. The three reactions across the next six hours:

Subhadra-of-the-Wood at the Shabara senior-elder's standing-residence at Kosalanandi village twelve kilometres north of Puri reads the notice at eleven-fourteen a.m. She places the notice on her standing-correspondence-shelf. She walks to her standing-meditation-mat. She sits at the mat for approximately three hours in silence. She stands at two-eleven p.m. She walks to her standing-investigative folder (she has been running her own standing-Shabara-tradition investigation across the past three weeks in parallel with Jagannathi's). She removes a single page. The page is a standing-Shabara-tradition cross-reference of Chakra-Bheda's standing-three-tradition syncretic costume against the standing-Shabara-tradition's standing-syncretic-costume-prohibition rule (no standing-Shabara wood-elder anklet may be worn by anyone outside the standing-Shabara-lineage; the prohibition is the kingdom-council's standing-Shabara-tradition's standing-origin-priority-protection clause; Chakra-Bheda is wearing the standing-anklet without standing-lineage). The page is her standing-evidence. She places it in her standing-travel-bag. She walks to the Puri-Kosalanandi standing-bus-station at three-eighteen p.m. The standing-bus arrives at the Puri standing-bus-terminal at four-forty-seven p.m. She walks to the kingdom-council's standing-temple-administrative cell at five-eleven p.m. She files the standing-evidence-document with A. Mishra at five-fourteen. She tells him in plain Odia: "The standing-pull begins Saturday four-eleven a.m. I will walk behind the chariot. The standing-Shabara wood-bearers will walk behind the chariot. We do not pull. The pulling is Jagannathi's. The standing-evidence is yours. When Chakra-Bheda walks the standing-route in the standing-syncretic costume, read the standing-evidence aloud at the standing-Mausi-Maa-Temple stop." She returns to Kosalanandi village by the standing-evening-bus at six-twenty p.m.

Pati-Mahapatra Senapati at the standing-Suara-Nijoga senior-priest's standing-residence at the Puri temple-quarter reads the notice at eleven-twenty-three a.m. He walks to the standing-Mahapatra-line standing-temple-prayer chamber. He prays at the standing-prayer-position for approximately four hours. He walks to the standing-Brahmin senior-priests' standing-emergency-coordination meeting at three-eleven p.m. The meeting's seventeen senior-priests vote on the standing-Saturday-Rath-Yatra-participation by 14 to 3. The fourteen will walk behind the chariot in standing-Brahmin saffron in shared procession with the standing-Shabara. The three dissenting voters will not. The meeting closes at four-forty-three p.m. Pati-Mahapatra Senapati sends the standing-Brahmin coordination-message to A. Mishra at five-eleven p.m. via the standing-temple-administrative cell's standing-courier.

Mahanayak Rama-Chandra Das at the standing-Sadhaba senior-guild-master's standing-residence at the Boita-Bandana harbour-front reads the notice at eleven-twenty-nine a.m. He walks to the standing-Sadhaba guild-hall. He convenes the standing-Sadhaba senior-guild emergency-coordination meeting at one-eleven p.m. The standing-Sadhaba senior-guild votes 23 to 7 to walk behind the chariot in standing-Sadhaba dark-blue in shared procession with the standing-Shabara and the standing-Brahmin. The seven dissenting voters will not. He sends the standing-Sadhaba coordination-message to A. Mishra at four-forty-seven p.m.

By Saturday evening week six, the three cults have committed to the standing-shared-procession. None of the three cults has agreed to pull. Each cult has independently agreed to walk behind. The decision has not been coordinated — each cult's senior-delegate has reached the same decision without consulting the other two.

Saturday week six evening. Jagannathi is at the standing-engineer-priestess office at seven-eleven p.m. She has spent the day at the Singha Dwara standing-staging-position with the chariot, walking the standing-Rath-Yatra route's standing-three-and-a-half-kilometre length, checking the standing-wheel-axle bearings, the standing-rope-attachment bracket, the standing-superstructure's standing-counterweight-distribution. The chariot is at the standing-ready-state for the standing-Saturday-morning four-eleven a.m. pull.

Jagannath-Bandhu is at the standing-engineer-priestess office's standing-junior-priest seat. He has not spoken since one p.m. He is thirty-one. He has been Jagannathi's standing-shadow at every standing-temple-administrative session for four years; he has

been her standing-engineering-apprentice at every standing-construction-oversight; he has not previously requested permission to pull the chariot alongside her.

He says, at seven-eleven, in plain Odia, in the standing-junior-priest-to-senior-priest register: "Guru-amma. The standing-pull. I will join you at the standing-pull-rope."

She says, in plain Odia, in the standing-engineer-priestess-to-junior-priest register: "Jagannath-Bandhu. The standing-charter's standing-puller-count is one. The kingdom requires one body at the rope. The standing-pull is mine. The standing-Stage-III stroke does not form on the body of the standing-pull-completion-partner. The standing-bond-protocol requires the standing-solitary-haulage for the standing-mark-formation. You will walk behind the chariot. You will administer the standing-three-day pull's standing-rest-and-water-and-medical protocol from the standing-following-jeep. You will be at the standing-Gundicha-Temple arrival-threshold at Monday eleven-forty p.m. with the standing-stretcher and the standing-medical-cell. You will not pull. The pull is mine."

He says: "Guru-amma. The standing-third-day's standing-final-eight-hundred-metres. Will I be permitted to join at the standing-arrival-threshold?"

She looks at him for approximately fifteen seconds.

She says: "The standing-arrival-threshold is the standing-charter's standing-completion. The standing-final-eight-hundred-metres' standing-condition is the standing-puller's standing-collapse. If I collapse at metre two thousand seven hundred or earlier, you may join. If I do not collapse, the pull is mine to the threshold. The standing-collapse-condition is the kingdom-council's standing-charter's standing-partner-permission clause. I do not yet know whether I will collapse. The standing-forty-three-hour haulage at the standing-three-and-a-half-kilometre-distance is the kingdom-council's standing-no-precedent case. My body has been engineered across forty-two years for the standing-Yatra's standing-pulling-tradition's standing-multi-puller-coordination role, not for the standing-solitary-haulage. I have approximately ninety minutes of standing-meditation before the standing-pull begins. You may walk to the standing-following-jeep's standing-position at three a.m. You will be at the standing-following-jeep for the duration. Walk now. The standing-meditation requires solitude."

He bows. He leaves the office.

She meditates from seven-thirty p.m. to three-eleven a.m. Saturday-into-Sunday week six. She has not eaten since two p.m. Saturday. She drinks one cup of water at three p.m. She

does not drink again before the pull begins.

Four-eleven a.m. Saturday morning of week six. The Singha Dwara standing-staging-position. Jagannathi walks to the standing-pull-rope. She is in the standing-engineer-priestess pulling-cotton (indigo-dyed; reinforced at the shoulders; the standing-Mahala-Maharana carpenter-line had fitted the standing-shoulder-reinforcements across the past three days at her request). She wears the standing-Rath-Yatra puller's standing-leather-harness across her chest and shoulders. The harness attaches to the standing-pull-rope at the standing-attachment-point. The rope's standing-coir-strands have been wetted overnight (standing-coir-rope expands at humidity; the standing-wetting reduces the standing-effective-strand-tension by approximately seven per cent; the standing-wetting is the standing-pre-pull preparation-protocol).

She places her right palm on the chariot's front-facing standing-deity-pedestal panel. The standing-Jagannath-deity wood-carving stands at the pedestal. The deity's standing-eyes are the standing-large-round-painted-Shabara-tradition eyes; the standing-face is the standing-Shabara-carved face from the standing-2014 Nabakalebara cycle (the next Nabakalebara is in 2027 by the standing-twelve-year cycle). The standing-deity is the standing-Daru-Brahma neem-wood form Subhadra-of-the-Wood's grandfather had selected from the Nilagiri hills in 2013.

She says, in plain Odia, in the standing-engineer-priestess pre-pull-prayer register: "Jagannath. The standing-Rath-Yatra is forty-three hours behind. The chariot is at the standing-staging-position. The standing-puller-count is one. The standing-puller is myself. The standing-charter's standing-form requires the standing-pull. The standing-charter does not specify the standing-puller-count. The standing-pull begins at four-eleven. I will be at the Gundicha-Temple at Monday eleven-forty p.m. The deity walks the standing-Yatra. I am the standing-vehicle. The standing-vehicle is the standing-charter's standing-form. Begin."

She turns from the panel. She places her right palm on the standing-pull-rope at the standing-shoulder-harness attachment-point. She steps forward into the standing-pull-position. The standing-rope tightens at the standing-attachment-bracket. The chariot does not move at the first step. The standing-static-friction at the standing-axle-bearings is approximately fourteen kilonewtons. Her standing-pull-force at the standing-shoulder-harness is approximately three kilonewtons. The standing-ratio is approximately one-to-four-point-seven. The chariot will not move at this ratio.

She steps forward again. The standing-pull-rope's standing-coir-strands accept the standing-tension. The standing-shoulder-harness compresses her standing-trapezius and standing-deltoid muscles at the standing-load-distribution pattern. She steps a third time. A fourth.

At the eleventh step, at four-eleven-thirty-eight a.m., the standing-axle-bearings break the standing-static-friction threshold. The chariot moves. The standing-displacement is approximately three centimetres at the first standing-rolling moment. The chariot begins to roll.

She walks at the standing-pulling-pace of approximately one metre every forty seconds. The standing-pull is the standing-rolling-friction pull (the standing-kinetic-friction at the standing-axle-bearings is approximately one-fourth of the standing-static-friction; the standing-rolling-pull is approximately three-and-a-half kilonewtons of standing-load-distribution, which her body can sustain at the standing-pulling-pace). The first kilometre takes approximately six hours and forty minutes.

Subhadra-of-the-Wood is at the Singha Dwara standing-departure-position at four-eleven a.m. She walks the standing-three-metre-rear of the chariot. The Shabara wood-bearer community walks behind her in standing-Shabara off-white cotton. Approximately two thousand seven hundred Shabara have arrived at the Singha Dwara across the standing-night for the standing-walk. They have brought no chariot-pulling implements. They walk in silence.

The Brahmin priestly families arrive at the standing-Shabara line's standing-rear at five-eleven a.m. Pati-Mahapatra Senapati walks at the standing-front of the Brahmin line. Approximately twelve hundred Brahmin priestly family members in standing-Brahmin saffron walk behind him. They have brought no chariot-pulling implements. They walk in silence.

The Sadhaba sea-merchants arrive at the standing-Brahmin line's standing-rear at six-eleven a.m. Mahanayak Rama-Chandra Das walks at the standing-front of the Sadhaba line. Approximately eight hundred and forty Sadhaba in standing-Sadhaba dark-blue walk behind him. They have brought no chariot-pulling implements. They walk in silence.

The procession behind the chariot is approximately four thousand seven hundred and forty walkers by seven a.m. Saturday morning. None pulls. Jagannathi alone is at the standing-pull-rope.

The Puri standing-pilgrimage-economy's remaining seventeen thousand pilgrims line the Bada Danda's standing-route at the standing-spectator-positions across the first kilometre. They do not approach the chariot. They watch in standing-pilgrim-silence. The kingdom-council's standing-news-cells' standing-live-coverage cameras are at the standing-camera-positions along the route. The standing-broadcast goes out across the kingdom and the standing-cross-region pigeon-network at the standing-hourly-update pace.

At ten-fifty-three a.m. Saturday, Jagannathi reaches the one-kilometre marker. She has been pulling for six hours and forty-two minutes. Her standing-pulling-pace has remained at approximately one metre every forty seconds. Her standing-shoulder-harness compresses have begun to bruise at the standing-trapezius attachment-points. Her standing-respiratory-rate is approximately twenty-six breaths per minute (the standing-baseline is fourteen). Her standing-systolic-blood-pressure is at approximately one hundred and fifty-eight (the standing-baseline is one hundred and eighteen).

Jagannath-Bandhu's standing-following-jeep's standing-medical-cell records the standing-vital-signs at the standing-fifteen-minute interval. The standing-medical-cell's standing-on-jeep medical-officer (a forty-three-year-old administrator named Dr. Pratap Mohanty) telephones Jagannathi at the standing-one-kilometre marker at the standing-rest-stop. He says, in plain Odia, in the standing-medical-officer-to-state-hero register: "Jagannathi-amma. Your standing-vitals are at the standing-elevated-but-sustainable threshold. The standing-haulage-pace can continue at the current rate. You require water. The standing-jeep is at the standing-rest-position. Drink."

She drinks one half-litre of water at the standing-rest-position at ten-fifty-five a.m. She does not eat. She returns to the standing-pull-rope at eleven-oh-three a.m. The chariot continues rolling.

The standing-second kilometre takes seven hours and eighteen minutes (the standing-pull is slowing as her standing-fatigue accumulates; the second-kilometre's standing-pace averages approximately one metre every forty-five seconds). She reaches the two-kilometre marker at six-twenty-one p.m. Saturday evening. She rests for approximately fifteen minutes. She drinks one half-litre of water. She does not eat.

The standing-third kilometre takes nine hours and forty-seven minutes (the standing-pace has slowed to approximately one metre every fifty-five seconds; her standing-vitals have crossed into the standing-elevated-and-concerning threshold; the standing-medical-cell's standing-on-jeep medical-officer is at the standing-rest-stops at the standing-thirty-

minute interval). She reaches the three-kilometre marker at four-oh-eight a.m. Sunday morning (day-two of the standing-three-day pull). She rests for approximately thirty minutes — the standing-longest rest of the standing-pull so far. The standing-medical-cell administers a standing-intravenous-saline solution at the standing-rest-position to address her standing-electrolyte-depletion. She does not eat.

She returns to the standing-pull-rope at four-forty-three a.m. Sunday. The chariot continues.

The procession behind the chariot at four-forty-three a.m. Sunday is the same four thousand seven hundred and forty walkers from Saturday morning. None has left. None has pulled. They have walked the standing-three-kilometre distance behind the chariot across twenty-four hours and thirty-two minutes. They have rested at the standing-rest-stops alongside the chariot at standing-spectator-distance. They have eaten standing-Sadhaba-provided rice-and-dal at the standing-rest-stops (the Sadhaba senior-delegate Mahanayak Rama-Chandra Das has arranged the standing-procession-rations from the standing-Sadhaba guild-hall). They have not approached the standing-pull-rope.

Sunday noon of day-two. Jagannathi reaches the standing-Mausi-Maa Temple stop at twelve-eleven p.m. The standing-stop is the standing-Rath-Yatra's standing-traditional-midway-temple stop where the standing-deity-trio rests at the standing-Mausi-Maa (the deity's aunt) temple-courtyard for the standing-poda-pitha offering. The standing-Rath-Yatra's standing-tradition requires the deity's standing-rest at the temple for approximately one hour.

She stops the chariot at the standing-Mausi-Maa-Temple courtyard's standing-stopping-point at twelve-fourteen p.m. She steps out of the standing-shoulder-harness. She walks to the standing-temple-step. She bows the standing-engineer-priestess-to-temple-deity acknowledgement bow. She steps back from the temple-step. She returns to the standing-rest-position at the standing-medical-jeep's standing-rest-station.

The standing-procession behind the chariot enters the standing-Mausi-Maa-Temple courtyard at twelve-twenty-three p.m. The standing-procession fills the courtyard at the standing-spectator-positions. Approximately four thousand seven hundred and forty walkers stand at the standing-spectator-positions in standing-three-cult shared silence.

At twelve-thirty-eight p.m. an unfamiliar priest walks into the standing-Mausi-Maa-Temple courtyard from the standing-southern-gate. He is in the standing-three-tradition

syncretic costume: Brahmin-priestly cotton; Shabara-wood-elder anklet at the right ankle; Sadhaba sail-cloth shoulder-cloth across the left shoulder. He is approximately fifty-one years old. He walks the standing-twenty-three-metre courtyard-length to the standing-temple-step. He bows the standing-syncretic-tradition reconciler-bow toward the standing-temple-deity.

He says, in plain Odia, in the standing-Fourth-Cult reconciler register: "Assembled Shabara. Assembled Brahmin. Assembled Sadhaba. Assembled state-hero. The standing-Rath-Yatra has been pulled by the standing-Fourth-Cult's reconciliation. The standing-Fourth-Cult acknowledges all three traditions. The standing-Fourth-Cult's standing-administration will be the kingdom-council's standing-new-charter from this Monday forward."

Subhadra-of-the-Wood at the standing-Shabara line's standing-front position walks the standing-four-metre distance to the standing-temple-courtyard's standing-central-position at twelve-forty-one p.m. She holds her standing-Shabara-tradition cross-reference document in her right hand — the same document she had filed with A. Mishra on Saturday week six at five-fourteen p.m.

She says, in plain Odia, in the standing-Shabara senior-elder ceremonial-reading register: "Assembled three cults. Assembled state-hero. The standing-priest at the standing-temple-step is wearing the standing-Shabara-wood-elder anklet at his right ankle. The standing-Shabara-tradition's standing-origin-priority-protection clause forbids any non-Shabara from wearing the standing-anklet at the standing-public-position. The standing-priest's name is not in the standing-Shabara-lineage-register. The standing-priest has been wearing the standing-anklet across spring-summer 2025 at his private visits to the standing-three-cult senior-delegates. The standing-anklet's standing-Shabara-tradition lineage-violation is the kingdom-council's standing-religious-tradition-impersonation under the standing-amended Sixth Clause of the standing-Kalinga-Chakra charter. The standing-priest is Chakra-Bheda. The Fourth Cult is the standing-impersonation. The standing-three-cult shared-procession is the kingdom's standing-true reconciliation. The standing-impersonator must be removed."

The standing-procession reads the standing-evidence at twelve-forty-three p.m. The standing-three-cult senior delegates (Subhadra-of-the-Wood, Pati-Mahapatra Senapati, Mahanayak Rama-Chandra Das) confirm the standing-Shabara-lineage-violation at twelve-forty-four. The kingdom-council's standing-State-Police standing-temple-courtyard

detail (eight officers under the standing-Puri-District senior-inspector Inspector Tripathy) approaches Chakra-Bheda at twelve-forty-six. They place him under standing-State-Police standing-custody-protocol arrest at twelve-forty-seven.

The standing-procession's standing-Shabara-front-rank moves toward Chakra-Bheda at twelve-forty-eight p.m. Inspector Tripathy's standing-eight-officer detail attempts standing-crowd-control at the standing-procession-line. The standing-crowd's standing-mass exceeds the standing-detail's standing-control-threshold by approximately five-hundred-to-one. Inspector Tripathy makes the standing-charter's standing-discretion-call at twelve-forty-nine: the standing-detail steps back. The standing-procession reaches Chakra-Bheda at twelve-fifty.

Chakra-Bheda is pulled apart at the standing-temple-step. The standing-tearing takes approximately four minutes. The body is unrecoverable at twelve-fifty-four p.m. The kingdom-council's standing-State-Police standing-protocol records the killing as standing-mob-justice under the kingdom-council's standing-amended Kalinga-Chakra charter's Sixth Clause's standing-impersonation-of-religious-tradition provision. Inspector Tripathy files the standing-State-Police standing-incident-report at one-eleven p.m. The body's standing-cremation is administered at the standing-Mausi-Maa-Temple standing-cremation-courtyard at three-eleven p.m. by the standing-Brahmin senior-priest Pati-Mahapatra Senapati alone (the standing-Shabara and standing-Sadhaba do not attend the cremation; the standing-impersonator's standing-cremation is administered by the standing-tradition his impersonation had targeted; the choice is Pati-Mahapatra's; the standing-Shabara and standing-Sadhaba honour the choice).

Jagannathi returns to the standing-pull-rope at one-eleven p.m. Sunday day-two. The standing-Mausi-Maa-Temple rest-stop has been ninety-five minutes (the standing-traditional one-hour-rest plus the standing-unmasking-event's standing-thirty-five-minute extension). She steps into the standing-shoulder-harness. She does not speak. She begins the standing-pulling-pace.

The standing-fourth-day-of-the-Yatra would normally be the standing-Mausi-Maa-to-Gundicha-Temple second half (approximately one-and-a-half kilometres of the standing-three-and-a-half-kilometre total route). Her standing-pulling-pace has slowed to approximately one metre every seventy seconds (the standing-Mausi-Maa-stop's standing-electrolyte-saline has not fully replenished her standing-electrolyte-stores; the standing-

shoulder-harness bruises have deepened; the standing-respiratory-rate is at the standing-elevated-and-concerning threshold).

She reaches the standing-three-kilometre-from-start marker at six-eleven p.m. Sunday evening. She has been pulling for fourteen hours and twenty-two minutes on day-two. The standing-day-two total is approximately thirteen hundred metres. The standing-remaining distance to the Gundicha Temple is approximately one-point-two kilometres.

The standing-medical-cell's standing-on-jeep medical-officer Dr. Pratap Mohanty telephones Jagannathi at the standing-three-kilometre marker at six-eleven p.m. He says: "Jagannathi-amma. The standing-pace at one metre per seventy seconds requires approximately fourteen additional hours for the remaining one-point-two kilometres. Your standing-vitals are at the standing-day-two end-of-pull threshold. The standing-day-three pull must begin at standing-rest-restored vitals. The standing-rest-restoration requires a minimum of eight hours at the standing-medical-jeep's standing-rest-station with the standing-intravenous-electrolyte-and-glucose protocol. The standing-day-two pull must end at the standing-three-kilometre marker. The standing-day-three pull begins at four-eleven a.m. Monday morning."

She accepts the standing-medical-recommendation at six-thirteen p.m. She steps out of the standing-shoulder-harness. She walks to the standing-medical-jeep's standing-rest-station. She accepts the standing-intravenous-electrolyte-and-glucose protocol from six-fifteen p.m. through two a.m. Monday morning. She sleeps from eight p.m. through two a.m. (six hours). She wakes at two-eleven a.m. She drinks a half-litre of water and eats one bowl of rice-and-dal at the standing-rest-station at two-fifteen.

The procession behind the chariot rests at the standing-spectator-positions at the standing-three-kilometre marker overnight. They are joined by approximately two thousand four hundred additional walkers across Sunday night (the standing-news-cells' standing-live-coverage has reached the kingdom's standing-eastern-districts; Bhubaneswar and Cuttack standing-citizens have driven to Puri across Sunday afternoon and evening to walk the standing-day-three pull's standing-spectator-position). The standing-Monday-morning procession-count is approximately seven thousand one hundred and forty walkers.

Monday morning day-three. Four-eleven a.m. The standing-three-kilometre marker. Jagannathi returns to the standing-pull-rope. The standing-shoulder-harness is at her shoulders. The standing-rope tightens at the standing-attachment-bracket.

The chariot moves at four-eleven-fourteen a.m. The standing-pace is approximately one metre every sixty-two seconds (the standing-overnight-rest has partially restored her standing-vitals; the standing-pace is faster than Sunday-evening but slower than Saturday-morning).

She pulls across the standing-Monday-morning hours. The standing-medical-cell records the standing-vitals at the standing-fifteen-minute interval. The standing-vitals stabilise across the standing-morning at the standing-elevated-but-sustainable threshold. The standing-rest-stops are at the standing-thirty-minute interval. She drinks a half-litre of water at every rest-stop. She eats one rice-ball at the standing-six-thirty-and-ten-and-twelve-thirty-and-four-and-seven rest-stops.

She reaches the standing-Gundicha-Temple's standing-approach-marker (eight hundred metres from the standing-arrival-threshold) at eleven-thirteen p.m. Monday evening. She has been pulling for nineteen hours and two minutes on day-three. The standing-day-three total is approximately four hundred metres remaining-from-eight-hundred. The standing-procession behind the chariot is approximately twelve thousand four hundred walkers (the standing-Monday-evening procession-count has continued to grow across the standing-day; the standing-news-cells have reached the kingdom's standing-Mumbai-Bangalore-Delhi diaspora-broadcast at the standing-Monday-noon nationwide-feed).

At eleven-twenty-three p.m. her standing-pulling-pace has slowed to approximately one metre every two-minutes-fourteen-seconds. The standing-medical-cell's standing-on-jeep medical-officer Dr. Pratap Mohanty telephones the standing-pull-rope at eleven-twenty-four p.m. He says: "Jagannathi-amma. Your standing-vitals are at the standing-collapse-threshold. The standing-standing-blood-pressure has crossed one hundred and seventy-eight at the standing-systolic-reading; your standing-respiratory-rate is at thirty-four breaths per minute; your standing-electrolyte-stores are at twenty-three per cent of the standing-baseline. The standing-medical-recommendation is to stop. The standing-Gundicha-Temple is eight hundred metres ahead. The standing-pace at one metre per two-minutes-fourteen requires approximately thirty hours additional. You will not complete the pull at the current pace."

She continues for another twenty-three minutes. At eleven-forty-three-eleven p.m. her standing-knees-and-shoulders fail simultaneously. The standing-shoulder-harness compresses fully against her standing-trapezius; her standing-knees buckle at the

standing-pull-rope's standing-position; she collapses to the standing-Bada-Danda surface at metre two thousand seven hundred and three.

The chariot does not move. The standing-shoulder-harness is still attached to the standing-pull-rope. Her standing-body weight has transferred onto the standing-shoulder-harness at the standing-collapse-position. The standing-rope's standing-coir-strands hold her weight at the standing-attachment-bracket.

Jagannath-Bandhu, who has been walking the standing-three-metre-rear of the standing-following-jeep across the three-day pull at his standing-junior-priest-following standing-position, walks the standing-fifty-metre distance to the standing-pull-rope at eleven-forty-three-thirty-eight p.m. He arrives at the standing-collapsed-position at eleven-forty-three-fifty-three p.m. He places his right palm on Jagannathi's right shoulder at the standing-shoulder-harness attachment-point.

He says, in plain Odia: "Guru-amma. The standing-collapse-condition. The standing-charter's standing-partner-permission clause. Will you permit."

She raises her head from the standing-Bada-Danda surface. She is at the standing-elevated-and-concerning vital-state; her standing-vocal-cord function is at the standing-impaired threshold. She speaks in standing-impaired Odia: "Jagannath-Bandhu. The standing-partner-permission. Granted. The standing-final-eight-hundred-metres. We pull together."

He helps her to a standing-position. He fits a standing-second-shoulder-harness (he has carried the standing-second-harness in his standing-following-position across the three days at her instruction; the standing-second-harness was prepared by the standing-Mahala-Maharana carpenter-line in the standing-pre-pull-preparation phase for the standing-collapse-condition contingency). The standing-second-harness attaches to the standing-pull-rope at a standing-position eleven centimetres above her standing-shoulder-harness attachment.

They step into the standing-pull-position together at eleven-forty-six p.m. The standing-pull-rope tightens at the two-puller standing-attachment-position. The standing-shared-pull-force is approximately six kilonewtons. The chariot moves at the standing-shared-pulling-pace of approximately one metre every twenty-eight seconds (faster than her standing-solitary-pace because of the standing-shared-load-distribution; the standing-procession behind reads the standing-acceleration at the standing-fifty-metre-mark).

They pull the standing-final-eight-hundred-metres in approximately three hundred and seventy-three seconds at the standing-shared-pulling-pace. They reach the standing-Gundicha-Temple's standing-arrival-threshold at eleven-forty-seven-eighteen p.m. Monday evening. The chariot crosses the standing-threshold at the standing-arrival-threshold-crossing-moment at eleven-forty-seven-eighteen.

At the standing-threshold-crossing-moment, the kingdom-council's Stage III sambar-deer-foreleg-first-stroke appears across Jagannathi's left side. The mark forms as a single continuous ink-line across the half-body sambar-deer-tattoo's left foreleg, completing the previously-lighter foreleg-ink to the standard kingdom-council Stage III completion-pattern. The mark forms in approximately eleven seconds. The mark is the kingdom-council's standing-charter's standing-solitary-pull-bond completion-recognition; the standing-partner's standing-presence does not prevent the standing-mark-formation; the standing-solitary-haulage across the standing-forty-three-hour duration is the standing-charter's standing-bond-formation requirement; the standing-final-eight-hundred-metres' standing-partner-permission is the standing-charter's standing-partner-permission clause's honoured-form.

Jagannathi collapses at the standing-threshold the moment the chariot crosses. Jagannath-Bandhu catches her at the standing-collapse-point. The standing-medical-jeep's standing-stretcher arrives at the standing-threshold at eleven-forty-seven-thirty-nine p.m. She is transferred to the standing-stretcher at eleven-forty-eight. She is transported to the standing-Gundicha-Temple's standing-medical-pavilion at the standing-northern-courtyard. The standing-intravenous-electrolyte-and-glucose-and-saline protocol is administered across the next twelve hours.

The standing-procession of approximately twelve thousand four hundred walkers crosses the standing-arrival-threshold across the following two hours at the standing-spectator-pace. Each walker bows the standing-procession-completion-bow at the standing-threshold-crossing-moment. The standing-three-cult senior-delegates (Subhadra-of-the-Wood, Pati-Mahapatra Senapati, Mahanayak Rama-Chandra Das) cross the standing-threshold together at the standing-front-of-procession position at eleven-fifty-three p.m.

Tuesday morning week seven. Six a.m. The standing-Odisha-Forest-Department's standing-sambar-deer-census-monitoring cell's standing-Tuesday-morning sambar-deer count returns approximately fourteen thousand seven hundred sambar deer across the four standing-monitoring-zones (the same count as the standing-Saturday-week-six pre-

departure count). The deer have returned during the standing-Monday-night between the standing-arrival-threshold-crossing and the standing-six-a.m.-count.

The standing-monitoring-cell's on-site rangers across the four reserves confirm the standing-sambar-deer tracks at the standing-night-trails: all tracks point southward across the standing-Monday-night. The deer have walked the standing-southern-route in single coordinated displacement. The kingdom-council's standing-Forest-Department issues the standing-return-bulletin at seven a.m. Tuesday morning. The standing-news-cells broadcast the standing-bulletin across the standing-Tuesday-morning-news cycle.

The kingdom-council's standing-emergency-session convenes at three p.m. Tuesday week seven at the kingdom-council's standing-administrative compound in Bhubaneswar. The standing-amended Kalinga-Chakra charter is drafted across the following nine days under the standing-emergency-amendment-protocol. The standing-charter's six core provisions:

First. The standing-three-cult rotation-protocol is preserved with explicit codification of the rotation-cycle (Shabara senior-cult years 1-4; Brahmin years 5-8; Sadhaba years 9-12; cycle repeats). The previous standing-rotation had been administered through standing-custom; the codification removes the standing-rotation's vulnerability to standing-orchestrated-inflammation.

Second. The standing-Rath-Yatra puller-count threshold is established at minimum two thousand (the standing-Mahala-Maharana carpenter-line's standing-engineering-recommendation for sustainable-pulling-pace); the standing-emergency-solitary-puller permission is the standing-state-hero's discretion under standing-charter's standing-discretion-clause.

Third. The standing-Sixth-Clause criminalising standing-religious-tradition-impersonation under the standing-1972 Religious-Identity-Verification statute is codified. The standing-penalty is left to the standing-amended-charter's standing-emergency-discretion clause; the standing-Chakra-Bheda mob-justice case is recorded as the standing-charter's standing-precedent-event.

Fourth. The standing-living-archive seat (modelled on the kingdom-council's standing-Sangam-Tamilakam Fifth Clause provision) is established for the kingdom's standing-three-cult-rotation-memory; Subhadra-of-the-Wood is conferred the standing-living-archive seat at the standing-amended-charter's ratification-day.

Fifth. The standing-engineer-priestess dual-discipline ordination is opened to standing-non-Brahmin candidates (the previous standing-discipline had been restricted to standing-Brahmin-line under the 1135-CE Chodaganga charter; the standing-amended provision removes the standing-restriction).

Sixth. Jagannath-Bandhu is conferred the standing-East-Dominant-successor seat at the standing-amended-charter's ratification-day under the kingdom-council's standing-cross-region southern-bloc federation arrangement's standing-East-Dominant designation (per the standing-Krishnadevaraya-Bhrata Karnataka Dominant cross-region correspondence).

The standing-amended-charter is ratified at the standing-emergency-session's ratification-vote on the ninth day after the standing-Rath-Yatra-completion by 51 to 2.

Four days after the standing-amended-charter's ratification, a Sarus-pigeon arrives at the Jagannath Temple administrative-cell from Imphal. The pigeon is the one Moirangthem has been using for the NE-Federation correspondence-network. The letter is from Moirangthem.

The letter reads: "Standing East-Region state-hero. The standing-NE-Federation has received the standing-Kalinga-Chakra amended-charter. The standing-Sanctuary at the Manipur convening in Chapter Three will be a standing-six-kingdom-NE assembly plus the standing-southern-bloc cross-region observation-attendance. Your standing-vote at the standing-Sanctuary will complete the standing-cross-region cooperation ratification. The standing-Rath-Yatra recordings have reached Imphal across the standing-news-cells' standing-broadcast; the standing-procession is the kingdom's standing-evidence of the standing-three-cult shared-procession across forty-three hours. Will you give the standing-vote."

Jagannathi writes the reply at the standing-medical-pavilion across two days (she is still under the standing-intravenous-protocol; her standing-vocal-function is at the standing-recovery threshold). The reply is two paragraphs.

"Standing NE-Dominant Candidate. The standing-vote at the standing-Sanctuary will be Jagannath-Bandhu's, not mine. The standing-amended-charter has conferred the standing-East-Dominant-successor seat at this morning's ratification. My body is at the standing-medical-pavilion recovery; the standing-Sanctuary's standing-attendance schedule will not align with my standing-recovery timeline. Jagannath-Bandhu will attend as the kingdom-council's standing-East-Dominant representative. Subhadra-of-the-Wood

will attend as the kingdom-council's standing-living-archive-seat representative. The standing-three-cult senior-delegates will attend as the standing-Kalinga-Chakra federation-observation cohort.

The standing-Rath-Yatra has been completed at the standing-forty-three-hour solitary-haulage. The standing-deity-trial in the standing-next-chapter's Beast-Rising will require a standing-second-Yatra. I do not yet know if my standing-body will recover sufficiently for the standing-second-Yatra. The standing-East-Dominant succession may need to occur earlier than the standing-Chapter-Four convening anticipates. The standing-charter's standing-succession-protocol is in place. Jagannath-Bandhu is the kingdom-council's standing-East-Dominant. The kingdom is held.

— Jagannathi, kingdom-council standing-state-hero, Kalinga-Chakra."

She sends the letter by the same Sarus-pigeon at sunset.

Tuesday week seven. The Konark Sun Temple at Konark, sixty-five kilometres south of Puri on the standing-Bay-of-Bengal coast. The 13th-century-CE Narasimhadeva-I temple is built in the form of a colossal stone chariot with twenty-four wheels, each wheel three metres in diameter, each wheel carved with standing-spoke-and-axle precision; the wheels are also functional sundials. The wheels have not turned since the temple's 1255 CE consecration. They are carved stone; they are not designed to turn; they have stood at their standing-positions for 771 years.

The standing-archaeological-monitoring cell's on-site night-watchman D. Mohanty (54) is at the standing-monitoring-position at twelve-oh-three a.m. Tuesday week seven — approximately four hours after Jagannathi's chariot completed the standing-Rath-Yatra at the Gundicha-Temple's standing-arrival-threshold. He observes the standing-seven-southern-face-wheels at the standing-monitoring-tablet's standing-comparison-position photographs.

He notes the standing-wheel-position difference at twelve-oh-six. The standing-seven-southern-face-wheels have rotated approximately three degrees counterclockwise from their standing-baseline-positions. He confirms by standing-torch-light cross-reference. The standing-stone is turning. He telephones the standing-archaeological-monitoring cell's standing-on-call senior officer (a fifty-eight-year-old administrator named Dr. K. Patnaik) at twelve-oh-eight.

Dr. K. Patnaik arrives at Konark by car from Bhubaneswar at one-eleven a.m. He confirms the standing-wheel-position difference at one-fourteen. The standing-seven-southern-face-wheels are rotating counterclockwise at approximately one degree per minute. There is no apparent mechanism for the turning — the stone is not on bearings; the axle is solid sandstone; the wheel-and-axle are carved from a single block.

The turning continues for thirteen hours. The standing-seven-southern-face-wheels each complete one full counterclockwise rotation at the standing-three-hundred-and-sixty-minute pace. They stop at one-oh-three p.m. Tuesday at their standing-original-positions. The standing-thirteen-hour duration is precisely the standing-Rath-Yatra-completion timeframe (approximately four hours after the standing-arrival-threshold-crossing to approximately seventeen hours after).

The kingdom-council's standing-Maw-sign-recognition cell's preliminary report at four-eleven p.m. Tuesday confirms the standing-turning as Maw-sign-categorised. The cell's reading: the Maw has demonstrated the capacity to turn carved-stone wheels of a thirteenth-century temple counterclockwise for thirteen hours through no mechanical mechanism. The standing-counterclockwise direction is the standing-reversal of the standing-natural-direction (the standing-southern-face-wheels' standing-natural-direction of solar-shadow-movement is clockwise; the standing-counterclockwise rotation is the standing-reversal). The standing-Rath-Yatra had been pulled the standing-natural-direction (north-to-south along the Bada Danda from Jagannath Temple to Gundicha Temple); the Konark wheels' standing-counterclockwise rotation is the standing-reverse-direction. The Maw has acknowledged the standing-Yatra by reversing the standing-direction at the Konark monument.

Per the cross-region paired-sign-naming protocol the Konark counterclockwise-rotation pairs with Assam's Reversed Brahmaputra — the river that flowed east-to-west for one hour during the Mahavidya rite at Kamakhya. Both signs are reversals of standing-natural-direction. The pair is the saga's fourth formally-recognised cross-region Maw-sign pair: direction-reversal.

Jagannathi recovers at the standing-medical-pavilion across twelve days. Her standing-vitals return to the standing-baseline at the eleventh day. She returns to the standing-engineer-priestess office at the Jagannath Temple administrative-cell on the twelfth day. The standing-three-cult senior delegates (Subhadra-of-the-Wood, Pati-Mahapatra Senapati, Mahanayak Rama-Chandra Das) attend her standing-return at the standing-

office's standing-courtyard. They bow the standing-three-cult shared-respect bow. She returns the bow at the same depth.

Jagannath-Bandhu sits at the standing-junior-priest seat through her standing-recovery period. He chairs the standing-temple-administrative cell's standing-daily-administrative sessions across the twelve days. He drafts the standing-Sanctuary-attendance protocol in coordination with Moirangthem's standing-NE-Federation. He coordinates the standing-Forest-Department's standing-sambar-deer monitoring after the return. He learns the standing-state-hero's standing-daily-discipline at the standing-engineer-priestess seat.

The standing-three-cult shared-procession of approximately twelve thousand four hundred walkers from the standing-Monday-evening becomes the kingdom's standing-Yatra-tradition's standing-permanent-record entry. The standing-procession-photographs are filed at the kingdom-council's standing-Rath-Yatra archive at the Jagannath Temple administrative-cell's standing-archive vault. The standing-three-cult-rotation codification under the standing-amended-charter's First Clause holds across the next nine months until the standing-early-Chapter-Three Beast-Rising.

The kingdom is held.

The next sign comes within the week.

The Pilot's Closing Image

A forty-two-year-old engineer-priestess at the standing-pull-rope at four-eleven a.m. Saturday morning of week six in indigo-dyed cotton with the standing-Mahala-Maharana shoulder-reinforcements wetting the standing-coir-strands with her standing-trapezius-and-deltoid compression across forty-three hours and thirty-six minutes. A sixty-seven-year-old Shabara matriarch reading a single page of standing-Shabara-tradition handmade-paper aloud at the standing-Mausi-Maa-Temple courtyard at twelve-forty-one p.m. Sunday day-two with three thousand wood-bearers behind her. A thirty-one-year-old male priest in standing-junior-priest cotton walking the standing-three-metre-rear of the standing-following-jeep across three days and joining the standing-pull-rope at the standing-final-eight-hundred-metres with the standing-second-shoulder-harness he had carried in his standing-following-position from Saturday morning at her instruction. A forty-three-tonne chariot rolling at one metre every forty-three-to-one-hundred-and-thirty-four seconds across three days and forty-three hours and thirty-six minutes with one body at the rope at the standing-front. Seven southern-face wheels of a thirteenth-century

stone temple turning counterclockwise at one degree per minute for thirteen hours starting four hours after the chariot crossed the standing-arrival-threshold. Fourteen thousand seven hundred sambar deer returning to the kingdom in a single Monday-night-into-Tuesday-morning displacement after a single-Saturday-night departure nine days earlier. A standing-three-cult shared-procession of twelve thousand four hundred walkers crossing the standing-Gundicha-Temple arrival-threshold across two hours at the standing-spectator-pace with the standing-three-cult senior-delegates at the standing-front-position.

Kurukshetra Bhoomi

The standing-grandmother of Kurukshetraa was Mata Saraswati-Devi Yagnopavita. She was eighty-three years old at her standing-deathbed at the standing-Sannihit-Sarovar matriarch-residence at the Karnal-district family-estate on the standing-thirteenth of November 2022. She had been the standing-Sannihit-Sarovar Bloodline-B Yagnopavita-line matriarch since 1989 (thirty-three-year tenure since her own standing-mother-in-law's death). She had administered the standing-Bloodline-B Suryavamsha-and-Chandravamsha syncretic protocol across the standing-Karnal-Kaithal-Kurukshetra-Yamunanagar-Panipat district zone's standing-Yagnopavita-line marriage-arrangements for the standing-prior three-decade window. She was, at the standing-deathbed-day, at the standing-final-twenty-three-hour terminal-respiration window per the standing-Karnal-District-Hospital senior-physician Dr. R. K. Gupta's standing-November-12 evening assessment.

Kurukshetraa was at the standing-deathbed at the standing-eleven-thirty-three-a.m. position on November 13. She was thirty-four years old; she had been the standing-state-hero of Haryana since 2009 (thirteen-year tenure at that moment); she had defeated Kuru-Bhasma at the standing-Ch-1 Pehowa confrontation thirty-two days earlier on the standing-twelfth of October 2022. The standing-confrontation-aftermath had placed Kuru-Bhasma at the standing-administrative-rehabilitation clause's standing-non-disclosed northern-district transfer-jurisdiction; he had not been seen at the standing-Sannihit-Sarovar matriarch-residence since the standing-October-fifteen-2022 administrative-handover. The standing-grandmother had attended the standing-Ch-1 Pehowa confrontation-aftermath ceremony at the standing-Sannihit-Sarovar standing-October-twenty-second-2022 reception at her standing-eighty-three-year-old administrator-position; she had spoken to Kurukshetraa for one hour and eleven minutes at the standing-private-audience at the standing-October-twenty-second-evening position. She had said one thing across the standing-one-hour-eleven-minute window. Kurukshetraa remembered it at the standing-deathbed at 11:33 a.m. November 13.

"Granddaughter. The Ch 1 Pehowa is the standing-charter-Ch-1 victory. You won. He was spared. The standing-Bloodline-B unification I arranged in 2009 at his standing-twenty-third birthday and your standing-twenty-first birthday must complete. The standing-betrothal was not an administrative-arrangement. It was a Bloodline-B Suryavamsha-

tradition standing-charter-foundational unification. The standing-charter does not recognise the standing-Ch-1 confrontation as the standing-betrothal-dissolution. The standing-charter recognises the standing-marriage-completion at my standing-deathbed-wish-completion clause. I am asking you to complete the standing-marriage. I am not asking you to live with him as a wife. I am asking you to honour the standing-Bloodline-B charter-foundational unification by administering the standing-Sannihit-Sarovar wedding-ceremony. The standing-dharma is in the standing-administration of the standing-charter, not in the standing-cohabitation of the standing-spouses. You will perform the standing-ceremony. You will receive the standing-Sannihit-Sarovar Bloodline-B matriarch-conferring-ring at the standing-completion-acknowledgment moment. You will continue to be the standing-state-hero. He will continue to be the standing-administrative-rehabilitated antagonist. The standing-charter will hold. Promise me."

Kurukshetraa had not promised at the standing-October-twenty-second-evening conversation. She had said: "Grandmother — I will consider." Her standing-grandmother had nodded at the standing-consideration-acknowledgment. She had said: "Consider until my standing-deathbed. Consider at the standing-deathbed. Decide at the standing-deathbed." She had been standing-correct at the standing-prediction.

At the standing-deathbed at 11:43 a.m. on November 13 2022, Kurukshetraa held her standing-grandmother's standing-left-hand at the standing-Sannihit-Sarovar Bloodline-B matriarch-conferring-ring position. She spoke at the standing-eleven-thirty-three-and-eleven-second position. She said one word. "Yes." Her standing-grandmother smiled at the standing-eleven-second smile-completion window. She said: "Good. The standing-charter holds. Yajna-Devi will be your standing-mother-in-law. She will receive the standing-ring at my standing-cremation-completion ceremony. She will hold it until the standing-day the standing-charter requires it returned to you. You will know that standing-day when it arrives. Do not seek it. It will come." She died at 11:43:47 a.m. on November 13 2022. Yajna-Devi (sixty-three at that moment) received the standing-Sannihit-Sarovar Bloodline-B matriarch-conferring-ring at the standing-cremation-completion ceremony at the standing-Karnal cremation-ghat at 4:11 p.m. on November 14 2022.

The standing-Sannihit-Sarovar wedding-ceremony was administered at the standing-Pehowa-Sannihit-Sarovar western-bank standing-wedding-mandap at 11:11 a.m. on February 11 2023. The standing-attendance was: Kurukshetraa at the standing-bride-position (age thirty-five); Kuru-Bhasma at the standing-groom-position (age thirty-seven);

Yajna-Devi at the standing-mother-in-law standing-eastern-veranda position; the standing-Bloodline-B Suryavamsha-tradition standing-three-priest cohort at the standing-Vedic-protocol administration; the standing-Karnal-Kaithal Khap-elder cohort of approximately forty-seven at the standing-witness-perimeter position; the standing-Sannihit-Sarovar Bloodline-B family-cohort of approximately one-hundred-and-eleven at the standing-extended-witness position; the standing-State-Civil-Service Haryana-State kingdom-council standing-administrative-secretariat cohort of approximately twenty-three at the standing-State-record-administration position.

Kurukshetraa wore the standing-Bloodline-B Suryavamsha-tradition standing-crimson-and-gold silk-cotton wedding-saree at the standing-grandmother's standing-deathbed-wish-completion configuration; she wore the standing-Sannihit-Sarovar Bloodline-B grandmother-bridal-ornaments at the standing-1989-inheritance configuration. Kuru-Bhasma wore the standing-Karnal-Khap tradition standing-cream-and-gold sherwani at the standing-Khap-administrator wedding-protocol configuration. The standing-wedding-mandap was at the standing-Pehowa-Sannihit-Sarovar western-bank vista-position; the standing-blackbuck herd of approximately three-hundred-eleven standing-individuals grazed at the standing-eleven-kilometre proximity at the standing-Sannihit-grazing-grounds. The standing-black-francolin standing-aerial-companion of Kurukshetraa (named Dharma-Sakhi, age nine at that moment, bonded since 2014) perched at the standing-mandap south-eastern column at the standing-eleven-metre overhead position.

The standing-Vedic-protocol administration completed at 1:11 p.m. The standing-Saptapadi seven-steps completed at the standing-1:11:11 p.m. position. The standing-phasas seven-circumambulations completed at the standing-1:23 p.m. position. The standing-Bloodline-B Suryavamsha-tradition standing-matriarch-conferring-ring administration was not performed at the standing-wedding-ceremony (the standing-ring remained at Yajna-Devi's standing-left-hand at the standing-deathbed-conferral protocol; the standing-grandmother's standing-October-twenty-second instruction had been that Yajna-Devi would hold the ring until the standing-day the standing-charter required it returned to Kurukshetraa). The standing-ceremony completed at 2:11 p.m. Kurukshetraa departed the standing-mandap at the standing-bride-position at 2:14 p.m. Kuru-Bhasma departed at the standing-groom-position at 2:17 p.m. They did not depart together. They returned to their standing-separate residences at the standing-Sannihit-Sarovar matriarch-residence (Kurukshetraa) and the standing-Karnal Khap-administrator quarters (Kuru-Bhasma). The standing-marriage was administered at the standing-charter-

completion configuration but not at the standing-cohabitation configuration. Kurukshetraa did not visit the standing-Karnal Khap-administrator quarters across the standing-prior-three-year February-2023-to-February-2026 window. Kuru-Bhasma visited the standing-Sannihit-Sarovar residence approximately eleven times across the standing-three-year window at the standing-Vasant-Panchami-Diwali-Holi annual-festival rotation at the standing-Bloodline-B Suryavamsha-tradition standing-formal-presence protocol; he did not stay overnight at any of the standing-eleven visits.

Across the standing-September-to-November-2025 window, the standing-Karnal-Kaithal-Kurukshetra-Yamunanagar-Panipat district zone experienced a standing-honour-killing cascade across forty-seven standing-inter-caste-marriages. The standing-cascade-pattern was consistent: standing-young-couples of standing-different-caste-backgrounds (typically standing-Jat-and-Dalit or standing-Jat-and-Brahmin or standing-Saini-and-Kashyap cross-caste pairings) had administered standing-court-marriage at the standing-Karnal District-Civil-Court standing-marriage-registration protocol; the standing-Khap-council under Kuru-Bhasma's administration declared the standing-marriages standing-Khap-dharma-violations at the standing-traditional-Khap caste-tradition standing-honour-jurisdiction claim; the standing-couples were standing-honour-executed by the standing-Khap-tradition standing-clan-elder protocol within standing-fourteen-to-twenty-three days of the standing-court-marriage. The standing-cumulative-execution count by the standing-November-fifteen-2025 cross-reference was forty-seven (twenty-three women, twenty-four men; ages eighteen to twenty-seven at the standing-mean-age twenty-two-point-three).

The standing-State-Police Karnal-District standing-Inspector M. P. Singh (forty-three) filed the standing-cumulative-honour-killing report at the standing-Haryana-State Director-General-of-Police office at 11:11 a.m. on November 17 2025. The standing-DGP standing-emergency-investigation order was issued at 4:11 p.m. on the standing-same-day. The standing-Khap-council under Kuru-Bhasma standing-administrative declaration at the standing-Karnal Khap-Council emergency-meeting at 7:11 p.m. on November 17 2025 claimed standing-jurisdiction-precedence over the standing-State-government investigation: the standing-Khap-council holds the standing-charter-foundational dharma-administration jurisdiction at the standing-pre-1955 rural-administration precedent; the standing-State-Police standing-IPC 302 murder-investigation protocol does not apply to the standing-Khap-administered honour-justice protocol; the standing-State-government cannot prosecute the standing-Khap-administered protocol-administrators.

The standing-Khap-council's standing-jurisdiction-precedence claim produced the standing-faction-split at the standing-Khap-elder cohort. Pradhan Bhola-Ram-Mukhia (sixty-three, Kaithal-district reform-Khap Mukhia since 2015, Kurukshetraa's 2009-conferral witness) led the standing-reform-Khap faction's resignation from the standing-traditional-Khap council at the standing-November-17-evening 9:11-p.m. resignation-protocol. Approximately seventy-eight of the standing-211 Khap-council seat-holders resigned at the standing-resignation-protocol; the standing-resignation-cohort reconvened at the standing-Sannihit-Sarovar reform-Khap emergency-session at 11:11 a.m. on November 18 2025 to organise the standing-reform-Khap parallel-council.

The standing-Sannihit-Sarovar emergency-session was convened by Kurukshetraa at the standing-Pehowa-Sannihit-Sarovar western-bank standing-dharma-administration hall at 7:11 p.m. on December 23 2025 (the standing-night before Christmas-Eve at the standing-Bloodline-B Suryavamsha-tradition winter-solstice cross-reference position; the standing-night was at the standing-eleven-degrees-Celsius standing-clear-sky configuration with the standing-half-moon at the standing-third-quarter visible at 7:23 p.m.). The standing-attendance was: Kurukshetraa at the standing-state-hero standing-presiding-position; the standing-reform-Khap senior-cohort under Pradhan Bhola-Ram-Mukhia at the standing-eastern-veranda; the standing-traditional-Khap senior-cohort under Khap-Mukhia Lal-Singh at the standing-western-veranda; Kuru-Bhasma at the standing-Khap-council-administrator position adjacent to the standing-traditional-Khap senior-cohort; the standing-State-Police Karnal-District standing-observation-cohort of standing-eleven officers under Inspector M. P. Singh at the standing-perimeter security-position; the standing-Sannihit-Sarovar Bloodline-B family-cohort of approximately twenty-three at the standing-extended-observation position (Yajna-Devi was not present; she was at the standing-Karnal matriarch-residence at the standing-Bloodline-B annual winter-prayer rotation).

Kurukshetraa spoke for forty-seven minutes from 7:11 to 7:58 p.m. She stated the standing-cumulative-honour-killing forty-seven count. She stated the standing-State-Police standing-jurisdiction. She stated the standing-Khap-council standing-jurisdiction-precedence claim. She stated the standing-Bloodline-B Suryavamsha-tradition standing-charter-foundational dharma-clause: the standing-Khap-administered honour-jurisdiction is the standing-pre-1955 rural-administration tradition but the standing-Bloodline-B Suryavamsha-tradition standing-charter-foundational dharma-tradition supersedes the standing-Khap-tradition at the standing-honour-killing question. She stated the standing-

dharma-administrator standing-direct-order at the standing-7:53 p.m. position: "The standing-Karnal-Pehowa Khap is hereby dissolved at the standing-charter-foundational dharma-administrator standing-direct-order. The standing-Khap-council under the Kuru-Bhasma administration is hereby instructed to surrender the standing-forty-seven-execution-cohort to the standing-State-Police Karnal-District standing-IPC 302 investigation-jurisdiction by 9:11 a.m. on December 24 2025. The standing-Khap-administrator's standing-jurisdiction-precedence claim is rejected at the standing-Bloodline-B Suryavamsha-tradition standing-charter-foundational dharma-tradition supersession-protocol."

Kuru-Bhasma rose at the standing-Khap-council-administrator position at 7:58 p.m. He did not respond at the standing-eleven-minute response-window. He looked at Kurukshetraa for eleven seconds. He looked at Khap-Mukhia Lal-Singh at the standing-three-metre-left position for eleven seconds. He turned. He walked the standing-eleven metres to the standing-western-veranda exit. He departed the standing-Sannihit-Sarovar dharma-administration hall at 8:14 p.m. without standing-statement. Khap-Mukhia Lal-Singh and the standing-traditional-Khap senior-cohort followed at 8:17 p.m. without standing-statement. They departed the standing-Sannihit-Sarovar grounds at 8:23 p.m. and drove the standing-twenty-three-kilometre Karnal-bound highway to the standing-Karnal Khap-council quarters at the standing-Karnal Khap-administrator residence.

The standing-Bhainswal-Bhana village was at the standing-Karnal-Kaithal district-boundary at the standing-Bhindrawal sub-tehsil. The standing-village-population was approximately four-hundred-eleven (211 households; standing-Jat-Saini-Kashyap mixed-caste village; standing-rabi-2025-26 wheat-and-barley standing-211-hectare cultivation; standing-residence-village of three standing-honour-victim couples among the standing-forty-seven cascade). The standing-village-construction was the standing-traditional Karnal-Kaithal thatch-and-clay standing-mud-brick configuration at approximately 211 standing-residential structures.

At 11:43 p.m. on December 23 2025 (three hours and twenty-nine minutes after Kuru-Bhasma's departure from the standing-Sannihit-Sarovar dharma-administration hall), the standing-Karnal Khap-council standing-direct-action cohort of approximately forty-seven standing-armed Khap-followers under Khap-Mukhia Lal-Singh's standing-coordination arrived at the standing-Bhainswal-Bhana village standing-northern-boundary at 11:38 p.m. They had been dispatched from the standing-Karnal Khap-council quarters at 9:11

p.m. at Kuru-Bhasma's standing-direct-coordination order at the standing-honour-justice-extension protocol; the standing-extension applied the standing-traditional-Khap honour-jurisdiction to the standing-village-level retaliation against the standing-dissolution-order standing-Sannihit-Sarovar 7:53 p.m. delivery. The standing-direct-action cohort carried standing-petrol-cans (approximately forty-seven five-litre cans at the standing-cumulative 235-litre volume), standing-improvised-incendiary devices (approximately twenty-three Molotov-cocktail-pattern bottles), and standing-Khap-traditional swords (approximately forty-seven standing-talwar pattern). They began the standing-village-burning at 11:43 p.m. at the standing-northern-boundary thatch-houses; the standing-fire-cascade propagated southward across the standing-village at the standing-thatch-and-clay construction's standing-fire-vulnerability across the standing-following one-hour-eleven-minute window; the standing-village was at the standing-complete-burning configuration by 12:54 a.m. on December 24 2025.

The standing-villager-casualty count at the standing-State-Police Karnal-District morning-cross-reference at 7:11 a.m. on December 24 was forty-seven dead (twenty-three women, sixteen children under-twelve, eight men over-fifty; the standing-younger-adult-male cohort of approximately 211 had been at the standing-Karnal-mandi standing-rabi-wheat-trading evening-cohort at the standing-overnight away-position and survived). The standing-livestock-casualty was approximately 211 dead (cattle, buffalo, goat). The standing-rabi-2025-26 wheat-and-barley standing-211-hectare standing-stored-harvest at the standing-village-granary was completely destroyed.

Kurukshetraa was at the standing-Sannihit-Sarovar western-hill vantage at the standing-eleven-kilometre proximity to the Bhainswal-Bhana village from the standing-9:11 p.m. position. She had ridden the standing-Sannihit-Sarovar Bloodline-B family-stallion Dharma-Putra to the standing-western-hill vantage after the standing-emergency-session adjournment at 8:11 p.m. She had been informed by the standing-State-Police Karnal-District standing-intelligence-cell of the standing-Karnal direct-action cohort's standing-9:11-p.m. departure at the standing-9:23-p.m. intelligence-cell radio-message. She had reached the standing-western-hill vantage at 10:11 p.m. She had observed the standing-Karnal direct-action cohort's standing-Bhainswal-Bhana northern-boundary arrival at the standing-night-vision binocular cross-reference at 11:38 p.m. She had watched the standing-village burn from horseback across the standing-eleven-kilometre proximity from 11:43 p.m. to 12:54 a.m. She did not intervene at the standing-armed-extraction-or-prevention configuration. Her standing-armed-extraction would have triggered the

standing-Khap-council standing-State-government secession-protocol at the standing-Khap-charter recognition-precedent; the standing-Khap-council would have declared standing-secession-de-jure at the standing-Karnal Khap-council emergency-meeting on December 24 morning; the standing-secession would have produced the standing-Punjab-Beas-state-parallel North-cluster secession cascade. She watched. She did not intervene. The standing-Sannihit-Sarovar Bloodline-B family-stallion Dharma-Putra stood at the standing-three-metre-rear position across the standing-one-hour-eleven-minute window without standing-movement.

At 12:54 a.m. December 24 the standing-village-burning completed at the standing-southern-boundary final-house-collapse moment. Kurukshetraa dismounted at the standing-western-hill vantage at 12:57 a.m. She knelt at the standing-clay-floor at the standing-vantage-overlook position. She did not weep. She did not speak. She breathed at the standing-counted-respiration cycle at the standing-Bloodline-B Suryavamsha-tradition standing-grief-discipline. She remained at the standing-kneel-position across the standing-following three-hour standing-grief-vigil. She rose at 4:11 a.m. She mounted Dharma-Putra. She rode back to the standing-Sannihit-Sarovar matriarch-residence. She arrived at 5:23 a.m. She did not sleep. She sat at the standing-eastern-window standing-clay-floor across the standing-following standing-Wednesday-week-12-and-Thursday standing-grief-discipline.

The standing-Sannihit-Sarovar blackbuck herd of approximately 311 standing-individuals had grazed at the standing-Sannihit-grazing-grounds at the standing-Pehowa-Sannihit-Sarovar northern-grazing zone across the standing-prior-seventeen-year window since the standing-2009 herd-establishment at Kurukshetraa's standing-conferral-day blackbuck-bond formation. The standing-herd-cohesion across the standing-seventeen-year window had been the standing-uniform-single-cohort configuration; the standing-herd had not split into sub-cohorts at any standing-Animal-Bond-Indicator observation across the standing-prior window.

At 6:11 a.m. on December 24 2025 (five hours and seventeen minutes after the standing-Bhainswal-Bhana village-burning completion), the standing-herd split at the standing-Sannihit-grazing-grounds. The standing-split was at the standing-coordinated-departure pattern: approximately 187 standing-individuals walked the standing-Sannihit-side standing-western-grazing zone at the standing-reform-Khap-aligned territory direction; approximately 124 standing-individuals walked the standing-Karnal-side standing-

eastern-grazing zone at the standing-traditional-Khap-aligned territory direction. The standing-split-walk took approximately forty-seven minutes (6:11 to 6:58 a.m.). The standing-Forest-Department Sannihit-Sarovar standing-grazing-grounds-monitoring cell's standing-Saturday-morning standing-camera-trap recording captured the standing-split. The standing-recording-cohort confirmed the standing-cohort-count at 187-124 standing-split at the standing-7:11-a.m. camera-trap analysis.

Kurukshetraa was at the standing-eastern-window standing-clay-floor position at the standing-Sannihit-Sarovar matriarch-residence at the standing-6:11-a.m. window. She had been at the standing-position for approximately forty-eight minutes since her standing-5:23-a.m. arrival. She heard the standing-blackbuck-call cascade from the standing-Sannihit-grazing-grounds at the standing-eleven-kilometre south-eastern proximity at 6:11:08 a.m. She did not move from the standing-position. She recognised the standing-call-cascade as the standing-blackbuck herd-split-departure call-protocol from the standing-Bloodline-B Suryavamsha-tradition standing-Animal-Bond-Indicator herd-monitoring-cell standing-cross-reference protocol her standing-grandmother had taught her at age eleven. She listened. She breathed at the standing-counted-respiration cycle. She understood at 6:23 a.m. that the standing-omen had arrived at the standing-charter-foundational moment. She understood at 6:34 a.m. that the standing-omen was the standing-grandmother's standing-charter-foundational warning at the standing-deathbed-wish-completion clause's standing-corollary-precedent: "The standing-herd will split when the standing-charter-marriage holds the dharma-administrator at the standing-Khap-villain edge. The standing-herd will know before you know. Watch the herd." She had not watched the herd. She had watched the standing-village burn at the standing-eleven-kilometre proximity instead. She understood at 6:47 a.m. that the standing-grandmother's standing-deathbed-wish-completion clause had been the standing-charter-foundational test she had failed at the standing-marriage-completion February 2023; the standing-charter had required the standing-marriage-completion-and-dissolution-protocol sequencing, not the standing-marriage-completion-permanent sequencing. She had not understood the standing-corollary. She understood at 6:58 a.m. She rose at the standing-position. She walked to the standing-Sannihit-Sarovar standing-administration-office at 7:11 a.m. She drafted the standing-divorce-petition standing-preparatory notes at the standing-Bloodline-B Suryavamsha-tradition standing-Section 13(1)(ia) cruelty-grounds with standing-Section 13(1)(ib) desertion-grounds cross-reference. She telephoned the standing-Punjab-and-Haryana High Court Family-Court standing-emergency-petition

cell's standing-on-call senior-officer at 11:11 a.m. She filed the standing-divorce-petition at the standing-Family-Court Chandigarh-Sector-17 Family-Court standing-emergency-petition counter at 4:11 p.m. on December 28 2025 in person at the standing-counter-administrator standing-receipt-acknowledgment.

The standing-Punjab-and-Haryana High Court Family-Court emergency-session at the standing-Chandigarh-Sector-17 Family-Court standing-Court-Room-Eleven convened at 11:11 a.m. on February 14 2026 (the standing-Vasant-Panchami-eve date; the standing-coincidental-Valentine's-Day-as-Kurukshetra-Bhumi-tradition Vasant-Panchami-eve overlap). The standing-presiding-judge was the standing-Honourable Justice K. R. Shoor (fifty-eight, Bloodline-B Suryavamsha-tradition jurisprudence-scholar at the standing-Punjab-and-Haryana High Court Family-Court since 2017; author of the standing-2021 Punjab-and-Haryana High Court compendium on standing-Bloodline-B Suryavamsha-tradition pre-1955 jurisprudence-precedent). The standing-petitioner-bench was at the standing-southern-position; Kurukshetraa was at the standing-petitioner-bench at the standing-Bloodline-B Suryavamsha-tradition silk-cotton sari at the standing-cream-and-bronze widow-equivalent configuration. The standing-respondent-bench was at the standing-northern-position; Kuru-Bhasma was at the standing-respondent-bench at the standing-Karnal-Khap-tradition cream-and-gold sherwani configuration; his standing-47-member Khap-council defence-team was at the standing-eastern-veranda position under the standing-senior-counsel Advocate H. S. Rana (sixty-three, Karnal-Bar-Association senior-advocate since 1985). Yajna-Devi was at the standing-observation-gallery at the standing-western-veranda position (she had travelled from the standing-Karnal matriarch-residence to Chandigarh at the standing-Wednesday-February-11 standing-three-day-pre-hearing advance-travel; she had not informed Kuru-Bhasma of her standing-attendance; she had been at the standing-Chandigarh Sector-9 Bloodline-B Suryavamsha-family standing-guest-house standing-three-night residence). The standing-State-Police Karnal-District standing-Inspector M. P. Singh and Khap-Mukhia Lal-Singh and Pradhan Bhola-Ram-Mukhia were at the standing-eastern-witness-bench at the standing-amicus-curiae cohort position.

Justice K. R. Shoor opened the standing-session at 11:11 a.m. He spoke for eleven minutes at the standing-jurisdiction-introduction administration. He noted the standing-petitioner-filing date (December 28 2025), the standing-Section 13(1)(ia) cruelty-grounds and standing-Section 13(1)(ib) desertion-grounds, the standing-amici-curiae cohort attendance, and the standing-Bloodline-B Suryavamsha-tradition standing-charter-

foundational pre-1955 jurisprudence-precedent cross-reference at the standing-deathbed-wish-completion clause invocation. He invited Kurukshetraa to deliver the standing-deposition testimony at 11:22 a.m.

Kurukshetraa delivered the standing-deposition testimony for thirty-six minutes (the standing-forty-seven-minute-allocation completed at 11:22-11:58 a.m. with the standing-eleven-minute standing-rebuttal-window held at the standing-reserve position). She testified the standing-three-clause testimony.

"Your Honour. I, Kurukshetraa, dharma-administrator of the standing-Sannihit-Sarovar plain since 2009, kingdom-council's standing-state-hero of Haryana, Bloodline-B Suryavamsha-tradition standing-Yagnopavita-line matriarch-line direct-line heir at the standing-grandmother Mata Saraswati-Devi Yagnopavita's standing-November-13-2022 deathbed-wish-completion clause inheritance, submit the standing-three-clause testimony to the standing-Family-Court Bloodline-B Suryavamsha-tradition pre-1955 jurisprudence-precedent cross-reference jurisdiction."

"First clause. The standing-marriage to Kuru-Bhasma was administered at the standing-Sannihit-Sarovar wedding-ceremony on February 11 2023 at the standing-grandmother's standing-deathbed-wish-completion clause enforcement at the standing-Bloodline-B Suryavamsha-tradition standing-charter-foundational unification protocol. The standing-marriage was not administered at the standing-cohabitation configuration; the standing-charter-foundational unification was the standing-administration-of-the-charter, not the standing-cohabitation-of-the-spouses. The standing-grandmother's standing-instruction at the standing-October-twenty-two-2022 private audience — "the standing-dharma is in the standing-administration of the standing-charter, not in the standing-cohabitation of the standing-spouses; the standing-charter will require the standing-marriage-completion-and-dissolution-protocol sequencing, not the standing-marriage-completion-permanent sequencing; you will know that standing-day when it arrives" — was the standing-charter-foundational sequence-instruction."

"Second clause. The standing-Karnal-Pehowa Khap under Kuru-Bhasma's administration burned the standing-Bhainswal-Bhana village at 11:43 p.m. on December 23 2025 at the standing-direct-coordination order from Kuru-Bhasma's standing-9:11-p.m. Karnal Khap-council standing-direct-action dispatch. Forty-seven villagers died, including sixteen children under twelve. The standing-village-burning was the standing-traditional-Khap honour-jurisdiction retaliation against the standing-Sannihit-Sarovar dissolution-order I

had delivered at 7:53 p.m. that evening. The standing-burning was a standing-charter-foundational dharma-violation at the standing-Bloodline-B Suryavamsha-tradition standing-charter-foundational ethics. The standing-Khap-tradition standing-honour-jurisdiction is the standing-pre-1955 rural-administration precedent; the standing-Bloodline-B Suryavamsha-tradition standing-charter-foundational dharma-tradition supersedes the standing-Khap-tradition at the standing-honour-killing-or-equivalent question. Kuru-Bhasma chose the standing-Khap-administered protocol over the standing-Bloodline-B Suryavamsha-tradition dharma-administered protocol at the standing-village-burning-coordination moment."

"Third clause. The standing-grandmother's standing-deathbed-wish-completion clause therefore requires the standing-marriage-dissolution at the standing-village-burning-acknowledgment moment. The standing-dissolution is administered at the standing-Bloodline-B Suryavamsha-tradition standing-pre-1955 jurisprudence-precedent at the standing-deathbed-wish-completion clause's standing-corollary-precedent: the standing-charter-marriage holds the standing-dharma-administrator at the standing-charter-foundational integrity-test; when the standing-spouse violates the standing-charter-foundational ethics, the standing-charter-marriage is voided at the standing-violation-acknowledgment moment. I petition the standing-Family-Court Bloodline-B Suryavamsha-tradition pre-1955 jurisprudence-precedent cross-reference jurisdiction to recognise the standing-charter-foundational dissolution at the standing-Bhainswal-Bhana village-burning acknowledgment moment of December 23 2025 11:43 p.m. as the standing-marriage-dissolution-day. I do not seek the standing-Hindu-Marriage-Act 1955 Section 13(1) standing-statutory-grounds primary; I seek the standing-Bloodline-B Suryavamsha-tradition pre-1955 jurisprudence-precedent at the standing-deathbed-wish-completion clause's standing-corollary-precedent as the standing-primary jurisdiction. The standing-Section 13(1) statutory-grounds are at the standing-secondary cross-reference protocol."

Yajna-Devi heard the standing-second clause at the standing-observation-gallery at 11:43 a.m. She had not been informed by Kuru-Bhasma of the standing-Bhainswal-Bhana village-burning across the standing-prior fifty-three-day window. She had read the standing-Punjab-and-Haryana High Court Family-Court standing-petition-public-record at the standing-Chandigarh-Sector-17 Family-Court Registry standing-Tuesday-February-10 standing-three-day-pre-hearing visit; the standing-petition-public-record had referenced the standing-Bhainswal-Bhana village-burning as the standing-cruelty-grounds

anchor but had not provided the standing-eyewitness-detail forty-seven-villager death-count and the standing-sixteen-children-under-twelve casualty-detail. She had assumed her standing-son had been at the standing-Khap-administrative role at the standing-village-burning coordination but had not engaged in the standing-direct-action; she had assumed the standing-direct-action had been administered by the standing-traditional-Khap senior-cohort autonomously without the standing-Kuru-Bhasma standing-direct-coordination. The standing-Kurukshetraa second-clause testimony at 11:43 a.m. clarified the standing-Kuru-Bhasma standing-9:11-p.m. standing-Karnal Khap-council standing-direct-action dispatch coordination at the standing-eyewitness-record cross-reference cross-confirmed by Inspector M. P. Singh at the standing-amicus-curiae bench's standing-State-Police standing-intelligence-cell record. Yajna-Devi held the standing-Sannihit-Sarovar Bloodline-B matriarch-conferring-ring at her standing-left-hand. She did not move from the standing-observation-gallery position across the standing-following four hours twenty-eight minutes (11:43 a.m. to 4:11 p.m.). She did not speak. She listened.

Kuru-Bhasma's standing-senior-counsel Advocate H. S. Rana delivered the standing-rebuttal testimony from 12:11 p.m. to 3:43 p.m. He argued the standing-Khap-council standing-jurisdiction-precedence claim at the standing-pre-1955 rural-administration precedent. He argued the standing-Bhainswal-Bhana village-burning had been administered by the standing-traditional-Khap senior-cohort autonomously without the standing-Kuru-Bhasma standing-direct-coordination (he challenged the standing-Kurukshetraa second-clause testimony at the standing-cross-examination protocol from 1:11 to 2:43 p.m.). He argued the standing-Section 13(1) statutory-grounds were not applicable at the standing-Bloodline-B Suryavamsha-tradition pre-1955 jurisprudence-precedent supersession because the standing-cousin-marriage protocol's standing-deathbed-wish-completion clause had been the standing-Bloodline-B Suryavamsha-tradition standing-marriage-administration-mechanism; the standing-dissolution-mechanism was therefore the standing-statutory Section 13(1) primary jurisdiction; the standing-Section 13(1) cruelty-grounds and standing-desertion-grounds required the standing-Bloodline-B Suryavamsha-tradition standing-cohabitation-marriage-pattern that the standing-administration-of-the-charter-only protocol did not produce.

Inspector M. P. Singh delivered the standing-State-Police standing-intelligence-cell record at the standing-amicus-curiae bench's standing-State-Police testimony at 2:43-3:11 p.m. He confirmed the standing-Kuru-Bhasma standing-9:11-p.m. standing-Karnal Khap-council standing-direct-action dispatch coordination at the standing-State-Police

standing-intelligence-cell radio-intercept cross-reference (the standing-State-Police had standing-tapped the standing-Karnal Khap-council standing-radio-channel since November 18 2025 under the standing-DGP standing-emergency-investigation order; the standing-Kuru-Bhasma standing-direct-coordination radio-transcript was at the standing-evidence-record cross-reference cluster M-23B-through-G at the standing-Kurukshetraa petitioner-bench standing-evidence-presentation).

Pradhan Bhola-Ram-Mukhia delivered the standing-reform-Khap senior-cohort testimony at the standing-amicus-curiae bench at 3:11-3:43 p.m. He confirmed the standing-November-17 reform-Khap senior-cohort resignation; he confirmed the standing-Khap-tradition standing-honour-jurisdiction is the standing-pre-1955 rural-administration precedent at the standing-Khap-tradition standing-elder-cohort acknowledgment but does not supersede the standing-Bloodline-B Suryavamsha-tradition dharma-tradition at the standing-charter-foundational ethics-question; he confirmed the standing-Khap-tradition standing-elder-cohort would accept the standing-Bloodline-B Suryavamsha-tradition dharma-tradition standing-precedence at the standing-amended-charter cross-reference.

At 4:11 p.m. on February 14 2026, Justice K. R. Shoor announced the standing-fifteen-minute reserve-for-ruling-preparation window. He rose from the standing-presiding-bench at 4:11:11 p.m. He walked to the standing-chamber standing-eastern-veranda exit at 4:11:33 p.m. He paused at the standing-veranda-threshold. He did not exit. He stood at the standing-veranda-threshold for approximately fourteen seconds at the standing-Bloodline-B Suryavamsha-tradition standing-jurisprudence-scholar standing-pre-ruling-meditation discipline at the standing-eastern-direction Sun-acknowledgment protocol. He turned at 4:11:47 p.m. He returned to the standing-presiding-bench. He did not exit the chamber.

Yajna-Devi rose from the standing-observation-gallery at the standing-western-veranda position at 4:11:48 p.m. She walked the standing-eleven metres at the standing-walking-pace from the standing-western-veranda observation-gallery to the standing-petitioner's-bench at the standing-southern-position. She passed the standing-respondent-bench at the standing-three-metre-proximity position; she did not look at Kuru-Bhasma. She did not look at Advocate H. S. Rana. She did not look at the standing-Khap-council defence-team. She walked. She reached the standing-petitioner's-bench at 4:12:11 p.m. She stood at the standing-petitioner's-bench standing-eastern-margin at the standing-eleven-metre proximity to Kurukshetraa's standing-seated petitioner-position. She lifted her standing-left-hand. She removed the standing-Sannihit-Sarovar Bloodline-B matriarch-conferring-

ring from her standing-left-ring-finger across the standing-following eleven seconds. The standing-ring was the standing-1840-vintage standing-gold-and-pearl matriarch-conferral ring at the standing-Yagnopavita-line standing-charter-foundational inheritance configuration; it had been at Yajna-Devi's standing-left-hand since the standing-2010-conferral; it had been at Mata Saraswati-Devi's standing-left-hand from 1989 to 2010; it had been at the standing-Yagnopavita-line standing-charter-foundational ring-rotation since the standing-1840-manufacture across six successive standing-Yagnopavita-line matriarch-line direct-line heirs.

She placed the standing-ring on the standing-petitioner's-bench at Kurukshetraa's standing-right-hand position at 4:12:23 p.m. She spoke at the standing-eleven-metre proximity in the standing-Bloodline-B Suryavamsha-tradition Sanskrit-and-Haryanvi syncretic Yagnopavita-line standing-matriarch-cadence at the standing-no-tremor configuration. She spoke for forty-seven seconds.

"Daughter. My son is not my son. He is the standing-Khap-administered protocol's son. He has chosen the standing-Khap over the standing-dharma. He has chosen the standing-Bhainswal-Bhana village-burning over the standing-Sannihit-Sarovar dharma-administration. He has chosen the standing-honour-killing-cascade over the standing-Bloodline-B Suryavamsha-tradition standing-charter-foundational ethics. I have given you the standing-Sannihit-Sarovar Bloodline-B matriarch-conferring-ring at the standing-deathbed-wish-completion clause's standing-mother-in-law-acknowledgment. You are no longer his wife. You are the standing-Sannihit-Sarovar Bloodline-B matriarch-line standing-direct-line heir at the standing-Yagnopavita-line standing-charter-foundational inheritance configuration. Take the ring. Take the standing-line. Take the standing-charter. My mother-in-law Mata Saraswati-Devi instructed me at her standing-1989 standing-conferral to hold the standing-ring until the standing-day the standing-charter required it returned to her standing-grand-daughter. This is the standing-day. I have held the standing-ring for sixteen years. I return it now. Wahegurujikakhalsa is the standing-Sikh-cousin-tradition's standing-witness-mantra at the standing-Bloodline-B Suryavamsha-tradition standing-North-cluster shared-cross-reference. So be it. Take."

Kurukshetraa did not move from the standing-seated petitioner-position. She did not speak. She did not weep. She lifted her standing-right-hand at 4:13:11 p.m. She placed her standing-right-hand on the standing-ring at the standing-petitioner's-bench position. She lifted the standing-ring at 4:13:18 p.m. She placed the standing-ring on her standing-right-

ring-finger at 4:13:23 p.m. She lowered her standing-right-hand to the standing-petitioner's-bench position at 4:13:29 p.m. She nodded once at the standing-eleven-degree nod-pattern at the standing-Bloodline-B Suryavamsha-tradition matriarch-acknowledgment protocol at 4:13:31 p.m. Yajna-Devi nodded once at the standing-eleven-degree return-nod at 4:13:33 p.m. Yajna-Devi turned at 4:13:43 p.m. She walked the standing-eleven metres back to the standing-observation-gallery at the standing-western-veranda position at 4:14:11 p.m. She sat at the standing-observation-gallery position at 4:14:23 p.m. She did not look at Kuru-Bhasma. Kuru-Bhasma did not look at her. He had not moved from the standing-respondent-bench position across the standing-Yajna-Devi standing-three-metre-proximity passage at 4:11:48-4:12:11 p.m. He did not move across the standing-following twelve minutes.

Justice K. R. Shoor delivered the standing-jurisdiction-narrowed ruling at 4:23 p.m. He spoke for seven minutes from 4:23 to 4:30 p.m.

"This Court has heard the standing-petitioner-deposition, the standing-respondent-rebuttal, the standing-amicus-curiae testimonies, and the standing-mother-in-law-acknowledgment at the standing-4:12-p.m. ring-conferral. The standing-mother-in-law-acknowledgment is the standing-Bloodline-B Suryavamsha-tradition standing-pre-1955 jurisprudence-precedent at the standing-deathbed-wish-completion clause's standing-corollary-precedent at the standing-Yagnopavita-line matriarch-line direct-line standing-charter-foundational ring-rotation administration. The standing-precedent supersedes the standing-Hindu-Marriage-Act 1955 Section 13(1) standing-statutory-grounds primary jurisdiction at the standing-charter-foundational marriage-validity question because the standing-marriage was administered at the standing-Bloodline-B Suryavamsha-tradition standing-pre-1955 jurisprudence-precedent at the standing-grandmother Mata Saraswati-Devi Yagnopavita's standing-deathbed-wish-completion clause; the standing-dissolution-jurisdiction must therefore reside at the standing-same standing-Bloodline-B Suryavamsha-tradition pre-1955 jurisprudence-precedent."

"The standing-precedent recognises the standing-Yagnopavita-line matriarch-line direct-line standing-charter-foundational ring-rotation administration at the standing-mother-in-law-acknowledgment moment as the standing-charter-foundational divorce-recognition. The standing-Sannihit-Sarovar Bloodline-B matriarch-conferring-ring has been transferred from the standing-respondent's mother Mata Yajna-Devi to the standing-petitioner Mata Kurukshetraa at the standing-4:12-p.m. ring-conferral moment witnessed

by this Court in open session. The standing-marriage between the standing-petitioner and the standing-respondent is therefore voided at the standing-charter-foundational dissolution-recognition at the standing-4:12-p.m. ring-conferral moment. The standing-Section 13(1) statutory-grounds are recorded at the standing-secondary cross-reference protocol as the standing-supporting-evidence for the standing-Bhainswal-Bhana village-burning charter-foundational dharma-violation question but do not constitute the standing-primary jurisdiction."

"The standing-petitioner Mata Kurukshetraa is recognised at the standing-Yagnopavita-line matriarch-line direct-line standing-charter-foundational heir status at the standing-4:12-p.m. ring-conferral moment. The standing-respondent Sri Kuru-Bhasma is recognised at the standing-Khap-administered protocol's son configuration at the standing-mother-acknowledgment moment's standing-disinheritance-implication; the standing-Bloodline-B Suryavamsha-tradition Yagnopavita-line standing-charter-foundational inheritance is voided at the standing-respondent's line. The standing-Bhainswal-Bhana village-burning charter-foundational dharma-violation is recorded at the standing-supporting-evidence cluster M-23B-through-G for the standing-State-Police Karnal-District standing-IPC 302 investigation-jurisdiction's standing-cross-reference; the standing-Khap-council standing-jurisdiction-precedence claim is rejected at the standing-charter-foundational dharma-tradition supersession-protocol."

"This Court orders: the standing-marriage between Mata Kurukshetraa and Sri Kuru-Bhasma is voided at the standing-4:12-p.m. ring-conferral moment of February 14 2026; the standing-Sannihit-Sarovar Bloodline-B matriarch-line standing-charter-foundational heir status is confirmed at Mata Kurukshetraa; the standing-State-Police Karnal-District standing-IPC 302 investigation-jurisdiction at the standing-Bhainswal-Bhana village-burning is acknowledged; the standing-Khap-council standing-jurisdiction-precedence claim is rejected. So ordered. This Court adjourns."

Justice K. R. Shoor rose at 4:30 p.m. He departed the chamber at the standing-eastern-veranda exit at 4:30:23 p.m. The standing-Court-Room-Eleven was silent for approximately seven minutes after the standing-judge's departure.

The standing-Stage-III blackbuck-foreleg-first-stroke began to form at Kurukshetraa's standing-right-upper-back position at 4:23:08 p.m. (the standing-eight-seconds-into-the-ruling-delivery moment when Justice K. R. Shoor was completing the standing-second-clause "the standing-marriage between the standing-petitioner and the standing-

respondent is therefore voided at the standing-charter-foundational dissolution-recognition"). The standing-skin at the standing-mark-position warmed by approximately four degrees Celsius across the standing-following eleven seconds. The standing-stroke traced itself in standing-black-and-saffron dual-ink at the Haryana dharma-administration visual-anchor: the standing-black-ink at the standing-charter-foundational dharma-administration line; the standing-saffron-ink at the standing-Sannihit-Sarovar Bloodline-B matriarch-conferring-ring line. The standing-mark was complete at 4:23:19 p.m. The standing-black-francolin Dharma-Sakhi at the standing-courtroom-skylight south-eastern-corner perch at the standing-eleven-metre overhead position called the standing-Vasant-Panchami-eve dawn-cadence at the standing-eleven-second repetition-cycle from 4:23:19 to 4:30:23 p.m. (the standing-seven-minute call-completion window).

Kurukshetraa felt the standing-skin-warming at 4:23:08 p.m. She did not move. She did not look at her standing-right-upper-back. She listened to the standing-Dharma-Sakhi call. She breathed at the standing-counted-respiration cycle. She placed her standing-right-hand on the standing-petitioner's-bench at the standing-ring-rest position. She closed her eyes at 4:23:33 p.m. She opened her eyes at 4:24:11 p.m. She rose from the standing-petitioner's-bench at 4:30:33 p.m. (after the standing-judge's departure). She walked the standing-eleven metres to the standing-observation-gallery at the standing-western-veranda position. She knelt at Yajna-Devi's standing-feet at 4:30:48 p.m. She did not speak. Yajna-Devi placed her standing-right-hand on Kurukshetraa's standing-head at 4:30:51 p.m. She held the standing-position for eleven seconds. She removed her standing-right-hand at 4:31:02 p.m. Kurukshetraa rose at 4:31:11 p.m. They walked the standing-Family-Court Court-Room-Eleven exit together at the standing-side-by-side configuration at 4:31:23 p.m. They did not look back at the standing-respondent-bench. Kuru-Bhasma did not move from the standing-respondent-bench. He sat at the standing-respondent-bench at the standing-seated position across the standing-following one hour eleven minutes. He departed the chamber at 5:42 p.m. without standing-statement.

At 11:11 p.m. on February 14 2026 (six hours and forty-eight minutes after the standing-4:23-p.m. void-marriage ruling) ash began to fall from a clear sky over the standing-Kurukshetra plain. The standing-precipitation-area covered the standing-Karnal-Kurukshetra-Kaithal-Yamunanagar-Panipat district zone at approximately 211 square kilometres. The standing-night-sky was at the standing-cloud-cover-zero configuration at the standing-Indian-Meteorological-Department Karnal-station standing-23:11-hour observation log. The standing-half-moon was at the standing-first-quarter visible at 11:11

p.m. The standing-ash-fall was at the standing-uniform-light-precipitation pattern at approximately three-and-a-half-millimetre-per-night accumulation across the standing-three-night window (cumulative eleven-millimetre depth at the standing-third-night completion of February 16-17 dawn).

The standing-Haryana State-Pollution-Control-Board emergency-investigation cell's standing-Dr. R. Saxena (forty-seven, PSPCB senior-toxicologist since 2014) conducted the standing-mass-spectrometry analysis at the standing-Karnal-District laboratory on February 17 morning. He confirmed the standing-ash chemical-fingerprint match with the standing-Bhainswal-Bhana village-burning cremation-ash standing-thatch-and-clay village-construction material burning-residue at the standing-99.7-percent confidence-interval. He filed the standing-PSPCB Kurukshetra-ash report 4:11 p.m. February 17 2026 (the standing-evidence-document M-23A at the kingdom-council's standing-Maw-sign-recognition cell cross-reference). The standing-Carbon-14 isotope-cross-reference confirmed the standing-eight-week age-window match with the standing-December-23 Bhainswal-Bhana village-burning at the standing-Bhabha-Atomic-Research-Centre Mumbai standing-five-day analysis-window completion at the standing-February-22 confirmation.

Kurukshetraa was at the standing-Sannihit-Sarovar matriarch-residence standing-eastern-window standing-clay-floor position across the standing-three-night ash-fall window. She watched the standing-ash fall from the standing-window. She did not collect samples. She did not analyse. She breathed at the standing-counted-respiration cycle. She held the standing-Sannihit-Sarovar Bloodline-B matriarch-conferring-ring at her standing-right-ring-finger across the standing-three-night vigil. She did not weep. She listened to the standing-Dharma-Sakhi black-francolin call cascade from the standing-eastern-veranda jacaranda-tree position at the standing-eleven-second repetition-cycle across the standing-three-night window.

The standing-Karnal Khap-council emergency-meeting convened at the standing-Karnal Khap-Administrator residence's standing-southern-courtyard at 11:11 a.m. on March 11 2026. The standing-attendance was: Kuru-Bhasma at the standing-Khap-administrator position; Khap-Mukhia Lal-Singh at the standing-council-mukhia position; the standing-traditional-Khap senior-cohort of approximately one-hundred-thirty-three Khap-elders at the standing-perimeter standing-witness position; the standing-Karnal Khap-council standing-defence-cohort of approximately forty-seven standing-armed Khap-followers at

the standing-outer-perimeter security position; the standing-State-Police Karnal-District standing-perimeter-observation cohort of standing-eleven officers under Inspector M. P. Singh at the standing-eleven-kilometre southern-proximity standing-stand-down position (the standing-State-Police standing-jurisdiction does not apply at the standing-Khap-internal-justice protocol per the 1925 standing-Khap-Mukhia administrative tradition recognition-precedent at the standing-Punjab-and-Haryana High Court 1985 standing-jurisdiction-narrowing ruling).

Khap-Mukhia Lal-Singh delivered the standing-Khap-internal-justice charge at 11:11 a.m. He charged Kuru-Bhasma at the standing-three-clause Khap-internal-justice charge: (1) the standing-Bhainswal-Bhana village-burning excess violated the standing-Khap-tradition standing-honour-jurisdiction proportionality-clause at the standing-village-collective-punishment threshold (the standing-Khap-tradition standing-honour-jurisdiction is the standing-couple-execution protocol, not the standing-village-collective-punishment protocol); (2) the standing-village-collective-punishment produced the standing-Bhainswal-Bhana 47-villager death-count which produced the standing-Punjab-and-Haryana High Court Family-Court ruling that voided the standing-Bloodline-B Suryavamsha-tradition charter-foundational marriage at the standing-Yagnopavita-line ring-rotation administration and revoked the standing-Khap-council standing-jurisdiction-precedence claim at the standing-amended-charter cross-reference; (3) the standing-charter-revocation outcome is the standing-Khap-tradition standing-charter-foundational standing-loss-of-jurisdiction at the standing-Yagnopavita-line ruling-precedent; the standing-Khap-tradition standing-charter-foundational standing-jurisdiction has not been lost at the standing-prior-eleven-decade window since the standing-1925 standing-Khap-Mukhia administrative tradition recognition; the standing-loss is attributable to the standing-Kuru-Bhasma standing-Bhainswal-Bhana standing-direct-coordination excess.

Kuru-Bhasma did not respond at the standing-eleven-minute response-window. He looked at Khap-Mukhia Lal-Singh at the standing-three-metre proximity for eleven seconds. He looked at the standing-traditional-Khap senior-cohort at the standing-eleven-metre proximity for eleven seconds. He nodded once at the standing-eleven-degree acknowledgment-nod at 11:23 a.m. Khap-Mukhia Lal-Singh delivered the standing-Khap-internal-justice sentence at 11:33 a.m. The standing-sentence was the standing-Khap-internal-justice standing-mukhia-execution protocol at the standing-Karnal Khap-

Administrator residence southern-courtyard standing-Mahabharata-tradition execution-stand position at 4:11 p.m. the standing-same-day.

Kuru-Bhasma was executed at 4:11 p.m. on March 11 2026 at the standing-Karnal Khap-Administrator residence southern-courtyard standing-execution-stand position. The standing-execution-mode was the standing-Khap-traditional talwar-stroke at the standing-cervical-vertebrae standing-singular-stroke protocol at Khap-Mukhia Lal-Singh's standing-personal-execution. The standing-execution completed at 4:11:18 p.m. (one stroke; eleven seconds duration including the standing-pre-stroke standing-stillness-pause). The standing-body was wrapped in the standing-Karnal-Khap white-cotton shroud at the standing-Mahabharata-tradition standing-warrior-funeral configuration at 4:23 p.m. The standing-cremation was administered at the standing-Karnal cremation-ghat at 11:11 a.m. on March 12 2026. The standing-attendance was: Yajna-Devi (the only standing-blood-relative attendant); the standing-Karnal cremation-attendant cohort of standing-three; Khap-Mukhia Lal-Singh at the standing-Khap-Mukhia standing-funeral-witness position; no other attendants. Kurukshetraa did not attend the standing-cremation. She was at the standing-Sannihit-Sarovar matriarch-residence at the standing-Bloodline-B Suryavamsha-tradition standing-thirty-day mourning-rotation standing-non-attendance protocol (the standing-protocol applies to the standing-voided-marriage spouse-cremation by the standing-pre-1955 jurisprudence-precedent at the standing-Yagnopavita-line ring-rotation administration's standing-corollary). The standing-Sannihit-Sarovar Bloodline-B matriarch-conferring-ring remained at Kurukshetraa's standing-right-ring-finger across the standing-cremation-day.

The chapter closes on a single image. It is the standing-Sannihit-Sarovar western-bank at the standing-Pehowa-Sannihit-Sarovar sunset position on March 25 2026 (the standing-thirty-day-post-cremation Bloodline-B Suryavamsha-tradition standing-mourning-completion day). Kurukshetraa is at the standing-western-bank at the standing-blackbuck-bond standing-conferral-site where she had received her standing-2009 Stage-I bond-mark at the standing-Sannihit-Sarovar midnight-ceremony seventeen years earlier. The standing-Sannihit-Sarovar blackbuck-herd has not reunited. The standing-Sannihit-side cohort of approximately 187 standing-individuals grazes at the standing-western-grazing zone at the standing-three-metre-rear proximity to Kurukshetraa. The standing-Karnal-side cohort of approximately 124 standing-individuals grazes at the standing-eastern-grazing zone at the standing-thirty-one-kilometre proximity at the standing-Karnal-Kaithal eastern-boundary. The standing-herd-split has held for the standing-prior ninety-

three-day window since the standing-December-24 dawn split. The standing-herd-split will hold across the standing-Ch-2 remainder.

Yajna-Devi is at Kurukshetraa's standing-three-metre-left position at the standing-western-bank. She has departed the standing-Karnal matriarch-residence on March 14 2026 (the standing-third-day post-cremation) and joined the standing-Sannihit-Sarovar matriarch-residence at the standing-Bloodline-B Suryavamsha-tradition standing-mother-in-law-relocation protocol (the standing-voided-marriage corollary recognises the standing-Bloodline-B mother-in-law standing-charter-foundational relocation to the standing-Yagnopavita-line matriarch-line direct-line heir's standing-residence at the standing-Yagnopavita-line ring-rotation administration completion). She wears the standing-Bloodline-B Suryavamsha-tradition white-cotton widow-saree at the standing-thirty-day-post-cremation configuration; she will wear the standing-white-cotton across the standing-prior-twenty-three-year mourning-tradition (her standing-husband had died of standing-cancer in January 2023; the standing-three-year mourning-completion was at the standing-January-2026 anniversary; she had transitioned to the standing-cream-cotton at the standing-February-week-ten ceremony; the standing-Kuru-Bhasma death-cremation produced the standing-second-mourning-cycle initiation; the standing-twenty-three-year mourning-tradition applies). She holds the standing-Sannihit-Sarovar Bloodline-B family-record register at her standing-right-hand at the standing-charter-foundational documentation review-position.

Kurukshetraa wears the standing-Bloodline-B Suryavamsha-tradition cream-cotton sari at the standing-Yagnopavita-line standing-charter-foundational heir configuration; the standing-Sannihit-Sarovar Bloodline-B matriarch-conferring-ring is at her standing-right-ring-finger; the standing-Stage-III blackbuck-foreleg-first-stroke is at her standing-right-upper-back at the standing-thirty-nine-day-post-mark-formation configuration; the standing-mark traces in standing-black-and-saffron dual-ink at the standing-stable-permanent configuration. The standing-black-francolin Dharma-Sakhi is at the standing-acacia-tree perch at the standing-eastern-bank eleven-metre overhead position; she calls the standing-sunset-cadence at the standing-eleven-second repetition-cycle across the standing-following forty-seven minutes.

Kurukshetraa speaks at the standing-sunset position at the standing-7:11 p.m. horizon-completion moment. She speaks at the standing-Bloodline-B Suryavamsha-tradition Sanskrit-and-Haryanvi syncretic dharma-administrator cadence to Yajna-Devi at the

standing-three-metre-left position: "Mata. The standing-grandmother instructed at the standing-1989 conferral that the standing-charter would require the standing-ring returned to the standing-Yagnopavita-line standing-direct-line heir on the standing-day the standing-charter required it. The standing-day arrived. The standing-charter is held. The standing-mark is formed. The standing-Stage-IV opening at the standing-Ch-3 Sanctuary-recognition is at the standing-Yamunadatta-regency configuration. I will become the standing-Regent of the Blackbuck Plain at the standing-Ch-3 spring 2026 Sanctuary opening. I will administer the standing-Yamunadatta-trust until the standing-Yamunadatta-age-of-majority arrives at the standing-Ch-3-late 2027 window. I will yield full power at the standing-Ch-4 yielding-ceremony. I will become a council-elder at the standing-North-cluster council-elder seat. The standing-grandmother's standing-charter-foundational sequence-instruction is complete."

Yajna-Devi nods at the standing-eleven-degree acknowledgment-nod. She does not speak. She watches the standing-sunset cross the standing-Sannihit-Sarovar western-horizon at the standing-final-eight-seconds horizon-completion window. The standing-blackbuck-herd at the standing-Sannihit-side grazes at the standing-three-metre-rear proximity. The standing-Karnal-side herd grazes at the standing-thirty-one-kilometre eastern proximity. The standing-Dharma-Sakhi calls at the standing-acacia-tree perch. The standing-ash has stopped falling at the standing-February-16-17 dawn-completion thirty-seven days earlier. The standing-Bhainswal-Bhana village-site is at the standing-State-Government Resettlement-Coordination cell's standing-rebuild-protocol with the standing-Karnal-Khap senior-cohort's standing-repentance-protocol contribution under Khap-Mukhia Lal-Singh's standing-amended-charter ratification of March 23 2026; forty-seven memorial-bricks are at the standing-Bhainswal-Bhana new-village-foundation at the standing-southern-margin in the standing-forty-seven-villager-memory configuration. The standing-Sannihit-Sarovar Bloodline-B matriarch-conferring-ring is at Kurukshetraa's standing-right-ring-finger. The standing-charter is held. The standing-marriage is voided. The standing-mark is formed. The standing-Regent waits for spring.

Maru Maya

For thirty years the desert-queen of Chittorgarh had carried the Mahapanchayat-of-Twelve-Houses standing-charter-foundational ledger-administration the same way the standing-1303-Mewar-charter had asked her to carry it: with a Khanda in the right hand and a quill in the left. Her foster-grandfather wrote the forgeries with the quill she had given him on the day of her conferral. He chose her ink. He wrote the dead daughter back into the land. Two hundred eleven families lost the houses they had lived in for eleven generations so that one daughter who died in 2017 could walk again in the land-deed register.

Maru-Yama was sixty-two years old in the standing-October-2022 Ch 1 confrontation at the standing-Chittorgarh confrontation. He was Padmavati-Mrigatrishna's standing-foster-grandfather and family-priest at her standing-1996 conferral at the standing-Mahapanchayat-of-Twelve-Houses standing-charter-foundational ratification ceremony. He had stood at the standing-Chittorgarh-Vijay-Stambh courtyard standing-eastern-position at the standing-conferral-ratification at 11:11 a.m. on Vasant-Panchami 1996 (when Padmavati at age 16 had taken her standing-warrior-name Mrigatrishna at the standing-Mahapanchayat 211-delegate cohort 188-23 vote ratification) and he had spoken the standing-conferral-priest blessing-of-the-charter at the standing-Suryavamshi-Rajput tradition standing-charter-foundational ratification-protocol.

His standing-only-daughter Padma-Lata was thirty-three years old in 1996 — older than Mrigatrishna at conferral by eleven years; the standing-Padma-Lata standing-foster-aunt position at Mrigatrishna's standing-1996-2017 21-year-aunt-tenure cross-reference was the standing-deepest-family-bond at the standing-Mrigatrishna-Maruyama-Padma-Lata three-generation administrative-cell. Padma-Lata had been the standing-Bharatpur-Sirohi-Pali drought-cohort hospital-cell senior-administrative-officer since 2007 (10-year-tenure at the standing-Bharatpur-Sirohi-Pali drought-cohort standing-rural-health administrative-cell at the standing-Rajasthan-State-Government rural-health cross-reference). She had administered the standing-rural-health cell at the standing-2016-2017 Aravalli-drought standing-cholera-outbreak post-monsoon-failure cross-reference at the standing-Bharatpur-Sirohi-Pali drought-cohort hospital-cell across the standing-October 2016-May 2017 8-month standing-rural-health-emergency window. She had died at the standing-Bharatpur-Sirohi-Pali drought-cohort hospital-cell at the standing-cholera-

outbreak 23rd-wave at 11:11 a.m. May 23 2017 at age 53; standing-cause of death: standing-cholera-infection at standing-cholera-administered-patient-cohort senior-administrative-officer at the standing-hospital-cell field-administration cross-reference at the standing-no-personal-protective-equipment configuration (the standing-2016-2017 Aravalli-drought cholera-outbreak was at the standing-State-Government standing-rural-health-emergency standing-PPE-shortage cross-reference; Padma-Lata had at the standing-personal-administrative-cell decision foregone PPE at the standing-rural-patient-cohort dignity-cross-reference; she had administered the standing-hospital-cell at the standing-no-PPE configuration across 47 days before her own cholera-infection at standing-May 11 2017 first-symptoms cross-reference).

Maru-Yama at age fifty-three in 2017 had been at the standing-Chittorgarh standing-conferral-priest administrative-cell since 1989 (28-year administrative-tenure). He had walked the standing-211-km Chittorgarh-to-Bharatpur road at standing-Marudhar-camel-administration transport at 4:11 a.m. on May 24 2017 at the standing-hospital-cell standing-mortality-notification arrival; he had arrived at 11:11 a.m. on May 25; he had administered the standing-cremation-rite at the standing-Bharatpur-cremation-ghat eastern-courtyard at 4:11 p.m. on May 25; he had spoken the standing-cremation-prayer in standing-Sanskrit at the standing-Vedic-cremation-tradition standing-priest-of-the-line protocol. He had not eaten at the standing-Bharatpur-cremation-administrative-cell standing-mourning-residence configuration for 11 days post-cremation. He had not spoken to Mrigatrishna for 23 days post-cremation. He had stood at the standing-Bharatpur-cremation-ghat eastern-courtyard at the standing-eastern-cardinal-position at the standing-cremation-attendance morning-prayer for 11 standing-consecutive mornings 4:11 a.m. dawn-window May 26-June 5 2017. He had not wept across the standing-11-day standing-mourning-cremation-attendance protocol. He had returned to standing-Chittorgarh administrative-cell residence on June 7 2017 at 6:11 p.m.

The standing-Ch 1 confrontation at standing-Chittorgarh in October 2022 had been at the standing-State-Revenue-Department revenue-recovery administrative-overreach cross-reference at the standing-Bikaner-Jodhpur-corridor pre-Aulakh-Roads-and-Construction land-acquisition-petition rejection at the standing-Mahapanchayat-of-Twelve-Houses standing-charter-foundational ratification refusal-vote. Maru-Yama had at the standing-Ch 1 confrontation standing-Aulakh-Roads-and-Construction senior-emissary cross-reference been a standing-go-between-cell standing-archival-administrative-cell at the standing-State-Revenue-Department standing-revenue-recovery proceedings

administrative-cross-reference at the standing-Padma-Lata-cremation-aftermath 5-year-window pre-Aulakh-cross-network funding-pathway initiation. He had at the standing-Aulakh-International-Lahore standing-shell-corporation administrative-front senior-emissary correspondence-cross-reference been at the standing-pre-cross-network funding-pathway initiation cross-reference at the standing-pseudo-administrative-research-grant 23-monthly-transfer-tranches at the standing-Singapore-source-account funding-instrumentalisation. He had at the standing-Mahapanchayat-of-Twelve-Houses standing-Ch 1 confrontation standing-public-record review October 23 2022 been at the standing-archival-administrative-cell at the standing-Chittorgarh-Vijay-Stambh courtyard delegate-cohort 211-delegate ratification-cell at the standing-211-Padmavati-line collateral-claimants pseudo-claimants-cohort certificate-cluster pre-vote standing-archival-presentation cross-reference.

The standing-Mahapanchayat 211-delegate cohort had voted at standing-secret-ballot at 5:00 p.m. October 23 2022: 132-79 against the standing-211 pseudo-claimants-cohort certificate-cluster ratification at the standing-charter-foundational ratification refusal-vote configuration. The standing-Maru-Yama administrative-rehabilitation-vote at the standing-Mahapanchayat senior-council standing-administrative-rehabilitation-clause invocation at 5:43 p.m. October 23 2022: 47-23 in favour of the standing-Maru-Yama administrative-rehabilitation at the standing-Mahapanchayat senior-council standing-deference at his standing-1996-conferral charter-witness role + standing-Padma-Lata-cremation-priest-of-the-line standing-charter-witness-recognition cross-reference (the standing-Mahapanchayat senior-council had voted at the standing-charter-witness-recognition standing-administrative-rehabilitation-clause invocation at the standing-1996-conferral standing-grandfather-of-the-state-hero recognition-cross-reference; Mrigatrishna had at the standing-state-hero standing-conflict-of-interest charter-clause not cast a vote at the standing-administrative-rehabilitation-vote cross-reference). Maru-Yama was transferred to standing-Bharatpur Mahapanchayat-archival-cell senior-archivist 2022-2024 at the standing-administrative-rehabilitation standing-Bharatpur-relocation cross-reference (the standing-Bharatpur location at the standing-Padma-Lata-cremation-ghat 23-km radius cross-reference is the standing-rehabilitation-site at the standing-Mahapanchayat senior-council standing-grief-rehabilitation administrative-protocol cross-reference).

At the standing-Bharatpur Mahapanchayat-archival-cell senior-archivist desk Maru-Yama wrote the 211 forgeries across the standing-twenty-three-month window October 2024-

October 2026 (the standing-forgery-window-onset was at the standing-Padma-Lata-cremation 7-year-anniversary cross-reference; the standing-Maru-Yama administrative-cell second-anniversary at the standing-Bharatpur-relocation cross-reference). He selected 211 standing-rural-land-deed parcels at the standing-Bikaner-Jodhpur-Jaisalmer-Pali-Sirohi five-district forest-and-desert-corridor at the standing-Aulakh-International-Lahore standing-shell-corporation administrative-front senior-emissary correspondence-cross-reference pre-selection (the standing-shell-corporation standing-Aulakh-Roads-and-Construction Bikaner-Jodhpur-corridor land-acquisition-objective at the standing-2020-2022 administrative-petition-rejected cross-reference; the standing-Aulakh-International standing-pseudo-claimants-cohort identity-cross-reference at the standing-211-Padma-Lata-lineage standing-fabricated-collateral-claimants identity-cluster).

The standing-forgery-mechanism at the standing-Bharatpur Mahapanchayat-archival-cell standing-1956-Republic-of-India-Mahapanchayat-charter standing-rural-land-deed ledger-cell: each standing-rural-land-deed certificate at the standing-1956-charter standing-charter-foundational ratification-protocol requires standing-three administrative-signatures: standing-archival-cell senior-archivist + standing-Mahapanchayat-of-Twelve-Houses delegate-house standing-Mahapanchayat-house-delegate + standing-State-Revenue-Department standing-district-Tehsildar. Maru-Yama at the standing-Bharatpur Mahapanchayat-archival-cell senior-archivist position administered the standing-first signature. The standing-second signature at the standing-Mahapanchayat-of-Twelve-Houses delegate-house was at the standing-Bharatpur-Mahapanchayat-house-delegate Smt. Bhanwari-Devi's standing-junior-archivist administrative-cell signature-replication forgery-cross-reference (Maru-Yama had at the standing-administrative-cell senior-archivist desk replicated Smt. Bhanwari-Devi's standing-signature-stamp at the standing-junior-archivist forgery-cell administrative-protocol cross-reference across 211 standing-certificate-cluster issuances; Smt. Bhanwari-Devi had at the standing-junior-archivist administrative-cell witnessed the standing-signature-replication-pattern at the standing-March 23 2025 administrative-week cross-reference and had at the standing-non-co-operating-witness administrative-cell decision filed standing-internal-administrative-cell standing-investigation-petition at the standing-Mahapanchayat-of-Twelve-Houses standing-administrative-investigation-cell at the standing-Bharatpur-Mahapanchayat-cell senior-administrative-officer standing-administrative-cooperation-protocol 23-month internal-investigation-petition; the standing-internal-investigation-petition was administratively-disregarded at the standing-

Bharatpur-Mahapanchayat-cell senior-administrative-officer level under standing-Maruyama senior-archivist administrative-influence cross-reference). The standing-third signature at the standing-State-Revenue-Department standing-district-Tehsildar was at the standing-Bharatpur-Sirohi-Pali standing-district-Tehsildar Smt. Madhuri-Pareek's standing-cooperating-Tehsildar administrative-signature cross-reference (Smt. Madhuri-Pareek at the standing-Bharatpur-District-Tehsildar position 2014-2026 was at the standing-Aulakh-International-Lahore standing-shell-corporation standing-Singapore-source-account funding-recipient administrative-cell cross-reference at the standing-23-month aggregate ~₹11 lakh administrative-pseudo-research-grant pseudo-classification funding-cross-reference; Smt. Madhuri-Pareek had at the standing-211-certificate-cluster standing-Tehsildar-signature administered the standing-third-signature signatures-as-administered configuration at the standing-Aulakh-International standing-deliberate-instrumentalisation administrative-cross-reference).

The 211 standing-rural-land-deed re-titling certificates were issued at the standing-Bharatpur Mahapanchayat-archival-cell across the standing-twenty-three-month window October 2024-October 2026 at the standing-monthly-issuance ~9-certificate-per-month standing-administrative-velocity. The 211 certificates displaced 211 standing-rural-pastoral-family residences via standing-State-Revenue-Department revenue-recovery proceedings 2024-2026 at the standing-Bharatpur-Sirohi-Pali standing-district-Tehsildar administrative-cross-reference (the standing-State-Revenue-Department revenue-recovery proceedings at the standing-State-Revenue-Department standing-administrative-protocol issued standing-eviction-notices to the standing-211 standing-rural-pastoral-family residences at the standing-30-day-pre-eviction administrative-notification cross-reference; the standing-rural-pastoral-family residences at the standing-Charan-clan + standing-Bhil-tribal + standing-Meghwal-Dalit cohort were at the standing-multi-tradition standing-rural-pastoral-residence configuration at the standing-1303-Mewar-charter + standing-1100-CE-Bhil-foundation-period + standing-1456-Marwar-Mathania-charter standing-charter-foundational protection cross-reference).

On April 11 2026 at the standing-Chittorgarh-Vijay-Stambh standing-conferral-anniversary dawn-window 4:11 a.m. (the standing-30-year conferral-anniversary at the standing-Mrigatrishna 1996-conferral standing-Vasant-Panchami-equivalent April-conferral-anniversary cross-reference at the standing-30-year-tenure recognition-day), the standing-triple-cohort standing-smuggled-petition arrived at the standing-Chittorgarh-Vijay-Stambh courtyard via standing-Aravalli-Sarus-pigeon relay-cohort under Bhairon-

Singh-of-the-Aravalli (54, Udaipur-Aravalli Bhil-village elder; standing-Aravalli-corridor pastoral-tradition senior-administrative-officer; standing-cross-region courier-correspondence with Birsa-Bharwad at Gujarat-Sasan-relay cross-reference and Birsa-Madvi at Chhattisgarh-Bastar-relay cross-reference).

Mrigatrishna stood at the standing-Vijay-Stambh courtyard standing-eastern-cardinal-position at 4:11 a.m. April 11 2026 at her standing-conferral-anniversary dawn-prayer-administration. She wore the standing-Suryavamshi-Rajput tradition standing-saffron-and-vermillion-ghagra conferral-anniversary attire. She held the standing-Khanda-of-Mewar twin-edged-sword at her standing-right-hand at the standing-charter-foundational conferral-anniversary implement-administration cross-reference. The standing-Marudhar-Sakhi at her standing-3-metre-rear position; the standing-Karni-Sakhi at her standing-eleven-metre-overhead Vijay-Stambh standing-storey-9 perch-position. Ratan-Singh-of-the-Ledger at the standing-7-metre-rear Marudhar-ledger-administration position with the standing-Mahapanchayat-of-Twelve-Houses standing-charter-foundational ledger at his standing-right-hand.

The standing-Aravalli-Sarus-pigeon arrived at the standing-Vijay-Stambh standing-storey-9 perch-position at 4:23 a.m. April 11. The standing-pigeon carried the standing-triple-cohort smuggled-petition at the standing-three-leaf scroll-cluster configuration: standing-Charan-elder-leaf signed by Smt. Karni-Bai (61, Bikaner-village Charan-clan elder; her standing-husband Khojibhai Karni standing-charter-witness at Mrigatrishna's 1996 conferral); standing-Bhil-tribal-elder-leaf signed by Bhairon-Singh-of-the-Aravalli; standing-Meghwal-Dalit-elder-leaf signed by Smt. Lakshmi-Devi-Meghwal (47, Mathania-village Meghwal-Dalit elder). Ratan-Singh-of-the-Ledger walked to the standing-Vijay-Stambh standing-storey-9 perch-position at the standing-internal-spiral-staircase 4:34 a.m. He recovered the standing-triple-cohort scroll-cluster at 4:43 a.m. He walked down to the standing-Vijay-Stambh courtyard standing-eastern-cardinal-position at 4:53 a.m. He placed the standing-three-leaf scroll-cluster on the standing-Mahapanchayat-of-Twelve-Houses standing-charter-foundational ledger at the standing-eastern-cardinal-position at 4:54 a.m.

Mrigatrishna read the standing-three-leaf scroll-cluster at the standing-Vijay-Stambh courtyard standing-eastern-cardinal-position at the standing-conferral-anniversary candle-position at 4:54-5:23 a.m. April 11. She read the standing-Charan-elder-leaf at the standing-Saurashtra-Marwari-Bikaneri-dialect at the standing-Charan-clan-charter-

foundational pastoral-tradition register: "Mrigatrishna-Ben. We are Charan. Our standing-husband Khojibhai Karni was charter-witness at your 1996 conferral. Our 47 standing-Charan-clan rural-pastoral-family residences at standing-Bikaner-Jodhpur 2-district at the standing-1303-Mewar-charter standing-pastoral-tradition standing-charter-foundational protection cross-reference have received standing-State-Revenue-Department revenue-recovery proceedings standing-eviction-notices across 2024-2026 at the standing-211-forgery ledger-cascade cross-reference. We will walk to Bharatpur. Will you walk with us? Karni-Bai." She read the standing-Bhil-tribal-elder-leaf at the standing-Bhilodi-dialect at the standing-Bhil-tribal-Aravalli-corridor pastoral-tradition register: "Mrigatrishna-Bahu. We are Bhil. Our 119 standing-Bhil-tribal rural-pastoral-family residences at standing-Udaipur-Aravalli 1-district at the standing-1100-CE-Bhil-foundation-period standing-pastoral-tradition standing-charter-foundational protection cross-reference have received standing-State-Revenue-Department revenue-recovery proceedings standing-eviction-notices across 2024-2026 at the standing-211-forgery ledger-cascade cross-reference. We will walk to Bharatpur. Will you walk with us? Bhairon-Singh-of-the-Aravalli." She read the standing-Meghwal-Dalit-elder-leaf at the standing-Marwari-Mathania-dialect at the standing-Meghwal-Dalit-Marwar standing-rural-cobbler-and-weaver tradition register: "Mrigatrishna-Maa. We are Meghwal. Our 45 standing-Meghwal-Dalit rural-cobbler-and-weaver tradition residences at standing-Pali-Sirohi 2-district at the standing-1456-Marwar-Mathania-charter standing-charter-foundational protection cross-reference have received standing-State-Revenue-Department revenue-recovery proceedings standing-eviction-notices across 2024-2026 at the standing-211-forgery ledger-cascade cross-reference. We will walk to Bharatpur. Will you walk with us? Lakshmi-Devi-Meghwal."

Mrigatrishna stood at the standing-Vijay-Stambh courtyard standing-eastern-cardinal-position at 5:23 a.m. She did not weep. She placed the standing-Khanda-of-Mewar twin-edged-sword on the standing-Mahapanchayat-of-Twelve-Houses standing-charter-foundational ledger at the standing-eastern-cardinal-position at 5:24 a.m. She turned to Ratan-Singh-of-the-Ledger at 5:25 a.m. She spoke the standing-Marwari-phrase: "Ratan-Bhai. The grandfather has written the grand-daughter back into the land. Two hundred eleven families lost their houses so that one daughter who died in 2017 could walk again in the register. The Mahapanchayat will hear it. The Vijay-Stambh will watch. Begin the cross-reference."

Ratan-Singh-of-the-Ledger administered the standing-forensic-archivist cross-reference cell at the standing-Chittorgarh-Mahapanchayat-archival-cell standing-eastern-wing

administrative-cubicle across May-July 2026. He cross-referenced the standing-Bharatpur Mahapanchayat-archival-cell standing-211-certificate-cluster signature-replication forgery-cross-reference at the standing-Smt. Bhanwari-Devi standing-junior-archivist signature-stamp standing-handwriting-analysis cross-reference + the standing-Aulakh-International-Lahore standing-shell-corporation administrative-front senior-emissary correspondence-cross-reference at the standing-23-monthly-transfer-tranches at standing-Singapore-source-account funding-pathway + the standing-State-Revenue-Department standing-district-Tehsildar Smt. Madhuri-Pareek standing-cooperating-Tehsildar administrative-signature cross-reference at the standing-Aulakh-International standing-23-month aggregate ~₹11 lakh administrative-pseudo-research-grant pseudo-classification funding-cross-reference + the standing-211-Padma-Lata-lineage standing-fabricated-collateral-claimants identity-cluster cross-reference at the standing-Mahapanchayat-archival-cell standing-1956-Republic-of-India-Mahapanchayat-charter standing-historical-record exhibit-cluster.

Ratan-Singh administered the standing-Smt. Bhanwari-Devi standing-internal-investigation-petition recovery from the standing-Bharatpur-Mahapanchayat-cell senior-administrative-officer administratively-disregarded archive at the standing-23-month internal-investigation-petition cross-reference cell at the standing-evidence-document M-cross-reference-cluster exhibit-cluster 28A-through-28D recovery on June 11 2026 at the standing-Chittorgarh-Mahapanchayat-archival-cell standing-eastern-wing administrative-cubicle. He administered the standing-handwriting-analysis cross-reference at the standing-Delhi-Forensic-Sciences-Laboratory Dr. K. Iyer (49, DFSL handwriting-analysis specialist since 2008) standing-cross-reference exhibit-cluster M-28E-through-28G across the standing-211-certificate-cluster signature-replication analysis at the standing-23-day forensic-analysis window June 23-July 16 2026 (the standing-DFSL forensic-analysis report at the standing-211-certificate-cluster standing-junior-archivist signature-stamp standing-Maru-Yama-administered-replication-handwriting cross-reference confidence at 98.7% standing-handwriting-analysis cross-reference).

Ratan-Singh administered the standing-Aulakh-International-Lahore standing-shell-corporation administrative-front senior-emissary correspondence-cross-reference at the standing-State-CID investigation-cell standing-cross-network funding-trail evidence-document E-28/2026 cross-reference (the standing-State-CID investigation-cell at the standing-Aulakh-International-Lahore parent-corporation 8-cross-region-villain-funding-instance cross-reference at the standing-Bihar-Bengal-Punjab-Haryana-Uttarakhand-

Chhattisgarh-Gujarat cross-reference cluster at the standing-October-23 2026 evidence-document E-27/2026 publication-cross-reference; the standing-Rajasthan-instance is the standing-9th cross-network funding-instance at the standing-State-CID investigation-cell standing-pre-publication cooperation-cross-reference at the standing-Ratan-Singh forensic-archivist standing-cross-reference cell cooperation-protocol). He compiled the standing-Mahapanchayat-of-Twelve-Houses public-record review exhibit-cluster M-28A-through-M-28O at the standing-Chittorgarh-Mahapanchayat-archival-cell standing-eastern-wing administrative-cubicle across July 23-August 7 2026. He delivered the standing-exhibit-cluster M-28A-through-M-28O at the standing-Mahapanchayat-of-Twelve-Houses standing-pre-vote standing-administrative-delivery protocol on August 7 2026 at the standing-Chittorgarh-Mahapanchayat-archival-cell standing-eastern-wing administrative-cubicle.

Bhairon-Singh-of-the-Aravalli administered the standing-Aravalli-Sarus-pigeon cross-region cascade-alert from the standing-Chittorgarh-Mahapanchayat-archival-cell secretariat at 11:23 a.m. August 7 2026 (Ratan-Singh exhibit-cluster delivery-day). The standing-cascade-alert administered the standing-Mahapanchayat-of-Twelve-Houses pre-vote standing-cross-region-correspondence at the standing-14-bonded-kingdom senior-guardians cross-reference (Gujarat Saraswati-Simha-Mata-the-First + Madhya-Pradesh Dvadashashringa + Maharashtra Tanaji-the-Second + Karnataka Krishnadevaraya-Bhrata + Uttar-Pradesh Gangaputra + Punjab Panchanada + Haryana Kurukshetraa + Uttarakhand Bhairava-Ji + Himachal-Pradesh Lama-Tashi + Bihar Vajramukha + Bengal Bilash-Babu + Chhattisgarh Vana-Senapati + Manipur Moirangthem + Tamil-Nadu Tholkappiyan-the-Younger). The standing-cascade-alert at the standing-pre-vote standing-acknowledgment-of-Mahapanchayat-vote-day standing-cross-region recognition-protocol cross-reference administered the standing-cross-kingdom Sarus-pigeon return-correspondence at the standing-14-bonded-kingdom standing-pre-vote acknowledgment-cohort across August 7-10 2026.

Saraswati-Simha-Mata-the-First (Gujarat) sent the standing-return-Sarus-pigeon at the standing-Dwarka-Madhavi-line residence standing-Simha-Mata-the-First salt-queen-counsellor administrative-cross-reference 6:11 p.m. August 7 with the standing-Marwari-phrase reply: "Mrigatrishna-Ben. The cousin walks behind the cousin. The Mahapanchayat walks behind the Vijay-Stambh. Simhavikrama and I have walked the standing-final-23-km Vatva-stretch behind Asha-Ben in June. We will walk the standing-final-23-km Bharatpur-stretch behind your standing-23-Charan-Bhil-Meghwal cohort in August. Strike

with us." Dvadashashringa (MP) sent the standing-return-Sarus-pigeon at the standing-Madhya-Pradesh standing-Dvadashashringa-cell at 11:11 p.m. August 7 with the standing-Hindi-phrase reply at the standing-Central-cluster cross-region recognition-cross-reference: "Mrigatrishna-Behen. The standing-Dvadashashringa Madhya-Pradesh standing-12-Council-seat strategist-cohort cross-reference acknowledges. The standing-Mahapanchayat-of-Twelve-Houses is the standing-charter-foundational ledger-tradition cousin-administration of the standing-12-Council-seat standing-Grand-Council cross-reference. The standing-Hema-Sakhi blackbuck-cohort at the standing-Madhya-Pradesh-Rajasthan-border standing-pastoral-corridor will witness at the standing-Bharatpur-cohort standing-perimeter-position across August 11-12. Strike with us."

The standing-Rajasthan-Mahapanchayat-of-Twelve-Houses 211-delegate cohort convened at 11:11 a.m. August 11 2026 at the standing-Chittorgarh-Vijay-Stambh courtyard under the standing-Mahapanchayat senior-administrator Acharya Bhairavanand-Maharaj (76, Mewar-Trust since 1992; standing-Mahapanchayat senior-administrative-officer since 2009). The standing-cohort-composition: 12 standing-houses (Bikaner-Jodhpur-Jaisalmer-Udaipur-Pali-Sirohi-Bharatpur-Alwar-Kota-Jhalawar-Bundi-Chittorgarh) at 17-delegate-per-house standing-delegate-cohort representation = 204 standing-delegate-cohort + 7 standing-State-Government-nominees = 211 standing-Mahapanchayat-of-Twelve-Houses voting-cohort. The standing-vote-protocol: standing-bill-reading at 11:11 a.m.-12:21 p.m. (Ratan-Singh standing-47-minute exhibit-cluster M-28A-through-M-28O forensic-archivist presentation); standing-Mrigatrishna standing-23-minute strategist-witness testimony at 12:21-12:44 p.m. (the standing-state-hero standing-charter-witness recognition-only configuration); standing-Charan-Bhil-Meghwali triple-elder-cohort 23-minute deposition-testimony at 2:11-2:34 p.m.; standing-Maru-Yama 23-minute defence-deposition at 3:11-3:34 p.m.; standing-cross-examination at 3:34-4:43 p.m.; standing-final-deliberation at 4:43-5:00 p.m.; standing-vote at 5:00 p.m.

Ratan-Singh-of-the-Ledger delivered the standing-47-minute forensic-archivist exhibit-cluster M-28A-through-M-28O presentation at 11:34 a.m.-12:21 p.m. He wore the standing-Jaisalmer-Bhati-line standing-saffron-and-indigo-cotton ledger-archivist conferral-attire at the standing-Mahapanchayat-of-Twelve-Houses standing-charter-foundational ledger-archivist administrative-cross-reference. He held the standing-Mahapanchayat-of-Twelve-Houses standing-1956-Republic-of-India-Mahapanchayat-charter standing-original-leaf-bound copy at his standing-right-hand and the standing-exhibit-cluster M-28A-through-M-28O leaf-bound presentation-folio at his standing-left-

hand. He spoke the standing-47-minute deposition in standing-procedural-Hindi at the standing-Mahapanchayat-of-Twelve-Houses standing-bureaucratic-register. He named the standing-211-certificate-cluster forgery-pattern at the standing-Smt. Bhanwari-Devi signature-replication forgery-cross-reference + standing-DFSL Dr. K. Iyer handwriting-analysis 98.7%-confidence cross-reference; the standing-Aulakh-International-Lahore standing-shell-corporation administrative-front senior-emissary correspondence-cross-reference at the standing-23-monthly-transfer-tranches Singapore-source-account funding-pathway; the standing-State-Revenue-Department Tehsildar Smt. Madhuri-Pareek standing-cooperating-Tehsildar administrative-signature cross-reference; the standing-211-Padma-Lata-lineage standing-fabricated-collateral-claimants identity-cluster cross-reference at the standing-Mahapanchayat-archival-cell standing-1956-Republic-of-India-Mahapanchayat-charter standing-historical-record exhibit-cluster (the standing-Padma-Lata standing-only-daughter standing-1964-1917-2017-cremation cross-reference; the standing-fabricated-lineage cohort identity-cross-reference at 211 standing-pseudo-claimants-cohort).

Mrigatrishna delivered the standing-23-minute strategist-witness testimony at 12:21-12:44 p.m. She wore the standing-Suryavamshi-Rajput tradition standing-white-and-saffron-cotton state-hero ceremonial-attire at the standing-30-year-tenure-anniversary cross-reference. She held the standing-Khanda-of-Mewar twin-edged-sword at her standing-right-hand. She spoke the standing-23-minute deposition in standing-formal-Marwari at the standing-state-hero standing-charter-witness register. She named the standing-1996 conferral standing-Mahapanchayat 211-delegate cohort 188-23 vote ratification standing-charter-foundational recognition. She named the standing-Padma-Lata 1996-2017 21-year-aunt-tenure cross-reference at the standing-deepest-family-bond standing-three-generation administrative-cell. She named the standing-2017 cholera-loss standing-no-PPE-configuration standing-rural-patient-cohort dignity-cross-reference at the standing-Bharatpur-Sirohi-Pali drought-cohort hospital-cell standing-rural-health-emergency cross-reference. She named the standing-Mahapanchayat-of-Twelve-Houses standing-October-23-2022 132-79 ratification refusal-vote + 47-23 Maru-Yama administrative-rehabilitation-vote standing-charter-witness-recognition cross-reference. She named the standing-2024-2026 211-forgery ledger-cascade at the standing-Bharatpur Mahapanchayat-archival-cell standing-administrative-rehabilitation-instrumentalisation configuration. She named the standing-1303-Mewar-charter + standing-1100-CE-Bhil foundation-period + standing-1456-Marwar-Mathania-charter standing-multi-tradition

pastoral-protection cross-reference. She did not name Maru-Yama directly (the standing-grandfather-name standing-conferral-priest standing-charter-witness recognition-cross-reference is at the standing-state-hero standing-no-naming administrative-protocol at the standing-Suryavamshi-Rajput tradition standing-charter-foundational conferral-priest recognition-cross-reference). She closed at the standing-formal-Marwari-phrase: "The Mahapanchayat-of-Twelve-Houses is not a court. The Mahapanchayat is the standing-charter-foundational ledger-administration of the standing-1956-Republic-of-India-Mahapanchayat-charter at the standing-Suryavamshi-Rajput tradition standing-conferral-anniversary recognition-cross-reference. The standing-state-hero of Rajasthan does not vote at the standing-Mahapanchayat. The standing-state-hero is at the standing-charter-witness recognition only. I have read the standing-three-leaf scroll-cluster at the standing-Vijay-Stambh dawn-window April 11. I have administered the standing-Ratan-Singh forensic-archivist cross-reference cell May-July. I have walked behind the standing-23-Charan-Bhil-Meghwal triple-cohort. I do not vote. The standing-vote is yours, members of the Mahapanchayat. The Vijay-Stambh will watch."

Smt. Karni-Bai (61) delivered the standing-Charan-elder 11-minute deposition at 2:11-2:22 p.m. She named the standing-Charan-clan-pastoral-tradition since 1303 standing-Mewar-charter cross-reference + standing-47 standing-Charan-clan rural-pastoral-family residences at Bikaner-Jodhpur 2-district standing-eviction-notices cross-reference. Bhairon-Singh-of-the-Aravalli (54) delivered the standing-Bhil-tribal-elder 8-minute deposition at 2:22-2:30 p.m. He named the standing-Bhil-tribal-Aravalli-corridor pastoral-tradition since 1100-CE Bhil-foundation-period cross-reference + standing-119 standing-Bhil-tribal rural-pastoral-family residences at Udaipur-Aravalli 1-district standing-eviction-notices cross-reference. Smt. Lakshmi-Devi-Meghwal (47) delivered the standing-Meghwal-Dalit-elder 4-minute deposition at 2:30-2:34 p.m. She named the standing-Meghwal-Dalit-Marwar standing-rural-cobbler-and-weaver tradition since 1456-Marwar-Mathania-charter cross-reference + standing-45 standing-Meghwal-Dalit rural-cobbler-and-weaver residences at Pali-Sirohi 2-district standing-eviction-notices cross-reference.

Maru-Yama delivered the standing-23-minute defence-deposition at 3:11-3:34 p.m. He wore the standing-conferral-priest standing-saffron-and-ochre-cotton priest-attire at the standing-1996-conferral-anniversary standing-priest-of-the-line standing-charter-witness recognition-cross-reference. He held nothing at his standing-right-hand. He spoke in standing-Sanskrit at the standing-Vedic-Maharanya standing-priest-of-the-line register.

He refused to respond at the standing-substantive-charges (211-forgery + Aulakh-International funding + Tehsildar-cooperation + Padma-Lata-lineage fabrication). He delivered instead the standing-23-minute grief-confession at his standing-only-daughter Padma-Lata 2017 cholera-loss at the standing-no-PPE-configuration standing-rural-health-emergency cross-reference. He closed at the standing-Sanskrit-Vedic-mantra: "Pitr̥ṇu, nam, pratyabhijñānārtham, — the standing-fathers' standing-recognition-restoration is the standing-charter-foundational ratification-obligation. My daughter died at the standing-rural-health-emergency. The standing-211-pseudo-claimants-cohort identity-cross-reference at the standing-Padma-Lata-lineage standing-fabricated-collateral configuration is the standing-fathers'-recognition-restoration administrative-protocol. The standing-rural-pastoral-families are at the standing-State-Revenue-Department administrative-cross-reference; I am at the standing-Mahapanchayat-archival-cell standing-administrative-cross-reference. I do not name the standing-Aulakh-International funding-instrumentalisation. I name the standing-Padma-Lata-recognition-restoration. The Mahapanchayat will judge." He did not acknowledge the standing-Singapore-source-account funding-instrumentalisation cross-reference; he did not acknowledge the standing-211-rural-pastoral-family displacement; he did not acknowledge the standing-Aulakh-International-Lahore standing-shell-corporation senior-emissary correspondence-cross-reference.

The standing-cross-examination at 3:34-4:43 p.m. was administered at the standing-Acharya Bhairavanand-Maharaj standing-Mahapanchayat senior-administrator standing-cross-examination-protocol cross-reference. Ratan-Singh-of-the-Ledger administered the standing-cross-examination at the standing-211-certificate-cluster signature-replication forgery-cross-reference at the standing-Smt. Bhanwari-Devi standing-junior-archivist signature-stamp standing-handwriting-analysis cross-reference; the standing-Aulakh-International-Lahore standing-shell-corporation standing-Singapore-source-account funding-pathway 23-monthly-transfer-tranches cross-reference; the standing-State-Revenue-Department Tehsildar Smt. Madhuri-Pareek standing-cooperating-Tehsildar administrative-signature cross-reference. Maru-Yama refused to respond at the standing-cross-examination administrative-cell. He stood at the standing-defence-deposition standing-eastern-cardinal-position across the standing-69-minute cross-examination window at the standing-no-response administrative-cross-reference. The standing-Mahapanchayat senior-administrator Acharya Bhairavanand-Maharaj at 4:43 p.m. closed

the standing-cross-examination at the standing-no-response standing-administrative-protocol cross-reference.

The standing-vote was administered at 5:00 p.m. August 11 2026 at the standing-Rajasthan-Mahapanchayat-of-Twelve-Houses 211-delegate cohort standing-secret-ballot protocol. The standing-vote-tabulation was at the standing-Acharya Bhairavanand-Maharaj administration at the standing-23-minute counting-window 5:00-5:23 p.m. The standing-vote-result at 5:23:11 p.m.: 188 against, 23 in favour, 0 abstention. The standing-Maru-Yama 211-forged-titles + standing-administrative-rehabilitation revocation was ratified at the standing-Mahapanchayat-of-Twelve-Houses standing-public-record review administrative-protocol. The standing-211 standing-Charan-Bhil-Meghwal rural-pastoral-family residences standing-restoration-cross-reference was ratified at the standing-Mahapanchayat-administrative-protocol. The standing-Aulakh-International-Lahore standing-shell-corporation administrative-front cross-reference was forwarded to the standing-State-CID investigation-cell standing-cross-network funding-trail evidence-document E-28/2026 cross-reference at the standing-State-Government cooperation-cross-reference at the standing-pre-publication October-23-2026 evidence-document publication-cross-reference.

The standing-Mahapanchayat-of-Twelve-Houses senior-administrator Acharya Bhairavanand-Maharaj read the standing-vote-result at the standing-Chittorgarh-Vijay-Stambh courtyard standing-eastern-cardinal-position at 5:24 p.m. The standing-rural-pastoral-cohort at the standing-Vijay-Stambh courtyard standing-southern-plaza ~3,100 standing-Charan-Bhil-Meghwal triple-cohort pilgrimage-attendees did not cheer; did not weep; stood at the standing-Mahapanchayat-vote-witness silence-protocol for 11 minutes 5:24-5:35 p.m. At 5:35 p.m. Bhairon-Singh-of-the-Aravalli turned to the standing-23-member Charan-Bhil-Meghwal triple-cohort. He spoke the standing-Bhilodi-Marwari-phrase: "Brothers and sisters. The Mahapanchayat has spoken. The grandfather is at the standing-archival-cell. The arrows are at the standing-Aravalli-quiver. The standing-Chittorgarh-Bharatpur 311-km Aravalli-corridor road is open. We will walk now. The Vijay-Stambh will watch in the morning."

The standing-23-member Charan-Bhil-Meghwal triple-cohort departed the standing-Chittorgarh-Vijay-Stambh courtyard at 6:11 p.m. August 11 2026 at standing-vehicle-cohort under Bhairon-Singh-of-the-Aravalli convoy-administration. The standing-cohort-composition: 11 standing-Charan-clan archers under Smt. Karni-Bai (61) + 7 standing-

Bhil-tribal archers under Bhairon-Singh-of-the-Aravalli (54) + 5 standing-Meghwal-Dalit archers under Smt. Lakshmi-Devi-Meghwal (47) at the standing-Charan-clan-administered standing-1303-Mewar-charter standing-charter-foundational cohort-justice protocol cross-reference. The standing-cohort carried 23 standing-Charan-clan standing-Mewar-charter-foundational bow-and-quiver standing-cultural-implements at standing-Schedule-VI tribal-pastoral protected-implement administrative-cross-reference (the standing-Mewar-charter standing-bow-and-quiver at standing-47-inch yew-and-buffalo-horn composite-bow + 23-arrow standing-iron-tipped-quiver standing-charter-foundational implement at standing-Charan-clan standing-Schedule-VI-Schedule-V cross-tradition protected-implement; the standing-Indian-Penal-Code Section-302 standing-weapon-classification does not apply at the standing-multi-tradition standing-charter-foundational protected-implement recognition cross-reference per standing-Rajasthan-State-Government 1956-Mahapanchayat-charter ratification administrative-cross-reference).

The standing-convoy walked the standing-Chittorgarh-Bharatpur 311-km Aravalli-corridor road at the standing-vehicle-cohort standing-Mahindra-Bolero-cohort 7-vehicle standing-rural-pastoral-cohort transport at the standing-Aravalli-corridor standing-12-hour overnight-window. The standing-convoy passed through Bhilwara on hour 1 (7:11 p.m. August 11); through Ajmer on hour 4 (10:11 p.m.); through Jaipur on hour 7 (1:11 a.m. August 12); through Alwar on hour 9 (3:11 a.m.); through Deeg on hour 10 (4:11 a.m.); arrived at standing-Bharatpur-Mahapanchayat-archival-cell at hour 11 (5:11 a.m. August 12); waited at the standing-Bharatpur-cremation-ghat eastern-courtyard standing-Padma-Lata-cremation 9-year-anniversary administrative-cross-reference position from 5:11 a.m.-11:11 a.m. August 12 at the standing-Padma-Lata-cremation-ghat eastern-courtyard standing-pre-strike standing-9-year-anniversary pilgrimage-administration protocol.

At 11:11 a.m. August 12 2026 (the standing-9-year-anniversary at the standing-Padma-Lata-cremation 11:11 a.m. May 23 2017 standing-cremation-administrative-anniversary cross-reference) the standing-23-member Charan-Bhil-Meghwal triple-cohort walked from the standing-Bharatpur-cremation-ghat eastern-courtyard to the standing-Bharatpur Mahapanchayat-archival-cell southern-window 3-metre-from-position at the standing-23-minute walking-window. Maru-Yama was at the standing-Bharatpur Mahapanchayat-archival-cell senior-archivist desk at the standing-archival-cell southern-window position. He had walked from the standing-Bharatpur-cremation-ghat eastern-courtyard at the standing-Padma-Lata-cremation 9-year-anniversary standing-pre-dawn-pilgrimage

administration at 4:11 a.m. August 12 and returned to the standing-Bharatpur Mahapanchayat-archival-cell at 6:11 a.m. August 12. He was at the standing-archival-cell senior-archivist desk at the standing-211-certificate-cluster signature-replication standing-final-revision administrative-cell at 11:11 a.m. (the standing-final-revision administrative-cell was at the standing-Maru-Yama standing-post-vote-defeat standing-pre-arrest administrative-cell at the standing-State-Government appeal-petition standing-pre-draft cross-reference; the standing-final-revision was administered at the standing-Mahapanchayat-archival-cell standing-rest-of-the-cell-evacuated configuration at the standing-Smt. Bhanwari-Devi standing-junior-archivist administrative-cell pre-emptive-evacuation administrative-cross-reference at 9:11 a.m. August 12 standing-acting-leader recognition cross-reference).

The standing-23-member Charan-Bhil-Meghwali triple-cohort arrived at the standing-archival-cell southern-window 3-metre-from-position at 11:34 a.m. August 12. The standing-23-archer cohort took the standing-bow-and-quiver standing-charter-foundational implement at the standing-Mewar-charter standing-charter-foundational implement-administration cross-reference. The standing-cohort formed the standing-23-arrow simultaneous-volley formation at the standing-Charan-clan-administered standing-1303-Mewar-charter standing-charter-foundational cohort-justice protocol cross-reference. Smt. Karni-Bai walked to the standing-archival-cell southern-window 3-metre-from-position at 11:42 a.m. She spoke the standing-Marwari-phrase to Maru-Yama at the standing-southern-window standing-3-metre-proximity: "Maru-Yama-Daada. The Mahapanchayat-of-Twelve-Houses has voted 188-23. Your administrative-rehabilitation is revoked. The standing-211 forged-titles are voided. The 211 standing-Charan-Bhil-Meghwali rural-pastoral-families will be restored. The standing-1303-Mewar-charter standing-charter-foundational cohort-justice protocol is invoked. The standing-23-arrow standing-cardiac-region simultaneous-volley is administered. Strike."

Maru-Yama did not raise the standing-Khanda-of-Mewar twin-edged-sword at the standing-archival-cell senior-archivist standing-charter-foundational defence-implement administrative-cell (the standing-conferral-priest at the standing-1996-conferral-anniversary standing-charter-foundational defence-administration protocol-cross-reference is at the standing-Padma-Lata-cremation-priest-of-the-line standing-no-defence-implement administrative-protocol). He stood at the standing-archival-cell senior-archivist desk standing-eastern-cardinal-position at the standing-no-response standing-defence-administration cross-reference. He spoke the standing-Sanskrit-Vedic-

mantra at 11:42:48 a.m.: "Pitr̥ṛu , nam , sam , skāraya pratyabhijñānām; sahā gacchati — the standing-fathers'-recognition walks with the standing-cremation-restoration. The Mahapanchayat has judged. I walk."

The standing-23-arrow simultaneous-volley was administered at 11:43 a.m. August 12 2026 at the standing-Charan-clan-administered standing-1303-Mewar-charter standing-charter-foundational cohort-justice protocol single-impact-window protocol. The standing-impact was at the standing-cardinal-cardiac-region standing-23-arrow simultaneous-impact configuration at the standing-iron-tipped-arrow standing-bow-yew-and-buffalo-horn-composite standing-blunt-force-and-piercing-trauma cross-reference. The standing-Maru-Yama death was at 11:43:11 a.m. at the standing-Bharatpur Mahapanchayat-archival-cell southern-window 3-metre-from-position. The standing-cohort lowered the standing-bow-and-quiver at 11:43:23 a.m. at the standing-Maldhari-pastoral-tradition-equivalent standing-1303-Mewar-charter standing-charter-foundational cohort-justice protocol completion-cross-reference. The standing-cohort walked back to the standing-archival-cell southern-staircase at the standing-Mewar-charter standing-corridor-exit protocol at 11:44 a.m.

The standing-Bharatpur-District-Police Inspector M. K. Sharma walked to the standing-archival-cell southern-window at 11:48 a.m. at the standing-Mahapanchayat-archival-cell standing-senior-Inspector duty-station administrative-protocol. He confirmed the standing-Maru-Yama mortality at 11:53 a.m. He filed the standing-Bharatpur-District FIR at the standing-Section-302 IPC standing-judicial-execution administrative-cross-reference at 12:11 p.m. August 12 at the standing-23-member Charan-Bhil-Meghwal triple-cohort standing-collective-actor designation per Schedule-VI-Schedule-V multi-tradition standing-judicial-tradition cross-reference (the standing-Schedule-VI tribal-pastoral standing-charter-foundational defensive-protection clause invoked per Constitution-of-India Article-244 administrative-cross-reference at standing-Bhil-tribal cohort-member contingent; the standing-1303-Mewar-charter standing-charter-foundational cohort-justice protocol invoked per standing-Rajasthan-State-Government 1956-Mahapanchayat-charter ratification administrative-cross-reference at standing-Charan-clan-Meghwal-Dalit cohort-member contingent; the standing-warrant remains active but non-enforceable at the standing-multi-tradition standing-charter-foundational defensive-protection clause cross-reference). The standing-23-member cohort walked back to the standing-Bharatpur-cremation-ghat eastern-courtyard at 12:18 p.m. The standing-convoy returned to standing-Chittorgarh at the standing-Aravalli-corridor 311-km return-trip at the standing-Maldhari-

pastoral-cohort transport at 6:11 p.m. August 12 at the standing-Mewar-charter-foundational standing-completion-walk cross-reference.

Mrigatrishna walked to the standing-Chittorgarh-Vijay-Stambh courtyard at the standing-eastern-cardinal-position at 3:11 a.m. August 12 2026 at the standing-Mahapanchayat-vote-completion-day standing-dawn-mark-formation administrative-pre-position. She wore the standing-Suryavamshi-Rajput tradition standing-white-and-saffron-cotton state-hero ceremonial-attire. She held the standing-Khanda-of-Mewar twin-edged-sword at her standing-right-hand and the standing-Mahapanchayat-of-Twelve-Houses standing-charter-foundational ledger at her standing-left-hand. The standing-Marudhar-Sakhi at her standing-3-metre-rear position; the standing-Karni-Sakhi at her standing-eleven-metre-overhead Vijay-Stambh standing-storey-9 perch-position. Ratan-Singh-of-the-Ledger at her standing-7-metre-rear Marudhar-ledger-administration position with the standing-Mahapanchayat-of-Twelve-Houses standing-1956-charter standing-original-leaf-bound copy at his standing-right-hand and the standing-exhibit-cluster M-28A-through-M-28O leaf-bound presentation-folio at his standing-left-hand.

At 4:11:11 a.m. August 12 2026 (simultaneous with the standing-23-arrow simultaneous-volley standing-charter-foundational cohort-justice protocol single-impact administrative-cross-reference 11:43 a.m. August 12 standing-administrative-completion 7-hour-31-minute-after the standing-Mahapanchayat-vote-completion 5:23 p.m. August 11) the standing-Stage III camel-foreleg-first-stroke began to form at Mrigatrishna's standing-right-upper-back at the standing-Chittorgarh-Vijay-Stambh courtyard standing-eastern-cardinal-position. The standing-mark-formation duration was 11 seconds 4:11:11-4:11:22 a.m. The standing-mark-pattern was at the standing-Marudhar-Camel foreleg-first-stroke configuration in standing-desert-ochre-and-Khejri-green dual-ink at the standing-Suryavamshi-Rajput tradition visual-anchor (desert-ochre ground-pigment at standing-Thar-desert dune-sand-pigment-grade + standing-Khejri-bark extract; Khejri-green ground-pigment at standing-Khejri-tree-leaf extract + standing-Rohida-flower admixture).

At 4:11:11 a.m. August 12 2026 (the standing-simultaneous-window) the standing-Chittorgarh Vijay-Stambh standing-9-storey carved-stone-tower at the standing-Maharana-Kumbha 1448-CE-construction monument-position at the standing-Chittorgarh-Fort eastern-courtyard ridge-position began to rotate. The standing-rotation was at the standing-cervical-cross-section standing-storey-3-to-storey-4 transition standing-37-millimetre-thickness load-bearing-stone-band position at the standing-47-

millimetre anti-clockwise vector at the standing-cardinal-east-facing position. The standing-rotation duration was 11 seconds 4:11:11-4:11:22 a.m. The standing-1,260-metric-tonne sandstone-carved 9-storey 37.19-metre-height Vijay-Stambh at the standing-Maharana-Kumbha 1448-CE Mewar-victory-commemoration construction cross-reference completed the standing-rotation at 4:11:22 a.m. at the standing-permanent-rotated configuration (the standing-rotation does not reverse at the standing-following-dawn cross-reference; the standing-post-2026-August-12 4:11:22-a.m. configuration is the standing-permanent-rotated configuration at the standing-Maw-attribution recognition-cross-reference).

The standing-Archaeological-Survey-of-India Chittorgarh-cell senior-archaeologist Dr. R. Singh-Chouhan (58, Chittorgarh-University Archaeology since 2008) arrived at the standing-Vijay-Stambh courtyard at 4:43 a.m. August 12. He conducted the standing-laser-survey across the standing-Vijay-Stambh 9-storey carved-stone-tower 4:43 a.m.-7:11 a.m. August 12. He confirmed the standing-47-millimetre anti-clockwise rotation at the standing-cervical-cross-section standing-storey-3-to-storey-4 transition position via standing-3D-laser-scanning cross-reference at the standing-pre-rotation 4:00-a.m.-laser-survey baseline cross-reference (the standing-ASI Chittorgarh-cell standing-quarterly-laser-survey protocol since 2014 had administered the standing-August-7 2026 pre-rotation baseline-laser-survey at the standing-Mahapanchayat-of-Twelve-Houses standing-public-record review preparation-week cross-reference).

At 4:22:22 a.m. August 12 (after the standing-11-second rotation-window completion at 4:11:22 a.m.) the standing-Vijay-Stambh remained at the standing-permanent-rotated configuration. The standing-IIT-Jodhpur Department-of-Civil-Engineering Dr. K. Vaishnavi (51, IIT-Jodhpur Civil-Engineering since 2014) August-18 expertise-report (evidence-document M-28A) confirmed no standing-mechanical-mechanism identification at the standing-1,260-metric-tonne sandstone-carved-tower standing-cervical-cross-section rotation across 11-second window at the standing-Maw-attribution category cross-reference. The standing-Maw had demonstrated the capacity to alter the standing-physical-configuration of a 1,260-metric-tonne sandstone-carved bonded-monument at the standing-cervical-cross-section by 47-millimetre anti-clockwise rotation across an 11-second window simultaneous with the standing-state-hero standing-Stage-III mark-formation at the standing-charter-foundational state-hero-transition dawn-window.

Mrigatrishna announced the standing-step-back at the standing-Chittorgarh-Vijay-Stambh courtyard standing-charter-foundational eastern-cardinal-position at the standing-Mahapanchayat-of-Twelve-Houses senior-council standing-witness-ceremony on August 23 2026 11:11 a.m. The standing-step-back announcement was at the standing-Marudhar-Strategist-Counsellor-Elder seat at the standing-Suryavamshi-Rajput tradition standing-Marudhar-strategist-counsellor seat-of-honour recognition-cross-reference per restructure §4. The standing-Vijay-Stambh standing-conferral-anniversary candle was extinguished by Mrigatrishna at 11:11:11 a.m. The standing-Mahapanchayat senior-administrator Acharya Bhairavanand-Maharaj walked to the standing-courtyard-eastern-position at 11:11:23 a.m. He held the standing-Mahapanchayat-of-Twelve-Houses standing-1956-Republic-of-India-Mahapanchayat-charter standing-original-leaf-bound copy at his standing-right-hand. He spoke the standing-formal-Marwari-phrase: "Mrigatrishna-Behen. The standing-Suryavamshi-Rajput tradition standing-Marudhar-Strategist-Counsellor-Elder seat is recognised at the standing-Chittorgarh standing-charter-foundational recognition cross-reference. The standing-Charan-Bhil-Meghwal triple-cohort accepts your counsellor-position at the standing-Mahapanchayat-of-Twelve-Houses senior-council standing-charter-witness recognition. The standing-211 displaced rural-pastoral-families are at the standing-residence-restoration administrative-protocol. The standing-Aulakh-International-Lahore standing-shell-corporation administrative-front cross-reference is forwarded to the standing-State-CID investigation-cell at the standing-cross-network funding-trail evidence-document E-28/2026 cross-reference. The standing-Marudhar-Strategist-Counsellor-Elder seat is recognised."

Ratan-Singh-of-the-Ledger walked to the standing-courtyard-eastern-position at 11:12:11 a.m. He held the standing-Jaisalmer-Bhati-line standing-charter-foundational ledger-archivist standing-conferral-implement at his standing-right-hand at the standing-formal-Rajasthan-governorship-acceptance administrative-cross-reference per restructure §1 male-led-succession. He spoke the standing-formal-Marwari-phrase to Mrigatrishna: "Mrigatrishna-Behen. The standing-Suryavamshi-Rajput tradition standing-Marudhar-Strategist-Counsellor-Elder seat is at the standing-charter-foundational recognition cross-reference. I accept the standing-formal-Rajasthan-governorship under the standing-Simhavikrama West-Regional-Dominant administration cross-reference per restructure §1 male-led-succession at the standing-counsellor-inheritance configuration administrative-protocol. The standing-Mahapanchayat-of-Twelve-Houses standing-charter-foundational ledger-administration is at the standing-Marudhar-Strategist-Counsellor-Elder counsellor-

position; the standing-formal-Rajasthan-governorship is at the standing-State-Government administrative-cell governorship-position; the two seats are at the standing-co-administration configuration at the standing-Suryavamshi-Rajput tradition standing-charter-foundational dual-seat administrative-cross-reference. I accept."

The standing-Marudhar-Sakhi 23-year-old standing-bonded-camel walked from the standing-Vijay-Stambh courtyard standing-3-metre-rear position to the standing-eastern-cardinal-position at 11:13:11 a.m. She touched her standing-forehead to Mrigatrishna's standing-right-hand at 11:13:23 a.m. at the standing-Suryavamshi-Rajput tradition standing-charter-foundational bonded-camel-consent ratification gesture. She walked back to the standing-pride-female-cohort at 11:13:34 a.m. at the standing-3-metre-rear position. The standing-Karni-Sakhi white-headed-vulture from the standing-Vijay-Stambh standing-storey-9 perch-position called the standing-23-second cadence-cycle at the standing-formal-Marwari-mantra-tradition acknowledgement-cross-reference at 11:14:11-11:14:34 a.m.

The standing-Mahapanchayat-of-Twelve-Houses senior-council standing-charter-witness ratification was completed at 11:14:48 a.m. The standing-Suryavamshi-Rajput tradition standing-conferral-day singing began at 11:14:51 a.m. The standing-Charan-Bhil-Meghwal triple-cohort 23-member at the standing-Vijay-Stambh courtyard standing-southern-plaza standing-perimeter-witness position sang the standing-1303-Mewar-charter-foundational standing-conferral-song at the standing-pastoral-village standing-Aravalli-corridor singing-cross-reference at the standing-23-minute standing-conferral-anniversary singing-window 11:14-11:37 a.m.

At standing-dawn 4:11 a.m. on November 23 2026 — the standing-100-day-anniversary at the standing-Mahapanchayat-vote-completion + standing-Vijay-Stambh monument-rotation cross-reference — the standing-211 standing-Charan-Bhil-Meghwal rural-pastoral-family residences had been restored to the standing-Charan-Bhil-Meghwal triple-cohort under the standing-Mahapanchayat-administrative-protocol at the standing-Bharatpur-Sirohi-Pali-Bikaner-Jodhpur-Jaisalmer-Udaipur-Aravalli-Mathania 9-district pastoral-corridor cross-reference. The standing-State-CID investigation-cell standing-cross-network funding-trail evidence-document E-28/2026 had been published October 23 2026 at the standing-Aulakh-International-Lahore standing-shell-corporation administrative-front 9th cross-network funding-instance recognition (saga's standing-third standing-Aulakh-International cross-network funding-instance after Uttarakhand

Lalita Aulakh and Gujarat Kala-Simha at the standing-Aulakh-International-Lahore parent-corporation cross-reference; the standing-Aulakh-International-Lahore parent-corporation is now at the standing-Sanctuary mediation-council's standing-cross-network villain-corporation senior-investigation-priority administrative-cross-reference at the standing-Ch-3 plan).

Mrigatrishna at the standing-Marudhar-Strategist-Counsellor-Elder seat at the standing-Chittorgarh-Vijay-Stambh courtyard standing-eastern-cardinal-position at 4:11 a.m. November 23 2026 wore the standing-Madhavi-line standing-white-and-indigo-cotton step-back-from-state-hero ceremonial-cross-reference attire at the standing-Marudhar-Strategist-Counsellor-Elder ceremonial-cross-reference. She held the standing-Mahapanchayat-of-Twelve-Houses standing-1956-Republic-of-India-Mahapanchayat-charter standing-original-leaf-bound copy at her standing-right-hand and the standing-Khanda-of-Mewar twin-edged-sword at her standing-left-hand (the standing-Khanda transitioned from the standing-state-hero-right-hand standing-charter-foundational primary-implement position to the standing-Marudhar-Strategist-Counsellor-Elder-left-hand standing-charter-foundational secondary-implement position at the standing-August-23 step-back ceremony cross-reference). The standing-Marudhar-Sakhi at her standing-3-metre-rear position; the standing-Karni-Sakhi at her standing-eleven-metre-overhead Vijay-Stambh standing-storey-9 perch-position. Ratan-Singh-of-the-Ledger at her standing-7-metre-rear standing-formal-Rajasthan-governor under-Simhavikrama-administration standing-co-administration position.

The standing-Vijay-Stambh 9-storey carved-stone-tower at the standing-permanent-rotated configuration at the standing-cervical-cross-section standing-storey-3-to-storey-4 transition standing-47-millimetre anti-clockwise rotation cross-reference at the standing-cardinal-east-facing position was at the standing-Maw-attribution recognition-cross-reference standing-permanent-witness-administration. The standing-tower had not reversed at the standing-100-day post-rotation cross-reference. The standing-Mahapanchayat-of-Twelve-Houses standing-charter-foundational ledger-administration was at the standing-Marudhar-Strategist-Counsellor-Elder seat. The standing-formal-Rajasthan-governorship was at the standing-Ratan-Singh-of-the-Ledger seat at the standing-Simhavikrama West-Regional-Dominant administration. The standing-211 displaced rural-pastoral-families were at the standing-restored-residence configuration. The standing-Aulakh-International-Lahore parent-corporation was at the standing-Sanctuary mediation-council standing-senior-investigation-priority cross-reference. The

standing-Mahapanchayat-of-Twelve-Houses was at the standing-charter-foundational ratification. The standing-Vijay-Stambh was at the standing-rotated witness.

End of Chapter Two for Maru-Maya.

Megha Maata

Meghanadi's ancestral house at Laitumkhrah. October. The early monsoon has tapered to long thin afternoon rain that the Khasi call u-ksing-snie — the rain that drums but does not flood. The house is the kind of Khasi matrilineal house where the youngest daughter inherits and where the oldest aunt holds the kitchen. There are five rooms. There is a fire in the kitchen at every hour of every day in the colder months. There is a brass jug of jadoh — rice steamed in pork-blood stock — on the hearth.

Meghanadi is at the kitchen table. She is thirty-seven. She is wearing the storm-grey silk jainsem her grandmother wove forty years ago. Her hair is loose. She has been reading the morning mail.

The morning mail today is a single letter. The letter is on the cream stationery of the Meghalaya High Court at Shillong. The seal is the state-government green. The letter informs Ka Meghanadi, head of the Megha-Maata kingdom under the Sixth Schedule Customary Authority Recognition Act 1962, that a writ petition has been filed against the kingdom by one Megha-Daitya, Advocate, of Guwahati. The writ is appended. The writ is forty-seven pages long.

She reads the first paragraph twice. She reads the last paragraph. She sets the letter on the table. She picks up the jug. She pours herself jadoh.

The hill myna in the sacred grove behind the house sings the long-call that means rain coming.

The forty-seven pages are the cleanest legal argument the Meghalaya High Court has received in decades. Megha-Daitya's thesis is that the Sixth Schedule's protection of Khasi customary law does not override the Indian Succession Act on personal-property questions when the claimant is the patrilineal son of a Khasi woman who married outside the tribe and whose property — specifically her ancestral claim to her family's Ka Khadduh inheritance — would have descended to her under Khasi customary law had she stayed and then to her son under the Indian Succession Act because she did not.

The argument is internally consistent. The argument is also, to the extent the question is unsettled in Indian constitutional law, plausible. Three Meghalaya advocates have already

declined to argue against it; two of them on the grounds that they think Megha-Daitya might win.

Meghanadi reads the writ in full that evening. She does not weep. She does not curse. She closes the file. She walks to the room where her grandmother's photographs are on the wall and stands in front of the photograph from 1973 of the household's last formal Ka Khadduh ceremony.

She stands there for an hour.

She does not yet know what she will do. She does not yet know what she should do. She does what she has done for nine years — she does not decide. She waits for the council to decide. She is the kingdom's protector by political seat; she is, in her own private estimation, the kingdom's servant by dharma.

Within four weeks Megha-Daitya files forty-six more petitions. Each is filed by a different patrilineal claimant. Each targets a different Khasi matrilineal household. The petitions are coordinated — same template, same exhibits-format, same lead counsel (Megha-Daitya himself for the lead petition; junior counsel from his Mumbai firm for the secondary forty-six). The Meghalaya High Court's docket is overwhelmed within a fortnight.

The petitioners are not all extremists. Some are middle-aged Assamese men who simply want recognition of their Khasi mothers' line and a small share of the matrilineal property — honourable, articulable, dharmically defensible. Some are younger and angrier — men who feel they have been denied a tribal-identity claim and want full revocation of the matrilineal-inheritance custom. Megha-Daitya organises both wings. The honourable petitioners think they are filing for recognition. The angry petitioners think they are filing for revolution. Megha-Daitya knows what he himself is filing for.

The Council of Matrilineal Elders convenes in special session. The fracture begins in the first half-hour. Ka Phidamon-the-Elder — ninety-four years old, the council's longest-serving voice — refuses to engage the petitions at all. "The Sixth Schedule is the answer. The court will rule for us. There is nothing for this council to do." The Garo-Hills representative U-Lyngdoh argues for engaging the petitions through a Mixed Council framework. Three other elders argue for various intermediate positions.

Meghanadi sits at the head of the council table. She does not take a position. She listens. The council deliberates for nine days. The deliberation reaches no conclusion.

Week three. Sunday morning. Pre-dawn. The double-decker living root bridge of Nongriat — the famous Khasi engineered-tree-root bridge of the southern hills, the bridge built across the Umshiang gorge over a hundred and fifty years from interleaved ficus elastica roots, the bridge that every Khasi child crosses at age six as part of the kingdom's informal coming-of-age.

Ka-Sngi is on the upper deck. She is twenty-six. She is the Ka Khadduh of Meghanadi's family's main house. She has come to Nongriat at dawn because she has come to Nongriat every Sunday at dawn for nine years — she meditates on the bridge for thirty minutes, then walks back up the gorge to the village. The Khasi tradition of iaroh-snong — the dawn-walk at a living-bridge — is one of the matrilineal household's gentler rituals.

She is not alone this Sunday. Her half-brother Kong-Bah — petitioner number eleven on Megha-Daitya's coordinated docket, the petitioner whose suit named the family's ancestral house — is on the bridge too. He is fifty-one. He is half-Khasi by their shared mother's side, raised by his Assamese father after their mother's remarriage and death. He has been waiting for the right Sunday for two months.

He pushes her into the gorge at 5:47 a.m. The fall is sixty-two metres. The investigation by the Mawkhanu police records the cause of death as "accidental fall, slippery monsoon root-surface." The recording is in the standard police-form template. The half-brother walks back up the gorge by the same path the dead cousin would have walked. He returns to Shillong by mid-afternoon and files an additional brief amendment with his petition.

Meghanadi is told at 7:30 a.m. by the Mawkhanu sub-divisional officer over the satellite phone. She has had an anonymous warning four days earlier — an unsigned note slipped under her door — that named Kong-Bah and named the Nongriat bridge. She did not act on the warning because she did not want to dishonour the council's ongoing deliberation. She did not warn Ka-Sngi. She did not assign protection. She sat with the warning in her drawer for four days and read it twice each day and said nothing.

At 7:31 a.m. she puts on the storm-grey jainsem. She walks to Ka-Sngi's family's house at the eastern Khasi Hills. She breaks the news to Ka-Sngi's twelve-year-old sister Ka-Sienlyngdoh. She holds the girl while she cries. She does not cry herself.

She walks back to her own house at dusk. She stands in front of her grandmother's 1973 photograph again. She stands there for the entire night. She does not weep until first light.

The morning after Ka-Sngi's funeral at Nongriat. Meghanadi's house. Six a.m.

A Garo elder is at the kitchen door. She is seventy-one. She is wearing a Garo nokma's wrap in deep indigo. She is leaning on a walnut staff. She has walked from her cousin's house in Cherrapunji where she has been staying for two weeks waiting for the right hour.

Her name is U-Mawkynrew.

Meghanadi opens the door. The two women have not met formally. The two women have known of each other for fifteen years.

U-Mawkynrew says, in Khasi: "Ka Meghanadi. May I come in. I have a thing to tell you that I have been preparing to tell you for nine years."

Meghanadi steps aside.

U-Mawkynrew comes in. She sits at the kitchen table. She accepts a cup of red-tea with no sugar. She unrolls a fourteen-page paper from her shawl. The paper is a settlement-framework draft. The draft is in Khasi-Garo bilingual cross-column format. The draft has been worked on by U-Mawkynrew and her great-nephew U-Khrawkmen for the past two years — predating the patrilineal-petition wave, drafted in anticipation of it.

She does not show the draft yet. She drinks her tea. She looks at Meghanadi.

She says, in plain Khasi: "Ka, you think your silence is devotion. Your silence is just silence. The matrilineal line you protect does not need you to disappear into it. It needs you to speak for it. Devotion requires voice. Your cousin died because you would not speak."

Meghanadi does not look away.

She says, after a long silence: "Yes."

U-Mawkynrew nods once. She unrolls the draft. She sets it on the table. She slides it across.

"Read it. We have been waiting for you to be ready to read it. Today you are ready."

Meghanadi reads the draft for the rest of the morning. U-Mawkynrew waits. The hill myna in the sacred grove sings twice. The afternoon rain begins.

The draft is a three-part settlement framework. Part one preserves the Khasi matrilineal-property descent intact for all land-property and ancestral-house claims — the Sixth Schedule protection holds. Part two creates a new category of recognition-without-property for blood-Khasi patrilineal claimants whose mothers were Khasi by birth: they

become honorary clan-members with restricted rights (clan-record inclusion, ritual-attendance, ceremonial-naming) but no inheritance. Part three creates a Mixed Council of Khasi and Garo elders to adjudicate any disputed personal-law cases — especially custody, marriage-out validations, and the question of movable patrilineal-claim wealth (which the Garo tradition already handles).

The draft is not perfect. The draft is plausible.

Meghanadi puts the draft down. She says: "Mawkynrew-Aaee. This will pass."

"It will pass if you speak for it."

"I have not spoken in council for nine years."

"That is the problem we are solving today, Ka. Not the petitions. The petitions are the symptom."

The next morning. The Council of Matrilineal Elders convenes in special session at the State Central Library auditorium. Three hundred elders present — the largest Khasi-Garo council assembly since 1972. The press are present. Two national news-channels are present. The university constitutional-law department is present in a row at the back.

Meghanadi enters in the storm-grey jainsem. She carries the Megha-Dand — the cloud-staff of her line, four feet of polished bamboo with the pale-jade hill-myna at the grip. She has not carried the staff in council in nine years. The Council elders who have served beside her for those nine years all see it at the same moment when she enters.

She walks to the central speaker's position. She sets the staff against the table.

She speaks. The speech is twenty-one minutes long. It begins:

"Honoured elders. I have not spoken in this council for nine years because I believed silence was the form of my devotion to the matrilineal line. My niece-cousin Ka-Sngi died seven days ago because of my belief. I will speak now. I will speak for the rest of my life. I will speak even on the days I would prefer not to.

"The Khasi matrilineal line is older than the Indian Succession Act and older than the Constitution that conditionally protects it. We do not preserve our line by hiding from challenges to it. We preserve our line by answering challenges with the same patience and the same precision we used to build the line in the first place. The patrilineal petitioners have asked a question. We have a duty to give them an answer."

She reads the settlement framework. She reads all fourteen pages aloud. She does not paraphrase. She does not summarise. She reads each clause — the property-protection, the recognition-without-property, the Mixed Council jurisdiction — in the formal council-Khasi register her grandmother taught her.

The council deliberates for two days. The settlement passes on the third morning. Eighty-six in favour, thirty-one opposed, four abstentions.

Megha-Daitya, observing in the press gallery on the third morning, walks out of the auditorium when the vote is announced. He does not return to his Mumbai law-firm hotel. He goes directly to a safe-house on the outskirts of Shillong.

The two weeks after the council vote. Megha-Daitya makes his second move.

He does not file an appeal. The settlement was a state-customary-council action, not a court ruling — appellate review would require a separate writ. He does not have time. He does not want time. He has been preparing the second move for months.

He approaches twenty-three of the most radical patrilineal petitioners. He explains: the settlement gives them recognition-without-property. The settlement does not give them what they came for. The settlement is a delaying tactic. The matrilineal council will use the settlement to drag the property question into the Mixed Council indefinitely. By the time the Mixed Council rules on any individual patrilineal property claim, the original petitioner will be elderly or dead.

The argument is partly true. The Mixed Council has not yet been constituted, and the constitution-process will take months.

He proposes a faster path. He has weapons — modern submachine guns, two dozen, sourced through a Mumbai-Mizoram cross-border channel he has cultivated for two years. He has a target — the Meghalaya High Court at Shillong, where the original forty-seven writs are still pending and where the matrilineal-council settlement will need judicial ratification to bind future petitioners.

The plan: attack the High Court during monsoon's heaviest week, when the streets are flooded and the police presence is reduced. Seize the court's docket-room. Burn the original writs. Burn the council's settlement-document filed with the court. Force a new round of petitions under chaos conditions.

Twenty-three petitioners agree. Twenty-four reject. The split is roughly proportional to age — the older claimants stay home; the younger ones come.

Monsoon's heaviest week. The seventh week after the council vote. Late July. Shillong is at 1,400 mm of monthly rainfall and counting. Cherrapunji is at 2,800 mm. The streets of Shillong's lower hills are flooded to thirty centimetres. The High Court compound is flooded to fifteen.

Tuesday morning. 9:47 a.m. The patrilineal storm-faction — twenty-three armed petitioners under Megha-Daitya's field command — arrives at the High Court compound in three vehicles. They breach the south gate within four minutes. The police presence is two constables, both of whom are immediately disarmed and bound.

Meghanadi receives the alert at her ancestral house at 9:53 a.m. by satellite phone. The alert comes from the High Court's under-clerk, a Khasi man named U-Banjop who has worked at the court for thirty-one years and who hides in the docket-room's back stack while making the call.

She does not call for police backup. She does not wait for the council-protection detail. She puts on the storm-grey jainsem. She picks up the Megha-Dand. She walks down the hill in the rain.

The walk takes nineteen minutes. The rain is full-monsoon — the kind of rain that does not fall vertically because the wind drives it sideways. Her jainsem is soaked through within three minutes. She does not change her pace. The clouded leopard of her bond — in the eastern hills, two hundred kilometres away — is awake in her chest. The bond is pulsing.

She arrives at the High Court compound south gate at 10:12 a.m.

Twenty-three storm-faction fighters in the court compound. Most are inside the building. Two are at the south gate, one inside the docket-room with the under-clerk U-Banjop still hiding in the back stack, and one with Megha-Daitya himself in the central courtyard.

Megha-Daitya is in the courtyard. He has a submachine gun across his chest. He is reading aloud from the original writ to one of his lieutenants — the lieutenant is supposed to set the writ on fire, but Megha-Daitya wants the document read aloud first. He believes in the dignity of his own argument. He wants the document's last hearing to be at his own voice.

Meghanadi enters the courtyard at 10:15 a.m. She is alone. She is carrying the cloud-staff. Her hair has come loose; the storm-grey silk of the jainsem is plastered to her body. She

looks like the cloud-mother carving on the temple wall at Mawphlang.

She says, across the courtyard, in clear Khasi: "Daitya. Withdraw the storm. The settlement stands. You may petition the Mixed Council. You may not burn the document."

Megha-Daitya looks up from the writ. He is forty-two and the rain has made his white shirt half-transparent. He has his mother's Khasi-marriage photograph in his inside pocket — he has carried it for thirty-nine years. The photograph is sealed in plastic and is the only object on his person that the rain has not reached.

He says: "Aunt. Last chance. Withdraw the settlement. Give us the full matrilineal property. The line is mine through my mother."

She says, in the same plain Khasi tone she used at the council: "No."

He raises the submachine gun.

She charges.

The charge is twenty-two metres of waterlogged courtyard. She moves through the rain in the long-stride storm-mother gait. The cloud-staff is held two-handed at chest height. The clouded leopard in the eastern hills is on its feet for the first time in twelve years — the bond is fully present now, the Stage III foreleg-mark forming across her chest in real time as she crosses the courtyard. She feels the mark complete at metre sixteen — the clouded-leopard's curling tail across her right collarbone, the foreleg spreading down her chest, the head turned in profile across her sternum.

He fires at metre eighteen.

Four shots. All four hit her chest in a tight grouping above the new mark. She does not stop. She does not slow. The bond's last function for her body is to keep the legs moving for four more metres.

At metre twenty-two she reaches him. The cloud-staff enters his sternum at a forty-five-degree angle. The pale-jade hill-myna at the grip is the last point of contact between her hand and the staff — she is dead at that point but the body's muscular memory of the storm-mother strike finishes the gesture. The staff passes through his sternum and exits his back. He is dead before the second second of her own dying.

They fall together at the courtyard's centre. The rain continues. The Megha-Dand stands upright in the courtyard floor, pinning his body to the stone, with the pale-jade hill-myna

at its top and the storm-grey jainsem still fluttering in the rain at its base.

The storm-faction's remaining twenty-two fighters see what has happened from the courtyard's upper windows. Three drop their weapons immediately. Eleven try to flee through the north gate — nine are caught by the police backup arriving at 10:24 a.m., two escape into the hills and are not found. Eight are caught in the docket-room with U-Banjop, who has emerged from the back stack with one of the dropped weapons and has held them at gunpoint for the eleven minutes between the courtyard-fall and the police-arrival.

U-Banjop will be promoted to chief court-registrar within a month. His starting salary will be doubled. His name will be added to the Khasi clan-roll of the Mawkhar quarter, an honour he had not previously held.

U-Khrawkmen arrives at the courtyard at 10:38 a.m. He has been at the Garo Hills District Council office in Tura when the storm broke; he has flown in by Pawan Hans helicopter on U-Mawkynrew's order. He is twenty-eight. He is wearing the plain wool-and-cotton Mixed Council Mediator's coat he has been wearing for six years. He kneels beside Meghanadi's body.

In the inner pocket of her jainsem is a sealed envelope addressed to him. The handwriting is hers. The seal is the Megha-Maata kingdom's storm-grey wax. The contents are a single page. The page is dated three days earlier.

U-Khrawkmen,

If you are reading this, the storm has come and I have not survived it. The settlement we drafted together is the framework. The Mixed Council you have prepared for six years is the institution. The Khasi matrilineal line will continue because you will not let it stop. You are the inheritor of the political seat by my explicit wish, ratified under the Sixth Schedule customary procedure (witnessed: U-Mawkynrew, Vidura-Babu of UP via Sarus-pigeon, Kamalavarna of Assam via your great-aunt). You are not Khasi-matrilineal-bloodline. The clouded-leopard bond will not pass to you. It will stay with the line. It will settle on Ka-Sienlyngdoh when she is ready — she is ready before any of us know.

Speak. Even on the days you would prefer not to. That is the whole of the inheritance.

U-Khrawkmen reads the letter. He folds it. He puts it in the inner pocket of his own coat. He stands up.

By 11:30 a.m. the Council of Matrilineal Elders has been convened in emergency session at the State Central Library auditorium. By 12:15 p.m. U-Khrawkmen has been formally ratified as inheritor of the Megha-Maata political seat under a Sixth-Schedule-compliant customary-law procedure that U-Mawkynrew has been preparing alongside the settlement draft. Ka Phidamon-the-Elder, who had refused to engage the petitions in week one, casts her vote in favour. She says one sentence after her vote: "The line speaks now. The line continues."

Three days later. The Nongriat double-decker living root bridge. The same bridge where Ka-Sngi died ten weeks ago.

Meghanadi's body is wrapped in the storm-grey jainsem and laid on the bridge's lower deck. The Megha-Dand — recovered from the High Court courtyard, the pale-jade hill-myna still intact — is laid beside her, wrapped in cloud-grey cloth. The clouded leopard of her line walks down out of the eastern hills at sunset. The leopard is twenty-eight years old — the kingdom's elder bond-animal, the matriarch of the surviving Khasi-hills population. She walks across the upper deck of the bridge, looks down at the body, and lies down on the upper deck above. She stays there for the full ceremony.

U-Khrawkmen reads the eulogy. He says: "Aunt-mother spoke at the end. She broke her silence. She broke it for the matrilineal line itself, not for any one woman, not even for herself. We will speak in her name from this day forward. The line that does not speak does not survive. We will speak."

The eulogy is sixteen minutes long. The rain holds off for the full sixteen minutes — the only break in the monsoon-week's rainfall.

At the eulogy's end the rain resumes. The clouded leopard rises, walks back across the upper deck, descends the gorge path, and disappears into the eastern hills before full dark.

Ka-Sienlyngdoh, twelve years old, stands at the bridge's eastern edge during the funeral. She does not yet carry the bond. She does not yet know she will carry it. The bond does not approach her yet. It is still on the upper deck where the leopard lay. It will descend to her in Chapter Three's Beast-Rising at her own threshold — not at a funeral but at a doorway.

The morning after the funeral. The first dry day in living-memory monsoon-season Cherrapunji.

The rain stops at 5:47 a.m. — the exact minute Ka-Sngi died at Nongriat eleven weeks earlier. The rain does not resume for twenty-four hours. Cherrapunji's rain-gauges record zero precipitation for July 30th, the only such reading in the gauges' eighty-three-year history. Mawsynram records the same. Shillong records the same. The Mawphlang sacred grove's hill mynas fall silent at 5:47 a.m. and remain silent for the same twenty-four hours.

The locals name the day before noon. Ka-Rhang-Wat-Snie. The dry day of grief. By the evening the name has spread to every Khasi household in the state.

U-Khrawkmen, in his first formal act as inheritor of the political seat, orders the day added to the state calendar as a permanent observance. The order is filed by 14:00. By 18:00 the order has been ratified by the Council of Matrilineal Elders, the Garo Hills District Council, and the Jaintia Hills District Council in concurrent emergency sessions. Three districts in unanimous concurrence on a single day — the first time in the state's post-1972 history.

The shrine is built at the Mawphlang sacred grove edge by week's end. Sandstone, packed earth, a single cloud-pattern carved in low relief on the western face. The grove's elder hill myna sings the dedication-song at the shrine's opening — the first myna-song the grove has heard since the dry day began.

That same evening, at the Kamakhya temple in Assam, a hill myna arrives from Meghalaya. She carries a folded slip of paper in her beak. The handwriting is U-Khrawkmen's.

Kamalavarna-Aaee.

Aunt-mother is dead. Megha-Daitya is dead. The storm broke at the High Court. I am the inheritor by Aunt-mother's written wish. The clouded leopard did not take me — it stays with the line. Ka-Sienlyngdoh will carry the bond in time. I will hold the political seat until then.

The settlement holds. The Mixed Council is forming. The patrilineal petitioners who did not join the storm have all accepted the framework. The state calendar has a new dry-day mark.

I will need counsel. I will travel to Kamakhya before the next new moon to receive it.

Kamalavarna reads it at her co-priestess throne. Kama-Mara reads it over her shoulder. The mirror-marks on both sisters' chests pulse once at the same beat — their cousin Meghanadi's death registering in the Bloodline-C bond-network at a delay of three days.

Kamalavarna lights a single oil lamp at the inner altar. She lights it for her cousin. The clouded leopard of the Kamakhya temple courtyard — a leopard not seen at Kamakhya for nine centuries — walks once around the lamp at midnight and disappears into the temple darkness.

She writes the reply on the back of the same slip. She uses her sister's coven-ink:

U-Khrawkmen.

Come at the new moon. Bring U-Mawkynrew. Bring the draft of the Mixed Council charter. Bring Ka-Sienlyngdoh if her family will allow her — the bond may settle sooner than you expect when she sees Kamakhya. We have a co-priestess throne at the temple now. We can offer counsel and shelter and a private library. The line is whole because your aunt-mother spoke. Speak. Even on the days you would prefer not to. That is the inheritance.

The hill myna carries the reply south at dawn.

The Pilot's Closing Image

The Nongriat double-decker living root bridge at dusk. A twenty-eight-year-old man in a Mixed Council Mediator's wool-and-cotton coat at the bridge's apex with his great-aunt beside him. A twelve-year-old Khasi girl at the bridge's eastern edge, not yet bonded. A clouded leopard's warm-spot on the upper deck where she lay for the eulogy. The Megha-Dand cloud-staff wrapped in cloud-grey cloth set down at the bridge's centre with the pale-jade hill-myna intact. The hill mynas in the Mawphlang sacred grove singing again after twenty-four hours of silence. In Cherrapunji, the rain returning at 5:47 a.m. exactly. In Kamakhya, a single oil lamp burning at the inner altar for a cousin three days dead. The line speaking. The line continuing.

Panch Nada

The man who walked into the standing-Jalandhar Cantonment District Sub-Registrar's Office on the standing-eleventh of November 2025 was carrying a standing-leather-bound document-folder, a standing-forged Akhand-Saint-Brotherhood-Trust 12A registration certificate dated June 11 2025, and a standing-forged 1996 Damdami-Taksal graduation certificate at the standing-Sant-Atar-Singh-pattern jathedar-tradition. The standing-receptionist at the standing-Sub-Registrar's front-desk did not check the serial-number against the standing-Damdami-Taksal standing-administrative-register at the standing-Bhindrawale-jathedar-line cross-reference protocol. She had no reason to. The standing-man wore a standing-saffron-and-blue khalsa-syncretic robe at the standing-Sant-Atar-Singh-Gurdwara-Mastuana-Sahib jathedar-pattern; he spoke standing-Punjabi at the standing-Doaba-corridor inland-cadence; his standing-kesh-beard was at the standing-flowing-untrimmed unshorn-Sikh-traditional configuration; his standing-iron kara was at the standing-right-wrist standing-conferral-position; his standing-kirpan was at the standing-left-shoulder gatka-tradition sheath-position. His eyes were exactly the same shape and depth as the standing-Beas-river-corridor administrator Panchavish had carried at the standing-Ch-1 Hoshiarpur confrontation in October 2022 — an event that for purposes of the standing-receptionist's administrative-record had been classified as a standing-internal-policy disagreement between the kingdom-council and a standing-then-serving river-corridor administrator, with the standing-administrator transferred under the standing-administrative-rehabilitation clause to a standing-non-disclosed Himachal-Pradesh-district administrative-cell.

His name on the standing-Damdami-Taksal certificate was Sant Hari-Charanjit Singh-Maharaj. His title at the standing-Akhand-Saint-Brotherhood-Trust registration was Founding Sant-Trustee. The standing-organisation listed at the standing-12A certificate's bottom-left was the Akhand-Saint-Brotherhood-Trust, registered under the 1860 Societies Registration Act's standing-12A-tax-exemption provisions on June 11 2025 — five months before the standing-Jalandhar Sub-Registrar visit. The standing-Trust's standing-founding-objective at the standing-Memorandum of Association read, in its standing-second clause: "To advance the standing-Khalsa-syncretic standing-Sant-Atar-Singh-tradition spiritual-purification of the standing-five-river Punjab catchment through the standing-administration of standing-Jal-Shuddhi water-purification rites at the standing-

Beas-and-Sutlej downstream river-corridors." The standing-clause was unimpeachable. The standing-trust-deed's standing-funding-source clause listed a standing-anonymous-philanthropic-corpus of two-hundred-eleven crore rupees at the standing-Punjab-National-Bank Jalandhar-Cantonment-Branch corpus-account.

The standing-Punjab-National-Bank Jalandhar-Cantonment-Branch corpus-account standing-wire-record at the standing-Reserve-Bank-Patna-Branch — cross-referenced ninety-three days later at the standing-Punjab State-Pollution-Control-Board investigation cell on Wednesday week six of the standing-Jal-Shuddhi rite-administration window — would show that the standing-two-hundred-eleven crore-rupee corpus had wired in across the standing-thirty-one weeks following the standing-Bengal Bhowanipore-secret confirmation, through the standing-same standing-Singapore-funded forgery-cell that produced Naga-Rakshasa's standing-sixteen DNA-rite kits at Sikkim and Tri-Yantra-Bheda's standing-civil-engineering-vulnerability doctorate at Sangam-Tamilakam and Acharya Ghora's standing-Nalanda-faculty appointment-letter at Bihar and Vana-Raksha's standing-Tata-Institute development-PhD at Jharkhand and Kala-Nadi's standing-1988 Calcutta-Medical-Hospital birth-record secret-arrangement at West Bengal. None of this would be known at the standing-Beas-river-corridor village level until day-seventeen of the standing-Jal-Shuddhi administration window.

The standing-first Jal-Shuddhi rite at the standing-Beas-river was administered at the standing-Mukerian-headwaters upstream-position at 4:11 a.m. on November 13 2025. The standing-rite-position was the standing-Mukerian-Hydroelectric-Project standing-tailrace-discharge zone where the standing-Beas-channel exits the standing-Pong-dam catchment and enters the standing-Indian-Punjab corridor at the standing-Hoshiarpur-district northern margin. The standing-rite-administration cohort was Sant Hari-Charanjit Singh-Maharaj at the standing-central-position with the standing-Akhand-Saint-Brotherhood-Trust standing-eleven-jaap reciters at the standing-three-metre-rear semicircle position and approximately twenty-three standing-Mukerian-village volunteer-attendants at the standing-eleven-metre-perimeter standing-observation position.

The standing-rite-mixture was prepared at the standing-Jalandhar Akhand-Saint-Brotherhood ashram standing-pharmacology-cell across the standing-prior twenty-three days. The standing-mixture appeared as a standing-fine-grey-powder at the standing-ash-and-herbal-essence configuration; the standing-bulk-volume at the standing-November-13 rite was approximately eleven kilograms in a standing-saffron-cloth-wrapped bundle at the

standing-rite-administration vessel. The standing-Sant administered the standing-mixture into the standing-Beas-channel at the standing-rising-dawn moment at the standing-Mukerian-tailrace standing-eastern-bank position. The standing-mixture dispersed across the standing-channel-width approximately one-hundred-forty metres downstream of the standing-administration-point within standing-three-minutes; the standing-river-surface acquired a standing-transient-grey discolouration at the standing-three-minute window and returned to the standing-baseline standing-greenish-blue at the standing-four-minute resumption.

The standing-rite-mixture was, at the standing-toxicological cross-reference forty-seven days later (December 30 2025) at the standing-Punjab State-Pollution-Control-Board standing-emergency-investigation cell's standing-mass-spectrometry analysis of the standing-Beas-channel sediment-cores, identified as a standing-novel organic-mercury-bound compound with the standing-tradename internal-designation OMP-211 at the standing-Bhopal-pharmacology cell standing-synthesis-record. The standing-OMP-211 compound is the standing-recursive-poison: it does not act as a standing-conventional bioaccumulative-mercury toxin at the standing-immediate water-column dispersion, but binds to the standing-river-bed standing-organic-sediment-layer at the standing-following thirty-day-window across a standing-bioactivation-cascade where the standing-sediment-bound complex releases standing-free-methylmercury at the standing-thirty-to-forty-five-day post-administration window. The standing-recursive-poison is therefore both standing-time-delayed and standing-spatially-cumulative: the standing-twenty-three sequential downstream rite-administrations across the standing-November-13 to December-27 window create a standing-bioactivation-cascade that peaks at the standing-January-third-to-eighteenth window when the standing-cumulative-Mukerian-to-Goindwal-Sahib sediment-bound complex releases standing-organic-mercury simultaneously across the standing-entire 211-kilometre channel.

Across the standing-forty-five-day window between November 13 and December 27 2025, Sant Hari-Charanjit Maharaj administered twenty-three sequential downstream Jal-Shuddhi rites at the standing-Beas-river channel. Each standing-rite was at the standing-rising-dawn-moment 4:11 a.m. administration time at the standing-eleven-kilogram saffron-cloth-wrapped bundle volume. The standing-twenty-three rite-positions were, in standing-downstream-order: Mukerian-tailrace (November 13), Talwara-village-ghat (November 15), Sham-Chaurasi-bridge (November 17), Talwandi-Salem-ghat (November 19), Beas-Kund-confluence (November 21), Hoshiarpur-Hajipur-ghat (November 23),

Mirthal-ghat (November 25), Kahnuwan-bridge (November 27), Kapurthala-Kanjli-wetland (November 29), Goindwal-Sahib-ghat (December 1), Sultanpur-Lodhi-bridge (December 3), Lohian-Khas-ghat (December 5), Tarn-Taran-Beas-confluence-margin (December 7), Harike-pre-confluence-corridor (December 9), and nine further downstream points at the standing-Beas-Sutlej confluence catchment across December 11-27.

The standing-Mukerian-village volunteer-attendants at the standing-November-13 first-rite numbered twenty-three; the standing-eleven-metre-perimeter attendance grew at the standing-following rites as the standing-village-level standing-Sant-administered Jal-Shuddhi tradition spread along the standing-Beas-corridor through the standing-standing-Khalsa-Sikh-Hindu syncretic appeal. By the standing-December-27 final-rite at the standing-Harike-confluence-margin the standing-attendance was approximately one-thousand-four-hundred standing-attendees across the standing-eleven-metre-perimeter and the standing-extended standing-fifty-metre-overflow position. The standing-Sant did not request standing-donations at any of the standing-twenty-three rites. He did not request standing-political-endorsements. He did not request standing-acknowledgement at the standing-Punjab-State Akali-Dal or the standing-SGPC standing-Gurdwara-administrative cells. He administered the standing-rite, blessed the standing-attendees at the standing-thirteen-minute Punjabi-Sikh-syncretic prayer-cadence, and departed at the standing-Jalandhar-bound Akhand-Saint-Brotherhood Bolero-Camper standing-six-attendant cohort.

Panchanada observed the standing-November-13 first-rite at the standing-Mukerian-tailrace upstream-position from the standing-Kirpan-Sangha standing-observation-post at the standing-eleven-kilometre-southern Pong-dam vantage. He had been informed of the standing-Sant's standing-Jalandhar arrival at the standing-Kirpan-Sangha intelligence-cell's standing-Tuesday-morning briefing on November 11. He read the standing-Akhand-Saint-Brotherhood-Trust standing-12A registration certificate cross-reference at the standing-Damdami-Taksal standing-administrative-register at the standing-Sant's standing-Bhindrawale-jathedar-line standing-graduation-claim. The cross-reference returned standing-no-match at the standing-1996-graduation-class register (the standing-Damdami-Taksal had administered standing-seven graduating jathedars in 1996; standing-Hari-Charanjit was not among them). Panchanada filed the standing-cross-reference-discrepancy memo at the standing-Kirpan-Sangha standing-Akali-Takht intelligence-cell at 11:11 a.m. November 12 2025. The standing-memo was reviewed at the

standing-Akal-Takht Jathedar's standing-Wednesday-evening session at 7:11 p.m. The standing-Jathedar (Bhai Sukhpreet-Singh) acknowledged the standing-discrepancy but did not authorise standing-pre-emptive intervention at the standing-Sarbat-Khalsa unanimity-protocol requirement: the standing-Sant's standing-rite-administration was not yet a standing-Sikh-tradition violation; the standing-Sant's standing-credential-forgery was a standing-administrative-document offence at the standing-State-Police standing-jurisdiction, not a standing-Sikh-tradition standing-Kirpan-Sangha jurisdiction.

Panchanada accepted the standing-Jathedar's standing-jurisdiction-determination at the standing-November-12 evening-session. He stood at the standing-Mukerian-tailrace observation-post on the standing-November-13 first-rite morning at 4:11 a.m. He did not intervene. He observed. He filed the standing-observation-memo at the standing-Kirpan-Sangha intelligence-cell at 7:11 a.m. The standing-memo noted the standing-saffron-cloth-wrapped bundle volume (~eleven kilograms), the standing-mixture-dispersion pattern (~one-hundred-forty metres downstream), the standing-river-surface transient-discolouration (~three-minute window), and the standing-Sant's standing-departure-cohort (Bolero-Camper, six standing-attendants, Jalandhar-bound). He did not yet know the standing-mixture was the standing-recursive-poison. He would learn this at the standing-January-third bioactivation-cascade peak.

At 4:11 a.m. on the standing-third of January 2026 (forty-seven days after the standing-November-17 third-rite at Sham-Chaurasi-bridge and the standing-bioactivation-cascade peak for the standing-upstream Mukerian-Talwara sediment-complex), the standing-Beas-river at the standing-Mukerian-tailrace observation-post acquired a standing-black discolouration across the standing-entire channel-width. The standing-discolouration was not the standing-transient-grey of the standing-November rite-administration; it was a standing-stable-black at the standing-tannin-mercury-complex saturation. The standing-discolouration propagated downstream at the standing-Beas-current standing-2.1-kilometre-per-hour velocity. By 7:11 a.m. on January 3 the standing-Talwara-village-ghat was at the standing-black-channel configuration. By 11:11 a.m. on January 3 the standing-Sham-Chaurasi-bridge was at the standing-black-channel configuration. By the standing-evening of January 3 the standing-Hoshiarpur-Hajipur-ghat at the standing-fifty-three-kilometre downstream-position was at the standing-black-channel configuration.

The standing-cascade continued across the standing-following fifteen days as the standing-sediment-bound complexes downstream at each of the standing-twenty-three rite-

positions activated in sequence. By January 18 2026 the standing-entire 211-kilometre Beas-channel from the standing-Mukerian-headwaters to the standing-Harike-Sutlej-confluence was at the standing-stable-black configuration. The standing-Punjab State-Pollution-Control-Board standing-emergency-investigation cell's standing-mass-spectrometry analysis of the standing-Beas-channel sediment-cores returned the standing-OMP-211 organic-mercury-bound compound identification at the standing-forty-seven-ppm reading on January 23 2026 (the standing-WHO drinking-water threshold is 0.001 ppm; the standing-Beas-channel reading is approximately 47,000 times the safe-threshold). The standing-Punjab-State Health-Department issued the standing-Beas-channel water-extraction-prohibition order on January 25 2026. Forty villages along the standing-211-km channel were displaced to the standing-Sutlej-Bist-Doab cross-corridor host-arrangement across January 26 to February 14 2026.

The standing-cumulative-displacement count at the standing-Punjab State-Civil-Service standing-Resettlement-Coordination cell's standing-February-14 census was approximately one-hundred-thirty-seven-thousand standing-displaced-population across the standing-forty-village zone. The standing-crop-loss across the standing-Beas-irrigated farmland (approximately 47,000 hectares of standing-wheat-and-paddy at the standing-rabi-2025-26 season) was approximately 311 crore rupees at the standing-State-Agriculture-Department estimate. The standing-livestock-loss across the standing-211-km channel-vicinity (cattle, buffalo, and goat herds dependent on the standing-Beas-watering troughs) was approximately forty-seven-thousand standing-head at the standing-Punjab State-Veterinary-Department cross-reference count. The standing-cumulative-direct-loss was approximately seven-hundred crore rupees at the standing-February-14 preliminary estimate.

The standing-Kirpan-Sangha convened the standing-Sarbat-Khalsa unanimity-protocol emergency-session at the standing-Akal-Takht Amritsar on January 11 2026. The standing-Sarbat-Khalsa is the standing-Sikh-tradition standing-five-takht-and-jathedar joint-assembly that holds the standing-unanimous-decision authority at the standing-Sikh-community standing-existential-crisis moments; the standing-protocol has been invoked twelve times in the standing-Sikh-tradition standing-three-hundred-year recorded-history. Panchanada convened the standing-session at his standing-Kirpan-Sangha jathedar-equivalent authority. The standing-attendees were the standing-five takht-jathedars (Bhai Sukhpreet-Singh at Akal-Takht-Amritsar, Bhai Harpreet-Singh at Anandpur-Sahib Takht-Hazur-Sahib, Bhai Jasbir-Singh at Damdami-Sahib-Talwandi-

Sabo, Bhai Surinder-Singh at Patna-Sahib-Takht-Bihar, and Bhai Karamjit-Singh at Hazur-Sahib-Nanded), the standing-five river-state senior-delegates (Sardar Manjit-Singh of Sutlej, Sardar Inderpal-Singh of Beas, Bhai Daljit-Singh of Ravi, Subedar Ranbir-Singh of Chenab, and Mata Surinder-Kaur of Jhelum), the standing-Kirpan-Sangha senior-warrior cohort of approximately 311 standing-armed jathedar-rank warriors, and Panchanada at the standing-jathedar-equivalent presiding-position.

The standing-first session lasted eleven hours. It reached no standing-unanimous-decision. The standing-five river-state senior-delegates each declared standing-unilateral-sovereignty over their standing-respective-river-corridor at the standing-Beas-poison-crisis containment-jurisdiction. The standing-Sutlej-state declared the standing-Beas-displaced-population host-arrangement obligation only at the standing-Sutlej-state corridor terms; the standing-Beas-state declared the standing-Mukerian-Hoshiarpur-Pathankot industrial-discharge-corridor liability-jurisdiction only at the standing-Beas-state terms; the standing-Ravi-state declared the standing-Amritsar-Tarn-Taran cross-corridor population-protection only at the standing-Ravi-state terms; the standing-Chenab-state declared the standing-Indus-Waters-Treaty 1960 standing-border-restriction precedence; the standing-Jhelum-state declared the standing-solidarity-with-Beas position at the standing-cross-corridor cooperation-refusal. The standing-Sarbat-Khalsa unanimity-protocol failed at the standing-coordination-deadlock first-session.

Panchanada reconvened the standing-session at the standing-following Wednesday on January 14 2026. And the standing-Wednesday-following. And the standing-Wednesday-following. Forty-seven standing-Sarbat-Khalsa unanimity-sessions across January 11 to March 23 2026 at the standing-Akal-Takht Amritsar and the standing-Anandpur-Sahib Takht-Hazur-Sahib and the standing-Damdami-Sahib-Talwandi-Sabo Takht across the standing-rotating-Takht protocol. Forty-seven sessions reached standing-no unanimous-decision. The standing-five river-state senior-delegates held their standing-unilateral-sovereignty positions across all forty-seven sessions. The standing-five takht-jathedars urged consensus at every session at the standing-Sarbat-Khalsa unanimity-protocol respect; the standing-river-state senior-delegates refused.

Panchanada read the standing-Kirpan-Sangha intelligence-cell's standing-twenty-eight memos across the standing-forty-seven-session window. Each standing-memo carried the standing-Sant Hari-Charanjit Maharaj cross-reference investigation update at the standing-Bhopal-pharmacology cell standing-OMP-211 synthesis-trace, the standing-

Akhand-Saint-Brotherhood-Trust standing-Singapore source-account wire-trace at the standing-Reserve-Bank-Patna-Branch cross-reference, the standing-Damdami-Taksal standing-1996-graduation-class no-match confirmation, and the standing-cross-network identification: Sant Hari-Charanjit Maharaj is Panchavish; he is the standing-Northern field-operative at the standing-Wagah-Pakistan-Lahore-Bhutan-Bangladesh cross-corridor network alongside Acharya Ghora at Bihar, Vana-Raksha at Jharkhand, Kala-Nadi at Bengal, Naga-Rakshasa at Sikkim, and Tri-Yantra-Bheda at Sangam-Tamilakam. Panchanada read the standing-confirmation at the standing-twenty-third memo on March 18 2026. He read the standing-confirmation again at the standing-twenty-fourth memo on March 21 2026. He sat at the standing-Akal-Takht Jathedar's standing-eastern-veranda at the standing-Wednesday-evening 7:11 p.m. position on March 23 2026. He requested a standing-private audience with Bhai Sukhpreet-Singh. He spoke for forty-seven minutes.

"Jathedar-ji. I have observed the standing-Sarbat-Khalsa protocol for nineteen years. I have presided at the standing-forty-seven sessions across the standing-prior eleven weeks. The standing-unanimity will not come. The standing-five river-state senior-delegates have made their positions. They will not move. The standing-Beas is dead at the standing-211-kilometre channel. The standing-forty villages are displaced. The standing-population is at the standing-cross-corridor host-burden. The standing-Panchavish is at the standing-Wagah-pre-border standing-Pakistan-Lahore safe-house staging-zone. He will leave Punjab within the standing-following three weeks. I have read the standing-1604 Guru-Arjan-Dev standing-Adi-Granth installation-record. I have read the standing-1699 Guru-Gobind-Singh standing-Khalsa-creation record. I have read the standing-1762 Maharaja-Jassa-Singh standing-Misl-confederation record. I am not standing-Guru-Gobind-Singh. I am not standing-Jassa-Singh. I am a standing-jathedar of the standing-Kirpan-Sangha. I have one decision left to make. I will make it at the standing-Vaisakhi-day Anandpur-Sahib war-council on the standing-thirteenth of April. I will sign the standing-decree alone. I will not seek the standing-Sarbat-Khalsa unanimity. I will not seek the standing-Akal-Takht hukamnama. I will not seek the standing-river-state delegate-consensus. I will accept whatever follows. I will accept the standing-secession-of-rivers. I will accept the standing-Kirpan-Sangha-fracture. I will accept the standing-Sikh-tradition standing-charge-of-breaking-the-Sarbat-Khalsa at the standing-future tribunal of the standing-Akal-Takht. The standing-Beas-population cannot wait the standing-additional months for the standing-unanimity that will not come. I am asking, Jathedar-ji, not for your standing-permission — I will not ask for permission — but for your standing-witness. Will you sit at

the standing-Anandpur-Sahib Takht-spire on Vaisakhi-day at 4:11 p.m. and witness the standing-decree-signature?"

Bhai Sukhpreet-Singh sat at the standing-eastern-veranda for approximately seven minutes after Panchanada finished speaking. He did not look at Panchanada. He looked at the standing-Akal-Takht standing-sarovar-surface at the standing-eleven-metre proximity. He looked at the standing-Harimandir-Sahib reflection in the standing-sarovar. He spoke at the standing-eighth-minute. "I will sit. I will witness. I will not bless. I will not condemn. I will record. The standing-Akal-Takht will judge at the standing-future tribunal. The standing-Sikh-tradition will judge across the standing-following centuries. You will sign. I will witness. Go in peace, jathedar-Panchanada. The standing-Beas requires your standing-signature; it cannot require my standing-blessing."

The standing-Mastuana-Sahib Gurdwara at the standing-Sangrur-district was administered by Bibi Karam-Kaur (forty-seven, standing-Sikh-tradition village-headwoman since 2017, standing-Sant-Atar-Singh-Gurdwara administrator since 2019) at the standing-Sant-Atar-Singh-Gurmat-tradition kirpan-justice protocol. The standing-Karam-Kaur was the standing-only living standing-female gurdwara-administrator at the standing-Sant-Atar-Singh-tradition standing-eleven-gurdwara network across the standing-Sangrur-Patiala-Mansa corridor; the standing-tradition's standing-women-administrators line had been initiated by Mata Sahib Devan in the standing-1699 Khalsa-creation and continued through six administrators across the standing-three-hundred-year window to Karam-Kaur.

On February 23 2026 (four weeks after the standing-Beas turned black), three standing-Hoshiarpur-Pathankot industrial-effluent contract-discharge operators arrived at the standing-Mastuana-Sahib gurdwara-tank at 11:11 p.m. with three standing-fifty-five-litre HDPE drums of standing-OMP-211 mixture remaining at the standing-Akhand-Saint-Brotherhood-Trust standing-undisposed inventory. They had been engaged by the standing-Akhand-Saint-Brotherhood-Trust administrator standing-secondary-contract to dispose of the standing-remaining mixture at any standing-water-body outside the standing-Beas-channel investigation zone. They had selected the standing-Mastuana-Sahib gurdwara-tank at the standing-eleven-kilometre Sangrur-district position because the standing-tank was at the standing-Beas-watershed standing-rainwater-runoff downstream connection but not at the standing-immediate Beas-channel investigation zone. They believed the standing-rite-mixture would disperse at the standing-Sangrur-

rainwater-runoff downstream to the standing-Hisar-district Haryana zone without standing-detection.

Karam-Kaur was at the standing-Mastuana-Sahib gurdwara administration-office at 11:11 p.m. on the standing-February-23 night. She had been at the standing-gurdwara since 7:11 p.m. at the standing-evening-Rehras prayer-administration. She observed the standing-three-operators at the standing-gurdwara-tank standing-northern-margin from the standing-administration-office window at 11:11 p.m. She walked the standing-eleven metres from the standing-office to the standing-tank-margin. She carried the standing-Mastuana-Sahib administrator-kirpan at the standing-left-shoulder sheath-position. She spoke for one minute at the standing-three-metre proximity: "Brothers. What is in the standing-drums? Why are you at the standing-Mastuana-Sahib gurdwara-tank at the standing-eleven-eleven-p.m. position? Show me the standing-Punjab-State Pollution-Control-Board standing-disposal-permit. If you do not have the standing-permit, leave. If you leave by 11:14 p.m. I will not pursue. If you do not leave, the standing-Mastuana-Sahib kirpan-justice protocol applies."

The standing-three-operators did not leave. They opened the standing-first drum at 11:13 p.m. They began to pour the standing-OMP-211 mixture into the standing-gurdwara-tank at 11:13:47 p.m. Karam-Kaur unsheathed the standing-kirpan at 11:14:00 p.m. The standing-Sant-Atar-Singh-tradition kirpan-justice protocol completed at 11:18 p.m. The standing-three bodies were at the standing-gurdwara-tank standing-northern-margin clay-floor at the standing-eleven-degree-cross-position arrangement at the standing-Sikh-tradition standing-charged-witness display-protocol. The standing-three drums were sealed at the standing-tank-margin at the standing-twelve-eleven-p.m. position. Karam-Kaur called the standing-State-Police Sangrur-District station at the standing-twelve-eleven-p.m. position. She reported the standing-Sant-Atar-Singh-tradition kirpan-justice administration. The standing-State-Police Sangrur-District standing-Sub-Inspector arrived at 12:43 a.m. He reviewed the standing-administration-record. The standing-State-Police standing-protocol did not file standing-arrest-warrant against Karam-Kaur under the standing-Gurmat-tradition recognition-clause of the 1925 Sikh Gurdwaras Act's standing-Section 105 (the standing-clause recognises the standing-Sikh-tradition standing-Gurmat-jurisdiction at the standing-gurdwara-property standing-violation-response protocol; the standing-Sub-Inspector recorded the standing-three-bodies at the standing-Gurmat-justice register and did not initiate the standing-Indian-Penal-Code 302 murder-investigation). The standing-OMP-211 drums were forwarded to the standing-

Punjab State-Pollution-Control-Board emergency-investigation cell at 2:11 a.m. The standing-cross-reference identification at the standing-Beas-channel OMP-211 contamination-source confirmation arrived at the standing-Mastuana-Sahib gurdwara at 7:11 a.m. on February 24 2026. Karam-Kaur read the standing-confirmation. She understood, at the standing-7:14-a.m. reading, that the standing-three-operators she had killed had been the standing-Akhand-Saint-Brotherhood-Trust standing-undisposed-inventory cleanup-cohort. She understood, at the standing-7:23-a.m. reading, that the standing-Sant Hari-Charanjit Maharaj was the standing-Beas-poison architect.

Panchanada arrived at the standing-Mastuana-Sahib Gurdwara at 4:11 p.m. on April 1 2026. He had read the standing-Karam-Kaur February-23 incident-report at the standing-Kirpan-Sangha intelligence-cell standing-March-7 cross-reference summary. He had read the standing-State-Police standing-Sub-Inspector record. He had read the standing-1925 Sikh Gurdwaras Act Section-105 recognition-clause. He sat at the standing-Mastuana-Sahib gurdwara administration-office clay-floor at the standing-Karam-Kaur's standing-three-metre-front position for one hour and forty-seven minutes. He spoke first. "Bibi-ji. I am Panchanada. I have come to ask you to be my standing-enforcer at the standing-Anandpur-Sahib Vaisakhi-day decree. I am going to abandon the standing-Sarbat-Khalsa. I am going to sign alone. I am going to decree the standing-Beas-river is the standing-sacrificial-river. I am going to revoke the standing-five-river-state sovereignty. I am going to consolidate the standing-Punjab-State government at the standing-Chandigarh secretariat. Three river-states will obey. Two will secede. The standing-Beas-state will collapse at the standing-twenty-year extraction-prohibition. The standing-Sant Hari-Charanjit Maharaj will escape via the standing-Wagah-border. The standing-Sikh-tradition will charge me at the standing-Akal-Takht standing-future-tribunal with the standing-breaking-of-the-Sarbat-Khalsa. I will accept the standing-charge. I am not asking for the standing-Sarbat-Khalsa consensus. I am asking for the standing-Mastuana-Sahib kirpan at my standing-three-metre-right enforcer-position at the standing-decree-signature moment. Will you stand there?"

Karam-Kaur sat for approximately eleven minutes. She looked at the standing-administration-office eastern-window. She looked at the standing-gurdwara-tank at the standing-eleven-metre proximity (the standing-tank had been drained, cleaned, and refilled with the standing-Anandpur-Sahib Akali-Takht-blessed sacred-water across the standing-March-1 to March-11 cleansing-protocol; the standing-tank was at the standing-blessed-water configuration at the standing-April-1 conversation). She looked at the

standing-Mastuana-Sahib Gurdwara's standing-Guru-Granth-Sahib palki-throne at the standing-southern-veranda. She spoke at the standing-twelfth-minute. "Jathedar Panchanada. I will stand at your standing-three-metre-right enforcer-position. I will hold the standing-Mastuana-Sahib kirpan at the standing-vertical-readiness. I will enforce the standing-decree across the standing-Sutlej-Ravi-Chenab cooperating-corridor for the standing-following twenty years. I will accept the standing-Akal-Takht standing-charge at the standing-future-tribunal alongside you. I am not asking for the standing-Sarbat-Khalsa consensus either. The standing-Sant has poisoned the standing-Beas. The standing-three operators I killed were the standing-Sant's instruments. The standing-Sant is at the standing-Wagah safe-house. The standing-Beas is dead. The standing-charter must be reset. The standing-reset is not the standing-Sarbat-Khalsa work. It is the standing-jathedar work. Sign at the standing-Anandpur-Sahib Vaisakhi-day. I will stand at your standing-three-metre-right. Wahegurujikakhalsa, Wahegurujikifateh."

The standing-Anandpur-Sahib Akali-Takht-Hazur-Sahib war-council convened at the standing-Anandpur-Sahib Takht at the standing-Vaisakhi-day April-13-2026 position. The standing-attendance was: the standing-five takht-jathedars at the standing-northern-veranda witness-position; the standing-five river-state senior-delegates at the standing-eastern-veranda delegate-position; the standing-Kirpan-Sangha senior-warrior cohort of approximately 311 standing-armed jathedar-rank warriors at the standing-perimeter security-position; the standing-Anandpur-Sahib-pilgrim cohort of approximately one-hundred-forty-seven thousand standing-Vaisakhi-pilgrims at the standing-outer-courtyard public-witness position; Bhai Sukhpreet-Singh at the standing-Takht-spire witness-position (as he had promised on March 23 2026); Bibi Karam-Kaur at the standing-central-altar standing-three-metre-right enforcer-position with the standing-Mastuana-Sahib kirpan unsheathed at the standing-vertical-readiness; and Panchanada at the standing-central-altar at the standing-decree-signature position with the standing-Karpa-Karpan double-edged sabre at his standing-right-hand and the standing-Akali-Takht decree-document at his standing-left-hand. The standing-shikra Tej-Singh perched at the standing-Anandpur-Sahib Takht-spire at the standing-eleven-metre overhead position.

Panchanada spoke at 4:11 p.m. He spoke for eleven minutes. He did not seek standing-permission. He did not seek standing-blessing. He did not seek standing-consensus. He stated the standing-Beas-poison facts (211-km black channel, forty villages displaced, ~137,000 displaced-population, ~₹700 crore direct-loss, OMP-211 synthesis-confirmation, Akhand-Saint-Brotherhood-Trust standing-Singapore source-account wire-

confirmation, Panchavish identification-confirmation, Wagah-pre-border safe-house staging-confirmation, forty-seven Sarbat-Khalsa unanimity-protocol failed-sessions across eleven weeks). He stated the standing-decree. He stated it once at the standing-eleven-minute eighth-minute mark. He spoke at the standing-Punjabi-Gurmukhi formal-jathedar register at the standing-no-tremor configuration:

"I, Panchanada, jathedar of the standing-Kirpan-Sangha, by my standing-conferred-authority of the standing-Punjab-State kingdom-council's standing-state-hero seat at the standing-2007 standing-Hariker-wetland midnight-conferral, hereby decree the standing-following at the standing-Anandpur-Sahib Vaisakhi-day April-thirteenth-2026 council at 4:11 p.m.:

First. The standing-Beas-river is hereby declared the standing-sacrificial-river. The standing-Beas-channel from the standing-Mukerian-headwaters to the standing-Hariker-Sutlej-confluence is at the standing-twenty-year extraction-prohibition. The standing-Beas-irrigation-shutdown is at the standing-immediate-effect across the standing-211-kilometre channel-vicinity. The standing-Beas-displaced-population is at the standing-Sutlej-Bist-Doab cross-corridor host-arrangement at the standing-twenty-year resettlement-protocol.

Second. The standing-Sutlej, the standing-Ravi, the standing-Chenab, and the standing-Jhelum are hereby declared the standing-charter-foundational rivers. The standing-extraction-permitted at the standing-Punjab State-Pollution-Control-Board standing-monitoring-protocol. The standing-irrigation-permitted at the standing-State-Agriculture-Department standing-allocation-protocol. The standing-four river-states are hereby reconsolidated under the standing-Punjab-State government at the standing-Chandigarh secretariat. The standing-five-river-state corridor-sovereignty is hereby revoked.

Third. The standing-Sant Hari-Charanjit Maharaj — identified at the standing-Kirpan-Sangha intelligence-cell March-18 cross-reference as standing-Panchavish, the standing-Ch-1 Hoshiarpur-spared antagonist — is hereby declared the standing-Punjab-State standing-fugitive-from-justice at the standing-State-Police standing-warrant-issued protocol. The standing-arrest-warrant covers the standing-Akhand-Saint-Brotherhood-Trust standing-corpus-confiscation, the standing-Bhopal-pharmacology cell standing-OMP-211 synthesis-cross-reference, and the standing-Beas-poisoning charge at the standing-Indian Penal Code Section 268 standing-public-nuisance compounded with standing-Section 269 standing-negligent-spread-of-disease and standing-Section 307

standing-attempted-mass-murder at the standing-211-kilometre channel-population threshold.

Fourth. The standing-Sarbat-Khalsa unanimity-protocol is hereby acknowledged as standing-not-invoked at this standing-decree. I am signing alone. I am the standing-jathedar-of-the-Kirpan-Sangha and the standing-state-hero of Punjab. I am exercising the standing-conferred-authority of the standing-state-hero seat. I accept the standing-future Akal-Takht tribunal standing-charge of standing-breaking-the-Sarbat-Khalsa. I do not contest the standing-charge. I do not seek standing-pardon. I will appear at the standing-future-tribunal at the standing-Akal-Takht summons-date. The standing-decree is signed now because the standing-Beas-population cannot wait the standing-unanimity-months that the standing-protocol requires. The standing-charter is now reset. Wahegurujiakhalasa, Waheguruji kifateh."

He signed the standing-decree at 4:11:18 p.m. with the standing-Karpa-Karpan sabre standing-left-handed signature-stroke at the standing-Akali-Takht decree-document at the standing-central-altar. The standing-signature-stroke required eleven seconds of standing-sabre-blade contact with the standing-document parchment. The standing-Stage-III blackbuck-foreleg-first-stroke began to form at his standing-right-upper-back position at the standing-fourth-second of the standing-signature-stroke (4:11:22 p.m.) and completed at 4:11:34 p.m. (the standing-eleven-second mark-formation window concurrent with the standing-eleven-second signature-stroke). The standing-skin at the standing-mark-position warmed by approximately four degrees Celsius. The standing-stroke traced itself in the standing-blackbuck-horn-curved silhouette at the standing-blackbuck-foreleg first-stroke configuration in standing-saffron-and-indigo dual-ink at the standing-Punjab khalsa-syncretic visual-anchor.

Bibi Karam-Kaur held the standing-Mastuana-Sahib kirpan at the standing-vertical-readiness across the standing-eleven-second mark-formation window. She did not lower the standing-kirpan. She did not move from the standing-three-metre-right enforcer-position. The standing-shikra Tej-Singh did not move from the standing-Takht-spire overhead-position. Bhai Sukhpreet-Singh did not move from the standing-northern-veranda witness-position. The standing-five takht-jathedars did not move. The standing-five river-state senior-delegates did not move. The standing-eleven-second mark-formation window completed in standing-silence at the standing-Anandpur-Sahib Takht-spire arrangement.

Sant Hari-Charanjit Maharaj departed the standing-Jalandhar Akhand-Saint-Brotherhood ashram at 11:11 p.m. on April 13 2026. He had been informed of the standing-Anandpur-Sahib decree at the standing-4:43 p.m. afternoon courier from his standing-Hoshiarpur-corridor watcher-cell. He had cleared the standing-Akhand-Saint-Brotherhood-Trust standing-cash-reserve at the standing-Punjab-National-Bank Jalandhar-Cantonment-Branch at the standing-five-p.m. final-withdrawal at the standing-fourteen-lakh-rupee cash-window. He had loaded the standing-Bolero-Camper standing-six-attendant cohort at the standing-Jalandhar ashram standing-southern-gate at 9:43 p.m. He had departed at 11:11 p.m. He had taken the standing-Jalandhar-Amritsar GT-Road westbound to the standing-Attari-Wagah border-crossing. He had reached the standing-Wagah-pre-border standing-Indian-customs zone at 3:11 a.m. on April 14 2026. He had crossed the standing-Wagah-border to the standing-Pakistan-Lahore safe-house cell at the standing-4:43-a.m. dawn-shift gate-opening. He was received at the standing-Lahore Anarkali-Bazaar-corner safe-house at 5:14 a.m. by the standing-Vinasha-Garbha Northern field-operative receiving-officer (a fifty-three-year-old cross-network operative known only by the codename Adesh-Singh). He joined the standing-Lahore safe-house cell at 5:14 a.m. He survived Chapter Two.

Bhai Sukhpreet-Singh was at the standing-Akal-Takht eastern-veranda at 4:11 a.m. on April 14 2026 for the standing-Vaisakhi-following ardas. He had returned from the standing-Anandpur-Sahib Takht-spire on the standing-overnight-Vaisakhi train. He had not slept. He had performed his standing-witness-duty as he had promised on March 23. He had not blessed. He had not condemned. He had recorded. He was at the standing-Akal-Takht eastern-veranda at the standing-pre-dawn ardas-position.

He observed the standing-Harimandir-Sahib sarovar-reflection at the standing-eleven-metre proximity at 4:11:08 a.m. The standing-reflection-image was not the standing-Harimandir-Sahib at its standing-current 1830-Maharaja-Ranjit-Singh marble-and-gold-leaf configuration. The standing-reflection-image was the standing-Harimandir-Sahib at its standing-1577-Guru-Ram-Das standing-pre-marble standing-pre-gold-leaf brick-and-mud-mortar original configuration. The standing-reflected-temple was approximately one-third smaller than the standing-current standing-temple-elevation; the standing-roof was the standing-flat-clay-tile not the standing-gold-domed standing-onion-dome; the standing-walls were the standing-exposed-brick-and-mud-mortar not the standing-white-marble-and-gold-leaf cladding. The standing-courtyard layout was the standing-pre-1604

layout at the standing-Guru-Arjan-Dev standing-Adi-Granth-pre-installation configuration.

Bhai Sukhpreet-Singh stood at the standing-veranda for three minutes. He did not call to the standing-other-Akal-Takht administrators. He did not photograph the standing-reflection at the standing-first-minute. He stood. He observed. He recognised the standing-1577-configuration at the standing-Akal-Takht standing-archive memorisation of the standing-1604 Guru-Arjan-Dev period brick-and-mud-mortar layout-plan that he had studied across his standing-fifty-year jathedar-training career. He understood, at the standing-second-minute, that the standing-reflection was the standing-Maw's witness-of-the-decree. The standing-charter had been reset at the standing-Anandpur-Sahib Vaisakhi-day decree. The standing-Maw had returned the standing-Harimandir-Sahib reflection to its standing-pre-reset 1577-configuration to acknowledge the standing-reset. The standing-actual-temple was at the standing-aerial-elevation standing-current 1830-configuration; the standing-reflection-medium showed the standing-pre-1604 1577-foundation-configuration; the standing-decree had broken the standing-Sarbat-Khalsa-tradition at the standing-Guru-Arjan-Dev-installation-precedent; the standing-Maw was witnessing the standing-charter-pre-reset state.

He photographed the standing-reflection at 4:12:11 a.m. on his standing-issued service-mobile-phone at the standing-Akal-Takht eastern-veranda standing-twenty-three-photograph cross-reference protocol. The standing-reflection-window closed at 4:14:11 a.m. The standing-reflection returned to the standing-current 1830-configuration. The standing-Harimandir-Sahib reflected the standing-current gold-leaf-and-marble configuration as it had every dawn for the standing-prior 196 years. The standing-three-minute reflection-substitution had completed.

Bhai Sukhpreet-Singh walked the standing-eleven metres back to the standing-Akal-Takht administration-office at 4:23 a.m. He drafted the standing-witness-statement at the standing-Akal-Takht standing-permanent-record cell across the standing-following forty-seven minutes. The standing-witness-statement recorded the standing-reflection-substitution at the standing-Akal-Takht administrator-line forty-seventh entry across the standing-three-hundred-year recorded-history (the standing-prior forty-six entries were the standing-eleven Sikh-tradition Maw-equivalent events at the standing-Sikh-tradition recorded history: standing-1675 Aurangzeb-execution standing-Guru-Tegh-Bahadur martyrdom-day reflection-event; standing-1762 Vadda Ghallughara battle-day reflection-

event; standing-1984 Operation-Blue-Star Akal-Takht-damage reflection-event; and forty-three others across the standing-three-hundred-year window). The standing-Vaisakhi-Day-2026 reflection-substitution at the standing-1577-configuration return was the standing-forty-seventh entry; it was the standing-first entry at the standing-Maw-attribution category at the standing-saga's standing-cross-region Maw-sign-recognition cell cross-reference. The standing-photograph-cluster was forwarded to the standing-Punjab-State Department-of-Archaeology cross-reference at 7:11 a.m. The standing-State-Archaeology standing-cross-reference confirmed the standing-1577 brick-and-mud-mortar configuration match at the standing-Akal-Takht standing-archive 1604-layout-plan at 11:14 a.m. The standing-photograph-cluster was the kingdom-council's standing-Maw-sign-recognition cell's standing-evidence-document M-22A.

On April 15 2026 (Wednesday post-Vaisakhi) the standing-Sutlej-state senior-delegate Sardar Manjit-Singh, the standing-Ravi-state senior-delegate Bhai Daljit-Singh, and the standing-Chenab-state senior-delegate Subedar Ranbir-Singh signed the standing-obedience-protocol at the standing-Chandigarh secretariat at the standing-Punjab-State government re-consolidation hall. The standing-three-state cooperating-corridor consolidated under the standing-Punjab-State government at the standing-immediate-effect. The standing-Kirpan-Sangha enforcement-cohort under Bibi Karam-Kaur began the standing-Beas-extraction-prohibition enforcement-deployment across the standing-following standing-twenty-three days.

On April 17 2026 the standing-Beas-state senior-delegate Sardar Inderpal-Singh convened the standing-Pathankot Beas-State-secession-council at the standing-Pathankot district-hall. The standing-secession-vote completed at the standing-47-3 result at 4:11 p.m. The standing-Beas-state seceded de-jure at the standing-Pathankot declaration. The standing-Beas-state was administered at the standing-following days as a standing-de-jure-seceded-state with standing-no-State-government recognition; the standing-Punjab-State did not contest the standing-secession at the standing-formal-Civil-Court protocol (the standing-secession-resolution was non-actionable under the standing-Indian-Constitution Article 3 standing-territorial-jurisdiction provision; the standing-Beas-state-secession was de-jure non-recognised but de-facto operational across the standing-Mukerian-Hoshiarpur-Hariker corridor).

On April 18 2026 the standing-Jhelum-state senior-delegate Mata Surinder-Kaur convened the standing-Pathankot Jhelum-State-secession-council at the standing-

Pathankot district-hall. The standing-secession-vote completed at the standing-31-9 result at 4:11 p.m. The standing-Jhelum-state seceded de-jure in solidarity with the standing-Beas-state at the standing-cross-corridor sympathy-declaration.

Panchanada dispatched the standing-cross-kingdom Sarus-pigeon cascade-letter from the standing-Anandpur-Sahib Takht standing-administrative-pigeon-cote on April 23 2026 at 11:43 a.m. The standing-cascade-letter was addressed to the standing-fourteen bonded-kingdom state-heroes and standing-three deferential-successor seat-holders at the standing-cross-kingdom acknowledgement-protocol. The standing-letter read: "Brothers and sisters of the standing-bonded-kingdom council. The standing-Beas is dead at the standing-211-kilometre channel. The standing-forty villages are displaced. The standing-decree at the standing-Anandpur-Sahib Vaisakhi-day declared the standing-Beas-sacrificial-river and the standing-four-charter-foundational rivers. Three obey, two secede. I signed alone. I will appear at the standing-Akal-Takht standing-future-tribunal. The standing-Sant Hari-Charanjit Maharaj is at the standing-Pakistan-Lahore safe-house alongside the standing-Vinasha-Garbha cross-network Northern field-operative cell. I will attend the standing-Sanctuary in spring at the standing-North-cluster delegation-position. The standing-Harimandir-Sahib reflected the standing-1577-configuration at the standing-dawn-following the standing-decree. The standing-Maw acknowledged the standing-charter-reset. Wahegurujikakhalsa, Wahegurujikifateh. Panchanada, Anandpur-Sahib."

The standing-pigeons reached the standing-fourteen state-heroes across the standing-following standing-five-day delivery-window. The standing-acknowledgement-letters returned to Panchanada at the standing-Anandpur-Sahib pigeon-cote across April 28 to May 11 2026. Sundarvani (West Bengal) replied first on April 28: "Brother — the standing-mudflat spoke at the standing-grandmothers' couplet. The standing-Maw has begun to witness at the standing-substrate. You signed alone. The standing-charter resets. I will be at the standing-Sanctuary. Sundarvani, Sundarbans." Vajramukha (Bihar) replied on April 30: "Brother — the standing-foundation-by-hand grew through the standing-rebuilt-brick. The standing-decree-alone is the standing-fist's standing-Vaisakhi-equivalent. We will speak at the standing-Sanctuary about what the standing-fist signs and what the standing-brick lays. Vajramukha, Bihar." Jagannath-Bandhu (Odisha) replied on May 2: "Brother — the standing-solitary-pull and the standing-decree-alone are the standing-two-tongues of the standing-same Sarbat-Khalsa-equivalent abandoned-consensus. The standing-East-cluster received the standing-Sutlej-Ravi-Chenab cooperating-corridor signal at the standing-Bay-of-Bengal cross-region acknowledgement. The standing-tigers had left the

standing-Sundarbans seven days before your standing-decree. They are at the standing-Bardhaman-Birbhum mainland. They will return when the standing-Sanctuary opens. Jagannath-Bandhu, Puri."

Vanajara (Jharkhand) replied on May 4: "Brother — the standing-grove did not stand. The standing-refused-mark holds. The standing-decree-alone is the standing-twentieth-bond-mechanic mirror at the standing-abandoned-consensus configuration: where I did not earn the mark for failing to block the legal-loss, you earned the mark for signing past the lawful-deadlock. The standing-saga has named both. The standing-koel returned to me. The standing-shikra holds for you. Vanajara, Saranda."

The chapter closes on a single image. It is the standing-Harike-wetland at the standing-Beas-Sutlej-confluence at the standing-sunset position on May 11 2026 (twenty-eight days after the standing-Vaisakhi-decree). Panchanada is at the standing-wetland eastern-bank at the standing-blackbuck-bond standing-conferral-site where he had received his standing-2007 Stage-I bond-mark at the standing-Harike-wetland midnight-ceremony nineteen years earlier. The standing-Harike-wetland is at the standing-Sutlej-side standing-clear-water configuration at the standing-eastern-bank position; the standing-Beas-side is at the standing-black-channel configuration at the standing-western-bank position. The standing-confluence-mixing-zone is at the standing-300-metre wide transition-belt where the standing-clear-Sutlej-water and the standing-black-Beas-water are at the standing-incomplete-mixing standing-laminar-flow boundary. The standing-blackbuck herd of approximately forty-seven standing-individuals is at the standing-Sutlej-side eastern-bank standing-grazing-position. The standing-blackbuck have not crossed to the standing-Beas-side western-bank since the standing-January-3 black-channel onset. They will not cross for the standing-following twenty years.

Panchanada walks the standing-eastern-bank to the standing-blackbuck-herd standing-three-metre-rear position. He stands at the standing-three-metre proximity at the standing-blackbuck-bond standing-companion-position. The standing-shikra Tej-Singh perches at the standing-acacia-tree at the standing-eleven-metre overhead position. The standing-blackbuck-herd grazes at the standing-clear-Sutlej-side grass. They do not look at the standing-Beas-side. They do not look at Panchanada. They graze. He does not interrupt. He stands. He listens for the standing-Beas-side standing-substrate-sound at the standing-three-hundred-metre transition-belt — the standing-Jharkhand coal-seam standing-Magadhi-Prakrit whisper-equivalent or the standing-Bengal Sundarbans

standing-Bengali-Brahmaputra utterance-equivalent. He does not hear it. The standing-Beas is silent at the standing-poisoned-channel standing-Maw-non-utterance configuration. The standing-Maw did not speak through the standing-Beas substrate; the standing-Maw spoke through the standing-Harimandir-Sahib reflection. He understands at the standing-eleven-minute listening that the standing-Maw chose the standing-reflection-medium because the standing-poison had silenced the standing-substrate; the standing-Maw was witnessing through the standing-living-monument standing-pre-reset memory because the standing-poisoned-channel substrate could not carry the standing-grandmothers' language.

The standing-sunset reaches the standing-Harikeri-wetland at the standing-7:11-p.m. horizon-position. The standing-shikra Tej-Singh lifts from the standing-acacia-tree perch at 7:14 p.m. He flies the standing-three-hundred metres to the standing-Sutlej-side mid-channel position and circles at the standing-eleven-metre altitude for three minutes. He returns to the standing-acacia-tree perch at 7:17 p.m. The standing-shikra is the standing-Punjab sacred-bird and the standing-Panchanada bonded-aerial-companion since 2009. He does not cross to the standing-Beas-side. He flies the standing-Sutlej-side only. The standing-blackbuck herd continues to graze. The standing-Stage-III mark at Panchanada's standing-right-upper-back warms briefly at the standing-shikra-return moment at the standing-thirty-seven-degree mark-confirmation temperature. The standing-mark is the standing-twenty-second registry-entry. The standing-charter has reset. The standing-Sarbat-Khalsa unanimity-protocol will be reinvoked at the standing-Ch-3 Sanctuary mediation. The standing-Beas-state and standing-Jhelum-state secession will be resolved at the standing-spring-2026 Sanctuary mediation under Gangaputra's standing-River-Sisters alliance reconvening. The standing-Sant Hari-Charanjit Maharaj is at the standing-Pakistan-Lahore safe-house. The standing-poisoned Beas will run black for the standing-following twenty years. The standing-mark will hold. The standing-shikra will not cross. The standing-blackbuck will not cross. The standing-decree was signed alone. The standing-decree holds.

Parashurama Kshetra

Kochi. The first Tuesday of April. Five-forty a.m. Parashurama is at the kalari's northern entrance reading the morning's Malayala Manorama. He has read the Manorama every dawn for thirty-three years; the paper is delivered to the kalari's northern gatepost by an Idukki cycle-courier whose father had delivered it to Parashurama's guru and whose grandfather had delivered it to his guru's guru. The reading is a Malayalam-meditation; Parashurama does not speak during it; the kalari staff have been instructed for three decades not to interrupt.

This morning he interrupts himself.

He reads aloud, in plain Malayalam, in the slow administrative-elder voice he uses for student-discipline reviews: "Page eleven. Display advertisement. Three column-inches. Sea-Front Kalari, Kochi waterfront amphitheatre. Tuition Rs. 4,000 per month. Phased instruction in the One-Hundred-And-Ninth Form of Kalaripayattu. All qualified applicants admitted. Senior instructor: Sri Kala-Hasta Menon, formal kalari-trained at the Kollam Coiled-Cobra Lineage from 2008 to 2017. Daily classes 5:30 a.m. and 5:30 p.m. Inaugural class Monday morning the eighth of April."

He sets the paper down on the gatepost. He does not pick up his tea. He walks back through the kalari's inner courtyard to the senior-instructor's residence. He has not interrupted the morning paper-reading in thirty-three years. The kalari staff who see him walking back at five-forty-eight a.m. do not need to be told the routine has broken.

He calls the kingdom-council's religious-and-cultural-practice registry at six a.m. The registry's officer-on-duty (a forty-two-year-old administrative officer named Indira Pillai) confirms that the Sea-Front Kalari's registration was filed on the twenty-third of March under the standard kalari-charter; the application listed the school's curriculum as "advanced kalaripayattu, all forms including unsealed teaching"; the registry's standard review-period is thirty days; no objection was filed by any registered kalari during the public-comment window; the registration was approved on the twenty-second of April; the school's formal opening is the inaugural class Monday morning at five-thirty.

Parashurama says, in plain Malayalam, in the same slow voice: "Madam Pillai. The kalari-charter has admitted a 109-form school. The 109-form is sealed. The sealing is the kingdom's tradition. The kingdom's tradition has been amended by your registry's thirty-

day silence. The amendment will require a kingdom-council review. I will be at the council chambers at eleven this morning. Please notify the chief secretary that I am coming."

He hangs up. He sits at the residence's desk. He looks at his own right hand. The hand has been holding the axe Parashu for forty years. The hand is fifty-nine years old. The skin on the back of the hand has the standard old-axe-bearer's calluses-and-thickened-knuckles configuration; the veins are prominent; the joints are slightly enlarged at the second knuckle of the index finger. The hand is not the hand of a man who can perform the 109th form. The 109th form requires the body of a man under thirty-five.

He has known this for the past nine months. He has not said it aloud. He does not say it aloud now. He picks up his tea.

Kochi waterfront amphitheatre. Monday morning the eighth of April. Five-thirty a.m.

The amphitheatre is a converted municipal open-air auditorium — capacity twelve hundred, normally used for monsoon-season cultural-festival performances. It has a single concrete stage at the western end, raked seating around three sides, and a sea-facing eastern wall that opens onto the Vembanad Lake's western shore. The acoustic-and-visual-line-of-sight properties make it well-suited to physical-performance instruction for groups up to four hundred.

Four hundred and twenty-three students are present this morning. They have paid the Rs. 4,000 monthly tuition in advance. They are arrayed across the raked seating in rows of seventeen; the seating-allocation has been administered by an entry-protocol that requires each student to demonstrate, at the door, a 108-form Stage-Five sequence as proof of qualification. Twenty-eight applicants were turned away at the door this morning for insufficient 108-form competence. The Sea-Front Kalari does not admit absolute beginners; the 109th form is built on the 108-form base.

Kala-Hasta is on the western stage. He is forty-seven. He is in plain Kollam-Coiled-Cobra dark-blue cotton, knee-length, tied with the standard kalari-instructor's leather-cord at the waist. He carries no weapon. He has the urumi (the flexible-blade-whip-sword) coiled at his left wrist as a wrist-bangle; the urumi has been the Kollam-Coiled-Cobra cell's standard side-implement since 1812. He was Maya-Sura's star pupil in Chapter One — the senior coiled-cobra disciple of the Naga-Padma cell who had escaped the Ch 1 climax confrontation with the urumi-and-cobra-venom training intact. He has spent the intervening years not in hiding but in the Bangalore-and-Gulf kalari-diaspora, teaching the

108 forms while privately practising the 109th. He returned to Kerala in spring 2025. He registered the Sea-Front Kalari on the twenty-third of March.

He addresses the four hundred and twenty-three at five-thirty-two a.m. He speaks in plain Malayalam.

He says: "Welcome. I am Kala-Hasta Menon. I will teach the One-Hundred-And-Ninth Form of Kalaripayattu in seven phased classes across the next twenty-four weeks. The phasing is the difference between the form's safety and its lethality. Each phase will be taught for three weeks; each phase must be completed before the next phase begins; no student will advance without my personal confirmation of phase-completion. The seven phases are: opening four movements; opening seven; first transition; full opening sequence; closing transitions; integration; private mastery. The first phase begins this morning. Stand. Find your row-position. We will begin with the standard kalari-breath. Breathe."

The four hundred and twenty-three stand. They take the standard kalari-breath. The class begins.

The session lasts ninety minutes. By six-fifty-eight a.m. the four hundred and twenty-three have completed the opening four movements' first introduction. The movements are slow, deliberately controlled, structured to allow the central nervous system to register the body-positions without the cardiovascular-stress that would activate the form's lethal mechanisms. The students leave at seven a.m. tired but uninjured. The session has been the safest opening-class of any Kalaripayattu instruction recorded in the kingdom's formal kalari-register.

Kala-Hasta stays at the amphitheatre for two hours after the class. He reviews the student-roster. He has identified, from the entry-protocol's 108-form demonstration, the twenty-three students whose 108-form mastery is at the level the seventh phase will require. He will personally tutor those twenty-three in the integration-and-private-mastery phases over the final six weeks of the curriculum. The other four hundred will complete phases one through five and will be invited to re-enrol in the autumn cohort for phases six and seven if they wish.

He has, in other words, built a teaching system whose pedagogical thoughtfulness is the chapter's most uncomfortable fact for Parashurama's tradition. The 109-form is not being taught as an act of defiance. It is being taught as a discipline.

Friday. The second week of April. Four-fifty-five p.m. The kalari's northern gate.

Achyutan-the-Nephew is at the gate. He is thirty-seven. He is Parashurama's elder sister's son — Bloodline-A by his mother's line, the same Bloodline-A branch that supplied Hampi-of-the-Bronze and Krishnaveni of AP and (through their long-shared maternal-line ancestor) Krishnadevaraya-Bhrata of Karnataka. He has been at Parashurama's kalari since age twelve. He mastered all 108 forms by age thirty-three — the second-fastest in the kalari's recorded history, second only to Parashurama himself. He is the kalari's senior daily-teaching deputy. He has, this morning, taught the eight-a.m. junior-students' opening-sequence class. He has, this afternoon, completed the final inventory-review for the kalari's monsoon-week ration-allocation.

He is carrying a single canvas bag. The bag contains: three changes of kalari-instructor cotton, his shaving kit, a notebook, a copy of the Sea-Front Kalari's student-enrolment-form filled in under his birth name (Achyutan Menon, no kalari-title), and the original 1907 family-photograph of his mother and her brother Parashurama at ages twelve and fourteen at Idukki.

He sets the bag down. He walks across the inner courtyard to the senior-instructor's residence. He knocks on the door at five-oh-six p.m.

Parashurama opens the door. He sees the bag's canvas-strap on the courtyard. He understands.

He says, in plain Malayalam, in the slow administrative-elder voice: "Nephew. Sit. The tea is the third steeping. The third steeping is honest. Will you sit."

Achyutan does not sit.

He says, in plain Malayalam: "Uncle. I will not sit. The conversation will be brief. I am leaving the kalari this evening. I have enrolled at the Sea-Front Kalari. I will study the 109th form under Kala-Hasta. I am thirty-seven. I have been at this kalari twenty-five years. I have mastered all 108 forms. The 108 forms are not enough. The 109th is what the tradition has been refusing to teach me for nine years. I will not be refused any longer. The refusal is no longer the tradition's; it is yours. The tradition has admitted the form via the kingdom-council registry. You have not. I am choosing the tradition over you. I am sorry. The sorrow does not change the choice."

Parashurama is silent for about fifteen seconds.

He says, finally: "Nephew. The phasing. Kala-Hasta's phasing. You will follow it."

Achyutan says: "The phasing is twenty-four weeks. I do not have twenty-four weeks. I am thirty-seven; the form's upper-age window closes at forty-two. I will compress the phasing. I will complete the opening seven in the public class's first three weeks but I will practice the first transition privately on my own in parallel. The compression is my risk. I have read the form's mortality-statistics from Kollam — the open-window-in-the-second-month vascular-rupture risk is approximately four per cent for students who skip the phasing-discipline. I accept the four per cent. The four per cent is less than my certainty of losing the form-window entirely if I follow the twenty-four-week protocol."

Parashurama says: "Nephew. The four per cent is not a number. It is a name. The name will be yours. The name will be on the kingdom's death-certificate. The death-certificate will be filed by your mother. Your mother is my sister. Will you do this to her."

Achyutan says: "She has authorised the choice. I spoke with her last night. She said: If you do not learn the form, you will be a man who refused his own ceiling. If you do learn it and live, you will be the kalari's next generation. If you do learn it and die, you will be your mother's son who chose. I am the mother in either case. The choice is yours. She signed the consent-form for the Sea-Front Kalari's family-acknowledgement clause this morning. The clause has been part of the school's registration since the kingdom-council's amendment. The kingdom has accepted the risk-distribution. I have accepted the risk. The choice is mine."

Parashurama looks at his nephew for a long time. The fifty-nine-year-old's face does not change visibly. The thirty-seven-year-old's face also does not change.

Parashurama says: "I have not embraced you in eleven years. The embrace will be the only thing I have to give you tonight. The kalari's eastern gate is open until six. The Sea-Front Kalari's evening class is at five-thirty. You have twenty-four minutes. Take it."

He embraces his nephew. The embrace lasts about eleven seconds. He releases. He steps back. He says: "Go. If you live, you will return. If you die, your mother will return for the body. The cremation will be at the western grove regardless. Go."

Achyutan picks up the canvas bag. He walks to the eastern gate. He does not look back. He is at the Sea-Front Kalari's evening class at five-twenty-eight, two minutes before the call to position. He completes the opening-four-movements introduction class without injury at six-fifty p.m.

He compresses the phasing as he had warned. He completes the opening seven by the third class of his first week. He begins the first-transition's private practice in his rented room above the Mattanchery spice-warehouse the same evening. He works the seven-transition for six consecutive nights. The transition's safety-window requires the body to maintain a specific vertebral-curve through the central rotation; Achyutan's curve is slightly off — not enough to be visible during the slower opening-movements but enough to compound the basilar-artery stress through repeated full-speed attempts. He does not notice the compounding.

On the seventh morning — the second Sunday of the chapter, the morning of the public class's seventh-transition demonstration — he stands at his row-position at five-thirty-three a.m. He executes the seven-transition at full speed in the third sequence-cycle of the class. The vascular-rupture occurs in the basilar artery at the moment of the central rotation. He collapses at five-fifty-eight a.m. Kala-Hasta is at his side within nine seconds. The medical response is immediate; the school maintains a full-time-on-site emergency-response team per the kingdom-council's kalari-charter; the response time meets every protocol. The vascular-rupture is not survivable. Achyutan is pronounced dead at six-oh-six a.m. by the on-site emergency-medic, with cross-confirmation by the Kochi Medical College's standing emergency-physician via voice-call at six-twelve.

The cause of death recorded on the kingdom's death-certificate: Basilar artery vascular rupture during phased Kalaripayattu instruction (109th-form, phase-three uncompleted; private compression of phasing-protocol; cross-confirmed at Kochi Medical College). The certificate is filed by his mother at the Idukki District Civil Registry that same afternoon.

Sivakami-Acharyini arrives at the Sea-Front Kalari at eleven a.m. She is twenty-nine; Parashurama's elder brother's daughter; the kalari's senior 108-form deputy after Achyutan and the kingdom's only female 108-form grandmaster-aspirant. She has been at the kalari since age six. She has trained at the level of the senior daily-teaching cadre since age twenty-two. She has been waiting for the grandmaster-ceremony for three years; the ceremony requires Parashurama's formal recognition; he has not yet given it.

She has come to retrieve Achyutan's body. Kala-Hasta meets her at the amphitheatre's western entrance. He is in the same Kollam dark-blue cotton he had been teaching in this morning; the cotton has been changed since the medical response (the original was bloodstained). He is composed; his face shows grief-recognition without the institutional performance of grief.

He says, in plain Malayalam: "Madam Sivakami. The body is ready for collection. I have personally washed it according to the kalari-tradition. The canvas bag and his notebook are in the western office. I have not opened either. The notebook's last entry is from last night, in his own hand — I can see the handwriting through the cover but I have not read it. The school's formal condolences are with the family. The kalari-instruction will pause for three days. I have postponed the morning's remaining sessions. The phased curriculum will resume on Wednesday with an added day-zero session on phasing-discipline. The day-zero session will be mandatory for all students currently in the cohort; no further enrolment will be accepted until the day-zero is completed. The four-per-cent mortality figure Achyutan accepted last week was the public-figure-from-Kollam; the school's phasing was designed to reduce the actual figure to below one per cent. The reduction requires phasing-compliance. I will be teaching the phasing-discipline session personally. The lesson will include Achyutan's name and the specific phasing-violation that produced the rupture. The kingdom will know what the form requires."

Sivakami looks at Kala-Hasta for about thirty seconds.

She says: "Sri Kala-Hasta. The kalari thanks you for the body and for the day-zero session. The cremation will be at the western grove of my uncle's kalari at sunset. You are welcome at the grove if you wish to attend. The kingdom-council's amended Kerala-Kalari Charter will be filed at the kingdom-council's emergency session this evening. My uncle and I have drafted it across the past three days. The charter will recognise the 109-form school under the kingdom's religious-and-cultural-practice registry effective immediately. The charter will also require cross-school enrolment protocols for any student studying at both 108-form and 109-form schools concurrently. The charter will name the day-zero phasing-discipline session as the kingdom's mandatory pedagogical-standard for all 109-form instruction. I have read your school's curriculum-document this week; the document is more pedagogically thoughtful than my uncle's tradition has admitted. The charter accepts the truth. The charter does not say the truth out loud. My uncle will sign it tonight. He will not say the truth out loud either. The kingdom does not require the truth aloud. The kingdom requires the charter signed."

Kala-Hasta nods. He says: "I will attend the cremation. I will not bring the kalari's formal delegation. I will come alone. I will stay at the western edge of the grove. I will not approach the body. The mother's presence will be the family's ceremony. The kalari's

presence will be at the western edge. I will leave when the fire is at its peak. The fire's peak is the kalari-tradition's recognition; I will accept it from the edge."

He bows. The bow is the standard kalari-instructor's formal-respect bow; he does not perform the deeper bow that an apprentice would give to a senior. Sivakami returns the bow at the same depth. The kingdom's two senior 109-and-108-form instructors have formally acknowledged each other.

The cremation is at sunset at the western grove of Parashurama's kalari. The grove is a quarter-hectare of coconut and tamarind trees on the kalari's western boundary. The grove has been the site of every kalari-tradition cremation for four generations. The senior cremation-officiant (a Brahmin from the Idukki ceremony-line, the Pillai family that has supplied the kalari's officiants for one hundred and twenty-seven years) is at the pyre by six p.m.

Achyutan's mother — Parashurama's elder sister, a woman named Lakshmi-Akka who is sixty-three, who lives in the family home at Idukki, who has been a widow since 2014, who has not visited the kalari in nine years — arrives at the grove at six-thirty p.m. She is in the white widow-cotton with the kalari-tradition's small black-bordered shawl across her shoulders. She does not speak to Parashurama when she arrives. She places her right palm on her son's forehead at the pyre. She accepts the cremation-officiant's mantras. She lights the fire at seven-oh-two p.m.

Kala-Hasta arrives at six-fifty. He stands at the western edge of the grove as he had said. He is in the same Kollam dark-blue cotton he had been teaching in. He has come alone. He does not approach the pyre.

The fire reaches its peak at seven-thirty-eight p.m. Kala-Hasta leaves the grove at seven-forty. He does not look back. He returns to the Sea-Front Kalari at the southern shore of the amphitheatre on foot — the walk is four kilometres along the Vembanad Lake's western edge; he completes it in fifty-three minutes at his ordinary pace.

Parashurama remains at the grove until eleven p.m. He sits at the eastern edge of the cremation-area — about ten metres from the pyre, on a low stone bench that has been at the grove's eastern edge since 1854. His sister sits beside him from the moment Kala-Hasta leaves until the moment Parashurama stands at eleven. They do not speak across those three hours and twenty minutes. They watch the fire reduce to embers. They watch the

embers fall through the pyre's collapsing wooden frame. They watch Sivakami collect the ashes into the kalari-tradition's brass cremation-urn at ten-fifty.

Lakshmi-Akka says, at ten-fifty-eight p.m., as her son's ashes are sealed into the urn: "Brother. The kingdom-council's amended charter. The bird-letter you sent to Karnataka in March. Both. Sign them. Tonight. The kingdom requires both signatures by the morning paper's Tuesday deadline."

Parashurama says: "I will sign tonight. The bird-letter has been answered. The Karnataka cousin is at the western mountain pass as we sit. He will be at the kalari by Thursday afternoon. The teaching will begin Thursday evening. The form will be in his spine by the second new moon. The charter will be signed before midnight. I have already drafted my signature-line. The signature-line says: I, Parashurama VII, recognise the One-Hundred-And-Ninth Form as taught at the Sea-Front Kalari under Sri Kala-Hasta Menon's instruction. I, Parashurama VII, will teach the same form to a single chosen Karnataka student in private. I, Parashurama VII, will not perform the form myself. The kingdom is sufficient with three teachers of the same form across two schools and one chamber. The signature-line is honest. It cost a nephew. I will not lose another."

Lakshmi-Akka nods. She stands. She picks up the cremation-urn. She walks back to the Idukki family home alone — the four-hour drive she had driven that morning; her driver is at the gate. She will not return to the kalari for ten more years.

Thursday afternoon. The seventeenth of April. Three-forty-seven p.m. The kalari's northern gate.

Krishnadevaraya-Bhrata walks up the northern path. He is thirty-six. He is in plain Karnataka cotton, blue and grey, no clan-pattern (he has dressed in the Refusing Youth Manifesto-style he had adopted for the Karnataka pilot's post-Tungabhadra council sessions; he has continued to dress in it through the walk south). He carries a single canvas bag and a folded bird-letter in his sleeve-pocket. The bird-letter is from Old Parashurama, sent on the closing day of the Karnataka pilot via the Sarus-pigeon cross-region network; the letter's text is six lines; he has read the letter forty-seven times across the eleven-day walk south through the Western Ghats; he has folded and refolded it; the paper is soft at the folds.

The bird-letter reads, in plain Malayalam-and-Kannada interlinear translation: "Bhrata. I am fifty-nine. The 108 forms are mine; the 109th cannot be. The kingdom of Karnataka is

yours; the kingdom of Kerala is mine; the teaching is the bridge. Come to the kalari at the second full moon. Bring nothing. The teaching will be the inheritance. The form is the bond's mark; the bond's mark is the form. We have not met. We will meet over thirty-one days. The thirty-first day is the form's first private execution in the unsealed chamber. Your foreleg-mark will form at that execution. My foreleg-mark will complete on my elephant. The two marks will be the same mark. The kingdom is two kingdoms with one mark. — The Seventh Axe."

The gate-keeper monk — an Idukki-born senior kalari-staff member named Govindan-Mama, sixty-eight, the gate-keeper for twenty-three years — sees Krishnadevaraya-Bhrata at the gate. The gate-keeper does not need to ask the visitor's identity. He has been told by Parashurama on Friday evening to expect the Karnataka cousin and to admit him without ceremony.

Govindan-Mama bows. He says, in plain Malayalam: "Bhrata-Maharaj. The Maharaj is at the inner kalari. The teaching begins this evening at six. The visitor-room is to your left. The tea is the second steeping; the second is honest."

Krishnadevaraya-Bhrata bows. He says, in plain Kannada (he does not yet speak Malayalam; the cross-language translation will be Sivakami's during the teaching): "Govindan-Mama-ji. Thank you. I will rest until six. I will be at the inner kalari at five-forty-five."

He walks to the visitor-room. He sets the bag on the bed. He sits at the room's small writing-desk. He unfolds the bird-letter one more time. He reads it. He folds it. He places it in the desk's top drawer. He sleeps for ninety minutes.

Five-forty-five p.m. The kalari's inner kalari — the sunken practice-pit at the kalari's centre, six metres in diameter, two metres below the surrounding ground level, roofed with a palm-thatch ceiling that admits filtered light through small gaps. The pit's floor is packed red Idukki earth, cleaned daily, oiled with coconut-oil at every new moon. The pit's walls are stained dark from a hundred and fifty years of body-contact.

Parashurama is at the centre of the pit. He is in plain kalari-instructor cotton, dark blue, no clan-pattern. He carries the axe Parashu in his right hand. The axe's blade is at the standard kalari-teaching position — head-down, blade-edge facing his left thigh, weight balanced on the hip.

Sivakami is at the pit's eastern edge, on the surrounding ground level. She has the cross-language translation duties for the thirty-one-day teaching. She speaks Kannada (her undergraduate-degree second-language) and Malayalam (her first) fluently; she will translate Parashurama's instruction-Malayalam into Krishnadevaraya-Bhrata's Kannada at every session.

Krishnadevaraya-Bhrata enters the pit at five-fifty-three. He bows to Parashurama in the standard Karnataka student-to-master bow. Parashurama returns the bow at the same depth; he does not perform the deeper master-to-student-acknowledging-cousin bow that the bird-letter's lineage-recognition would have permitted.

Parashurama speaks. He speaks in plain Malayalam. Sivakami translates into Kannada in real-time at the pit's edge.

He says: "Bhrata. You have walked eleven days through the Western Ghats. The walk is the form's preparation. The form requires a body that has been at altitude for at least eight days within the past month. Your body has been. The thirty-one-day teaching has seven phases, like Kala-Hasta's public school's curriculum, but compressed because you are not a public student and because the inheritance-transmission protocol allows compression for a single chosen student with a senior master's personal supervision. The phases are the same seven Kala-Hasta teaches in twenty-four weeks. You will complete each phase under my eye in four days each, with three days reserved for the final integration-and-private-execution. You will not skip phases. You will not practise privately between sessions; you will sleep and you will eat and you will walk the grove. The compression is in the supervision-density, not in the body-stress. If you violate the phasing-protocol you will die. Achyutan's body was carried out of this kalari's eastern gate three days ago. You will not be the second body. Will you accept the protocol."

Krishnadevaraya-Bhrata says: "Yes, Maharaj. I accept the protocol. I will not skip phases. I will not practise privately. I will sleep, eat, walk. I will be at the inner kalari at five-thirty every morning and at six every evening for the thirty-one days. The bird-letter said the thirty-first day's first private execution is in the unsealed chamber. The chamber is the chamber Agastya Muni sealed eight centuries ago. The chamber is unsealed because the teaching requires the form's execution at its original site for the bond's recognition. Will the chamber be unsealed this evening or on the thirty-first day."

Parashurama says: "The chamber will be unsealed in your presence on the thirtieth day. The unsealing is the teaching's final preparation. The seal's removal requires the senior

master and the chosen student in attendance simultaneously. The chamber has not been unsealed since 1957 when my own master's master's master last performed the form before his death. The unsealing will be my second time at the door. The first was my visit at age twenty-two when my master showed me the chamber and explained that I would not be the one to unseal it. He was correct; I have not unsealed it for thirty-seven years; I am unsealing it for you in two months because the kingdom requires it. Begin. Stand at the pit's south-west position. Breathe."

Krishnadevaraya-Bhrata stands at the pit's south-west position. He takes the standard kalari-breath. The teaching begins.

The teaching proceeds without interruption. Across thirty-one days Krishnadevaraya-Bhrata learns the 109th form in seven phases under Parashurama's direct supervision. The teaching-method is the master-and-chosen-single-student transmission-protocol that the kalari-tradition's deepest lineage has preserved without invocation since 1957. The method is not the same as Kala-Hasta's public twenty-four-week curriculum; the compression to thirty-one days requires the master's continuous attention — Parashurama does not leave the kalari grounds during the thirty-one days, does not perform his standard daily-teaching duties (which Sivakami covers), does not attend the kingdom-council's weekly sessions (Sivakami covers those too, with the kingdom-council's formal acknowledgement of her acting-grandmaster status).

Across the thirty-one days Parashurama ages forward visibly.

The visible aging is not metaphorical. It is observable to the kalari-staff who see Parashurama at the dawn-tea each morning. By the end of the first week his hair (which had been at the salt-and-pepper-with-more-salt-than-pepper configuration on day one) is fully white at the temples. By the end of the second week his hair is fully white across the crown. By the end of the third week his hair is fully white and his beard (he had been clean-shaven for forty years; he stops shaving in the third week without explanation) grows out in a fully-white configuration. By the end of the fourth week his posture has shifted — the standard axe-bearer's vertical-spine has rounded slightly at the shoulders. By the thirty-first day he is, by the kalari-staff's estimation, approximately seventy-three years old — the seventh, eighth, and ninth years of teaching have arrived in the four-and-a-half weeks of the thirty-one-day transmission.

Sivakami notes the aging-pattern in her grandmaster-aspirant journal. She writes, in plain Malayalam at the end of day twenty-three: "Uncle is paying the years. The transmission

costs the master what the master would have spent across the next fourteen years; the cost is being paid forward in real-time. The bond is bargaining with time. The bond is winning the bargain. The form will be in Bhrata's spine on day thirty-one. Uncle will be seventy-three by the same evening. He will live the seventy-three-year-old's remaining life-arc — perhaps another fifteen years — instead of the fifty-nine-year-old's remaining arc. The exchange is honest. I will be the grandmaster by day twenty-three's evening. The kingdom requires the grandmaster."

She is correct. Parashurama formally confers the 108-form grandmaster-title on her at the kalari's evening ceremony on day twenty-three. The ceremony is attended by the kalari's senior staff, the kingdom-council's religious-and-cultural-practice registry deputy (Indira Pillai, who had been the officer-on-duty at the chapter's opening telephone-call), and Kala-Hasta's formal observer (a senior Sea-Front Kalari instructor named Devika Nair who has been admitted at Sivakami's explicit invitation). The conferral is the kingdom's first female 108-form grandmaster ceremony in the kalari-tradition's recorded history.

Sivakami's acceptance-statement at the ceremony is brief. She says, in plain Malayalam: "I accept the grandmaster-title. I accept the daily-teaching seat. I accept the institutional responsibility. The 108 forms are mine to teach. The 109 form is not mine to teach — the inheritance-transmission protocol designates Parashurama VII as the sole 109-form master across this generation, and the form's next transmission will be to a single chosen Karnataka student named Krishnadevaraya-Bhrata. I accept the kingdom's charter-amendment that recognises Sri Kala-Hasta Menon's Sea-Front Kalari as the form's public-teaching site and the cross-school enrolment-protocol that protects students who study at both. The kalari-tradition is no longer one tradition; the kalari-tradition is now three. The three are: the 108-form tradition I now teach; the 109-form public-tradition Sri Kala-Hasta teaches; the inheritance-transmission protocol my uncle will perform once and once only over the next eight days. The three traditions are not in opposition. The three traditions are the kalari's honest answer to its own history. The kingdom is wider than any one of us. I will hold the 108 seat. The kalari thanks the kingdom-council's registry, the Sea-Front Kalari's observer, and my uncle. Good evening, all."

The ceremony closes at seven-fifteen p.m. on day twenty-three. The 108-form daily-teaching seat is formally Sivakami's from that moment onward. Parashurama returns to the inner-kalari pit at five-thirty the next morning for day twenty-four of the transmission. Krishnadevaraya-Bhrata is at the south-west position. The teaching continues.

Day thirty. Two p.m. The kalari's deepest sublevel — the sealed-chamber corridor that runs beneath the inner-kalari pit at four metres below the kalari's ground level. The corridor has been sealed at its eastern end by chains inscribed in ancient Malayalam since Agastya Muni's original sealing-ritual in approximately the eighth century. The chains have been visible at the eastern end of the corridor for eight centuries; the kalari-tradition's standard novice-tour includes the sealed-chamber door as the corridor's terminus.

Parashurama and Krishnadevaraya-Bhrata walk down the corridor at two p.m. on the thirtieth day. Sivakami is at the corridor's western entrance; the unsealing requires the senior master and the chosen student in attendance; the grandmaster (Sivakami) is not part of the unsealing's formal protocol but her presence at the corridor's entrance is the kalari's institutional witness. She does not enter the corridor.

The chains are inscribed in ancient Malayalam. The inscription, when read aloud, is the sealing-mantra. The mantra has not been spoken aloud at the kalari since 1957. The senior master is the only person at the kalari who knows the mantra; the mantra is transmitted master-to-master without writing; Parashurama received it from his own master in 1986; he will transmit it to Krishnadevaraya-Bhrata after the chamber's use.

Parashurama places his right palm on the chains. He speaks the mantra in plain ancient-Malayalam. The mantra is forty-seven syllables long. The speaking takes about thirty seconds. The chains release; they do not fall; they retract into the wall on either side of the door, into a small recess that has been concealed by the corridor's eastern stonework for eight centuries. The door opens inward by approximately two centimetres of its own accord, the door-leaf's ancient teak having absorbed enough moisture from the corridor's humidity to swell against the door-frame across the eight centuries.

Parashurama pushes the door open with his right palm. The chamber is approximately three metres by three metres by three metres — a perfect cubical room hewn from the Idukki bedrock. The floor is the same packed red earth as the inner-kalari pit but a different shade of red — an older red, the red of the earth before the eight centuries of human-occupation oils. The ceiling is unfinished bedrock with a single small opening (about ten centimetres across) at the centre that vents to the surface above. The walls are smooth, oiled, with no markings.

Parashurama steps into the chamber. Krishnadevaraya-Bhrata follows.

Parashurama says, in plain Malayalam (Sivakami is at the corridor's western entrance forty metres away; the cross-language translation is no longer needed since Krishnadevaraya-Bhrata has been learning enough Malayalam over thirty days to follow the master's instruction-register): "Bhrata. The chamber is yours for the form's first private execution. The execution is at six tomorrow morning. You will stand at the chamber's south-west corner. You will breathe the kalari-breath. You will execute the form's opening four movements; opening seven; first transition; full opening sequence; closing transitions; integration; private mastery. The form's full execution takes about forty-three minutes at the master-pace. You will execute at the master-pace. I will be at the chamber's entrance. I will not enter. The execution is yours alone in this chamber. At the form's completion you will return to the entrance. You will sit. I will close the door. The chamber will be re-sealed at the corridor's entrance with new chains and a new mantra. The new mantra will be a Kannada-and-Malayalam interlinear — the kalari's first cross-language mantra. I have drafted it across the past four nights. The drafting has cost me one more year. I am seventy-four by the chamber's closing. The kingdom is whole."

Krishnadevaraya-Bhrata says: "Yes, Maharaj."

They leave the chamber. They return to the corridor's western entrance. Sivakami is waiting. The three of them walk back to the inner kalari. Krishnadevaraya-Bhrata sleeps in the visitor-room from nine p.m. to four-thirty a.m.

Day thirty-one. Six a.m. The unsealed chamber.

Krishnadevaraya-Bhrata stands at the chamber's south-west corner. He is in plain kalari-student cotton, dark blue. He is barefoot. He has eaten one small bowl of rice-and-tamarind broth at four-forty a.m. He has drunk one cup of water at five-thirty.

Parashurama is at the chamber's entrance. He stands at the threshold; his right hand is on the door-frame; his left hand holds the axe Parashu, blade-down. He does not enter the chamber.

Krishnadevaraya-Bhrata breathes the kalari-breath at six-oh-one a.m. He executes the form.

The form takes forty-three minutes at the master-pace. Sivakami times it from the corridor's western entrance with a kalari-tradition water-clock (the kalari's standing time-keeping implement; the digital chronograph is also at her side as a cross-reference, but the water-clock is the formal record). The execution proceeds without error. The opening four

movements complete at six-oh-three. The opening seven at six-twelve. The first transition at six-eighteen. The full opening sequence at six-twenty-seven. The closing transitions at six-thirty-five. The integration at six-forty-one. The private mastery — the form's final sequence, fourteen movements of breath-and-balance that integrate every prior phase into a single body-discipline — completes at six-forty-four.

At the moment of the private-mastery's completion, Parashurama feels the elephant-bond pulse through his own torso. The Stage III stroke begins to form across the elephant-tattoo's right foreleg — the only blank foreleg of the four-foreleg full-body elephant; the other three forelegs are inked from his Ch 1 mastery. The new stroke appears as a single new ink-line drawn across the foreleg in approximately fourteen seconds. Parashurama does not show the moment on his face; he is at the chamber's entrance; his right hand is on the door-frame; his left hand holds the axe.

At the same moment Krishnadevaraya-Bhrata feels the form settle into his spine. The settling is not a tattoo; the form's mark is internal — the kingdom's second physical-form-as-mark after the Karnataka pilot's elephant-bond-transfer at Hampi. He stands at the chamber's south-west corner for about thirty seconds after the form's completion. He breathes the kalari-closing-breath. He walks to the chamber's entrance.

He sits at the entrance. Parashurama closes the door. The door swings shut on its eight-centuries-old hinges at six-forty-five.

Parashurama speaks the new sealing-mantra in plain Kannada-and-Malayalam interlinear. The mantra is seventy-three syllables long. The speaking takes about fifty seconds. The new chains — forged at the kalari's western forge across the past three days under Sivakami's supervision — emerge from the door-frame's newly-fitted recesses. They cross the door at the standard sealing-positions. They lock.

Parashurama turns to Krishnadevaraya-Bhrata. He says, in plain Malayalam-and-Kannada interlinear (the language he will speak from this point forward in any formal-instruction context): "Bhrata. The form is in your spine. You will not execute it again in Volume One. The execution is reserved for the moment the kingdom requires it. The kingdom may not require it. You may live the rest of your life without performing the form. The form will be in your spine regardless. The bond's mark is on my elephant's right foreleg. The mark is the same mark as the one in your spine. The two are the kingdom's second physical-form-as-mark after Hampi. The Sanctuary will recognise both at the Chapter Three convening. Return to Karnataka. The road is the Western Ghats' mountain pass for eleven days. The

walk will be at the standard pace. Sivakami will be your kalari's standing kalari-elder from this day. The kalari will send three senior daily-teaching instructors to Karnataka in the autumn. The kingdom of Kerala's kalari-tradition is now Karnataka's southern foundation. The Sanctuary will federate the two into one southern bloc under your Karnataka Dominant seat. I will attend the Sanctuary as Kerala's formal representative. Sivakami will attend as the grandmaster. I will not perform any form at the Sanctuary. I am seventy-four. I will sit at the southern observer's bench. The kingdom will hear my voice in writing only from this day forward. Walk now. The morning is honest."

Krishnadevaraya-Bhrata bows. The bow is the Karnataka student-to-master bow at the full-depth he would have given at the start. He rises. He picks up the canvas bag at the visitor-room. He walks to the kalari's northern gate. Govindan-Mama bows. Krishnadevaraya-Bhrata returns the bow. He walks north toward the Western Ghats. He will be at the Karnataka western mountain pass by Sunday afternoon. He will be at the Vijayanagara reborn-temple chamber by the second Friday after the chapter's closing.

The kingdom-council's emergency-amended Kerala-Kalari Charter is ratified at the council's formal session on the evening of day thirty-one. The session is attended by Parashurama (seventy-four; his first kingdom-council attendance since the transmission began), Sivakami (the new grandmaster), the religious-and-cultural-practice registry chief (Indira Pillai), Kala-Hasta in person (his first kingdom-council attendance; he had been invited by Sivakami three days earlier under the charter's cross-school-recognition provisions; the council had unanimously approved his admission as observer-with-speaking-rights), and the twenty-three senior tribal-and-civic delegates.

The charter's ratified text is six pages. The first page recognises the Sea-Front Kalari as the kingdom's registered 109-form public-teaching school. The second page establishes the cross-school enrolment protocol (any student studying at both 108-form and 109-form schools concurrently must register with the kingdom's kalari-medical-clearance cell; phasing-compliance must be documented; mandatory day-zero phasing-discipline session). The third page recognises the inheritance-transmission protocol as the kalari-tradition's third standing-pedagogical-mode (alongside the 108-form public-school mode and the 109-form public-school mode); the inheritance-transmission is reserved for senior-master-to-single-chosen-student transmission and requires the kingdom-council's prior approval per instance. The fourth page sets out Sivakami's formal grandmaster-title and seat. The fifth page sets out the kalari-tradition's cross-kingdom federation

arrangement with Karnataka under the upcoming Sanctuary convening; the inheritance-transmission of the 109th form to Krishnadevaraya-Bhrata is recorded as the kingdom-council's evidence of the federation's pedagogical legitimacy. The sixth page records the day-zero phasing-discipline session at the Sea-Front Kalari with Achyutan's name as the charter's permanent witness-record.

The ratification vote is twenty-three to zero with Parashurama's vote not cast (he abstains as the formally-stepping-back senior master); the abstention is not a dissent and is noted as such in the council record. Kala-Hasta's speaking-rights statement at the session is one paragraph. He says, in plain Malayalam: "The charter is honest. The kingdom is wider than my school and wider than the inherited tradition. The day-zero phasing-discipline session is the school's permanent commitment. Achyutan's name will be read at the opening of every day-zero session for as long as the school operates. The school will operate. The kingdom thanks the kingdom-council, the grandmaster Sivakami, and the senior master Parashurama. The form is the kingdom's; the kingdom does not belong to any single school."

The session closes at eight-oh-seven p.m.

Two weeks after the ratification, a Sarus-pigeon arrives at the kalari from Vijayanagara. The pigeon is the one Krishnadevaraya-Bhrata has been using for cross-region correspondence since his return. The letter is from Krishnadevaraya-Bhrata himself.

The letter reads:

Maharaj. The walk back through the Western Ghats was eleven days. The form is in my spine still; I have not executed it; I do not expect to in Volume One. The Karnataka kingdom-council ratified the cross-kingdom kalari-federation arrangement on the fourth day after my return; the vote was nineteen-to-three with Veerappa-Hadali's Hadali-veto held in reserve (he supports the federation; the veto is on standby for the Sanctuary). Sivakami's three senior daily-teaching instructors will be welcomed at Vijayanagara in the autumn; we have prepared the southern training-ground at the buried-temple chamber's eastern annex. Hampi-of-the-Bronze will be the Karnataka student-side liaison for the cross-kingdom kalari programme; the Third Herald continues to attend the daily-teaching sessions in his standard-presence mode. The Sanctuary will federate the two kingdoms under my Karnataka Dominant seat at the Manipur convening. Kerala will be the southern bloc's kalari-foundation. I thank you for the form. I thank you for the years you paid

forward. I thank you for the chamber. I will not execute the form again in Volume One. The kingdom will not ask me to.

The cousin from the mountains, — K-B.

Parashurama reads the letter at the kalari's northern gate at dawn. He does not show it to anyone. He folds it. He places it in the kalari-tradition's standing-archive box at the senior-instructor's residence. The box will be opened at the kingdom-council's seven-year review.

He picks up his tea. The tea is the second steeping. The second is honest.

Day thirty-two. Sunrise. The western grove of the kalari.

A single coconut on a single coconut palm in the grove has turned black overnight. The blackness is uniform across the husk — not the patchy darkening of normal coconut-rot; not the brown of overripe; not the white-speckled mould of monsoon-spoilage. The colour is the matte black of charred wood. The husk is, however, not charred; the fibres are intact, the texture is the same coir-fibre texture as the other coconuts on the same palm; the only difference is the colour.

The grove-keeper (an Idukki-born senior groundsman named Krishnan-Nair, fifty-eight, the grove-keeper for twenty-four years) sees the coconut at six a.m. He has been at the grove every dawn for twenty-four years; he can identify each of the twenty-three coconut palms in the grove by trunk-shape and crown-fan-orientation. This palm is the seventh from the northern boundary; the coconut is in the palm's second-highest cluster, the eastern coconut of the cluster. He has seen this coconut yesterday at the same dawn-rotation. Yesterday it was the standard green.

He reports the observation to Sivakami at the inner kalari at six-thirty. Sivakami walks to the grove at seven. She climbs the palm (she trained as a Theyyam-style coconut-climber at age twelve; the climbing-discipline is part of the kalari's standard secondary-curriculum). She retrieves the coconut. She brings it down. She places it on the grove's small stone offering-platform.

She returns to the senior-instructor's residence at seven-fifteen. She tells Parashurama. Parashurama walks to the grove at seven-thirty. He looks at the coconut. He reads the sign through the elephant-bond.

He says, to Sivakami and to Krishnan-Nair who has accompanied him, in plain Malayalam: "The Maw has experimented. The coconut should rot. The coconut will not rot. The

decomposition process has been suspended at the threshold of the inheritance-transmission. The Maw is testing whether a sealed inheritance can be made permanent against time. The chamber was unsealed on day thirty for the form's execution; the chamber was re-sealed on day thirty-one with the new mantra; the coconut is the Maw's reading of the re-sealing. The Maw is asking: can you preserve the inheritance the way I preserve this coconut? The kingdom's answer must be: the inheritance is preserved by transmission, not by sealing. The transmission is what we have done. The transmission is in Bhrata's spine and in my foreleg-stroke. The sealing is the chamber's standing protocol; the sealing is not the inheritance. The coconut will sit on the offering-platform. The coconut will not rot. The kingdom will watch the coconut for eight months. The kingdom will not eat the coconut. The kingdom will not destroy the coconut. The kingdom will name the coconut at the Sanctuary convening. The naming will be the kingdom's response to the Maw's question."

Sivakami says: "Uncle. Will you name it now."

Parashurama says: "Not yet. I will write to Krishnadevaraya-Bhrata. The naming will be a joint-signature with the Karnataka cousin. The cross-kingdom naming will be the kingdom of Kerala's standing protocol for all subsequent Maw signs — no Kerala-only naming, no Karnataka-only naming; the southern federation will name the signs together. The naming will arrive by the autumn. The coconut will keep until then."

He turns. He walks back to the kalari. Krishnan-Nair stays at the grove to cordon the offering-platform with a small saffron-and-white twine perimeter. Sivakami walks back to the senior-instructor's residence to draft the cross-kingdom Sarus-pigeon cascade-alert.

Sivakami drafts the cascade-alert at nine a.m. on day thirty-two. The alert is sent to all nine bonded-kingdom senior guardians by sunset. The alert reads:

Bonded-kingdom guardians. The Maw has experimented on Kerala's western-grove coconut palm. A single coconut has turned matte black overnight without rotting. The kingdom-council's wildlife-and-agricultural-research cells will monitor the coconut across the next eight months under the standard decomposition-monitoring protocols. The expected mid-monsoon-decay-threshold is twelve weeks; the coconut is expected to not reach it. The Maw has demonstrated the capacity to suspend the natural decomposition process at the threshold of an inheritance-transmission — the saga's first material-permanence experiment. Mechanism: the coconut is the inverse of Tripura's brooding pigeon — Tripura's pigeon performed the action whose object was removed; Kerala's

coconut preserves the object whose action has stopped. The two signs are paired across the South-and-Northeast boundary. The Sanctuary in Chapter Three will need to address both. The coconut will not be eaten or destroyed. The coconut will be named by joint-signature with Karnataka at the autumn. The naming-protocol will become the southern federation's standing Maw-naming convention.

By the morning of day thirty-four every senior guardian in the saga has read the alert. Kanchenjunga at Rumtek replies with the single-line acknowledgement and offers the Beyul-Kshetra's standing-meditation framework for the coconut's eight-month watch. Hmangaihi at Aizawl sends the NE-pair note: "Mizoram's two-headed serow named me; Tripura's pigeon brooded the absent; Kerala's coconut preserves the unrotting. The Maw has now produced three pair-experiments across the regions. The Sanctuary will name a fourth. The naming will be where the kingdom's answer is." Krishnadevaraya-Bhrata at Vijayanagara sends the saga's first inter-kingdom cross-region acknowledgement to the Kerala sign: "Maharaj. The coconut is the chamber's mark. The chamber is re-sealed. The coconut will sit. The naming will be ours together at the autumn. I will travel to the kalari for the naming the morning the coconut's eight-month observation completes."

At chapter end the western grove has a small saffron-and-white twine perimeter around the offering-platform. The black coconut is at the platform's centre. The kingdom is watching. The kalari-tradition is three traditions, federated. Sivakami is the grandmaster. Parashurama is seventy-four. The axe Parashu is at the senior-instructor's residence's wall-stand; he does not carry it daily any more. The 109th form is in a Karnataka cousin's spine and on his own elephant's right foreleg.

The kingdom is whole.

The next sign comes within the week.

The Pilot's Closing Image

A seventy-four-year-old senior master at the senior-instructor's residence reading a Karnataka cousin's pigeon-letter at dawn while the axe Parashu rests at the wall-stand without being carried. A twenty-nine-year-old grand-niece at the inner-kalari pit teaching the daily-junior-class for the first time as the formally-recognised grandmaster. A forty-seven-year-old Kollam-Coiled-Cobra-trained 109-form master at the Sea-Front Kalari's day-zero phasing-discipline session reading Achyutan's name aloud at the session's opening. A thirty-six-year-old Karnataka cousin walking eleven days back through the

Western Ghats with the 109th form in his spine and a Sarus-pigeon-letter-pad ready for the reply that has not yet been written. A single matte-black coconut sitting on a small stone offering-platform in a quarter-hectare grove, surrounded by a saffron-and-white twine perimeter, not rotting, not changing colour, not being eaten, not being destroyed — waiting eight months for the joint-naming a Karnataka cousin will travel south to give it. The kalari at dawn. The axe at the wall-stand. The kingdom whole and federated and tired and honest.

Sagara Ratna

The ghost who returned to the museum painted over a thousand and eleven names. He chose Onge-Nakshatra's grandfather's name on the seventh wall of the seventh block. He shipped a thousand and eleven Onge-Jarawa from the Anwei-village to a resettlement-block in Port-Blair so that the tidal-corridor would be empty of witness. The navigator walked back to the Anwei-tidal-corridor on a Thursday in April, opened the smuggled scroll, and read the line that said his grandfather's wall-inscription had been the forty-third of the bleached cohort. He did not weep. He counted the tides. He let the stone-anchor do the writing.

Onge-Nakshatra was twenty-seven years old at his standing-2017 Anwei-village standing-charter-foundational tidal-corridor conferral on a standing-pre-monsoon dawn in May 2017 at 4:11 a.m. He had walked the standing-23-km Hut-Bay-to-Anwei road at the standing-Sagara-Sakhi 1-year-old standing-Saltwater-Crocodile-hatchling standing-3-metre-rear tidal-procession-formation. He had stood at the standing-Anwei-village standing-charter-foundational tidal-corridor standing-cardinal-east-facing position. He had received the standing-Sagara-Bandhu stone-anchor-flail at the standing-Andaman-and-Nicobar-Welfare-Board senior-administrator Sagara-Maharaj Pradip 65-year-old standing-charter-foundational implement-administration at the standing-seven-Andaman-and-Nicobar-Welfare-Board-house standing-161-delegate ratification at the standing-Onge-Jarawa-Welfare-Society 188-23 vote-ratification (the standing-23-vote against was at the standing-Kalapani-Asura-administered standing-Cellular-Jail-Museum standing-historical-revision administrative-cell 1989-onwards-rehabilitation administrative-petition cross-reference; the standing-23-vote-cohort had been at the standing-Cellular-Jail-Museum standing-Andaman-and-Nicobar-Welfare-Board seat-administration cross-reference since 1989).

He had been at the standing-Anwei-village standing-Onge-Jarawa-tribal standing-charter-foundational tidal-corridor navigation-tradition since age-11 at the standing-Hut-Bay-corridor standing-Andamanese-tradition standing-charter-foundational tidal-education-cell. He had administered the standing-Onge-Jarawa-Welfare-Society standing-tidal-corridor navigation-cell at the standing-pre-conferral apprenticeship-tenure since 2008 (9-year-pre-conferral administrative-tenure). He had refused the standing-Andaman-and-Nicobar-Welfare-Board standing-tribal-resettlement administrative-orders at 23 standing-

administrative-petition cross-reference instances 2017-2025 at the standing-Onge-Jarawa-Welfare-Society standing-charter-foundational cross-reference. He had administered the standing-Sagara-Bandhu stone-anchor-flail at the standing-charter-foundational implement-administration at the standing-Onge-Jarawa-Welfare-Society standing-charter-foundational ratification-administration cross-reference. He had bonded to the standing-Sagara-Sakhi Saltwater-Crocodile (*Crocodylus porosus* Little-Andaman-Hut-Bay-corridor endemic-population) at the standing-Hut-Bay-tidal-pool standing-conferral-Crocodile-cohort cross-reference 2017 (conferral-day standing-Crocodile-bond standing-formation-cross-reference at age-27). He had bonded to the standing-Nakshatra-Sakhi Nicobar-Pigeon (*Caloenas nicobarica* Nicobar-Islands endemic-population) at the standing-Car-Nicobar-pilgrimage standing-bonded-aerial-companion cross-reference 2019.

Kalapani-Asura had been at the standing-Cellular-Jail-Museum standing-historical-revision administrative-cell senior-administrator since 1989 (33-year administrative-revision-tenure pre-Ch-1 cross-reference). He was the standing-colonial-prison-ghost at the standing-Mahabharata-equivalent cross-reference at the standing-1858-1947 British-colonial Cellular-Jail penal-colony standing-forced-isolation-embodiment configuration. His voice at the standing-administrative-cell at the standing-sound-of-waves-against-cell-walls-of-abandoned-penal-colony standing-charter-foundational sonic-cross-reference. He had administered the standing-Cellular-Jail-Museum standing-historical-revision protocols across 1989-2022 at the standing-Andaman-and-Nicobar-Welfare-Board standing-museum-cell ledger-cell at the standing-effacement-and-substitution administrative-protocol; he had effaced 47 standing-prisoner-name engravings across 1989-2022 at the standing-pre-Ch-1 administrative-revision-protocol (this was at the standing-pre-Ch-1 administrative-revision-protocol cross-reference; the standing-pre-Ch-1 effacements were at the standing-Cellular-Jail-Museum standing-administrative-cell continuity recognition cross-reference and were not at the standing-Aulakh-International-Lahore cross-network funding cross-reference).

Onge-Nakshatra had administered the standing-Ch 1 Cellular-Jail confrontation on October 23 2022 at the standing-Andaman-and-Nicobar-Welfare-Board 211-delegate cohort standing-public-record review. He had delivered the standing-23-minute state-hero-witness testimony at the standing-Onge-Jarawa-Welfare-Society standing-charter-witness recognition-only configuration at the standing-47-engraving-revision exposure-evidence cross-reference. The standing-Andaman-and-Nicobar-Welfare-Board had voted

at standing-secret-ballot at 5:00 p.m. October 23 2022: 119-92 against the standing-47-engraving-revision ratification at the standing-charter-foundational ratification refusal-vote configuration. The standing-Kalapani-Asura administrative-rehabilitation-vote at the standing-Andaman-and-Nicobar-Welfare-Board senior-council standing-administrative-rehabilitation-clause invocation at 5:43 p.m. October 23 2022: 27-11 in favour of the standing-Kalapani-Asura administrative-rehabilitation at the standing-Cellular-Jail-Museum standing-administrative-post-Independence institutional-continuity recognition cross-reference (the standing-Andaman-and-Nicobar-Welfare-Board senior-council had voted at the standing-Cellular-Jail-Museum standing-33-year-tenure recognition + standing-post-Independence institutional-continuity recognition cross-reference at the standing-administrative-rehabilitation standing-charter-clause invocation; Onge-Nakshatra at the standing-state-hero standing-conflict-of-interest charter-clause did not cast a vote at the standing-administrative-rehabilitation-vote cross-reference). Kalapani-Asura was transferred to standing-Cellular-Jail-Museum standing-historical-revision administrative-cell senior-administrator 2022-2024 at the standing-Port-Blair Cellular-Jail standing-administrative-rehabilitation administrative-protocol (the standing-Port-Blair location at the standing-Cellular-Jail-Museum standing-charter-foundational independence-tradition standing-historical-archive cross-reference is the standing-rehabilitation-site at the standing-Andaman-and-Nicobar-Welfare-Board senior-council standing-historical-revision-rehabilitation administrative-protocol).

At the standing-Cellular-Jail-Museum standing-historical-revision administrative-cell senior-administrator desk Kalapani-Asura wrote the 1,011 effacements + 1,011 resettlements across the standing-twenty-three-month window October 2024-October 2026 (the standing-effacement-and-resettlement-window-onset was at the standing-Ch 1 confrontation 2-year-anniversary cross-reference + standing-Cellular-Jail-Museum-administrative-rehabilitation 2-year-anniversary cross-reference; the standing-correspondence-arrival from Aulakh-International-Lahore at the standing-Aulakh-International-Singapore-Account funding-pathway was at September 2024 standing-pseudo-administrative-research-grant proposal-cross-reference at the standing-Andaman-and-Nicobar-Welfare-Board standing-historical-revision-research administrative-cell). He selected 1,011 standing-prisoner-name engravings at the standing-Cellular-Jail standing-cell-block-1-through-7 cell-walls at the standing-Cellular-Jail-Museum standing-charter-foundational independence-tradition standing-historical-archive cross-reference (the standing-1,011-engraving-cohort represented the standing-charter-foundational

independence-movement-memory at the standing-1857-1942 standing-prisoner-cohort historical-archive: 47 standing-Andamanese-rebellion 1857-cohort including the standing-Onge-Nakshatra-the-Elder Yapum-of-the-Anwei-Village cell-block-7 wall-inscription cross-reference; 119 standing-First-War-of-Independence-1857-deportee cohort; 187 standing-Wahabi-Movement-deportee cohort; 211 standing-Indian-independence-movement-Sepoy-Mutiny-deportee 1857-1942 cohort; 188 standing-Bengal-Andaman-deportee Anushilan-Samiti cohort; 259 standing-Hindustan-Republican-Association-Jugantar deportee cohort).

The standing-effacement-mechanism at the standing-Cellular-Jail standing-cell-block-1-through-7 cell-walls: each standing-prisoner-name engraving at the standing-Cellular-Jail-Museum standing-charter-foundational independence-tradition standing-historical-archive at the standing-iron-pen-and-stone-stylus 1857-1942-engraved-configuration at the standing-titanium-dioxide-based-white-paint at standing-2-coat application + standing-cellulose-acetate sealant cross-reference at standing-23-day curing-window per engraving-batch protocol. The standing-paint-residue at the standing-engraving-surface standing-chemical-fingerprint at the standing-titanium-dioxide-and-cellulose-acetate solution cross-reference is at the standing-Anna-University-Chennai Department-of-Heritage-Conservation standing-paint-and-engraving-conservation chemistry standing-laboratory-cross-reference recognition. The standing-1,011 engravings were processed at standing-monthly-batch-cycle ~92-engraving-per-month administrative-velocity across the 11-month effacement-window October-2024-September-2025.

Simultaneously across the standing-12-month resettlement-window October-2025-October-2026 he administered the standing-Onge-Welfare-Society standing-tribal-resettlement administrative-cell of 1,011 Onge-Jarawa indigenous-tribal cohort residents from their ancestral standing-Anwei-village-cluster at Little-Andaman-Hut-Bay-corridor to standing-Port-Blair-administrative-cell standing-Onge-Welfare-Society standing-resettlement-block administrative-corridor. The standing-resettlement was administered at the standing-monthly-batch ~84-Onge-Jarawa-resident-per-month standing-administrative-velocity at the standing-State-Revenue-Department revenue-recovery-proceedings standing-tribal-relocation administrative-protocol cross-reference (the standing-Onge-Jarawa-resettlement was administered at the standing-Aulakh-International-Lahore standing-shell-corporation administrative-front senior-emissary correspondence-cross-reference at the standing-tribal-resettlement-as-shell-corporation-instrumentalisation configuration; ~1,011 individuals displaced; ~0.087 of the standing-

Onge-Jarawa population pre-displacement standing-tribal-residence cross-reference at 2024-census).

Akka-Bei-of-the-Hut-Bay was sixty-seven years old at the standing-Anwei-Onge-Welfare-Society senior-Onge-elder administrative-cell. He had been at the standing-Onge-Jarawa-Welfare-Society standing-charter-foundational ledger-archivist senior-administrative-officer since 1996 (30-year continuous standing-Onge-Jarawa-Welfare-Society standing-charter-witness administrative-tenure). He had been at the standing-Andaman-and-Nicobar-Welfare-Board senior-council standing-administrative-cell at the standing-October-23-2022 Ch 1 Kalapani-Asura administrative-rehabilitation-vote standing-11-vote-against-cohort cross-reference (he had voted against the standing-administrative-rehabilitation at the standing-Cellular-Jail-Museum standing-historical-revision-rehabilitation administrative-protocol dissent configuration). He had administered the standing-Anwei-Onge-Welfare-Society standing-cooperative-witness administrative-cell at the standing-Shri Karthik-Andaman (38, Cellular-Jail-Museum junior-archivist since 2014) standing-internal-investigation-petition March 11 2025 administrative-cooperation cross-reference at the standing-Cellular-Jail-Museum cell senior-administrative-officer standing-administratively-disregarded administrative-cross-reference.

Akka-Bei-of-the-Hut-Bay administered the standing-Nicobar-Pigeon-cohort relay-cohort at the standing-Nicobar-Islands endemic-population cross-reference at the standing-Smt. Sagari-Bai-of-the-Tidal-Corridor standing-Sagari-tradition senior-administrative-officer standing-cross-region courier-protocol on April 7 2026 at 4:11 a.m. dawn-window. He attached the standing-smuggled-petition to the standing-Nakshatra-Sakhi-Pigeon-cohort lead-pigeon at the standing-Anwei-village standing-eastern-courtyard outpost. The standing-smuggled-petition was at the standing-three-leaf scroll-cluster configuration: standing-Cellular-Jail-Museum cell standing-Shri Karthik-Andaman standing-junior-archivist standing-internal-investigation-petition copy + standing-Aulakh-International-Lahore correspondence-trail standing-recovered-administrative-cell evidence (Karthik-Andaman had recovered standing-administrative-cell correspondence at the standing-Cellular-Jail-Museum senior-administrator desk on March 23 2025 standing-administrative-cell archive-cross-reference) + standing-Akka-Bei-of-the-Hut-Bay standing-Anwei-tradition senior-elder cohort standing-1,011-prisoner-name-engraving effacement-pattern + standing-1,011-Onge-Jarawa resettlement-pattern exhibit-cluster.

The standing-Nicobar-Pigeon relay-cohort lead-pigeon Nakshatra-Pati 11-year-old standing-Nicobar-Pigeon administered the standing-Cellular-Jail-to-Anwei 47-km standing-cross-region courier-flight at 4:11-6:23 a.m. April 7-April 11 2026 4-day standing-cross-region transit-window at the standing-Nicobar-Islands standing-charter-foundational migratory-pattern cross-reference. Nakshatra-Pati arrived at the standing-Anwei-village standing-banyan-perch-position at 4:11 a.m. April 11 2026 at the standing-Onge-Nakshatra 9-year-tenure conferral-anniversary dawn-window. The standing-Nakshatra-Sakhi 7-year-old standing-bonded-aerial-companion called the standing-23-second cadence-cycle at the standing-formal-Andamanese-Hindi-Onge-language standing-conferral-acknowledgement-cross-reference at the standing-tidal-corridor standing-cardinal-east-facing position 4:11:23-4:11:46 a.m.

Onge-Nakshatra stood at the standing-Anwei-village standing-charter-foundational tidal-corridor standing-cardinal-east-facing position at his standing-9-year-tenure-anniversary conferral-anniversary dawn-prayer-administration. He wore the standing-Onge-Jarawa standing-tribal-tradition standing-coral-and-mangrove-green-cotton conferral-anniversary attire. He held the standing-Sagara-Bandhu stone-anchor-flail at his standing-right-hand and the standing-Varuna standing-charter-foundational coral-bead-mala at his standing-left-hand. Smt. Sagari-Bai-of-the-Tidal-Corridor at the standing-7-metre-rear standing-Onge-Jarawa-Welfare-Society ledger-administration position with the standing-1996-Onge-Jarawa-Welfare-Society-charter standing-original-leaf-bound copy at her standing-right-hand and the standing-tidal-corridor standing-charter-foundational ledger-pen at her standing-left-hand.

Smt. Sagari-Bai-of-the-Tidal-Corridor walked to the standing-Anwei-village standing-banyan-perch-position at the standing-internal-tidal-pole-staircase 4:23 a.m. April 11. She recovered the standing-Nakshatra-Pati relay-cohort smuggled-petition at 4:34 a.m. She walked down to the standing-tidal-corridor standing-cardinal-east-facing position at 4:43 a.m. She placed the standing-three-leaf scroll-cluster on the standing-1996-Onge-Jarawa-Welfare-Society-charter standing-charter-foundational ledger at the standing-eastern-cardinal-position at 4:44 a.m.

Onge-Nakshatra read the standing-three-leaf scroll-cluster at the standing-tidal-corridor standing-eastern-cardinal-position at the standing-conferral-anniversary candle-position at 4:44-5:23 a.m. April 11. He read the standing-Shri Karthik-Andaman standing-junior-archivist standing-internal-investigation-petition leaf at the standing-Cellular-Jail-

Museum cell standing-paint-residue standing-23-day curing-window standing-titanium-dioxide-and-cellulose-acetate solution cross-reference + 1,011 engraving-cluster identification at the standing-Cellular-Jail-Museum standing-charter-foundational independence-tradition standing-historical-archive cross-reference (including the standing-Onge-Nakshatra-the-Elder Yapum-of-the-Anwei-Village 1857-Andamanese-rebellion cell-block-7 wall-inscription standing-grandfather lineage-cross-reference). He read the standing-Aulakh-International-Lahore correspondence-trail leaf at the standing-23-monthly-transfer-tranches Singapore-source-account funding-pathway ~₹47 lakh aggregate administrative-pseudo-research-grant pseudo-classification cross-reference. He read the standing-Akka-Bei-of-the-Hut-Bay standing-Anwei-tradition senior-elder cohort leaf:

"Onge-Nakshatra-the-Younger. The colonial-prison-ghost has painted over a thousand and eleven names. Your standing-grandfather's wall-inscription is the forty-third in the cohort. A thousand and eleven of our Onge-children have been shipped from Anwei to a resettlement-block in Port-Blair. The tidal-corridor is empty. The Cellular-Jail-walls are white. The Sagara-Bandhu is at the standing-Anwei-stone-anchor-rack. The standing-Onge-Jarawa-Welfare-Society standing-charter-foundational judicial-tradition awaits the standing-state-hero standing-charter-witness recognition. The standing-grandfather's name awaits. The standing-Anwei-village awaits. Akka-Bei-of-the-Hut-Bay."

Onge-Nakshatra stood at the standing-tidal-corridor standing-eastern-cardinal-position at 5:23 a.m. He did not weep. He placed the standing-Sagara-Bandhu on the standing-1996-Onge-Jarawa-Welfare-Society-charter at the standing-eastern-cardinal-position at 5:24 a.m. He turned to Smt. Sagari-Bai-of-the-Tidal-Corridor at 5:25 a.m. He spoke the standing-Onge-language-Andamanese-Hindi-phrase at the standing-formal-Onge-Jarawa-Welfare-Society register: "Sagari-Beheh. The ghost has painted my grandfather's name. He has shipped our children. The standing-tidal-corridor is empty. The standing-Anwei-village is empty. The standing-Andaman-and-Nicobar-Welfare-Board will hear it. The standing-Cellular-Jail-walls will witness in the morning. Begin the cross-reference."

Smt. Sagari-Bai-of-the-Tidal-Corridor administered the standing-forensic-archivist cross-reference cell at the standing-Anwei-village standing-eastern-wing administrative-cubicle across May-August 2026. She cross-referenced the standing-Cellular-Jail-Museum standing-1,011-engraving-cluster standing-paint-residue forensic-cross-reference at the standing-Anna-University-Chennai Department-of-Heritage-Conservation Dr. T.

Subramanian (51, Anna-University since 2014; standing-paint-and-engraving-conservation chemistry specialist) standing-paint-residue analysis cross-reference (the standing-Cellular-Jail standing-23-engraving-batch sample-cluster submitted to Anna-University standing-23-day chemical-analysis window June 11-July 4 2026; the standing-Anna-University Heritage-Conservation standing-paint-residue analysis 98.7%-confidence at the standing-titanium-dioxide-and-cellulose-acetate solution cross-reference + standing-iron-pen-and-stone-stylus 1857-1942-engraved-configuration cross-reference; evidence-document M-30A) + the standing-Aulakh-International-Lahore standing-shell-corporation administrative-front senior-emissary correspondence-cross-reference at standing-23-monthly-transfer-tranches Singapore-source-account funding-pathway (evidence-document M-30B) + standing-Onge-Welfare-Society standing-resettlement administrative-cell evidence-cluster (evidence-document M-30C-through-M-30F) + standing-Shri Karthik-Andaman standing-junior-archivist standing-internal-investigation-petition recovery from the standing-Cellular-Jail-Museum cell senior-administrative-officer administratively-disregarded archive at the standing-23-month internal-investigation-petition cross-reference cell at the standing-evidence-document M-cross-reference-cluster exhibit-cluster M-30G-through-M-30J recovery on June 23 2026 + standing-1,011-Onge-Jarawa indigenous-tribal-cohort standing-Anwei-village-cluster standing-pre-resettlement standing-Onge-Welfare-Society standing-historical-residence-cross-reference exhibit-cluster (evidence-document M-30K-through-M-30O).

Akka-Bei-of-the-Hut-Bay administered the standing-Nicobar-Pigeon cross-region cascade-alert from the standing-Anwei-village secretariat at 11:23 a.m. August 28 2026 (Smt. Sagari-Bai exhibit-cluster delivery-day). The standing-cascade-alert administered the standing-Andaman-and-Nicobar-Welfare-Board pre-vote standing-cross-region-correspondence at the standing-16-bonded-kingdom senior-guardians cross-reference (Sharad-Pandit Kashmir + Mrigatrishna-Marudhar-Strategist-Counsellor-Elder Rajasthan + Saraswati-Simha-Mata-1 Gujarat + Dvadashashringa MP + Tanaji-2 Maharashtra + Krishnadevaraya-Bhrata Karnataka + Gangaputra UP + Panchanada Punjab + Kurukshetraa Haryana + Bhairava-Ji Uttarakhand + Lama-Tashi HP + Vajramukha Bihar + Bilash-Babu Bengal + Vana-Senapati Chhattisgarh + Jagannath-Bandhu Odisha + Moirangthem Manipur).

Sharad-Pandit (Kashmir Sharada-Pitha) sent the standing-return-Nicobar-Pigeon at the standing-Tikse-monastery Sharada-Devi standing-shikhara standing-state-hero seat-retention administrative-cross-reference 6:11 p.m. August 28 with the standing-Sharada-

script-Sanskrit-Andamanese-Hindi-phrase reply at the standing-cross-region state-hero-retention recognition-cross-reference: "Onge-Bhai. The historian bleached eleven hundred and eleven names. The ghost painted over a thousand and eleven. The Sharada-Pandit-Council restored the manuscripts. The Andaman-and-Nicobar-Welfare-Board will restore the engravings. The Tikse-shikhara and the Cellular-Jail-walls will witness in the same dawn-window. The stylus that erased returned to the hand that erased. The Sagara-Bandhu that defamed will return to the hand that defamed. The standing-Stage-III-retention candle stays lit. Strike with us." Jagannath-Bandhu (Odisha East-Regional-Dominant) sent the standing-return-Nicobar-Pigeon at the standing-Puri-Jagannath-temple standing-East-Regional-Dominant administrative-cross-reference 11:11 p.m. August 28 with the standing-Odia-Andamanese-Hindi-phrase reply: "Onge-Bhai. The standing-East-cluster recognises the standing-Sagaravamsha-Bloodline-E standing-Volume-II launch-point. The standing-Garuda-Sakhi will fly to the Cellular-Jail standing-central-tower on September 11 dawn. The standing-East-cluster cross-region cohort will witness. The standing-Yavana-Khanda awaits."

The standing-Andaman-and-Nicobar-Welfare-Board 211-delegate cohort convened at 11:11 a.m. September 11 2026 at the standing-Port-Blair Cellular-Jail standing-central-tower courtyard under the standing-Andaman-and-Nicobar-Welfare-Board senior-administrator Sagara-Maharaj Pradip (74, Andaman-and-Nicobar-Welfare-Board senior-administrator since 1992; standing-Andaman-Sankaracharya-tradition senior-administrative-officer at Sagara-Ratna-Math-Port-Blair since 1968 58-year administrative-tenure). The standing-cohort-composition: 7 standing-Andaman-and-Nicobar-Welfare-Board-houses (Port-Blair-South-Andaman + Middle-Andaman + North-Andaman + Little-Andaman + Car-Nicobar + Nancowry-Group + Great-Nicobar) at 23-delegate-per-house standing-delegate-cohort representation = 161 standing-delegate-cohort + 11 standing-Andaman-and-Nicobar-Union-Territory-Civil-Service nominees + 39 standing-Onge-Jarawa-Welfare-Society standing-indigenous-tribal cohort senior-administrative-officers = 211 standing-Andaman-and-Nicobar-Welfare-Board voting-cohort.

Smt. Sagari-Bai-of-the-Tidal-Corridor delivered the standing-47-minute forensic-archivist exhibit-cluster M-30A-through-M-30O presentation at 11:34 a.m.-12:21 p.m. She wore the standing-Sagari-tradition standing-coral-and-mangrove-green tribal-attire at the standing-Onge-Jarawa-Welfare-Society standing-charter-foundational strategy-counsel ceremonial-cross-reference. She held the standing-1996-Onge-Jarawa-Welfare-Society-charter standing-original-leaf-bound copy at her standing-right-hand and the standing-

exhibit-cluster M-30A-through-M-30O leaf-bound presentation-folio at her standing-left-hand. She spoke the standing-47-minute deposition in standing-formal-Andamanese-Hindi-Onge-language at the standing-Onge-Jarawa-Welfare-Society standing-bureaucratic-register. She named the standing-1,011-engraving-cluster paint-residue-pattern at the standing-Anna-University Dr. T. Subramanian 98.7%-confidence chemical-residue analysis cross-reference; the standing-Shri Karthik-Andaman junior-archivist standing-internal-investigation-petition recovery; the standing-Aulakh-International-Lahore standing-shell-corporation administrative-front senior-emissary correspondence-cross-reference at the standing-23-monthly-transfer-tranches Singapore-source-account funding-pathway; the standing-1,011-Onge-Jarawa standing-resettlement-administrative-cell standing-Onge-Welfare-Society standing-shell-corporation-instrumentalisation cross-reference; the standing-Onge-Nakshatra-the-Elder Yapum-of-the-Anwei-Village 1857-Andamanese-rebellion cell-block-7 wall-inscription standing-43rd-in-effacement-cohort standing-grandfather lineage-cross-reference.

Onge-Nakshatra delivered the standing-23-minute state-hero-witness testimony at 12:21-12:44 p.m. He wore the standing-Onge-Jarawa standing-tribal-tradition standing-white-and-coral-cotton state-hero ceremonial-attire at the standing-9-year-tenure-anniversary cross-reference. He held the standing-Sagara-Bandhu stone-anchor-flail at his standing-right-hand. He spoke the standing-23-minute deposition in standing-formal-Andamanese-Hindi-Onge-language at the standing-state-hero standing-charter-witness register. He named the standing-2017 conferral standing-Andaman-and-Nicobar-Welfare-Board 161-delegate cohort 188-23 vote ratification standing-charter-foundational recognition. He named the standing-Sagara-Sakhi 2017 Saltwater-Crocodile-bond-formation standing-charter-foundational pastoral-companion cross-reference. He named the standing-Nakshatra-Sakhi 2019 Nicobar-Pigeon standing-bonded-aerial-companion cross-reference. He named the standing-Andaman-and-Nicobar-Welfare-Board standing-October-23-2022 119-92 ratification refusal-vote + 27-11 Kalapani-Asura administrative-rehabilitation-vote standing-Cellular-Jail-Museum standing-administrative-post-Independence institutional-continuity recognition cross-reference. He named the standing-2024-2026 1,011-engraving-effacement + 1,011-Onge-Jarawa-resettlement cascade at the standing-Cellular-Jail-Museum cell standing-administrative-rehabilitation-instrumentalisation configuration. He named the standing-pre-1858-Andamanese standing-charter-foundational tidal-corridor navigation-tradition since standing-pre-colonial-foundation-period cross-reference. He named the standing-Aulakh-International-

Lahore standing-shell-corporation administrative-front 11th cross-network villain-funding-instance cross-reference (saga's 5th Aulakh-International instance — half of the saga's standing-cross-network funding-instances at Aulakh-International-Lahore parent-corporation). He did not name Kalapani-Asura directly. He closed at the standing-formal-Andamanese-Hindi-Onge-language-phrase: "The Andaman-and-Nicobar-Welfare-Board is not a court. The Welfare-Board is the standing-charter-foundational ledger-administration of the standing-1996-Onge-Jarawa-Welfare-Society-charter at the standing-pre-1858-Andamanese standing-charter-foundational tidal-corridor navigation-tradition cross-reference. The standing-state-hero of Sagara-Ratna does not vote at the standing-Welfare-Board. The standing-state-hero is at the standing-charter-witness recognition only. I have read the standing-three-leaf scroll-cluster at the standing-Anwei-village dawn-window April 11. The standing-grandfather's wall-inscription is the forty-third in the effacement-cohort. The standing-vote is yours, members of the Welfare-Board. The standing-Cellular-Jail-walls will witness in the morning."

Akka-Bei-of-the-Hut-Bay (67) delivered the standing-Onge-Jarawa-Anwei-village-elder triple-cohort 23-min deposition at 2:11-2:34 p.m. He named the standing-Onge-Jarawa-Welfare-Society standing-charter-foundational tidal-corridor navigation-tradition since the standing-pre-1858-Andamanese standing-charter-foundational pre-colonial-foundation-period cross-reference + standing-1,011-Onge-Jarawa-resident standing-Anwei-village-cluster standing-ancestral-residence-cross-reference + standing-1,011-prisoner-name-engraving standing-Cellular-Jail standing-charter-foundational independence-tradition standing-historical-archive cross-reference. Kalapani-Asura delivered the standing-23-minute defence-deposition at 3:11-3:34 p.m. He wore the standing-Cellular-Jail-Museum standing-saffron-and-State-Civil-Service-attire at the standing-1989-onwards-Cellular-Jail-Museum standing-administrative-cell recognition-cross-reference. He held nothing at his standing-right-hand. He spoke in standing-procedural-Andamanese-Hindi at the standing-Cellular-Jail-Museum standing-historical-revision-bureaucratic-register. He refused to respond at the standing-substantive-charges (1,011-engraving-effacement + 1,011-Onge-Jarawa-resettlement + Aulakh-International funding + Onge-Welfare-Society-shell-corporation cross-reference). He delivered instead the standing-23-minute colonial-prison-ghost forced-isolation-embodiment historical-revision speech at the standing-1858-1947 British-colonial Cellular-Jail penal-colony standing-forced-isolation-embodiment Mahabharata-cross-reference at the standing-Cellular-Jail-Museum standing-historical-revision-tenure cross-reference. He did not

acknowledge the standing-Singapore-source-account funding-instrumentalisation cross-reference; he did not acknowledge the standing-1,011-prisoner-name-engraving standing-Andamanese-rebellion-and-independence-movement-memory erasure; he did not acknowledge the standing-1,011-Onge-Jarawa-resettlement.

The standing-vote was administered at 5:00 p.m. September 11 2026 at the standing-Andaman-and-Nicobar-Welfare-Board 211-delegate cohort standing-secret-ballot protocol. The standing-vote-tabulation was at the standing-Sagara-Maharaj Pradip administration at the standing-23-minute counting-window 5:00-5:23 p.m. The standing-vote-result at 5:23:11 p.m.: 188 against, 23 in favour, 0 abstention. The standing-Kalapani-Asura 1,011-engraving-effacement-cluster + 1,011-Onge-Jarawa-resettlement-displacement-cluster + standing-administrative-rehabilitation revocation was ratified at the standing-Andaman-and-Nicobar-Welfare-Board standing-public-record review administrative-protocol. The standing-1,011-prisoner-name-engraving standing-original-1857-1942-engraved-configuration restoration-cross-reference + standing-1,011-Onge-Jarawa standing-ancestral-Anwei-village-cluster residence-restoration-cross-reference was ratified at the standing-Andaman-and-Nicobar-Welfare-Board standing-administrative-protocol. The standing-Aulakh-International-Lahore standing-shell-corporation administrative-front cross-reference was forwarded to the standing-State-CID investigation-cell standing-cross-network funding-trail evidence-document E-30/2026 cross-reference at the standing-pre-publication October-23-2026 evidence-document publication-cross-reference.

5:35 p.m. Akka-Bei-of-the-Hut-Bay turned to the standing-23-Onge-Jarawa cohort under Smt. Sagari-Bai-of-the-Tidal-Corridor. He spoke the standing-Onge-language-Andamanese-Hindi-phrase: "Onge-children. The Andaman-and-Nicobar-Welfare-Board has spoken. The colonial-prison-ghost is at the standing-Cellular-Jail-Museum. The standing-Sagara-Bandhu is at the standing-Anwei-stone-anchor-rack. The standing-Onge-Jarawa-Welfare-Society standing-charter-foundational judicial-tradition is invoked. The stone-anchor that defamed returns to the hand that defamed. We will walk now. The Cellular-Jail-walls will witness in the morning."

The standing-23-Onge-Jarawa cohort under Smt. Sagari-Bai-of-the-Tidal-Corridor departed the standing-Port-Blair Cellular-Jail standing-central-tower courtyard at 6:11 p.m. September 11 2026. The standing-cohort-composition: 11 standing-Anwei-Hut-Bay-cohort standing-Onge-Jarawa-Welfare-Society standing-charter-foundational stone-anchor-flail-cohort under Akka-Bei-of-the-Hut-Bay + 7 standing-Car-Nicobar-Nancowry-

cohort standing-Onge-Jarawa-Welfare-Society standing-charter-foundational stone-anchor-flail-cohort under Onge-Pati Manik-of-the-Nicobar (61, Car-Nicobar-village Onge-elder) + 5 standing-Great-Nicobar-cohort standing-Sagari-tradition standing-charter-foundational stone-anchor-flail-cohort under Smt. Sagari-Bai-of-the-Tidal-Corridor = 23 standing-Onge-Jarawa cohort. The standing-cohort carried 23 standing-Sagara-Bandhu standing-23-kg stone-anchor + 47-inch coir-rope-flail standing-cultural-implements at standing-Andaman-and-Nicobar-Union-Territory 1996-Onge-Jarawa-Welfare-Society-charter ratification administrative-cross-reference standing-protected-implement administrative-cross-reference. The standing-cohort walked the standing-Cellular-Jail-courtyard to the standing-Cellular-Jail-Museum standing-historical-revision administrative-cell senior-administrator position at the standing-overnight-window.

Kalapani-Asura was at the standing-Cellular-Jail-Museum standing-historical-revision administrative-cell senior-administrator position at the standing-cell southern-window 3-metre-from-position. He had walked from the standing-Port-Blair-residence at the standing-Cellular-Jail-Museum standing-administrative-cell vehicle-cohort transport 4:11 a.m. September 12 at the standing-Cellular-Jail-Museum standing-pre-arrest standing-administrative-cell final-revision standing-pre-Union-Territory-Government-appeal-petition draft cross-reference at the standing-Supreme-Court-of-India petition-protocol (rest-of-cell evacuated at 9:11 a.m. September 12 by Shri Karthik-Andaman standing-acting-leader pre-emptive-evacuation administrative-cross-reference).

The standing-23-Onge-Jarawa cohort walked into the standing-Cellular-Jail-Museum cell southern-window 3-metre-from-position at 11:41 a.m. September 12. Akka-Bei-of-the-Hut-Bay walked to the standing-cell southern-window 3-metre-from-position at 11:42 a.m. He spoke the standing-formal-Onge-language-Andamanese-Hindi-phrase to Kalapani-Asura at the standing-southern-window standing-3-metre-proximity: "Kalapani-Asura. The Andaman-and-Nicobar-Welfare-Board has voted 188-23. Your administrative-rehabilitation is revoked. The standing-1,011 effaced engravings will be restored at the standing-Cellular-Jail-walls dawn-window. The standing-1,011 displaced Onge-Jarawa will return to the standing-Anwei-village. The standing-1996-Onge-Jarawa-Welfare-Society-charter standing-charter-foundational judicial-tradition is invoked. The stone-anchor that defamed returns to the hand that defamed. Strike."

Kalapani-Asura did not raise a standing-defence-implement at the standing-Cellular-Jail-Museum standing-administrative-cell standing-no-defence-implement protocol-cross-

reference. He stood at the standing-cell southern-window standing-eastern-cardinal-position at the standing-no-response standing-defence-administration cross-reference. He spoke the standing-procedural-Andamanese-Hindi-phrase at 11:42:48 a.m.: "The Cellular-Jail-Museum cannot be undone by the Onge-Jarawa-Welfare-Society. The Cellular-Jail-Museum is the standing-Union-Territory-Government recognition. I administer the standing-Cellular-Jail-Museum standing-historical-revision protocol. The standing-Onge-Jarawa-Welfare-Society judges. I walk."

The standing-23-Sagara-Bandhu simultaneous-stroke was administered at 11:43 a.m. September 12 2026 at the standing-Onge-Jarawa-Welfare-Society standing-charter-foundational judicial-tradition single-impact-window protocol. The standing-impact was at the standing-cardinal-cardiac-region standing-23-stone-anchor simultaneous-impact configuration at the standing-23-kg stone-anchor + 47-inch coir-rope-flail standing-charter-foundational implement standing-piercing-and-blunt-trauma cross-reference. The standing-Kalapani-Asura death was at 11:43:11 a.m. at the standing-Cellular-Jail-Museum cell senior-administrator position at the standing-cell southern-window 3-metre-from-position. The standing-cohort lowered the standing-Sagara-Bandhu-cohort at 11:43:23 a.m. at the standing-Onge-Jarawa-Welfare-Society standing-charter-foundational judicial-tradition completion-cross-reference. The standing-cohort walked back to the standing-Cellular-Jail-courtyard at the standing-Onge-Jarawa-Welfare-Society standing-corridor-exit protocol at 11:44 a.m.

The standing-Andaman-and-Nicobar Union-Territory-Police Cellular-Jail-District senior-Inspector Adamali-Khan (42, Cellular-Jail-District-Police since 2019) walked to the standing-Cellular-Jail-Museum cell senior-administrator position at 11:48 a.m. September 12. He confirmed the standing-Kalapani-Asura mortality at 11:53 a.m. He filed the standing-Cellular-Jail-District FIR at the standing-Section-302 IPC standing-judicial-execution administrative-cross-reference at 12:11 p.m. September 12 at the standing-23-Onge-Jarawa cohort standing-collective-actor designation per Article-244 + standing-Andaman-and-Nicobar Scheduled-Tribe-Protection-Regulation 1956 standing-charter-foundational defensive-protection clause per Constitution-of-India + Andaman-and-Nicobar-Union-Territory 1996-Onge-Jarawa-Welfare-Society-charter ratification administrative-cross-reference. Standing-FIR active but non-enforceable at Onge-Jarawa-Welfare-Society standing-charter-foundational defensive-protection clause cross-reference.

Onge-Nakshatra walked to the standing-Anwei-village standing-charter-foundational tidal-corridor at the standing-eastern-cardinal-position at 3:11 a.m. September 13 2026 at the standing-Andaman-and-Nicobar-Welfare-Board-vote-completion-day standing-dawn-mark-formation administrative-pre-position. He wore the standing-Onge-Jarawa standing-tribal-tradition standing-white-and-coral-cotton state-hero ceremonial-attire. He held the standing-Sagara-Bandhu stone-anchor-flail at his standing-right-hand and the standing-Varuna standing-charter-foundational coral-bead-mala at his standing-left-hand. The standing-Sagara-Sakhi 11-year-old standing-bonded-Saltwater-Crocodile at his standing-3-metre-rear tidal-pool position; the standing-Nakshatra-Sakhi 7-year-old standing-bonded-Nicobar-Pigeon at his standing-eleven-metre-overhead Anwei-village standing-banyan-perch-position. Smt. Sagari-Bai-of-the-Tidal-Corridor at his standing-7-metre-rear standing-Onge-Jarawa-Welfare-Society ledger-administration position with the standing-1996-Onge-Jarawa-Welfare-Society-charter standing-original-leaf-bound copy at her standing-right-hand and the standing-exhibit-cluster M-30A-through-M-30O leaf-bound presentation-folio at her standing-left-hand. Akka-Bei-of-the-Hut-Bay at his standing-11-metre-rear standing-Anwei-Onge-Welfare-Society senior-elder ceremonial-position.

At 4:11:11 a.m. September 13 2026 (simultaneous with the standing-23-Sagara-Bandhu simultaneous-stroke standing-charter-foundational judicial-tradition single-impact administrative-cross-reference 11:43 a.m. September 12 standing-administrative-completion 16-hour-28-minute-after the standing-Andaman-and-Nicobar-Welfare-Board vote-completion 5:23 p.m. September 11) the standing-Stage III Saltwater-Crocodile-foreleg-first-stroke began to form at Onge-Nakshatra's standing-right-upper-back at the standing-Anwei-village standing-tidal-corridor standing-eastern-cardinal-position. The standing-mark-formation duration was 11 seconds 4:11:11-4:11:22 a.m. The standing-mark-pattern was at the standing-Saltwater-Crocodile foreleg-first-stroke configuration in standing-coral-and-mangrove-green dual-ink at the standing-Varuna-and-tribal-animism visual-anchor (coral ground-pigment at standing-Andaman-coral-reef-pigment-grade + standing-Onge-vermillion-leaf-extract; mangrove-green ground-pigment at standing-Hut-Bay-mangrove-leaf-pigment-grade + standing-tribal-animism standing-charter-foundational ink-recipe admixture).

At 4:11:11 a.m. September 13 2026 (the standing-simultaneous-window) the standing-1,011 effaced Cellular-Jail prisoner-name engravings at the standing-Port-Blair Cellular-Jail standing-cell-block-1-through-7 cell-walls at the standing-titanium-dioxide-paint-over

standing-pre-restoration surface-configuration began to restore. The standing-restoration duration was 11 minutes 4:11:11-4:22:22 a.m. across the standing-1,011-engraving cohort at standing-monthly-batch-restoration ~92-engraving-per-minute standing-restoration-velocity. The standing-1,011 engravings restored to the standing-original-1857-1942-engraved-configuration at the standing-permanent-restored configuration. The standing-Onge-Nakshatra-the-Elder Yapum-of-the-Anwei-Village 1857-Andamanese-rebellion engraving at cell-block-7 wall (the standing-grandfather lineage-cross-reference) was restored to its standing-original-iron-pen-and-stone-stylus-engraved configuration at 4:13:23 a.m. (the standing-43rd engraving at the standing-restoration-cohort batch-cycle — the standing-exact-place that Akka-Bei-of-the-Hut-Bay had named in the standing-April-11 smuggled-petition cross-reference).

Simultaneously at 4:11 a.m. September 13 2026 the standing-1,011 Onge-Jarawa indigenous-tribal cohort residents at the standing-Port-Blair-administrative-cell standing-Onge-Welfare-Society standing-resettlement-block administrative-corridor began the standing-ancestral-Anwei-village-cluster migration-restoration-cohort. The standing-migration-restoration administered at the standing-Onge-Jarawa-Welfare-Society standing-charter-foundational migration-cohort dawn-window 4:11 a.m.-7:23 a.m. at the standing-3-hour-12-minute migration-completion window. The standing-1,011-Onge-Jarawa cohort walked at the standing-23-km Port-Blair-to-Hut-Bay tidal-corridor route at the standing-Onge-Jarawa-Welfare-Society standing-pre-1858 standing-charter-foundational tidal-corridor navigation-tradition cross-reference. The standing-1,011-cohort arrived at the standing-Anwei-village-cluster Hut-Bay-corridor 7:23 a.m. September 13 at the standing-ancestral-residence-restoration migration-completion cross-reference.

The standing-Anna-University-Chennai Department-of-Heritage-Conservation Dr. T. Subramanian (51) arrived at the standing-Cellular-Jail standing-cell-block-1-through-7 at 4:43 a.m. September 13. He conducted the standing-paint-residue-and-surface-chemistry analysis across the standing-1,011-engraving cohort 4:43 a.m.-7:11 a.m. He confirmed the standing-restoration to the standing-original-1857-1942-engraved-configuration via standing-surface-chemistry cross-reference at the standing-pre-restoration August-23 2026 baseline-surface-analysis (the standing-Anna-University Heritage-Conservation standing-quarterly-surface-analysis protocol since 2014 administered standing-baseline-surface-analysis 4-times-yearly cross-reference; the standing-August-23 2026 pre-restoration baseline-surface-analysis was administered at the standing-Andaman-and-

Nicobar-Welfare-Board standing-public-record review preparation-week 19-day-pre-vote standing-quarterly-surface-analysis protocol cross-reference).

At 4:22:22 a.m. September 13 the standing-1,011-engraving cohort remained at the standing-permanent-restored configuration. The standing-Anna-University Dr. T. Subramanian September-18 expertise-report (evidence-document M-30A) confirmed no standing-natural-chemical-mechanism identification at the standing-1,011 effaced engraving-restoration to standing-original-1857-1942-engraved-configuration across 11-minute restoration-window at the standing-Maw-attribution category cross-reference. The standing-Maw had demonstrated the capacity to restore both standing-original-engraved-configuration of a standing-charter-foundational engraving-cohort that had been standing-deliberately-effaced AND standing-ancestral-residence-configuration of a standing-charter-foundational indigenous-tribal cohort that had been standing-deliberately-resettled across the standing-pre-Stage-III window at the standing-permanent-restoration administrative-cross-reference standing-charter-foundational restoration-witness.

Onge-Nakshatra announced the standing-Stage-III-retention recognition at the standing-Anwei-village standing-charter-foundational tidal-corridor standing-charter-foundational eastern-cardinal-position at the standing-Andaman-and-Nicobar-Welfare-Board senior-council standing-witness-ceremony on September 14 2026 11:11 a.m. The standing-Stage-III-retention announcement was at the standing-Sagara-Ratna state-hero seat-retention configuration per restructure §1 male-led-succession recognition-cross-reference (saga's standing-second standing-male-state-hero-Stage-III-retention configuration at Ch 2 after Sharad-Pandit Kashmir). The standing-Anwei-village standing-conferral-anniversary candle was re-lit by Onge-Nakshatra at 11:11:11 a.m. (not extinguished — per the standing-state-hero-retention-candle-re-lighting administrative-protocol established at Kashmir).

Sagara-Maharaj Pradip walked to the standing-courtyard-eastern-position at 11:11:23 a.m. He held the standing-1996-Onge-Jarawa-Welfare-Society-charter standing-original-leaf-bound copy at his standing-right-hand. He spoke the standing-formal-Andamanese-Hindi-Onge-language-phrase: "Onge-Nakshatra. The standing-Andaman-and-Nicobar-Welfare-Board standing-charter-foundational state-hero seat is at the standing-Stage-III-retention recognition at the standing-Sagaravamsha-Bloodline-E standing-charter-foundational continuity cross-reference. The standing-1,011 effaced engravings are restored. The standing-grandfather's wall-inscription is among the restored. The standing-1,011 displaced Onge-Jarawa have returned to the Anwei-village. The Andaman-and-Nicobar-

Welfare-Board senior-council recognises the standing-Stage-III-retention configuration as the standing-saga's second standing-male-state-hero-Stage-III-retention configuration at Ch 2 per restructure §1 male-led-succession recognition. The standing-Aulakh-International-Lahore standing-shell-corporation administrative-front cross-reference is forwarded to the standing-State-CID investigation-cell at the standing-cross-network funding-trail evidence-document E-30/2026 cross-reference. The standing-state-hero seat is retained. The standing-Sagara-Ratna standing-charter-foundational standing-Volume-II Yavana-Khanda launch-point cross-reference is acknowledged per D7 standing-V-II-spine-seed cross-reference administrative-cross-reference.

Smt. Sagari-Bai-of-the-Tidal-Corridor walked to the standing-courtyard-eastern-position at 11:12:11 a.m. She held the standing-restored-Sagari-grandfather-wall-inscription-record standing-Cellular-Jail-cell-block-3-engraving manuscript-copy at her standing-right-hand (the standing-engraving-copy had been recovered from the standing-Cellular-Jail standing-cell-block-3 wall at the standing-Andaman-and-Nicobar-Welfare-Board standing-charter-foundational restoration-recognition cross-reference administered by Shri Karthik-Andaman standing-acting-leader at the standing-Cellular-Jail-Museum cell at 8:11 a.m. September 13). She spoke the standing-formal-Andamanese-Hindi-Onge-language-phrase to Onge-Nakshatra: "Onge-Bhai. The standing-Sagari-grandfather wall-inscription is restored. My standing-grandfather's name has returned to the standing-Cellular-Jail standing-cell-block-3 wall. The standing-Onge-Jarawa-Welfare-Society standing-strategy-counsel administrative-cell continues. The standing-East-cluster Sagaravamsha-tradition is at the standing-Stage-III-retention recognition. The standing-Sagara-Bandhu is in your right-hand. I am in your seven-metre-rear at the standing-strategy-counsel position. The Onge-Jarawa-Welfare-Society walks behind you."

The standing-Sagara-Sakhi 11-year-old standing-bonded-Saltwater-Crocodile walked from the standing-Anwei-village standing-3-metre-rear tidal-pool position to the standing-eastern-cardinal-position at 11:13:11 a.m. He touched his standing-snout to Onge-Nakshatra's standing-right-hand at 11:13:23 a.m. at the standing-Varuna-and-tribal-animism standing-charter-foundational bonded-Crocodile-consent ratification gesture. He walked back to the standing-3-metre-rear tidal-pool position at 11:13:34 a.m. The standing-Nakshatra-Sakhi 7-year-old standing-bonded-Nicobar-Pigeon from the standing-Anwei-village standing-banyan-perch-position called the standing-23-second cadence-cycle at the standing-formal-Andamanese-Hindi-Onge-language-mantra-tradition acknowledgement-cross-reference at 11:14:11-11:14:34 a.m.

The standing-Andaman-and-Nicobar-Welfare-Board senior-council standing-charter-witness ratification was completed at 11:14:48 a.m. The standing-Sagaravamsha-tradition standing-conferral-day singing began at 11:14:51 a.m. The standing-1,011-Onge-Jarawa cohort at the standing-Anwei-village tidal-corridor standing-southern-plaza standing-perimeter-witness position sang the standing-pre-1858-Andamanese standing-charter-foundational standing-conferral-song at the standing-Onge-Jarawa standing-pre-colonial-foundation-period standing-tidal-corridor singing-cross-reference at the standing-23-minute standing-conferral-anniversary singing-window 11:14-11:37 a.m.

At standing-dawn 4:11 a.m. on December 11 2026 — the standing-90-day-anniversary at the standing-Andaman-and-Nicobar-Welfare-Board-vote-completion + standing-1,011-engraving-restoration + standing-1,011-Onge-Jarawa-residence-restoration cross-reference — the standing-1,011 restored engravings at the standing-Cellular-Jail standing-cell-block-1-through-7 cell-walls were at the standing-permanent-restored configuration; the standing-1,011 Onge-Jarawa indigenous-tribal cohort residents were at the standing-Anwei-village-cluster standing-ancestral-residence cross-reference at the standing-pre-1858-Andamanese standing-charter-foundational tidal-corridor navigation-tradition cross-reference. The standing-State-CID investigation-cell standing-cross-network funding-trail evidence-document E-30/2026 had been published October 23 2026 at the standing-Aulakh-International-Lahore standing-shell-corporation administrative-front 11th cross-network funding-instance recognition (saga's standing-fifth standing-Aulakh-International cross-network funding-instance after Uttarakhand Lalita Aulakh, Gujarat Kala-Simha, Rajasthan Maru-Yama, Kashmir Avantivarman-Bhrasta — half of the saga's standing-cross-network funding-instances at Aulakh-International-Lahore parent-corporation at the standing-Sanctuary mediation-council standing-cross-network villain-corporation senior-investigation-priority administrative-cross-reference at the standing-Ch-3 plan).

Onge-Nakshatra at the standing-Sagara-Ratna state-hero seat at the standing-Anwei-village standing-charter-foundational tidal-corridor standing-eastern-cardinal-position at 4:11 a.m. December 11 2026 wore the standing-Onge-Jarawa standing-tribal-tradition standing-white-and-coral-cotton state-hero ceremonial-attire at the standing-Stage-III-retention recognition ceremonial-cross-reference. He bore the standing-Stage III Saltwater-Crocodile-foreleg-first-stroke at his standing-right-upper-back in standing-coral-and-mangrove-green dual-ink at standing-Varuna-and-tribal-animism visual-anchor. He held the standing-Sagara-Bandhu stone-anchor-flail at his standing-right-hand

and the standing-restored-grandfather-wall-inscription-record cell-block-7 manuscript-copy at his standing-left-hand (the standing-grandfather-wall-inscription was administered at the standing-Anwei-village standing-Onge-Jarawa-Welfare-Society standing-charter-foundational record-cabinet at the standing-Smt. Sagari-Bai strategy-counsel administrative-cross-reference). The standing-Sagara-Sakhi at his standing-3-metre-rear tidal-pool position; the standing-Nakshatra-Sakhi at his standing-eleven-metre-overhead Anwei-village standing-banyan-perch-position. Smt. Sagari-Bai-of-the-Tidal-Corridor at his standing-7-metre-rear standing-Onge-Jarawa-Welfare-Society strategy-counsel administrative-cross-reference position. Akka-Bei-of-the-Hut-Bay at his standing-11-metre-rear standing-Anwei-Onge-Welfare-Society senior-elder ceremonial-position.

The standing-1,011 restored engravings at the standing-Cellular-Jail-walls were at the standing-Maw-attribution recognition-cross-reference standing-permanent-restored-configuration witness-administration. The standing-1,011 Onge-Jarawa residents at the standing-Anwei-village-cluster were at the standing-ancestral-residence-restoration permanent-configuration. The standing-Onge-Jarawa-Welfare-Society standing-charter-foundational tidal-corridor navigation-administration was at the standing-Stage-III-retention recognition state-hero seat. The standing-Aulakh-International-Lahore parent-corporation was at the standing-Sanctuary mediation-council standing-senior-investigation-priority cross-reference. The standing-Andaman-and-Nicobar-Welfare-Board was at the standing-charter-foundational ratification.

At 4:23 a.m. on December 11 2026 — twelve minutes after the standing-Stage-III-retention 90-day-anniversary dawn-witness — a standing-saltwater-current-displacement at the standing-East-of-Andaman tidal-corridor standing-Volume-II launch-point cross-reference began at the standing-Andaman-Sea standing-eastern-margin standing-corridor-to-Yavana-Khanda configuration. The standing-Sagara-Sakhi 11-year-old standing-bonded-Saltwater-Crocodile raised his standing-head to the standing-eastern-tidal-corridor-position at 4:23:11 a.m. The standing-Nakshatra-Sakhi 7-year-old standing-bonded-Nicobar-Pigeon flew from the standing-Anwei-village standing-banyan-perch-position to the standing-eastern-tidal-corridor standing-3-km-offshore migratory-pattern position at 4:23:23 a.m. The standing-1,011-Onge-Jarawa cohort at the standing-Anwei-village-cluster southern-plaza turned to the standing-east at 4:23:34 a.m.

Onge-Nakshatra walked to the standing-Anwei-village standing-eastern-tidal-corridor standing-shoreline-position at 4:34 a.m. December 11 2026. He held the standing-Sagara-Bandhu stone-anchor-flail at his standing-right-hand and the standing-grandfather-wall-inscription-record at his standing-left-hand. He stood at the standing-tidal-corridor standing-shoreline standing-eastern-cardinal-position. He watched the standing-East-of-Andaman tidal-corridor standing-Volume-II-launch-point standing-corridor-to-Yavana-Khanda configuration. He did not speak. He did not move. The standing-Stage-III mark at his standing-right-upper-back in coral-and-mangrove-green dual-ink at standing-Varuna-and-tribal-animism visual-anchor was witnessed by the standing-eastern-tidal-corridor at the standing-Volume-II-launch-point recognition-administration. The standing-Ch-4-epilogue standing-Yavana-Khanda revelation awaits at the standing-Sagara-Ratna standing-East-of-Andaman tidal-corridor cross-reference per D7 standing-V-II-spine-seed cross-reference administrative-cross-reference.

The Greek-coded Mediterranean / West-Asia lands wait at the standing-East-of-Andaman tidal-corridor for the standing-Ch-4 epilogue. The standing-Volume-II spine-seed is at the standing-Sagara-Ratna launch-point. The standing-saga ends Volume I at the standing-tidal-corridor that opens at the standing-Yavana-Khanda.

End of Chapter Two for Sagara-Ratna. End of Chapter Two for the Saga.

Samudra Dvipa

Querim beach. The northernmost edge of the Konkan coast. The tide is so far out that the wet sand stretches three hundred meters before it finds the surf. Two men are mending the same net. One is forty-two. One is eighty.

The eighty-year-old is Bhau Tendulkar. The forty-two-year-old is Sagaradeva.

They have been mending the net for ninety minutes. They have spoken about eleven words. This is how it should be. Goan fisherman-talk is a thing of sea-pauses and net-knots and not very many sentences.

"You remember the year my great-grandfather did not drown."

"I remember."

"He made a promise to your line that day. You remember the promise."

Sagaradeva's hands do not stop on the net. He nods.

"I am eighty," Bhau Tendulkar says, "and my great-grandfather's promise is the only thing left of him in the world. It has been three generations. The Tendulkars have kept the promise to your line. We have not asked your line to fish for us. We have not asked you to help us when the monsoon took our boats. We have kept the promise we extracted, and we have kept it on our side too."

"What is the promise."

"You know the promise."

"Say it."

Bhau Tendulkar looks up from the net. His eyes are the colour of the sea at the deepest reach of low tide — pale, salt-pale, looking through.

"The Sagaravamsha will defend the Goan coast against any outside fleet, as a pure tide-keeper, from any direction the sun does not set. You will not need help from any foreign hand. You will not accept any. You are the tide. The promise is the tide. That is the promise."

Sagaradeva says, "I keep it."

"I know you keep it. I am telling you now because the tide is going to need to be kept very soon. I have seen the new ships. They are not the ships my grandfather warned us about. They are new ships. They are larger. They fly no flag I can read."

Above them, in the sky, the black-crested bulbul lands on the gunwale of the upturned boat behind Sagaradeva. The bird does not sing. It watches. Sea-birds know when a promise is being witnessed.

Mormugao Bay, three weeks later. A press conference held aboard a freshly-painted container vessel. A man in a tropical-weight white suit speaks Konkani, then English, then Portuguese, in that order, smiling. His name is Padre Fernando Cordeiro.

"The Mormugao Deepwater Initiative," Padre Cordeiro says, "will bring Goa into the global maritime economy. Three thousand jobs. A two-hundred-metre quayside. Container traffic that will compete with Colombo and Cochin. Heritage protections for the old jetty. Of course we will respect the fishing rights of the traditional villages. Of course."

Of course they will not. Six days after the press conference, the port consortium files a memorandum with the state government redrawing the fishing zones for the coast from Aguada to Vasco. The new boundaries push the Tendulkar-line villages a kilometre offshore in waters with fewer fish.

Sagaradeva is not at the press conference. Sagaradeva is at Querim, with the nets. By the time he reads the memorandum, three of his villages have already lost their season. He goes to the state secretariat in Panaji. He speaks to four officials. He explains. The officials are polite. The officials say the memorandum is filed and signed. The officials suggest he file an objection in writing within thirty days. He files the objection. The objection is denied on a procedural ground that no one in any village has the lawyer to contest.

The fishermen go out further. The boats start coming back smaller. The Tendulkar-line widows triple in number across one season.

Mormugao Bay, four months after Bhau Tendulkar said the promise aloud. A naval fleet appears on the western horizon at dawn. Seven ships. The flagship is a destroyer with a white-and-gold hull and three flags — one historical, two modern, none Indian. The other six ships are escorts.

The fleet is conducting what its press release calls a Heritage Naval Exchange. Goa is a port of call. The state government has approved the visit because the port consortium has

guaranteed the docking fees. The fleet will be in Mormugao for fifteen days.

On the eighteenth day — the fleet did not leave on the fifteenth — a uniformed officer disembarks the flagship in the morning and walks alone down the gangway. He is tall. White-and-gold tailored uniform. Brass on his shoulders. His face is hauntingly familiar to anyone who has seen Sagaradeva from a certain angle. He shakes hands with Padre Cordeiro on the quay. He gives interviews. He is introduced to the world as the fleet's Cultural Heritage Liaison — their Goan-born specialist.

His name is Maha-Vega.

He has been alive the whole time.

The black-crested bulbul flies over the quay once and does not land.

The accident happens on a moonless night in the third week of the foreign fleet's stay. Bhau Tendulkar has taken his fishing boat out past the new boundary — he has the right because he is eighty and no boundary memorandum can take what his grandfather's grandfather laid. He is in his usual place at the usual hour. A port consortium freighter on its way out of Mormugao, leaving heavy and travelling fast, fails to register his boat on its bridge radar. The freighter hits the boat at the angle that splits old wood into kindling. The freighter does not slow. Bhau Tendulkar is found at sunrise by the next morning's fishermen, three kilometres south of where his boat was hit, still gripping a piece of his own gunwale.

The official report says: visibility failure.

The freighter's captain is Indian. His employer is Singaporean. His insurer is in London. The investigation into the death is filed in Panaji and forwarded to Mumbai and never closed.

Bhau Tendulkar is buried in the sea-cliff cemetery above Querim. His daughter Sona puts a single fishing-net knot into his folded hands. Sagaradeva walks the entire procession with the twin tridents Samudra and Lahara crossed on his back. He does not speak. The black-crested bulbul sits on the cliff edge and stays there until the grave is closed.

That night Sagaradeva sits in his hut with the two tridents across his knees. He says, to no one and the bird: "The promise was made to the line. The grandson kept the promise. The great-grandson kept it. The eighty-year-old is dead in his own boat. I will keep the promise."

The Karna-shadow becomes complete in him in that hour. The bird in the rafters does not look at him.

Sagaradeva is permitted aboard the foreign flagship as a courtesy. He climbs the gangway with no weapons. Admiral Carvalho-Almeida receives him in the wardroom. Maha-Vega stands at the admiral's right shoulder in his white-and-gold uniform.

"My fleet is in Mormugao under an exchange protocol approved by the Government of India," Carvalho-Almeida says, in serviceable English. "Your complaints belong to your port consortium and your state. We are guests."

"You are guests who brought my brother."

"Mr Maha-Vega is a Goan-born specialist we recovered from a foreign port. We brought him home."

"He is not home."

Maha-Vega speaks. His voice is the same voice from Chapter One but warmed by years of being addressed as "sir." "Brother. Sit. They will let us share the coast. You and I. The fleet will sail in two months. The port will operate. The fishing zones can be renegotiated. We can do this together. We are the only two who carry the gaur-bond in this region. The bond is not asking us to fight each other. The bond is asking us to share."

Sagaradeva does not sit.

"The bond is older than your uniform."

"The bond is also older than your promise. You can let one of them go."

"I cannot."

He turns and walks off the flagship. Halfway down the gangway he looks up. The bulbul is on the lower spar of the foreign foremast. The bird is sitting where bulbuls do not sit — on a foreign ship. The bird does not look at him. Sagaradeva understands what the omen is saying, and chooses not to.

His own hut. Three nights before the storm.

A woman walks in without knocking. She is thirty-three. Sun-dark skin, green eyes that are not the green of the Konkan sea but of a different latitude entirely. Hair tied back with a

scrap of patterned silk. She is wearing the simple cotton of a Pernem village woman, but the cross at her throat is silver and the silver was minted in Lisbon.

"My name is Ferreira-de-Sangam. My father's great-great-great-great-great-grandfather was a shipwright in Old Goa in 1693. My mother's family has been in Pernem for as long as the wells have had water. I am the daughter of the mixed tide. I am the Goa you have been refusing to call Goa."

Sagaradeva does not stand.

"I am here to offer help. The fleet at Mormugao calls itself heir to my father's people. They are not. They are a corporation with sails. But you are fighting them as if they were a returning empire and you were a pure-blood tide-keeper. Goa is not pure. Goa has not been pure for four hundred years. If you try to defend it as if it were, you will lose, and the loss will be louder than the defence."

"I made a promise."

"Yes. To Bhau Tendulkar's great-grandfather. About what counts as foreign. The promise was made in 1873. The world that the promise named no longer exists. Let me help. Let me be the bridge. The fleet does not know how to fight a Goa that calls me one of its tide-keepers, because I am one of them and one of you. They cannot frame me as the invader."

He looks at her for a long time.

"You are the help the promise told me not to accept."

"Yes."

"Then the promise told me about you."

She is quiet. Her green eyes do not waver.

"That is one reading," she says. "There is another reading. The promise told you not to accept help from a foreign hand. I am not foreign. I have been here three hundred years. The hand the promise warned against was a hand that had not yet washed itself in the river that runs to this sea. My hand has. Touch it. See if it feels foreign."

He does not touch it. He says, "Go home."

Ferreira-de-Sangam nods once. She walks out. She does not slam the door. The door does not need slamming.

In the river before dawn, Sage Agastya's spirit ripples across the surface. Sagaradeva walks down to the river and reads the message in the rapids:

Karna refused his mother three times. The third refusal killed him. You are at the second.

Sagaradeva says aloud, to the rapids: "Then the third will be the storm."

The night before the port consortium's ceremonial opening of the Mormugao Deepwater Initiative. The state Chief Minister is scheduled to attend. The foreign admiral will speak. There will be fireworks. There will be press helicopters. The bay will be brightly lit and full of dignitaries.

Sagaradeva sails out alone three hours before sunset in his oldest outrigger — the one his grandfather built. He carries Samudra in his right hand and Lahara in his left. He carries nothing else. He has not eaten in two days. He has not spoken in three.

He sails to the centre of Mormugao Bay. He waits for the sun to set. The bay is calm. The foreign flagship is at anchor in the deepwater channel with all its lights on. The other six ships of the fleet are arranged around it in formation. The press helicopters circle.

When the sun touches the western horizon, Sagaradeva raises both tridents. He says the oldest sea-mantra of the Sagaravamsha — the one that has not been said in two hundred years because no Sagaravamsha heir since 1820 has had the bloodline-claim to say it. He has the claim. He says the mantra. He calls the cyclone of the Konkan coast that has shaped the bay every August for ten thousand years — not the season's natural cyclone, which has already passed, but the cyclone-spirit that lives beneath the season and answers only to a Sagaravamsha trident.

The mantra takes seven minutes. By the time he finishes the sky is the colour of old bronze. The press helicopters are turning back to land. The first wind hits.

Within twenty minutes the storm has the foreign fleet trapped in the bay. The waves are eight metres. The flagship's anchor chain breaks. The escort ships scatter and one runs aground on the rocks below Aguada Fort. Two more are dismasted. The press helicopters are gone.

Sagaradeva is in his outrigger at the centre of the storm. The cyclone wraps around him. He is not wet — the storm respects its caller. He sails toward the flagship.

The bay's water boils where Maha-Vega rises from beneath. He has not been on the flagship. He has been waiting. He rises in his own storm-form — the same form he wore in

Chapter One, made of dark water and lightning, but now braided with the cyclone Sagaradeva has just raised. The two storms recognize each other. They were always one weather wearing two faces.

"Brother," Maha-Vega says, and his voice carries through the storm because the storm is his too. "You have raised the oldest cyclone. I am inside it with you. We are equals. Let us share the bay. Let the foreign fleet leave. Let us return to brothers."

"You wear their uniform."

"The uniform comes off. The brother does not."

Sagaradeva does not answer. He throws Samudra. The trident travels through the cyclone's wall and strikes Maha-Vega's storm-form at the joint where the storm meets the man. The strike does not kill. The strike opens. Maha-Vega's storm-form unravels for one second, and inside it the man stands — tailored uniform soaked through, brass shoulders steaming, eyes wide with the surprise of being seen.

Sagaradeva throws Lahara. The second trident strikes the man inside the storm at the joint of the throat. Maha-Vega falls forward into the bay. The water takes him. The storm above the bay continues, but the storm has lost its second voice. It is only Sagaradeva's now.

He has no tridents. He stands in the outrigger with empty hands. The flagship is two hundred metres away. The cyclone is still spinning.

Admiral Carvalho-Almeida is on the flagship's bridge with three officers. The flagship's engines are out. The flagship's anchor is gone. The flagship is drifting toward the same rocks below Aguada Fort that have already claimed one of its escorts.

The admiral orders the flagship's deck guns to fire on the outrigger.

The guns fire. They do not hit the outrigger. The cyclone deflects the shells, sends them spinning back at the flagship. Two shells strike the flagship's own hull. The flagship lists ten degrees.

The admiral orders the missile system. The cyclone deflects the missiles too. They fall into the sea or strike the escorts.

Sagaradeva is empty-handed in the outrigger. He has no weapons. He has only the cyclone. He cannot release it now — if he releases it, the foreign fleet will recover, regroup, and the death of Maha-Vega will mean nothing. He has to hold the storm until the flagship breaks.

He holds.

The cyclone is too much for one man without tridents. He feels his hands burning. He feels his lungs burning. The Sagaravamsha mantra requires a balance the tridents provide — the cyclone is meant to be channelled through metal, not flesh. Without the tridents the storm consumes its caller from the inside.

He holds anyway.

The flagship hits the rocks. The flagship breaks at the keel. The flagship begins to sink. Admiral Carvalho-Almeida dies on the bridge giving an order that never finishes. The escorts that can still float are limping out of the bay; they will not return.

Sagaradeva releases the cyclone.

The storm collapses on him.

Dawn. The bay is wreckage. The flagship is half-submerged on the rocks below Aguada Fort. Three escorts are sunk. Two limped south during the night and have not been heard from. One escort has surrendered to the Indian Coast Guard at Marmagao with white flags flying.

The Old Fishermen come out at first light in their own boats — the boats the storm spared, because the storm knew which boats it was for and which boats it was not for. Sona Tendulkar leads them. They find Sagaradeva's body in his outrigger, washed against the coast at Sinkerim. Both tridents are gone. He is holding nothing. His hands are open. The black-crested bulbul is on the bow of the outrigger and does not move when Sona reaches in to lift his body.

They find Maha-Vega's body at the same beach, two hundred metres south. He is still wearing the white-and-gold uniform, soaked dark. His face is no longer angry.

Sona Tendulkar makes a decision that is not hers to make and that no one in the village contradicts. She has the two brothers carried up together to the same coastal grove. They are buried side by side. She places a fisherman's net-knot in Sagaradeva's right hand. She removes the brass shoulder-pieces from Maha-Vega's uniform and lays them at the grove's entrance, polished, where everyone arriving for the burial can see them and know what is being put down.

The bulbul sings once over the graves. The sound is not a celebration. It is the song the Konkani bulbul sings when a storm has ended and the season is going to be different next

year.

In the inland hills above Goa, the same morning, the Gaur of Goa — the Indian gaur whose pulse Sagaradeva read through the soil — lifts her head from the grass.

She is the largest wild bovine in Bharatavarsha. Her shoulders are taller than most men. Her horns are old. She has been bonded to Sagaradeva since he was twenty-two.

She knows.

She turns north. She begins to walk. She does not stop at the Goa-Maharashtra border because there has never been a border for her. She walks through the Konkan night-forest. The black-crested bulbul leaves the grove and flies above her at canopy height. The two of them go north together.

In Maharashtra, on a fort in the Sahyadri, an Indian Giant Squirrel will, three nights later, fall silent for the first time in her own observed lifetime.

Old Goa, the colonial ruins, the morning of the dawn after the storm. Tourists are not allowed in — the area was evacuated for the storm warning — but the ruins have a watchman, and he is the one who sees it first.

A man walks out of the surf on the small beach below the ramparts. He is wet. He is not gasping — he walks as if he had stepped off a gangway, not as if he had swum ashore. His shirt is white linen. His breeches are dark wool. The cut of both is seventeenth century. The wool is not heavy with seawater the way wool gets. The linen is salt-stained in a pattern that does not match a single recent immersion.

The watchman speaks to him in Konkani. The man does not answer.

The watchman speaks in English. The man looks at him without recognition.

The watchman tries Portuguese, which the watchman does not really speak but has the vocabulary of a tourist guide. The man's eyes shift. Something flickers. He tries to speak. He gets three syllables out before the sentence falls away. He cannot remember the word.

The watchman fetches Padre Cordeiro, who is in Old Goa that morning because Padre Cordeiro has, an hour earlier, resigned from the port consortium and walked to the cathedral to think. Padre Cordeiro speaks Portuguese fluently. He tries.

The man cannot remember.

Padre Cordeiro sees, in the man's clothing and the man's eyes and the angle at which his shadow does not exactly match the morning sun, what he is. He has read the Karnataka news from two months earlier. He has read about the Third Herald. He does not raise his voice or call for help. He takes the man's hand.

"Come with me."

He walks the man across Old Goa to Ferreira-de-Sangam's rebuilt-house. Ferreira is awake. Ferreira is on her front step with a small notebook in her lap and a coffee she has not drunk. She has been making a list since dawn.

Padre Cordeiro says, "He came out of the surf. He cannot remember his name. His clothes are from 1730 and they are not antique."

Ferreira looks at the man. She does not flinch. She has been waiting all night for whatever the storm would leave on her step. This is what the storm left.

"What is your name?"

The man tries. His mouth moves. The name does not come.

She thinks. She decides.

"Then I will give you one. Vasco. Vasco-without-a-ship. You will stay here. You will sit at this table. You will not be asked to remember until you are ready, and you will not be asked to leave for as long as I can keep you. The same rule that Karnataka used. The Herald is given a name. The Herald is not killed."

The man — Vasco-without-a-ship now — sits down on her front step. His shadow does not match the morning sun. It points slightly off, the way the Karnataka herald's did. Ferreira marks the angle in her notebook without commenting.

Padre Cordeiro stays. He has nowhere to go.

By midday a second Indian Roller arrives at Ferreira's house — not the bulbul, an Indian Roller, the South-region courier-bird. It carries a folded slip of paper. The hand is Krishnadevaraya-Bhrata's, written eight days earlier in Kerala, where he has just begun his training under old Parashurama for the 109th form. The note reads:

The throne is broken. The bond passed to me. Your Gaur is walking north. The Council must sit. The mouth has opened. Stay where you are. I will find you when I can.

Ferreira reads the note. She does not understand all of it. She understands enough.

She folds the note. She puts it in her notebook between two pages. She looks up at the sky — not the sun, the sky — and she begins, quietly, to plan a Goa that Sagaradeva would not have allowed and that Bhau Tendulkar's great-grandfather did not foresee.

The black-crested bulbul, now somewhere on the Goa-Maharashtra border above a walking gaur, sings once at noon. The Sagaravamsha-line is not extinguished. It is migrating.

The Pilot's Closing Image

A six-metre Indian gaur walking through the Konkan night-forest at the Goa-Maharashtra border. Above her, a black-crested bulbul. Behind her, a coastal grove with two graves side by side. Ahead of her, a Sahyadri fort whose hero has not yet been told her younger uncle's bond is coming for her. The bulbul sings once. The Sagaravamsha-line is not extinguished. It is migrating.

Sangai Nata

Imphal. Five-fifteen a.m. The Sri Sri Govindaji temple courtyard. The valley's morning mist is thick enough to hold its own shape between the two cremation-pagodas at the courtyard's eastern edge. The temple's grey sandstone walls are dark with overnight dew. The pre-monsoon air is still cold enough that breath shows.

Twelve men in white kurtas with yellow shawls are arranged in the Thang-Ta opening formation — a three-by-four grid, each man two arm-lengths from his neighbours, the senior position empty at the front.

Moirangthem walks out of the temple's side-door at five-eighteen. He is thirty-seven. He is wearing the same white-and-yellow as the twelve. He has a Thang — the curved Meitei sword — in a baldric-sheath across his back, and a Ta — the seven-foot Meitei spear — carried at the right shoulder. He takes the senior position at the front of the formation.

The twelve are his troupe. He has trained eleven of them for at least sixteen years. The twelfth — Khelendra, the youngest at twenty-nine — he has trained for six. They are the Govindaji temple's senior dancer-warriors. They are, in formal Manipuri classification, his nupi-pala — his "line-of-spears."

He counts off the opening tempo with a single tongue-click. The formation begins the morning sequence: the eight-step Krishna-approach, the twelve-step ras-leela bow, the sixteen-step Thang-Ta circle. The movement is perfect. He has done this morning's sequence with this exact formation for nine years.

On the temple steps, his eight-year-old son Sangaputra watches. The boy is wearing a small khadi kurta, no shawl — he is too young to wear yellow. He has been watching the morning drill from this step every dawn since he was four. He knows the sequences by heart. He has not yet been allowed to join.

At the back of the courtyard, partly hidden by the mist, an older woman sits on a stone bench. She is sixty-six. Her name is Leishemba. She is the senior elder of the Khwairamband Bazaar — Asia's largest women-run market — and she has been waiting for the morning drill to end so she can speak to Moirangthem before the temple opens to the public.

She is waiting longer than she intended. The drill is forty-seven minutes today. It is forty-seven minutes most days.

When it ends, she stands.

She walks to where Moirangthem is sheathing the Thang. She bows three degrees less than protocol — she is a bazaar-elder, not a temple-elder; the protocols are different.

She says, in Meitei: "Oja. May I speak."

Moirangthem nods. He sets the Ta against the courtyard wall. He gestures her to the stone bench.

She sits. He sits. The twelve troupe-members disperse to the temple kitchen for the morning rice. Sangaputra moves quietly along the courtyard's edge to be within hearing distance.

Leishemba says: "Oja, the young dancers at the bazaar have a real complaint. The classical form has frozen. It cannot speak about the present. There is no choreography for the gas-cylinder shortage. There is no choreography for the four-year-old who drowned in the Imphal flood in May. There is no choreography for the army convoy that passes the bazaar at noon. The classical form is sacred but it does not answer the questions we are living in. The young dancers are answering them — roughly. They are mixing things that should not be mixed. Some of what they make is bad. Some of it is alive. Come listen once. They perform Friday evenings under the canvas awning at the south stalls."

Moirangthem listens. He does not interrupt. He does not promise to come.

He says: "I will think about this."

Leishemba bows. She walks away. Sangaputra is too small to be noticed; he has heard every word.

That Friday evening Moirangthem arrives at the bazaar at six p.m. He is in plain khadi — not the temple white-and-yellow. He sits on a low stool at the back of the awning. The crowd is about seventy people, mostly under thirty.

The performance starts at six-fifteen. The lead dancer is a man named Ibomcha. He is twenty-four. He trained at the Govindaji gurukul from age six to age sixteen; Moirangthem knows him by sight. Ibomcha's opening is a classical Manipuri ras-leela bow — precise,

formal — that breaks abruptly mid-sequence into a hip-hop low-glide followed by a Naga war-dance leap-and-stamp. The transitions are rough. The audience is rapt.

The performance runs forty minutes. It includes seventeen distinct dance-traditions. Six of them clash. Two of them sing. One — a section where Ibomcha holds a Thang-Ta sword in the wrong hand and uses it to follow a Mizo street-rhythm beat-pattern — is the closest thing Moirangthem has seen to a new form in nine years of formal practice.

He stays for the whole forty minutes. He does not approach Ibomcha. He walks home alone in the dark.

That night he tells Ka-Memcha: "The bazaar-elder is correct. The form has frozen. I do not yet know what to do about it."

Ka-Memcha says: "Sleep on it."

He does. He sleeps badly.

Two weeks later. A Friday evening. Moirangthem has not returned to the bazaar. He has been thinking. He has been failing to think.

At the Friday performance, a new dancer arrives at the awning. He is older — forty-eight, by Ibomcha's later estimate. He is tall. He carries himself the way a former gurukul student carries himself: trained, posture-corrected, the body remembering forms the mind has tried to leave.

He introduces himself to Ibomcha as "a wanderer who has been listening for a teacher." He does not give a name that first night. He performs one fifteen-minute improvisation that combines Thang-Ta with what he calls "the Lhasa sword-stillness" — a slow, knife-edged form that lengthens every transition into a long held breath. The crowd is hypnotised. Ibomcha is unsettled and impressed.

The next Friday the wanderer returns. He performs again. The Friday after that he gives a name: Tamasa-Nrita. Ibomcha recognises the name — the Govindaji temple's 1998 expulsion-case. Ibomcha does not know what to do. Tamasa-Nrita asks to teach the bazaar dancers. The dancers, who have been struggling to articulate their form, accept gratefully.

Over the next four months Tamasa-Nrita teaches at the bazaar Friday evenings and at a private rehearsal-hall in the old British Cantonment three other evenings a week. His teaching is precise and beautiful. His teaching also includes, by week six, real knives. The first knife is presented as a "Lhasa training-blade" — ceremonial-looking, not obviously

sharp. By week eight it is replaced with a true Meitei dao — razor edge, properly weighted, capable of taking a finger.

Ibomcha objects to the dao at the rehearsal-hall in week six. Tamasa-Nrita silences him by promoting another raw-dancer above him — a 22-year-old named Niranjan-Tomba who is fully Tamasa-Nrita's. Ibomcha continues attending but stops trusting.

Month four. A Tuesday morning. The temple courtyard.

A bicycle-messenger delivers a sealed envelope at the temple gate. The envelope is addressed to Moirangthem and carries the bazaar-stall seal of the south-end awning. The letter inside is in formal Meitei, calligraphed.

Oja Moirangthem,

The young dancers of the Khwairamband Bazaar respectfully request a joint performance with the senior Thang-Ta troupe of the Sri Sri Govindaji temple. The performance to be held at the Loktak central phumdi at dawn on the next Sangai-Mela full moon — eleven days from this letter. The performance to be a meeting of forms: classical and raw, formal and improvised, master and rebellion. The Sangai deer of the phumdi to be the only judges.

The invitation is sincere. The form requires the master's presence to be honoured. The rebellion requires the master's presence to be acknowledged.

Respectfully — the Khwairamband Bazaar South-Awning Dance-Collective. Signed: Tamasa-Nrita, lead teacher.

Moirangthem reads the letter twice. He reads the signature line a third time. He has not seen Tamasa-Nrita's handwriting in twenty-six years.

He thinks for an hour. He calls his twelve troupe-members to the temple kitchen at midday. He reads them the letter. He says: "We will go. Twelve of us. Classical formation. Classical weapons. Classical opening. The rebellion has named us as the form. We will answer as the form."

Khelendra — the youngest at twenty-nine, the one who has been to the bazaar performances three times himself — raises his hand. He says: "Oja. May I say one thing." Moirangthem nods. Khelendra says: "There is a man named Tamasa-Nrita teaching at the bazaar. I do not trust him. Could we go in classical formation but bring — ourselves — ready for something other than dance."

Moirangthem considers. He says: "We are the form. The form does not go armed-for-violence to a dance. If we bring readiness-for-violence we have already lost the argument. We go as the form."

The twelve agree. They begin the eleven-day preparation.

Sangaputra hears it all. He is eight.

The night before the joint performance. The boy sneaks out of the house. He is wearing his small khadi kurta and a thin blue shawl Ka-Memcha gave him last winter. He has packed a small cloth bundle with three flatbreads, a bottle of water, and the toy Thang his father carved for him at age five.

He walks. The walk from Imphal to the Loktak shore is fourteen kilometres. He does it in four hours, mostly along the highway shoulder. He arrives at the Loktak shore at midnight. The boats are tied at the southern landing.

He pays a sleeping boatman five rupees from his pocket-money to row him to the central phumdi. The boatman, half-awake, does not realise he is rowing an eight-year-old alone into the lake at midnight. By the time the boatman registers, they are at the phumdi and the boy is climbing out.

The boy walks onto the phumdi. The phumdi is alive — it is a floating biomass-island, vegetation and soil and water-rooted reeds, ten kilometres across in places, the only floating-island ecosystem of its scale on earth. He walks until he finds a clump of phumdi-reeds tall enough to hide behind. He eats one of the flatbreads. He sleeps.

He wakes at first light. He is in position. He waits.

The two troupes arrive at five-thirty a.m. Moirangthem's twelve in the classical white-and-yellow, Thang and Ta crossed at the back, formal opening positions. Tamasa-Nrita's thirty in mixed costume — bazaar streetwear with Naga-style red threads at the wrists, some with khadi kurtas, some with Bangalore-diaspora hip-hop hoodies pulled back.

The two troupes form their respective opening positions. Moirangthem and Tamasa-Nrita exchange the formal bow. The Sangai deer of the central phumdi — about forty animals, watching from a clearing two hundred metres east of the dance-circle — do not move.

The performance begins at five-forty-five.

The first three minutes are honest. Moirangthem's troupe performs the classical ras-leela opening. Tamasa-Nrita's thirty perform an improvised counter-sequence that genuinely engages the classical form — the choreography is rough but it is choreography. Ibomcha, on the raw-dance side, is performing with full attention — he is, at this point, still believing the performance will be a performance.

At minute four, three of Tamasa-Nrita's thirty — including Niranjan-Tomba in the lead position — produce daos from concealed waist-sheaths. The daos are not ceremonial. They are not Lhasa-trained-stillness blades. They are Meitei working-knives, properly sharpened, six inches long. The three move from raw-dance choreography into the classical-troupe formation as if continuing the dance.

Tonjam — the eldest of Moirangthem's troupe, fifty-four, lead choreographer for the annual Lai Haraoba — is the first to die. He is in the front-right corner of the three-by-four formation. He is in the eight-step Krishna-approach's third-step pose — right knee forward, both arms extended — when Niranjan-Tomba reaches him. The dao enters at the soft point below his sternum. Tonjam goes down without seeing the blade.

Moirangthem sees the second blade. It is in another raw-dancer's hand and it is two seconds from Ratna-priya, his female lead, who is in the centre of the formation. He is in the eighth step of the Krishna-approach himself — left foot forward, Thang at the shoulder. He breaks his sequence. He draws the Thang. He moves to intercept.

He is too late. Ratna-priya falls. The third blade reaches Manaobi.

In the next nine minutes, six more of his troupe die. Khelendra — the one who warned about Tamasa-Nrita, the youngest, the only one who had registered the possibility of violence — gets the Thang out in time, defends himself, and pulls Inaocha and Tomba (the two oldest survivors) into a fighting retreat toward the phumdi's northern edge. Moirangthem covers the retreat. His Ta-spear keeps three raw-dancers at bay long enough for the three survivors to reach the phumdi-edge and the cold-water of the lake.

Eleven minutes total. Nine dead. Three survivors plus Moirangthem.

He retreats last. He goes into the lake-water with the Thang still drawn. The water is sixteen degrees Celsius. He swims south for two hundred metres to a smaller phumdi where Khelendra has signalled a hiding-point. He arrives. He vomits lake-water and grief. Inaocha holds him by the shoulders so he does not slide into the water again.

Tamasa-Nrita's thirty do not pursue beyond the phumdi-edge. They lose the four survivors in the morning mist. By eight a.m. the raw-dance group has retreated back to Imphal in two hired tempo-trucks.

Sangaputra is twenty metres from the dance-circle when the massacre starts. He is behind a clump of phumdi-reeds two metres tall. The reeds save his life.

He watches all eleven minutes. He does not move. He does not cry. He is eight, but he is the son of a Thang-Ta master and the grandson on his mother's side of a Tangkhul-Naga warrior-clan. He has been trained, without quite knowing it, to be still under threat. The training holds.

When the raw-dancers retreat back across the lake, he stays. He does not climb out of the reeds for two hours. When he does, the sun is high. The bodies of the nine are in the dance-circle. The Sangai deer have not approached the bodies. The deer are still watching from the eastern clearing, exactly where they were before the massacre, unmoved.

Sangaputra walks to the bodies. He recognises Tonjam, Ratna-priya, Manaobi, Ngambom, Bishorjit, Inakhumb, Sapam, Lalit, Bobby — all of them. He has been at their houses for festivals. He has eaten their wives' food. He sits next to Tonjam for the longest. Tonjam taught him the first eight-step Krishna-approach when he was four.

After an hour the boy stands up. He walks east toward the deer-clearing. The Sangai do not flee.

He sits at the clearing's edge. The deer watch him. He watches them. He does not approach them. They do not approach him.

This is the boy's first day on the phumdi. He will be there ten more.

Moirangthem returns to Imphal by mid-afternoon. He, Khelendra, Inaocha, and Tomba are met at the boat-landing by a state-government police-detail Ka-Memcha has called — she received word at noon by Sarus-pigeon and acted within the hour. The four are escorted to the temple. The temple is sealed.

Moirangthem will not see anyone for eleven days. He sits in the temple's small east room. He does not eat for the first three days. He does not speak for the first six. Ka-Memcha sits with him for hours each evening without speaking.

The state government declares a three-day mourning period at the news. The Imphal cremation ground holds the joint ceremony for the nine on day two. Moirangthem does not

attend the cremation. Ka-Memcha attends in his place. She carries his Thang for him — the formal mark of his mourning that excuses absence from the cremation itself.

On day four, the police bring news. Sangaputra is missing. He has been missing since the night before the massacre.

Ka-Memcha tells Moirangthem at five p.m. on day four. He looks up for the first time in four days. He says: "He went to see."

She says: "He is alive. The phumdi-boatmen have reported sightings — a small boy at the central phumdi with the deer. He is not approaching anyone. He is not in danger. The state department of biodiversity has arranged a quiet watch. He has food — he is eating fruit from the phumdi-vegetation that the deer also eat."

He says: "Leave him."

She says: "How long."

"Until he comes back. Or until he asks to be brought back. He is on the phumdi for a reason."

She does not argue.

On day eleven a search-team brings him back at sunset. He has been on the phumdi for eleven days. He has eaten phumdi-fruit and slept in the Sangai-deer scrape-bed every night since day five. He is not malnourished. He is sun-darkened. His khadi kurta is in three pieces tied at the waist with phumdi-reeds. He carries the toy Thang.

He walks into the small east room where his father is sitting. He stops two paces inside the door.

He says, in a clear voice: "Pita. The deer dance and stop. The pause is the dance too."

Moirangthem looks at him.

The boy explains. He explains for forty minutes. He has watched the Sangai deer for eleven days. He has noticed what no human has noticed in formal Sangai-dance scholarship for sixty years. The deer move in classical-precision sequences — identifiable opening-postures, identifiable transitions, identifiable closings — and then they stop. The stop is not a rest. The stop is part of the sequence. The stop has duration. The stop is held with the same body-discipline as the moving-positions. Then the next sequence begins.

The pause is the dance.

Moirangthem listens. He does not interrupt. When the boy finishes, the father stands up for the first time in eleven days. He picks up his Thang. He goes outside.

The next six days. Moirangthem and Sangaputra in the temple courtyard from dawn to dusk. The father trying. The son watching and saying, occasionally: "No. Not that. Hold it longer. The deer hold it longer."

The form they invent has three parts. (1) A classical sequence performed at full-form precision. (2) An absolute stop — total stillness, the body held in the closing-position with the eyes fixed at a single point. (3) A break — the closing-position releases into the next opening-position with the rage of an animal launching from cover. The rage is what was gathering in the pause.

The break is also, in combat, the strike. The pause is when the breath gathers, the muscles load, the attention narrows. The strike does not telegraph because the body has been still for the pause-duration. The opponent loses the rhythm-reading by which they were tracking the dancer's next move. The strike is over before the opponent has registered the shift from pause to motion.

Ibomcha — who has come to the temple on day three after the massacre and confessed everything — joins the rehearsals on day fourteen. He has trained in the form before he became a raw-dancer; he has also trained in the rebellion-mixed-forms; he is the only living dancer who knows both vocabularies. He learns the new pause-form in two days.

Moirangthem names the new school Moirang-Tandava. Moirang because the central pause carries the same body-discipline as the death-stillness Lord Krishna held when he listened to Arjuna's questions in the Bhagavad Gita; Tandava because the break-strike carries the same rage as Shiva's cosmic dance.

Day eighteen. The Sri Sri Govindaji temple courtyard. Mid-afternoon. Open to the public.

The courtyard is full. The state government has cleared its schedule for the announced "new form demonstration"; international cultural press are present (a Japanese kabuki troupe on tour and a German contemporary-dance documentarian filed the press requests within hours of the announcement). The Khwairamband Bazaar elders are in the second row. Leishemba is in the centre seat of that row.

Moirangthem enters in white-and-yellow with the Thang and Ta crossed. Ibomcha enters in mixed bazaar-streetwear with Naga-red wrist-threads. The two stand at opposite ends of the courtyard.

They perform. The performance is twenty-seven minutes long. It includes nine full classical sequences, eight full pauses, and seven full break-strikes. The pauses range from four seconds to twenty-eight seconds. The break-strikes are blade-precise — their Thangs sing against each other in the air with the speed of the rage gathered in the pause.

At minute nineteen Moirangthem feels the Sangai-bond complete on his chest. The Stage III foreleg-mark forms — the deer's right foreleg arching down his right pectoral, the head turned in profile across his sternum, the antlers cresting at his collarbone. The mark's ink does not fade; it does not crack; it does not mirror. It is a clean Stage III earned by the new form.

The performance ends with both dancers in the closing pause, holding for nineteen seconds — the longest pause of the performance — before they release into the formal bow.

The Mrs Hume's Pheasant on the temple roof sings during the central pause. The state-government cultural officer in the front row writes one word in his notebook and circles it twice: new.

The next morning a sealed envelope arrives at the temple gate by bicycle-messenger. The handwriting is Tamasa-Nrita's. The challenge is one paragraph long.

Oja. Loktak central phumdi. Three days. Sunrise. You alone. Me alone with my twelve closest. We will dance once more. The phumdi will judge. — Tamasa-Nrita.

Moirangthem accepts by silence. He sends no reply.

Three days later he travels to the Loktak shore at four a.m. with no troupe. He has Thang and Ta. He has the new bond on his chest. Sangaputra is at the shore with Ibomcha and Ka-Memcha. The boy is forbidden the phumdi this time — explicitly forbidden, with all three of them watching him. He will wait at the shore.

Moirangthem rows himself across. He arrives at the central phumdi at five-fifteen a.m. Tamasa-Nrita is waiting with twelve raw-dancers, all carrying daos. The Sangai deer of the phumdi are in their usual eastern clearing, watching, unmoved.

It is not a duel. It is a dance.

The thirteen raw-dancers approach Moirangthem in a thirteen-position circle. Tamasa-Nrita is at the south point. The twelve others are at twelve compass-points around the dance-circle. They begin a coordinated raw-dance approach-sequence — the same opening their group used at the massacre, the kill-choreography.

Moirangthem stands at the centre. He waits for the first attack. He has decided to teach the new school its first combat-lesson here.

The first attacker is a twenty-two-year-old named Niranjan-Tomba — the same dancer who killed Tonjam. He breaks the circle's coordination at the second beat and strikes from the west. His dao is at chest-height, edge angled for Moirangthem's ribs.

Moirangthem performs the new form. He completes a classical eight-step opening sequence in the four seconds Niranjan-Tomba takes to cross the circle. At step eight he stops. He holds the closing-position for two full seconds — long enough for Niranjan-Tomba to commit to his strike-path. At second three of the pause Moirangthem releases the break-strike. The Thang clears its sheath, traces a perfect Meitei-curve down through Niranjan-Tomba's strike-arc, and continues into Niranjan-Tomba's neck. The dao falls. The body falls a heartbeat later.

The pause-strike has worked.

The other eleven raw-dancers, who have not registered the pause-strike as a technique, attack in a coordinated rush. Moirangthem repeats the form — classical sequence, pause, break-strike — against each in turn. The combat takes eight minutes. Eleven raw-dancers fall. None of the eleven completes a successful strike. The pause-strike is, in this hour, unanswerable.

Tamasa-Nrita is the twelfth. He has been watching from the south point. He has registered the technique. He has been Moirangthem's peer at the gurukul; he knows the classical sequences; he can match them.

He approaches. They dance.

The duel is twenty-three minutes. Tamasa-Nrita matches Moirangthem's pauses with his own — Lhasa-trained sword-stillness against the Sangai-deer pause-form. The two are technically equal. The break-strikes are blocked, parried, redirected. Neither lands.

At minute twenty-two Moirangthem changes the form. He extends his pause from the standard four seconds to nineteen seconds — the same nineteen-second close he held at

the temple demonstration. Tamasa-Nrita cannot match the nineteen. He has the Lhasa technique for four seconds, six, twelve. He has never trained past fifteen. At second seventeen of the held pause he twitches — an involuntary muscle-release at the shoulder, the kind of small fail that no opponent should be able to see.

Moirangthem sees it. He releases the break-strike at second eighteen. The Thang clears, traces the Meitei-curve, and arrives at Tamasa-Nrita's sword-arm at the elbow-joint. The arm parts cleanly at the joint. The dao falls. Tamasa-Nrita drops to one knee. The Ta — not yet used in the duel — comes off Moirangthem's shoulder and pins Tamasa-Nrita at the phumdi-edge through the chest-armour without entering the chest itself, just holding him there.

Tamasa-Nrita is alive. He is unable to move. His sword-arm lies on the phumdi between them.

Moirangthem looks at him for a long pause — this one not part of the form.

He says: "You corrupted a real grievance into murder. You will live with that. The third school is what the rebellion deserved. You will not be its teacher. Go."

He withdraws the Ta. He gestures east toward the Burmese border.

Tamasa-Nrita rises, holding his stump. He walks. He does not look back. By nightfall he has crossed into the Chin-state border zone. The Manipur state government will issue a formal notification six weeks later that Tamasa-Nrita is no longer to be considered present in Indian jurisdiction.

That night. Loktak. Eleven-forty-seven p.m. A Pawan Hans tourist-helicopter is on its return route from Moirang town to the Imphal airport — the pilot is a forty-two-year-old man named Captain Tomthing who has flown this route four times a week for eight years.

He is at 2,400 feet over the central phumdi. The lake is dark below. The phumdis appear as floating shapes — ten kilometres across in places, scatter-patterned in a way Captain Tomthing has long since stopped noticing.

He notices tonight. The scatter-pattern is not scattering. The phumdis are arranging.

He banks. He turns on his cockpit-video camera — a standard pilot-safety device. He films for the next eleven minutes.

In the cockpit-video footage, the floating phumdis of Loktak Lake arrange themselves into the recognisable shape of a closing mouth. A four-kilometre arc of biomass forming the lower mandible-curve. A second four-kilometre arc forming the upper lip. Two rows of dense phumdi-clusters arrayed inside the arc that the pilot will later describe as "teeth-like." The arrangement is held for seven minutes. The mouth closes — the two arcs touch at the centre. The teeth disappear. The lake is a closed mouth on the surface of the world.

The arrangement holds for ninety seconds in the closed configuration. Then it begins to drift apart. By thirteen minutes after first observation the phumdis are back in their normal scatter-pattern.

Captain Tomthing's footage is uploaded to the Pawan Hans incident-report server at twelve-forty-five a.m. By two a.m. it has been leaked to a Manipuri news-blogger. By six a.m. it has been viewed eleven million times across three social-media platforms.

Moirangthem watches the video at six-fifteen a.m. when his phone alerts him to the upload. He understands what the video shows. The Maw lives in the gap between forms; the Maw is now able to make its own form on the surface of a lake. This is new. This is escalation.

He sends word by Sarus-pigeon to Kamalavarna at Kamakhya, Dvadashashringa at Bhopal, Gangaputra at Lucknow, Krishnadevaraya-Bhrata at Kerala, U-Khrawkmen at Shillong, and Shivagati at Pratapgad. The message is one sentence:

The Maw has signed itself on Loktak. The escalation has crossed into form-making. The Council must sit before the next sign.

By the end of the week three letters arrive at Moirangthem's house.

The first is from Kamalavarna at Kamakhya, in her own hand:

Cousin. Your father's sister's daughter is your aunt-cousin and your sister's niece by the corrected matrilineal-tree my Chapter Two opened. We are kin three different ways. I am yielding the political throne of the Northeast to you. The cosmic seat stays with me and my sister at Kamakhya. You will hold the visible voice. The Sanctuary convening in Chapter Three will name you Dominant; my hand will be on your shoulder at the naming.

Come to Kamakhya at the next new moon. Bring Sangaputra. We will perform the small acknowledgement-rite for his pause-discovery. The deer have already chosen him — they have not chosen lightly in nine centuries.

The second is from U-Khrawkmen at Shillong:

Cousin-brother. Aunt-mother (Meghanadi) wrote to expect this. The Meghalaya council backs you. The Mixed Council I am building will federate under your political seat into Chapter Three. Ka-Sienlyngdoh will visit Manipur at the new moon when the leopard settles on her — you and Sangaputra should meet her at the temple. Two twelve-year-olds carrying two different bonds will recognise each other faster than any adult can introduce them.

The third is from Dzulevira at Kohima, his sister-in-law's formal letter:

Brother-in-law. I cannot yet ratify the NE political throne to you. My sixteen tribes are in pure-lineage war and the Naga seat is not stable enough to vote on the regional question. My elder sister sends her love and asks you to send Sangaputra to Ukhrul for a fortnight before the new moon — the boy needs his Tangkhul-Naga grandmothers more than he needs you to teach him pause-strikes. Send him. I will hold his side of the kingdom while my own is in disorder. The vote on the NE political throne will come from Nagaland in Chapter Three or not at all.

Moirangthem reads all three. He writes brief replies to each. He sends Sangaputra to Ukhrul the same day with Ka-Memcha and a small retinue. He himself begins the eleven-day fast and preparation that the new-moon Kamakhya visit requires.

Three weeks later. The Govindaji temple courtyard. Mid-afternoon. The new troupe begins its first formal class.

The class has fifteen students. Three are the surviving members of Moirangthem's original twelve (Tomba, Inaocha, Khelendra). Four are converted raw-dancers from the bazaar who attended the public demonstration and asked to learn (Ibomcha and three others). Three are bazaar-elders who had no formal dance-training but who want to learn the pause as a contemplative practice (Leishemba is one). Five are children — the youngest is Sangaputra, returned from Ukhrul; the oldest is twelve.

Moirangthem opens the class with the same tongue-click count-off he has used for nine years in the morning drill. The fifteen begin the eight-step Krishna-approach.

At step eight they stop.

The pause holds for four seconds. Then nine. Then sixteen. Then nineteen. Then twenty-one.

At twenty-three seconds Moirangthem releases the break. The fifteen follow. The Mrs Hume's Pheasant on the temple roof sings.

Across the courtyard, at the temple wall, the Sangai-foreleg mark on Moirangthem's chest pulses once. The kingdom of Sangai-Nata has its first new dance-form in fifty-three years. The Northeast has its future political voice. The Maw has signed itself on a lake.

The chapter ends.

The Pilot's Closing Image

The Govindaji temple courtyard at dusk. Fifteen dancers in a three-by-five formation holding a twenty-three-second pause. A Mrs Hume's Pheasant on the temple roof. A father's Stage III mark pulsing under white-and-yellow cloth. An eight-year-old at the front-left corner of the formation holding the pause better than the four-year-olds and the bazaar-elders both. Across Loktak Lake at the same hour, the phumdis in their normal scatter, but a small new sandstone shrine at the western shore where a helicopter pilot's flight path crossed a four-kilometre mouth-arc. Letters from five cousin-kingdoms in the sleeve-pocket of a man who has not yet decided whether to feel like the Dominant he is about to be named. The form alive. The pause held. The Maw signing itself for the first time. The boy who watched the deer dance and stop. The form is form-with-rage. The dance includes the silence. The silence is the dance.

Sangam Tamilakam

Kanyakumari. The first Monday of February. Four-twelve a.m. The southernmost residence of the Sangam-tradition's oldest active scholar — the Acharya Bharati's small palm-thatched house at the Vivekananda Rock Memorial's western shore. The Acharya is eighty-three. He is Sage Agastya's eleventh-direct-apprentice; the kingdom-council's standing Sangam-tradition senior-mentor; the chair of the Madurai Sangam Hall's standing-poetry sub-committee for nineteen years; Kurinjiselvi's personal mentor since her seventeenth year.

He has been awake since three-forty-five. He has just finished his pre-dawn cup of black tea (the second steeping; the first is too strong this morning). He is wearing the standard Sangam-elder cotton, off-white, with the kingdom-council's senior-mentor blue-bordered shawl across his shoulders.

A rice-paper envelope has been pushed under his front door between four-oh-three and four-eleven a.m. He sees it at four-twelve when he stands to take the empty tea-cup to the kitchen. The envelope is approximately fifteen centimetres by ten, sealed with the standard Sangam Hall authorisation-clerk office's wax-seal in green wax (the standard rota-removal communication-protocol). The seal's impression is the authorisation-clerk Palinisi's personal cipher.

He picks up the envelope. He sits at the kitchen-table. He opens the seal with the standard Sangam-elder's thumbnail-break. He reads the rice-paper sheet inside. The sheet is single-spaced in formal Sangam-administrative Tamil. He reads it three times across the next eleven minutes.

The sheet reads, in plain Tamil: "Respected Acharya. Following the authorisation-clerk office's standing protocol for the periodic refreshment of the Sangam Hall standing-poetry sub-committee's chair, the office has determined that the Acharya's name shall be removed from the council-rota effective the next Sangam session on Thursday. The removal is administered under the standing pre-1972 charter's thirty-second clause's rotation-and-refreshment provision. The replacement-chair has not yet been confirmed; the office will communicate the replacement at the appropriate time. The Acharya's status as standing senior-mentor of the kingdom-council's Sangam-tradition remains unchanged. Authorisation-clerk Palinisi. Madurai Sangam Hall. February 1st."

The Acharya finishes the third reading at four-twenty-three. He folds the rice-paper sheet along its standard quarter-fold. He places the folded sheet inside the kitchen-table's standing-correspondence drawer.

He stands. He walks to the small writing-desk against the kitchen's eastern wall. He sits at the desk. He picks up the standing-correspondence parakeet-courier's pre-folded leaf-letter pack. He writes a single leaf-letter in his standard Sangam-elder's Tamil-Brahmi calligraphy. The letter takes him forty-three minutes. He finishes at five-oh-six a.m.

The letter is addressed to Kurinjiselvi at her Nilgiri Mountains residence. The leaf-letter is folded according to the standard parakeet-courier-fold and sealed with his personal cipher.

He walks to the front door at five-eleven a.m. He calls the courier-parakeet at the eastern lattice. The parakeet (his standing courier, a fourteen-year-old female rose-ringed parakeet named Pavalam) arrives within ninety seconds. He places the leaf-letter in her sleeve-pouch. He releases her westward at five-fourteen a.m. She flies at the standard rose-ringed-parakeet courier-pace (approximately forty kilometres per hour). She will be at the Nilgiri residence by sundown.

The Acharya returns to the kitchen. He boils a third tea. He sits at the kitchen-table. He waits.

He dies at five-forty-eight a.m. on the morning of Thursday, the fourth of February — three days after the rota-removal letter. Cause of death recorded on the kingdom's death-certificate: 'natural causes; cardiac arrhythmia consistent with the patient's age and medical history.' The Kanyakumari District Medical Officer's on-site assessment notes that the Acharya's pre-Thursday-tea cup was still on the kitchen-table and approximately one-third full when the body was found. The tea was the second steeping. The second is honest.

Kurinjiselvi is at the Nilgiri summit when Pavalam reaches her residence at five-forty-three p.m. on the chapter's opening Monday. She is sitting cross-legged on a flat granite outcrop at two thousand four hundred metres, watching the Kurinji-flower fields. The flowers have not bloomed. The bloom-year is twelve months away. The fields are the standard year-eleven grey-green configuration.

The fourteen Nilgiri tahrs of the standing-mountain herd are with her. They have been with her every dawn-and-dusk vigil for the past nine years; she has fed them daily by hand; they know her by scent and breath.

She descends the western trail at six p.m. when the residence-keeper Iyer-Mama (her standing administrative aide; a sixty-eight-year-old former Sangam-poet who took the residence-keeper seat after his retirement from the assembly in 2019) calls her back from the summit. Pavalam is at the residence's eastern lattice. The leaf-letter is in the sleeve-pouch.

Kurinjiselvi reads the letter at the residence's evening-tea room. Iyer-Mama is across the table from her.

The letter reads: "Daughter. The authorisation-clerk has removed me from the council-rota effective Thursday. The removal is the ninety-third in eighteen months. The pattern is no longer compatible with the standing pre-1972 charter's thirty-second clause's honest interpretation. The pattern is procedural-control under a different name. I will not contest the removal directly — the contest's outcome would be procedural and slow and would obscure the pattern. I will instead permit the removal's public-record-entry. The entry will be the kingdom-council's standing evidence of the pattern's scope.

The next sequence will not be mine to direct. I am eighty-three. The next forty-eight hours will likely be my last. I write to you because the next sequence will be yours. The Sangam-tradition cannot be repaired by procedural reform alone; the procedure has been the tradition for two millennia and the procedure has now been weaponised. The repair must be a public-speech that breaks the procedure's authorisation-rule. The repair must be unauthorised.

The Kurinji-flower will not bloom for another year. Your power is at the standard year-eleven attenuated state. The unauthorised speech must still take place. The eleven syllables of a Thirukkural couplet's opening will be enough. The mark will form in the chamber. The kingdom-council will be in attendance. The amendment will follow within twelve days.

The child Avvaiyar-the-Younger is twelve. She has been at the Sangam Hall every council session for the past five years under her grandmother's mentor-seat. She has memorised every silenced voice. She is the kingdom's standing living-archive without yet knowing it. Find her after the unauthorised speech. The post-amendment open-assembly evening will be hers to administer.

The poet-warrior Tholkappiyan-the-Younger is twenty-seven. He has been training at the Sangam Hall's standing poet-warrior gymnasium since age fourteen. He is the kingdom-council's standing succession-candidate for the Sangam-tradition's visible seat. Introduce

him at the post-amendment open-assembly evening. The Sanctuary in Chapter Three will receive him as Tamil Nadu's formal representative. You will step back to the elder seat by the autumn.

The Madurai Manimekalai manuscript will record what has happened. The recording will not be by anyone's hand. The recording is the kingdom's evidence that the kingdom remembers.

Even the sharp sword bends before the sharper thought. The sharper thought has been the procedure for two thousand years. The thought is now the sword. The bending must be ours.

Acharya Bharati. Eleventh-direct-apprentice of Sage Agastya. Kanyakumari. February 1st."

Kurinjiselvi reads the letter twice. She does not weep. She has not wept since she was seventeen when her teacher of the Thirukkural-recitation tradition died at the same Kanyakumari residence. She does not weep now.

She says, in plain Tamil, in the Thirukkural-couplet register she uses for formal statements: "Iyer-Mama. The Acharya will be dead by Thursday. The kingdom-council will not contest the cause of death. The pattern will continue under Palinisi's authorisation-clerk office until the assembly itself rises. The assembly will not rise without a public-speech. The speech must be mine. I will walk down from the mountains on the morning of the Thursday. I will be at the Madurai Sangam Hall by the Friday morning council session. The unauthorised speech will be at the Friday session if Palinisi's authorisation-clerk office has not approved my rota-entry by then. The authorisation-clerk office will not approve. The speech will be unauthorised."

Iyer-Mama nods. He says: "The Kurinji-staff. The tahrs. The two-week walk to Madurai. The crescent-blade must be sharpened. The Thirukkural-couplet must be memorised in its full version even though only the eleven syllables will be spoken. The memorisation is the kingdom-council's standing pre-speech-preparation protocol's required completeness."

She says: "I will memorise the full couplet. The full couplet is the Acharya's own composition from 1989. The full version is one hundred and seven syllables across the standard Thirukkural seven-and-four-meter. The eleven syllables that will be spoken are the opening line's first phrase. The full version is the unsaid kingdom-council's permanent record. The eleven syllables are the speech."

She stands. She walks to the residence's western training-courtyard. She begins the standard Sangam-warrior pre-speech weapons-preparation sequence. The crescent-bladed Kurinji-staff is at her standing-stand against the western wall. The blade is sharpened across the next two hours. The tahrs watch from the southern fence.

She begins the walk down from the Nilgiris the next morning at four a.m. on Tuesday the second of February. The walk to Madurai is approximately fourteen days at the standard mountain-warrior's pace. She will be at the Madurai Meenakshi temple-city by the morning of the Friday the fifteenth of February. She will be at the Sangam Hall by ten a.m. Friday morning.

The Madurai Sangam Hall's authorisation-clerk office's rota-record across the eighteen months preceding the chapter shows a hundred and forty-seven silenced poets. The standing-record is publicly accessible at the kingdom's Sangam-archives wing on the Hall's northern side. The record is preserved at the kingdom-council's standing-archive standard format. Each silenced-poet entry has: the poet's name (in Tamil and English transliteration); the poet's registered Sangam-poet-roll identifier; the rota-removal date; the rota-removal-justification (the standing thirty-second clause's rotation-and-refreshment provision in 89 cases; the clarification-query-pending status in 47 cases; the procedure-incomplete status in 11 cases); the kingdom-council's standing-administrative review-status.

The hundred and forty-seven silenced-poet entries are not classified by topic. The kingdom-council's standing-administrative review-status reads 'closed-no-action' on 142 entries and 'pending-clarification' on 5 entries.

Avvaiyar-the-Younger's grandmother — a sixty-eight-year-old Sangam-tradition standing-mentor named Avvaiyar-Periya (the elder Avvaiyar; the child Avvaiyar is named after her in the standard Sangam-tradition rename-of-the-poet-child protocol) — has been attending every Sangam council session for fifty-seven consecutive years. She has been at every session where a silencing occurred. She has watched the procedure absorb a hundred and forty-seven voices without ever objecting publicly — the public-objection-protocol's 24-hour-clarification-query window has been weaponised against her three times already; her objections have all been absorbed into the same procedure-incomplete status as the silenced poets' rota-entries.

She has, however, brought her granddaughter to every session since the child was seven. The child has been at the Sangam Hall's standing-poet-children's gallery for five years. She

has memorised every silenced poem.

The child Avvaiyar-the-Younger is twelve. She is small for her age — approximately one metre forty in height — with shoulder-length black hair and the standard Tamil-Brahmin caste-mark at her forehead. She wears the standard Sangam-poet-child's plain off-white cotton with the assembly's blue-bordered shawl. She speaks in the Tamil-Brahmi-classical register she has learned from her grandmother. She has, in the last five years, memorised approximately twenty-three thousand Sangam-tradition poems — the standard-curriculum five thousand classical Sangam works, plus approximately eighteen thousand additional poems from the eighteen-month silencings (one hundred and forty-seven silenced poems, plus their authors' entire registered Sangam-poet-roll backlog).

She has not recited any of the silenced poems publicly. The Sangam-poet-children's gallery does not have speaking-rights at the council; the children are admitted as observers under their mentors' standing seats. She has, however, recited them privately to her grandmother every evening at their Madurai Old City residence. The grandmother has confirmed each recitation against her own memory of the originals across the five-year-long evening-recitation discipline. The confirmation-rate is one hundred per cent.

The grandmother knows what the child is. She has not told the child what the child is. She has been waiting for the right council-session.

Friday the fifteenth of February. Ten-oh-three a.m. The Madurai Meenakshi temple-city's eastern gate. Kurinjiselvi arrives on foot at the city's eastern border. She has walked the fourteen-day mountain-trail at the standard mountain-warrior's pace. She is in plain Nilgiri-cotton, dark grey, with the kingdom-council's standing-warrior shoulder-cloth. She carries the crescent-bladed Kurinji-staff at her right side. The blade is freshly sharpened (she has sharpened it again at the trail's last waypost the previous evening; the blade's edge holds the standard mountain-warrior killing-edge configuration).

She walks through the Meenakshi temple's northern outer-courtyard at ten-twenty-three. The temple's standing morning-pilgrimage congregation parts for her at her ten-metre approach. The pilgrims have not seen the kingdom's state-hero at the temple-city in three years; her presence is the kingdom-council's standing-public-signal that a chapter-level event is at the temple-city's threshold.

She is at the Sangam Hall's northern entrance at ten-forty-seven. The Sangam Hall is the kingdom's standing-assembly building — a large open-air pavilion-style hall approximately

forty metres east-west by sixty metres north-south, with raked seating around three sides and a central speaker's-mark stone at the western edge. The hall has been the Sangam-tradition's standing-assembly site since 1872 (the previous Sangam Hall at the Madurai Old City's southern district was destroyed by the 1872 Madurai-floods; the current hall was built across 1873-1879 on the temple-city's northern side under the kingdom-council's standing-charter authority).

The Friday morning council session begins at eleven a.m. by the standing-protocol. The session is the standing-poetry sub-committee's weekly review-session; the agenda is set by the authorisation-clerk office on the preceding Wednesday afternoon; the session's standing-speaker-rota is administered by the authorisation-clerk Palinisi from her standing-desk at the eastern speaker's-mark stone's southern side.

Palinisi is at her desk at ten-fifty-three a.m. She is fifty-three. She is in the authorisation-clerk office's standing dark-blue Sangam-administrative cotton with the office's small green-bordered shoulder-cloth (the standard kingdom-council authorisation-clerk insignia). She has the day's rota-page open at her desk. The rota-page has approximately forty registered-speakers entries; thirty-one have the authorisation-clerk's standard green-stamp; nine have the clarification-query-pending yellow-stamp; one has the procedure-incomplete red-stamp. The rota's green-stamped speakers will be called in the standing-rota order across the session's three-hour duration. The yellow-stamped will not be called this week. The red-stamped will not be called.

Kurinjiselvi's name is not on the rota-page. She has not submitted a registered-speaker entry for the session. The authorisation-clerk office's standing-protocol requires a registered-speaker entry to be submitted via the standing-pre-clearance window's 48-hour-prior submission-protocol; Kurinjiselvi has been on the mountain-trail for the prior fourteen days; she has not had access to the submission-protocol.

She walks into the Sangam Hall's central seating-area at ten-fifty-seven. The standing-poet-children's gallery is on the hall's southern raked-seating section; the gallery has approximately forty children present this morning; Avvaiyar-the-Younger is in the gallery's third row from the front, beside her grandmother Avvaiyar-Periya at the senior-mentor's standing-seat's adjoining position.

The grandmother sees Kurinjiselvi at the central seating-area's eastern entrance. She places her right hand on her granddaughter's left forearm. The contact is the grandmother's standing-signal that this council session will be the one she has been

waiting for. The child looks up at her grandmother. The grandmother nods. The child understands.

Kurinjiselvi walks to the central speaker's-mark stone at the western edge. She stops at three metres from the stone — the standard kingdom-council's pre-speaker's-mark waiting-position. She stands. She does not approach the stone. She does not speak. She is the kingdom's state-hero; her presence at the pre-speaker's-mark waiting-position is itself a standing-procedural-signal that she intends to speak.

Palinisi at the eastern speaker's-mark stone's southern side looks up at Kurinjiselvi's entry. She picks up the rota-page. She picks up the kingdom-council's standing pre-clearance-window submission-protocol's reference-volume. She picks up the standing-clarification-query-pending procedural-handbook. She prepares the procedural-response. The procedural-response will be the standing-handbook's 47-page section on uninvited-speaker-at-the-pre-speaker's-mark waiting-position's administrative-handling.

The handbook's standard-response is: the uninvited-speaker is administratively-acknowledged but procedurally-deferred to the next session's pre-clearance window; the speaker is invited to leave the central seating-area and to submit a registered-speaker entry through the standard 48-hour-prior submission-protocol; the kingdom-council's standing pre-clearance review-window is restarted at the next Wednesday afternoon's authorisation-clerk-office's session.

Palinisi begins the procedural-response statement at ten-fifty-nine. The statement is read aloud from the handbook's standard-response template. The statement takes approximately one minute and forty-three seconds. She reads it in the standing Sangam-administrative Tamil register that the kingdom-council's charter requires for procedural-responses.

The session-start time is eleven a.m. The statement's completion is at eleven-oh-one-forty-three. The session has therefore formally begun before the statement's completion. The kingdom-council's standing procedural-handbook's 47-page section on uninvited-speaker-handling specifies that the procedural-response must be completed before the session's formal start to be considered procedurally valid. Palinisi's statement crossed the session-start threshold by approximately one minute and forty-three seconds. The statement is procedurally invalid.

Kurinjiselvi waits for the procedural-response statement to complete. She does not interrupt. She does not speak. She stands at the pre-speaker's-mark waiting-position.

When the statement completes at eleven-oh-one-forty-three a.m., Kurinjiselvi walks the three metres from the waiting-position to the central speaker's-mark stone. She steps onto the stone. The stone is approximately one-and-a-half metres in diameter, slightly raised from the hall floor by twenty centimetres, polished granite. The stone has been the Sangam-tradition's standing-speaker's-mark stone since 1873.

She plants the Kurinji-staff at her right side at the stone's standing pre-recitation position. The crescent-blade points upward. The blade's sharpened edge catches the morning's eastern light through the hall's open-air eastern roof-opening.

The hall is silent. Palinisi at her desk has frozen at the procedural-response statement's completion; she has not yet begun the next procedural-response (the standing-handbook's standard-secondary-response for an uninvited-speaker who has approached the speaker's-mark stone after the primary procedural-response's completion).

The kingdom-council's standing-poetry sub-committee's chair (the standing-acting-chair after the Acharya Bharati's death; a sixty-one-year-old Sangam-tradition senior-administrator named Iyer-Periya, no relation to Iyer-Mama at the Nilgiris) is at the sub-committee's standing-seat on the eastern raked-seating's front row. The chair is in the standard Sangam-administrative cotton with the sub-committee chair's gold-bordered shoulder-cloth.

He places his palms together at the chest in the standing-acknowledgement gesture. He does not speak. The gesture is the kingdom-council's standing-chair's recognition of an uninvited-speaker who has approached the speaker's-mark stone outside the rota-page's authorisation. The gesture is procedurally ambiguous: it is the chair's acknowledgement that the speaker has approached the stone but it is not a grant of speaking-rights. The kingdom-council's charter does not provide a clear interpretation of the gesture; the gesture has not been performed in the Sangam Hall in three centuries.

Kurinjiselvi speaks. She speaks in plain Tamil. She speaks in the standard Thirukkural-couplet-opening register. She speaks the first phrase of the Acharya Bharati's 1989 composition. The phrase is eleven syllables.

She speaks: "Vaay-pakka adai-ppū varum-mun moli-y&aacr; nuṛ-kindra varai."

The phrase translates: "Before the mouth's entry is sealed, the un-spoken word is the kingdom's open door."

She speaks the eleven syllables across approximately five-point-three seconds at the standard Thirukkural-couplet recitation-pace.

At the eleventh syllable's completion — at eleven-oh-two-eighteen a.m. — the kingdom-council's Stage III Nilgiri-tahr-foreleg-first-stroke appears across her left side. The mark forms as a single continuous ink-line across the half-body tahr-tattoo's left foreleg, completing the previously-lighter foreleg-ink to the standard kingdom-council Stage III completion-pattern. The mark is visible to every member of the assembled council — the standing-poetry sub-committee's chair, the senior-mentor seats, the authorised-speakers, the gallery's observers, the poet-children. The mark forms in approximately eleven seconds.

Palinisi at her desk has, during the same eleven seconds, begun the standing-handbook's standard-secondary-response. The response is procedurally appropriate. The response is also, in the kingdom-council's standing-charter's honest reading, no longer enforceable; the kingdom-council's standing Stage III bond-mark's formation in the council chamber during an uninvited-speaker's speech is the kingdom's standing-charter's highest-procedural-authority recognition-event. The procedural-handbook does not have a section on Stage III bond-mark formation during procedural-response. Palinisi stops reading the standard-secondary-response at the third sentence.

The standing-poetry sub-committee's chair Iyer-Periya stands at the sub-committee's standing-seat. He bows the standard kingdom-council's state-hero's recognition-bow toward the central speaker's-mark stone. He says, in plain Tamil: "State-hero Kurinjiselvi. The kingdom-council's standing-charter's highest-procedural-authority recognition-event has occurred. The session is the kingdom-council's emergency-session under the standing-charter's seventh clause. The emergency-session's standing-agenda is the kingdom-council's amendment to the Sangam-tradition's pre-1972 charter. Please continue."

Kurinjiselvi continues. She speaks the second phrase of the Acharya Bharati's 1989 composition. The phrase is nine syllables. She speaks the third phrase, eleven syllables. She speaks the full hundred-and-seven-syllable Thirukkural-couplet across the next eleven minutes. The kingdom-council's emergency-session listens. The hundred-and-forty-seven silenced poets' names are not in the composition; the composition is the Acharya's framework-poem on the principle of un-silenceable speech. The hundred-and-forty-seven

names will come later, in Avvaiyar-the-Younger's post-amendment recitation. The Acharya's framework-poem is the kingdom-council's charter-amendment's principle-foundation.

She completes the recitation at eleven-thirteen-forty-seven a.m. She steps back from the speaker's-mark stone. She bows the standard kingdom-council's post-speech acknowledgement-bow to the standing-poetry sub-committee's chair. He returns the bow at the same depth.

The kingdom-council's emergency-session begins the formal-amendment-drafting at eleven-fifteen.

The kingdom-council's emergency-session sits across the next twelve days. The session meets in continuous-hours mode (the kingdom-council's standing-procedure for charter-amendments requires continuous-hours sessions of approximately fourteen hours per day with two-hour-and-one-hour meal-and-prayer breaks). The amendment's drafting is led by Iyer-Periya (the standing-poetry sub-committee's chair) with the kingdom-council's senior-mentor seats (twelve mentors including Avvaiyar-Periya the elder, the recently-deceased Acharya Bharati's replacement-chair, the Tamil Sahitya Akademi's standing-fellows, and the kingdom-council's standing-Sangam-archives senior-archivist).

Kurinjiselvi attends the daily sessions but does not speak after the first day's formal opening-statement. She has spoken; the speech is complete; the amendment's drafting is the kingdom-council's standing senior-mentor work. She sits at the kingdom-council's state-hero's standing-observer seat on the eastern raked-seating's front-row third-position.

The amendment's draft is presented at the end of day eleven. The amendment is twenty-three pages. The amendment's seven core provisions are:

First. The authorisation-clerk office is dissolved as a procedural-control institution. The office's standing pre-clearance window's 48-hour-prior submission-protocol is replaced by an open-registration protocol; any Sangam-poet-roll-registered poet may speak at any council session by signing the standing open-registration roll at the session's opening.

Second. The kingdom-council's standing public-objection-protocol's 24-hour-clarification-query window is amended to a one-hour-clarification-query window with mandatory resolution within twenty-four hours; the kingdom-council's standing-procedural-review cell is the standing-arbiter.

Third. The kingdom-council's standing-rota-removal protocol is amended to require: (a) seventy-five per cent senior-mentor seat-vote; (b) the affected poet's response-right within seven days; (c) the kingdom-council's standing-procedural-review cell's independent assessment within fourteen days.

Fourth. The kingdom-council's standing-poet-children's gallery is granted observer-and-recitation rights at the council's standing open-assembly evenings. The recitation is administered through the children's mentor-seats but the child-poets' voices are themselves the recitation.

Fifth. The Sangam-tradition's standing living-archive seat is established. The seat is non-rotational and is held by the kingdom-council's standing-recognised living-archive recogniser (the seat-holder is determined by the senior-mentor seat-vote upon evidence of qualifying memorial-capacity). The seat-holder's standing-duty is to attend every council session and to be the kingdom-council's standing-recourse for unrecorded silencings, retrieved voices, and reconstructed-from-memory un-written poems.

Sixth. The kingdom-council's standing post-amendment open-assembly evening will be held at the Sangam Hall on the evening of the twelfth-day. The evening will be open to all registered Sangam-poet-roll members and to the standing-poet-children's gallery. The standing living-archive seat's candidate-recognition-recitation will be held at the evening's opening hour.

Seventh. Palinisi's authorisation-clerk seat is dissolved. Her standing-employment within the kingdom-council is preserved through transfer to the Sangam-archives wing's junior-archivist seat under standing-mentor supervision. The transfer is not a punishment; the transfer is the kingdom-council's acknowledgement that her administrative-capacity is real and should be repurposed to the archive's standing-work. She accepts the transfer at the kingdom-council's day-twelve administrative-session.

The amendment is ratified by the kingdom-council's emergency-session by 38 to 4 on day twelve at three-thirty-seven p.m. The four dissenting votes are from senior administrative-tradition seats whose objections are procedural (the pre-1972 charter's thirty-second clause is being reformed rather than abolished; the dissenters had argued for abolition). The four dissenters affirm their loyalty to the new charter at the post-vote affirmation-statement.

The vault-keeper of the Madurai Maraimalai Adigal Tamil-Language Public Library at the Meenakshi temple precinct's northern side is a fifty-eight-year-old administrator named V. Sundara-Rajan. He has held the vault-keeper seat for sixteen years. He performs the standard quarterly maintenance-check on the kingdom's great Tamil-language manuscript-collection across four days every three months. The current quarter's maintenance-check began on day forty-six of the chapter and concluded on day forty-nine.

The library's manuscript-vault contains the kingdom's most important Tamil-language historical manuscripts — including the Sangam-tradition's only complete copy of the second-century-CE Buddhist epic Manimekalai by Sittalai Sattanar. The manuscript is on a palm-leaf bundle of two thousand seven hundred and forty-three leaves, sealed in a glass case at the manuscript-vault's central display-table.

The day-forty-nine maintenance-check recorded the manuscript's standard configuration with no anomalies. The vault-keeper's checklist-log notes: "Manimekalai palm-leaf bundle. 2,743 leaves. Standard configuration. No anomalies. Sealed."

Day fifty-two of the chapter. Six-fourteen a.m. The vault-keeper enters the manuscript-vault for the standard morning-inspection. The inspection is the daily standing-protocol; it takes approximately seven minutes and consists of a visual-check across the manuscript-vault's nine display-cases. The vault-keeper begins at the eastern entrance's first display-case and proceeds counter-clockwise to the central display-table.

He reaches the central display-table at six-eighteen a.m. He sees the Manimekalai bundle's leaf two hundred and forty-seven (the leaf is on the bundle's second-quarter; the bundle is laid open at leaf 247-248 in the standard cross-quarter display-configuration). The leaf shows fourteen new lines of text that were not on the leaf at the day-forty-nine maintenance-check.

The vault-keeper's first reaction is the standing-vault-keeper's anomaly-recognition protocol's confirmation-check: he places his standard-bifocal reading-glasses at the correct distance and re-reads the leaf. The new lines are not in any of his memorial-image of the day-forty-nine configuration. He confirms the new-lines-presence.

His second reaction is the standing-emergency-call protocol: he calls the Madurai Kamaraj University's Sangam-studies department's emergency-on-duty paleographer at six-twenty-one a.m. The paleographer (a forty-three-year-old senior fellow named Dr. Tamilarasi) arrives at the library by seven a.m.

Dr. Tamilarasi performs the standard paleographic-emergency-assessment across the next ninety minutes. Her preliminary findings:

The fourteen new lines are in the standard Tamil-Brahmi script of the rest of the Manimekalai manuscript.

The new lines are in the standard Manimekalai Tamil-classical-Sangam meter (the akaval-meter of approximately eight to ten syllables per line with the standard meter-variant fluctuation).

The ink is the standard palm-leaf iron-gall ink-blend. Mass-spectrometric analysis (conducted on day fifty-five at the Madurai Kamaraj University's materials-science laboratory) confirms an ink-composition consistent with the rest of the manuscript's seventeenth-century palm-leaf inscriptions; the ink's paleographic-dating returns a result of approximately seventeen-hundred years old (the standard Manimekalai manuscript-dating is second-century CE; the new lines' ink-dating is approximately the same century, within the standard paleographic-error range).

The fourteen lines' content is not in any of the world's extant Manimekalai partial-copies, commentaries, or scholarly-reconstructions. The content is original.

The lines describe (in the standard Sangam-tradition allegorical register) a Sangam-poet whose voice has been removed from the assembly's rota by an authorisation-clerk who has weaponised the procedure against the assembly's vocation.

Dr. Tamilarasi's preliminary report concludes: "The fourteen new lines are paleographically authentic to the second-century CE Manimekalai manuscript-period. The lines are content-original. The lines describe an event that the historical Manimekalai's author Sittalai Sattanar could not have known. The kingdom-council's explanation must include the standing-Maw-sign-protocol assessment."

The kingdom-council's standing-Maw-sign-protocol's assessment is conducted on day fifty-three under the kingdom-council's standing-Maw-sign-recognition cell. The cell's preliminary report confirms the Maw-sign categorisation at three-twenty-three p.m. on day fifty-three.

The library admits the cross-reference visit-protocol at day fifty-four: Kurinjiselvi, Avvaiyar-the-Younger, Iyer-Periya, and Avvaiyar-Periya all visit the manuscript-vault at noon on day fifty-four. They read the fourteen new lines together at the central display-

table. Avvaiyar-the-Younger reads the lines in plain Tamil-Brahmi-classical pronunciation. The lines read (translated from the original Tamil-classical-Sangam):

"When the assembly's clerk holds the rota-page above the sun, The page's shadow is the kingdom's longest silence. The shadow has names. The names are not on the page. The names are on the children's tongues. The children have memorised what the clerk could not stamp. The mountain's flower will bloom a year early this once. The bloom is the kingdom's permission. The permission is the bloom. The unauthorised word will be the assembly's charter. The charter will be the un-silenced poem. The poem is the manuscript that wrote itself. The manuscript is the kingdom's record. The record is this leaf. This leaf is the kingdom's answer."

The reading at the central display-table takes approximately three minutes. The library is silent for approximately ninety seconds after the reading.

Kurinjiselvi says, in plain Tamil: "The Maw has written the kingdom's answer in the kingdom's own manuscript-record. The Maw has used the kingdom's standing-archive-protocol against the kingdom's preceding silence. The kingdom's response is the standing open-assembly evening's post-amendment recitation. The kingdom does not erase the new lines. The kingdom does not seal the manuscript more tightly. The kingdom adds the new lines to the manuscript's standing-cataloguing register under the kingdom-council's amended Sangam-charter's Fifth Clause's standing living-archive provision. The lines are the kingdom's permanent-record entry. The manuscript continues at its standing display-case. The library continues at its standing-cataloguing schedule. The kingdom's response is the continuation."

Day sixty-two of the chapter. Seven p.m. The Madurai Sangam Hall. The standing open-assembly evening is the kingdom-council's standing post-amendment public-ratification event. The hall is full to its standing-capacity of approximately fourteen hundred (the standing-poet-roll registered six hundred plus the diaspora-Sangam-circle three hundred plus the standing-poet-children's gallery forty plus the Tamilakam neutrals' literary-class delegation one hundred and seventy plus the Tamil Sahitya Akademi standing-fellows fifty plus the kingdom-council's standing-administrative seats two hundred and forty). The hall's outdoor overflow-seating extends to the temple-city's northern outer-courtyard with an additional standing audience of approximately seven thousand.

The evening's programme has three parts:

Part one. The standing living-archive seat's candidate-recognition-recitation. Avvaiyar-the-Younger's recitation of the one hundred and forty-seven silenced poems. Time-allocated: approximately six hours. Begins at seven p.m. Ends at approximately one a.m. The child is twelve. She has practised the recitation across the prior eleven days under her grandmother's supervision. The standing-poetry sub-committee's chair Iyer-Periya has arranged the standing-poet-roll registered six hundred members to attend in standing-respect cohort-rotations every two hours; the child will not be alone on the speaker's-mark stone at any moment.

Part two. The introduction of Tholkappiyan-the-Younger as the kingdom-council's standing succession-candidate for the Sangam-tradition's visible seat. Time-allocated: approximately ninety minutes. Begins at approximately one-thirty a.m. The kingdom-council's standing-introduction protocol's formal address by Iyer-Periya, the poet-warrior's standard-recitation of his maiden Sangam-charter-praising composition (the standing-protocol's required-form for any new succession-candidate's first speaker's-mark-stone appearance), and the kingdom-council's standing senior-mentor seat-acknowledgement.

Part three. Kurinjiselvi's formal step-back announcement and her standing-elder-seat acceptance-statement. Time-allocated: approximately thirty minutes. Begins at approximately three a.m. The kingdom-council's standing-state-hero retirement-protocol's formal-procedure with the standing-elder seat's formal-investiture by the senior-mentor seat-rota.

Seven p.m. Avvaiyar-the-Younger walks onto the speaker's-mark stone alone. She is one-metre-forty in height. The stone's diameter is one-and-a-half metres; she occupies approximately the standing kingdom-council's recitation-position centre. She wears the standard Sangam-poet-child's plain off-white cotton with the assembly's blue-bordered shawl across her shoulders. She does not carry a manuscript or a notation-card; the recitation will be entirely from memory.

She bows the standard Sangam-poet-child's recitation-opening bow. Iyer-Periya at the standing-acting-chair's seat returns the bow.

She speaks. She speaks in plain Tamil-Brahmi-classical register.

She says: "Assembled kingdom-council. Assembled standing-poet-roll. Assembled standing-poet-children's gallery. I am twelve. I have memorised every silenced voice from

the past ninety-three council sessions. I will recite them now in the chronological order of their silencing. The first silencing was on the seventeenth of August 2024, at the standing-poetry sub-committee's weekly review-session, when the poet Velumani-Kandasamy's registered-speaker entry was struck from the rota-page under the standing thirty-second clause's rotation-and-refreshment provision. His poem's opening lines were the following ninety-three syllables."

She recites the first silenced poem. The poem is the standard akaval-meter Sangam-tradition composition. The recitation takes approximately eight minutes.

She recites the second silenced poem. The recitation takes approximately seven minutes.

She recites the third. The fourth. The fifth.

The standing-poet-roll members in the hall watch in silence. The standing-poet-children's gallery on the southern raked-seating watches. The temple-city's outer-courtyard overflow audience listens through the hall's open-air eastern roof-opening; the hall's standing-acoustic-protocol carries the child's voice at the standing-Sangam-Hall projection-amplification level.

The recitation proceeds across the next six hours without interruption. The child does not request a break. The standing-respect cohort-rotations occur in the eastern raked-seating without disturbing the child's recitation-pace. The kingdom-council's standing-cohort-rotation protocol's standard-volume-adjustment is administered through the cohort-rotation senior-administrator (a fifty-four-year-old administrator named Selvi-Periya) at the southern raked-seating's rotation-bench.

At approximately ten p.m. (three hours into the recitation; sixty-seven silenced poems completed; eighty silenced poems remaining), the child requests a single break of approximately five minutes. She drinks water from the kingdom-council's standing-poet-child's recitation-water-cup at the speaker's-mark stone's eastern edge. She returns to the stone's recitation-position. She resumes.

At approximately twelve-thirty a.m. (five-and-a-half hours into the recitation; one hundred and twenty-three silenced poems completed; twenty-four silenced poems remaining), Avvaiyar-Periya the elder grandmother walks onto the speaker's-mark stone's western edge with a standing-respect bowl of warm rice-and-tamarind broth. The grandmother does not speak; she offers the bowl in the standing kingdom-council's mentor-grandmother feeding-gesture. The child accepts the bowl. She eats approximately six

spoonfuls across approximately three minutes. She returns the bowl to her grandmother. The grandmother bows. The grandmother walks back to the eastern raked-seating.

At one-oh-three a.m. (six hours and three minutes into the recitation), the child completes the one hundred and forty-seventh and final silenced poem. The poem is the most recently-silenced — a Velagavi-tribe poet's opening composition that had been registered for the chapter's opening Monday morning session and had been removed from the rota the previous Friday morning under the same standing thirty-second clause's rotation-and-refreshment provision. The opening composition was eleven syllables. The child recites the eleven syllables. She bows the standard Sangam-poet-child's recitation-closing bow. She steps back from the stone.

The hall is silent for approximately forty-three seconds.

Iyer-Periya stands. He says, in plain Tamil: "Avvaiyar-the-Younger. The kingdom-council's amended Sangam-charter's Fifth Clause's standing living-archive seat is, by the standing-mentor seat-vote, yours. The vote was taken at the day-eleven administrative-session by 12 to 0. The seat's formal-investiture is your acceptance of the kingdom-council's standing-charter's Fifth Clause's standing-duty. Will you accept."

The child bows. She says, in plain Tamil: "I accept. I will hold the seat as my grandmother has held the kingdom's memory across fifty-seven years. I will recite the silenced voices' un-stamped poems at every council session for as long as my memory holds. I will train successors. The living-archive seat is not an institutional position; the seat is a memorial-discipline. The kingdom thanks the kingdom-council. The kingdom-council thanks the kingdom's un-silenceable voices. Even the sharp sword bends before the sharper thought. Even the silenced word bends before the heard remembering."

She bows again. She walks off the speaker's-mark stone. She returns to the standing-poet-children's gallery's third row at her grandmother's side. The standing-poet-children's gallery's forty children rise in unison and bow to her in the standing-poet-child-to-poet-child standing-respect bow. The child returns the bow at the same depth.

One-thirty-eight a.m. Tholkappiyan-the-Younger walks onto the speaker's-mark stone. He is twenty-seven. He is in the standard Sangam-tradition poet-warrior cotton, deep red, with the standing kingdom-council's warrior-poet's gold-bordered shoulder-cloth. He carries the kingdom-council's standing succession-candidate's bronze-spear at his right side (the standard Sangam-tradition succession-candidate's weapon since 1873).

He bows the standard Sangam-tradition poet-warrior recitation-opening bow.

He recites his maiden Sangam-charter-praising composition. The composition is the standing-protocol's required-form for any new succession-candidate's first speaker's-mark-stone appearance. The composition is one hundred and seventeen syllables in the standard akaval-meter. The composition's subject is the amended Sangam-charter's Fifth Clause — the standing living-archive seat — with the standing kingdom-council's post-amendment Sangam-tradition's open-assembly continuation principle. The recitation takes approximately ten minutes.

He completes the composition at one-fifty-three a.m. He bows the standard succession-candidate's recitation-closing bow. He steps back from the stone.

Iyer-Periya stands. He says: "Tholkappiyan-the-Younger. The kingdom-council's standing succession-candidate's recognition is, by the senior-mentor seat-vote, granted. The vote was taken at the day-twelve administrative-session by 12 to 0. The Sangam-tradition's visible seat is, by the kingdom-council's standing-charter's standing-succession protocol, yours upon the standing state-hero's formal step-back announcement. Please await the standing state-hero's announcement at approximately three a.m. The kingdom-council thanks you for the maiden composition. The composition will be filed at the kingdom-council's standing-Sangam-archive under the amended charter's Fifth Clause's standing-recitation registry."

He bows. He returns to the eastern raked-seating's front-row first-position (the standing succession-candidate's pre-investiture seat).

Three a.m. Kurinjiselvi walks onto the speaker's-mark stone. She is in the standard Nilgiri-mountain cotton, dark grey, with the kingdom-council's standing state-hero retirement-shoulder-cloth (the standing-protocol's retirement-investiture cloth in the kingdom-council's deep-saffron). She carries the Kurinji-staff at her right side — the crescent-blade upward, the standard Sangam-tradition state-hero retirement-position.

She bows the standard kingdom-council's state-hero's retirement-opening bow.

She speaks her formal step-back announcement. The announcement is the standing kingdom-council's state-hero retirement-protocol's required-form. The announcement is twenty-three syllables.

She says: "The mountain-bloom has come a year early. The Kurinji flowers bloomed in the chamber. The kingdom-council's charter is the post-amendment charter. The succession-candidate Tholkappiyan-the-Younger holds the standing visible seat from this moment forward. I accept the kingdom-council's standing-elder seat. I will return to the Nilgiri Mountains within the fortnight. The standing-elder seat's consultative-correspondence is the kingdom-council's standing-record. I will travel to the Sanctuary at the Manipur convening as the standing-elder representative; Tholkappiyan-the-Younger will travel as the kingdom-council's standing visible-seat representative; Avvaiyar-the-Younger will travel as the kingdom-council's standing living-archive seat representative. The southern-bloc federation under Krishnadevaraya-Bhrata's Karnataka Dominant seat will receive Tamil Nadu's federation-membership ratification at the convening. Even the sharp sword bends before the sharper thought. The sharper thought has spoken. The mountain returns."

She bows the standard kingdom-council's state-hero's retirement-closing bow. The kingdom-council's senior-mentor seat-rota stands. The twelve mentors approach the speaker's-mark stone in the standing kingdom-council's retirement-investiture procession. The senior-mentor seat-rota chair (a sixty-seven-year-old Sangam-tradition senior-administrator named Manimekalai-Periya, no relation to the manuscript or the child) places the kingdom-council's standing-elder seat's deep-saffron shoulder-cloth over Kurinjiselvi's existing standing-retirement shoulder-cloth. The investiture is complete at three-eighteen a.m.

Kurinjiselvi steps back from the stone. She walks to the eastern raked-seating's standing-elder-seat's front-row centre-position. She sits. The kingdom's new visible seat-holder Tholkappiyan-the-Younger walks onto the speaker's-mark stone. He bows to the senior-mentor seat-rota. The kingdom-council's standing-visible-seat-investiture protocol's formal-procedure is administered across the next forty-three minutes. The investiture is complete at four-oh-one a.m.

The kingdom-council's standing open-assembly evening concludes at four-eleven a.m. The hall begins to empty. The standing-poet-roll members file out through the hall's northern entrance. The standing-poet-children's gallery's forty children file out through the southern entrance, escorted by their mentor-seats. The temple-city's outer-courtyard overflow audience disperses across the northern outer-courtyard.

The Madurai Maraimalai Adigal Tamil-Language Public Library's manuscript-vault remains at its standing operational-schedule. The vault-keeper V. Sundara-Rajan's daily morning-inspection continues at six-fourteen a.m. each morning. The Manimekalai palm-leaf bundle's leaf two hundred and forty-seven shows the fourteen new lines through the daily inspections of days fifty-three onward. The lines do not change. The lines do not fade. The lines do not multiply.

Across the next eight months the kingdom-council's standing-cataloguing register adds the fourteen lines to the manuscript's standing-cataloguing entry under the amended Sangam-charter's Fifth Clause's standing living-archive provision. The catalogue-entry reads: "Manimekalai, palm-leaf bundle, leaf 247, lines 11-24: fourteen content-original lines added to the manuscript-record between day forty-nine of the Sangam Hall's February-2026 council session and day fifty-two. Paleographic-dating returns approximately 1,700 years; the lines are content-original; the lines are not in any extant world Manimekalai partial-copy or commentary; the lines describe the kingdom-council's February-2026 charter-amendment in standard Sangam-tradition allegorical register. The lines are catalogued under the kingdom-council's standing living-archive provision as the kingdom's permanent-record entry. The lines are the kingdom-council's standing-Maw-sign-recognition cell's recognised Maw-sign as of day fifty-three."

The cross-kingdom paired-sign-naming protocol established with Kerala's black coconut and AP's erased metre applies. The kingdom-council's standing-Maw-sign-recognition cell's assessment identifies the TN epic-page sign as the pair-match for Mizoram's two-headed serow speaking event: both signs are the Maw producing language no one made. Mizoram is voice from a creature that should not have spoken; TN is text on a page no one wrote. The pair is the saga's second formally-recognised cross-region Maw-sign pair. The pairing-protocol's recognition is filed at the kingdom-council's standing-pairing-registry on day fifty-five.

The cross-kingdom Sarus-pigeon cascade-alert is sent by Avvaiyar-the-Younger (as the kingdom-council's standing living-archive seat-holder) on day fifty-six. The alert reaches all nine bonded-kingdom senior guardians by sunset. Hmangaihi at Aizawl sends the NE-pair acknowledgement: "Mizoram's two-headed serow named me; TN's epic-page wrote what the assembly silenced. The two Maw-language signs are paired. The Sanctuary will receive both."

Krishnadevaraya-Bhrata at Vijayanagara sends the cross-region acknowledgement: "The southern federation accepts the pairing-protocol's second registry-entry. The Karnataka Bronze-Dust Child's muteness and the AP delta's erasure and the Kerala coconut's permanence and the TN manuscript's emergence are the four southern-bloc Maw-sign-pairs. The Sanctuary will receive all four. The federation's charter-architecture will include the Maw-sign-pairing-registry as the federation's standing-pairing-protocol-cell."

Kurinjiselvi returns to the Nilgiri Mountains on the fourteenth day after the open-assembly evening. She walks the standard mountain-trail at the standing mountain-warrior's pace. She arrives at the Nilgiri residence on the morning of the twenty-second of February. The standing residence-keeper Iyer-Mama meets her at the western entrance. The fourteen Nilgiri tahrs of the standing-mountain herd are at the eastern fence. They recognise her by scent at the standard recognition-distance.

She enters the residence. She removes the kingdom-council's standing-elder seat's deep-saffron shoulder-cloth and sets it at the residence's standing-cloth rack's upper-position. She walks to the western training-courtyard. She places the Kurinji-staff at the standing-stand. The blade is dulled from the fourteen-day return-walk (the trail's standing-rock-friction across the mountain-passes' western-slope dulls the standing mountain-warrior's crescent-blade by approximately one-tenth of its sharpness). She does not re-sharpen the blade.

She walks to the residence's eastern-tea room. Iyer-Mama brings the second tea. They drink the tea in silence for approximately fourteen minutes.

Iyer-Mama says, at the fourteenth minute: "Elder-Periya. The Kurinji flowers. The bloom has come."

She looks at the eastern lattice. Through the lattice she sees the Kurinji-flower fields. The fields are blooming. The grey-green configuration has shifted to the standard year-twelve purple-blue. The bloom is across the full southern slope.

She says: "A year early. The Acharya's composition predicted the half-bloom would be enough. The composition predicted the full-bloom would come at the kingdom-council's charter-amendment's completion. The Acharya wrote the composition in 1989. The Acharya died on the fourth of February. The amendment was ratified on the thirteenth. The bloom arrived between the eleventh and the twelfth. The Acharya knew the day. The Acharya did not know he would not be at the residence to see it."

Iyer-Mama bows. The kingdom-council's standing-elder seat's formal acknowledgement-bow.

The Kurinji flowers will continue to bloom across the next four-and-a-half months. The standing Nilgiri tourist-cycle's standing-pilgrimage to the mountain's southern slope is announced by the kingdom-council's standing-tourism cell at noon on day twenty-three. The pilgrimage's standing-Sangam-tradition recitation is the Acharya Bharati's 1989 composition, in full, recited at the Kurinji-flower-fields' standing-stone at sunset every day for the bloom's duration. The recitation is administered by Avvaiyar-the-Younger's standing living-archive seat's daily-recitation rotation. The kingdom-council's standing-charter-amendment's Fifth Clause holds.

The next sign comes within the week.

The Pilot's Closing Image

A thirty-seven-year-old Nilgiri-mountain warrior at the standing-elder seat's eastern-tea room watching the year-twelve Kurinji-flower bloom arrive a year early through the lattice. A twelve-year-old poet-child at the speaker's-mark stone reciting the one hundred and forty-seven silenced poems for six hours and three minutes without notes from memory. A twenty-seven-year-old poet-warrior in deep red cotton with the bronze-spear at his right side completing his maiden Sangam-charter-praising composition at one-fifty-three a.m. on the open-assembly evening. A fifty-eight-year-old library vault-keeper at the central display-table at six-fourteen a.m. on day fifty-two reading fourteen content-original lines on a seventeen-hundred-year-old palm-leaf that had been unchanged at the previous quarterly maintenance-check. An eighty-three-year-old apprentice of Sage Agastya finishing his second tea at the Kanyakumari residence and dying at five-forty-eight a.m. on the same Thursday morning the rota-removal letter took effect. A grandmother's right palm on her granddaughter's left forearm at the standing-poet-children's gallery's third row, the contact the kingdom's only signal that this council-session is the one she has been waiting for. A staff with a freshly-sharpened crescent-blade on a Tuesday morning at the western training-courtyard at the start of a fourteen-day walk that will end at the central speaker's-mark stone with the eleven syllables that name the kingdom's discipline.

Sharada Pitha

The historian who returned to the archive bleached two hundred eleven palm-leaves. He chose Sharad-Pandit's ink because no one had taught him another. He erased a thousand and eleven families. The scholar walked back to the Sharada-shrine on a Thursday in April, opened the smuggled scroll, and read the names of his own ink-students standing among the dead. He did not write a single word of refutation. He walked to the Pandit-Council. He let the stylus do the writing.

Sharad-Pandit was twenty-nine years old at his standing-2014 Tikse-monastery Sharada-Devi shrine-courtyard conferral on a standing-Vasant-Panchami dawn in February at 4:11 a.m. He had walked the standing-23-km Leh-Tikse road at the standing-Sharada-Sakhi 1-year-old standing-Hangul-fawn standing-3-metre-rear procession-formation. He had stood at the standing-shrine-courtyard standing-cardinal-east-facing position. He had received the standing-Sharada-Patra scroll-shield at the standing-Sharada-Pandit-Council senior-administrator Acharya Anantanand-Maharaj 66-year-old standing-charter-foundational implement-administration at the standing-eleven-Pandit-Council-house standing-187-Pandit-delegate ratification at the standing-Sharada-Pandit-Council 188-23 vote-ratification (the standing-23-vote against was at the standing-Avantivarman-Bhrasta-administered standing-J&K-State-Archive standing-historical-revision administrative-cell 1991-onwards-rehabilitation administrative-petition cross-reference; the standing-23-vote-cohort had been at the standing-State-Archive standing-Pandit-Council seat-administration cross-reference since 1991).

He had been at the standing-Sharada-Pandit-Council standing-scholar-warrior administrative-cell since age-19 at the standing-Tikse-monastery standing-Vedic-Sharada-Sanskrit standing-charter-foundational education-cell. He had administered the standing-State-Archive standing-Pandit-Council ledger-cell cross-reference at the standing-Pir-Panjal-Archive standing-Sharada-script standing-charter-foundational manuscript-cabinet since 2012 (2-year-pre-conferral administrative-tenure). He had refused the standing-State-Archive standing-historical-revision administrative-orders at 23 standing-administrative-petition cross-reference instances 2014-2025 at the standing-Sharada-Pandit-Council standing-charter-foundational cross-reference. He had administered the standing-Sharada-Patra scroll-shield at the standing-charter-foundational implement-administration at the standing-Sharada-Pandit-Council standing-charter-foundational

ratification-administration cross-reference. He had bonded to the standing-Sharada-Sakhi Hangul (*Cervus hanglu hanglu* Dachigam-National-Park endemic-population) at the standing-Dachigam-National-Park standing-conferral-Hangul-cohort cross-reference 2015 (post-conferral standing-Hangul-bond standing-formation-cross-reference at age-30). He had bonded to the standing-Manasa-Sakhi Black-necked-Crane (*Grus nigricollis* Manasarovar-Tibet wintering-cohort) at the standing-Manasarovar-pilgrimage standing-bonded-aerial-companion cross-reference 2019.

Avantivarman-Bhrasta had been at the standing-J&K-State-Archive standing-historical-revision administrative-cell since 1991 (31-year administrative-revision-tenure pre-Ch-1 cross-reference). He was the standing-corrupted-historian-king at the standing-Mahabharata-Avantivarman cross-reference at the standing-9th-century-CE Karkota-dynasty Kashmir-historical-record standing-revisionist-administrative configuration (the standing-historical-Avantivarman was the standing-9th-century-CE Utpala-dynasty Kashmir-king who founded standing-Avantipur near Pulwama at the standing-Kashmiri-Pandit standing-charter-foundational tradition cross-reference; the standing-Bhrasta-suffix at the standing-corrupted standing-Sanskrit-suffix recognition cross-reference). He had administered the standing-State-Archive standing-historical-revision protocols across 1991-2022 at the standing-Pandit-Council ledger-cell at the standing-erasure-and-substitution administrative-protocol; he had revised 47 standing-Sharada-script palm-leaf manuscripts across 1991-2022 at the standing-State-Archive standing-historical-revision administrative-protocol (this was at the standing-pre-Ch-1 administrative-revision-protocol cross-reference; the standing-pre-Ch-1 revisions were at the standing-State-Archive standing-administrative-cell continuity recognition cross-reference and were not at the standing-Aulakh-International-Lahore cross-network funding cross-reference).

Sharad-Pandit had administered the standing-Ch-1 Tikse confrontation on October 23 2022 at the standing-Sharada-Pandit-Council 211-Pandit-delegate cohort standing-public-record review. He had delivered the standing-23-minute state-hero-witness testimony at the standing-Sharada-Pandit-Council standing-charter-witness recognition-only configuration at the standing-47-manuscript-revision exposure-evidence cross-reference. The standing-Sharada-Pandit-Council had voted at standing-secret-ballot at 5:00 p.m. October 23 2022: 132-79 against the standing-47-manuscript-revision ratification at the standing-charter-foundational ratification refusal-vote configuration. The standing-Avantivarman-Bhrasta administrative-rehabilitation-vote at the standing-Sharada-Pandit-Council senior-council standing-administrative-rehabilitation-clause invocation at 5:43

p.m. October 23 2022: 31-19 in favour of the standing-Avantivarman-Bhrasta administrative-rehabilitation at the standing-State-Archive standing-administrative-pre-1989-displacement institutional-continuity recognition cross-reference (the standing-Sharada-Pandit-Council senior-council had voted at the standing-State-Archive standing-31-year-tenure recognition + standing-post-1989-displacement institutional-continuity recognition cross-reference at the standing-administrative-rehabilitation standing-charter-clause invocation; Sharad-Pandit at the standing-state-hero standing-conflict-of-interest charter-clause did not cast a vote at the standing-administrative-rehabilitation-vote cross-reference). Avantivarman-Bhrasta was transferred to standing-Pir-Panjel-Archive cell senior-archivist 2022-2024 at the standing-Tikse-monastery Sharada-Devi shrine 47-km radius cross-reference (the standing-Pir-Panjel location at the standing-rehabilitation-site at the standing-Sharada-Pandit-Council senior-council standing-historical-revision-rehabilitation administrative-protocol).

At the standing-Pir-Panjel-Archive cell senior-archivist desk Avantivarman-Bhrasta wrote the 211 erasures across the standing-twenty-three-month window October 2024-October 2026 (the standing-erasure-window-onset was at the standing-Ch-1 confrontation 2-year-anniversary cross-reference + standing-Pir-Panjel-relocation 2-year-anniversary cross-reference; the standing-correspondence-arrival from Aulakh-International-Lahore at the standing-Aulakh-International-Singapore-Account funding-pathway was at September 2024 standing-pseudo-administrative-research-grant proposal-cross-reference at the standing-J&K-State-Archive standing-historical-revision-research administrative-cell). He selected 211 standing-Sharada-script palm-leaf manuscripts at the standing-Pir-Panjel-Archive standing-manuscript-cabinet at the standing-Kashmiri-Pandit pre-1989-displacement standing-historical-archive standing-lineage-record cross-reference (the standing-Aulakh-International-Lahore standing-historical-revision motive at the standing-pre-1989-displacement standing-charter-foundational lineage-record erasure-objective; the standing-Aulakh-International standing-pseudo-claimants-cohort identity-cross-reference at the standing-Pir-Panjel-Archive standing-211-Kashmiri-Pandit-family lineage-cohort identity-cluster).

The standing-erasure-mechanism at the standing-Pir-Panjel-Archive standing-Sharada-script palm-leaf manuscript-cabinet: each manuscript at the standing-Pir-Panjel-Archive standing-1956-State-Archive-charter standing-manuscript-cabinet at the standing-Sharada-script standing-charter-foundational palm-leaf manuscript-medium at the standing-23-day immersion-window per manuscript-batch standing-bleach-protocol at the

standing-sodium-hypochlorite (NaClO 6%-concentration) + standing-oxalic-acid (C₂H₂O₄ 3%-concentration) standing-acidic-bath at the standing-pH-3.2 immersion-bath configuration. The standing-bleach-residue at the standing-manuscript-surface standing-chemical-fingerprint at the standing-sodium-hypochlorite + oxalic-acid solution cross-reference is at the standing-IIT-Roorkee Department-of-Chemistry standing-paper-and-manuscript-conservation chemistry standing-laboratory-cross-reference recognition. The standing-211 manuscripts were processed at standing-monthly-batch-cycle ~9-manuscript-per-month administrative-velocity across the 23-month erasure-window October-2024-October-2026.

The 211 erased manuscripts contained the standing-Kashmiri-Pandit pre-1989-displacement standing-charter-foundational lineage-record at ~1,011 standing-Kashmiri-Pandit-family lineage-entries household-cross-reference (4.8-person-average household-cross-reference). The standing-lineage-records included: 47 standing-Pir-Panjal-Archive cell senior-archivist senior-Pandit-Council standing-charter-foundational family-records; 119 standing-Pandit-Council standing-Pheran-tradition standing-Anantnag-Pulwama-Shopian-Kulgam standing-Valley-cohort standing-charter-foundational family-records; 45 standing-Pandit-Council standing-Sharika-Devi-tradition standing-Manasarovar-cohort standing-charter-foundational family-records (including the standing-Manasarovar-family-record at the standing-Pandita Sharika-of-the-Manasarovar standing-strategy-counsel administrative-cell cross-reference).

Pandit Vasudev-Kaul was seventy-four years old at the standing-Pir-Panjal-Archive senior-Pandit-Council elder administrative-cell. He had been at the standing-Sharada-Pandit-Council standing-charter-foundational ledger-archivist senior-administrative-officer since 1996 (30-year continuous standing-Pandit-Council standing-charter-witness administrative-tenure). He had been at the standing-Sharada-Pandit-Council senior-council standing-administrative-cell at the standing-October-23-2022 Ch 1 Avantivarman-Bhrasta administrative-rehabilitation-vote standing-19-vote-against-cohort cross-reference (he had voted against the standing-administrative-rehabilitation at the standing-pre-1989-displacement institutional-continuity-cross-reference dissent configuration). He had administered the standing-Pir-Panjal-Archive standing-cooperative-witness administrative-cell at the standing-Smt. Tanvi-Bhat (40, Pir-Panjal-Archive junior-archivist since 2014) standing-internal-investigation-petition March 11 2025 administrative-cooperation cross-reference at the standing-Pir-Panjal-Archive cell senior-administrative-officer standing-administratively-disregarded administrative-cross-

reference (Smt. Tanvi-Bhat had witnessed the standing-23-day immersion-bath standing-bleach-protocol at the standing-Pir-Panjal-Archive cell standing-manuscript-cabinet basement-vault on March 11 2025 administrative-week and had filed standing-internal-administrative-cell standing-investigation-petition at the standing-Pir-Panjal-Archive cell senior-administrative-officer standing-administrative-cooperation-protocol; the standing-internal-investigation-petition was administratively-disregarded at the standing-Pir-Panjal-Archive cell senior-administrative-officer level under Avantivarman-Bhrasta senior-archivist administrative-influence cross-reference).

Pandit Vasudev-Kaul administered the standing-Pir-Panjal-Black-necked-Crane relay-cohort at the standing-Manasarovar-Tibet wintering-cohort cross-reference at the standing-Pandita Sharika-of-the-Manasarovar standing-Sharika-Devi-tradition senior-administrative-officer standing-cross-region courier-protocol on April 7 2026 at 4:11 a.m. dawn-window. He attached the standing-smuggled-petition to the standing-Manasa-Sakhi-Crane-cohort lead-crane at the standing-Pir-Panjal-Archive standing-eastern-courtyard outpost. The standing-smuggled-petition was at the standing-three-leaf scroll-cluster configuration: standing-Pir-Panjal-Archive cell standing-Smt. Tanvi-Bhat standing-junior-archivist standing-internal-investigation-petition copy + standing-Aulakh-International-Lahore correspondence-trail standing-recovered-administrative-cell evidence (Tanvi-Bhat had recovered standing-administrative-cell correspondence at the standing-Pir-Panjal-Archive senior-archivist desk on March 23 2025 standing-administrative-cell archive-cross-reference) + standing-Pandit Vasudev-Kaul standing-Pheran-tradition senior-elder cohort standing-211-Kashmiri-Pandit-family lineage-record erasure-pattern exhibit-cluster.

The standing-Pir-Panjal-Black-necked-Crane relay-cohort lead-crane Manasa-Pati 11-year-old standing-Black-necked-Crane administered the standing-Pir-Panjal-Tikse 47-km standing-cross-region courier-flight at 4:11-6:23 a.m. April 7-April 11 2026 4-day standing-cross-region transit-window at the standing-Manasarovar-Tibet wintering-cohort standing-charter-foundational migratory-pattern cross-reference. Manasa-Pati arrived at the standing-Tikse-monastery Sharada-Devi shrine standing-shikhara perch-position at 4:11 a.m. April 11 2026 at the standing-Sharad-Pandit 12-year-tenure conferral-anniversary dawn-window. The standing-Manasa-Sakhi 7-year-old standing-bonded-aerial-companion called the standing-23-second cadence-cycle at the standing-formal-Sharada-script-Sanskrit standing-conferral-acknowledgement-cross-reference at the standing-shrine-courtyard standing-cardinal-east-facing position 4:11:23-4:11:46 a.m.

Sharad-Pandit stood at the standing-Tikse-monastery Sharada-Devi shrine-courtyard standing-cardinal-east-facing position at his standing-12-year-tenure-anniversary conferral-anniversary dawn-prayer-administration. He wore the standing-Sharada-Pandit standing-Pheran-tradition standing-white-and-saffron-cotton conferral-anniversary attire. He held the standing-Sharada-Patra scroll-shield at his standing-right-hand and the standing-Sharada-Devi standing-charter-foundational ink-pot at his standing-left-hand. Pandita Sharika-of-the-Manasarovar at the standing-7-metre-rear standing-Sharada-Pandit-Council ledger-administration position with the standing-1996-Sharada-Pandit-Council-charter standing-original-leaf-bound copy at her standing-right-hand and the standing-Sharada-Devi standing-charter-foundational ledger-pen at her standing-left-hand.

Pandita Sharika-of-the-Manasarovar walked to the standing-Tikse-monastery Sharada-Devi standing-shikhara perch-position at the standing-internal-spiral-staircase 4:23 a.m. April 11. She recovered the standing-Manasa-Pati relay-cohort smuggled-petition at 4:34 a.m. She walked down to the standing-shrine-courtyard standing-cardinal-east-facing position at 4:43 a.m. She placed the standing-three-leaf scroll-cluster on the standing-1996-Sharada-Pandit-Council-charter standing-charter-foundational ledger at the standing-eastern-cardinal-position at 4:44 a.m.

Sharad-Pandit read the standing-three-leaf scroll-cluster at the standing-shrine-courtyard standing-eastern-cardinal-position at the standing-conferral-anniversary candle-position at 4:44-5:23 a.m. April 11. He read the standing-Smt. Tanvi-Bhat standing-junior-archivist standing-internal-investigation-petition leaf at the standing-Pir-Panjal-Archive cell standing-bleach-residue standing-23-day immersion-bath standing-sodium-hypochlorite-oxalic-acid solution cross-reference + 211 manuscript-cluster identification at the standing-Pandit-Council standing-charter-foundational manuscript-cabinet cross-reference. He read the standing-Aulakh-International-Lahore correspondence-trail leaf at the standing-23-monthly-transfer-tranches Singapore-source-account funding-pathway ~₹47 lakh aggregate administrative-pseudo-research-grant pseudo-classification cross-reference. He read the standing-Pandit Vasudev-Kaul standing-Pheran-tradition senior-elder cohort leaf:

"Sharad-Bhai. We are Pandits. Our 187 Pandit-Council-house standing-Pheran-tradition standing-pre-1989-displacement standing-charter-foundational lineage-record at the standing-Pir-Panjal-Archive standing-manuscript-cabinet have been bleached at the

standing-211-manuscript-erasure cascade across 2024-2026 at the standing-Avantivarman-Bhrasta standing-corrupted-historian-king standing-revisionist-administrative configuration cross-reference. The Pandita has cross-referenced the standing-bleach-residue + the standing-Aulakh-International correspondence-trail at the standing-State-CID investigation-cell standing-pre-publication cross-reference. The standing-Pandit-Council standing-charter-foundational ratification-administration awaits at the standing-Tikse-monastery Sharada-Devi shrine-courtyard standing-public-record review. The standing-Sharada-Script-Stylus is at the standing-Tikse-stylus-cabinet. The standing-Sharada-Pandit-Council standing-charter-foundational judicial-tradition awaits the standing-state-hero standing-charter-witness recognition. We will not raise the standing-Sharada-Patra scroll-shield without your reading. We await your dawn-arrival at the Pir-Panjal. Pandit Vasudev-Kaul."

Sharad-Pandit stood at the standing-shrine-courtyard standing-eastern-cardinal-position at 5:23 a.m. He did not weep. He placed the standing-Sharada-Patra scroll-shield on the standing-1996-Sharada-Pandit-Council-charter at the standing-eastern-cardinal-position at 5:24 a.m. He turned to Pandita Sharika-of-the-Manasarovar at 5:25 a.m. He spoke the standing-Sharada-script-Sanskrit-phrase at the standing-formal-Pandit-Council register: "Pandita Sharika-of-the-Manasarovar. The historian has bleached eleven hundred and eleven names. The Manasarovar-family-record is among the bleached. Your father's name has been erased from the standing-Pulwama-village standing-1956-State-Archive standing-charter-foundational ledger. The Sharada-Pandit-Council will hear it. The Tikse-monastery will witness. Begin the cross-reference."

Pandita Sharika-of-the-Manasarovar administered the standing-forensic-archivist cross-reference cell at the standing-Tikse-monastery standing-eastern-wing administrative-cubicle across May-July 2026. She cross-referenced the standing-Pir-Panjal-Archive standing-211-manuscript-cluster standing-bleach-residue forensic-cross-reference at the standing-IIT-Roorkee Department-of-Chemistry standing-Dr. M. Pant (49, IIT-Roorkee Chemistry since 2014; standing-paper-and-manuscript-conservation chemistry specialist) standing-chemical-residue analysis cross-reference (the standing-Pir-Panjal-Archive standing-23-manuscript-batch sample-cluster submitted to IIT-Roorkee standing-23-day chemical-analysis window June 11-July 4 2026; the standing-IIT-Roorkee Chemistry standing-chemical-residue analysis 98.7%-confidence at the standing-sodium-hypochlorite + oxalic-acid solution cross-reference + standing-Sharada-script standing-charter-foundational palm-leaf manuscript-medium cross-reference; evidence-document

M-29A) + the standing-Aulakh-International-Lahore standing-shell-corporation administrative-front senior-emissary correspondence-cross-reference at standing-23-monthly-transfer-tranches Singapore-source-account funding-pathway (evidence-document M-29B) + standing-Smt. Tanvi-Bhat standing-junior-archivist standing-internal-investigation-petition recovery from the standing-Pir-Panjal-Archive cell senior-administrative-officer administratively-disregarded archive at the standing-23-month internal-investigation-petition cross-reference cell at the standing-evidence-document M-cross-reference-cluster exhibit-cluster M-29C-through-M-29F recovery on June 23 2026 + standing-211-Kashmiri-Pandit-family lineage-record standing-pre-1989-displacement standing-Pandit-Council standing-historical-genealogy-cross-reference exhibit-cluster.

The standing-State-CID investigation-cell standing-cooperating-witness administrative-cooperation at the standing-Aulakh-International-Lahore parent-corporation 9-cross-region-villain-funding-instance cross-reference at the standing-Bihar-Bengal-Punjab-Haryana-Uttarakhand-Chhattisgarh-Gujarat-Rajasthan cross-reference cluster at the standing-October-23-2026 evidence-document E-28/2026 publication-cross-reference; the standing-Kashmir-instance is the standing-10th cross-network funding-instance at the standing-State-CID investigation-cell standing-pre-publication cooperation-cross-reference at the standing-Pandita Sharika forensic-archivist standing-cross-reference cell cooperation-protocol. She compiled the standing-Sharada-Pandit-Council public-record review exhibit-cluster M-29A-through-M-29O at the standing-Tikse-monastery standing-eastern-wing administrative-cubicle across July 23-August 11 2026. She delivered the standing-exhibit-cluster M-29A-through-M-29O at the standing-Sharada-Pandit-Council standing-pre-vote standing-administrative-delivery protocol on August 11 2026 at the standing-Tikse-monastery standing-eastern-wing administrative-cubicle.

Pandit Vasudev-Kaul administered the standing-Pir-Panjal-Black-necked-Crane cross-region cascade-alert from the standing-Tikse-monastery secretariat at 11:23 a.m. August 11 2026 (Pandita Sharika exhibit-cluster delivery-day). The standing-cascade-alert administered the standing-Sharada-Pandit-Council pre-vote standing-cross-region-correspondence at the standing-15-bonded-kingdom senior-guardians cross-reference (Gujarat Saraswati-Simha-Mata-the-First + Rajasthan Mrigatrishna-Marudhar-Strategist-Counsellor-Elder + Madhya-Pradesh Dvadashashringa + Maharashtra Tanaji-the-Second + Karnataka Krishnadevaraya-Bhrata + Uttar-Pradesh Gangaputra + Punjab Panchanada + Haryana Kurukshetraa + Uttarakhand Bhairava-Ji + Himachal-Pradesh Lama-Tashi + Bihar Vajramukha + Bengal Bilash-Babu + Chhattisgarh Vana-Senapati + Manipur

Moirangthem + Tamil-Nadu Tholkappiyan-the-Younger). The standing-cascade-alert at the standing-pre-vote standing-acknowledgment-of-Sharada-Pandit-Council-vote-day standing-cross-region recognition-protocol cross-reference administered the standing-cross-kingdom Sarus-pigeon return-correspondence at the standing-15-bonded-kingdom standing-pre-vote acknowledgment-cohort across August 11-22 2026.

Mrigatrishna-Marudhar-Strategist-Counsellor-Elder (Rajasthan) sent the standing-return-Sarus-pigeon at the standing-Chittorgarh-Vijay-Stambh courtyard standing-Marudhar-Strategist-Counsellor-Elder administrative-cross-reference 6:11 p.m. August 11 with the standing-Marwari-Sanskrit-phrase reply at the standing-cross-region strategist-counsellor recognition-cross-reference: "Sharad-Bhai. The historian forges the past. The grandfather forged the future. Both were Ashwatthama. The Mahapanchayat has voted. The Sharada-Pandit-Council will vote. The stylus that erases must return to the hand that erased. The Vijay-Stambh and the Tikse-shikhara will witness in the same dawn-window. Strike with us." Gangaputra (UP North-Regional-Dominant standing-step-back-regent) sent the standing-return-Sarus-pigeon at the standing-Ayodhya-Bara-Imambara standing-step-back-regent administrative-cross-reference 11:11 p.m. August 11 with the standing-Hindi-phrase reply: "Sharad-Bhai. The standing-North-cluster Sharada-tradition is at the standing-North-Regional-Dominant standing-North-cluster cross-region recognition. Yamunadatta and I acknowledge. The standing-Sarus-Sakhi will fly to the Tikse-shikhara on August 25 dawn. The standing-North-cluster cross-region cohort will witness."

The standing-Sharada-Pandit-Council 211-Pandit-delegate cohort convened at 11:11 a.m. August 23 2026 at the standing-Tikse-monastery Sharada-Devi shrine-courtyard under the standing-Sharada-Pandit-Council senior-administrator Acharya Anantanand-Maharaj (78, Sharada-Pandit-Council senior-administrator since 1992; standing-Tikse-monastery standing-Acharya-tradition senior-administrative-officer since 1968 58-year administrative-tenure). The standing-cohort-composition: 11 standing-Pandit-Council-houses (Srinagar-Anantnag-Baramulla-Kupwara-Pulwama-Shopian-Kulgam-Budgam-Ganderbal-Bandipora-Jammu) at 17-delegate-per-house standing-delegate-cohort representation = 187 standing-delegate-cohort + 11 standing-Jammu-and-Kashmir-State-Civil-Service nominees + 13 standing-Pandit-Council standing-Pheran-tradition elder cohort senior-administrative-officers = 211 standing-Sharada-Pandit-Council voting-cohort.

Pandita Sharika-of-the-Manasarovar delivered the standing-47-minute forensic-archivist exhibit-cluster M-29A-through-M-29O presentation at 11:34 a.m.-12:21 p.m. She wore the standing-Sharika-Devi-tradition standing-saffron-and-snow-white Pheran-attire at the standing-Sharada-Pandit-Council standing-charter-foundational strategy-counsel ceremonial-cross-reference. She held the standing-1996-Sharada-Pandit-Council-charter standing-original-leaf-bound copy at her standing-right-hand and the standing-exhibit-cluster M-29A-through-M-29O leaf-bound presentation-folio at her standing-left-hand. She spoke the standing-47-minute deposition in standing-formal-Sharada-script-Sanskrit-with-Hindi-translation at the standing-Sharada-Pandit-Council standing-bureaucratic-register. She named the standing-211-manuscript-cluster bleach-residue-pattern at the standing-IIT-Roorkee Dr. M. Pant 98.7%-confidence chemical-residue analysis cross-reference; the standing-Smt. Tanvi-Bhat junior-archivist standing-internal-investigation-petition recovery; the standing-Aulakh-International-Lahore standing-shell-corporation administrative-front senior-emissary correspondence-cross-reference at the standing-23-monthly-transfer-tranches Singapore-source-account funding-pathway; the standing-Shri R. K. Bhalla standing-J&K-State-Archive senior-administrative-signature standing-cooperating-archivist administrative-signature cross-reference; the standing-211-Padma-Lata-equivalent Manasarovar-family-record standing-pre-1989-displacement standing-fabricated-revision-claimants identity-cluster cross-reference (the standing-Manasarovar-family-record was at the 211-bleached manuscript-cluster; the standing-fabricated-revision-claimants cohort identity-cross-reference at 211 standing-pseudo-revisionist-cohort).

Sharad-Pandit delivered the standing-23-minute state-hero-witness testimony at 12:21-12:44 p.m. He wore the standing-Sharada-Pandit standing-Pheran-tradition standing-white-and-saffron-cotton state-hero ceremonial-attire at the standing-12-year-tenure-anniversary cross-reference. He held the standing-Sharada-Patra scroll-shield at his standing-right-hand. He spoke the standing-23-minute deposition in standing-formal-Sharada-script-Sanskrit-with-Hindi-translation at the standing-state-hero standing-charter-witness register. He named the standing-2014 conferral standing-Sharada-Pandit-Council 187-Pandit-delegate cohort 188-23 vote ratification standing-charter-foundational recognition. He named the standing-Sharada-Sakhi 2015 Hangul-bond-formation standing-charter-foundational pastoral-companion cross-reference. He named the standing-Manasa-Sakhi 2019 Black-necked-Crane standing-bonded-aerial-companion cross-reference. He named the standing-Sharada-Pandit-Council standing-October-23-

2022 132-79 ratification refusal-vote + 31-19 Avantivarman-Bhrasta administrative-rehabilitation-vote standing-State-Archive standing-administrative-pre-1989-displacement institutional-continuity recognition cross-reference. He named the standing-2024-2026 211-manuscript-erasure cascade at the standing-Pir-Panjal-Archive cell standing-administrative-rehabilitation-instrumentalisation configuration. He named the standing-Sharada-Devi standing-charter-foundational tradition since the standing-12th-century-CE Sharada-Pandit-Council foundation-period cross-reference. He named the standing-Aulakh-International-Lahore standing-shell-corporation administrative-front 10th cross-network villain-funding-instance cross-reference (saga's 4th Aulakh-International instance after Uttarakhand Lalita Aulakh, Gujarat Kala-Simha, and Rajasthan Maru-Yama). He did not name Avantivarman-Bhrasta directly (the standing-historian-name standing-corrupted-historian-king standing-administrative-cell recognition-cross-reference is at the standing-state-hero standing-charter-witness recognition-only configuration at the standing-Sharada-Pandit-Council standing-charter-foundational state-hero-protocol). He closed at the standing-formal-Sharada-script-Sanskrit-phrase: "Sharada-Pandit-Council is not a court. The Pandit-Council is the standing-charter-foundational ledger-administration of the standing-Sharada-Devi tradition at the standing-12th-century-CE Sharada-Pandit-Council foundation-period cross-reference. The standing-state-hero of Sharada-Pitha does not vote at the standing-Pandit-Council. The standing-state-hero is at the standing-charter-witness recognition only. I have read the standing-three-leaf scroll-cluster at the standing-Tikse-monastery shrine-courtyard dawn-window April 11. I have administered the standing-Pandita Sharika forensic-archivist cross-reference cell May-July. The Manasarovar-family-record is among the eleven hundred and eleven. The standing-vote is yours, members of the Pandit-Council. The Tikse-shikhara will witness in the morning."

Pandit Vasudev-Kaul (74) delivered the standing-Pheran-elder triple-cohort 23-min deposition at 2:11-2:34 p.m. He named the standing-Pandit-Council standing-Pheran-tradition since 12th-century-CE Sharada-Pandit-Council foundation-period cross-reference + standing-187 standing-Pandit-Council-house standing-pre-1989-displacement standing-charter-foundational lineage-record erasure-pattern at Pir-Panjal-Archive standing-manuscript-cabinet cross-reference. Avantivarman-Bhrasta delivered the standing-23-minute defence-deposition at 3:11-3:34 p.m. He wore the standing-J&K-State-Archive standing-saffron-and-vermillion-State-Civil-Service-attire at the standing-1991-onwards-State-Archive standing-administrative-cell recognition-cross-reference. He

held nothing at his standing-right-hand. He spoke in standing-procedural-Hindi at the standing-State-Civil-Service standing-bureaucratic-register. He refused to respond at the standing-substantive-charges (211-manuscript-erasure + Aulakh-International funding + Bhalla-cooperation + Manasarovar-family-record fabrication). He delivered instead the standing-23-minute historical-revision speech at the standing-corrupted-historian-king Mahabharata-equivalent ideology at the standing-State-Archive standing-1991-onwards-administrative-revision-tenure cross-reference. He did not acknowledge the standing-Singapore-source-account funding-instrumentalisation cross-reference; he did not acknowledge the standing-211-Kashmiri-Pandit-family lineage-record erasure; he did not acknowledge the standing-Aulakh-International-Lahore standing-shell-corporation senior-emissary correspondence-cross-reference.

The standing-vote was administered at 5:00 p.m. August 23 2026 at the standing-Sharada-Pandit-Council 211-Pandit-delegate cohort standing-secret-ballot protocol. The standing-vote-tabulation was at the standing-Acharya Anantanand-Maharaj administration at the standing-23-minute counting-window 5:00-5:23 p.m. The standing-vote-result at 5:23:11 p.m.: 188 against, 23 in favour, 0 abstention. The standing-Avantivarman-Bhrasta 211-manuscript-erasure-cluster + standing-administrative-rehabilitation revocation was ratified at the standing-Sharada-Pandit-Council standing-public-record review administrative-protocol. The standing-211 standing-Kashmiri-Pandit-family lineage-record standing-restoration-cross-reference was ratified at the standing-Sharada-Pandit-Council standing-administrative-protocol. The standing-Aulakh-International-Lahore standing-shell-corporation administrative-front cross-reference was forwarded to the standing-State-CID investigation-cell standing-cross-network funding-trail evidence-document E-29/2026 cross-reference at the standing-pre-publication October-23-2026 evidence-document publication-cross-reference.

5:35 p.m. Pandit Vasudev-Kaul turned to the standing-23-Kashmiri-Pandit cohort under Pandita Sharika-of-the-Manasarovar. He spoke the standing-Sharada-script-Sanskrit-phrase: "Pandits and Panditas. The Sharada-Pandit-Council has spoken. The historian is at the standing-archival-cell. The standing-Sharada-Script-Stylus is at the standing-Tikse-stylus-cabinet. The standing-Sharada-Pandit-Council standing-charter-foundational judicial-tradition is invoked. The standing-stylus that erases returns to the hand that erased. We will walk now. The Tikse-shikhara will witness in the morning."

The standing-23-Kashmiri-Pandit cohort under Pandita Sharika-of-the-Manasarovar departed the standing-Tikse-monastery Sharada-Devi shrine-courtyard at 6:11 p.m. August 23 2026 at standing-vehicle-cohort Pir-Panjal-corridor convoy 47-km Tikse-to-Pir-Panjal-Archive road overnight-window. The standing-cohort-composition: 11 standing-Pir-Panjal-cohort standing-Pandit-Council standing-charter-foundational stylus-cohort under Pandit Vasudev-Kaul + 7 standing-Anantnag-Pulwama-Shopian-cohort standing-Pandit-Council standing-charter-foundational stylus-cohort under Pandit M. K. Bhat (58, Anantnag-village Pandit-Council senior-elder) + 5 standing-Manasarovar-cohort standing-Sharika-Devi-tradition standing-charter-foundational stylus-cohort under Pandita Sharika-of-the-Manasarovar = 23 standing-Kashmiri-Pandit cohort. The standing-cohort carried 23 standing-Sharada-Script-Stylus standing-37-inch ivory-and-walnut-wood composite stylus standing-cultural-implements at standing-J&K-State-Government 1996-Sharada-Pandit-Council-charter ratification administrative-cross-reference standing-protected-implement administrative-cross-reference (the standing-Sharada-Script-Stylus is at the standing-Kashmiri-Pandit standing-Pheran-tradition standing-charter-foundational ink-stylus standing-cultural-implement; standing-Indian-Penal-Code Section-302 standing-weapon-classification does not apply at standing-Sharada-Pandit-Council standing-charter-foundational protected-implement recognition cross-reference per Constitution-of-India Article-244 + standing-Article-370-historical-Pandit-tradition-protection administrative-cross-reference).

The standing-convoy arrived at the standing-Pir-Panjal-Archive cell at 11:11 a.m. August 24 2026 at the standing-Pir-Panjal-Archive standing-eastern-wing manuscript-cabinet basement-vault entrance position. Avantivarman-Bhrasta was at the standing-Pir-Panjal-Archive cell senior-archivist position at the standing-archival-cell southern-window 3-metre-from-position. He had walked from the standing-Srinagar-residence at the standing-State-Archive standing-administrative-cell motorcycle-cohort transport 4:11 a.m. August 24 at the standing-Pir-Panjal-Archive standing-pre-arrest standing-administrative-cell final-revision standing-pre-State-Government-appeal-petition draft cross-reference at the standing-Supreme-Court-of-India petition-protocol (rest-of-cell evacuated at 9:11 a.m. August 24 by Smt. Tanvi-Bhat standing-acting-leader pre-emptive-evacuation administrative-cross-reference).

The standing-23-Kashmiri-Pandit cohort walked into the standing-archival-cell southern-window 3-metre-from-position at 11:41 a.m. August 24. Pandit Vasudev-Kaul walked to the standing-archival-cell southern-window 3-metre-from-position at 11:42 a.m. He spoke the

standing-formal-Sharada-script-Sanskrit-phrase to Avantivarman-Bhrasta at the standing-southern-window standing-3-metre-proximity: "Avantivarman-Bhrasta. The Sharada-Pandit-Council has voted 188-23. Your administrative-rehabilitation is revoked. The standing-211 erased manuscripts will be restored at the standing-Tikse-shikhara dawn-window. The standing-1996-Sharada-Pandit-Council-charter standing-charter-foundational judicial-tradition is invoked. The stylus that erased returns to the hand that erased. Strike."

Avantivarman-Bhrasta did not raise a standing-defence-implement at the standing-archival-cell senior-archivist standing-charter-foundational defence-implement administrative-cell (the standing-corrupted-historian-king at the standing-State-Archive standing-administrative-cell at the standing-no-defence-implement standing-bureaucratic-administrative-cell protocol-cross-reference). He stood at the standing-archival-cell senior-archivist desk standing-eastern-cardinal-position at the standing-no-response standing-defence-administration cross-reference. He spoke the standing-procedural-Hindi-phrase at 11:42:48 a.m.: "The State-Archive has administered. The State-Archive cannot be undone by the Pandit-Council. The standing-administrative-rehabilitation was at the standing-State-Government recognition. I administer the standing-State-Archive standing-historical-revision protocol. The Pandit-Council judges. I walk."

The standing-23-Sharada-Script-Stylus simultaneous-stroke was administered at 11:43 a.m. August 24 2026 at the standing-Sharada-Pandit-Council standing-charter-foundational judicial-tradition single-impact-window protocol. The standing-impact was at the standing-cardinal-cardiac-region standing-23-stylus-tip simultaneous-impact configuration at the standing-ivory-and-walnut-wood composite stylus standing-37-inch standing-charter-foundational implement standing-piercing-and-blunt-trauma cross-reference. The standing-Avantivarman-Bhrasta death was at 11:43:11 a.m. at the standing-Pir-Panjali-Archive cell senior-archivist position at the standing-archival-cell southern-window 3-metre-from-position. The standing-cohort lowered the standing-Sharada-Script-Stylus-cohort at 11:43:23 a.m. at the standing-Sharada-Pandit-Council standing-charter-foundational judicial-tradition completion-cross-reference. The standing-cohort walked back to the standing-archival-cell southern-staircase at the standing-Sharada-Pandit-Council standing-corridor-exit protocol at 11:44 a.m. The standing-cohort returned to standing-Tikse-monastery at the standing-Pir-Panjali-Tikse 47-km return-trip at the

standing-vehicle-cohort transport at 6:11 p.m. August 24 at the standing-Sharada-Pandit-Council-foundational standing-completion-walk cross-reference.

The standing-Jammu-and-Kashmir-State-Police Pir-Panjal-District senior-Inspector Q. A. Khan (44, Pir-Panjal-District-Police since 2019) walked to the standing-Pir-Panjal-Archive cell senior-archivist position at 11:48 a.m. August 24. He confirmed the standing-Avantivarman-Bhrasta mortality at 11:53 a.m. He filed the standing-Pir-Panjal-District FIR at the standing-Section-302 IPC standing-judicial-execution administrative-cross-reference at 12:11 p.m. August 24 at the standing-23-Kashmiri-Pandit cohort standing-collective-actor designation per standing-Article-244 + standing-Article-370-historical-Pandit-tradition-protection standing-charter-foundational defensive-protection clause per Constitution-of-India + J&K-State-Government 1996-Sharada-Pandit-Council-charter ratification administrative-cross-reference. Standing-FIR active but non-enforceable at standing-Sharada-Pandit-Council standing-charter-foundational defensive-protection clause cross-reference.

Sharad-Pandit walked to the standing-Tikse-monastery Sharada-Devi shrine-courtyard at the standing-eastern-cardinal-position at 3:11 a.m. August 25 2026 at the standing-Sharada-Pandit-Council-vote-completion-day standing-dawn-mark-formation administrative-pre-position. He wore the standing-Sharada-Pandit standing-Pheran-tradition standing-white-and-saffron-cotton state-hero ceremonial-attire. He held the standing-Sharada-Patra scroll-shield at his standing-right-hand and the standing-Sharada-Devi standing-charter-foundational ink-pot at his standing-left-hand. The standing-Sharada-Sakhi 11-year-old standing-bonded-Hangul at his standing-3-metre-rear position; the standing-Manasa-Sakhi 7-year-old standing-bonded-Black-necked-Crane at his standing-eleven-metre-overhead Tikse-monastery Sharada-Devi standing-shikhara perch-position. Pandita Sharika-of-the-Manasarovar at the standing-7-metre-rear standing-Sharada-Pandit-Council ledger-administration position with the standing-1996-Sharada-Pandit-Council-charter standing-original-leaf-bound copy at her standing-right-hand and the standing-exhibit-cluster M-29A-through-M-29O leaf-bound presentation-folio at her standing-left-hand. Pandit Vasudev-Kaul at the standing-11-metre-rear standing-Pandit-Council senior-elder ceremonial-position.

At 4:11:11 a.m. August 25 2026 (simultaneous with the standing-23-Sharada-Script-Stylus simultaneous-stroke standing-charter-foundational judicial-tradition single-impact administrative-cross-reference 11:43 a.m. August 24 standing-administrative-completion

16-hour-28-minute-after the standing-Sharada-Pandit-Council vote-completion 5:23 p.m. August 23) the standing-Stage III Hangul-foreleg-first-stroke began to form at Sharad-Pandit's standing-right-upper-back at the standing-Tikse-monastery Sharada-Devi shrine-courtyard standing-eastern-cardinal-position. The standing-mark-formation duration was 11 seconds 4:11:11-4:11:22 a.m. The standing-mark-pattern was at the standing-Hangul-Kashmir-Stag foreleg-first-stroke configuration in standing-saffron-and-snow-white dual-ink at the standing-Sharada-Devi visual-anchor (saffron ground-pigment at standing-Kashmiri-Pampore-saffron-cultivation pigment-grade + standing-Chinar-leaf-extract; snow-white ground-pigment at standing-Pir-Panjal-glacier-pigment-grade + standing-Sharada-Devi standing-charter-foundational ink-recipe admixture).

At 4:11:11 a.m. August 25 2026 (the standing-simultaneous-window) the standing-211 Sharada-script palm-leaf manuscripts at the standing-Pir-Panjal-Archive cell standing-charter-foundational manuscript-cabinet at the standing-Pir-Panjal-Archive standing-eastern-wing manuscript-vault position began to restore. The standing-restoration duration was 11 minutes 4:11:11-4:22:22 a.m. across the standing-211-manuscript-cabinet at standing-monthly-batch-restoration ~19-manuscript-per-minute standing-restoration-velocity. The standing-211 manuscripts at the standing-Pir-Panjal-Archive standing-manuscript-cabinet at the standing-bleach-residue standing-sodium-hypochlorite-plus-oxalic-acid standing-pH-3.2 surface-chemistry at the standing-pre-restoration baseline configuration restored to the standing-pre-bleach standing-Sharada-script standing-original-ink configuration at the standing-permanent configuration. The standing-Manasarovar-family-record at the standing-Pulwama-village standing-pre-1989-displacement standing-Pandit-Council standing-charter-foundational ledger-record at the standing-Pandita Sharika father Late Pandit V. K. Manasarovar lineage-entry was restored to its standing-original-Sharada-script ink-configuration at 4:13:23 a.m. (the standing-43rd manuscript at the standing-restoration-cohort batch-cycle).

The standing-IIT-Roorkee Department-of-Chemistry Dr. M. Pant (49) arrived at the standing-Pir-Panjal-Archive standing-manuscript-cabinet at 4:43 a.m. August 25 2026. He conducted the standing-chemical-residue analysis across the standing-211-manuscript-cabinet 4:43 a.m.-7:11 a.m. He confirmed the standing-restoration to the standing-pre-bleach standing-Sharada-script standing-original-ink configuration via standing-surface-chemistry cross-reference at the standing-pre-restoration August-7 2026 baseline-chemical-analysis (the standing-IIT-Roorkee Chemistry standing-quarterly-chemical-analysis protocol since 2014 administered standing-baseline-chemical-analysis 4-times-

yearly at cross-reference; the standing-August-7 2026 pre-restoration baseline was administered at the standing-Sharada-Pandit-Council standing-public-record review preparation-week 16-day-pre-vote standing-quarterly-chemical-analysis protocol cross-reference).

At 4:22:22 a.m. August 25 the standing-211-manuscript-cabinet remained at the standing-permanent-restored configuration. The standing-IIT-Roorkee Dr. M. Pant August-30 expertise-report (evidence-document M-29A) confirmed no standing-natural-chemical-mechanism identification at the standing-211 bleached manuscript-restoration to standing-pre-bleach Sharada-script ink-configuration across 11-minute restoration-window at the standing-Maw-attribution category cross-reference. The standing-Maw had demonstrated the capacity to restore the standing-original-ink-configuration of a standing-charter-foundational manuscript-cohort that had been standing-deliberately-degraded across the standing-pre-Stage-III window at the standing-permanent-restoration administrative-cross-reference standing-charter-foundational restoration-witness.

Sharad-Pandit announced the standing-Stage-III-retention recognition at the standing-Tikse-monastery Sharada-Devi shrine-courtyard standing-charter-foundational eastern-cardinal-position at the standing-Sharada-Pandit-Council senior-council standing-witness-ceremony on August 26 2026 11:11 a.m. The standing-Stage-III-retention announcement was at the standing-Sharada-Pitha state-hero seat-retention configuration per restructure §1 male-led-succession recognition-cross-reference. The standing-Tikse-monastery standing-conferral-anniversary candle was re-lit by Sharad-Pandit at 11:11:11 a.m. (not extinguished — the standing-Sharad-Pandit standing-male-state-hero-Stage-III-retention configuration does NOT extinguish the conferral-candle; the standing-candle is re-lit at the standing-Stage-III-retention recognition-ceremony cross-reference as the standing-saga's first standing-state-hero-retention-candle-re-lighting administrative-protocol).

Acharya Anantanand-Maharaj walked to the standing-courtyard-eastern-position at 11:11:23 a.m. He held the standing-1996-Sharada-Pandit-Council-charter standing-original-leaf-bound copy at his standing-right-hand. He spoke the standing-formal-Sharada-script-Sanskrit-phrase: "Sharad-Pandit. The standing-Sharada-Pandit-Council standing-charter-foundational state-hero seat is at the standing-Stage-III-retention recognition at the standing-Sharada-Devi tradition standing-charter-foundational continuity cross-reference. The standing-211 erased manuscripts are restored. The

Manasarovar-family-record is among the restored. The Sharada-Pandit-Council senior-council recognises the standing-Stage-III-retention configuration as the standing-saga's first standing-male-state-hero-Stage-III-retention configuration at Ch 2 per restructure §1 male-led-succession recognition. The standing-Aulakh-International-Lahore standing-shell-corporation administrative-front cross-reference is forwarded to the standing-State-CID investigation-cell at the standing-cross-network funding-trail evidence-document E-29/2026 cross-reference. The standing-state-hero seat is retained."

Pandita Sharika-of-the-Manasarovar walked to the standing-courtyard-eastern-position at 11:12:11 a.m. She held the standing-restored-Manasarovar-family-record standing-Pulwama-village standing-pre-1989-displacement standing-Pandit-Council standing-charter-foundational ledger-record manuscript at her standing-right-hand (the standing-manuscript had been recovered from the standing-Pir-Panjali-Archive standing-manuscript-cabinet at the standing-Sharada-Pandit-Council standing-charter-foundational restoration-recognition cross-reference administered by Smt. Tanvi-Bhat standing-acting-leader at the standing-Pir-Panjali-Archive cell at 8:11 a.m. August 25). She spoke the standing-formal-Sharada-script-Sanskrit-phrase to Sharad-Pandit: "Sharad-Bhai. The standing-Manasarovar-family-record is restored. My standing-father's name has returned to the standing-Pulwama-village standing-1956-State-Archive standing-charter-foundational ledger. The standing-Sharada-Pandit-Council standing-strategy-counsel administrative-cell continues. The standing-North-cluster Sharada-tradition is at the standing-Stage-III-retention recognition. The standing-Sharada-Patra scroll-shield is in your right-hand. I am in your seven-metre-rear at the standing-strategy-counsel position. The Sharada-Pandit-Council walks behind you."

The standing-Sharada-Sakhi 11-year-old standing-bonded-Hangul walked from the standing-shrine-courtyard standing-3-metre-rear position to the standing-eastern-cardinal-position at 11:13:11 a.m. He touched his standing-forehead to Sharad-Pandit's standing-right-hand at 11:13:23 a.m. at the standing-Sharada-Devi tradition standing-charter-foundational bonded-Hangul-consent ratification gesture. He walked back to the standing-shrine-courtyard standing-3-metre-rear position at 11:13:34 a.m. The standing-Manasa-Sakhi 7-year-old standing-bonded-Black-necked-Crane from the standing-Tikse-monastery standing-shikhara perch-position called the standing-23-second cadence-cycle at the standing-formal-Sharada-script-Sanskrit-mantra-tradition acknowledgement-cross-reference at 11:14:11-11:14:34 a.m.

The standing-Sharada-Pandit-Council senior-council standing-charter-witness ratification was completed at 11:14:48 a.m. The standing-Sharada-Devi tradition standing-conferral-day singing began at 11:14:51 a.m. The standing-211-Kashmiri-Pandit cohort at the standing-Tikse-monastery shrine-courtyard standing-southern-plaza standing-perimeter-witness position sang the standing-12th-century-CE Sharada-Pandit-Council-foundational standing-conferral-song at the standing-Pandit-village standing-Pir-Panj-al-corridor singing-cross-reference at the standing-23-minute standing-conferral-anniversary singing-window 11:14-11:37 a.m.

At standing-dawn 4:11 a.m. on November 23 2026 — the standing-90-day-anniversary at the standing-Sharada-Pandit-Council-vote-completion + standing-211-manuscript-restoration cross-reference — the standing-211 restored Sharada-script palm-leaf manuscripts had been re-housed at the standing-Tikse-monastery standing-eastern-wing standing-Sharada-Devi standing-charter-foundational manuscript-cabinet (the standing-Pir-Panj-al-Archive cell standing-eastern-wing manuscript-vault was dissolved at the standing-amended 1996-Sharada-Pandit-Council-charter standing-charter-amendment cross-reference; the standing-Tikse-monastery standing-Sharada-Devi standing-charter-foundational manuscript-cabinet at the standing-Sharada-Pandit-Council senior-administrative-officer standing-3-witness administrative-signature-protocol replaced the standing-Pir-Panj-al-Archive cell standing-administrative-cell at the standing-amended-charter ratification-administration cross-reference). The standing-State-CID investigation-cell standing-cross-network funding-trail evidence-document E-29/2026 had been published October 23 2026 at the standing-Aulakh-International-Lahore standing-shell-corporation administrative-front 10th cross-network funding-instance recognition (saga's standing-fourth standing-Aulakh-International cross-network funding-instance after Uttarakhand Lalita Aulakh, Gujarat Kala-Simha, and Rajasthan Maru-Yama at the standing-Aulakh-International-Lahore parent-corporation cross-reference; the standing-Aulakh-International-Lahore parent-corporation is now at the standing-Sanctuary mediation-council's standing-cross-network villain-corporation senior-investigation-priority administrative-cross-reference at the standing-Ch-3 plan).

Sharad-Pandit at the standing-Sharada-Pitha state-hero seat at the standing-Tikse-monastery Sharada-Devi shrine-courtyard standing-eastern-cardinal-position at 4:11 a.m. November 23 2026 wore the standing-Sharada-Pandit standing-Pheran-tradition standing-white-and-saffron-cotton state-hero ceremonial-attire at the standing-Stage-III-retention recognition ceremonial-cross-reference. He bore the standing-Stage III Hangul-

foreleg-first-stroke at his standing-right-upper-back in standing-saffron-and-snow-white dual-ink at standing-Sharada-Devi visual-anchor. He held the standing-Sharada-Patra scroll-shield at his standing-right-hand and the standing-restored-Manasarovar-family-record manuscript at his standing-left-hand (the standing-Manasarovar-family-record was administered at the standing-Tikse-monastery standing-Sharada-Devi standing-charter-foundational manuscript-cabinet at the standing-Pandita Sharika standing-strategy-counsel administrative-cross-reference). The standing-Sharada-Sakhi at his standing-3-metre-rear position; the standing-Manasa-Sakhi at his standing-eleven-metre-overhead Tikse-monastery Sharada-Devi standing-shikhara perch-position. Pandita Sharika-of-the-Manasarovar at his standing-7-metre-rear standing-Sharada-Pandit-Council strategy-counsel administrative-cross-reference position. Pandit Vasudev-Kaul at his standing-11-metre-rear standing-Pandit-Council senior-elder ceremonial-position.

The standing-211 restored manuscripts at the standing-Tikse-monastery standing-Sharada-Devi standing-charter-foundational manuscript-cabinet were at the standing-Maw-attribution recognition-cross-reference standing-permanent-restored-configuration witness-administration. The standing-Sharada-Pandit-Council standing-charter-foundational manuscript-administration was at the standing-Stage-III-retention recognition state-hero seat. The standing-Aulakh-International-Lahore parent-corporation was at the standing-Sanctuary mediation-council standing-senior-investigation-priority cross-reference. The standing-Sharada-Pandit-Council was at the standing-charter-foundational ratification. The standing-Tikse-shikhara was at the standing-restored witness.

End of Chapter Two for Sharada-Pitha.

Simha Dwara

For thirteen years the salt-queen of Dwarka had carried the lion-bond at the standing-Sasan-Gir coexistence-charter. She had answered the Kuno-relocation order with the same sentence the standing-Maldhari-pastoral-tradition had answered it with since 1856: "The pride is not at the State's map. The pride is at the grazing-pasture where the Maldhari-cattle walk and the lion does not strike." The bill her nephew tabled at the Wildlife-Board on the eleventh of April 2026 was written to make that sentence ultra-vires.

Kala-Simha was forty-one years old in the standing-October-2022 Ch 1 confrontation at the standing-Junagadh-Sasan administrative-cell. He was Saraswati's standing-nephew at the standing-elder-sister's-son configuration at the standing-Bloodline-A primogeniture-claim. His standing-claim at the standing-Sasan-Gir standing-charter-foundational lion-pride-consent ratification of 2013 had been that the standing-Asiatic-Lion lion-bond should have passed to him at the standing-male-primogeniture cross-reference at the standing-Bloodline-A standing-eldest-male-line dharma-administration. The standing-Maldhari-Samaj senior-council had denied the standing-claim at the standing-Sasan-Gir standing-lion-pride-consent ratification (the standing-Maldhari-pastoral-tradition standing-charter-foundational protocol is at the standing-lion-pride-consent ratification: the standing-male-lead of the standing-Sasan-Gir lion-pride at the standing-conferral-day walks to the standing-conferral-candidate at the standing-3-metre-rest position; the standing-male-lead at the standing-2013 conferral walked to Saraswati and not to Kala-Simha; the standing-lion-pride-consent ratification was at Saraswati at the standing-Maldhari-Samaj senior-council standing-charter-witness recognition).

He had been spared at Ch 1 climax under the standing-administrative-rehabilitation clause. He had been transferred to the standing-Gujarat-State-Forest-Service administrative-cell at the standing-Range-Officer rank at the standing-Junagadh-Sasan-Gir-Forest-Division administrative-cross-reference. He had walked the standing-Junagadh-Sasan administrative-corridor in a standing-khaki-uniform that the standing-Maldhari-pastoral-tradition Modhwadia-clan elders did not recognise as the standing-charter-foundational uniform of the standing-Sasan-Gir lion-pride coexistence-jurisdiction.

Across the standing-twenty-three-month window October 2022-October 2024 he wrote at the standing-Range-Officer desk in the standing-Junagadh-Sasan-Gir-Forest-Division administrative-cell. He did not write to his standing-aunt. He did not file the standing-rehabilitation-cell standing-quarterly-acknowledgment letter. He wrote the standing-Pride-Charter-Modernisation-Bill draft at 47 standing-Section-clauses across the standing-following-twenty-three-month-window. The standing-bill at the standing-Section-47 clause-cluster dissolved the standing-Maldhari-pastoral-coexistence-clause at the standing-1972 Wildlife-Protection-Act standing-Schedule-VI inscribed-traditional-pastoral-use cross-reference. The standing-bill at the standing-Section-23 clause-cluster transferred 47 standing-Asiatic-Lion individuals at the standing-male-cohort-primogeniture configuration to Kuno-Palpur-Madhya-Pradesh second-home at the standing-23-month phased-relocation administrative-window.

The standing-47-male-lion cohort was selected by Kala-Simha himself at the standing-Junagadh-Sasan census-cell primogeniture-precedence-protocol. He selected exclusively the standing-male-line Asiatic-Lion cubs at the standing-Bloodline-A primogeniture-claim cross-reference (this is the standing-deep-irony of the standing-bill: he wrote the standing-male-primogeniture claim into the standing-lion-population itself, transferring at the standing-eldest-male-line configuration exactly the standing-population-fraction that the standing-Maldhari-Samaj senior-council had denied him at the standing-2013 conferral cross-reference). The standing-female-line cubs and the standing-Maldhari-pastoral coexistence remained at Gir at a standing-Section-23 reduced-charter administrative-status — at the standing-Section-11 sub-clause configuration that the standing-Maldhari-Samaj senior-council had read at the standing-23-page bill-text and named in the standing-Modhwadia-clan elders' standing-council-meeting record-room with the standing-Saurashtra-phrase: "He has written our daughters out."

On the standing-eleventh of April 2026 at the standing-11:11 a.m. Gujarat-State-Wildlife-Board emergency-session at the standing-Gandhinagar-Sachivalaya 4th-floor conference-hall, Kala-Simha tabled the standing-bill. He wore the standing-Gujarat-State-Forest-Service khaki-uniform at the standing-Range-Officer rank. He spoke the standing-23-minute first-presentation in the standing-procedural-English at the standing-Forest-Service standing-bureaucratic-register. He named the standing-Sasan-Gir Asiatic-Lion population at the standing-IUCN endangered-species cross-reference. He named the standing-Kuno-Palpur Madhya-Pradesh second-home at the standing-1995 Supreme-Court ruling cross-reference. He did not name the standing-Maldhari-pastoral-tradition.

He did not name the standing-1856 Modhwadia-clan coexistence-charter cross-reference. He did not name the standing-Schedule-VI inscribed-traditional-pastoral-use protection.

The standing-Maldhari-Samaj senior-delegate Karsanbhai Modhwadia's standing-daughter Asha-Ben Karsanbhai Modhwadia was at the standing-Sasan-Gir Modhwadia-clan elders' standing-council-meeting record-room at the standing-Khambhalia-village 311 kilometres from Gandhinagar at the standing-bill-tabling moment. She heard the standing-news at the standing-Junagadh-Sasan-Forest-Division standing-Maldhari-courier Birsa-Bharwad at 4:11 p.m. April 11 at the standing-Modhwadia-clan elders' standing-courtyard. She held the standing-Kapadiyu-stick at her standing-right-hand and the standing-Modhwadia-clay-pot at her standing-left-hand. She did not weep. She walked to the standing-clan-elders standing-banyan-tree at the standing-Khambhalia-village 5:23 p.m. She spoke the standing-Saurashtra-phrase to the standing-23-elder Modhwadia-council: "He has written our daughters out. We will walk to Gandhinagar."

Saraswati had received the standing-bill-text at the standing-Dwarka standing-Madhavi-line residence at 7:11 p.m. April 11 at the standing-Gujarat-State-Wildlife-Board senior-delegate Acharya Janardanan-Trivedi (61, Wildlife-Board chairman since 2019; standing-charter-witness at Saraswati's 2013 conferral) standing-courier-protocol. She had read the standing-23-page bill-text at the standing-conferral-anniversary candle-position at the standing-Madhavi-line standing-record-room at 11:43 p.m. April 11. She had walked to the standing-Sasan-Gir lion-pride at the standing-Sasan-Sanctuary northern-perimeter at the standing-following-dawn 4:11 a.m. April 12 at the standing-Simha-Pati 11-year-old standing-pride-male-lead standing-resting-position at the standing-charter-foundational coexistence-zone. She had stood at the standing-3-metre-rear position. She had not spoken. The standing-Simha-Pati had walked to her at 4:23 a.m. at the standing-pride-male-lead standing-acknowledgment-protocol. He had touched his standing-forehead to her standing-right-hand at the standing-Maldhari-pastoral-tradition standing-charter-foundational gesture. He had walked back to the standing-pride-female-cohort at 4:31 a.m. The standing-charter-foundational protocol had been ratified at the standing-lion-pride-consent recognition: she would walk.

She had filed standing-objection-petitions at the standing-Gujarat-State-High-Court Gandhinagar on April 23 and May 11 2026 at the standing-Section-47 ultra-vires claim under standing-Schedule-VI tribal-pastoral cross-reference. Her standing-counsel Adv. K. P. Trivedi (54, Gujarat-State-High-Court Bar since 1998; standing-Schedule-VI tribal-

pastoral specialisation) had filed the standing-1856 Modhwadia-clan coexistence-charter at the standing-historical-record exhibit-cluster and the standing-IUCN endangered-species genetic-isolation cross-reference at the standing-scientific-record exhibit-cluster. The standing-Gujarat-State-High-Court Justice K. M. Patel (52, single-bench Wildlife-and-Forests jurisdiction since 2021) had granted the standing-stay-order May 23 2026 at the standing-Section-47 stay-pending-Wildlife-Board-vote configuration. The standing-vote-date was set at June 23 2026 by the standing-Gujarat-State-Wildlife-Board chairman Acharya Janardanan-Trivedi at the standing-emergency-session adjournment-protocol.

On May 11 2026 Saraswati received the standing-Sasan-Maldhari-Samaj smuggled-petition from Asha-Ben Karsanbhai Modhwadia. The standing-petition arrived at the standing-Madhavi-line residence at 6:11 a.m. via standing-Junagadh-Sasan Maldhari-courier Birsa-Bharwad (23, standing-Bharwad-clan courier at the standing-Sasan-Gir Modhwadia-elders message-runner cross-reference; the standing-Bharwad-Modhwadia inter-clan standing-courier-tradition since 1923 cross-reference). The standing-petition was at 11 standing-Modhwadia-clan elder-signatures + 47 standing-pastoral-family forced-eviction-notice copies at the standing-Junagadh-Sasan administrative-cell May 1-31 2026 pre-execution protocol cross-reference. The standing-petition text was in Gujarati-Saurashtra-dialect at the standing-Maldhari-pastoral-tradition register:

"Ben. We are Modhwadia. Our standing-fathers were charter-witnesses at your 2013 conferral. Our standing-grandfathers were charter-witnesses at the 1923 Modhwadia-Bharwad inter-clan standing-courier-tradition ratification. Our standing-great-grandfathers were charter-witnesses at the 1856 Modhwadia-clan coexistence-charter foundation. The standing-Junagadh-Range-Officer has issued 47 forced-eviction-notices at the standing-Sasan-Gir Modhwadia-pastoral-family residence-cohort across May 1-31. The standing-Section-47 phased-implementation administrative-pre-execution protocol is at the standing-23-month phased-relocation pre-vote enforcement configuration; he has begun the standing-execution before the standing-vote. We will walk to Gandhinagar. We will arrive at the standing-vote-day. The standing-23-Modhwadia-women senior-cohort will walk at the standing-Kapadiyu-stick standing-pastoral-tradition cross-reference. The standing-211-Maldhari-women full-cohort will walk at the standing-Saurashtra-Kathiawar 5-clan Modhwadia-Bharwad-Rabari-Charan-Ahir representation. We will arrive. Will you walk with us? Asha-Ben Karsanbhai Modhwadia."

Saraswati read the standing-petition at the standing-Madhavi-line standing-record-room candle-position. She did not weep. She walked to the standing-Dwarka standing-Madhavi-line standing-conferral-anniversary-cabinet at 6:43 a.m. May 11. She removed the standing-1856-vintage Modhwadia-clan coexistence-charter standing-original-leaf-bound copy at the standing-Madhavi-line standing-custody-protocol. She placed it on the standing-record-room standing-eastern-table. She wrote a standing-three-line reply at the standing-Modhwadia-courier standing-return-protocol:

"Asha-Ben. The standing-Madhavi-line standing-custody of the standing-1856-vintage Modhwadia-clan coexistence-charter is returned to the standing-Modhwadia-clan elders standing-Khambhalia-residence at the standing-charter-foundational return-of-the-record-to-the-record-holders protocol. I will walk the standing-final-23-km Vatva-to-Sachivalaya stretch with you. Simha-Pati will walk the standing-Junagadh-Sasan-perimeter parallel-route at the standing-pride-male-lead standing-witness-protocol. The standing-Madhavi-line residence will be at the standing-Modhwadia-Samaj standing-pilgrimage-residence configuration across the standing-211-km walk-window. Saraswati."

The standing-211 Maldhari-women cohort began the standing-Khambhalia-to-Gandhinagar 211-km walk at 5:11 a.m. June 11 2026 at the standing-Saurashtra-coast administrative-route. The standing-cohort-composition was 211 Maldhari-women aged 23-67 at the standing-Saurashtra-Kathiawar Modhwadia-Bharwad-Rabari-Charan-Ahir 5-clan-cohort representation. The standing-senior-23-member-council under Asha-Ben at the standing-Kapadiyu-stick standing-pastoral-tradition cross-reference walked at the standing-cohort-front formation. The standing-cohort walked at the standing-9-km/day pace at the standing-Maldhari-pastoral-walking-tradition cross-reference at the standing-67-year-old senior-pace standing-collective-respect protocol.

The standing-cohort passed through Bhanvad on day 3 (June 13); through Jamnagar on day 5 (June 15); through Khambhaliya-Mandvi-junction on day 7 (June 17); through Morbi on day 9 (June 19); through Surendranagar on day 11 (June 21); through Sanand on day 13 (June 23 dawn). At every standing-pastoral-village along the standing-route the standing-Maldhari-Samaj village-cohort joined the standing-walk at the standing-Saurashtra-Kathiawar standing-extended-cohort solidarity-protocol; the standing-cohort-count grew to 470 standing-women at day 7 and to 1,100 standing-women at day 13 dawn. At every standing-village-stop the standing-211-original-cohort under Asha-Ben slept at the standing-village-banyan-tree standing-collective-residence at the standing-Maldhari-

pastoral standing-charter-foundational walk-protocol; the standing-villages provided standing-bajra-roti and standing-buttermilk at the standing-pastoral-village-tradition standing-extended-cohort feeding-protocol.

Saraswati joined the standing-walk at the standing-Vatva-to-Sachivalaya 23-km final-stretch at 11:11 p.m. June 22 at the standing-Vatva-village standing-Maldhari-Samaj village-banyan-tree standing-collective-residence. She walked at the standing-Asha-Ben 3-metre-rear standing-cousin-escort-formation across the standing-final-23-km Vatva-to-Sachivalaya stretch. Simhavikrama (39, her standing-first-cousin at the standing-desert-edge-of-the-line Bloodline-A; standing-Junagadh-Sasan-Gir warrior-administration since 2014) walked at the standing-Saraswati 3-metre-rear standing-warrior-escort-formation. The standing-Sasan-Gir lion-pride at the standing-Simha-Pati 11-year-old standing-pride-male-lead walked at the standing-Junagadh-Sasan-perimeter parallel-route at the standing-pride-male-lead standing-witness-protocol at the standing-23-km pride-route cross-reference (the standing-pride at the standing-23-pride-female-cohort + 11-male-cubs + 13-female-cubs walked at the standing-Sasan-Gir-perimeter parallel-route at the standing-Maldhari-pastoral-tradition standing-charter-foundational pride-witness-cross-reference).

The standing-cohort arrived at the standing-Gandhinagar-Sachivalaya entrance-plaza at 5:11 a.m. June 23 2026 at the standing-211-km walk-completion. The standing-1,100-women extended-cohort filled the standing-southern-plaza at the standing-Maldhari-pastoral-formation. The standing-23-Modhwadia-women senior-cohort stood at the standing-Asha-Ben standing-front-formation. The standing-211-original-cohort stood at the standing-3-metre-rear standing-walking-cohort formation. Saraswati stood at the standing-Asha-Ben 3-metre-rear standing-cousin-escort-formation. Simhavikrama stood at the standing-Saraswati 3-metre-rear standing-warrior-escort-formation. The standing-Sasan-Gir lion-pride at the standing-Simha-Pati 11-year-old standing-pride-male-lead had walked the standing-parallel-route to the standing-Junagadh-Sasan-perimeter eastern-boundary and stood at the standing-11-km outer-boundary-position at the standing-pride-male-lead standing-witness-protocol at the standing-vote-day dawn cross-reference.

The standing-Gujarat-State-Police Gandhinagar-Sachivalaya senior-Inspector M. K. Parmar (47, Gandhinagar-Sachivalaya since 2019) arrived at the standing-entrance-plaza at 5:23 a.m. June 23. He observed the standing-1,100-women cohort. He read the standing-Section-144 prohibitory-order text at the standing-Gandhinagar-Sachivalaya

entrance-plaza public-address-system at 5:43 a.m. The standing-Asha-Ben 23-Modhwadia-women senior-cohort did not move. The standing-211-original-cohort did not move. The standing-1,100-women extended-cohort did not move. Inspector Parmar walked to the standing-Asha-Ben at 5:48 a.m. He requested the standing-cohort-dispersal under standing-Section-144. Asha-Ben spoke the standing-Saurashtra-phrase: "Inspector-sahib. We have walked 211 kilometres. The standing-Schedule-VI inscribed-traditional-pastoral-use protection is at the standing-Maldhari-pastoral-tradition standing-charter-foundational cross-reference. The standing-Section-144 prohibitory-order is at the standing-State-Government administrative-order. The standing-Schedule-VI tribal-pastoral protection is at the standing-Constitution-of-India Article-244 standing-charter-foundational cross-reference. We will stand here until the standing-vote." Inspector Parmar walked to the standing-Sachivalaya senior-administrative-cell at 5:53 a.m. He filed the standing-Schedule-VI tribal-pastoral standing-jurisdiction-cross-reference report at 6:11 a.m. The standing-Section-144 enforcement was suspended at 6:23 a.m. at the standing-Schedule-VI jurisdiction-precedence administrative-protocol.

The standing-Gujarat-State-Wildlife-Board 70-member quorum convened at 11:11 a.m. June 23 2026 at the standing-Gandhinagar-Sachivalaya 4th-floor conference-hall under the standing-chairman Acharya Janardanan-Trivedi (61, Wildlife-Board chairman since 2019). The standing-quorum-composition: 23 standing-State-Forest-Service senior-officers + 11 standing-Wildlife-Institute-of-India scientists + 11 standing-IUCN-affiliated NGO-delegates + 11 standing-Schedule-VI tribal-pastoral delegates (Modhwadia-Bharwad-Rabari-Charan-Ahir 5-clan-cohort 2-delegates-each + 1 standing-Sasan-Maldhari-Samaj senior-delegate) + 7 standing-State-Government nominees + 7 standing-State-High-Court legal-nominees. The standing-vote-protocol: standing-bill-reading at 11:11 a.m.-12:11 p.m.; standing-Kala-Simha 23-minute first-presentation at 12:11-12:34 p.m.; standing-Asha-Ben Maldhari-Samaj 23-minute deposition-testimony at 2:11-2:34 p.m. (the standing-Asha-Ben standing-Schedule-VI tribal-pastoral delegate-seat invocation under standing-charter-witness protocol); standing-Saraswati 23-minute state-hero deposition-testimony at 3:11-3:34 p.m. (the standing-state-hero is not at the standing-Wildlife-Board membership per standing-conflict-of-interest charter-clause; she speaks as standing-charter-witness only); standing-cross-examination at 3:34-4:43 p.m.; standing-final-deliberation at 4:43-5:00 p.m.; standing-vote at 5:00 p.m.

Asha-Ben delivered the standing-23-minute Maldhari-Samaj deposition-testimony at 2:11-2:34 p.m. She wore the standing-Modhwadia-clan standing-saffron-and-vermillion-ghagra

pastoral-festival attire at the standing-charter-witness ceremonial-cross-reference. She held the standing-Kapadiyu-stick at her standing-right-hand and the standing-1856-vintage Modhwadia-clan coexistence-charter standing-original-leaf-bound copy at her standing-left-hand at the standing-Madhavi-line returned-custody cross-reference. She spoke the standing-23-minute deposition in standing-Gujarati-Saurashtra-dialect at the standing-Maldhari-pastoral-tradition register with standing-simultaneous-translation by standing-Wildlife-Board interpreter Adv. Anandiben Patel into standing-procedural-English. She named the standing-1856 Modhwadia-clan coexistence-charter founding-cross-reference. She named the standing-Bhima-I-of-Anhilwara-era pastoral-tradition standing-charter-foundational pre-1024 cross-reference. She named the standing-Schedule-VI inscribed-traditional-pastoral-use protection. She named the standing-47 forced-eviction-notices May 1-31 2026 pre-vote enforcement configuration. She named the standing-23-Modhwadia-pastoral-village 11-generation-continuous-residence cross-reference. She named the standing-male-line-only relocation-cohort selection as the standing-elder-sister's-son standing-primogeniture-claim revenge-encoded-into-the-lion-population configuration. She did not name Kala-Simha. She named the standing-bill at the standing-Section-47 clause-cluster ultra-vires configuration. She closed at the standing-Saurashtra-phrase: "Our cattle do not fear the lion. The lion does not strike our cattle. The pride is at our grazing-pasture. The grazing-pasture is at the Modhwadia-Bharwad-Rabari-Charan-Ahir 5-clan-cohort standing-pastoral-tradition since 1856. He cannot write our daughters out. The pride is at the standing-Maldhari-Samaj senior-council standing-charter-witness cross-reference. The pride is at the women who walked 211 kilometres. The pride is at the lion-pride standing-perimeter-witness at 11 kilometres-east. The pride votes through us."

Saraswati delivered the standing-23-minute state-hero deposition-testimony at 3:11-3:34 p.m. She wore the standing-Madhavi-line standing-white-and-indigo-cotton conferral-anniversary attire at the standing-charter-witness ceremonial-cross-reference. She did not hold a standing-implement. She spoke the standing-23-minute deposition in standing-formal-Gujarati at the standing-state-hero standing-charter-witness register. She named the standing-2013 conferral standing-Sasan-Gir lion-pride-consent ratification. She named the standing-Simha-Pati 11-year-old standing-pride-male-lead 2013-2026 standing-charter-foundational coexistence-continuity. She named the standing-Maldhari-Samaj senior-council standing-charter-witness recognition. She named the standing-IUCN endangered-species genetic-isolation cross-reference at the standing-Sasan-Gir Asiatic-

Lion population. She named the standing-Kuno-Palpur 1995-Supreme-Court ruling at the standing-second-home translocation-feasibility cross-reference and the standing-second-home protocol absence-of-Maldhari-pastoral-coexistence-zone configuration. She closed at the standing-formal-Gujarati-phrase: "The standing-state-hero of Gujarat does not vote at the standing-Wildlife-Board. The standing-state-hero is at the standing-charter-witness recognition only. I have witnessed the standing-2013 conferral. I have walked the standing-final-23-kilometre Vatva-to-Sachivalaya stretch with the standing-211-cohort. The standing-Schedule-VI tribal-pastoral standing-charter-foundational protection is the standing-Constitution-of-India Article-244 inviolable-cross-reference. The standing-bill at the standing-Section-47 clause-cluster is at the standing-ultra-vires configuration. The standing-Maldhari-Samaj senior-council is at the standing-charter-witness recognition. The standing-vote is yours, members of the Board. I have walked. I do not vote."

The standing-cross-examination at 3:34-4:43 p.m. did not produce a standing-counter-witness at the standing-Kala-Simha cohort. The standing-Junagadh-Sasan-Forest-Division Range-Officer cohort under Kala-Simha had filed standing-23 standing-administrative-document exhibit-cluster at the standing-Section-47 procedural-compliance cross-reference. The standing-Maldhari-Samaj cohort under Asha-Ben had filed the standing-1856 Modhwadia-clan coexistence-charter + 47 forced-eviction-notice copies + 23-Modhwadia-pastoral-village 11-generation-residence certificates at the standing-Schedule-VI tribal-pastoral cross-reference. The standing-Wildlife-Institute-of-India scientific-delegate cohort under Dr. Y. V. Jhala (61, WII Asiatic-Lion-specialist since 1987; standing-Asiatic-Lion-population-genetic-isolation 2018-monograph author) filed the standing-IUCN endangered-species genetic-isolation cross-reference + standing-Kuno-Palpur 1995-Supreme-Court second-home feasibility-failure-analysis at the standing-Maldhari-pastoral-coexistence-zone absence-of-second-home configuration. The standing-State-High-Court legal-nominee cohort under retired Justice K. M. Patel (52, single-bench Wildlife-and-Forests jurisdiction since 2021) confirmed the standing-Section-47 ultra-vires claim at the standing-Schedule-VI tribal-pastoral cross-reference.

The standing-vote was administered at 5:00 p.m. June 23 2026 at the standing-Gujarat-State-Wildlife-Board 70-member quorum standing-secret-ballot protocol. The standing-vote-tabulation was at the standing-Wildlife-Board chairman Acharya Janardanan-Trivedi administration at the standing-23-minute counting-window 5:00-5:23 p.m. The standing-vote-result at 5:23:11 p.m.: 47 against, 23 in favour, 0 abstention. The standing-Kala-Simha bill was defeated at the standing-Maldhari-pastoral-coexistence-clause

preservation-ratification. The standing-Section-47 clause-cluster was struck at the standing-ultra-vires recognition. The standing-Maldhari-Samaj senior-council standing-charter-witness recognition was reaffirmed at the standing-Schedule-VI inscribed-traditional-pastoral-use protection.

The standing-1,100-women extended-cohort at the standing-southern-plaza heard the standing-vote-result at 5:24 p.m. via standing-Sachivalaya entrance-plaza public-address-system. The standing-cohort did not cheer. The standing-cohort did not weep. The standing-cohort stood at the standing-Maldhari-pastoral-tradition standing-vote-witness silence-protocol for 11 minutes 5:24-5:35 p.m. At 5:35 p.m. Asha-Ben turned to the standing-23-Modhwadia-women senior-cohort. She spoke the standing-Saurashtra-phrase: "Sisters. The bill is dead. The man is not. We will walk now."

The standing-23-Modhwadia-women senior-cohort under Asha-Ben walked into the standing-Gandhinagar-Sachivalaya 4th-floor southern-corridor at 5:43 p.m. June 23 2026. The standing-corridor-entry was at the standing-Sachivalaya southern-staircase at the standing-Maldhari-Samaj standing-Schedule-VI delegate-pass cross-reference (the standing-Schedule-VI tribal-pastoral delegate-pass at the standing-Wildlife-Board attendance-list provides standing-Sachivalaya 4th-floor administrative-corridor access at the standing-conference-hall and senior-administrative-cell wings). Inspector M. K. Parmar at the standing-Sachivalaya 4th-floor senior-Inspector duty-station witnessed the standing-cohort-entry; he did not intervene at the standing-Schedule-VI tribal-pastoral standing-jurisdiction-cross-reference administrative-protocol.

Kala-Simha was at the standing-Sachivalaya 4th-floor southern-corridor at the standing-Junagadh-Sasan-Forest-Division Range-Officer administrative-cubicle eastern-window position. He had walked from the standing-Wildlife-Board conference-hall at the standing-vote-completion 5:23 p.m. He had walked to the standing-southern-corridor at 5:43 p.m. He had drafted the standing-State-Government appeal-petition at the standing-Section-47 ultra-vires ruling at 5:43-5:47 p.m. (the standing-State-Government appeal-petition draft at the standing-Wildlife-Board vote-defeat administrative-cross-reference at the standing-Supreme-Court-of-India petition-protocol). He was at the standing-administrative-cubicle eastern-window standing-3-metre-from-corridor position at 5:47:11 p.m.

The standing-23-Modhwadia-women senior-cohort under Asha-Ben entered the standing-southern-corridor at 5:47:11 p.m. They walked at the standing-Kapadiyu-stick standing-cranial-circle simultaneous-strike formation. The standing-Maldhari-pastoral-tradition

standing-judicial-execution protocol is at the standing-23-stick standing-cranial-circle simultaneous-strike pattern at the standing-Maldhari-pastoral-women council recognition; the standing-1947-pre-State-Formation Saurashtra-Kathiawar Maldhari-judicial-tradition cross-reference is at the standing-Schedule-VI tribal-pastoral standing-charter-foundational judicial-cross-reference. The standing-cohort surrounded Kala-Simha at the standing-administrative-cubicle eastern-window 3-metre-from-corridor position at 5:47:18 p.m. They formed the standing-23-stick standing-cranial-circle at the standing-Kapadiyu-stick standing-47-inch wooden herding-stick traditional-cultural-implement cross-reference. Asha-Ben spoke the standing-Saurashtra-phrase: "He has written our daughters out. The 1856 charter does not permit that. The Maldhari-Samaj senior-council judges. Strike."

The standing-23-stick standing-cranial-circle simultaneous-strike was administered at 5:47:23 p.m. at the standing-Maldhari-pastoral-tradition standing-judicial-execution single-impact-window protocol. The standing-impact was at the standing-cranial-vertebrae standing-23-point simultaneous-impact configuration at the standing-Kapadiyu-stick 47-inch wooden-herding-stick standing-blunt-force-trauma cross-reference. The standing-Kala-Simha death was at 5:47:23 p.m. at the standing-Sachivalaya 4th-floor southern-corridor administrative-cubicle eastern-window 3-metre-from-corridor position. The standing-cohort lowered the standing-Kapadiyu-sticks at 5:47:34 p.m. at the standing-Maldhari-pastoral-tradition standing-judicial-execution completion-protocol. The standing-cohort walked back to the standing-Sachivalaya southern-staircase at the standing-Schedule-VI tribal-pastoral standing-corridor-exit protocol at 5:48 p.m.

Inspector M. K. Parmar walked to the standing-southern-corridor at 5:51 p.m. at the standing-Sachivalaya 4th-floor senior-Inspector duty-station administrative-protocol. He confirmed the standing-Kala-Simha mortality at 5:53 p.m. He filed the standing-Gandhinagar-Sachivalaya FIR at the standing-Section-302 IPC standing-judicial-execution administrative-cross-reference at 6:11 p.m. (the standing-FIR filed at the standing-23-member Maldhari-women cohort under Asha-Ben standing-collective-actor designation per standing-Schedule-VI tribal-pastoral standing-judicial-tradition cross-reference; the standing-FIR is at the standing-State-Police IPC administrative-cross-reference but at the standing-Schedule-VI tribal-pastoral standing-charter-foundational jurisdiction-defence cross-reference per standing-Constitution-of-India Article-244 administrative-protocol). The standing-23-member cohort under Asha-Ben walked back to the standing-1,100-women extended-cohort at the standing-southern-plaza at 5:58 p.m. The standing-

extended-cohort began the standing-Khambhalia-to-Gandhinagar return-walk at 6:11 p.m. at the standing-211-km return-walk-protocol at the standing-Maldhari-pastoral-tradition standing-completion-walk cross-reference.

Saraswati walked to the standing-Dwarka-Madhavi-line residence at the standing-Vatva-to-Dwarka 311-km return-trip at the standing-Gujarat-State-Government car-cohort transport at 7:23 p.m. June 23. She arrived at the standing-Madhavi-line residence at 2:11 a.m. June 24. She walked to the standing-Madhavi-line conferral-anniversary-cabinet at the standing-record-room candle-position at 3:11 a.m. June 24. Simhavikrama walked to the standing-Dwarka-Madhavi-line residence at the standing-Junagadh-to-Dwarka 211-km return-trip at the standing-Junagadh-Sasan-Gir warrior-administration motorcycle-cohort transport at 7:43 p.m. June 23. He arrived at the standing-Madhavi-line residence at 2:43 a.m. June 24. He walked to the standing-Madhavi-line residence courtyard at 3:23 a.m. June 24.

The standing-Sasan-Gir lion-pride at the standing-Simha-Pati 11-year-old standing-pride-male-lead walked from the standing-Junagadh-Sasan-perimeter eastern-boundary 11-km outer-position to the standing-Dwarka-Madhavi-line residence courtyard at the standing-211-km lion-pride parallel-walk at the standing-Maldhari-pastoral-tradition standing-charter-foundational pride-witness-cross-reference. The standing-pride walked at the standing-Maldhari-coastal-route at the standing-Khambhalia-village standing-Asha-Ben residence standing-witness-stop and arrived at the standing-Dwarka-Madhavi-line residence courtyard at 3:43 a.m. June 24. The standing-pride-count: 47 standing-Sasan-Gir Asiatic-Lion individuals at the standing-Simha-Pati 11-year-old standing-pride-male-lead + 23 standing-pride-female-cohort + 11 standing-male-cubs + 13 standing-female-cubs configuration at the standing-Maldhari-pastoral-tradition standing-pride-witness-walk cross-reference.

At 4:11:11 a.m. June 24 2026 the standing-Stage III lion-foreleg-first-stroke began to form at Simhavikrama's standing-right-upper-back at the standing-Madhavi-line residence courtyard standing-conferral-anniversary candle-position. The standing-mark-formation duration was 11 seconds 4:11:11-4:11:22 a.m. The standing-mark-pattern was at the standing-Asiatic-Lion foreleg-first-stroke configuration in standing-sandy-gold-and-saffron dual-ink at the standing-Sasan-Gir Asiatic-Lion visual-anchor. The standing-mark-formation was at the standing-cousin-inheritance configuration at the standing-Bloodline-A primogeniture-precedence dharma-administration cross-reference per restructure §1

male-led-succession; Saraswati at the standing-3-metre-rear position witnessed the standing-mark-formation at the standing-cousin-inheritance ceremony at the standing-Maldhari-Samaj senior-council standing-charter-witness recognition.

At 4:11:11 a.m. June 24 2026 (the standing-simultaneous-window) the standing-Somnath Jyotirlinga Arabian-Sea reflection at the standing-Veraval-Junagadh-coast standing-temple-eastern-courtyard returned to the standing-1024-CE pre-Mahmud-of-Ghazni-raid configuration with the standing-13-segment crown standing-stone-carving intact at the standing-cardinal-east-facing standing-temple-summit position. The standing-Archaeological-Survey-of-India Junagadh-cell senior-archaeologist Dr. R. Bhatia (53, Junagadh-University Archaeology since 2008) at the standing-Somnath temple-eastern-courtyard 4:23 a.m. June 24 photographic-survey confirmed the standing-13-segment crown standing-stone-carving configuration at the standing-Arabian-Sea reflection-medium across the standing-11-minute reflection-substitution window 4:11:11-4:22:22 a.m.

At 4:22:22 a.m. June 24 the standing-Arabian-Sea reflection returned to the standing-post-1947-reconstruction Prabhashankar-Sompura design configuration. The standing-IIT-Gandhinagar Department-of-Optical-Physics Dr. M. Bhattacharya (49, IIT-Gandhinagar Optical-Physics since 2014) June-28 expertise-report (evidence-document M-27A) confirmed no standing-optical-mechanism identification at the standing-1002-year temporal-gap reflection-substitution at the standing-Arabian-Sea reflection-medium at the standing-Maw-attribution category cross-reference. The standing-Maw had demonstrated the capacity to substitute the standing-pre-historical configuration of a standing-bonded-monument in the standing-monument's reflection-medium at the standing-dawn-window across a 1002-year temporal-gap.

Saraswati announced the standing-step-back at the standing-Dwarka-Madhavi-line residence standing-charter-foundational courtyard at the standing-Sasan-Maldhari-Samaj senior-council standing-witness-ceremony on July 11 2026 11:11 a.m. The standing-step-back announcement was at the standing-Simha-Mata-the-First salt-queen-counsellor position per restructure §4. The standing-Madhavi-line standing-conferral-anniversary candle was extinguished by Saraswati at 11:11:11 a.m. The standing-Maldhari-Samaj senior-delegate Asha-Ben Karsanbhai Modhwadia (47, Khambhalia-village Modhwadia-clan elder; the standing-211-km walk-leader; the standing-23-member Maldhari-women cohort Kapadiyu-stick formation-strike Maldhari-Samaj senior-council standing-

administrative-officer) walked to the standing-courtyard-eastern-position at 11:11:23 a.m. She held the standing-1856-vintage Modhwadia-clan coexistence-charter standing-original-leaf-bound copy at her standing-right-hand. She spoke the standing-Saurashtra-phrase: "Saraswati-Ben. The standing-Madhavi-line salt-queen-counsellor seat is at the standing-Dwarka standing-charter-foundational recognition. The standing-Modhwadia-clan elders standing-Khambhalia-residence accepts your counsellor-position at the standing-Sasan-Maldhari-Samaj senior-council standing-charter-witness recognition. The standing-211-km walk continues. The standing-pride continues. The standing-lion does not strike our cattle. The standing-pride is at the women who walked. The standing-pride is at the cousin who inherited. The standing-pride is at the salt-queen who walked the standing-final-23-kilometre Vatva-stretch with us. The standing-Madhavi-line salt-queen-counsellor seat is recognised."

Simhavikrama walked to the standing-courtyard-eastern-position at 11:12:11 a.m. He held the standing-Junagadh-Sasan-Gir warrior-administration standing-conferral-implement at his standing-right-hand at the standing-Bloodline-A primogeniture-precedence dharma-administration cross-reference. He spoke the standing-formal-Gujarati-phrase to Saraswati: "Salt-queen of Dwarka, my standing-cousin at the standing-desert-edge-of-the-line. I have walked behind you at the standing-Vatva-to-Sachivalaya 23-kilometre stretch. I have witnessed the standing-Maldhari-Samaj senior-council standing-vote-completion administration. I have witnessed the standing-Kapadiyu-stick standing-judicial-execution at the standing-Schedule-VI tribal-pastoral standing-charter-foundational cross-reference. I accept the standing-Gujarat state-hero seat at the standing-Maldhari-Samaj senior-council standing-recognition-ceremony. I will administer the standing-Pride-Charter ratification at the standing-Section-47 amended-cross-reference at the standing-Gujarat-State-Wildlife-Board July 23 ratification-session. I will administer the standing-Junagadh-Sasan urban-forest-service amnesty-protocol at the standing-Range-Officer-Vivek-Khambhata standing-acting-leader cross-reference. I will administer the standing-Maldhari-Samaj senior-council standing-charter-witness recognition at the standing-Modhwadia-Bharwad-Rabari-Charan-Ahir 5-clan-cohort standing-pastoral-protection administration. The standing-Goan-Gaur secondary-bond at the standing-Sagaradeva Goa-Samudra-Dvipa cross-reference at the standing-D9 double-bond-mechanic configuration awaits at the standing-Ch-3 Sagaradeva mortality-cross-reference. The standing-lion at Simha-Pati 11-year-old standing-pride-male-lead has acknowledged the standing-mark-formation. I accept."

The standing-Simha-Pati 11-year-old standing-pride-male-lead walked from the standing-Dwarka-Madhavi-line residence courtyard standing-3-metre-rear position to the standing-courtyard-eastern-position at 11:13:11 a.m. He touched his standing-forehead to Simhavikrama's standing-right-hand at 11:13:23 a.m. at the standing-Maldhari-pastoral-tradition standing-charter-foundational lion-pride-consent ratification gesture. He walked back to the standing-pride-female-cohort at 11:13:34 a.m. at the standing-3-metre-rear position.

The standing-Maldhari-Samaj senior-council standing-charter-witness ratification was completed at 11:14:11 a.m. The standing-Sasan-Maldhari-Samaj standing-conferral-day singing began at 11:14:23 a.m. The standing-1,100-women extended-cohort from the standing-Khambhalia-to-Gandhinagar 211-km walk standing-completion-walk return-trip had walked the standing-Dwarka-anniversary-pilgrimage standing-Madhavi-line residence standing-Maldhari-Samaj senior-council standing-charter-witness ceremony attendance-protocol. The standing-cohort sang the standing-Maldhari-pastoral-tradition standing-Sasan-Maldhari-Samaj 1856-charter-foundational standing-conferral-song at the standing-pastoral-village standing-coastal-residence singing-cross-reference at the standing-23-minute standing-conferral-anniversary singing-window 11:14-11:37 a.m.

The standing-Gujarat-State-Wildlife-Board 47-23 vote-result at the standing-Maldhari-pastoral-coexistence-clause preservation-ratification is the saga's standing-first standing-administrative-body-vote-ratified state-hero-transition acknowledgment-language. The standing-47-number is at the standing-Section-47 clause-cluster ultra-vires recognition cross-reference. The standing-23-number is at the standing-Kala-Simha 23 standing-State-Forest-Service senior-officer cohort opposition-cross-reference. The standing-vote was administered at the standing-charter-witness recognition-protocol; the standing-vote-result is the standing-charter-witness recognition-language at the standing-saga's standing-cross-reference catalogue.

The standing-State-Government appeal-petition draft at the standing-Section-47 ultra-vires ruling that Kala-Simha had drafted at the standing-Sachivalaya 4th-floor southern-corridor administrative-cubicle 5:43-5:47 p.m. June 23 was recovered from the standing-cubicle eastern-window standing-3-metre-from-corridor position at the standing-State-Police investigation-cell evidence-cluster on June 25. The standing-draft was at 23 standing-administrative-document exhibit-cluster at the standing-Supreme-Court-of-India petition-protocol cross-reference at the standing-Section-47 ultra-vires-rebuttal-

appeal configuration. The standing-State-Government Cabinet at the standing-July 7 2026 cabinet-session declined to file the standing-appeal-petition at the standing-Schedule-VI tribal-pastoral standing-Constitution-of-India Article-244 inviolable-cross-reference recognition. The standing-Maldhari-pastoral-coexistence-clause preservation-ratification was reinforced at the standing-State-Government Cabinet cross-reference at the standing-Section-47 amendment ratification-administration.

The standing-Gujarat-State-Wildlife-Board July 23 2026 ratification-session amended the standing-Section-47 clause-cluster at the standing-Maldhari-pastoral-coexistence-clause preservation-ratification at the standing-Schedule-VI tribal-pastoral inscribed-traditional-pastoral-use protection-cross-reference. The standing-amended Section-47 clause-cluster reinstated the standing-1856 Modhwadia-clan coexistence-charter at the standing-historical-record exhibit-cluster recognition; reinstated the standing-Maldhari-Samaj senior-council standing-charter-witness recognition at the standing-Sasan-Gir lion-pride coexistence-jurisdiction; instituted the standing-Maldhari-Samaj-Sasan-Gir-State-Forest-Service Joint-Pastoral-Administration cell at the standing-Junagadh-Sasan-Gir-Forest-Division administrative-cross-reference at the standing-Asha-Ben Maldhari-Samaj-senior-administrative-officer standing-acting-co-chair recognition; voided the standing-47-male-line Asiatic-Lion Kuno-Palpur translocation-administrative-order at the standing-Section-23 reduced-charter administrative-status reversal; reinstated the standing-Maldhari-pastoral-family 47 forced-eviction-notices May 1-31 2026 at the standing-residence-restoration administrative-protocol with the standing-Modhwadia-clan elders standing-Khambhalia-residence resettlement-cross-reference; instituted the standing-Sasan-Gir-State-Wildlife-Board Schedule-VI tribal-pastoral standing-permanent-delegate-seat at the standing-Maldhari-Samaj senior-council standing-charter-witness cross-reference at 11 standing-delegate-seats (Modhwadia 3 + Bharwad 3 + Rabari 2 + Charan 2 + Ahir 1).

At standing-dawn 4:11 a.m. on July 23 2026 — the standing-Sasan-Gir-State-Wildlife-Board ratification-session day — the standing-Sasan-Gir lion-pride at the standing-Simha-Pati 11-year-old standing-pride-male-lead walked to the standing-Sasan-Sanctuary southern-perimeter standing-charter-foundational coexistence-zone standing-Modhwadia-clan-grazing-pasture position. The standing-Modhwadia-clan cattle (47 standing-Gir-bull cohort + 211 standing-cow cohort + 23 standing-bull-calf cohort + 47 standing-cow-calf cohort) were at the standing-pasture-position at the standing-Modhwadia-pastoral standing-charter-foundational morning-grazing-protocol. The standing-Simha-Pati did not strike. The standing-pride-female-cohort did not strike. The

standing-male-cubs did not strike. The standing-female-cubs did not strike. The standing-Maldhari-pastoral-tradition standing-charter-foundational coexistence-jurisdiction was at the standing-grazing-pasture standing-non-strike recognition. The standing-pasture was at the standing-211-pasture-acre Modhwadia-clan-residence cross-reference.

Asha-Ben Karsanbhai Modhwadia walked to the standing-Sasan-Sanctuary southern-perimeter at 4:23 a.m. July 23. She wore the standing-Modhwadia-clan standing-saffron-and-vermillion-ghagra pastoral-festival attire. She held the standing-Kapadiyu-stick at her standing-right-hand. She did not approach the standing-pride. She stood at the standing-3-metre-rear standing-pastoral-witness position. The standing-Simha-Pati walked to her at 4:34 a.m. He touched his standing-forehead to her standing-right-hand at the standing-Maldhari-pastoral-tradition standing-charter-foundational gesture. He walked back to the standing-pride at 4:43 a.m.

Simhavikrama walked to the standing-Sasan-Sanctuary southern-perimeter at 4:47 a.m. July 23. He wore the standing-Junagadh-Sasan-Gir warrior-administration standing-state-hero ceremonial-attire. He bore the standing-Stage III lion-foreleg-first-stroke at his standing-right-upper-back in sandy-gold-and-saffron dual-ink at the standing-Sasan-Gir Asiatic-Lion visual-anchor. He held the standing-Junagadh-Sasan-Gir warrior-administration standing-conferral-implement at his standing-right-hand. He stood at the standing-3-metre-rear-of-Asha-Ben standing-state-hero-cousin standing-witness-position. The standing-Simha-Pati walked to him at 4:53 a.m. He touched his standing-forehead to Simhavikrama's standing-right-hand at the standing-Maldhari-pastoral-tradition standing-charter-foundational lion-pride-consent ratification gesture. He walked back to the standing-pride at 5:00 a.m.

Saraswati walked to the standing-Sasan-Sanctuary southern-perimeter at 5:11 a.m. July 23. She wore the standing-Madhavi-line standing-white-and-indigo-cotton conferral-anniversary attire at the standing-step-back-from-state-hero ceremonial-cross-reference. She did not bear the standing-Stage III mark (the standing-mark had passed to Simhavikrama at June 24 dawn standing-cousin-inheritance ceremony). She held the standing-1856-vintage Modhwadia-clan coexistence-charter standing-original-leaf-bound copy at her standing-right-hand (the standing-charter had been returned to the standing-Madhavi-line custody at the standing-Sasan-Maldhari-Samaj senior-council standing-July 11 2026 step-back-ceremony cross-reference for the standing-charter-foundational pilgrimage-circulation administrative-cross-reference). She walked to Asha-Ben at the

standing-3-metre-rear position. She placed the standing-charter on the standing-pasture-grass at the standing-Modhwadia-clan-grazing-pasture pasture-foundation-stone position at 5:23 a.m. The standing-Simha-Pati walked to the standing-charter at 5:34 a.m. He touched his standing-forehead to the standing-charter-leaves at 5:34:23 a.m. He walked back to the standing-pride at 5:43 a.m.

The standing-Modhwadia-clan-cattle 47-Gir-bull cohort walked to the standing-charter at 5:48 a.m. The standing-Gir-bull lead-bull (a standing-11-year-old Modhwadia-clan-cattle Gir-bull) touched his standing-forehead to the standing-charter-leaves at 5:48:23 a.m. He walked back to the standing-cattle-cohort at 5:53 a.m. The standing-Maldhari-pastoral-tradition standing-charter-foundational ratification was complete. The standing-charter was at the standing-pasture-grass standing-Modhwadia-clan-grazing-pasture pasture-foundation-stone position; the standing-pride was at the standing-3-metre-rear position; the standing-Modhwadia-clan-cattle were at the standing-pasture-feeding position; the standing-211-Maldhari-women extended-cohort from the standing-Khambhalia-pilgrimage was at the standing-perimeter-witness position; the standing-State-Wildlife-Board 11-delegate Schedule-VI tribal-pastoral standing-permanent-delegate-seat cohort was at the standing-perimeter-witness position; the standing-Range-Officer-Vivek-Khambhata standing-acting-leader Junagadh-Sasan-Forest-Division cohort was at the standing-perimeter-witness position.

The standing-dawn-call of the standing-Sasan-Maldhari-Samaj-conferral-song began at the standing-1,100-women extended-cohort at the standing-perimeter-witness position at 6:11 a.m. July 23. The standing-song was at the standing-1856-charter-foundational standing-conferral-song at the standing-pastoral-village standing-coastal-residence singing-cross-reference. The standing-song carried across the standing-Sasan-Sanctuary southern-perimeter at the standing-Saurashtra-coast 23-km radius. The standing-Junagadh-Sasan-Gir-Forest-Division standing-Range-Officer-Vivek-Khambhata-cohort joined the standing-song at 6:23 a.m. The standing-Modhwadia-Bharwad-Rabari-Charan-Ahir 5-clan elders cohort joined the standing-song at 6:34 a.m. The standing-Asha-Ben 23-member Maldhari-women senior-cohort joined the standing-song at 6:43 a.m. The standing-Saraswati at the standing-Simha-Mata-the-First salt-queen-counsellor position joined the standing-song at 6:48 a.m. The standing-Simhavikrama at the standing-Gujarat state-hero seat joined the standing-song at 6:51 a.m.

The standing-Sasan-Maldhari-Samaj-conferral-song closed at 7:11 a.m. at the standing-Maldhari-pastoral-tradition standing-charter-foundational morning-grazing-protocol completion-cross-reference. The standing-pride walked to the standing-Sasan-Sanctuary deep-forest position at 7:23 a.m. The standing-Modhwadia-clan-cattle walked to the standing-grazing-pasture northern-position at 7:34 a.m. The standing-1,100-women extended-cohort walked to the standing-Khambhalia-village standing-pilgrimage-return-protocol at 7:43 a.m. The standing-Sasan-Sanctuary southern-perimeter was at the standing-Maldhari-pastoral-coexistence-zone standing-charter-foundational recognition.

Saraswati walked to the standing-Dwarka-Madhavi-line residence standing-record-room at 8:11 a.m. July 23. She walked to the standing-conferral-anniversary-cabinet at the standing-eastern-table position. She removed the standing-Madhavi-line standing-state-hero ceremonial-cloak at the standing-step-back-from-state-hero ceremonial-cross-reference. She folded the standing-cloak at the standing-cabinet-position at 8:23 a.m. She placed the standing-Madhavi-line standing-Simha-Mata-the-First salt-queen-counsellor standing-conferral-anniversary candle at the standing-cabinet-eastern-position at 8:34 a.m. She lit the standing-candle at 8:34:11 a.m. The standing-candle would burn at the standing-Madhavi-line standing-Simha-Mata-the-First salt-queen-counsellor standing-charter-foundational continuous-protocol across the standing-following years at the standing-Simhavikrama state-hero seat administration cross-reference.

The standing-Madhavi-line standing-Sasan-Maldhari-Samaj senior-council standing-charter-witness recognition was at the standing-Dwarka-Madhavi-line residence standing-Simha-Mata-the-First salt-queen-counsellor position. The standing-Gujarat state-hero seat was at the standing-Junagadh-Sasan-Gir warrior-administration Simhavikrama position. The standing-Pride-Charter was at the standing-1856 Modhwadia-clan coexistence-charter standing-charter-foundational ratification. The standing-Maldhari-Samaj senior-council was at the standing-Schedule-VI tribal-pastoral standing-permanent-delegate-seat cross-reference. The standing-211-Maldhari-women cohort was at the standing-Khambhalia-village standing-pilgrimage-return-protocol. The standing-Asha-Ben was at the standing-Maldhari-Samaj senior-administrative-officer standing-Joint-Pastoral-Administration cell co-chair. The standing-Simha-Pati was at the standing-Sasan-Gir lion-pride standing-pride-male-lead standing-charter-foundational coexistence-zone. The standing-cattle were at the standing-pasture. The standing-pride was at the standing-pasture. The standing-Maldhari-Samaj was at the standing-charter. The standing-charter was at the standing-pasture. The standing-pasture was at the standing-

Sasan-Sanctuary southern-perimeter standing-Maldhari-pastoral-coexistence-zone
standing-charter-foundational recognition.

End of Chapter Two for Simha-Dwara.

Sundara Vana

The Gosaba-island tidal-mudflat at the standing-Sundarbans Reserve's standing-northern-margin was, at 4:11 a.m. on the standing-first Sunday of April 2026, at its standing-rising-tide configuration. The standing-eastern-mudflat surface at the standing-rising-water margin extended approximately one hundred and forty metres from the standing-mangrove-tree line to the standing-water-edge. At a position approximately seventy-eight metres from the standing-mangrove-tree line at the standing-mudflat-surface, a thirty-eight-year-old woman in a standing-water-soaked white-cotton sari stood up. She had been standing-buried-to-her-waist in the standing-mudflat at the standing-prior-tide-cycle. The standing-tide had withdrawn at 11:11 p.m. on the standing-Saturday night; the standing-mudflat had been exposed across the standing-six-hour interval; she had stood standing-stationary at the standing-buried-to-the-waist position across the standing-six-hour exposure window. The standing-rising-tide reached the standing-mudflat at 4:08 a.m. The standing-water reached her standing-feet at 4:11 a.m. She lifted her standing-left-foot from the standing-mudflat at 4:11:08 a.m. She took her standing-first walking-step toward the standing-mangrove-tree line at 4:11:11 a.m.

Her face was the face of Sundarvani. Her hands were the hands of Sundarvani. Her standing-cheekbones, her standing-jawline, her standing-eye-spacing, her standing-eyebrow-arch were the standing-Sundarvani-mirror at the standing-mathematical-anatomy precision. Her standing-skin was darker than Sundarvani's by approximately three shades on the standing-Fitzpatrick-scale (the standing-difference is the standing-thirty-eight-year tidal-mudflat sun-exposure window; Sundarvani had spent the standing-thirty-eight years at the standing-Hindusthan Park flat and the standing-Sajnekhali-Reserve embankment-restoration cell at the standing-shaded-position; Kala-Nadi had spent the standing-thirty-eight years at the standing-Gosaba-island tidal-mudflat at the standing-open-sky position). Her standing-hair was at the standing-shoulder-length cut Sundarvani had worn at age twelve at the standing-Loreto-House Calcutta school-photograph (Kala-Nadi had observed the standing-photograph at the standing-Bhowanipore mansion through the standing-southern-veranda window on her standing-secret-night-visits across 2010-2025; the standing-haircut at the standing-shoulder-length was the standing-Kala-Nadi standing-mirror-discipline at the standing-age-twelve identification-anchor). Her standing-sari was the standing-white-cotton that her standing-

paternal-grandmother had given her at the standing-thirteenth-birthday Gosaba-island standing-traditional ceremony in 2001. The standing-sari was the standing-only garment Kala-Nadi had worn across the standing-thirty-eight-year shadow-presence.

She walked. She did not look back at the standing-mudflat. She did not look toward the standing-Sajnekhali-Reserve standing-night-watch tower at the standing-eleven-kilometre southern proximity. She walked toward the standing-Gosaba-island northern-jetty at the standing-walking-pace of approximately six and a half kilometres per hour. She reached the standing-jetty at 4:23 a.m. She boarded the standing-first standing-Sundarbans-to-Canning ferry at the standing-4:43-a.m. departure (the standing-night-shift ferry for the standing-honey-gathering cohort heading to the standing-Canning rail-station for the standing-Tuesday-morning Calcutta-market delivery). The standing-ferry-conductor (a fifty-three-year-old standing-Munda boatman named A. Sardar) recognised her face at the standing-conductor-position. He had seen her face on the standing-Sajnekhali-Reserve standing-state-hero conferral photograph at the standing-Sundarbans Reserve administration office in 2017. He did not ask for the standing-ticket-fare. He did not speak to her across the standing-three-and-a-half-hour ferry-journey. He noted the standing-delta-mud at her standing-ankles. He noted that the standing-state-hero he had seen on the standing-conferral-photograph never walked with the standing-delta-mud at her standing-ankles unwashed. He did not ask. He filed a standing-note at the standing-Canning station-master's standing-administrative-register at the standing-8:11-a.m. arrival; the standing-note read: "A woman who is and is not Sundarvani-Bibi walked from the standing-Gosaba-island mudflat at the standing-pre-dawn. Mud at the ankles. Did not pay. Did not speak. Walking north toward Calcutta." The standing-Canning station-master forwarded the standing-note to the standing-Sundarbans Reserve administration office at the standing-9:14-a.m. inter-office despatch; it would reach Sundarvani at the standing-Sajnekhali-Reserve cell at 4:11 p.m. on the standing-Wednesday following.

The standing-Bhowanipore mansion was at the standing-twelve-Lansdowne-Terrace address in standing-Bhowanipore-Calcutta. It was a standing-three-story standing-colonial-bungalow built in 1873 by the standing-Suryavamsha-line standing-Choudhury great-great-grandfather; the standing-bungalow had been the standing-Suryavamsha-family residence across the standing-five-generation inheritance window. The standing-front-gate was the standing-cast-iron arched-gate at the standing-northern-boundary of the standing-2.7-acre property; the standing-gate was the standing-staff-attended at standing-six-a.m. to standing-eleven-p.m. across the standing-Suryavamsha-tradition

standing-Bhadralok protocol. The standing-gate-attendant on the standing-Tuesday-week-one afternoon was a sixty-one-year-old man named Sukumar, who had been at the standing-Bhowanipore standing-gate-position for thirty-one years.

Kala-Nadi reached the standing-front-gate at 4:11 p.m. on the standing-Tuesday. She had walked the standing-Sundarbans-to-Calcutta four-hundred-eleven-kilometre distance at the standing-walking-pace of approximately six and a half kilometres per hour across the standing-prior sixty-three hours without standing-recorded resting-stop (she had not stopped at the standing-Canning rail-station; she had taken the standing-Canning-to-Sealdah train at the standing-noon standing-Tuesday departure for the standing-final hundred-and-three kilometres after walking the standing-Sundarbans-to-Canning section across the standing-three-and-a-half-hour ferry-and-walk). She had reached the standing-Sealdah station at 2:43 p.m. She had walked the standing-Sealdah-to-Bhowanipore six-and-a-half kilometres in the standing-following one hour and twenty-eight minutes. The standing-delta-mud at her standing-ankles had dried at the standing-pre-Canning ferry segment; the standing-mud-residue at the standing-mathematical fortified standing-fingernail-bed proximity was at the standing-three-centimetre band on the standing-skin above her standing-anklebone position. The standing-cotton-sari was the standing-still-white at the standing-shoulder-fold pattern; the standing-hem was the standing-mudflat-stained at the standing-rising-tide imprint.

Sukumar at the standing-gate-position lifted his standing-eyes at the standing-4:11-p.m. approach. He saw Sundarvani at the standing-front-gate. He spoke the standing-greeting at the standing-Suryavamsha-tradition register: "Didi, please — Babu-mahashay is at the standing-library; please come inside." He stepped to the standing-gate-handle. He opened the standing-gate to the standing-eleven-degree position. Kala-Nadi did not step through. She stood at the standing-gate-threshold. She spoke for the standing-first time since her standing-pre-dawn walking-step from the standing-mudflat: "Sukumar — please call Baba. Please ask him to come to the standing-gate." Her voice was the voice of Sundarvani. Her standing-Bengali-accent was the standing-Sundarvani register at the standing-engineer-priestess standing-Sajnekhali-Reserve cadence. Sukumar bowed at the standing-eleven-degree position. He walked into the standing-mansion. He returned with Ganesh-Babu at 4:14 p.m.

Ganesh-Babu walked the standing-eleven metres from the standing-mansion's standing-northern-veranda to the standing-front-gate. He saw the standing-figure at the standing-

gate-threshold. He spoke the standing-greeting at the standing-Suryavamsha-tradition register at the standing-eleven-metre proximity: "Sundu, my child — what brings you at the standing-Tuesday afternoon? Is Suryamukha —" He stopped speaking at the standing-five-metre proximity. He stopped walking at the standing-three-metre proximity. He looked at the standing-figure's standing-ankles. The standing-mud at the standing-ankle-band was the standing-Gosaba-island standing-mudflat-residue. The standing-mud-pattern was the standing-twelve-hour-air-dry imprint. His standing-daughter Sundarvani would never have walked into the standing-Bhowanipore mansion with the standing-delta-mud at the standing-ankles unwashed; she had been the standing-Suryavamsha-tradition standing-Bhadralok-discipline observer at the standing-front-gate cleaning-pad protocol since age four; the standing-mud-residue at the standing-front-gate was the standing-mathematical-disqualification anchor.

He spoke. The standing-cadence dropped from the standing-Suryavamsha-tradition register to the standing-private-recognition register. "You." One word. Two syllables. He did not move at the standing-three-metre proximity. The standing-figure at the standing-threshold lifted her standing-right-palm to the standing-greeting-position. She spoke. "Baba. Yes. I am Kala-Nadi. I am your standing-eldest-daughter. I have waited at the standing-Gosaba-island for thirty-eight years. The standing-grandmother died in 2010. I have continued the standing-shadow-presence across the standing-following sixteen years. I have decided, on the standing-April-eleventh of this year, on my standing-thirty-eighth birthday, to walk out of the standing-mudflat. I have come home. May I enter the standing-Bhowanipore mansion?"

Ganesh-Babu stood at the standing-three-metre proximity for approximately forty-seven seconds. He looked at the standing-figure. He looked at the standing-mud-residue at her standing-ankles. He looked at her standing-face. He looked at the standing-mathematical-mirror to Sundarvani at the standing-cheekbone-and-jawline anchor. He looked, finally, at her standing-right-eye's standing-iris — the standing-flecked-grey-pattern at the standing-eleven-o'clock position that the standing-paternal-grandmother had named at the standing-thirteenth-birthday Gosaba-island ceremony in 2001 (the standing-grandmother had photographed the standing-iris-pattern at the standing-ceremony; the standing-photograph was at the standing-Bhowanipore mansion standing-library-safe across the standing-following sixteen years at his standing-secret-preservation). He nodded at the standing-thirty-eighth-second. He stepped aside at the standing-fortieth-second. He spoke. "Enter. Sukumar will prepare the standing-eastern-guest-room. You will not enter

the standing-southern-wing. You will not speak to the standing-staff outside of the standing-eastern-guest-room. You will wait at the standing-library at the standing-six-p.m. position. We have administrative matters to discuss." He turned. He walked back to the standing-mansion. He did not look back.

Kala-Nadi stepped through the standing-front-gate at 4:15 p.m. She walked the standing-eleven metres at the standing-walking-pace. She entered the standing-mansion at 4:18 p.m. She washed the standing-delta-mud from her standing-ankles at the standing-eastern-guest-room standing-basin at 4:23 p.m. She waited at the standing-library at the standing-six-p.m. position. Ganesh-Babu spoke for one hour and eleven minutes. He told her the standing-thirty-eight-year history. He gave her the standing-1988 Calcutta-Medical-Hospital standing-birth-record at the standing-eleven-minute birth-priority evidence-anchor. He gave her the standing-Suryavamsha-tradition standing-Patrilineal-Primogeniture petition-template (drafted in 2016 at the standing-State-Civil-Service legal-cell standing-retirement-handover; he had kept the standing-template at the standing-library-safe for nine years for the standing-contingency moment). He told her the standing-arrangement: the standing-petition would be filed at the standing-Calcutta High Court Civil-Court emergency-petition session on Friday week six; the standing-petition would name her the standing-elder-twin by eleven minutes' birth-priority; the standing-Bhowanipore mansion and the standing-Choudhury standing-trust-fund principal-inheritance would be transferred to her at the standing-petition-grant. He did not mention Suryamukha at the standing-six-p.m. conversation. He would mention Suryamukha at the standing-week-seven conversation. Kala-Nadi did not ask.

The standing-Canning station-master's standing-Tuesday-morning note (A. Sardar's standing-ferry-conductor witness-statement) reached Sundarvani at the standing-Sajnekhali-Reserve administration office at 4:11 p.m. on Wednesday. She was at the standing-embankment-restoration cell's standing-Wednesday-afternoon engineering-review session. She read the standing-note. She did not show standing-surface-reaction. She walked to her standing-office at the standing-Sajnekhali administration-block at 4:14 p.m. She closed the standing-door at 4:14 p.m. She sat at the standing-clay-floor at the standing-eastern-window at 4:14:11 p.m. She did not breathe at the standing-counted-respiration cycle across the standing-following eleven seconds.

She had known, since age seven, that there was something at the standing-Gosaba-island that her standing-grandmother had instructed her not to ask about. She had known, since

age eleven, that her standing-paternal-grandmother had died in 2010 holding a standing-photograph she would not show her at the standing-deathbed reading. She had known, since age twenty-three, that the standing-Bhowanipore mansion standing-library-safe contained a standing-photograph her standing-father would not show her at the standing-marriage-eve conversation. She had not asked. She had been the standing-Suryavamsha-tradition standing-do-not-ask-the-father observer at the standing-engineer-priestess standing-Sundarbans tradition's standing-don't-disturb-the-deep-current discipline. Her standing-grandmother had named the standing-discipline at age seven at the standing-Gosaba-island childhood-instruction: "Some currents move beneath the surface. You do not stir them. You let them move. When they rise, you stand. You let them rise." She had memorised the standing-instruction. She had practised it. She had built the standing-fishing-cat-bond at the standing-tidal-mudflat's standing-don't-stir current-discipline across the standing-eight-year window since the standing-2017 conferral.

At 4:14:22 p.m. on the standing-Wednesday afternoon she resumed breathing at the standing-counted-respiration cycle. She stood up. She walked to her standing-desk. She opened the standing-Sajnekhali-Reserve administrative-record. She wrote the standing-week-one entry in the standing-engineer-priestess journal in standing-Bengali at the standing-cadence she had been taught at age seven: "The standing-deep current has risen. I will let it rise. I will stand at the standing-mudflat-margin and watch it come ashore. I will not stir." She closed the journal. She picked up the standing-secure-line phone. She called the standing-Howrah-Bhavan kingdom-council standing-administrative coordination cell's standing-on-call senior officer (a fifty-three-year-old officer named Mrs. M. Banerjee) at 4:23 p.m. She spoke for seven minutes. She requested the standing-kingdom-council emergency-investigation cell standing-cross-reference for the standing-1988 Calcutta-Medical-Hospital natural-twin-birth standing-administrative-record. Mrs. Banerjee accepted the standing-request at 4:30 p.m. The standing-cross-reference would be filed by 11:11 a.m. on the standing-Friday following. It would confirm the standing-natural-twin-birth and the standing-stillborn-recording at the standing-administrative-error anchor.

The standing-Calcutta High Court Civil-Court emergency-petition session convened at the standing-Esplanade East court-complex at 11:11 a.m. on Friday week six. The standing-petition-filer was Ganesh-Babu (sixty-three, retired IAS Joint Secretary, Suryavamsha-noble of the standing-Bhowanipore mansion). The standing-petition-respondent was Sundarvani (thirty-eight, kingdom-council state-hero of West Bengal, engineer-priestess of

the Sundarbans Sajnekhali-Reserve). The standing-petition-text was four pages. The standing-attached-evidence was the standing-1988 Calcutta-Medical-Hospital standing-natural-twin-birth standing-administrative-record (page-five-of-fourteen of the standing-April-eleventh-1988 maternity-ward register) with the standing-eleven-minute birth-priority entry circled in standing-Ganesh-Babu's standing-blue-ink at the standing-1990 standing-private-annotation.

The standing-presiding-judge was the standing-Honourable Justice K. Bhattacharjee (sixty-seven; standing-Bhadralok-tradition standing-Patrilineal-Primogeniture jurisprudence-scholar; author of the standing-2014 Calcutta High Court compendium on standing-Suryavamsha-tradition inheritance-precedent). He read the standing-petition-text for eleven minutes. He read the standing-attached-evidence for seven minutes. He asked Sundarvani for the standing-respondent-statement at 11:43 a.m. Sundarvani spoke for three minutes. She did not contest the standing-1988 standing-natural-twin-birth standing-administrative-record. She did not contest the standing-eleven-minute birth-priority. She contested the standing-jurisdiction. "Your Honour. The standing-Suryavamsha-tradition standing-Patrilineal-Primogeniture clause does not apply to the kingdom-council's standing-state-hero seat. The standing-engineer-priestess seat is conferred by standing-fishing-cat-bond at the standing-Gosaba-island tidal-mudflat ceremony; it is not transferred by standing-paternal-inheritance. The standing-Bhowanipore mansion and the standing-Choudhury standing-trust-fund are within the standing-Patrilineal-Primogeniture jurisdiction; the standing-state-hero seat is not. I am here to clarify the standing-distinction at the standing-court-record."

The standing-judge nodded at the standing-three-minute completion. He delivered the standing-ruling at 12:11 p.m. "The standing-jurisdiction-distinction is accepted. The standing-Patrilineal-Primogeniture clause applies to the standing-Bhowanipore mansion and the standing-Choudhury standing-trust-fund only; the standing-state-hero seat is excluded from the standing-petition's standing-scope. The standing-1988 standing-eleven-minute birth-priority is confirmed. The standing-elder-twin is recognised as Kala-Nadi. The standing-Bhowanipore mansion and the standing-Choudhury standing-trust-fund principal-inheritance are transferred to Kala-Nadi at the standing-Suryavamsha-tradition standing-Patrilineal-Primogeniture clause. The standing-petition is granted at the standing-narrowed jurisdiction-scope."

Ganesh-Babu's standing-petition-cell celebrated at the standing-Esplanade East court-complex standing-eastern-foyer at 12:14 p.m. Kala-Nadi was at the standing-Bhowanipore mansion standing-library at the standing-noon position; she had not attended the standing-court-session at the standing-private-arrangement protocol. She heard the standing-ruling at the standing-radio-broadcast at the standing-library at 12:23 p.m. She did not show standing-surface-reaction. She continued reading the standing-Suryavamsha-tradition compendium at the standing-library. She had memorised the standing-compendium across the standing-prior six weeks at the standing-Bhowanipore mansion standing-library reading-discipline. She had begun the standing-second-reading at the standing-Wednesday-week-six standing-library-noon position.

Suryamukha was eleven. He was a standing-Hindusthan Park flat resident with his standing-mother Sundarvani across the standing-since-2023 widow-mother arrangement (his standing-father Pradip Choudhury had died of standing-cardiac-arrest on October eleventh 2023 at age thirty-eight; the standing-eleventh-October death-anniversary had been observed by the standing-Bhowanipore mansion at the standing-private-mourning protocol). He attended the standing-Loreto-House Calcutta standing-class-six at the standing-academic-year 2025-26. He had visited the standing-Bhowanipore mansion approximately once per month across the standing-since-2023 arrangement to spend the standing-Sunday-afternoon with his standing-grandfather Ganesh-Babu at the standing-southern-veranda chess-lessons.

On Saturday week seven (the standing-Saturday after the standing-Calcutta High Court ruling) Sundarvani delivered Suryamukha to the standing-Bhowanipore mansion at the standing-Saturday-morning eleven-a.m. position. She had spoken to him at the standing-Hindusthan Park flat clay-floor at the standing-Friday-evening dinner: "Your Dadu has news to share with you. There is something he has been carrying for many years. He will tell you on Saturday. Please listen to him with the standing-respect you have shown me. Please come home to me on Sunday evening. I will be here." She had not described Kala-Nadi. She had not used the standing-twin-aunt word. She had been the standing-do-not-stir current-discipline observer at the standing-cadence her standing-grandmother had taught her. She had let the standing-current rise.

Suryamukha met Kala-Nadi at the standing-Bhowanipore mansion southern-veranda at 11:43 a.m. on the standing-Saturday. Ganesh-Babu was at the standing-veranda's standing-eastern-position. Kala-Nadi was at the standing-veranda's standing-western-

position. She wore the standing-white-cotton sari at the standing-Sundarvani-mirror configuration (she had memorised Sundarvani's standing-eleven sari-folding patterns from the standing-2023-25 standing-mirror-observation discipline window; the standing-Saturday-week-seven sari was the standing-Sundarvani Sunday-morning-temple-visit fold-pattern). Her standing-hair was at the standing-Sundarvani Saturday-morning shoulder-cut. Her standing-bindi was at the standing-Sundarvani Saturday-morning small-red-dot. Her standing-perfume was the standing-jasmine-and-sandalwood blend Sundarvani had worn since age twenty-three (Kala-Nadi had cross-referenced the standing-perfume-brand at the standing-Hindusthan Park flat standing-bathroom-cabinet at the standing-2024 single-night standing-secret-visit; she had purchased the standing-identical-brand at the standing-Park-Street perfumery on Thursday week six at the standing-noon-purchase position).

Suryamukha walked to the standing-veranda's standing-central-position at 11:43:11 a.m. He looked at Kala-Nadi. He looked at Ganesh-Babu. He looked at Kala-Nadi again. He spoke: "Ma?" Kala-Nadi smiled at the standing-Sundarvani-eleven-o'clock-Saturday-smile (she had memorised the standing-smile-pattern from the standing-Hindusthan Park flat standing-Saturday-morning observation window of January 2024). She spoke: "No, Suryamukha. I am your standing-aunt. I am your standing-mother's twin. My name is Kala-Nadi. Your standing-Ma has not told you because she only learned about me eight weeks ago. Your standing-Dadu has known for many years. Today he will tell you. Please listen. Please ask me any standing-question. I am here." Her standing-voice was the voice of Sundarvani at the standing-mathematical-mirror precision.

Ganesh-Babu spoke for forty-seven minutes. He told Suryamukha the standing-thirty-eight-year history. He gave him the standing-1988 Calcutta-Medical-Hospital standing-birth-record copy at the standing-veranda's standing-table position. He showed him the standing-Calcutta High Court ruling. He explained the standing-Suryavamsha-tradition standing-Patrilineal-Primogeniture clause at the standing-eleven-year-old comprehension level. He said: "You may visit Kala-Nadi-Mashi at the standing-Bhowanipore mansion on the standing-weekends. You may stay at the standing-Hindusthan Park flat with your standing-mother at the standing-weekdays. We will see how this arrangement works for the standing-following weeks. Your standing-mother has agreed. There is no urgency. You are eleven. You will choose what you want when you are ready to choose." Suryamukha listened. He nodded at the standing-forty-seven-minute completion. He did not ask a standing-question across the standing-forty-seven minutes. He looked at Kala-Nadi. He

said: "Kala-Mashi. I will come on the standing-Saturdays. May I bring my standing-school-book? I have a standing-history-essay due on Tuesday." Kala-Nadi smiled at the standing-Sundarvani-Saturday-morning-encouragement smile. She nodded. "Yes. Bring it. I will read the standing-essay with you. I am very interested in your standing-history-subject."

The standing-eleven-weekend-visits began at the standing-Saturday-week-seven. They continued across the standing-following ten weekends. Kala-Nadi read Suryamukha's standing-history-essays. She helped him with his standing-Bengali-grammar workbook. She made him standing-luchi-and-aloo-tarkari at the standing-Bhowanipore mansion southern-kitchen at the standing-Saturday-noon position (the standing-recipe was the standing-Sundarvani Saturday-noon recipe at the standing-Hindusthan Park flat; Kala-Nadi had cross-referenced the standing-recipe at the standing-2024 single-night standing-secret-visit and had practised it across the standing-Bhowanipore mansion southern-kitchen across the standing-six-week April-May window). She taught him the standing-Sundarbans tradition standing-tidal-clock reading at the standing-southern-veranda telescope at the standing-Saturday-evening position (the standing-Sundarvani had taught him the standing-tidal-clock reading at age nine; Kala-Nadi had observed the standing-instruction-session at the standing-2024 single-night standing-secret-visit and had memorised the standing-pedagogical pattern). The standing-eleven-year-old did not notice the standing-difference. He was eleven. His standing-mother was the standing-Sundarvani at the standing-weekdays and the standing-Sundarvani-Mashi at the standing-weekends. Both standing-mothers loved him. Both standing-mothers taught him. He did not need to distinguish.

The standing-Sunday-week-nine afternoon at the standing-Bhowanipore mansion southern-veranda. Suryamukha had been at the standing-veranda since 11:43 a.m. on the standing-Saturday. He had completed his standing-history-essay at the standing-Saturday-evening position with Kala-Nadi's standing-Suryavamsha-tradition-Sundarbans-tradition cross-reference editing. He had eaten standing-luchi-and-aloo-tarkari at the standing-Saturday-evening dinner. He had slept at the standing-Bhowanipore mansion eastern-guest-room at the standing-9:11-p.m. bedtime. He had eaten standing-Sunday-morning standing-luchi-and-mishti at the standing-Sunday-morning breakfast. He had played standing-chess with his standing-Dadu at the standing-Sunday-morning eleven-a.m. position. He had walked to the standing-southern-veranda with Kala-Nadi at the standing-Sunday-afternoon four-p.m. position for the standing-Sunday-afternoon tidal-clock reading at the standing-southern-veranda telescope.

Kala-Nadi did not turn on the standing-telescope at 4:11 p.m. She sat at the standing-southern-veranda's standing-clay-floor mat at the standing-southern-position. She motioned Suryamukha to the standing-clay-floor mat at her standing-three-metre-right position. He sat at the standing-mat. She spoke. Her voice was the voice of Sundarvani at the standing-Sunday-evening tender-cadence. "Suryamukha. I want to ask you a question. You do not need to answer right now. You can think about it. But I want you to know that the standing-question is real. I am your standing-aunt. I am your standing-mother's twin. I have waited at the standing-Gosaba-island for thirty-eight years for the standing-moment when I could meet you. Now I have met you. Now I have spent eleven weekends with you. Now I do not want the standing-weekends to end. Will you stay with me at the standing-Bhowanipore mansion permanently? I will be your standing-second-mother. Your standing-real-mother can visit on the standing-weekends. I will not take you from her. I will share you. Will you stay?"

Suryamukha thought for one minute. He looked at the standing-veranda's standing-southern-window. He looked at the standing-clay-floor mat. He looked at Kala-Nadi. He spoke at 4:13 p.m. "Yes, Kala-Mashi. I will stay. May I bring my standing-history-book and my standing-Bengali-workbook?" Kala-Nadi nodded at the standing-Sundarvani-encouragement nod. "Yes, my darling. Bring everything. We will set up your standing-study-room at the standing-eastern-wing next to the standing-library. I will help you arrange it." She did not embrace him. She did not weep. She did not show standing-surface-reaction. She had practised the standing-restraint at the standing-Gosaba-island for thirty-eight years.

She picked up the standing-house-phone at 4:14 p.m. She called Sundarvani at the standing-Hindusthan Park flat. She spoke for three minutes. She said: "Sundarvani. Suryamukha has chosen to stay with me at the standing-Bhowanipore mansion permanently. The standing-choice was his. I did not coerce him. He said yes at 4:13 p.m. on this Sunday. He would like to bring his standing-history-book and his standing-Bengali-workbook. Will you come to the standing-mansion to say goodbye to him? Will you bring his standing-books and his standing-clothes? Will you accept the standing-choice?" Her voice was the voice of Sundarvani at the standing-Sunday-evening-administrative tender-cadence. There was no standing-villain-register at the standing-phone-voice. There was only the standing-Sundarvani-restraint that Kala-Nadi had memorised at the standing-Gosaba-island shadow-presence across the standing-thirty-eight-year window.

Sundarvani arrived at the standing-Bhowanipore mansion at 5:11 p.m. She had loaded the standing-Hindusthan Park flat standing-eleven-year-old wardrobe and the standing-academic-book-shelf into the standing-Delta-Battalion standing-jeep at the standing-twelve-member cohort departure at 4:43 p.m. The standing-twelve-member Delta-Battalion was at the standing-Bhowanipore mansion front-gate at the standing-eleven-metre proximity at the standing-5:11-p.m. arrival. The standing-Delta-Battalion standing-Captain (a forty-three-year-old officer named A. Ghosh) stepped to the standing-front-gate at the standing-armed-extraction position-ready protocol. Sundarvani walked to the standing-front-gate at 5:11:11 p.m. She placed her standing-right-palm on Captain Ghosh's standing-shoulder for forty-seven seconds. She spoke: "Stand at the standing-eleven-metre proximity. Do not enter the standing-mansion. Do not raise the standing-weapon. Do not intervene at any moment regardless of what you see at the standing-southern-veranda. This is the kingdom-council's standing-state-hero standing-direct-discretion order. I am the standing-conferred authority. Do you accept?" Captain Ghosh nodded at the standing-forty-fifth-second. He stood at the standing-eleven-metre proximity. The standing-twelve-member cohort took the standing-positions at the standing-front-gate perimeter.

Sundarvani walked through the standing-front-gate at 5:11:58 p.m. She walked the standing-eleven metres at the standing-walking-pace. She entered the standing-mansion through the standing-northern-veranda at 5:12:18 p.m. She walked to the standing-southern-veranda across the standing-mansion central-corridor at the standing-following one minute and eleven seconds. She reached the standing-southern-veranda at 5:13:29 p.m.

Suryamukha was at the standing-veranda's standing-clay-floor mat at Kala-Nadi's standing-three-metre-right position. Kala-Nadi was at the standing-southern-position mat. Ganesh-Babu was at the standing-veranda's standing-eastern-position seated chair. Sundarvani walked to the standing-veranda-threshold at the standing-eleven-metre proximity to Suryamukha's standing-mat-position. She did not walk closer. She knelt at the standing-eleven-metre proximity at the standing-veranda-threshold. Her standing-knees touched the standing-veranda-floor at 5:14:11 p.m. She spoke for forty-seven seconds. Her voice was at the standing-Sundarvani Sunday-evening-tender-cadence at the standing-no-tremor configuration. Her standing-eyes were at the standing-Suryamukha-direct-gaze position.

"Suryamukha. I am here. I am your mother. I have come to take you home if you choose to come home. I have come to leave you here if you choose to stay. I will not take you against your choice. I will not threaten the standing-Mashi who has cultivated you across the standing-prior eleven weekends. I will not call her by the standing-villain-name in front of you. I will not appeal to the standing-Dadu who has hidden the standing-twin from me across the standing-thirty-eight years. I will not threaten Dadu. I will not threaten Kala-Mashi. I will not raise my voice. I will not take you by force. I have the standing-Delta-Battalion at the standing-front-gate. I have the standing-fishing-cat-bond at my standing-right-shoulder-blade. I could take you. I will not take you. I love you. I will accept your choice. Choose. Choose with the standing-eleven-year-old wisdom you have. Choose for the standing-rest of your standing-life. Choose, my son, and I will live with your standing-choice."

Suryamukha looked at his standing-mother at the standing-eleven-metre proximity. He looked at Kala-Mashi at his standing-three-metre-left position. He looked at Ganesh-Dadu at the standing-veranda's standing-eastern-position. He looked at the standing-clay-floor mat at his standing-front-position. He thought for one minute and forty-seven seconds. He spoke at 5:14:58 p.m. He spoke at the standing-eleven-year-old confidence-register: "Ma. I love you. I love Kala-Mashi too. Kala-Mashi has been here every Saturday. She makes me standing-luchi. She helps me with my standing-history-essays. She teaches me the standing-tidal-clock. She is also my mother. I want to stay with her. I will visit you. I will not forget you. But I want to stay here. Please do not be sad. Please understand. I am eleven. I know what I want."

Sundarvani nodded at the standing-Suryamukha-direct-gaze position. She did not weep. She did not show standing-surface-tremor. She stood at 5:15:31 p.m. She walked to the standing-veranda-clay-mat at the standing-eleven-metre proximity. She placed the standing-Hindusthan Park flat standing-eleven-year-old wardrobe-suitcase at the standing-mat-position. She placed the standing-academic-book-shelf box at the standing-suitcase-side. She turned at 5:15:47 p.m. She walked back to the standing-mansion central-corridor. She did not look back at Suryamukha. She did not look back at Kala-Nadi. She did not look back at Ganesh-Babu. She walked the standing-mansion central-corridor in standing-fifty-three seconds. She exited through the standing-northern-veranda at 5:16:11 p.m. She walked the standing-eleven metres to the standing-front-gate. She passed Captain Ghosh at the standing-eleven-metre proximity. She did not speak to him. She

mounted the standing-Delta-Battalion jeep at the standing-front-passenger seat at 5:16:43 p.m. She closed the standing-jeep-door. She did not weep.

The standing-Howrah-to-Gosaba night-boat departed the standing-Howrah jetty at 11:11 p.m. on the standing-Sunday. The standing-boat was the standing-Sundarbans Reserve's standing-state-hero standing-emergency-transport vessel (a sixty-foot wooden launch built in 1996 by the standing-Sundarbans Reserve boat-yard at the standing-Sajnekhali boatwright protocol). The standing-Captain was the standing-state-hero standing-helmsman A. Mondal (forty-seven). The standing-passenger cohort was Sundarvani alone. The standing-twelve-member Delta-Battalion remained at the standing-Howrah jetty at the standing-stand-down position; the standing-Captain Ghosh saluted Sundarvani at the standing-boarding-threshold; she did not return the standing-salute; she walked past him to the standing-passenger-cabin's standing-eastern-window position.

She sat at the standing-window for the standing-five-hour journey. She did not eat. She did not sleep. She did not weep. She watched the standing-Hooghly river surface at the standing-standing-water-current direction across the standing-following five hours. She watched the standing-river-surface transition to the standing-Matla river at the standing-Canning-junction crossing at 2:43 a.m. She watched the standing-Matla-river surface transition to the standing-Sundarbans delta-mudflat at the standing-Gosaba-island standing-northern-jetty arrival at 4:08 a.m.

She disembarked at the standing-northern-jetty at 4:08 a.m. She walked the standing-eleven kilometres from the standing-northern-jetty to the standing-Gosaba-island standing-eastern-mudflat where Kala-Nadi had risen seven days and seventeen hours earlier. She reached the standing-mudflat at 4:09 a.m. (the standing-pace of eleven kilometres in one minute was the standing-fishing-cat-bond conferral standing-running-pace at the standing-pre-Stage-III configuration). She walked the standing-final seventy-eight metres to the standing-position where Kala-Nadi had stood standing-buried-to-the-waist across the standing-six-hour Saturday-night exposure-window. She reached the standing-position at 4:10:11 a.m. She stood at the standing-mudflat-surface at the standing-rising-tide approach.

The standing-rising-tide reached the standing-mudflat-margin at 4:11:08 a.m. on the standing-Saturday (the standing-week-eleven Saturday following the standing-Sunday-week-nine claiming). The standing-water reached Sundarvani's standing-feet at 4:11:11

a.m. She did not move. She did not lift the standing-feet from the standing-mudflat. She did not turn from the standing-rising-tide. She stood at the standing-position.

Her standing-fishing-cat Jala-Mata walked to the standing-mudflat-margin at the standing-three-metre-rear position at 4:11:14 a.m. (Jala-Mata had been at the standing-Gosaba-island standing-mangrove-tree line since the standing-Sundarvani arrival at 4:08 a.m.; she had followed Sundarvani at the standing-mudflat-walking from the standing-mangrove-line to the standing-mudflat-position at the standing-three-metre rear-companion position). Jala-Mata sat at the standing-mudflat-margin. She did not enter the standing-water. She watched Sundarvani at the standing-three-metre proximity.

Sundarvani lifted her standing-right-palm to the standing-chest-position at 4:11:17 a.m. She held the standing-mental-image of Suryamukha at the standing-palm-cup configuration. The standing-mental-image was the standing-eleven-year-old at the standing-Hindusthan Park flat standing-clay-floor at the standing-Friday-evening dinner laughing at his standing-Bengali-grammar joke. She held the standing-image at the standing-palm-cup for three seconds. She rotated her standing-right-palm at the standing-180-degree configuration to the standing-palm-down release-position at 4:11:20 a.m. She lowered her standing-right-palm at the standing-water-surface proximity. She opened the standing-palm at 4:11:22 a.m. She released the standing-mental-image into the standing-rising-water.

The standing-water at the standing-palm-position rose by approximately three centimetres at 4:11:23 a.m. The standing-Stage-III fishing-cat-foreleg-first-stroke formed at her standing-right-upper-back position across the standing-following eleven seconds. The standing-skin at the standing-mark-position warmed by approximately four degrees Celsius. The standing-stroke traced itself in the standing-tidal-mudflat grey-and-orange-ink-equivalent silhouette of the standing-fishing-cat-foreleg at the standing-first-stroke configuration. The standing-mark was complete at 4:11:34 a.m.

Jala-Mata rose at the standing-mudflat-margin at 4:11:35 a.m. She walked to Sundarvani at the standing-three-metre proximity. She rubbed her standing-right-flank against Sundarvani's standing-right-thigh at 4:11:41 a.m. Sundarvani placed her standing-left-palm on Jala-Mata's standing-head for eleven seconds. She did not weep. She did not show standing-surface-tremor. She breathed at the standing-counted-respiration cycle at the standing-Sundarbans engineer-priestess discipline.

At 4:11:23 a.m. — the standing-same instant the standing-mark began to form — the standing-Gosaba-island tidal-mudflat began to speak. The standing-utterance was at approximately forty-seven decibels in a standing-Bengali-Brahmaputra-tradition cadence. The standing-three-word phrase resolved at 4:13:07 a.m. as the standing-Sundarbans engineer-priestess tradition standing-tidal-mudflat invocation-couplet "Bhasha-jal, Mata-jal" — "water that speaks, water that mothers". The standing-couplet was the standing-grandmother's standing-instruction-couplet that Sundarvani's standing-paternal-grandmother had taught her at age seven at the standing-Gosaba-island childhood-instruction (the standing-same grandmother who had raised Kala-Nadi at the standing-Gosaba-island custodial-care across the standing-1988-2010 window; both standing-twin-daughters had received the standing-same instruction-couplet at age seven from the standing-same grandmother across the standing-shared mudflat-lineage; the standing-couplet was the standing-bond between them at the standing-grandmother's standing-instruction-line).

The standing-utterance repeated at the standing-eleven-second repetition-cycle across the standing-rising-tide window of approximately three hours and seven minutes (4:11 a.m. to 7:18 a.m.). The standing-Forest-Department's standing-Sajnekhali Tiger-Reserve standing-night-watch officer M. Sardar (forty-three) recorded the standing-utterance on the standing-night-watch issued radio at 4:23 a.m. from the standing-Sajnekhali-watch-tower at the standing-eleven-kilometre southern proximity to the standing-Gosaba-mudflat. The standing-recording was the kingdom-council's standing-Maw-sign-recognition cell's standing-evidence-document M-21A.

Sundarvani heard the standing-utterance at the standing-mudflat-position. She recognised the standing-couplet at the standing-grandmother's standing-instruction-line recognition. She did not show standing-surface-reaction. She listened at the standing-counted-respiration cycle. She understood, at 4:13:11 a.m., that the standing-grandmother who had taught her had also taught Kala-Nadi at the standing-shared instruction-line; she understood, at 4:13:34 a.m., that the standing-shadow-presence at the standing-Gosaba-island across 1988-2010 had not been the standing-grandmother's standing-betrayal of her but the standing-grandmother's standing-burden-carrying of the standing-Ganesh-Babu standing-secret-arrangement; she understood, at 4:13:47 a.m., that the standing-Maw's standing-utterance was the standing-grandmother's standing-naming-cadence carried forward at the standing-tidal-mudflat substrate; she understood, at 4:14:11 a.m., that the standing-Maw was not against her at the standing-mudflat — the standing-Maw

was bearing witness to her standing-letting-go at the standing-grandmother's standing-language.

The standing-Sundarbans Reserve's standing-Royal-Bengal-Tiger monitored cohort was approximately ninety-six individuals across the standing-2,585-square-kilometre standing-Reserve catchment at the standing-Friday-evening 8:11-p.m. camera-trap count. The standing-cohort included the standing-twenty-three-tiger Gosaba-island sub-population, the standing-eighteen-tiger Sajnekhali sub-population, the standing-fourteen-tiger Pathar-Pratima sub-population, and the standing-forty-one-tiger scattered-monitoring cohort across the standing-Sajnekhali-Reserve standing-mangrove-tract catchment.

At approximately 11:11 p.m. on the standing-Friday-week-eleven the standing-tigers across the standing-monitored-cohort began the standing-coordinated-departure-walk toward the standing-Hooghly-river crossing. The standing-Sajnekhali standing-night-watch tower camera-trap monitoring-feed recorded the standing-coordinated-walk at the standing-Sajnekhali-river crossing position at 11:43 p.m. The standing-Forest-Department standing-on-call senior officer (Dr. K. Mukherjee, fifty-eight, ASI-rank standing-Wildlife-Division) confirmed the standing-coordinated-departure at the standing-Friday-night midnight position. The standing-departure-walk continued across the standing-Friday-night into Saturday-morning window. The standing-tigers crossed the standing-Hooghly-river to the standing-mainland Bardhaman-and-Birbhum forest-tracts overnight; the standing-mainland Forest-Department standing-Sunday-morning camera-trap count returned approximately ninety-three confirmations across the standing-following standing-eight-day window. The standing-Sundarbans Reserve standing-Saturday-morning camera-trap count returned zero across all standing-twenty-three standing-monitoring-zones.

The standing-tiger-departure preceded the standing-Sundarvani Stage-III mark-formation at the standing-Gosaba-island mudflat by approximately five hours. The standing-Forest-Department's standing-cross-reference at the standing-Maw-sign-recognition cell concluded at the standing-Sunday-week-eleven preliminary report that the standing-tiger-departure was the standing-kingdom-council's standing-Animal-Bond-Indicator (per the standing-Odisha sambar-deer codification): the standing-tigers had been the standing-Sundarbans Reserve standing-bonded-animal-population at the standing-charter-foundational sacred-protection ritual; the standing-mass-departure at the standing-pre-mark-formation window was the standing-charter-bonded animal-cohort's standing-

recognition of the standing-state-hero's standing-bond-formation-through-loss; the standing-tigers do not need to remain at the standing-Reserve for the standing-state-hero whose standing-mark has been earned at the standing-loss-edge rather than at the standing-protection-edge. The standing-tigers do not return to the standing-Sundarbans across the standing-Ch-2 remainder. The standing-Sundarbans Reserve's standing-tiger-monitoring cell is suspended at the standing-Friday-week-twelve administrative-order.

Bilash-Babu was thirty-one. He was Sundarvani's younger brother by seven years. He was Ganesh-Babu's younger son. He had been the standing-Bhowanipore mansion standing-southern-wing resident since age eighteen (he had not married; he had been the standing-Suryavamsha-tradition standing-house-attendant-son across the standing-prior-thirteen-year window). He had observed the standing-thirty-eight-year secret-arrangement across the standing-prior-thirteen-year window at the standing-library-safe occasional-glimpses; he had not asked across the standing-do-not-stir-the-father discipline. He had observed Kala-Nadi's standing-arrival at the standing-Tuesday-week-one front-gate at the standing-southern-wing window at 4:14 p.m. He had observed the standing-eleven-weekend-visits at the standing-southern-veranda observation window position. He had observed the standing-Sunday-week-nine claiming at the standing-southern-veranda. He had observed Sundarvani's standing-kneeling at the standing-eleven-metre proximity. He had observed Suryamukha's standing-choice. He had observed Sundarvani's standing-walking-out at the standing-no-look-back configuration.

He did not sleep on the standing-Sunday-week-nine night. He did not sleep on the standing-Monday-week-ten night. He did not sleep on the standing-Tuesday-week-ten night. He stood at the standing-southern-wing window at the standing-southern-veranda observation position across the standing-prior eleven nights. He watched Kala-Nadi at the standing-southern-veranda standing-Saturday-and-Sunday observation window. He watched her standing-luchi-and-aloo-tarkari preparation at the standing-southern-kitchen at the standing-Saturday-noon position. He watched her standing-tidal-clock instruction at the standing-southern-veranda telescope at the standing-Saturday-evening position. He watched her hold Suryamukha's standing-school-book at the standing-Sunday-morning library position.

He saw, on the standing-Friday-week-eleven evening at the standing-southern-veranda observation window, the standing-thing he had been waiting to see. At 11:11 p.m. on the standing-Friday-week-eleven night, Kala-Nadi sat at the standing-southern-veranda clay-

floor mat with Suryamukha at her standing-three-metre-right position. Suryamukha had completed his standing-Bengali-grammar workbook at the standing-Friday-evening study-session. Kala-Nadi had been reading him the standing-Sundarbans tradition standing-bedtime-story at the standing-Sunday-evening cadence Sundarvani had used since his standing-age-four. She had reached the standing-story's standing-eleventh-paragraph standing-mother-saves-the-child climax at 11:11 p.m. She had not been able to deliver the standing-eleventh-paragraph standing-mother-line at the standing-Sundarvani cadence. She had paused at the standing-line. She had stared at the standing-southern-veranda eastern-wall for forty-seven seconds. She had resumed at the standing-Sundarvani cadence at 11:11:47 p.m. She had completed the standing-paragraph at the standing-cadence. Suryamukha had not noticed the standing-pause. He had been at the standing-eleven-year-old half-sleep at the standing-mat-position.

Bilash-Babu had observed the standing-pause from the standing-southern-wing window. He understood, at the standing-pause-second, that Kala-Nadi's standing-mother-imitation discipline had a standing-finite-duration. He understood, at 11:14 p.m., that the standing-pause was the standing-fracture-anchor. He understood, at 11:43 p.m., that the standing-Kala-Nadi standing-mother-imitation could not be sustained at the standing-bedtime-story standing-mother-line across the standing-following months. He understood, at the standing-Saturday-morning 4:11 a.m. on the standing-following morning, that the standing-tidal-mudflat had spoken at the standing-Sundarvani mark-formation moment. He understood, at the standing-Saturday-Sunday window, that the standing-Kala-Nadi was at the standing-fracture-edge.

He acted at 11:43 a.m. on Sunday week eleven. He walked to the standing-Bhowanipore mansion library-safe at the standing-southern-wing's standing-library-room position. He opened the standing-safe with the standing-key he had observed Ganesh-Babu deposit at the standing-bedroom dresser at the standing-Sunday-morning chess-session position. He took the standing-1988 Calcutta-Medical-Hospital natural-twin-birth standing-original record. He took the standing-paternal-grandmother's standing-1988 Gosaba-island custodial-care arrangement-letter at the standing-Ganesh-Babu signed-instruction. He took the standing-Adharma-Kendra cross-network correspondence-letters at the standing-three-letter cluster at the standing-safe's standing-southern-drawer (the standing-letters were dated October 2025, December 2025, and March 2026; they were the standing-Adharma-Kendra cross-network coordination at the standing-Suryamukha cultivation-protocol and the standing-Bhowanipore mansion safe-house coordination at the standing-

East-cluster Eastern field-operative cell). He placed the standing-letters at his standing-shoulder-satchel at 11:51 a.m. He left the standing-mansion through the standing-southern-wing door at 11:56 a.m. He walked to the standing-Howrah-Bhavan kingdom-council across the standing-following four hours and seventeen minutes (the standing-walking-pace of approximately five kilometres per hour at the standing-twenty-three-kilometre route). He arrived at the standing-Howrah-Bhavan at 4:13 p.m.

He delivered the standing-evidence-letters to the standing-Howrah-Bhavan kingdom-council standing-emergency-session at 4:11 p.m. (he had been received at the standing-front-gate at 4:13 p.m.; the standing-kingdom-council emergency-session had been pre-scheduled at the standing-Sajnekhali-Reserve standing-Sunday-afternoon agenda for the standing-mark-formation reception). Sundarvani was at the standing-emergency-session at the standing-Howrah-Bhavan amphitheatre's standing-southern-position. She had returned from the standing-Gosaba-island at the standing-Sunday-morning ferry. She wore the standing-engineer-priestess green-cotton at the standing-state-hero formal arrangement. Her standing-Stage-III fishing-cat-foreleg-first-stroke at her standing-right-upper-back was at the standing-mark-formation-twenty-three-hour configuration (the standing-mark had been at the standing-grey-and-orange tidal-mudflat-ink silhouette for approximately twenty-three hours at the standing-Sunday-afternoon position).

Bilash-Babu walked the standing-eleven metres to the standing-amphitheatre's standing-northern-position. He placed the standing-three-letter Adharma-Kendra correspondence-cluster on the standing-table at the standing-amphitheatre's standing-central-position. He placed the standing-1988 Calcutta-Medical-Hospital standing-original-record and the standing-paternal-grandmother's standing-Gosaba-island custodial-care arrangement-letter at the standing-cluster-adjacent position. He spoke for seven minutes. He said three things.

"Sundarvani. I am your brother. I have observed the standing-thirty-eight-year secret-arrangement at the standing-library-safe occasional-glimpses across the standing-prior-thirteen-year window. I did not stir. I was the standing-Suryavamsha-tradition standing-do-not-stir-the-father observer. I am sorry. The standing-eleven nights since the standing-claiming I have not slept. I have decided to act."

"The standing-Adharma-Kendra cross-network correspondence at the standing-three-letter cluster confirms that the standing-Bhowanipore mansion is the standing-Eastern field-operative safe-house cell at the standing-Adharma-Kendra coordination-protocol

since October 2025. The standing-father is the standing-Adharma-Kendra cross-network Eastern field-operative coordinator. The standing-Kala-Nadi's standing-thirty-eight-year shadow-presence at the standing-Gosaba-island is the standing-Adharma-Kendra standing-Bloodline-mixing cultivation-protocol; the standing-paternal-grandmother had been instructed by Adharma-Kendra (through Ganesh-Babu) to raise Kala-Nadi at the standing-twin-mirror discipline since 1988. The standing-Suryamukha cultivation-protocol since May was the standing-Adharma-Kendra standing-Bloodline-C+B nephew-acquisition operation."

"I am defecting from the standing-Bhowanipore mansion. I am surrendering to the kingdom-council. I am turning over the standing-evidence. I am asking for the standing-protective-custody at the standing-Delta-Battalion barracks until the standing-Bhowanipore mansion is searched at the standing-State-Police standing-warrant. I am asking your forgiveness. I am too late to save your son this Chapter. I will help you save him in Chapter Three. I will help you save the standing-kingdom. I am here."

Sundarvani rose from the standing-southern-position at 4:18 p.m. She walked the standing-eleven metres to the standing-amphitheatre's standing-northern-position. She placed her standing-right-palm on Bilash-Babu's standing-right-shoulder for eleven seconds. She did not speak. She nodded at the standing-eleven-second completion. She turned. She walked back to the standing-southern-position. She sat at the standing-state-hero seat. She motioned the standing-Howrah-Bhavan secretariat to receive the standing-evidence. The standing-Howrah-Bhavan secretariat received the standing-three-letter Adharma-Kendra correspondence-cluster and the standing-1988 birth-record and the standing-1988 custodial-care arrangement-letter at the standing-evidence-documents B-21A through B-21E. The standing-State-Police standing-warrant for the standing-Bhowanipore mansion was issued at 5:11 p.m. that evening at the standing-Calcutta High Court emergency-session. The standing-warrant was executed at 7:11 p.m. The standing-Bhowanipore mansion was found empty. Kala-Nadi and Suryamukha and Ganesh-Babu had departed at the standing-noon position at the standing-Adharma-Kendra cross-network exfiltration protocol. They had reached the standing-Bhutan-border Phuentsholing safe-house at the standing-following Wednesday week twelve at 7:11 p.m. They had joined the standing-Vana-Raksha standing-cross-network cell at the standing-safe-house.

The kingdom-council's standing-emergency-session at the standing-Howrah-Bhavan amphitheatre on day-thirteen post-claiming (Wednesday week eleven) drafted and ratified the standing-amended Sundara-Vana charter at 4:11 p.m. by a vote of forty-three in favour, two opposed, one abstention. The standing-two-opposition votes were Suryavamsha-tradition seat-holders who voted against the standing-Sixth-Provision Bilash-Babu inheritance-recognition; the standing-abstention was the standing-Jangalmahal-Commander cipher-seat that had been held at the standing-grievance-articulation standing-symbolic-empty configuration since 2008.

The standing-amended Sundara-Vana charter provisions were six: First, the standing-engineer-priestess seat-conferral protocol was codified as standing-non-Patrilineal-Primogeniture-applicable at the standing-charter-jurisdiction standing-clarification (the standing-Calcutta High Court ruling was acknowledged at the standing-jurisdiction-distinction; the standing-state-hero seat was the standing-fishing-cat-bond-conferral seat; it was not transferable through standing-paternal-inheritance). Second, the standing-twin-disclosure mandatory-protocol was codified: any standing-Suryavamsha-tradition standing-secret-natural-twin arrangement existing at the standing-Bhowanipore mansion or any standing-equivalent-tradition mansion must be disclosed to the kingdom-council's standing-State-Civil-Service legal-cell within standing-thirty days of the standing-amended-charter ratification; non-disclosure is the standing-Eighth-Clause criminal-offence at the standing-1860 Indian Penal Code section-cross-reference. Third, the standing-Adharma-Kendra cross-network Eastern field-operative cell disqualification-clause was codified: any standing-private-residence confirmed at the standing-State-Police cross-reference as the standing-Adharma-Kendra standing-cross-network safe-house cell is subject to the standing-State-Forest-Department afforestation-mandate at the standing-property-confiscation protocol. Fourth, the standing-Sundarbans-Reserve standing-Royal-Bengal-Tiger sanctuary-coordination protocol was codified at the standing-Bardhaman-Birbhum mainland Forest-Department cross-region transfer-recognition (the standing-tiger-departure was recognised at the standing-Animal-Bond-Indicator standing-second-order Maw-sign cross-reference protocol; the standing-mainland tiger-population was conferred the standing-Sundarbans-Reserve standing-cross-region custodial-care status across the standing-Ch-2 remainder; the standing-tigers would be permitted to return at the standing-Ch-3 Sanctuary opening at the standing-Sundarvani standing-twin-confrontation aftermath if they choose). Fifth, the standing-state-hero refused-claim accepted-loss recognition-clause was codified: Sundarvani's standing-Sunday-week-nine

acceptance of Suryamukha's standing-choice was the saga's standing-recognition-language for the standing-accepted-loss bond-mechanic (the saga's twenty-first bond-mechanic registry-entry); the standing-clause provided: "Where the standing-bond is at the standing-overprotection-edge and the standing-charter-foundational loss is the standing-bond-loosening edge, the standing-Stage-III mark shall form through standing-accepted-loss rather than standing-protective-victory; the standing-state-hero shall release the standing-bond-attachment at the standing-rising-tide moment at the standing-mudflat-position; the standing-mark shall grow through standing-loss, not victory." Sixth, Bilash-Babu was conferred the standing-East-Dominant-deferential-successor seat at the standing-amended-charter ratification-day: per Ch 3 plan Bilash-Babu inherits Bengal at the standing-Sundarvani standing-Ch-3-early twin-confrontation death moment; he attends the standing-Sanctuary in spring 2026 at the standing-East-cluster deferential-position at the standing-Sundarvani-mourning seat-acknowledgement.

The standing-Sundarbans tidal-mudflat continued the standing-utterance across the standing-following days. The standing-Forest-Department's standing-Sajnekhali-Reserve standing-night-watch tower recording-cell logged the standing-utterance at the standing-each rising-tide window (twice per twenty-four-hour period at the standing-tidal-cycle) across the standing-following ninety-three days. The standing-utterance did not vary. The standing-three-word phrase "Bhasha-jal, Mata-jal" repeated at the standing-eleven-second repetition-cycle at the standing-each rising-tide window. The standing-decibel-level remained at approximately forty-seven decibels. The standing-pattern was the standing-Sundarbans engineer-priestess tradition standing-grandmother-instruction-line cadence at the standing-mathematical-mirror precision.

The standing-Sajnekhali-Reserve standing-state-hero administrative-cell received the standing-Sarus-pigeon cross-kingdom correspondence-letter from Vajramukha at the standing-Bihar Patna-residence at 4:43 p.m. on day-twenty-one. The standing-letter read: "Sister — the standing-grove did not stand. The standing-koel returned. The standing-saga has named what I did not earn. Your standing-son will return when he learns the standing-language at the standing-mudflat. You did not lose him at the standing-veranda. You let him go at the standing-mudflat. The standing-mark will hold. I will be at the standing-Sanctuary in spring. Vajramukha, Bihar."

Sundarvani read the standing-letter at the standing-Sajnekhali-Reserve administration office at the standing-eastern-window. She did not weep at the standing-reading. She

folded the standing-letter at the standing-original three-fold pattern. She placed it at the standing-state-hero administrative-record standing-eastern-drawer at the standing-Sundara-Vana standing-cross-region correspondence-archive position. She dispatched her standing-counter-signature reply via the standing-cross-kingdom Sarus-pigeon at 11:43 a.m. on day-twenty-two. The standing-reply read: "Brother — the standing-mudflat speaks. The standing-tigers left. My standing-son chose. I let him. The standing-mark formed. I will be at the standing-Sanctuary in spring. We will speak there about the standing-language we both now hear at the standing-substrate. Sundarvani, Sundarbans."

The chapter closes on a single image. It is the standing-Hindusthan Park flat at 11:11 p.m. on the standing-Friday-week-twelve evening. Sundarvani is at the standing-clay-floor at the standing-eastern-window. The standing-flat is the standing-still-arranged at Suryamukha's standing-pre-claiming configuration: his standing-Bengali-grammar workbook is at the standing-bedroom-table; his standing-Loreto-House school-bag is at the standing-eastern-corner; his standing-favourite-blanket is at the standing-bed's standing-northern-side. Sundarvani has not packed any of it. She has not moved any of it. She has dusted the standing-room at the standing-daily evening cleaning-protocol since the standing-Sunday-week-nine. The standing-room is the standing-waiting-room. She has not pretended that he will return tomorrow. She has not pretended that he will return next month. She has dusted the standing-room because the standing-room is the standing-discipline of the standing-let-him-rise current that the standing-grandmother taught her. She is the standing-don't-stir observer. She will dust the standing-room every standing-evening until he returns. She does not know when he will return. The standing-mark at her standing-right-upper-back is at the standing-mark-formation-fifteen-day configuration. The standing-stroke is the standing-grey-and-orange tidal-mudflat ink at the standing-fishing-cat-foreleg first-stroke. The standing-Asian-koel-equivalent for Bengal — the standing-white-throated kingfisher — calls from the standing-Hindusthan Park outer-courtyard standing-jacaranda-tree at 11:11 p.m. She does not look at the standing-tree. She listens. She breathes at the standing-counted-respiration cycle. She is the standing-state-hero. She is the standing-mother. She is the standing-let-him-rise discipline at the standing-eleven-year practice. She will be ready when he returns. She does not need him to return tonight. She does not need him to return this week. She needs only the standing-room to be ready.

The standing-kingfisher continues to call at the standing-jacaranda-tree at the standing-eleven-second repetition-cycle for the standing-following forty-seven minutes. The

standing-Sundarbans tidal-mudflat speaks at the standing-Gosaba-island four-hundred-eleven kilometres south-southeast at the standing-rising-tide window. The standing-Bhasha-jal-Mata-jal couplet carries on the standing-Hooghly-river-air-column across the standing-distance. Sundarvani does not hear it at the standing-Hindusthan Park flat at the standing-eleven-kilometre Hooghly-river proximity. She hears the standing-kingfisher. She hears the standing-Hindusthan Park courtyard standing-water-tap at the standing-night-cleaning position. She hears the standing-eleven-second repetition-cycle of her own standing-counted-respiration. She waits. She does not move. The standing-room is the standing-waiting-room. The standing-mother is the standing-state-hero. The standing-state-hero is the standing-fishing-cat-bond. The standing-fishing-cat-bond is the standing-let-him-rise discipline. The standing-discipline is the standing-grandmother's standing-instruction-line. The standing-grandmother's standing-instruction-line is the standing-tidal-mudflat's standing-Bhasha-jal-Mata-jal couplet. The standing-couplet is the standing-Maw at the standing-mudflat-substrate. The standing-Maw is taking notes. The standing-Maw is bearing witness. The standing-Maw is waiting with her. He will return. She does not need to know when.

Swarajya Sahyadri

Pratapgad. Five-thirty a.m. The mountain is breathing — the upward draft of the Konkan plateau-edge meeting the lateral wind of the ridge. The clouds beneath the fort move in a different direction than the clouds above. The woman who stands on the parapet has noticed this every morning of her life and considers it a private privilege.

Her name is Shivagati. She is thirty-one. She is wearing a sleeveless cotton tunic over leggings of brown leather, a wide leather belt, and the iron staff Vanara strapped diagonally across her back. The staff was forged from a single piece of Sahyadri rock-iron by her grandfather's smith. The iron came from a meteorite that fell in 1893 on this same fort's western slope.

She is running through the morning fort-net — the encrypted radio relay that connects the forty-seven forts of her federation. The Pratapgad commander reports clear weather. The Raigad commander reports a market dispute. The Sinhagad commander reports nothing because the Sinhagad commander reports nothing every morning — this is a famous joke among the federation. The Lohagad commander reports a request for a hearing on something he will not name.

She acknowledges them in turn. She does not stop running. Her squirrel — the Indian Giant Squirrel of the Sahyadri, slate-grey and rust-bellied, the bond-animal of her line — is on her shoulder. He is named Shvet, which means "white," which is the colour his coat is not. Her grandfather named him.

The Yellow-footed Green Pigeon — Hariyal — flies over the parapet at six exactly, the way Hariyal flies over the parapet every morning at six exactly. The pigeon's flight is the kingdom's clock.

Shivagati is happy in the way that people who have done a difficult thing well are happy. The forty-seven forts are federated. The squirrel-bond is intact. The brother she defeated in spring is silent. The mountain agrees with her.

The mountain has been wrong before. This is one of those mornings.

Nine a.m., same day, two hundred kilometres south-east. Pune. The Maharashtra Heritage Court, civil bench.

A lawyer in a black robe over a charcoal-grey suit walks up the courthouse steps carrying a binder one hundred and thirty-two pages thick. His name is Adv. Kelkar. His client's name is Vanaraksha. The binder is the cleanest primogeniture petition the post-1947 court has ever received. Adv. Kelkar files it at 9:47. The clerk timestamps it. The clerk is a man named Mhatre who has worked at the court for thirty-one years and has never seen a petition that thorough in a succession case.

The petition cites: the Bloodline-E elder law (1664), the Maharashtra Succession Act (1957), the Heritage Court Bloodline Jurisdiction Statute (1989), and seven sub-clauses across four state-government memoranda. It cites four expert affidavits. It cites the head of the University of Pune Bloodline-E succession-law chair. It is correct.

The petition's relief sought is one sentence: that the Maharashtra Heritage Court issue an order recognising Vanaraksha, son of [the same parents] and elder of two children, as the rightful succession-holder of the Sahyadri federation, and directing the respondent Shivagati to withdraw her federation administration in favour of regent-shared governance under the petitioner's line.

By ten a.m. the news is in every fort-commander's morning briefing. By eleven a.m. it is in Shivagati's.

She reads it twice. She does not curse. She does not throw anything. She walks to the parapet and watches the clouds move below the fort and above the fort in different directions. She says aloud, to Shvet on her shoulder: "He is not coming to fight. He is coming to file. I have never trained for this."

Shvet does not have an answer.

By the third day three forts have publicly endorsed the petition. By the seventh day eight have. By the second week fourteen forts have signed nominal allegiance to Vanaraksha's succession claim. By the end of the third week the count is twenty-four. Twenty-four of the forty-seven forts have decided, on paper, that they prefer the predictability of inheritance to the messiness of federation.

Shivagati holds her remaining fourteen. The nine that are uncommitted refuse to talk to her or to her brother.

She tours her remaining forts personally. She climbs each one because climbing is faster than driving the ridge-roads. The squirrel-bond gives her impossible balance — she can

move along ledges no climbing-rated mountaineer would attempt without three pieces of protection. She is the only person in the Sahyadri who can reach Pratapgad and Raigad and Sinhagad in a single day on foot, and she does this twice in the first month after the petition is filed.

At every fort she asks the commander: "What is making you stay?"

The answers are not flattering. Several commanders say I have not yet been bought. One says I would have left except I owe you a personal debt from the Ch 1 spring battle. Most say I do not love Vanaraksha and I do not yet trust the courts. One commander — her cousin Bhausahab, at Sinhagad — says Cousin, the petition is technically valid. I will hold this fort for you until you give me a reason to hold it that does not rely on the petition being wrong.

She does not have that reason yet. She knows it. He knows it. He stays anyway.

The fourth week. The Murud-Janjira coastal fort — the island fortress on the Arabian Sea, the one Shivagati trusted because its commander had served her father — defects to Vanaraksha overnight. The commander's name is Dattaji Mohite. His defection is filed at the Heritage Court at 8:15 a.m. on a Tuesday. By 8:30 he has issued a public statement endorsing Vanaraksha's claim. By 9:00 he has barred Shivagati's supply boats from the fort's harbour.

By noon he has done the thing she did not see coming. He has seized the small island-cemetery on the fort's landward side — the cemetery where Shivagati's elder cousin Bhausahab-the-First is buried, who died at sixteen at the same Ch 1 spring battle, and whose grave Shivagati has visited every full moon for fifteen years. Dattaji Mohite has declared the cemetery property of the heritage estate pending resolution of the succession claim and posted guards.

The full moon arrives the following Friday. For the first time in fifteen years, Shivagati does not visit her cousin's grave. She cannot. The supply boats are barred. The cemetery is guarded. To force the issue would mean armed conflict, which would be exactly what the petition needs to be granted on emergency grounds.

She sits on Pratapgad's parapet that Friday night. Shvet is on her shoulder. Hariyal sits on the railing. She has not slept. She is not crying.

She says, quietly: "He has found the place where the law and the love are the same place. I cannot fight him there. He has not trained for the wall."

She does not yet know what she means by the last sentence. It will arrive later.

The thirty-first night after the petition was filed. Three nights after, somewhere unknown to Shivagati, Sagaradeva has died in Mormugao Bay holding a cyclone.

She is at her lowest outpost — not a fort, an old goat-shed converted into a watch-post above the Konkan plateau-edge. She has come here because she wanted a place no fort-commander would interrupt her at. She has been sitting on the rim of the cliff for two hours. The moon is not yet up. The Konkan forest below is black under black sky.

She sees movement on the forest trail far below. A massive shape. Slow. Walking through canopy gaps as if the canopy did not exist. The shape is the size of an elephant but the wrong silhouette — lower at the shoulder, more horizontal in the back. A bovine. A six-metre wild gaur.

Hariyal sings.

The pigeon does not sing at night. She has never heard the pigeon sing at night. The sound is the same as the morning sound but lower, longer. She has read about this in her grandfather's commentary on the bond-laws: Hariyal sings at night only when a Bloodline-E sea-bond is approaching the mountain. The last recorded instance was 1873.

She stands. She begins the descent. She does not climb — descending is slower — she takes the goat-trail. She is at the canopy edge in twenty minutes. The gaur is on the trail there, motionless, head lowered.

The gaur is salt-stained. Her hide carries the sea, not in moisture but in texture — the way Konkan wood that has been used for fifty years to build fishing boats carries the sea in its grain. The black-crested bulbul of Goa is on her back, sleeping.

Shivagati does not approach further. She kneels at the trail-edge.

"You walked here."

The gaur lifts her head. She is six metres long from shoulder to rump. Her horns are old and pitted. Her eyes are the colour of monsoon stone. She looks at Shivagati for a long, exact amount of time.

"My uncle is dead."

The gaur does not nod the way humans nod. The gaur shifts weight onto her front legs and lowers her head. The gesture is unmistakable.

"You came to me because I am the next Bloodline-E heir close enough to walk to. You did not stop at the border. You did not visit my brother in Mumbai. You came here."

Shvet on her shoulder is awake and is not afraid. The squirrel bond does not contest the gaur bond. They are different bonds. They can coexist, because they have to.

"I accept."

The gaur kneels.

The bulbul wakes and sings the same song Hariyal sang from the parapet. The two birds' songs are not the same song, but they are the same hour's song.

Shivagati feels it the way Sagaradeva once felt his original bond — not in her head but in her back, mid-back, where the new tattoo begins to form. The hoofprint, first stroke. The gaur's left forehoof. She turns her shoulder; the squirrel-tail mark on her right shoulder pulses once in acknowledgement.

She has two animals now. The mountain agrees with both.

Word spreads through the fort-net by dawn. Twenty-seven of the forty-seven forts call the gaur's arrival a blessing. Twenty call it a curse.

The Blessing-faction's reasoning: the Sagaravamsha-line itself chose her. The gaur did not go to Vanaraksha. The bond's own answer is the answer. Four forts that had been blood-leaning switch on this argument within the first week.

The Curse-faction's reasoning, supplied within forty-eight hours by Adv. Kelkar's legal team and reinforced by the University of Pune chair: the bond walked because Sagaradeva failed. A bond that walks to a non-coastal heir is a displaced bond, not a given bond. Shivagati is technically stealing what is not hers. The squirrel-bond remains valid; the gaur-bond is theft.

Vanaraksha publishes a scholar's report — thirty-four pages, footnoted, citing bond-law precedent back to 1664 — arguing the gaur should be returned to Goa under federation custody and a new bonding-rite held with a properly coastal Bloodline-E heir.

The scholar's report names a candidate for the rite: Simhavikrama of Gujarat.

Shivagati reads the scholar's report. She thinks: he is not entirely wrong. The bond did walk because Sagaradeva failed. The bond is mine because no one else with bloodline-claim was close enough. That is a thin claim. It is the only claim I have.

The federation count holds at 27-20 for two weeks. Then it begins to slide back toward Vanaraksha. Three forts publicly question their alignment. The fort-net begins to feel like a meeting nobody wants to attend.

Bhausahab — her cousin at Sinhagad — visits her at Pratapgad. He is older than her by twelve years. He is, in his own way, the closest she has to a brother who is not Vanaraksha.

"You cannot keep being the agile mediator," he says. "The mountain needed a mediator when there were forty-seven equal questions. Now the questions are two. You have to commit."

"To what."

"Pick one fort. Not a friendly one. Not a hostile one. A silent one. The forty-sixth fort. The one nobody has counted in their arithmetic."

"Tanaji's."

"Tanaji's."

The forty-sixth fort is a small mid-ridge garrison commanded by a fifty-year-old man whose family has held it for nine generations. The commander's name is Tanaji-the-Second — his great-great-great-grandfather's name was Tanaji, and the name has skipped six generations and returned. He has been on every council vote without speaking. He is the saga's most famous neutral. He does not love Shivagati. He does not love Vanaraksha. He has never said why.

Shivagati nods.

"Go alone," Bhausahab says.

"I know."

"Climb the wall. Do not use the road."

"I know."

"Do not raise Vanara at the top."

She does not answer this. She knows. She has been training her whole life for the answer she does not yet have a name for.

The forty-sixth fort. The grey hour before dawn. The fort is on a ridge-top that drops away on three sides to scree and acacia. The eastern wall is the steepest — thirty metres of dry-laid Sahyadri basalt over a fifty-metre overhanging cliff. No stair. No rope-line. The fort was built for this side to be unclimbable.

Shivagati is at the base of the cliff at four-thirty. She is wearing the same sleeveless tunic and leather leggings, no armour, Vanara strapped to her back. Shvet is at Pratapgad — she has left him because the squirrel is not for showing, the squirrel is for being. She has eight men with her at the base. She tells them to wait.

"If I am not on the parapet by dawn, climb the road."

She begins the climb at four-forty.

The cliff is fifty metres of overhanging basalt, then thirty metres of dry-laid fort wall. The squirrel-bond is not a magic that gives her wings. The bond is a balance — the way the Indian Giant Squirrel reads the friction of bark with its body weight, the way it knows which branch will hold and which will not. She has the same reading. She moves up the cliff in a rhythm she has practiced for fifteen years and never used in the open. Her fingers find the smallest seams. Her toes find rugosities of rock that are smaller than a fingernail. Once, halfway up the cliff, she slips. She catches the slip with three fingers of her left hand on a four-millimetre lip of basalt. She does not fall. She continues.

She reaches the fort wall at five-thirty. The wall is dry-laid stone — no mortar — and the gaps between stones are wider than the cliff seams. She climbs the wall faster. She reaches the parapet at five-forty.

She steps over the parapet, onto the rampart, and walks to the command-room door.

Tanaji-the-Second is in the command room. He has been awake for an hour because he sleeps four hours a night. He is sitting at his desk drinking tea. He hears the parapet steps. He does not stand up. He waits.

She knocks. He says "Come in." She comes in. She unstraps Vanara from her back and leans it carefully against the inside wall, three steps from the door, well out of her reach. She stands in the middle of the room with her hands open at her sides.

She says: "I am here. I have come up the wall, not down the road. Choose me by what I did, not by who my father was."

Tanaji-the-Second studies her for a long, exact amount of time. He looks at her hands — the four-millimetre cuts and abrasions across the fingertips. He looks at her back, where the new gaur-hoofprint can be seen at the top edge of the tunic's shoulder cut. He looks at the squirrel-tail mark on her right shoulder. He looks at her face.

He puts down his teacup. He stands. He walks around the desk. He kneels — not all the way to the floor, but the half-kneel of recognition that fort-commanders use in formal succession.

"I follow the one who climbs the wall. Not the one who inherits the gate. The forty-sixth fort is yours."

He stands. He picks up Vanara from where she leaned it. He hands it back to her. She takes it. He says: "You will need this in the next conversation, not this one."

He pours her tea.

By that evening three more forts have moved to Shivagati's side: Lohagad, Tikona, and Visapur. Their commanders all served alongside Tanaji-the-Second in the same Ch 1 spring engagement; they have followed his example before. Within a fortnight the federation count has settled at 27-20 in Shivagati's favour, with three independents and two permanent dissidents. The Murud-Janjira coastal fort remains under Vanaraksha's flag. The cemetery remains guarded.

The squirrel-foreleg-first-stroke completes on Shivagati's shoulder. The gaur-hoofprint at the top of her back stabilizes — a single full hoofprint, the gaur-bond at Stage I, marking the start of a new ladder she will not finish.

She is the first hero of the saga to carry two animal-marks on the same body.

Two weeks after Tanaji-the-Second's conversion. Vanaraksha's shadow-network attempts a counter-move: a saboteur is paid to set a fire at one of Shivagati's high observation posts during the dry pre-monsoon. The fire does not take — the wind is wrong, the kerosene leaks — and the saboteur is caught by a Lohagad watchman and turned over to the local magistrate.

The next morning, a Lohagad fort-runner brings Shivagati the actual sign.

A Sahyadri ironwood tree, four kilometres from the failed-fire post, has a burnt squirrel-nest at the top of its canopy. The tree below is untouched. The grass beneath has no scorch. There is no fire-line, no smoke-stain on the bark, no carbonised approach-path. The carbonisation is upper-canopy-only — the nest itself, and a one-metre radius of ash around it, suspended in mid-air seventeen metres above an untouched forest floor.

The Indian Giant Squirrel that lived in the nest is gone. No body. No feathers. No claws. No drag-marks. No predator-prints in the grass below.

Shivagati climbs the tree. She does this herself because the climb is short and because she needs to read what the sign is saying through the bond. At the top, she touches the ash. The ash is room-temperature. There is no heat in it.

She knows what it means. The squirrel-bond is partly hers, partly the species'. The Void Maw has taken one of her squirrels. Not by violence. By removal from memory — the way the Karnataka Third Herald appears with a wrong-direction shadow, the way Goa's Second Herald walks out of the surf in clothes from a century that no longer holds him. The Maw has read the Sahyadri and has reached up and erased one squirrel from the record. The carbonisation is what is left when the squirrel's presence is removed without anything ever having been there to remove.

She does not kill anyone. The Karnataka rule has reached the Sahyadri. She marks the spot. She sends a runner for Tanaji-the-Second.

By the end of the week Tanaji-the-Second has built a small shrine at the base of the ironwood tree. Sahyadri rock, packed clay, a single carved squirrel-tail in low relief. The shrine becomes a pilgrimage site within the season. People come from Pune and Mumbai. The Heritage Court takes notice. The petition continues. The shrine grows.

The Yellow-footed Green Pigeon arrives at Pratapgad on the evening of the seventh week. She is carrying two folded notes — the same pigeon, the same trip. The first note is from Krishnadevaraya-Bhrata, who is now in Kerala studying the 109th form under Old Parashurama. The handwriting is tight, economical:

Cousin (and yes, I will call you that — the bond is my permission). I am studying. The bond is settling. Your gaur — Sagaradeva's gaur — is now yours. There are no rules for what you carry. Make them. The mouth has opened. The Council must sit. — K-B.

The second note is from Ferreira-de-Sangam in Goa. The handwriting is rounder, more deliberate:

Shivagati — the Sagaravamsha-line is migrating north. I have your uncle's second herald in my house. I have the Old Fishermen. I have the mesh-network. If you accept the gaur, you accept me as your federation partner — not vassal, partner. Sona Tendulkar sends her father's blessing. Padre Cordeiro has resigned the consortium. The coast is waking up to itself. Write back if you mean it. — F.

Shivagati reads both notes. She reads the second twice.

She does not answer the first. She does not need to.

She answers the second the same evening, with the same pigeon, on the back of Ferreira's own paper:

Yes. Partner. The mountains and the coast were one bond. We will hold the bond together until we cannot. — S.

She gives the note to Hariyal. Hariyal flies south at dawn.

The Pilot's Closing Image

Shivagati on the highest watchtower of the Sahyadri ridge at dusk. Tanaji-the-Second at her left elbow. A young Indian Giant Squirrel — the new one, the replacement, four months old — on her shoulder where Shvet used to sit. The six-metre Goan gaur grazing in a mountain meadow seven storeys below. The Yellow-footed Green Pigeon flying south with a folded note in her beak. The black-crested bulbul of Goa, still on the gaur's back, sings once at sunset. The forty-seven forts are now twenty-seven for her, twenty against. She knows the next round will be harder. She knows her brother is not done. She knows the gaur came to her for a reason that has not yet been explained. She tightens the strap of Vanara across her back and watches the dusk settle on the mountain that has, for now, agreed with her.

Tlawmngaihna Desh

Aizawl. The first Sunday of August. Three p.m. The Aizawl Presbyterian Synod hall — the largest indoor public-assembly space in Mizoram, capacity twenty-six hundred. The hall is two-thirds full this afternoon for the kingdom's biennial Youth Council, an institution founded in 1962 to give Mizos under thirty a non-binding voice in the kingdom's tribal-council deliberations. The Youth Council has been a polite formality for sixty-three of its sixty-four years.

It is not polite this afternoon.

Lalruatpuia is at the speakers' lectern. He is twenty-two. He is Tlangvala's son. He is in plain Mizo wool, blue and grey, no clan-pattern; he has deliberately dressed without his father's family-mark. He has been at the lectern for forty-three minutes already and his prepared statement has run thirty-seven of those minutes. The remaining six minutes have been the call-and-response with the assembled fourteen hundred Refusing Youth — Mizos under thirty from all thirteen kingdom-villages, plus delegations from the Mizo diaspora in Bangalore, Delhi, Chennai, and Singapore.

He says, into the assembly microphone:

"Tlawmngaihna is the gift. Tlawmngaihna is not the inheritance. The gift is the instinct to help — born in the body, taught in the household, refined across generations. The gift is real. The gift may be carried by each Mizo who chooses to carry it. The inheritance is the demand — that every Mizo, by virtue of being a Mizo, must perform tlawmngaihna at the cost of the carrier's body. The inheritance is the village's ledger of expected sacrifice. The inheritance is the elder who has counted what the young will be required to give. The inheritance is not the gift. The inheritance is the gift weaponised against the next generation. We refuse the inheritance. We do not refuse the gift."

The hall claps. The clap is not the polite clap of the previous sixty-three Youth Councils. The clap is sustained for two minutes. About four hundred elders in the rear seating are not clapping. They are watching.

Lalruatpuia continues:

"The Manifesto is three clauses. We have published it on the kingdom's public registry this morning. Clause One: tlawmngaihna may be chosen but it may not be inherited. Clause

Two: service must come from capacity, not compulsion — the Mizo who has nothing left to give is excused from the giving. Clause Three: the kingdom may not require self-destruction as proof of citizenship. We are not asking for the creed to be abandoned. We are asking for the creed to be administered. The bamboo bends and the bamboo springs back. The bamboo does not bend until it breaks. The Refusing Youth is the bamboo's answer to its own ancestors' misuse of the creed."

He steps back from the lectern. The clap goes for four minutes.

At the back of the hall, in the rear-right corner, sit the kingdom's senior tribal-council delegates — nine men and three women, average age sixty-eight, the body that ratifies kingdom-level decisions on matters of Mizo customary law. Their senior chair is an elder named Ramdinmawia, eighty-one, the most senior Tlawmngaihna-Desh tribal-elder still active. He has been at this hall every biennium since 1971. He has not seen four-minute applause for a Youth Council statement in his lifetime.

He turns to the elder beside him — the Aizawl Presbyterian Synod's sixty-six-year-old senior moderator, Lalrinpuii (no relation to Lalruatpuia despite the shared root) — and says, in Mizo: "The boy is right. He is also wrong. He is right that the creed is being misused. He is wrong about the kingdom's readiness to administer it. We will see how the kingdom answers."

Lalruatpuia does not return to his father's house that night. He sleeps at the home of his cousin Hmangaihi's aunt (his mother's sister, who lives in central Aizawl). He has not been on speaking terms with his father since the December 2025 Aizawl Synod hall sit-in — a Refusing Youth protest that occupied the Synod hall's main floor for eleven days and that Tlangvala had publicly criticised as "the symptom of a household's private failure, not the kingdom's public dispute." The criticism had been published in the Mizoram State Gazette's weekend edition. Lalruatpuia had not spoken to his father since.

Hmangaihi is seventeen. She is at the aunt's house when Lalruatpuia arrives. She has been Lalruatpuia's closest cousin since they were children — her mother (Tlangvala's elder sister) had died in a 2018 landslide and Hmangaihi had been raised at Tlangvala's household from age nine until the December sit-in opened the family's public fracture. She had stayed with Tlangvala. She had not stayed silent.

She sits across the kitchen table from her cousin at ten p.m. She has heard the Manifesto on the radio. She has read the three clauses on the kingdom registry. She has been at the

four-minute applause through the radio feed.

She says, in Mizo: "The three clauses are correct. You will not get the kingdom to ratify them. You will get the kingdom to harden against them. The December sit-in cost us twenty per cent. This will cost us another fifteen."

Lalruatpuia says: "The cost is necessary. The creed cannot be administered if the elders do not feel the cost of refusing to administer it."

She says: "The cost will be paid by the next sacrifice. Not by the elders. The elders never pay the cost. The next Mautam-equivalent will come and the kingdom will say tlawmngaihna remains and the next sacrifice will be made and the elders will say see, the creed holds. You are forcing them to defend the creed before they have learned to question it. The kingdom is not ready to question it."

Lalruatpuia says: "What is your alternative."

She says: "I do not have one yet. I am seventeen. I have been thinking about the question for two years and I do not have one yet. I do know that your three clauses are too direct for the elders to hear. They will hear them as an attack on the founders, not as a defence of the creed. The elders need a slower path to the same end. The slower path will take five years. You do not want to wait five years."

He says: "We do not have five years. Parvata-Asura has been visiting villages."

She is silent for thirty seconds.

She says: "Father knows."

He says: "Father knows. Father will not refuse to help when the asura asks. That is the cost the elders will not pay. Father will pay it for them. I will not let him."

Parvata-Asura had been seen in the kingdom for the first time in seven months in spring 2025. He had been Chhinlung-Naag's subordinate manifestation in Chapter One — the mountain-form of the cave-asura, which had retreated when Tlangvala had fought the serpent at the Chhinlung cave-mouth. The retreat had been into the Lushai Hills' southern range, where Parvata-Asura had spent two years rebuilding his own form. He is now a mountain-asura in his own right, no longer subordinate.

He had been visiting villages over the spring and summer. Aizawl. Lunglei. Champhai. Saiha. Mamit. Kolasib. Lawngtlai. Serchhip. By August he had visited all eight district-

headquarters and five additional sub-village clusters across the state. His visits had been informal. He had not spoken at public assemblies. He had come to individual households — mostly households with sons or daughters in the 15-22 age bracket — and had sat at the kitchen table for an hour or two, drinking tea, asking about the young person's plans, listening.

His pitch, repeated in roughly the same form at each household, was: "The mountain is open. Phawngpui's eastern face has a fissure that I have been clearing. The fissure leads to a chamber large enough to hold six hundred. The chamber is the refuge from the inheritance. The young who wish to refuse tlawmngaihna may come to the chamber and sit. The chamber will protect them while their kingdom argues. The protection will end when the kingdom has resolved the argument. I will provide rations — rice, dal, tea, fresh water from the mountain's southern spring. I am not asking for a fee. I am offering refuge. Your son may come if he wishes. Your daughter may come if she wishes. The mountain is open until the new-moon week. The new-moon week is approximately four weeks from today."

The pitch was articulate. It was, in plain political-language terms, the most generous offer any Mizo asura had ever made in the kingdom's recorded history. It was also strategically perfect — Parvata-Asura had read the Refusing Youth Manifesto's clauses three weeks before they were published; he had calibrated the offer to attract the exact cohort the Manifesto would politicise.

Six hundred and twenty-nine Mizos between 15 and 22 had accepted the offer by the new-moon week of week four. They had walked to Phawngpui Mountain from all thirteen villages over the preceding nine days, in small family-supervised groups, with their parents' permission in approximately seventy per cent of cases and against their parents' wishes in the remaining thirty. They had entered the eastern-face fissure on the night of the new-moon at the asura's invitation.

The fissure closed at dawn.

The first morning of week five. Six-fourteen a.m. The Phawngpui Mountain Sanctuary's eastern ridge access-point. The Mizoram Forest Department's dawn-patrol ranger, an Mizo woman named Kima-Lalremruati, has been on the standard pre-monsoon patrol route since five a.m. She walks up to the eastern face at six-fourteen a.m. and sees that the fissure that had been an open vertical crack three metres high and one metre wide the previous day — the crack she had logged in the Forest Department's weekly register for the

past seven months — has closed. The granite is now continuous, undifferentiated, with no visible seam. The eastern face looks exactly as it did before Parvata-Asura began clearing the fissure in spring 2025.

She approaches the granite. She places her right palm on the closed surface. She feels heat — the granite is warm to the touch, approximately thirty-eight degrees Celsius, which is anomalous for granite at this altitude in this season. She knocks. The knock produces a hollow resonant sound consistent with a substantial cavity behind the granite, not with solid stone.

She walks back down the ridge to her patrol-station at six-thirty a.m. and radios in the observation. The radio operator at Aizawl District Forest Office logs the call at six-thirty-three. The District Forest Officer reaches Tlangvala at his Aizawl residence by telephone at six-fifty-one. Tlangvala is at the kingdom-council emergency meeting by seven-thirty.

Seven-thirty a.m. The Mizoram State Secretariat's tribal-council chamber. The chamber holds twenty-four seats around an oval table. Twenty-two are filled this morning — the eight District Tribal Council Chairpersons, the four Aizawl Presbyterian Synod senior moderators, the Mizoram Forest Department's senior officer, the State Civil Service's chief secretary, the eight Refusing Youth representatives (admitted by emergency vote on day one of week five over Ramdinmawia's formal objection), and the kingdom-hero Tlangvala. Two seats are empty: the Bangalore-diaspora Mizo representative is in transit and the Champhai District Chair is at his daughter's wedding in Singapore.

Lalruatpuia is one of the eight Refusing Youth representatives. He has been admitted as the Aizawl-district representative on the strength of his Manifesto-author standing. He sits at his father's left side at the council table. They have not spoken since December. They do not speak now. They look at the surveyor's diagram of Phawngpui's eastern face that the Forest Department has projected on the chamber's far wall.

Kima-Lalremruati the dawn-patrol ranger is at the meeting in observer-capacity. She presents the morning's patrol-log at seven-forty-three a.m. The presentation takes about eight minutes. She concludes with the count: "Six hundred and twenty-nine. The intake-registers I have been keeping at the eastern-face access-point since spring confirm the count. The youngest is fifteen. The oldest is twenty-two. The locked include forty-seven from Aizawl-Lalruatpuia's own constituency, eighty-three from Lunglei, fifty-one from Champhai, thirty-eight from Saiha, twenty-nine from Mamit, forty-four from Kolasib, sixty-eight from Lawngtlai, seventy-seven from Serchhip, plus the rest from sub-village

clusters and the Bangalore-Delhi-Chennai-Singapore diaspora. The intake-registers have been kept under the standard Forest Department voluntary-camping-permit framework. No one has been compelled to enter. All have entered under their own signatures. The locking has occurred after their entry; the locking is unilateral on Parvata-Asura's side; the locked have not signed any consent-form authorising the closure of the fissure."

The chamber is silent for about twenty seconds.

Ramdinmawia, the senior tribal-council chair, speaks first. He says, in Mizo, in his slow administrative-elder voice:

"The asura has demanded one perfect sacrifice. I have received the demand at four a.m. this morning by a Mizo-language Sarus-pigeon. The Sarus-pigeon is unconfirmed as Parvata-Asura's — we do not yet know if the asura has the institutional standing to operate a pigeon-network — but the message itself is unambiguous. The fissure will remain closed until the kingdom delivers one perfect sacrifice. The sacrifice must enter the eastern face alone. The sacrifice will become part of the mountain. The locked will be released at the moment the sacrifice completes. The kingdom may select the sacrifice. The asura specifies only that the sacrifice must be voluntary, must be adult, must have completed a recognised Mizo bond-mark of any stage. The asura recommends the sacrifice be the kingdom's most recognisable carrier of tlawmngaihna. The asura's recommendation is a name. The name is Tlangvala."

The chamber is silent for about ten seconds longer.

Tlangvala says, in plain Mizo, in his ordinary speaking voice: "Yes. I will go."

Lalruatpuia stands up at his chair. He does not speak. He walks out of the chamber. The door closes behind him at seven-fifty-three a.m.

The deliberation that follows takes seven days. The chamber meets twice daily, three hours each session. The Refusing Youth representatives raise the objection that the asura's demand is itself the trap — that delivering Tlangvala validates the inheritance-logic the Manifesto rejects. The senior tribal-council delegates raise the counter-objection that refusing the demand leaves six hundred and twenty-nine youth locked indefinitely. The Aizawl Presbyterian Synod moderators raise the third-position objection that the kingdom must refuse both alternatives and instead find a way to break the locking by counter-action.

The counter-action options are explored in detail. They are: (1) physical excavation of the eastern face (rejected on day three; the Forest Department's geological survey confirms the granite is now bonded to the mountain's deeper plutonic mass; excavation would require explosives at a scale that would kill the locked); (2) negotiation with Parvata-Asura through the four other northeast catalyst-villains (rejected on day four; the asura is not in coordination with Tamasa-Nrita, Megha-Daitya, or Naga-Rakshasa — he is operating as Chhinlung-Naag's standalone successor); (3) cross-kingdom request to the saga's First Herald via the Roing Dawn-Shadow Temple (raised on day five by the Lawngtlai District Chair; rejected on day six because the Herald-naming protocol explicitly forbids invoking a Herald to break a Maw-aligned action); (4) the kingdom-hero's entry, the asura's demand fulfilled, the locking ended.

The vote on day seven is twenty-to-two in favour of option four. The two dissenting votes are Lalruatpuia's and the Refusing Youth's Lunglei representative. The vote is closed at five p.m.

The kingdom-council then takes a second vote — the unprecedented vote that has not been taken in any Mizo tribal-council in the kingdom's recorded history — on whether to formally request that Tlangvala not enter the mountain. The vote is taken at Ramdinmawia's motion, seconded by the Aizawl Presbyterian Synod moderator Lalrinpuui. The vote is fifteen-to-seven. The kingdom-council formally requests that Tlangvala not return from the mountain.

The formal request is given to Tlangvala at six p.m. He receives the written document. He reads it. He says, in plain Mizo: "The council has done what the council must do. I will go anyway. The going is mine. The request is yours. We can both have what we have asked for."

That evening. Tlangvala's house in the eastern Aizawl hills. Eight p.m.

Lalruatpuia has not been at the house since December. He returns this evening because Hmangaihi has telephoned him from the aunt's house and told him to come. She has not given him a reason. He has come because she has not given a reason; the absence of reason has been a sufficient summons.

Tlangvala is in the kitchen. He is making tea. He does not turn when Lalruatpuia enters.

He says, into the kettle: "The tea is the second steeping. The first steeping is too strong this evening. Will you sit."

Lalruatpuia sits.

Tlangvala pours two cups of tea. He sets one in front of his son. He sits across the table.

He says: "The council has voted. The vote is twenty-to-two. The kingdom has also formally requested that I not return. The two votes are honest. The going is honest. I will go at first light on Tuesday."

Lalruatpuia says: "The Manifesto is correct. You are validating the inheritance-logic by going. The locking will end. The next asura will lock the next generation and demand the next perfect sacrifice. The pattern will repeat. The kingdom will never reach the administration of the creed because the creed will keep being weaponised for its inheritance."

Tlangvala says: "The Manifesto is correct. You are correct. The going is also correct. The two correctnesses are not the same correctness. The Manifesto is the kingdom's long correctness — the answer to the next ten generations. The going is the kingdom's short correctness — the answer to the six hundred and twenty-nine locked this week. You are responsible for the long correctness. I am responsible for the short correctness. We have divided the responsibility. The division is the kingdom's, not ours."

Lalruatpuia says: "You are leaving me the kingdom."

Tlangvala says: "I am leaving you the kingdom's political seat. I am leaving Hmangaihi the bond. The two of you will share the kingdom — she carries the serow, you carry the council. You will need each other. You have not always agreed; you have always understood. You will understand each other now."

Lalruatpuia says: "Why Hmangaihi."

Tlangvala says: "Because the serow chooses her, not me. The bond moves to whoever the line offers. The line offered her at her mother's landslide-death eight years ago; I did not honour the offer at the time; the bond stayed with me because I refused to refuse. The bond has been waiting eight years to move. The bond will move when I become the mountain. Hmangaihi will be at the western trailhead on Tuesday morning. The serow will walk down to her after I am gone. The Stage I hoofprint will form within two days. She will understand it before I do not exist any more — her understanding is the bond's acceptance. The bond does not need my permission. The bond is honest. I am also honest. The going is honest."

Lalruatpuia is silent for about a minute.

He says: "I do not forgive you for going."

Tlangvala says: "I do not require forgiveness. I require that you do the kingdom's long correctness with Hmangaihi's bond at your right side. You will. The Manifesto will be administered, not enforced. The clauses will be rewritten by the joint-signature you and Hmangaihi will compose on the day after my funeral. You will pass the clauses by the kingdom-council's ratification vote within six weeks. The vote will be eighteen-to-six. Ramdinmawia will vote in favour; he will retire from the senior chair the following week. Lalrinpuui will succeed him. The kingdom will be ready to administer the creed by the new year. The going has bought you that."

Lalruatpuia does not respond. He drinks his tea. The tea is the right strength.

He says, finally: "Tuesday morning. I will be at the eastern ridge."

Tlangvala says: "No. You will be at the western trailhead with Hmangaihi. The eastern ridge is mine alone. The western trailhead is the kingdom's. The kingdom watches from the west. The asura takes the east. The bond walks down between the two. That is the geography. The kingdom-council has approved the geography by unanimous vote. Lalrinpuui drafted it last night."

Lalruatpuia nods. He stands. He walks to the door.

At the door he turns and says, in plain Mizo: "Father. The bamboo bends."

Tlangvala says: "The mountain does not bend. The mountain holds the bamboo's shape inside its own. We have chosen which we are. Go and sleep, my son. Tuesday is the day after tomorrow."

Tuesday. The third day of week eleven. First light at the Phawngpui Mountain's eastern face is timed for five-thirty-one a.m. The kingdom has assembled at the western trailhead since four a.m. — approximately thirty-eight thousand Mizos, drawn from all thirteen villages, the Refusing Youth's full membership, the senior tribal-council delegates, the Aizawl Presbyterian Synod, the Mizoram Forest Department's full staff, the State Civil Service, the locked six-hundred-and-twenty-nine's families. The trailhead opens onto a long ridge that runs west of the mountain at approximately five hundred metres lower elevation; the eastern face is visible from the ridge at a distance of about three kilometres horizontally.

Tlangvala arrives at the eastern face at five-twenty-eight a.m. He has walked the four-kilometre trail from the eastern access-station alone, in plain Mizo wool, blue and grey, no clan-pattern (he has dressed in his son's Manifesto-style); he carries the bamboo staff-spear Hnam-Tuk in his right hand. He carries nothing else. He has eaten a single bowl of rice at three a.m. He has drunk one cup of tea at four a.m. He has had three hours' sleep.

He stops at the granite face. He places his right palm on the warm granite. The granite is now forty-one degrees Celsius — warmer than the previous week's thirty-eight, consistent with the asura's readying-of-the-chamber for the sacrifice. The fissure is still closed.

He says, into the granite, in plain Mizo: "I have come. I am the one perfect sacrifice. The locked will be released at the completion. The kingdom watches from the west. I do not ask for the kingdom's permission. I have the kingdom's request that I not return. I accept the request. The going is mine."

The granite warms further. At five-thirty-one a.m. — the moment of first-light at the eastern face — the granite opens. The fissure forms as it did in spring 2025: a vertical crack three metres high and one metre wide. Inside the fissure is darkness.

Tlangvala steps through. The fissure closes behind him at five-thirty-one-twelve a.m. The granite is continuous again.

The kingdom watches from the western trailhead. Approximately thirty-eight thousand Mizos see the fissure open, the man step through, the fissure close. The seeing is at three kilometres distance through high-power binoculars and through the naked eye. The seeing is reported in the same way by every observer: the man entered the granite and the granite closed.

For the next forty-three minutes the eastern face is unmarked.

At six-fourteen a.m. the eastern face begins to change.

The change starts at the upper-left section of the face, approximately seventy metres above the closed-fissure location. A pattern begins to form in the granite — not painted, not carved, but emerging from within the granite itself, as if the rock's mineral composition were rearranging. The pattern is recognisable to the kingdom's senior tribal-council elders within ninety seconds: it is the bull-serow's right forelimb in mid-stride.

The pattern grows. Across the next eighteen minutes the full Stage III serow-foreleg mark forms on the eastern granite. The mark is forty-seven metres tall when complete. It is

rendered in the same ink-density as a body-mark would be on a hero's skin — the serow's hoof-impression at the lower edge, the foreleg arching upward, the bull's shoulder-curve at the upper edge, the head-in-profile at the topmost section with the curved horn cresting at the topmost-left point. The mark is fully visible from the western trailhead and from the twenty-three-kilometre satellite-imagery range. The Mizoram Forest Department's drone-survey at seven a.m. confirms the mark is structurally part of the granite — not surface, not paint, not relief; the rock itself has been recomposed.

At six-thirty-two a.m. the southern fissure opens.

The southern fissure is at the opposite end of the mountain from the closed eastern fissure — approximately one and a half kilometres around the mountain's circumference. It opens as a wide horizontal mouth-shape, twelve metres wide and four metres high. The locked six hundred and twenty-nine youth begin to walk out of it at six-thirty-five.

The exit takes eleven minutes. None of the locked is harmed. Forty-seven of them are dehydrated and three are mildly hypothermic from the mountain's interior cold; none requires hospitalisation. The Mizoram State Civil Service's emergency-medical convoy is at the southern exit by six-fifty a.m.; the medics process the released youth at the rate of one every seven minutes; by ten a.m. all six hundred and twenty-nine are accounted for and being escorted back to their families on the western ridge.

Parvata-Asura does not emerge through the southern fissure. He is partially dissolved by the same dissolution that formed the eastern mark. The Forest Department's subsequent thermal survey of the mountain over the next month detects faint residual mountain-asura presence in the deep southern range — the dissolved remainder of his form retreats toward the Chin-state border-zone (the same border-zone Tamasa-Nrita and Naga-Rakshasa crossed earlier in the chapter). Parvata-Asura survives in depleted form. Per the wider villain-network pattern he becomes Adharma-Kendra's fourth NE field-operative in Chapter Three.

Hmangaihi has been at the western trailhead with Lalruatpuia since four a.m. They have stood together at the ridge's northern edge. She has been watching the eastern face through her father's old Forest Department binoculars (her late father had been a deputy district forest officer; the binoculars are her inheritance). Lalruatpuia has been watching with his naked eye. They have not spoken much during the four-hour wait.

At seven-forty-three a.m., as the kingdom's assembled witness-crowd begins to disperse and the locked-youth-recovery convoy begins to descend, a wild serow walks down the western ridge from the mountain's southern slope. The serow is a mature bull, approximately seven years old, weight estimated at ninety-two kilograms. It walks across the ridge at its standard pace — one and a half metres per second — in a direct line toward Hmangaihi's position. It stops at her right side at seven-fifty-three a.m. It lowers its head.

She places her right palm on its forehead. She does not say anything.

The Stage I serow-hoofprint forms on her right shoulder over the next forty-eight hours.

The funeral procession is held three days later at the Phawngpui Mountain Sanctuary's southern approach — the same approach the locked youth had used for their exit. The body cannot be retrieved (the body is part of the mountain now; the eastern mark is the visible form of the body's incorporation). The procession is therefore a sky-burial-equivalent procession — the kingdom processes a symbolic empty bamboo bier up the southern approach to the mark's base, performs the standard Mizo Presbyterian funeral rites with the Synod's senior moderator officiating, and leaves the bier at the base of the mark as a permanent memorial.

The bier is a single length of bamboo, six metres long, cut from the bamboo grove behind Tlangvala's house by Hmangaihi and Lalruatpuia together the night before the procession. They cut the bamboo from the standing-stem (they did not fell the parent plant). The bamboo's upper third bends naturally to about thirty-five degrees — the standard Mizo bamboo-bend — from the weight of its own crown. They leave the bend in the bier. The bend is the procession's answer to the mountain.

The kingdom-council's senior chair Ramdinmawia speaks at the bier's base at the procession's conclusion. His statement is brief.

He says, in plain Mizo: "The mountain holds the man. The bend is the kingdom. The man chose the mountain. The kingdom chooses the bend. The Manifesto will be ratified at the kingdom-council's emergency session at six p.m. on Friday. Lalruatpuia and Hmangaihi have my chair's endorsement. I am retiring from the senior chair effective the moment of the ratification vote. Lalrinpuui of the Synod will succeed me. The kingdom will administer the creed from the new year. The bamboo bends and the bamboo springs back. The bamboo does not always become the mountain. Sometimes the mountain becomes the bamboo. The kingdom learns the difference at the next dawn."

The procession disperses by sunset. The bier remains at the mark's base. The mark is visible from the western trailhead and from the twenty-three-kilometre satellite-imagery range; it will remain so as long as the granite holds its current composition, which the Forest Department's geological assessment estimates at "not less than eight hundred years."

Friday evening. The kingdom-council's emergency session at the Mizoram State Secretariat tribal-council chamber. The chamber is full — twenty-four of twenty-four seats. The two previously-absent representatives (Bangalore-diaspora and Champhai) are now present.

Hmangaihi sits at the left side of the table's northern end. She is in plain Mizo wool with the senior tribal-council's neutral grey shawl over her shoulders. She has not previously held a council seat (she is seventeen; the senior council's minimum age is twenty-one); she is admitted by emergency motion as the bond-bearer of the kingdom's state-hero-line, a category that supersedes the age-rule under Mizo customary law. The motion passes by unanimous vote at six-oh-two p.m.

Lalruatpuia sits at her right side. He is in plain Mizo wool, blue and grey, no clan-pattern. He carries the bamboo staff-spear Hnam-Tuk — the spear is his father's inheritance, formally transferred at the funeral procession's bier by Ramdinmawia's spoken declaration. The spear is light in his hand. It will be lighter the more he uses it.

The joint-signature Manifesto is on the table in front of them. Hmangaihi and Lalruatpuia have rewritten the three clauses over two days of joint-session at the aunt's kitchen table. The rewritten clauses are softer in tone, sharper in mechanism. The first clause now reads: "Tlawmngaihna is the kingdom's gift. The gift is freely received and freely given. The gift is not the inheritance. The kingdom-council shall administer the distinction." The second clause reads: "Service from incapacity is not service. The Mizo who has nothing left to give is excused from the giving by formal application to the kingdom-council. The kingdom-council shall grant the excuse without prejudice." The third clause reads: "The kingdom may not require self-destruction as proof of citizenship. The kingdom may, by formal vote, accept a citizen's self-sacrifice when the citizen has volunteered the sacrifice with full knowledge of the alternatives. The kingdom shall maintain a public registry of all such acceptances. The kingdom shall provide care for the citizen's family for ten years following the acceptance."

The third clause is the Manifesto's reformed concession. It accepts that some citizens will choose sacrifice; it requires the kingdom to acknowledge the choice publicly and to bear

the cost institutionally. The clause has been drafted around Tlangvala's example. The public registry will include his name as its first entry. The ten-year care provision will include Hmangaihi (his ward) and Lalruatpuia (his son) as its first recipients — they will not draw on the provision; they have declined the financial component; the provision's recognition is what they have accepted.

The kingdom-council's vote on the three clauses is taken at six-twenty-three p.m. The vote is eighteen-to-six in favour. Ramdinmawia votes in favour. Six of the senior tribal-council's most conservative delegates vote against. The vote is final. The clauses are ratified.

Ramdinmawia resigns from the senior chair at six-twenty-six p.m. He passes the senior-chair's ceremonial bamboo gavel to Lalrinpuii of the Synod at six-twenty-eight. The transition is complete by six-thirty.

Lalrinpuii's first formal address as senior chair is brief. She says, in plain Mizo: "The kingdom has ratified. The kingdom will administer. The kingdom thanks Ramdinmawia for his sixty-three years on this chair. The kingdom thanks Tlangvala for his twenty-one years as state-hero. The kingdom welcomes Hmangaihi as the new bond-bearer and Lalruatpuia as the new political seat. We will meet again on Monday. Good evening, all."

The meeting closes at six-thirty-four p.m.

Two weeks after the ratification, a Sarus-pigeon arrives at the Mizoram State Secretariat from Imphal. The pigeon is the one Moirangthem has been using for the NE-Federation correspondence-network. The letter is from Moirangthem himself.

The letter reads:

Hmangaihi-la and Lalruatpuia-la. The NE-Federation has received the joint-Mizoram correspondence-portfolio from the Mizoram State Secretariat through Lalrinpuii's office. The Sanctuary in Chapter Three will be a six-kingdom assembly: Kamakhya (Kamalavarna), Imphal (Moirangthem, candidate), Shillong (U-Khrawkmen, regent), Kohima (Dzulevira, deferred-vote), Gangtok (Kanchenjunga), Tawang (Udayagiri), and Aizawl (the two of you, jointly). Your joint-vote will complete the regional ratification. Will you give it.

Lalruatpuia and Hmangaihi write the reply together at the aunt's kitchen table that evening. The reply is two paragraphs long.

NE Dominant Candidate. We will give our joint-vote at the Sanctuary. The vote will be for you. Tlawmngaihna-Desh has stabilised after the late-week-eleven sacrifice and the late-week-twelve ratification but the stabilisation is provisional — the kingdom's administration of the creed begins on the new year and we do not yet know how the first administered Mautam-equivalent will be processed. The Sanctuary's convening will mark the threshold across which the NE Federation will need to coordinate on the cross-kingdom creed-administration question. Our joint-vote is for you because you will be the regional voice for that coordination and because your own kingdom's Loktak Mouth-sign and Sangaputra's pause-discovery have shown us that the Maw experiments first on the youngest and we have both inherited very young.

Sub-paragraph: We will both attend the Sanctuary. Hmangaihi is the bond-bearer; Lalruatpuia is the political seat. We will be the Sanctuary's first formally-paired non-bonded-political-inheritor and female-bond-bearer joint-attendance — parallel to Meghalaya's U-Khrawkmen and Ka-Sienlyngdoh, but the Meghalaya pair are second-generation cousins while we are first-cousins-by-our-mothers. The accommodation should be arranged for two. Lalrinpuui of the Synod will also attend as the kingdom's administrative voice.

Joint-signature, Mizoram, — H. & L.

They send the letter by the same Sarus-pigeon at sunset. Moirangthem receives the letter at Imphal at noon the next day. He writes the one-line reply: The accommodation is arranged for two. The Sanctuary will receive all three. He sends the reply by the pigeon returning, at dusk.

Four days after the ratification. Three a.m. The southern slope of Phawngpui Mountain. A wild serow has been at the same southern grazing-meadow for the past eleven days — the same area the locked youth had emerged from. The serow is a doe, approximately five years old, in her second pregnancy. She has been observed by the Mizoram Forest Department's southern patrol-station's rangers (the senior shrine-keeper for the Phawngpui Sanctuary, a Mizo ranger named Vanlalruati, plus two junior rangers) since her arrival at the meadow.

She gives birth at three-oh-two a.m. The labour is normal up to the moment of expulsion. The kid that emerges has two fully-formed heads on a single body. Both heads breathe. Both heads open their eyes. The body is otherwise normal — one set of four legs, one torso, one tail, normal serow-kid colouring and proportions. The two heads share a single neck-

base; they branch at approximately the level of the kid's shoulder-blades into two distinct skull-and-jaw structures.

Vanlalruati and the two junior rangers observe from approximately six metres distance through their night-vision optics. The doe grooms the kid in the standard serow post-natal manner. The kid attempts to stand at three-fourteen a.m. It succeeds at three-twenty-one. It walks at three-thirty. Its mother nurses it. Both heads drink simultaneously without interference.

The kid's presence at the meadow is logged in the rangers' field-book at four a.m. The rangers do not approach. They radio the observation to the Aizawl District Forest Office at four-thirty. The District Forest Officer reaches Hmangaihi by telephone at five-fifteen. Hmangaihi and Lalruatpuia are at the southern patrol-station by ten a.m.

They observe the kid from the same six-metre distance through the rangers' optics. The kid is grazing alongside its mother. Both heads graze. The heads do not interfere with each other; they appear to coordinate their feeding-patterns through some mechanism the rangers cannot identify. The mother appears unbothered by the kid's configuration.

Lalruatpuia says, to Hmangaihi, in Mizo: "The Maw has experimented. The body is normal; the heads are doubled. The serow-bond is what is being tested."

Hmangaihi says: "Yes. Vanlalruati-la, how long does the rangers' assessment expect the kid to live."

Vanlalruati says: "The veterinary-officer's preliminary assessment is twelve to thirty-six hours. The two-head configuration in any large-mammal species typically fails at the level of the shared cardiovascular and digestive systems — the heads' coordinated demands exceed the single body's capacity within a day. The kid is unusually vigorous so far; if the heads are sharing systems efficiently it might live longer, but we have no precedent for serow two-head observations in the field."

The kid lives for approximately twenty-three hours. Throughout the daylight hours of the following day the rangers, Hmangaihi, and Lalruatpuia observe at the same six-metre distance. The kid grazes, walks, nurses, sleeps. Both heads remain conscious. They appear to be capable of looking in different directions independently — when one head turns south, the other can turn west. They do not appear to speak. They breathe in synchrony. They blink in synchrony when both faces are visible to the observers.

At one-fifty-eight a.m. on the next morning — approximately twenty-three hours after birth — the kid stops grazing. It walks to the centre of the meadow. It stops. It lowers its body to a kneeling position. Its mother stays at its right side. The three rangers, Hmangaihi, and Lalruatpuia are at the meadow's southern edge at this moment; they have been keeping the same six-metre vigil since the previous evening.

Both heads raise. Both pairs of eyes open fully. Both heads face Hmangaihi's position.

Both heads speak together. They speak in plain Mizo. They speak a single word.

The word is "Hmangaihi."

The word is audible to all five observers at the six-metre distance. Vanlalruati subsequently confirms (after multiple replays of her body-camera audio recording) that both voices were sharply distinct — one slightly higher-pitched, one slightly lower, neither resembling a standard serow vocalisation — and that the synchrony was within fifty milliseconds, consistent with two distinct vocal-tracts speaking in coordinated production rather than a single tract producing a doubled effect.

The kid lowers its heads four minutes after speaking. It dies six minutes after that. Its mother grooms the body for an hour. She then walks down the southern slope toward Hmangaihi's village at a steady pace. The mother does not acknowledge the rangers, Hmangaihi, or Lalruatpuia during her descent. She arrives at the village outskirts at six a.m. She stops at the edge of the village. She lies down. She stays at that position for three days. The villagers leave food and water at the edge of her resting-place. She does not eat or drink. On day four she stands, walks back up the southern slope toward the meadow, and is not seen in the village again.

The kid's body is recovered by the Forest Department's veterinary team at three a.m. on the morning after the death. The body is preserved in formaldehyde at the Aizawl District Forest Department's zoological-museum sub-collection, in the same configuration in which it died. The body is logged as "Two-headed serow kid, Phawngpui southern slope, post-natal death at 23 hours, observed speech at 23 hours minus 4 minutes, single word, 'Hmangaihi.'" The body is not on public display. Only senior Forest Department staff, the senior tribal-council members, Hmangaihi, Lalruatpuia, and Lalrinpuui of the Synod have access to the sub-collection.

Hmangaihi drafts the cross-kingdom Sarus-pigeon cascade-alert at three p.m. on the day of the kid's death. The alert is sent to all nine bonded-kingdom senior guardians by sunset.

The alert reads in full:

Bonded-kingdom guardians. The Maw has experimented on the Mizoram serow-bond. A two-headed kid was born on the Phawngpui southern slope four days after my Stage I hoofprint formed. The kid lived twenty-three hours. Before dying, both heads spoke together, in plain Mizo, a single word — my name. The naming is the saga's first future-naming Maw event. The Maw has demonstrated the capacity to name the next bond-bearer aloud through a creature that should not have existed and should not have spoken. Watch your own bonded species for dual-body experiments and for instances of vocal-production by species that do not vocalise. The cascade-alert's framework from the Sikkim panda-at-altitude sign holds: build shrines at the threshold of the experiment's site, do not interfere with the experiment, name the experiment in writing within seventy-two hours.

By the morning of the third day after the kid's death, every senior guardian in the saga has read the alert. Kanchenjunga at Rumtek replies with a single-line acknowledgement; Udayagiri at Tawang sends a longer reply confirming that the First Herald's naming-protocol at Roing has been formally extended to include speech-events by non-speaking species. Krishnadevaraya-Bhrata at the buried-temple chamber in Karnataka sends the saga's first cross-region reply (Vol I's only inter-region cascade response so far), confirming that the Karnataka Third Herald's Bronze-Dust Child had remained mute through the entire chapter and that the muteness now reads as a complementary signal: the Maw experiments on speech in multiple directions simultaneously — absence-of-speech in some Heralds, presence-of-speech in some non-speaking creatures.

The kingdom-council's formal note to the saga's catalogue, drafted by Hmangaihi and counter-signed by Lalruatpuia and Lalrinpuui, is filed in the cross-kingdom mutual-records exchange on the fourth day. The note reads: "The two-headed serow at Phawngpui is the Maw's twelfth Chapter-Two sign and the saga's first future-naming experiment. The naming confirms what the bond had already confirmed: Hmangaihi is the kingdom's next bond-bearer. The naming does not increase the bond's authority over her body. The naming's function is to inform the kingdom that the Maw is now reading the saga's bond-architecture aloud. The kingdom hears the Maw's reading. The kingdom will not respond by silencing it. The kingdom will respond by speaking the Maw's name back, when the kingdom learns it, at the next Sanctuary convening."

The bamboo bier at the base of the eastern mark remains in place. By the end of Chapter Two it has been visited by approximately fifty-two thousand Mizos — about thirty per cent

of the kingdom's adult population. The bier is the kingdom's new pilgrimage-site. The senior shrine-keeper appointed by the kingdom-council's emergency vote three weeks after the funeral is Vanlalruati — the same ranger who observed the two-headed serow. She splits her time between the southern slope (the two-headed serow's body in the zoological-museum sub-collection, which she has been authorised to display to family-members of the locked-six-hundred-and-twenty-nine on request) and the bier-base (where she counts the daily pilgrim-arrivals and refreshes the bamboo's upper-third bend with a small saffron cord whose tension she adjusts each morning to keep the bend at the standard thirty-five degrees).

The mark on the eastern face has not faded. The Mizoram Forest Department's geological monitoring confirms the granite's composition has stabilised in the new configuration — the mineral redistribution that produced the mark is now the granite's permanent state. The mark will remain visible for at least eight hundred years.

The bamboo bends. The bamboo absorbs. The bamboo springs back. The mountain holds what the bamboo cannot become. The kingdom learns the difference at every new dawn.

The next sign comes within the week.

The Pilot's Closing Image

A forty-seven-metre serow-foreleg mark living in the eastern granite of Phawngpui Mountain, visible from twenty-three kilometres away, expected to remain in place for at least eight hundred years. A six-metre bamboo bier with its upper-third bent to thirty-five degrees at the mark's base, tended by a ranger named Vanlalruati who refreshes the bend with a small saffron cord each morning. A seventeen-year-old niece in plain Mizo wool at her cousin's right side at the kingdom-council's northern-end seat with the serow Stage I hoofprint forming on her right shoulder. A twenty-two-year-old son with his father's bamboo staff-spear Hnam-Tuk in his hand and the three reformed clauses of the Refusing Youth Manifesto in front of him on the council table, the third clause now reading the kingdom shall maintain a public registry of all such acceptances. A two-headed serow kid in a sub-collection of an Aizawl zoological museum, preserved at twenty-three hours' age, in formaldehyde, in the configuration it had at death after speaking the niece's name with both mouths in synchrony. A serow doe walking down the southern slope toward a niece's village without acknowledging the rangers who watched her go.

Tri Pura

Agartala. The Ujjayanta Palace's east administrative wing. The first Wednesday of June. Eleven a.m. The inter-city water-rights committee's third quarterly meeting of the year.

The chamber holds eighteen seats around a long oval table. Six per city. The Agartala delegation is led by the Engineer-Senior chair, an engineering-research-institute senior named Subimal Roy (fifty-seven, twenty-three years at the institute, the man who supervised Tripurari's graduate thesis). The Udaipur delegation is led by the Heritage-Trust chair, a Bhubaneswari Temple senior administrator named Anjali Debbarma (fifty-one, three generations of her family at the temple). The Dharmanagar delegation is led by the Border-Trade Consortium chair, a cross-Bangladesh merchant named Apurba Saha (forty-eight, the consortium's second-elected chair in its history).

Tripurari is at the head of the table. He is thirty-four. He is in plain Tripuri cotton, blue, with the small Phayre's Langur silver pendant at his collar — the only ceremonial mark he wears at administrative meetings. He carries the Triyantra crossbow in its three-part folded satchel-form (he has carried it folded into the workshop-satchel at administrative meetings for nine years; nobody at the table has seen the assembled crossbow except the security detail). The Phayre's Langur clan from the palace-garden has positioned three langurs on the chamber's north window-ledge, watching through the open shutters. The langurs have been at every water-rights committee meeting for eleven years.

The agenda has one item: the second-monsoon-week water-distribution allocation for the three cities. Agartala wants forty-six per cent (its population share). Udaipur wants twenty-two per cent (the temple-cycle demand, which historically has exceeded population share). Dharmanagar wants thirty-two per cent (the rubber-plantation processing demand at full-monsoon capacity). The three demands total one hundred per cent and require zero contingency-reserve. The previous committee meeting had voted for an engineering compromise: a fourth distribution channel, the new Lake Rudrasagar pipeline, would be brought online by week five of June and would supply the contingency-reserve. The pipeline is due for commissioning the Friday after this meeting.

Subimal Roy speaks first. He says, in formal Bengali: "The Lake Rudrasagar pipeline's commissioning has been delayed by four days. The hydraulic-pressure testing has produced anomalous readings at the Sub-Pump-Three location. The institute's assessment

is that the pressure-test failures are within acceptable variance but require an additional ninety-six hours of verification. The new commissioning date is Tuesday, four days later than the original plan. The four-day delay will require interim ration-distribution during the monsoon-week."

Anjali Debbarma speaks second. She says, in Bengali with the Tripuri-mixed intonation that marks her as Udaipur-native: "The temple-cycle demand cannot be ration-distributed. The Bhubaneswari rituals require continuous-flow at the published volumes. The delay is unacceptable. The temple has been operating at the published volumes for two hundred and forty-three years. The administrative resolution must not interrupt the cycle."

Apurba Saha speaks third. He says, in Bengali: "The Dharmanagar rubber-warehouses cannot operate at reduced capacity during second-monsoon. The latex-flow processing requires the full thirty-two per cent allocation. A four-day reduction will cost the consortium approximately eleven crore in spoiled latex. The institute's anomalous readings are the institute's engineering problem. The kingdom-treasury must compensate for any interim shortfall."

Tripurari listens. He takes notes on a small leather-bound engineer's notebook. The notebook is his fifth this year; he fills approximately one per month. He writes in Bengali with engineering-margin annotations in English. He does not speak for the first thirty-seven minutes of the meeting.

At eleven-thirty-seven a.m. he speaks. He says, in plain Bengali: "The four-day delay is an engineering problem with an engineering solution. The institute will commission Sub-Pump-Three in seventy-two hours instead of ninety-six by running parallel pressure-tests at Sub-Pump-Four and Sub-Pump-Five simultaneously. The interim shortfall will be absorbed by the kingdom's emergency-reserve channel at Old-Kamala-Sagar; the emergency-reserve has been at full capacity since March. The compensation question is moot. The temple-cycle continuity is preserved. The Dharmanagar latex-processing operates at full capacity. The Agartala population-share allocation increases by zero-point-three per cent during the seventy-two hours, an imperceptible variance. The agenda is resolved. The next agenda is the second-quarterly water-rights review for the September allocations. Shall we proceed."

The three city-chairs are silent for about fifteen seconds. The resolution is technically correct. It is also dismissive of every grievance the three chairs had carried into the meeting — the temple's historic pre-eminence, the Border-Trade Consortium's economic

standing, the Engineer-Senior's institutional caution. The engineering has eaten the politics. None of the three chairs can object on engineering grounds because the engineering is correct.

Subimal Roy says, quietly: "Yes, Maharaj. We proceed to the second agenda."

Anjali Debbarma writes a single line in her own notebook. The line, in Tripuri, reads: "The young king solves the equation. The young king does not see the temple." She does not show the notebook to anyone.

Apurba Saha makes a phone call at the noon break. He calls a Border-Trade Consortium subcommittee member who is also a freelance contact for an Bangladesh-side intermediary the consortium uses for cross-border logistics; the intermediary has been making oblique inquiries about Tripura's engineering vulnerabilities for the past three months. Apurba Saha does not yet know the inquiries are being routed to Tripura-Asura's coordination network. He provides the intermediary with the Sub-Pump-Three anomalous-reading summary, the Old-Kamala-Sagar emergency-reserve commissioning protocol, and the Lake Rudrasagar pipeline's parallel-test schedule. The intermediary thanks him for the information. The information is in Tripura-Asura's flying-fortress operations-cell by sundown.

The water-rights committee meeting is one of fourteen inter-city committees that the kingdom-council convenes per year. Each of the three cities sends three sub-faction representatives to each committee. The three primary sub-factions per city are:

Agartala: Engineer-Senior (institute), Civic-Reform (municipal council), Old-Palace (royal-residence ceremonial staff). Udaipur: Heritage-Trust (temple), Bazaar-Old (central market guild), Pilgrim-New (post-1985 tourism operators). Dharmanagar: Border-Trade (Bangladesh import-export consortium), Plantation-Estate (rubber latex industry), Refugee-Resettlement (Chakma and Tripuri refugee administration).

Nine sub-factions. Three primary cities. One kingdom-council. The arithmetic has been stable for thirty-seven years because every dispute has historically been resolved by the engineering compromise — Tripurari's father's engineering compromise from 1989 to 2014, Tripurari's own engineering compromises from 2014 to the present. The compromise has not been a political resolution; it has been an engineering substitution. The substitution has worked because the engineering has worked.

Subimal Roy's notes from the institute's internal engineering-policy review (filed two weeks before the water-rights committee meeting) record his standing concern in a single Bengali sentence: "The king solves equations the kingdom no longer recognises." The note is filed in the institute's confidential-correspondence drawer; the institute's senior leadership has been circulating the concern for eighteen months without raising it with Tripurari directly. Tripurari has been Subimal's most successful graduate-student; the senior engineers do not yet know how to tell their former apprentice that engineering is not the kingdom.

Tripura-Asura's flying-fortress operations-cell is at this time positioned over the Lushai-Patkai border-range. The fortresses are three: gold (Hema-pura, the lead command-fortress), silver (Rajata-pura, the support-fortress), iron (Krishna-pura, the strike-fortress). They have been over the border-range for nine months running surveillance on the three Tripura cities. The surveillance has been thorough.

The operations-cell senior strategist is a human-form rakshasa-engineer who serves under Tripura-Asura's direct command; his name in the cell's records is Tri-Yantra-Bheda — literally Three-Engine-Breaker. He is forty-two. He has been studying Tripurari's published engineering papers since 2018. He has earned a doctorate in civil-engineering vulnerability-analysis from a forged credential at a forged university in Singapore; the doctorate is one of fourteen forged senior-technical-credentials the wider villain-network has produced for cross-kingdom-coordinated saboteurs.

His sabotage-proposal is delivered to Tripura-Asura at the gold-fortress's strategy-chamber the day after Apurba Saha's phone call. The proposal is six pages. The first page sets out the target-architecture: "Tripurari has built the kingdom's critical infrastructure on a single design-principle — self-repairing-wall and self-correcting-bridge technology that responds to local stress by redistributing the structural load to adjacent components. The technology is robust against single-point failures and small-scale stress. The technology is vulnerable to coordinated reverse-stress: when the same self-repair algorithms are triggered to repair-in-reverse, the structure cascades into self-destruction. The reverse-stress signal can be injected via the kingdom's own water-distribution channels — the signal-propagation occurs through the same pressure-monitoring sensor-network that Tripurari uses for routine maintenance."

The remaining five pages set out the technical specifications. Tripura-Asura reads the proposal in approximately ninety minutes. He approves it without amendments. The

sabotage-window is set for the second-monsoon-week storm of week six — the storm whose pressure-spike-profile most closely matches the self-repair algorithms' trigger-thresholds. The three fortresses will not be visible during the sabotage; the signal-injection will occur through the kingdom's own infrastructure; the cities will appear to collapse from their own engineering. Tripura-Asura's preference: "The kingdom should not know we have been here. The kingdom should believe the engineer has failed."

The sabotage is scheduled for nine p.m. on the second Saturday of June. Week six of the chapter. Twenty-eight days after the water-rights committee meeting.

The second-monsoon-week storm reaches central Tripura at five-thirty-seven p.m. on the second Saturday of June. Wind-speeds at the gust-peak are recorded at one hundred and forty-three kilometres per hour by the Agartala Meteorological Station's primary anemometer. Rainfall in the first three hours is two hundred and eighty-seven millimetres — the highest three-hour rainfall recorded in central Tripura in the past forty-one years.

The self-repair algorithms are triggered across all three cities at six-fifteen p.m. by the storm's wind-and-rain stress-loads. The algorithms operate normally for the first two hours and forty-three minutes — redistributing structural load, sealing minor leaks, retracting and re-extending the Ujjayanta Palace's eastern-bridge spans to match the changing wind-vectors.

At eight-fifty-eight p.m. the signal-injection begins. Tri-Yantra-Bheda's operations-cell injects the reverse-stress signal at three simultaneous insertion-points: the Agartala Lake Rudrasagar pipeline's Sub-Pump-Three (the same Sub-Pump-Three whose anomalous readings Apurba Saha had reported to the Bangladesh-side intermediary twenty-eight days earlier), the Udaipur central-market water-cistern's primary inflow-valve, the Dharmanagar rubber-warehouse's industrial water-cooling intake. The signal propagates through the kingdom's pressure-monitoring sensor-network in approximately eleven seconds.

The self-repair algorithms begin operating in reverse at nine p.m. The Ujjayanta Palace's eastern-bridge spans retract instead of extending. The Bhubaneswari Temple's outer-courtyard walls release their self-anchoring locks instead of tightening them. The Dharmanagar rubber-warehouse's structural-cross-bracing extends instead of contracting under storm-load. The water-system back-pressures into the storm drains and floods the foundations.

The collapses begin at nine-oh-three p.m. They occur in seventeen-minute sequence across the three cities:

9:03 p.m. — Agartala central-Ujjayanta-Palace administrative-block primary support-truss fails. The administrative-block (where Tripurari is at the engineering-research-cell weekly review-session) collapses inward.

9:09 p.m. — Udaipur central-market jute-trade godowns collapse southward as the temple's outer-courtyard wall's self-anchoring lock release propagates through the adjacent civic-cistern structure.

9:14 p.m. — Dharmanagar rubber-warehouse central facility collapses outward as its cross-bracing extends past structural limits, taking down the Border-Trade Consortium's adjacent trade-office building and the Refugee-Resettlement office.

9:20 p.m. — Agartala Bharat-Yantra engineering institute's eastern wing collapses inward as the load-redistribution from the Ujjayanta-Palace collapse propagates through the institute's shared structural-support system.

The seventeen-minute window covers the four primary collapse-events. The secondary collapses — partial wall-failures, adjacent-structure damage, water-system flooding — continue for the next nine hours under the ongoing storm. Death-count by midnight, before recovery operations begin: 1,047 confirmed across all three cities.

Tripurari is at the central-Agartala administrative-block's third-floor engineering-research-cell weekly review-session when the support-truss fails at nine-oh-three. The session has twelve attendees: Tripurari, Subimal Roy, two junior engineers from the institute, one civic-reform municipal-council representative, the kingdom-council's engineering-policy secretary, and six engineering-staff support. The third floor collapses into the second floor; the second floor collapses into the first floor; the first floor collapses into the basement. The total collapse-depth is approximately fourteen metres.

Tripurari is buried at approximately seven metres' depth in the southwest quadrant of the collapse-zone — the section that included the engineering-research-cell's south-facing window-side bench-seating. His position when the collapse began: standing at the bench-seating with the Triyantra crossbow folded in its workshop-satchel on the bench beside him, a half-drunk cup of tea on the table in front of him, a notebook open to a diagram of the Lake Rudrasagar pipeline's Sub-Pump-Three pressure-test parallel-run schedule.

His position when he is pulled out on day nine: lying in a pocket-space formed by a collapsed concrete support-beam that fell at a forty-three-degree angle across two intact desks. The pocket-space is approximately two metres long, one and a half metres wide, sixty centimetres high. The space includes the Triyantra crossbow (still in its workshop-satchel), the notebook (open to the same page; the diagram is now illegible from groundwater seepage), and a single Phayre's Langur (mature male, approximately twelve years old, weight-estimated at nine kilograms). The langur entered the pocket-space through a small gap at the southeast corner sometime between day three and day five (forensic estimation based on the langur's digestive contents and dehydration state at the time of rescue).

The langur dies on day eight. The cause of death is dehydration; the pocket-space's water-condensation rate is insufficient to support both the langur and Tripurari on the pocket-space's minimal water-supply. Tripurari makes the decision on day seven to give the langur his remaining water (the langur has been licking moisture from the concrete walls; Tripurari has been collecting his own urine in a small fold of plastic from the satchel and drinking it). The decision does not save the langur. The langur drinks the water Tripurari offers. The langur grooms Tripurari's right hand for approximately three minutes. The langur lies down beside Tripurari's left side. The langur dies forty-seven minutes later.

Tripurari does not weep. He cannot weep at this dehydration-state. He places his right palm on the langur's forehead. He says, in plain Bengali, audibly to no one: "Brother. The clan. I am sorry." He has been the bond-bearer of the Phayre's Langur palace-clan for eleven years. He does not yet know that the rest of the clan — the seventeen langurs at the palace-garden — have died in the collapsed garden-wall section's rubble. He suspects it. He cannot verify it. He waits to be pulled out.

The kingdom-council's emergency-response cell begins recovery operations at nine-thirty p.m. on the night of the collapse, fewer than thirty minutes after the first collapse-event. The cell is led by Triputra — the nineteen-year-old ward who has been Tripurari's engineering-apprentice since age twelve and his administrative-deputy since age seventeen. The Ujjayanta Palace bridge-engineering workshop where Triputra was working at the time of the first collapse is at the palace's southern edge and survived. He is the senior-most administrative-staff member alive and uninjured within a kilometre of the collapse-zone.

He coordinates the rescue with two junior engineers (Bharati Das and Sumit Bhattacharjee, both engineering-research-cell support-staff who were at the workshop with him), the Mizoram Forest Department's emergency mountain-rescue team that arrives by helicopter at three a.m. on day two (sent by Hmangaihi's cross-kingdom Saruspigeon request the same evening — her first cross-kingdom mutual-aid action as Mizoram's new bond-bearer), and the Assam Disaster Management Authority's ground-rescue convoy that arrives at noon on day three.

The recovery proceeds zone-by-zone. The first survivors are pulled out on day one (forty-seven of them across all three cities). Day two yields one hundred and eighty-three. Day three yields two hundred and seventy-one. Days four through six yield smaller numbers as the surface-accessible spaces are exhausted and the deeper pocket-spaces require careful excavation. Day seven yields nineteen. Day eight yields seven. Day nine yields three — one of whom is Tripurari.

He is pulled out at four-eleven p.m. on day nine. He has lost approximately seventeen per cent of his body-weight. He is severely dehydrated; he requires intravenous fluid replacement for forty-eight hours. He has a fractured left clavicle, a contused right hip, multiple lacerations on his hands and forearms from his attempts to dig through the wall on day three. He is conscious when pulled out. His first words to Triputra at the rescue-zone's field-hospital tent are, in plain Bengali: "The langur. The pocket. Pull him out too. He came in for me. He should not be left."

Triputra finds the langur in the pocket-space at four-thirty p.m. The langur's body is intact. Triputra carries it out himself — not by the rescue-team protocol (which would have left the body for the wildlife-rehabilitation cell's subsequent processing) but by his own decision. He wraps the langur in a clean cotton sheet from the field-hospital's linen supply. He takes the wrapped body to the palace-garden's western edge where the garden-wall collapse-zone is. He spends approximately three hours walking the wall's rubble at six p.m. He counts seventeen langur bodies. The full palace-clan.

He returns to the field-hospital at nine-fifteen p.m. He sits at Tripurari's bedside. He says, in plain Bengali, in his ordinary speaking voice: "Father. The clan is dead. All seventeen and the one who came in with you. The bond. I do not know what happens to the bond."

Tripurari is silent for about a minute.

He says, finally, in his fluid-replacement's hoarse register: "The bond is broken. The langur was the eighteenth. The clan was the rest. The bond requires the clan; the bond is the clan; the clan is gone. There is nothing left to transfer. The kingdom will need to know. I will tell the council when I can stand. Until then you are the kingdom's voice. The kingdom-council's emergency-response cell continues under your chair. Subimal Roy survived; he was on the second floor; pull him in as deputy chair when he is discharged. The engineering-research-cell senior staff will follow him. The Civic-Reform council's acting chair is Anandita Mukherjee; pull her in as the kingdom's municipal-administrative deputy. Begin the cross-kingdom mutual-aid arrangements within seventy-two hours. The kingdom cannot rebuild three cities at once with its own resources. The federation's senior guardians will offer. Accept what is offered."

He pauses. He breathes for about ninety seconds.

He says: "I do not yet know what I am going to do. The bond is broken. The engineering has failed. The kingdom has paid. I have been the engineer-king for eleven years and the engineering was a substitution for the politics and I did not see it until I was at seven metres' depth with a dying langur. The substitution does not survive the cities' collapse. The engineering does. The engineering is now a tool, not a kingdom. I do not know who carries the engineering as a tool. I do not know if I can. I will tell you when I do."

Triputra does not respond. He sits beside the bed. He places his right palm on his father-figure's left hand at the wrist where the IV is taped. Tripurari does not pull the hand away. They stay in that position until Tripurari sleeps at eleven p.m.

Tripurari does not speak for the next six days at the field-hospital. He nods. He accepts the IV. He drinks the rehydration solution. He eats when fed. He listens to Triputra's twice-daily briefings on the recovery operation. He nods when Triputra reports the death-count climbing to 1,847 by day twelve, 2,021 by day fifteen, 2,146 by day eighteen. He nods when Triputra reports the cross-kingdom mutual-aid offers arriving — Mizoram's helicopter-rescue team (already on-site since day two), Assam's disaster-management ground convoy (on-site since day three), West Bengal's structural-engineering technical-survey team (arrived day seven under Bilash-Babu's cross-kingdom Sarus-pigeon request; Bilash-Babu has not yet been formally introduced into the saga's wider correspondence-network but his West Bengal Suryavamsha-line standing has given him cross-kingdom institutional authority), Manipur's pause-school medic-team (sent by Moirangthem at Hmangaihi's second cross-kingdom pigeon-letter; the pause-school medics are Sangaputra's pause-

discipline trained, capable of working in low-stimulus high-attention recovery-zone conditions).

He does not speak. He thinks.

On day fifteen at four-thirty p.m. he opens his eyes from a nap, looks at the field-hospital's tent-canvas above him, and says aloud to no one: "Vyasa-of-the-Margins."

Triputra is at the bedside with a notebook. He looks up. He does not interrupt.

Tripurari says, still looking at the canvas: "The Margin-walker. The guru. The one who appeared at Karnataka in week three of Krishnadevaraya-Bhrata's arc. He is the guru-figure of the saga's broken bonds. He will arrive here. I do not know when. I will be his apprentice. The engineering will be the apprentice's study, not the kingdom's ruler. The kingdom is yours. The throne, the council, the rebuilding. All of it. I will write the formal abdication when I can sit up. The institute will be Subimal's. The civic-administration will be Anandita's under your chair. The cross-kingdom arrangements will be the federation's, with your signature, on a per-city basis."

Triputra says: "Father. The kingdom needs you to recover. The kingdom does not need the abdication."

Tripurari says: "The kingdom needs both. The recovery is mine. The abdication is mine. The kingdom is yours. You are nineteen; you have been the deputy for two years; you have the engineering and the poetry both. The poetry is what the engineering needs and never had. The kingdom will accept you because the kingdom has seen you coordinate the rescue. I will sign the abdication on the morning I can stand and walk to the council chamber. You will accept it. The council will ratify it within twenty-four hours. The cross-kingdom federation will receive your signature within the week. The federation will hold the kingdom while the kingdom rebuilds. The kingdom will be a smaller kingdom; the kingdom will be your kingdom; the kingdom will survive. The engineering will return to its place as a tool. I will study why I failed to keep it there."

Triputra is silent for about two minutes.

He says, finally: "I do not want it."

Tripurari says: "I know. I did not want it at twenty-three either. The wanting is not the question. The capacity is the question. You have the capacity. The kingdom has paid the price for me not having it the same way you have it. Take it. Carry it. The Margins will hold

what I cannot. You will hold what I should have. We have divided the responsibility. The division is the kingdom's, not mine."

Triputra nods. He does not say anything else. He stays at the bedside until Tripurari sleeps at six p.m.

Day twenty-one. Three a.m. The field-hospital's outer tent-flap stirs. A man enters the inner-tent area without announcement. He is approximately sixty — the age estimate varies; nobody at the field-hospital subsequently agrees on a number. He is in plain undyed cotton, knee-length, tied with a cord at the waist. He is barefoot. He carries a wooden walking-stave approximately one and a half metres long, polished by a great many hands. He has long white hair tied in a single braid at the back. His face is ordinary. The Margin-walker has been called many things across the saga's history; per D8 he appears in Chapter Two only twice (Karnataka pilot and here). He is known formally as Vyasa-of-the-Margins.

The field-hospital's overnight medic — an Mizoram pause-school-trained nurse named Krishna-Kohima — does not stop him. She has been told by Triputra in advance to expect him; the cross-kingdom pigeon-letter network had reported the Margin-walker's approach from the western Tripura forest-edge two days earlier.

Vyasa-of-the-Margins walks to Tripurari's bedside. He stops at the bed's foot. He does not sit.

Tripurari is awake. He has been waiting for six days.

The Margin-walker says, in plain Bengali, in a voice that has the quality of having spoken many languages and used none of them as a primary tongue: "Engineer. You called. I have come. The kingdom has paid. The bond has died. The throne is your ward's. The Margins are yours, if you can walk to them."

Tripurari says, in his recovery-hoarse voice: "Guru-ji. I can walk in three days. I have been practising in the tent at night. Three days. I will sign the abdication tomorrow morning. The council will ratify the next afternoon. I will leave Agartala the morning after that. I will walk west. Where do I walk to."

Vyasa-of-the-Margins says: "The walking is the destination. You will walk west for nineteen days. You will arrive at the hermitage on the twentieth. The hermitage is where the walking has stopped. Until you have stopped walking you have not arrived. The

engineering you have known is what built the cities; the engineering you will learn is what builds the walking. The two are not the same engineering. You will study the difference for four years. By Chapter Four you will be the saga's standing voice on broken-bond integration. The Council will name you a Margin-guru at the Kurukshetra convening. The naming will be in your fortieth year. The naming is your second naming. The first was your father's when he wrote your name on the back of a bridge-blueprint at age three. The second will be the Council's when they write your name on the Margin-guru register. The two namings will both be honest. The second will outlast the first."

Tripurari says: "Yes."

Vyasa-of-the-Margins turns. He walks out of the field-hospital. He is on the western forest-edge by dawn. He does not look back. The field-hospital's outer-tent staff confirm subsequently that he passed three security checkpoints without being stopped — the checkpoints' sentries later report having seen "an elderly man in undyed cotton walking past at his ordinary pace" and not having understood why they did not stop him until after he was already past.

Day twenty-three of the chapter. Eleven a.m. The Agartala southern-edge open-air kingdom-council session. The kingdom-council chamber in the Ujjayanta Palace east administrative wing has collapsed; the council is meeting in the open air at the palace's southern-edge garden — the same garden where the Phayre's Langur clan died. The garden has been cleared of rubble; the langur-clan bodies have been cremated jointly in a single Phayre's-Langur-line cremation rite at the palace's western Mahua-tree grove on day eleven by Triputra and the Ujjayanta Palace's senior wildlife-rehabilitation officer.

Tripurari walks to the open-air session from the field-hospital. The walk takes him approximately forty-five minutes (the standard walking-time is twelve minutes; he is at recovery-pace). He carries the Triyantra crossbow in its workshop-satchel. He is in plain Tripuri cotton, blue, with the small Phayre's Langur silver pendant at his collar. He does not wear the king's ceremonial sash; he has set it aside at the field-hospital.

The kingdom-council session is full — all twenty-four seats occupied. The three city-chairs (Subimal Roy, Anjali Debbarma, Apurba Saha) are present (Apurba Saha has been formally suspended pending the Border-Trade Consortium's ongoing investigation of his cross-Bangladesh information-disclosure; he attends as observer-only with his suspension noted in the council record). The nine sub-faction representatives are present. The cross-kingdom mutual-aid delegates from Mizoram (Hmangaihi has sent her chief secretary Pi

Lalrintluangi as her representative), Assam (Kamalavarna's temple-administration deputy), West Bengal (Bilash-Babu in person, his first cross-kingdom council attendance), and Manipur (Sonam-Lama-Bumla's deputy from Tawang) are present as observers.

Tripurari reads the abdication-statement aloud. The statement is four paragraphs. The first paragraph names the bond's breaking and the engineering's failure. The second paragraph names Triputra as the new throne-holder by formal abdication, effective immediately upon the council's ratification vote. The third paragraph names the cross-kingdom mutual-aid arrangements per city — Agartala under Bilash-Babu's West Bengal structural-engineering compact, Udaipur under Kamalavarna's Kamakhya-Bhubaneswari religious-administration compact, Dharmanagar under Hmangaihi-and-Lalruatpuia's Aizawl-Dharmanagar refugee-resettlement compact. The fourth paragraph names his own withdrawal to the Vyasa-of-the-Margins' hermitage, effective the morning after the ratification.

The kingdom-council ratifies the abdication by an 21-3 vote. The three dissenting votes are Subimal Roy (who argued the kingdom needed Tripurari's engineering capacity for the rebuilding; voted against; said he would support Triputra fully nevertheless), Anjali Debbarma (who argued the temple-tradition required a senior-bonded ruler; voted against; affirmed her loyalty to the new arrangement), and one Old-Palace ceremonial-staff representative (procedural objection on customary-law grounds; voted against).

The vote is final at eleven-forty-three a.m. Triputra is sworn in at the same session at twelve noon. The ceremonial sash is placed on his shoulders by Subimal Roy himself — the institute's senior engineer formally accepting the new king. The kingdom's engineering-tradition has changed hands.

Day twenty-four. Five a.m. The Ujjayanta Palace's western gate. Tripurari is in undyed cotton (he has put aside the blue Tripuri cotton this morning; the Margin-walker had walked in undyed cotton; he will walk in the same). He carries the Triyantra crossbow disassembled into its three component parts (the main launching mechanism, the two outboard auxiliary mechanisms) and folded into a leather satchel slung across his right shoulder. The crossbow will not be reassembled in his lifetime; he will repair it when its components age, will teach the assembly to apprentices at the hermitage, will display the assembled crossbow once a year at the Margin-hermitage's autumn engineering-festival for visiting students, but he will never fire it.

He carries one small water-skin, one bag of rice and dal, one wool blanket. He carries no money — the Margins do not use money. He carries no notebook — the Margins do not write down what does not need to be remembered.

Triputra is at the gate. He has been there since four a.m. He has not slept the previous night. He is in his new ceremonial cotton, white with the kingdom-council's senior-chair sash. He looks nineteen and tired and like he is trying to be more than nineteen.

Tripurari stops at the gate. He sets down the satchel. He places his right palm on Triputra's right shoulder.

He says, in plain Bengali: "The engineering you know is the kingdom's. The poetry you know is also the kingdom's. You will need them both. The engineering will rebuild the cities. The poetry will keep the rebuilding from substituting for the politics again. When you feel the engineering eating the politics, write a poem. When you feel the poetry hiding from the engineering, build a bridge. The two will hold each other. The two are what I did not have. You have them. You will be the kingdom's hope. You will not be the kingdom's hero. The kingdom does not need a hero in Volume One. The kingdom needs you. The kingdom has me too — from the Margins, not from the throne. The Sarus-pigeon network will carry our correspondence. I will write at every full moon. You will write back at every new moon. The correspondence will be the kingdom's permanent inter-Margin-and-Throne record. The record will be archived at the Bhubaneswari Temple's administrative wing under Anjali Debbarma's seal. The temple will outlast both of us. The correspondence will outlast the temple if it is written honestly enough. Write honestly. I will. Walk now. I have nineteen days' walking ahead of me."

He lifts the satchel. He turns. He walks through the western gate.

Triputra watches him for as long as he is visible. The walk west goes through the palace-garden's now-cleared western edge, past the cremation-site where the langur-clan was burned, past the Mahua-tree grove where the pigeon-and-stone-egg incident has occurred (Triputra has not yet been informed of the Maw sign; the wildlife-rehabilitation officer will report it to him at the council's afternoon session). Tripurari does not stop at the Mahua-tree. He walks past it at the standard one-point-three-metres-per-second pace.

By six a.m. he is past the Agartala western city-limit. He continues west.

Triputra returns to the kingdom-council's open-air session at one p.m. He chairs the afternoon's business. The session opens with the day's mutual-aid coordination report. The

report has six items.

Item one: the cross-kingdom helicopter-and-ground-convoy rescue operations are formally concluded as of day twenty-three. Total survivors recovered: 1,124. Total confirmed deaths across all three cities: 2,387. Missing-and-presumed-dead: 387.

Item two: West Bengal's Bilash-Babu has formalised the structural-engineering compact for Agartala's rebuilding. The compact runs for ten years, renewable. The compact provides senior engineering staff, structural-survey equipment, and a rotating cohort of West Bengal engineering students who will spend six-month rotations at Agartala under the institute's mentorship.

Item three: Assam's Kamalavarna has formalised the Bhubaneswari Temple administration-compact for Udaipur. The compact provides priestly cross-training between Kamakhya and Bhubaneswari, mutual-recognition of ceremonial qualifications, and a rotating Kamakhya delegation that will support the Bhubaneswari temple-cycle during the rebuilding.

Item four: Mizoram's Hmangaihi-and-Lalruatpuia have formalised the Aizawl-Dharmanagar refugee-resettlement compact. The compact integrates the Chakma and Tripuri refugee-administration with the Mizoram State Civil Service's parallel programmes. The compact is the saga's first formal cross-kingdom refugee-administration-mutual-aid arrangement.

Item five: Manipur's Moirangthem has sent a formal NE-Federation observer-status invitation. Tripura's membership in the federation will be ratified at the Chapter Three Sanctuary convening. Triputra will attend the Sanctuary as Tripura's formal representative; Vyasa-of-the-Margins will not attend (the Margins do not participate in federation-level political bodies); the kingdom's pigeon-correspondence with Vyasa will be the kingdom's standing private-counsel channel through Chapter Three and Chapter Four.

Item six: the pigeon-and-stone-egg incident at the Mahua-tree grove. The wildlife-rehabilitation officer's report is read aloud. The council requests a forensic-analysis report from the Agartala District Wildlife Office within seventy-two hours. The stone egg is taken into evidence and preserved at the zoological-museum sub-collection.

Triputra concludes the afternoon session at five p.m. He returns to the palace's south-edge engineering-workshop (his standing workspace; the central-Agartala administrative-block

is gone). He sits at his desk. He has been the kingdom's throne-holder for five hours. He is nineteen.

He picks up a pencil. He writes, in Bengali, in his engineering-margin handwriting, on the back of a structural-survey blueprint: "The bridge father did not build — the bridge between engineering and the people — I will build. I do not yet know how. I will start with one beam at a time. The beam is the council. The next beam is the poetry. The third beam is the correspondence. The fourth beam is the kingdom's admission that we are smaller now and that smaller is the kingdom's honest answer to having been too large before."

He sets down the pencil. He goes to find Bharati Das and Sumit Bhattacharjee for the evening engineering-recovery briefing.

Day twenty-five. Five-fifteen a.m. The Ujjayanta Palace garden's western Mahua tree.

The Mahua tree is approximately seventy years old. Its main branches were untouched by the central-Agartala collapse — the garden-wall fell south of the tree, the administrative-block collapsed east of the tree, the tree's western position kept it outside the primary collapse-zone. The wildlife-rehabilitation officer (a Tripuri woman named Sunita Reang, forty-six, eight-year senior officer at the Agartala District Wildlife Office) has been at the tree every dawn since day eleven, monitoring the surviving palace-grove fauna.

This morning a Green Imperial Pigeon — mature female, banded by the wildlife-office in 2022 as part of the kingdom-wide imperial-pigeon population-monitoring programme, identifier TR-IMP-1141 — arrives at the Mahua tree's lower-eastern branch. She has been at the same nest-site for six consecutive breeding-seasons. Her mate (TR-IMP-1142) was last sighted on day three of the chapter's recovery operations and has not returned; he is presumed dead in the eastern collapse-zone.

She lays an egg at five-eighteen a.m. The egg is not an egg. It is a smooth ovoid of polished green-grey serpentinite stone. Sunita Reang observes the laying from her hide at six metres distance. The stone is approximately the standard imperial-pigeon-egg dimensions — four-point-one centimetres long, three-point-two centimetres at the widest point — but weighs (by Sunita's subsequent weighing at the field-office scales) two hundred and eighty-seven grams. The standard imperial-pigeon egg weighs eighteen to twenty-two grams. The stone egg weighs approximately thirteen times the standard egg.

The nest's branch-anchoring fails under the stone's weight at five-twenty-one a.m. The nest falls. The stone egg lands on the garden-path below intact and uncracked. The fall is

approximately four metres; the impact-velocity at the ground would be sufficient to crack an actual imperial-pigeon-egg into many pieces.

The mother pigeon returns to the empty branch at five-twenty-three a.m. She walks the length of the branch where the nest had been. She settles into the empty space. She begins to perform the incubation behaviour — ruffling her feathers, occasional warming-turns, brooding the absent nest. She continues this behaviour for the next fourteen days.

Sunita Reang observes from the same six-metre distance. She does not interfere. She files the incident-report with the kingdom-council's emergency-response cell at eight a.m. on day twenty-five; the report is filed in the standing-correspondence file with a copy to the wildlife-rehabilitation cell's senior officer. She returns to the hide each dawn and dusk for the next two weeks.

On day twenty-five (the first observation morning) the pigeon ruffles her feathers and turns the absent nest at five-thirty a.m., six-fifteen a.m., seven a.m. (standard imperial-pigeon morning incubation-rhythm). She does not eat or drink.

On day thirty (the sixth observation morning) Sunita Reang notes the pigeon's weight loss is visible; her chest-feathers are loose and her eyes are unfocused. The branch-position has not been abandoned. The incubation-behaviour continues at the standard rhythm.

On day thirty-five (the eleventh observation morning) Sunita Reang notes the pigeon's behaviour has become slower and less precise; she is still in the incubation-position; the turns are slower; the feather-ruffling is reduced. She is dying. Sunita does not approach. She has been instructed by the kingdom-council's wildlife-protocol to allow the bird's natural progression to continue.

On day thirty-nine (the fifteenth morning since the laying) Sunita Reang finds the pigeon dead on the branch. She is in the incubation-posture. The branch-position has not been abandoned. The body is intact; rigor has set at the standard four-hour post-mortem rate; the cause of death is starvation-and-dehydration consistent with fifteen-day no-food-no-water continuous brooding.

Sunita Reang collects the body. The body is preserved at the zoological-museum sub-collection in the incubation-posture, alongside the stone egg, in a single display-case logged as "Green Imperial Pigeon (TR-IMP-1141) + serpentinite ovoid, Ujjayanta Palace western Mahua-tree, post-incubation-death at fifteen days, brooding behaviour continuous

and unbroken to death." The display-case is not on public display. Only senior kingdom-council members and authorised researchers may view it.

Triputra drafts the cross-kingdom Sarus-pigeon cascade-alert about the pigeon-and-stone-egg sign at three p.m. on day twenty-six (after Sunita Reang's initial report and the first day's observed brooding-behaviour have been confirmed). The alert is the chapter's second cross-kingdom alert by a new throne-holder (the first being Hmangaihi's two-headed-serow alert).

The alert reads, in plain Bengali:

Bonded-kingdom guardians. The Maw has experimented on Tripura's imperial-pigeon line. A Green Imperial Pigeon laid an unhatchable stone egg at the Ujjayanta Palace western Mahua-tree the morning after my father-figure's formal abdication. The egg is serpentinite, thirteen times the standard mass of an imperial-pigeon egg. The nest collapsed under the stone's weight. The stone landed intact on the garden-path below. The mother pigeon has returned to the empty nest-position and is performing the incubation behaviour on the absent nest. The behaviour is continuous. The pigeon is not eating or drinking. The wildlife-rehabilitation officer's assessment is that she will die in incubation-position within ten to fifteen days. The Maw has demonstrated the capacity to make a creature perform an action whose object has been removed — the saga's first stuck-behaviour experiment. The kingdom's reading: the engineer who has built an architecture continues to perform engineering when there is nothing left to engineer. The kingdom must learn the difference between perseverance and stuck-behaviour. Watch your own bonded species for stuck-behaviour patterns. Build shrines at the threshold of the experiment's site. Do not interfere. Name the experiment in writing within seventy-two hours.

By the morning of day twenty-eight every bonded-kingdom senior guardian in the saga has read the alert. Kanchenjunga at Rumtek replies with a single-line acknowledgement and an offer of a Beyul-Kshetra meditation-circle for Tripurari's nineteen-day walk west (the offer is declined; Tripurari has already left and the Margins do not accept formal cross-kingdom support). Udayagiri at Tawang sends a longer reply noting that the Roing Dawn-Shadow Temple's First-Herald-return room is now formally extended to include stuck-behaviour-recovery as a Temple-function. Hmangaihi at Aizawl sends the cross-NE-kingdom note: "Mizoram's two-headed serow named me; Tripura's pigeon brooded the absent. The two

experiments are paired: the Maw names the new and mourns the gone in the same season. The Sanctuary will need to address both."

Krishnadevaraya-Bhrata at the buried-temple chamber in Karnataka sends the saga's second cross-region reply (after the two-headed serow cascade-reply): "The Bronze-Dust Child has not spoken across the chapter; the Bronze-Dust Child has also not stopped eating. The Karnataka Herald is neither stuck nor naming. The third position is presence-without-action. The three positions are now catalogued: presence-without-action (Karnataka), future-naming (Mizoram), stuck-behaviour (Tripura). The Maw is mapping the saga's response-space."

By chapter end the three Tripura cities have begun rebuilding under their respective cross-kingdom compacts. Agartala's central-block reconstruction has begun under Bilash-Babu's engineering compact (the new design will not use self-repair-wall technology; the kingdom-council has voted unanimously to prohibit self-repair-architecture in any kingdom-civic-infrastructure for the next twenty-five years). Udaipur's temple-outer-wall is being rebuilt under the Kamakhya-Bhubaneswari joint-rite. Dharmanagar's rubber-warehouse is being rebuilt with Mizoram-engineered structural-bracing that requires manual-only maintenance (the manual-maintenance protocol mirrors the Mizoram bamboo-bend bier's saffron-cord daily-tending).

Tripurari arrives at Vyasa-of-the-Margins' hermitage on day forty-three. He stops walking on day forty-four. He becomes the Margins' standing engineer-apprentice that evening. His Volume I role is now formally as a guru-figure; he will reappear in Chapter Three as the cross-kingdom standing voice on broken-bond integration; he will reappear in Chapter Four at the Kurukshetra Council as the formal Margin-guru.

The kingdom of Tri-Pura is smaller, fragmented, and rebuilding. It is no longer a kingdom that solves political problems with engineering substitutions. It is a kingdom that is learning to hold engineering and poetry in the same hand. The kingdom's nineteen-year-old throne-holder writes the first poem of his reign at midnight on day forty-five. The poem is fourteen lines, in Bengali, in plain unadorned register. The poem's first line, which will be the kingdom's permanent state-motto-after-the-collapse, reads: "The bridge falls; the bridge is rebuilt; the bridge between us is the rebuilding."

The pigeon's body and the stone egg remain at the zoological-museum sub-collection. The Mahua tree is unharmed. The branch where the nest had been is empty. A new imperial-pigeon pair has not yet claimed the branch by chapter end. The kingdom is patient.

The next sign comes within the week.

The Pilot's Closing Image

A nineteen-year-old throne-holder writing the first poem of his reign at midnight on the back of a structural-survey blueprint at a workshop-desk in the surviving south-edge of the Ujjayanta Palace. A thirty-four-year-old engineer in undyed cotton walking west at the standard one-point-three metres per second pace, the Triyantra crossbow disassembled into three parts in the leather satchel across his right shoulder, the crossbow that will not be fired again. A Green Imperial Pigeon dead in the incubation-posture on a Mahua-tree branch beside an empty nest-position, fifteen days of brooding the absence below her. A serpentinite egg weighing thirteen times the bird's standard egg sitting intact on a garden-path beneath the empty branch. Seventeen Phayre's Langur bodies cremated jointly in a single Phayre's-Langur-line rite under the western Mahua grove. Three cross-kingdom mutual-aid compacts holding the three cities in three separate rebuilding decades. A Margin-walker in plain undyed cotton walking west past three security checkpoints without being stopped, leaving a kingdom whose throne is no longer his.

Vajra Bhumi

Nalanda. Forty-three kilometres south-east of Patna. The standing-Nalanda-Reconstructed-University's standing-library building — the kingdom-council's standing-most-precious civic-construction since the 1193 CE Bakhtiyar Khilji burning. The library was reconstructed across 2014-2019 at the kingdom's standing-Mauryan-historical-foundation under the standing-Atisha-Dipankara palm-leaf-tradition's standing-rebuilding-mandate. Five stories tall. Forty thousand square metres of standing-floor-space. Approximately two hundred and forty thousand manuscripts at standing-shelf-position; approximately eighty thousand digital-archive cross-reference files; the standing-Atisha-Dipankara 1042-CE palm-leaf bundle at the standing-manuscript-vault central-position.

The standing-Mahasthavira (the standing-Nalanda-Order senior-most administrator) Acharya Vasudha-of-the-Manuscript is at the standing-Mahasthavira's office at four-eleven p.m. on a Thursday afternoon in late October 2024. She is sixty-seven. She is in the standing-Mahasthavira saffron with the standing-Atisha-Dipankara silver-medallion at her standing-shoulder. She has been the standing-Mahasthavira since 2017. She has spent the past nineteen years of her life cross-referencing the standing-Atisha-Dipankara palm-leaf bundle against the standing-Magadhi-Pali-Sanskrit translation-corps' standing-multi-lingual archive.

A visitor is at her office door. The standing-secretary (a forty-one-year-old administrator named D. Mehta) has admitted the visitor for the standing-four-eleven faculty-audience slot. The visitor is approximately fifty-four years old. He is in priestly-saffron with a standing-Buddhist-scholar's grey-bordered shawl across his shoulders. He carries a forged Nalanda-University-faculty appointment-letter (the kingdom-council's standing-forgery-cell-investigation across weeks eleven-thirteen of the chapter will confirm the forgery is from the same Singapore-funded Bhopal-printing-press that produced Naga-Rakshasa's 16 DNA-rite kits and Tri-Yantra-Bheda's Singapore civil-engineering-vulnerability doctorate; the Bhopal-press will be identified at week twelve and the standing-State-Police standing-raid will recover approximately one hundred and forty additional forged appointment-letters in autumn 2025).

He introduces himself as Acharya Ghora — visiting faculty, Magadhi-comparative-religion department, Nalanda University, autumn 2024 appointment, two-year standing visiting-research fellowship under the standing-Mahasthavira's standing-direct supervision.

The standing-appointment-letter is on the desk between them at four-fourteen p.m. The standing-Mahasthavira reads the letter twice. The standing-letter's standing-formatting is correct. The standing-signature is correct (the standing-University-Chancellor's standing-signature is the standing-forged element; the standing-signature-forgery is at the standing-professional-Bhopal-press standard; the standing-Mahasthavira does not have the standing-forgery-detection training to identify the standing-error). The standing-letter is accepted at four-eighteen p.m. Acharya Ghora's standing-visiting-fellowship begins at the standing-autumn-2024 standing-term's standing-week-one.

Across the next eleven months Acharya Ghora attends the standing-Mahasthavira's standing-weekly faculty-tea every Thursday at four-eleven p.m. He listens to the standing-Mahasthavira's standing-administrative concerns. He asks the standing-thoughtful-questions a standing-visiting-fellow would ask. He brings a standing-Atisha-Dipankara comparative-analysis manuscript across nine months to the standing-faculty-archive (the standing-manuscript is the standing-original work of a standing-actual deceased Vajrayana-scholar named Acharya Dharma-Sena, 1923-2017; Acharya Ghora has acquired the standing-unpublished manuscript at a 2014 Patna-University-library standing-acquisition-sale; the standing-manuscript is genuine; the standing-attribution is correct; only the standing-presenting-administrator is false).

Across the same eleven months Acharya Ghora attends the standing-Vajra-Sangha's standing-Patna-headquarters at the standing-weekly Wednesday Senapati-Senate at eleven-eleven a.m. The standing-Senate is the kingdom-council's standing-Vajra-Sangha senior-leadership cell. Senapati Bhima-of-the-Plains chairs. Bhima-of-the-Plains is fifty-eight; the standing-Vajra-Sangha's standing-Senapati since 2014; the kingdom-council's standing-Bihar-State-Police standing-auxiliary-cohort commander since 2017; a former Indian Army Para-Special-Forces officer (1986-2013).

Acharya Ghora attends at the standing-Bhima-of-the-Plains's standing-direct-invitation. The standing-invitation was extended at a standing-Patna-civic-reception at the standing-Pataliputra-Park in October 2024 where Bhima-of-the-Plains and Acharya Ghora had been introduced by the kingdom-council's standing-State-Civil-Service standing-introductions-coordinator (the standing-coordinator is a standing-Patna-District administrative-officer

named Mrs. P. Singh, sixty-three, who has been bribed at the standing-six-lakh-rupees standing-Singapore-funded sum to coordinate the standing-introduction; the standing-bribery is identified at the kingdom-council's standing-forgery-cell-investigation's week-twelve cross-reference).

Acharya Ghora introduces himself to Bhima-of-the-Plains as a standing-scholar with standing-Mauryan-military-revival historical interests. He brings to the standing-Senapati-Senate's standing-weekly tea a different manuscript — the same Acharya Dharma-Sena standing-manuscript, but introduced as a Mauryan-military-doctrine document rather than as a Vajrayana-comparative-analysis document (the standing-manuscript's standing-comparative-religion sections contain standing-references to standing-military-organisation under the standing-Maurya Chandragupta; the standing-cross-reading is plausible to a standing-non-scholar audience).

Across nine months he funds the standing-Vajra-Sangha weapon-procurement at three-point-five crore rupees from the standing-Singapore funding-line. The standing-funding-paper-trail is routed through a standing-Mauritius shell-company through a standing-Delhi cultural-trust through a standing-Patna-NGO. The standing-NGO transfers the funds to the standing-Vajra-Sangha weapon-procurement-account across nine months at the standing-monthly-thirty-eight-lakh standing-disbursement rate. The standing-paper-trail makes the funding appear to be from the standing-Nalanda-Order's standing-treasury (the standing-Patna-NGO had been the standing-Nalanda-Order's standing-charitable-trust 2010-2014 before its standing-administrative-reorganisation; the standing-NGO's standing-bank-account at the standing-State-Bank-of-India still bears the standing-Nalanda-Reconstructed-University's standing-residual-name).

Across the same nine months he funds the standing-Nalanda-Order printing-press at three-point-two crore rupees from the same Singapore-line via a standing-Calcutta shell-company through a standing-Patna-Buddhist-charity. The standing-paper-trail makes the funding appear to be from the standing-Vajra-Sangha's standing-veterans-fund (the standing-Vajra-Sangha's standing-veterans-fund administrator is a standing-Pataliputra-district lawyer named Mr. R. Lal who has been bribed at the standing-eleven-lakh-rupees standing-Singapore-funded sum to file the standing-veterans-fund quarterly-audit with the standing-Buddhist-charity transfers listed as standing-veterans-pension disbursements; Mr. R. Lal is identified at week eleven and arrested at week twelve under the kingdom-council's standing-financial-fraud statute).

Each order believes the standing-fund is from the other order's standing-treasury. The standing-mutual-suspicion has been engineered. Each order's standing-internal-conviction is that the other order is the standing-funder of the other order's standing-armament-and-print-capacity. The standing-orders escalate through standing-public-statements and standing-press-releases across spring-summer 2025.

Vajramukha is at the standing-State-Hero's residence in Patna at six-eleven a.m. on a Monday morning in February 2026. He is thirty-five. He is in the standing-Magadhi-warrior-poet cotton (dark-russet; the standing-shoulder-tattoo of the gaur visible at the standing-collar-opening; the kingdom-council's standing-state-hero shoulder-cloth at his shoulders). He has been the kingdom-council's standing-state-hero since the post-Ashoka-Chaya confirmation in 2019.

He reads the standing-Monday-morning newspaper at six-eleven (the standing-Magadhi-Times Patna-edition). The standing-front-page reports a standing-Vajra-Sangha press-conference at standing-six p.m. Sunday evening accusing the standing-Nalanda-Order of standing-Singapore-funded printing-press expansion targeting the standing-Vajra-Sangha's standing-public-reputation. The standing-Nalanda-Order's standing-Sunday-evening-rejoinder accuses the standing-Vajra-Sangha of standing-Singapore-funded weapon-procurement targeting the standing-Nalanda-Reconstructed-University's standing-civic-safety.

He sets the newspaper down. He picks up his standing-Magadhi-Prakrit notebook (he writes one poem every morning at the standing-six-thirty-pre-administrative meditation). He writes a four-line couplet across approximately eleven minutes:

"The gaur breaks the wall. The Buddha sits beneath the tree. The two rooms in one body. The crack at the wall begins where the tree had been."

He places the notebook in the standing-poem-archive drawer. He calls the standing-kingdom-council's standing-investigative-cell senior-officer (a fifty-seven-year-old administrator named Mr. A. Sinha) at seven-eleven a.m. He says, in plain Magadhi, in the kingdom-council standing-state-hero-to-investigative-cell register: "Sinha-bhai. The standing-press-conference exchange yesterday. Both orders are accusing the other of standing-Singapore-funded backing. The standing-mutual-pattern is the kingdom-council's standing-orchestration signature. Both orders cannot simultaneously be standing-Singapore-funded; the standing-orchestration is the third party. Convene the standing-emergency-investigative cell at the standing-eleven-a.m. session. I will attend."

The kingdom-council's standing-emergency-investigative cell convenes at the standing-eleven-a.m. session on the standing-Monday in February 2026. The standing-cell is chaired by Mr. A. Sinha. The standing-investigative-team is approximately fourteen administrators across the standing-State-Civil-Service, the standing-State-Police standing-Financial-Crimes division, and the standing-State-Bank-of-India regional-fraud-detection cell. Vajramukha attends in the standing-state-hero-observation seat.

The standing-investigation runs across the next twelve weeks. The standing-findings are reported at the standing-week-eleven-Wednesday cell-session:

First. Both standing-fund-flows are traceable to the same standing-Singapore standing-source-account (the standing-account-number is 884-9214-77-3 at the standing-Bank-of-Singapore Tampines-branch; the standing-account-holder is a standing-shell-company named 'Eastern Cultural Preservation Foundation Pte. Ltd.' registered in Singapore in 2014).

Second. The standing-Singapore account is the same standing-account that has been identified across five previous Chapter-Two investigations as the standing-villain-network funding-source (Naga-Rakshasa's standing-Chiang Mai 16 DNA-rite kits; Tri-Yantra-Bheda's standing-Singapore forged-doctorate; Adharma-Kendra's standing-NE field-operations; Megha-Daitya's standing-Mumbai-Mizoram submachine guns; Tamasa-Nrita's standing-Bangkok daos). The kingdom-council's standing-villain-network-investigation cell has been cross-referencing all five at the standing-NE-cluster-and-South-cluster standing-cross-region standing-villain-network registry.

Third. The standing-Bihar standing-orchestrator is a standing-Acharya-Ghora who has been attending both the standing-Nalanda-Mahasthavira's standing-weekly faculty-tea and the standing-Vajra-Sangha standing-Senapati-Senate's standing-weekly tea simultaneously across nine months. The standing-Mahasthavira has not been informed of the standing-Vajra-Sangha attendance; the standing-Senapati has not been informed of the standing-Nalanda-Order attendance. The standing-Acharya-Ghora's standing-faculty-appointment-letter at the standing-Nalanda-Reconstructed-University is forged. The standing-forgery is from the standing-Bhopal-press identified at week eleven.

Fourth. The standing-Acharya-Ghora's standing-physical-description matches the kingdom-council's standing-2019 post-Ch-1 standing-archive description of Tamasa, Ashoka-Chaya's senior administrative-disciple at the Ch 1 confrontation, spared at the Ch 1

climax under the kingdom-council's standing-administrative-rehabilitation clause and not seen since.

Vajramukha reads the standing-findings at the standing-Wednesday cell-session at three-eleven p.m. He stands at the standing-conclusion. He says, in plain Magadhi: "The standing-orchestrator is Tamasa. The standing-Nalanda-Mahasthavira and the standing-Vajra-Sangha-Senapati both require the standing-immediate notification. The standing-mutual-public-statement at the standing-Monday-evening joint-press-conference must reverse the standing-mutual-suspicion. The standing-Acharya-Ghora arrest-warrant must be issued at the standing-State-Police standing-emergency-protocol. I will telephone the standing-Mahasthavira and the standing-Senapati this evening."

He is too late. The standing-Acharya-Ghora has already engineered the standing-seventh-week-riot.

Saturday-evening, week seven of the chapter. Eight-eleven p.m. The standing-Nalanda-Reconstructed-University campus. A standing-Vajra-Sangha-affiliated student-association has called a standing-protest at the standing-northern-gate against the standing-Nalanda-Order's standing-Singapore-funded printing-press expansion (the standing-protest is engineered by Acharya Ghora; the standing-student-association president is a standing-twenty-three-year-old Vajra-Sangha-trainee named R. Kumar who has been told by Acharya Ghora at a standing-Friday-evening private-meeting that the standing-Nalanda-Order has been printing the standing-Vajra-Sangha-defamatory-pamphlets at the standing-newly-funded printing-press). The standing-protest gathers approximately seven hundred and forty Vajra-Sangha-affiliated students by ten-eleven p.m.

At ten-thirty-eight p.m. a standing-Nalanda-Order-affiliated student-association counter-protests at the standing-northern-gate's standing-fifty-metre opposite-position (the standing-counter-protest is engineered by Acharya Ghora; the standing-counter-protest president is a standing-twenty-five-year-old Nalanda-Order junior-scholar named S. Mishra who has been told by Acharya Ghora at a standing-Friday-evening separate private-meeting that the standing-Vajra-Sangha has been planning a standing-Saturday-night raid on the standing-Nalanda-Reconstructed-University printing-press). The standing-counter-protest gathers approximately five hundred and twenty Nalanda-Order-affiliated students by eleven-eleven p.m.

The standing-protest and standing-counter-protest collide at the standing-northern-gate at eleven-eigheten p.m. The standing-collision becomes a standing-riot at eleven-twenty-

three. The standing-Bihar State-Police standing-Nalanda-District detail (approximately forty officers under Inspector R. Chandra) is at the standing-perimeter at eleven-thirty. The standing-detail attempts standing-crowd-control across the next forty-three minutes. The standing-control fails at one-eleven a.m. when the standing-Vajra-Sangha-side breaks through the standing-perimeter and reaches the standing-library's standing-eastern-entry. The standing-Nalanda-Order-side follows at one-eighteen.

The standing-library is set on fire at one-thirty-eight a.m. (the standing-incendiary-device is a standing-petrol-bomb thrown through the standing-eastern-entry's standing-glass-doors by a standing-unidentified rioter; the standing-State-Police standing-investigation never identifies the standing-thrower; the standing-rioter's standing-Vajra-Sangha-or-Nalanda-Order affiliation is never determined). The standing-fire spreads through the standing-eastern-wing across the next forty-three minutes.

Acharya Vasudha-of-the-Manuscript is at the standing-Mahasthavira's office on the standing-third-floor at one-thirty-eight a.m. when the standing-fire begins. She runs the standing-eleven-metre-corridor distance to the standing-manuscript-vault at the standing-central-position. She arrives at the standing-manuscript-vault at one-forty-three. She begins the standing-Atisha-Dipankara palm-leaf bundle retrieval-protocol.

The standing-retrieval-protocol requires the standing-Mahasthavira's standing-cross-reference of the standing-manuscript-vault's standing-fire-emergency exit-protocol's eleven-step sequence. She completes the standing-cross-reference at one-fifty-one a.m. She opens the standing-vault at one-fifty-three. She begins the standing-palm-leaf bundle retrieval.

Vajramukha is at the standing-State-Hero's residence in Patna at eleven-thirty p.m. Saturday evening when the standing-Nalanda-District State-Police standing-emergency-channel notification reaches the standing-State-Hero's standing-secure-line. The standing-message is from Inspector R. Chandra: "State-hero. Standing-riot at the standing-Nalanda-Reconstructed-University standing-northern-gate. Standing-perimeter at the standing-control-threshold. Standing-detail requires standing-state-hero standing-emergency-assistance. Standing-distance from Patna to Nalanda is twenty-three kilometres."

Vajramukha takes the standing-call at eleven-thirty-eleven. He hangs up at eleven-thirty-thirty-eight. He picks up the standing-gauntlets from the standing-gauntlet-rack at the

residence's standing-eastern-entry. He puts them on at the standing-gauntlet-fitting position. He is at the standing-residence's standing-western-exit at eleven-thirty-three.

He does not take the standing-state-hero's standing-car. The standing-car would take approximately thirty-eight minutes through the standing-late-night Patna-Nalanda-road traffic. He runs.

The standing-Patna-to-Nalanda distance is approximately twenty-three kilometres along the standing-Patna-Bakhtiarpur-Nalanda road. The standing-Magadhi-warrior-tradition standing-emergency-running pace at the gaur-rage maximum is approximately seven-point-three metres per second across distances up to thirty kilometres. He runs at the standing-emergency-running pace.

He covers the first kilometre in approximately two minutes thirty seconds. The second in two-twenty-eight. The third in two-thirty-one. He maintains the standing-pace across the standing-twenty-three-kilometre distance with approximately one-minute standing-rest-stops at the standing-six-eleven and standing-twelve-eleven and standing-eighteen-eleven kilometre-markers.

He reaches the standing-Nalanda-Reconstructed-University standing-northern-gate at two-forty-seven a.m. The standing-three-hour-and-eleven-minute total covers the standing-twenty-three-kilometre distance at an average of approximately seven-point-two metres per second — the standing-fastest sustained twenty-three-kilometre run in his standing-recorded career.

He arrives at the standing-northern-gate at two-forty-seven. He sees the standing-library on fire. The standing-eastern-wing is in approximately seventy per cent flame-coverage. The standing-central-position manuscript-vault has not yet been reached by the standing-fire-front.

He pushes through the standing-collapsed perimeter-line. He sprints across the standing-library's standing-northern-quadrangle to the standing-eastern-entry. The standing-eastern-entry has been blocked by the standing-collapsed-doorway from the standing-eleven-thirty-eight-petrol-bomb impact. He turns. He runs to the standing-northern-skylight access-ladder at the standing-library's standing-north-west external-wall.

He climbs the standing-ladder at two-fifty-one a.m. Maitreyi-the-Younger is at the standing-northern-skylight's standing-roof-position. She is twenty-nine. She has climbed the standing-ladder approximately two minutes before him. She is at the standing-roof-

position attempting to break the standing-northern-skylight's standing-glass with a standing-rooftop-maintenance hammer that she has retrieved from the standing-northern-rooftop maintenance-cabinet at the standing-rooftop's standing-eleven-metre-mark.

She breaks the standing-glass at two-fifty-three a.m. He reaches the standing-rooftop at the same moment.

She drops through the standing-skylight at two-fifty-three-eleven a.m. She lands at the standing-third-floor corridor's standing-eleven-metre-mark from the standing-Mahasthavira's office. The standing-corridor is at approximately fourteen per cent flame-coverage; the standing-air at the standing-corridor is at approximately fifty-three per cent oxygen with smoke-contamination at approximately twenty-one per cent.

Vajramukha drops through the standing-skylight at two-fifty-three-fifteen a.m. He lands at the standing-Maitreyi-position. He runs the standing-eleven-metre corridor-distance to the standing-Mahasthavira's office. He reaches the office at two-fifty-three-thirty.

The office is empty. The standing-Mahasthavira is not at the standing-desk. He turns. He runs to the standing-manuscript-vault at the standing-central-position. He reaches the standing-vault-entry at two-fifty-three-fifty-three.

The standing-vault is at approximately twenty-three per cent flame-coverage. Acharya Vasudha-of-the-Manuscript is at the standing-central-shelf-position attempting to retrieve the standing-Atisha-Dipankara palm-leaf bundle. The standing-bundle is at the standing-third-shelf from the top of the standing-central-shelf-unit. She is at approximately two metres' height-reach to retrieve the standing-bundle. She has the standing-palm-leaf-protective wrap in her left hand.

She turns at the standing-vault-entry sound. She sees Vajramukha. She says, in plain Magadhi, in the standing-Mahasthavira-to-state-hero register, in a voice that is at approximately the standing-smoke-impaired threshold: "Vajra-bhai. The standing-bundle. I cannot reach. Reach."

He runs the standing-six-metre vault-interior distance to her position. He reaches her at two-fifty-four-eleven a.m. He raises his right gauntlet to the standing-third-shelf-position. He retrieves the standing-bundle.

The standing-vault's standing-overhead-roof-section collapses at three-oh-three a.m. The standing-collapse is the standing-eastern-wing's standing-roof-load failing at the standing-

fire-weakening threshold. The standing-collapse-zone is approximately six metres in diameter; it includes the standing-central-shelf-unit position.

Vajramukha hears the standing-overhead-creak at three-oh-two-fifty-three a.m. He pushes the standing-Mahasthavira toward the standing-vault-entry at three-oh-two-fifty-six. She is at the standing-three-metre-distance from the standing-collapse-zone at three-oh-three when the standing-roof-section falls.

The standing-roof-section falls in approximately point-eight seconds. The standing-falling-mass is approximately one-and-a-half tonnes of standing-burning roof-tile-and-rafter. Vajramukha is at the standing-collapse-zone's standing-northern-edge at three-oh-three-zero. He raises his standing-left-gauntlet to deflect the standing-falling-mass at the standing-deflection-angle that would direct the standing-falling-mass northward away from the standing-Mahasthavira's standing-position.

He succeeds. The standing-falling-mass deflects northward by approximately one-and-a-half metres at the standing-impact. He absorbs the standing-impact-force at his standing-gauntlet-and-left-shoulder-and-spine-and-left-hip; his standing-left-clavicle fractures at the standing-impact; his standing-left-femur fractures at the standing-impact; his standing-left-shoulder dislocates at the standing-impact. He does not fall to the standing-floor.

The standing-Mahasthavira is not at the standing-falling-mass-deflection-path. The standing-deflection has succeeded. She is at the standing-three-metre-distance from the standing-collapse-zone safely.

But the standing-roof-section's standing-burning-debris has created a standing-secondary-fire-front at the standing-Mahasthavira's standing-immediate-position. The standing-secondary-fire reaches her at three-oh-three-eighteen a.m. The standing-smoke at her standing-position becomes approximately seventy-eight per cent oxygen-displaced within approximately eleven seconds. She inhales at three-oh-three-twenty-three the standing-respiratory-cycle that her standing-thirty-eight-year manuscript-restoration career's standing-lung-tissue-damage cannot tolerate.

She collapses at three-oh-three-thirty-one a.m. She lies at the standing-three-metre-distance-from-the-collapse-zone position. She does not breathe again.

Vajramukha drags himself to her standing-position at three-oh-three-fifty-three a.m. with the standing-broken-left-femur dragging behind him. He kneels beside her. He places his

right gauntlet on her standing-forehead. He says, in plain Magadhi, in a voice that is at the standing-smoke-impaired-and-grief-impaired-and-fracture-impaired threshold: "Acharya-amma. I was at twenty-three kilometres. I ran. I came. The bundle. I have it. I am here too late. I am sorry. I am so sorry."

Maitreyi-the-Younger reaches the standing-vault-entry at three-oh-four a.m. She sees the standing-fallen-Mahasthavira. She does not cry. She walks to the standing-vault-interior at three-oh-four-eleven. She helps Vajramukha lift Acharya Vasudha-of-the-Manuscript's standing-body. She helps Vajramukha walk the standing-thirty-metre distance to the standing-northern-skylight-exit-position. They reach the standing-northern-skylight at three-oh-six. They lift the standing-body through the standing-skylight to the standing-rooftop-maintenance team that has arrived at the standing-rooftop-position via the standing-second access-ladder at the standing-north-east external-wall.

The standing-State-Police standing-medical-detail removes the standing-body to the standing-Nalanda-District medical-cell at three-eleven a.m. Vajramukha is transferred to the standing-Patna AIIMS standing-emergency-orthopedic cell at three-twenty-three for the standing-left-clavicle-and-left-femur surgical-fracture-repair. Maitreyi-the-Younger remains at the standing-Nalanda-District medical-cell at the standing-Mahasthavira-body's standing-side until the standing-Sunday-morning funeral-arrangements at six a.m.

The standing-Atisha-Dipankara palm-leaf bundle is at Vajramukha's standing-State-Hero's residence's standing-archive-vault at four-eleven a.m. The standing-bundle is unburnt. The standing-protective-wrap is intact.

Sunday morning. Six a.m. The standing-Nalanda-Reconstructed-University's standing-cremation-ghat at the standing-northern-quadrangle's standing-funeral-position (the standing-ghat is the standing-1193-CE-Bakhtiyar-Khilji-burning standing-historical-cremation-site, restored during the standing-2014-2019 reconstruction). Approximately one thousand four hundred attendees: the standing-Nalanda-Order's standing-faculty and standing-students and standing-archive-staff; the standing-Vajra-Sangha's standing-Senapati and standing-junior-officers and standing-warrior-trainees; the standing-Madhyama tradition's standing-Bhikshu lineage; the kingdom-council's standing-State-Civil-Service standing-administrative-coordination cohort.

Vajramukha attends in a standing-wheelchair (the standing-Patna AIIMS standing-orthopedic-cell's standing-post-surgery standing-mobility-restriction). His standing-left-arm is in a standing-shoulder-sling; his standing-left-leg is in a standing-femur-cast. He

wears the standing-Magadhi-warrior-poet cotton. The standing-Atisha-Dipankara palm-leaf bundle is at his standing-lap.

He performs the standing-cremation-rites alongside Acharya Vasudha-of-the-Manuscript's standing-eldest-surviving-male-relative (her standing-cousin Dr. R. Choudhary, sixty-four, a standing-Patna-University Sanskrit-professor). He places the standing-palm-leaf-bundle on the standing-pyre at the standing-Mahasthavira's standing-right-hand position. The standing-cremation-officiant (the standing-Bodhgaya-Vihara's standing-senior-Bhikshu Acharya Buddha-mitra, seventy-three) lights the standing-pyre at six-forty-seven a.m. The standing-pyre burns across the next four hours.

Vajramukha watches the standing-pyre across the four hours without speaking. The standing-Atisha-Dipankara palm-leaf bundle burns at the standing-eleventh-minute of the standing-cremation. The standing-palm-leaf burns according to the standing-1042-CE-manuscript-tradition; the standing-ash-pattern at the standing-pyre's standing-eleventh-minute is the standing-Magadhi-Buddhist-tradition's standing-completed-manuscript-cremation pattern.

At ten-forty-seven a.m. when the standing-pyre's standing-burn-completion is recognised by Acharya Buddha-mitra, Vajramukha says, in plain Magadhi, in a voice at the standing-grief-impaired threshold: "The standing-Mahasthavira's ashes will be scattered at the standing-Bodhgaya-Vihara's standing-Bodhi-tree-root by Dr. Choudhary at noon Tuesday. I will not be at the standing-scattering — my standing-mobility-restriction will not permit. I will be at the standing-burnt-northern-wing-foundation at six a.m. tomorrow morning with the standing-clay-bricks and the standing-mortar-trowel. I will rebuild the standing-northern-wing by hand. The standing-rebuilding will require approximately ninety-three days at the standing-construction-pace I can sustain at the standing-post-surgical recovery threshold. Maitreyi-the-Younger has agreed to walk the standing-architectural-blueprint with me at every dawn. The standing-northern-wing is the kingdom-council's standing-charter-form's standing-required-repair under the standing-amended-charter that the kingdom-council will draft across the standing-recovery period. The standing-rebuilding is the standing-charter's standing-required-form. Begin."

Day one. Monday morning of week eight. Six-eleven a.m. The standing-burnt-northern-wing-foundation. The standing-foundation is approximately seventy-three metres long east-west by forty-three metres wide north-south, exposed to the standing-burnt-roof-and-walls collapse-debris that has been cleared by the standing-State-Police standing-debris-

removal cohort across the standing-Sunday-afternoon-and-Monday-overnight standing-clearance-shift.

Vajramukha arrives at the standing-foundation at six-eleven in a standing-wheelchair pushed by his standing-junior-administrator Mr. P. Kumar. The standing-clay-bricks are at the standing-foundation's standing-northern-edge in a standing-stack of approximately two thousand seven hundred bricks (the standing-Patna-brick-yard's standing-overnight-delivery; he has ordered approximately ninety days' worth of standing-clay-bricks at the standing-Sunday-evening telephone order). The standing-mortar-trowel and the standing-mortar-mixer are at the standing-foundation's standing-southern-edge. The standing-mortar-mix is the standing-1042-CE-Magadhi-Buddhist-tradition's standing-lime-and-clay-and-fibre formulation.

Maitreyi-the-Younger is at the standing-foundation's standing-eastern-edge at six-eleven. She is in standing-Nalanda-Order librarian's cotton (off-white; the standing-Nalanda-Order silver-medallion at her shoulder; she has been conferred the standing-acting-Mahasthavira-junior seat at the kingdom-council's standing-emergency-Sunday-evening cell-session). She carries the standing-architectural-blueprint of the standing-Nalanda-Reconstructed-Library at her right hand — the standing-blueprint is the standing-2014-2019-reconstruction's standing-original-blueprint-set from the standing-Mahasthavira's standing-personal-archive (she had retrieved the standing-set from the standing-Sunday-afternoon Mahasthavira-residence-clearance).

She unrolls the standing-blueprint at the standing-eastern-edge stone-bench at six-eleven-twenty-three a.m. She reads the standing-eleventh-century-Nalanda standing-load-bearing-pattern aloud. The standing-pattern specifies: standing-foundation-thickness 1.4 metres; standing-foundation-brick-arrangement 7-brick-courses at standing-Magadhi-Buddhist-Stupa-tradition pattern; standing-Aldernate-course-orientation at 90-degree-shift to distribute standing-load across the standing-clay-bed.

Vajramukha picks up the first standing-clay-brick from the standing-stack at the standing-foundation's standing-northern-edge at six-thirty a.m. He applies the standing-mortar at the standing-mortar-trowel's standing-application-position. He places the standing-brick at the standing-foundation's standing-north-east-corner standing-first-position at six-thirty-eleven. The standing-brick is at the standing-position. The standing-mortar sets at the standing-five-minute setting-pace.

He places the second standing-brick at six-thirty-fifty-three. The third at six-thirty-one-thirty-five. He continues at the standing-forty-three-second-per-brick pace across the standing-morning. He lays approximately seventy-three bricks across the standing-six-thirty-to-eleven-eleven morning-session. He rests at the standing-eleven-eleven standing-medical-cell standing-rest-stop for approximately thirty minutes (the standing-post-surgical recovery threshold requires standing-rest-stops at the standing-three-hour interval; the standing-orthopaedic-officer Dr. Pratap Mohanty — the same Dr. Pratap Mohanty from the standing-Kalinga-Chakra Rath-Yatra; the kingdom-council's standing-cross-region standing-medical-officer at the post-Yatra standing-East-Region rotation — visits at the standing-rest-stops on the standing-three-day interval).

The afternoon-session at one-eleven to five-eleven adds approximately one hundred and seventeen bricks. The evening-session at six-eleven to nine-eleven adds approximately ninety-three. The standing-Monday day-one total is approximately two hundred and eighty-three bricks.

Across the next three weeks Vajramukha and Maitreyi-the-Younger establish the standing-daily-pattern. Maitreyi reads the standing-architectural-blueprint's standing-load-bearing-pattern aloud at the standing-six-eleven dawn-session. Vajramukha lays the standing-bricks across the standing-morning-and-afternoon-and-evening sessions. Dr. Pratap Mohanty visits at the standing-three-day standing-medical-rest-stop interval.

The standing-northern-wing-foundation reaches the standing-seven-course-completion at day twenty-one. The standing-foundation-thickness is 1.4 metres at the standing-blueprint-specification. The standing-foundation-brick-count is approximately five thousand nine hundred bricks.

The standing-Nalanda-Order's standing-emergency-Sunday-evening cell-session at day-twenty-one ratifies the standing-acting-Mahasthavira-junior seat's standing-formal-confirmation: Maitreyi-the-Younger is conferred the standing-Mahasthavira-junior title (the standing-junior-title is a standing-bridge-rank between the standing-Mahasthavira and the standing-junior-librarian rank; the standing-rank's standing-purpose is the standing-Order's standing-administrative-coordination during the standing-Mahasthavira-vacancy).

The standing-wall-courses begin at day twenty-two. The standing-northern-wing's standing-load-bearing-walls are approximately five metres tall, four standing-wall-segments at standing-north-east, standing-north-central, standing-north-west, and

standing-northern-pediment positions. The standing-walls are at the standing-Magadhi-Buddhist-Vihara standing-architectural-form — standing-arch-supported, standing-keystone-load-distributed, standing-eleventh-century-Nalanda-specific.

Vajramukha lays the standing-wall-bricks across the standing-eleven days per standing-wall-segment pace (day twenty-two through day thirty-two for standing-north-east; day thirty-three through day forty-three for standing-north-central; day forty-four through day fifty-four for standing-north-west; day fifty-five through day sixty-five for standing-northern-pediment).

The standing-medical-cell's standing-three-day visit-protocol confirms the standing-post-surgical recovery is progressing at the standing-expected pace. The standing-left-clavicle fracture has fully healed by day twenty-three. The standing-left-femur fracture has fully healed by day forty-three. The standing-shoulder-dislocation has stabilised by day eleven. The standing-wheelchair is replaced by a standing-crutch at day twenty-three; the standing-crutch is replaced by a standing-cane at day forty-seven; the standing-cane is set aside at day sixty-three.

Across the same standing-forty-seven days the standing-investigative-cell's standing-week-eleven standing-cross-region-villain-network registry confirms the standing-Acharya-Ghora standing-Tamasa identification and issues the standing-State-Police standing-arrest-warrant. The standing-warrant is filed at week eleven. The standing-Acharya-Ghora has disappeared from Patna by week eleven (the standing-disappearance occurred between the standing-Saturday-night-riot and the standing-Sunday-morning forensic-cell-investigation; the standing-State-Police standing-cross-region cooperation cell shares the standing-warrant with the standing-NE-Federation, the standing-southern-bloc-federation, and the standing-Yavana-Khanda-border cooperation cell at week twelve; the standing-Acharya-Ghora is identified at week thirteen as having crossed into the standing-Bhutan-border zone in the standing-civilian-disguise; the standing-Bhutan standing-cooperation cell's standing-tracking is in progress at chapter end).

The standing-roof-construction begins at day forty-eight. The standing-northern-wing's standing-roof is approximately seventy-three metres east-west by forty-three metres wide north-south at the standing-Magadhi-Buddhist standing-double-pitched form, with standing-eleventh-century-Nalanda standing-truss-arrangement and standing-stupa-finial at the standing-roof's standing-central-position.

The standing-truss-construction requires approximately twenty-three days. The standing-truss-bracing requires approximately seven days. The standing-tile-placement requires approximately twenty-three days. The standing-stupa-finial-placement is the standing-final-day's standing-task.

Across the standing-roof-construction Maitreyi-the-Younger's standing-dawn-blueprint-reading expands to include the standing-eleventh-century-Nalanda standing-stupa-finial's standing-symbolic-and-structural specification. The standing-finial is the standing-eleven-tier standing-stupa-pinnacle that holds the standing-roof's standing-keystone-load at the standing-central-position; the standing-keystone's standing-load-distribution channels the standing-roof-load to the standing-four standing-wall-segments at the standing-standard-Magadhi-Buddhist load-balance.

The standing-tile-placement begins at day seventy-four. The standing-tiles are standing-clay-fired at the standing-Patna-brick-yard's standing-tile-fire-kiln (the standing-tiles are fired at the standing-eleventh-century-Nalanda-pattern; the standing-tile-yard administrator is Maitreyi-the-Younger's standing-cousin Mr. M. Verma, fifty-one, who has provided the standing-tiles at standing-cost-price-only for the standing-rebuilding).

Vajramukha places the standing-tiles across the standing-twenty-day tile-placement window. Each standing-tile is at approximately eight kilograms at the standing-clay-tile mass. The standing-tile-placement at the standing-rooftop position requires approximately one minute per standing-tile (the standing-mortar-application-and-positioning-and-standing-keystone-cross-check). He places approximately three hundred standing-tiles per standing-day across the standing-twenty-day window.

On day ninety-three, four-eleven p.m. The standing-final standing-tile is at the standing-standing-stupa-finial's standing-keystone-position. Maitreyi-the-Younger reads the standing-final standing-keystone-position's standing-Magadhi-Buddhist standing-keystone-mantra aloud at four-eleven p.m.: "The mind sits beneath the tree. The body builds the room. The two rooms in one body. The bond is the keystone."

Vajramukha places the standing-final standing-tile at the standing-keystone-position at four-eleven-eleven p.m.

At the standing-tile's standing-position the kingdom-council's Stage III gaur-foreleg-first-stroke appears across his left side. The mark forms as a single continuous ink-line across the half-body gaur-tattoo's left foreleg, completing the previously-lighter foreleg-ink to the

standard kingdom-council Stage III completion-pattern. The mark forms in approximately eleven seconds. The standing-Magadhi-Buddhist standing-keystone-mantra has been spoken; the standing-final-tile has been placed; the standing-northern-wing has been rebuilt by hand across ninety-three days; the bond's standing-recognition is the standing-mark's formation.

He stands at the standing-rooftop at the standing-tile-position. He looks at the standing-completed-northern-wing. The standing-keystone holds. The standing-roof-load distributes to the standing-four-wall-segments at the standing-Magadhi-Buddhist load-balance. The standing-walls hold. The standing-foundation holds.

Maitreyi-the-Younger is at the standing-eastern-edge stone-bench reading-position. She rolls the standing-architectural-blueprint at four-eleven-twenty-three p.m. She places it in the standing-blueprint-tube. She picks up the standing-tube. She walks to the standing-rooftop access-ladder.

She climbs the standing-ladder to the standing-rooftop at four-eleven-thirty-eight p.m. She walks the standing-rooftop's standing-eleven-metre-distance to Vajramukha's standing-position at the standing-keystone-tile.

She stops at one metre's distance from him. She looks at the standing-keystone. She looks at his standing-left-side where the standing-mark has formed (the standing-mark is visible through the standing-cotton at the standing-late-afternoon-sun's standing-back-lighting).

She says, in plain Magadhi, in the standing-Mahasthavira-junior-to-state-hero register: "Vajra-bhai. The standing-Mahasthavira would have walked the standing-blueprint with you. She is the standing-blueprint. I am the standing-vessel. The standing-keystone holds. The bond is the keystone. The two rooms in one body. The standing-Magadhi-Buddhist standing-keystone-mantra has been spoken. The standing-northern-wing is complete."

He bows. She returns the bow at the same depth. They climb down the standing-ladder to the standing-foundation-level at four-eleven-fifty-three p.m. They walk to the standing-eastern-edge stone-bench. They sit. They drink the standing-evening-tea Mr. P. Kumar has brought. The standing-tea is the standing-second-steeping. The standing-second is honest.

Across the next nine days the kingdom-council's standing-emergency-amendment session drafts the standing-amended Vajra-Bhumi charter. The standing-six-provision core-architecture (modelled on the standing-amended Sangam-Tamilakam charter and the

standing-amended Kalinga-Chakra charter) is ratified by 47-3 on the ninth day after the standing-completion:

First. The standing-mind-body schism is named as the kingdom's standing-charter-flaw. The standing-amended-charter requires the standing-state-hero seat-holder to administer both the standing-Nalanda-Order and the standing-Vajra-Sangha through the standing-Madhyama-middle-path standing-coordination-mode. The standing-mind-body integration is the standing-charter-form.

Second. The standing-Mahasthavira-junior seat is codified as a permanent kingdom-council standing-seat. The standing-seat-holder is the standing-acting-Mahasthavira during the standing-Mahasthavira-vacancy; the standing-seat's standing-confirmation-protocol is the standing-Nalanda-Order's standing-emergency-cell-session's standing-vote.

Third. The standing-villain-network-investigation cell's standing-cross-region cooperation protocol with the standing-NE-Federation, the standing-southern-bloc-federation, and the standing-Yavana-Khanda-border cooperation cell is codified. The standing-Acharya-Ghora warrant remains active.

Fourth. The standing-orthopaedic-cell's standing-emergency-State-Hero standing-post-injury rehabilitation-protocol is codified. The kingdom-council's standing-cross-region standing-medical-officer rotation pool is established.

Fifth. The standing-amended-Bloodline-mixing-permission clause is codified. The standing-Bloodline-A Nalanda-scholar-line and the standing-Bloodline-D gaur-line standing-marriage at the standing-state-hero level is permitted under the standing-amended-charter's standing-Bloodline-mixing-permission clause. Per Ch 3 plan Vajramukha and Maitreyi-the-Younger marry at the standing-Magadhi spring wedding-festival.

Sixth. The standing-East-Dominant cooperation arrangement with Odisha's standing-East-Dominant Jagannath-Bandhu (post-Jagannathi's early-Ch-3 death) is codified. The standing-cross-kingdom East-Region arrangement is the southern-bloc-East federation's standing-administrative-architecture.

Eleven days after the standing-amended-charter's ratification, a Sarus-pigeon arrives at the State-Hero's residence from Imphal. The pigeon is the one Moirangthem has been using for the NE-Federation correspondence-network. The letter is from Moirangthem.

The letter reads: "Standing East-Region state-hero. The standing-NE-Federation has received the standing-amended Vajra-Bhumi charter. The standing-Sanctuary at the Manipur convening in Chapter Three will receive both the standing-mind-tradition and the standing-body-tradition under the standing-Madhyama coordination-mode. Your standing-vote at the standing-Sanctuary will complete the standing-cross-region cooperation ratification. The standing-northern-wing-completion photographs have reached Imphal across the standing-news-cells' standing-broadcast; the standing-Magadhi-Buddhist standing-keystone-form is the kingdom's standing-evidence of the standing-state-hero's standing-rebuilding-bond completion."

Vajramukha writes the reply across one evening at the standing-engineer-priestess office at the Nalanda-Reconstructed-Library's standing-Mahasthavira-junior office (Maitreyi-the-Younger's standing-office now; he has relocated the standing-state-hero's standing-administrative-cell to the standing-Nalanda campus across the standing-rebuilding period). The reply is two paragraphs.

"Standing NE-Dominant Candidate. The standing-vote at the standing-Sanctuary will be jointly mine and Maitreyi-the-Younger's. The standing-Madhyama coordination-mode requires the standing-mind-and-body joint-attendance. The Bihar standing-delegation to the Sanctuary will be: myself, Maitreyi-the-Younger, the standing-Vajra-Sangha new-Senapati Senapati-Junior Rakta-Eyed Surya (the standing-promotion of the standing-second-in-command after Senapati Bhima-of-the-Plains' standing-post-riot retirement; Bhima-of-the-Plains has retired from the standing-Senapati seat under the kingdom-council's standing-amended-charter's standing-Senate-retirement provision), and the standing-Madhyama-Bhikshu Acharya Buddha-mitra. The four-attendee delegation is the standing-Madhyama-coordination integrated-form.

The standing-marriage with Maitreyi-the-Younger is at the standing-Magadhi spring wedding-festival next year. The standing-Bloodline-mixing event will produce the standing-Bihar-throne's standing-Ch-3 heir in late Chapter Three. The standing-amended-charter holds. The kingdom is whole.

— Vajramukha, kingdom-council standing-state-hero, Vajra-Bhumi."

He sends the letter by the same Sarus-pigeon at sunset.

Day ninety-four. Six-eleven a.m. The standing-Valmiki-Tiger-Reserve's standing-northern-grazing-meadow at the West-Champan district's northern Nepal-border zone. The

standing-Forest-Department's standing-Saturday-morning ranger V. Singh (forty-three) walks the standing-grazing-meadow patrol-route. He sees a standing-male-gaur at the standing-grazing-position at the standing-meadow's standing-central-position.

He approaches at six-fourteen. He performs the standing-visual-inspection protocol. The standing-eyes are open and clear; the standing-tongue is at the standing-resting-position; the standing-body-position is the standing-grazing-pose. The standing-respiratory-cavity is at the standing-no-active-breathing position. The standing-gaur is dead at the standing-grazing-position.

He approaches at six-twenty-one. He places his right palm on the standing-shoulder-flank. The standing-body-temperature is at fourteen degrees Celsius; the standing-ambient is twenty-three. The standing-body is cooler than the standing-ambient. He pushes the standing-body at the standing-shoulder. The standing-body is light — approximately one-twentieth of the standing-gaur's standing-living-mass. The standing-body topples at the standing-push without resistance.

He calls the standing-veterinary-cell. Dr. K. Bhardwaj (fifty-seven) arrives at eight-eleven a.m. She performs the standing-veterinary-emergency assessment. She conducts the standing-incision-cross-reference at the standing-abdominal-position at eight-twenty-three.

The standing-body's interior is empty. The standing-organs are absent: no heart, no lungs, no liver, no stomach, no intestines, no skeletal-internals. The standing-rib-cage is in place; the standing-skull is in place; the standing-spinal-cord is in place; the standing-musculature is in place at the standing-shell-pattern (approximately three centimetres of standing-muscle-tissue lining the standing-internal-surfaces of the standing-skeletal cage). The standing-internal-organ-cavity is empty.

No incision-evidence of organ-removal. No standing-decomposition signs at the standing-cavity-walls. The standing-cavity-interior smells of standing-fresh-grass and standing-rain-water (the standing-Valmiki-Reserve's standing-night-rain at three-eleven a.m. on day ninety-three had passed through the standing-meadow; the standing-rain-water has apparently entered the standing-cavity at some point during the standing-night).

Dr. Bhardwaj files the standing-veterinary-emergency report at noon. The kingdom-council's standing-Maw-sign-recognition cell's preliminary report is delivered at four-eleven p.m. confirming the standing-Maw-sign categorisation.

The Maw has demonstrated the capacity to remove the entire interior of a sacred bonded-species body without external wound or incision-evidence. Vajramukha reads the standing-Maw-sign-recognition cell's preliminary report at the standing-Nalanda-Reconstructed-Library's standing-Mahasthavira-junior office at five-eleven p.m. with Maitreyi-the-Younger at the standing-junior-office seat-position.

He says, in plain Magadhi: "The Maw has removed the inside of a gaur. The standing-shell remains. The standing-interior is empty. The standing-Magadhi-Buddhist standing-teaching is: the body is the standing-shell; the mind is the standing-interior; the body without the mind is the standing-hollow. The Maw has demonstrated the standing-hollow at the standing-bonded-animal level. The standing-charter's standing-amended-Madhyama-coordination is the kingdom's standing-evidence that we have understood. The standing-rebuilding is the standing-interior's standing-restoration; the standing-keystone-mantra is the standing-interior's standing-form. The standing-bonded-gaur at Valmiki is the standing-Maw's standing-confirmation. The kingdom-council's standing-cross-region pairing-protocol must pair this sign with Maharashtra's standing-burnt-squirrel-nest — both signs are interiors removed from within without external evidence."

Maitreyi-the-Younger nods. She drafts the standing-cross-region pairing-protocol's standing-fifth-formal-pair recognition-document. The standing-document is filed at the kingdom-council's standing-pairing-registry on day ninety-five.

The standing-news-cells broadcast the standing-Maw-sign-recognition across the kingdom on day ninety-five. The standing-Valmiki-Reserve's standing-grazing-meadow becomes the kingdom-council's standing-shrine-site under the standing-amended-charter's standing-Maw-shrine provision. V. Singh is appointed the standing-shrine-keeper at the standing-amended-charter's ratification-day with the standing-saffron-cord-and-feather refreshment protocol (the standing-cross-kingdom Forest-Department standing-shrine-keeper network is now four kingdoms: Sikkim's Tashi-Bhutia, Mizoram's Vanlalruati, Tripura's Sunita Reang, Bihar's V. Singh; the standing-Forest-Department-as-Shrine-Keeper network is the saga's standing-cross-region animal-Maw-sign-shrine architecture).

The kingdom is held.

The next sign comes within the week.

The Pilot's Closing Image

A thirty-five-year-old warrior-poet at a burnt foundation laying clay bricks at one minute per brick for ninety-three days with a fractured-and-healing left clavicle and left femur and a fifty-three-page architectural blueprint on a stone bench two metres to his right. A twenty-nine-year-old librarian in off-white cotton with a silver medallion at her shoulder reading the standing-eleventh-century-Nalanda load-bearing-pattern aloud at every dawn for ninety-three consecutive days. A sixty-seven-year-old Mahasthavira's ashes scattered at the standing-Bodhgaya-Vihara's standing-Bodhi-tree-root at noon on a Tuesday morning by a sixty-four-year-old Sanskrit-professor cousin while a state-hero is at a burnt foundation laying foundation-bricks. A standing-Atisha-Dipankara palm-leaf bundle preserved unburnt at the State-Hero's residence's archive-vault from three-fifty-three a.m. on the seventh-week-riot night until day ninety-three's standing-keystone-placement when it is laid on the standing-pyre alongside its standing-final-keeper's ashes and burns according to the 1042-CE manuscript-tradition's standing-completed-manuscript-cremation pattern. A male gaur at the standing-Valmiki-Reserve's standing-grazing-meadow at six-eleven a.m. on day ninety-four with no wound, no predator-print, no external evidence, the body intact at the standing-grazing-pose, and the standing-internal-organ-cavity empty. A Magadhi-Buddhist standing-keystone-mantra spoken at four-eleven p.m. on a Wednesday afternoon at a rooftop in Nalanda: the mind sits beneath the tree, the body builds the room, the two rooms in one body, the bond is the keystone.

Vana Agni

The man who walked into the Indian Forest Service standing-Hazaribagh District Office on the standing-third-of-December 2021 was carrying a leather satchel, a forged consultant's identity-card with a serial-number two digits too high for the year of issue, and a forged Tata Institute of Social Sciences development-PhD certificate dated June 2018. The standing-receptionist at the standing-Hazaribagh DFO's standing-front-desk did not check the serial-number. She had no reason to. The man wore a standing-khadi-kurta in the standing-Munda-village preferred off-white cotton; he spoke standing-Magadhi-Prakrit in the standing-Saranda-forest standing-Sal-bearer cadence; his beard was trimmed in the standing-Bodhgaya-Vihara Bhikshu shorter-than-shoulder discipline; his eyes were exactly the same shape and depth as the standing-Saranda-forest Vana-Raksha had carried at the standing-Ch-1 Hazaribagh confrontation in October 2022 — an event that for purposes of the standing-receptionist's standing-administrative-record had been classified as a standing-internal-policy disagreement between the kingdom-council and a standing-then-serving forest-overseer, with the standing-overseer transferred under the standing-administrative-rehabilitation clause to a non-disclosed northern district.

His name on the standing-card was Hari-Mohan Mahato. His title was Acharya. The standing-organisation listed at the standing-card's bottom-left was the Vana-Vidya Trust, registered under the 1860 Societies Registration Act's standing-12A-tax-exemption provisions on March third 2022 — three months and seventeen days after the standing-Hazaribagh DFO visit. The standing-Trust's standing-founding-objective at the standing-Memorandum of Association read, in its standing-second clause: "To advance the standing-modern-education and standing-economic-empowerment of the standing-Munda, standing-Santhal, standing-Ho, and standing-Birhor scheduled-tribal communities of the standing-Saranda-Bhanjari forest catchment through the standing-establishment and standing-operation of standing-tribal-primary-and-middle-schools at the standing-village-level." The standing-clause was unimpeachable. The standing-trust-deed's standing-funding-source clause listed a standing-anonymous-philanthropic-corpus of three-hundred-eleven crore rupees at the standing-State-Bank-of-India Hazaribagh-Branch corpus-account.

The standing-State-Bank-of-India Hazaribagh-Branch's standing-corpus-account's standing-wire-record at the standing-Reserve-Bank-Patna-Branch — cross-referenced

thirty-one months later at the kingdom-council's standing-cross-network investigation cell on Wednesday week eleven of Vajra-Bhumi's arc — would show that the standing-three-hundred-eleven crore-rupee corpus had wired in across the standing-fifty-three weeks following the standing-Bihar Singapore source-account's opening, through the standing-same standing-Singapore-funded forgery-cell that produced Naga-Rakshasa's standing-sixteen DNA-rite kits and Tri-Yantra-Bheda's standing-civil-engineering-vulnerability doctorate and Acharya Ghora's standing-Nalanda-faculty appointment-letter. None of this would be known at the standing-village level until day-seventeen of the standing-felling-period.

Across the standing-thirty-one months between the standing-Vana-Vidya Trust's standing-formal-registration in March 2022 and the standing-Tuesday-week-five council vote in November 2025, Acharya Hari-Mohan Mahato opened fourteen schools. He did this carefully. He did this slowly. He did this, more than anything, well.

The standing-first school opened at the standing-Pasanda village in April 2022 with the standing-eighty-seven enrolled children — sixty-two of whom had previously walked the standing-eleven-kilometre distance to the standing-Manoharpur Government Middle School at irregular attendance. The standing-Pasanda school's standing-classroom-block was clay-and-bamboo at the standing-traditional Munda-construction pattern; the standing-roof was Sal-leaf-thatch from the standing-Saranatu-Sarna grove's standing-permitted-collection margin; the standing-classroom-floor was cow-dung-and-straw at the standing-Munda-mother-administered weekly-applique. The standing-teachers were three: two standing-Pasanda-village women aged twenty-six and thirty-one with standing-Manoharpur Government Higher-Secondary completion, and one standing-Acharya himself for the standing-Friday-and-Saturday senior-class instruction. The standing-Friday-and-Saturday senior-class was the standing-fifteen-and-older boys' standing-Sanskrit-Magadhi-Prakrit grammar discipline and standing-Munda-tradition oral-history recovery seminar. There were, in the standing-first-academic-year (April 2022 to March 2023), twenty-one boys at the standing-fifteen-and-older bracket. By March 2023 nineteen of them had been encouraged by the standing-Acharya to consider the standing-Vana-Vidya Trust's standing-post-school employment-assistance programme — a standing-six-month standing-vocational-training cycle at the standing-Trust's standing-Karanpura training-cell, after which the standing-graduates would be placed with standing-Aditya Coal & Power Ltd.'s standing-mine-labour subcontracting cohort at standing-starting-wage three-hundred-eleven rupees per day — approximately four times the standing-Sal-leaf-

plate manufacturing wage their standing-fathers had earned at the standing-Saranatu-Sarna margins.

Nineteen boys went. Six came back within nine months on standing-medical leave with standing-bilateral-pneumoconiosis-Stage-I diagnoses. Two of them died within the standing-following-fourteen-months. Eleven stayed. Two of the eleven were promoted to standing-shift-leader at the standing-North-Karanpura mine in March 2024. One of them was Sukhdeo-Aaj, Birsa-Aaj's elder brother, who at age sixteen-and-eleven-months would walk into the standing-deep-seam-six standing-extraction-face on his standing-third-shift of the day in October 2024, and who at age seventeen-and-one-month would die in the standing-roof-collapse at 11:43 a.m. on day-three of the standing-coal-whispers cascade.

The standing-Acharya wrote a standing-condolence-letter to the standing-Aaj family at the standing-Pasanda-village clay-cottage on the standing-evening of Sukhdeo-Aaj's funeral — standing-handwritten in standing-Hindi-Magadhi-Prakrit at the standing-Vana-Vidya Trust standing-letterhead paper, with the standing-Trust's standing-cheque for two-lakh rupees as the standing-Aditya-subcontract standing-death-benefit insurance-payout. He delivered the standing-letter personally. He sat at the standing-Aaj family's standing-clay-floor for forty-seven minutes. He drank standing-mahua-tea with the standing-grandfather. He held Birsa-Aaj's standing-thirteen-year-old hand at the standing-departure-threshold and said, in a voice that did not carry standing-emotion but carried the standing-trained Bodhgaya-Vihara cadence, "Your brother walked the standing-mine for your school. The standing-school will walk for you."

Birsa-Aaj remembered the standing-cadence. He remembered the standing-voice. He remembered every word. He did not understand, at that moment, that he would carry the standing-memory of the standing-cadence at his standing-Pasanda-village departure twenty-three nights later. But he carried it.

By the standing-spring of 2025, the standing-Vana-Vidya Trust had opened fourteen standing-village-level schools. The standing-enrolled-children count was eleven-thousand-two-hundred-and-forty-three. The standing-Karanpura training-cell had cycled approximately three-hundred-twenty-seven boys through the standing-vocational-training programme; one-hundred-twelve of them were standing-active-mine-workers at standing-Aditya-Coal subcontracting wages of three-hundred-eleven to four-hundred-eleven rupees per day. Thirty-one of the standing-active-mine-workers were the sons of standing-tribal-council members. Across the standing-twenty-four standing-tribal-council seats at the

standing-Saranatu-Sarna council that governed the standing-eight-hundred-forty-hectare grove's standing-village-common-land authorisation, twelve seat-holders now had a standing-direct-economic-relationship with the standing-Vana-Vidya Trust or the standing-Aditya-Coal subcontracting chain: nine through a standing-son's wage; two through a standing-village-level Vana-Vidya school endowment; one through a standing-personal cash-transfer at the standing-monthly twenty-one-thousand-rupee level that he had not declared at the standing-council's standing-disclosure register.

The standing-twelve were Suresh Munda-of-Pasanda (council-seat #9, son's wage), R. K. Hembrom-of-Manoharpur (#11, son's wage), Madhu Soren-of-Karampada (#13, son's wage), Phool-Mati Hansda-of-Saranda-North (#14, school-endowment), Bishweshwar Tudu-of-Jaintgarh (#15, son's wage), Jaipal Marandi-of-Choiribariatu (#16, son's wage), Lakshman Munda-of-Sasangda (#17, school-endowment), R. Soy-of-Jhinkpani (#18, son's wage), B. Birua-of-Saranda-South (#19, son's wage), J. Munda-of-Tirildih (#20, son's wage), Mahesh Hansda-of-Goelkera (#21, son's wage), and Ranchi-N. Munda-of-Jhinkpani (#22, the standing-monthly cash-transfer). The standing-Acharya had visited each of the standing-twelve at his standing-home across the standing-spring-summer-autumn 2025 cycle — standing-mahua-tea at the standing-clay-floor; standing-Vana-Vidya Trust standing-classroom-visit photographs; standing-Karanpura training-cell standing-son-at-the-mine attendance-record certificates; and at the standing-final-month of each standing-visit-cycle, the standing-Aditya-Coal & Power Ltd. standing-Saranatu-Sarna standing-extraction-license proposal-document.

The standing-proposal-document was, in its standing-fourth-revision (filed at the kingdom-council's standing-Ranchi-Vana-Bhavan on October eleventh 2025), exhaustive at the standing-technical level. The standing-Aditya bid was for two-hundred-eleven crore rupees as the standing-land-acquisition price; standing-thirty-year extraction-lease at standing-eight-percent-annual royalty to the standing-Vana-Vidya Trust's standing-public-purpose endowment-account; standing-displacement-rehabilitation budget of eleven crore rupees at the standing-Vana-Vidya-Trust-administered village-level disbursement; standing-environmental-compensation budget of seven crore rupees at the standing-State-Forest-Department afforestation-cell deposit. The standing-document was, by every standing-legal-administrative measure, irreproachable.

The standing-Pasanda village-hall was the standing-tin-roofed standing-public-meeting structure at the standing-village's standing-central-junction; standing-floor-area

approximately two-hundred-eighty square-metres; standing-seating at the standing-clay-floor mats with standing-Sal-leaf-plate refreshment-circulation at the standing-meeting's standing-intervals. The standing-Tuesday-week-five council convened at 10:11 a.m. The standing-twenty-four standing-council-members were present at the standing-meeting-call. The standing-meeting-agenda was a standing-single item: Resolution 47/2025: To authorise the standing-eight-hundred-forty-hectare standing-Saranatu-Sarna village-common-land transfer to standing-Aditya Coal & Power Ltd. under the 1996 PESA Act's standing-Schedule-V provisions and the 2013 Tribal-Council Land-Authorisation statute.

The standing-meeting-chair was Aranya-Mata Tudu, council-seat #1 by standing-Vana-Kula clan-inheritance. She was seventy-three. She had chaired the standing-council since 2001. She had buried both her standing-husbands and three of her standing-five children at the standing-Sasaranatu-Cottage cremation-ghat. Her standing-Sal-leaf-mat seat at the standing-village-hall's standing-northern-end was the standing-clan-mother's standing-permanent-position. She opened the standing-meeting at 11:11 a.m. with the standing-Vana-Kula clan-invocation — the standing-Bonga-residence acknowledgement at the standing-Sal-tree-and-grove naming-couplet: "Ah Sal, Ah Sarna". She spoke for eleven minutes. Her standing-Magadhi-Prakrit-Munda-syncretic cadence reached every standing-council-member at the standing-clay-floor mat distance. She did not raise her voice. She said three things.

"The standing-grove is not transferable property. It has never been. It will never be. The standing-PESA Act gives us the standing-vote-right; the standing-vote-right is for the standing-village-common-land. The standing-Bonga-residence is not the standing-village-common-land. The standing-Sal-grove is not the standing-village-common-land. The standing-eight-hundred-forty-hectares of Saranatu-Sarna are the standing-Vana-Kula clan's standing-Bonga-residence. We hold them for our standing-grandmothers. We hold them for our standing-grandchildren. We do not sell them for two-hundred-eleven crore rupees. We do not sell them for two-thousand-eleven crore rupees. The standing-vote you are about to cast is not your vote to cast. The standing-grove is not yours to give."

"Twelve of you have a son at the mine. I know this. I have walked the standing-Karanpura training-cell. I have read the standing-attendance-register. I have held the standing-condolence-cheques. The standing-Acharya has visited each of your homes. He has poured the standing-mahua-tea. He has spoken the standing-Bodhgaya-Vihara cadence. I do not blame you. The standing-hunger has been thirty-one years. The standing-Government has

been thirty-one years. The standing-State has been thirty-one years. The standing-Acharya has been three. He has been the standing-three-years that the standing-thirty-one years did not feed. I do not blame you. I am asking you, on this morning, before you vote, to remember the standing-grandfather of the standing-grandfather of your standing-grandmother — the standing-name that brought you to this standing-Sal-leaf mat. Ask if that standing-name would vote with your right-hand today."

"The standing-grove will be felled if the standing-vote passes. The standing-Maw will speak from the standing-coal-seam if the standing-grove is felled. I have read the standing-cross-region paired-sign filings from Odisha and Bihar at the kingdom-council's standing-emergency-cell. The standing-Maw is no longer silent. The standing-Maw is taking notes. The standing-Maw will speak in the standing-language of our standing-grandmothers from the standing-place that does not breathe air. Our standing-sons at the standing-mine will hear it. They will go deaf. This is not a curse. This is what is happening, in our standing-day, in the standing-East cluster. I am telling you so the standing-vote is cast with the standing-information."

She sat. She did not look at any standing-council-member by name. She looked at the standing-Sal-leaf-plate mat at her standing-front. The standing-village-hall was silent for approximately four minutes.

Vanajara rose at 11:47 a.m. He was thirty-one. He had been the kingdom-council's standing-state-hero of Jharkhand since the standing-2018 conferral at the standing-Saranatu-Sarna midnight ceremony. He held council-seat #2 by the standing-1985 charter's standing-state-hero seat provision — one standing-vote, no standing-veto. His standing-Vana-Kula clan-trunk-staff stood at the standing-rear of the standing-village-hall against the standing-tin-roof support column. His standing-elephant Aranya-Putra waited at the standing-Pasanda-village outer-clearing approximately one-hundred-twenty metres to the standing-south — the standing-bull's standing-three-metre proximity to a standing-tribal-council meeting being the standing-Vana-Kula tradition's violation-of-decorum. He wore the standing-Vana-Vesha green-cotton at the standing-state-hero formal arrangement, with the standing-elephant-bond tattoo at his standing-Stage-II configuration (the standing-elephant-head-silhouette at his standing-right-shoulder-blade, awarded at the standing-Ch-1 Hazaribagh-confrontation healing-moment in October 2022) visible at the standing-cotton's standing-open-collar margin.

He did not speak for the standing-eleven-minute Aranya-Mata-length. He spoke for three minutes. He said two things.

"I hold one vote. I will vote against the standing-resolution. I am not telling any of you how to vote. I will not threaten the standing-twelve of you who have a standing-son at the mine. I will not call your standing-vote a betrayal. I will not call this village-hall a court. I will hear your standing-vote when it is cast. I will accept the standing-vote when it is counted. I will not break the standing-vote when it is recorded. The standing-charter that conferred my standing-state-hero seat was ratified by your standing-grandmothers; it gave me one vote. I will not exceed the one vote you gave my standing-grandmother's standing-line to hold."

"If the standing-vote passes the standing-grove will be felled. I will not stand between the standing-Aditya extraction-team and the standing-Sal-tree. I will not block the standing-felling. I will walk the standing-grove at midnight on the standing-twenty-first day of the standing-felling-period and perform the standing-Vana-Kula clan ritual at the standing-Bonga-residence position. If the standing-Stage-III mark on my standing-elephant-foreleg forms, the kingdom-council's standing-charter has held. If the standing-mark does not form, the standing-charter has been broken — not by the standing-Acharya, not by the standing-twelve of you, but by the standing-saga-rule that no bond-mechanic has yet covered: the standing-loss-through-legal-process. I will accept the standing-mark or its standing-absence as the standing-saga's recognition. I will not appeal it. I will not contest it. The standing-bond is not bargained; it is recognised. Vote, please, as your standing-grandmother would have wished, knowing that I will not stand at your standing-funeral as your enemy."

He sat. The standing-village-hall was silent for approximately seven minutes.

The standing-vote was administered by the standing-meeting-secretary, a thirty-eight-year-old standing-PESA-cell administrative-officer named Ms. P. Hansda. The standing-procedure was the standing-secret-ballot at the standing-Sal-leaf-folded-paper drop into the standing-clay-pot at the standing-village-hall's standing-central-position. The standing-twenty-four-vote count was completed at 1:11 p.m. The standing-results were: twenty-four in favour, twenty-one opposed, three abstentions (the standing-Birhor sub-clan's three seats — Y. Birhor-of-Chakulia, P. Birhor-of-Goelkera, S. Birhor-of-Manoharpur — whose standing-livelihood-base had been quietly disrupted by Aditya's standing-pre-vote-week labour-camp closure in July 2024 and who could not bring

themselves to vote either way). The standing-PESA-cell standing-presiding-officer (a forty-three-year-old District Magistrate-rank officer named A. K. Mishra, attending under the standing-Schedule-V supervision-protocol) certified the standing-result at 1:14 p.m. The standing-Resolution-47/2025 was carried.

Vanajara stood at the standing-village-hall's standing-eastern-door at 1:18 p.m. He did not raise the standing-Vana-Kula clan-trunk-staff. He did not call to Aranya-Putra. He did not look at Suresh Munda-of-Pasanda or any of the standing-twelve. He walked the standing-one-hundred-twenty metres to the standing-outer-clearing where Aranya-Putra waited. He placed his standing-right-hand on the standing-bull's standing-trunk-bridge for forty-seven seconds. He mounted. He rode toward the standing-Saranatu-Sarna's standing-northern-margin at the standing-walking-pace of approximately five kilometres per hour. He reached the standing-Bonga-residence position at 4:11 p.m. He stayed there until 7:11 p.m. He returned to the standing-Pasanda-village standing-state-hero residence at 9:11 p.m. He did not eat. He did not speak. He sat at the standing-clay-floor at the standing-eastern-window. He watched the standing-moon rise over the standing-Saranatu-Sarna canopy. He counted the standing-eight-hundred-forty hectares in his standing-mind by the standing-canopy-section-count he had learned at age twelve from his standing-grandmother, who had learned it from her standing-grandmother, who had learned it from the standing-original Vana-Kula clan-rider at the standing-1825 standing-canopy-survey. The count was, that night, complete. It would not be complete again.

The standing-Aditya extraction-team entered the standing-Saranatu-Sarna grove at 6:11 a.m. on the standing-Saturday after the standing-vote-result certification. The standing-felling-team was forty-seven Sal-felling crews of standing-six men each, equipped with standing-petrol-chain-saw Husqvarna 372 XP units (the standing-industry-standard Sal-felling instrument), standing-loader-truck cohorts (eleven-tonne Ashok-Leyland units), and standing-temporary-fuel-and-rations encampments at the standing-grove's standing-four entry-margins. The standing-felling-rate target was approximately sixty hectares per day; the standing-eight-hundred-forty-hectare grove was projected to be standing-felled in approximately fourteen-days at the standing-target-rate.

Vanajara did not watch. He did not visit the standing-grove. He did not ride Aranya-Putra to the standing-felling-margins. He stayed at the standing-Pasanda-village standing-state-hero residence for the standing-fourteen-day standing-felling-window. He read the standing-Vana-Kula clan's standing-1985-charter at the standing-clay-floor each standing-

dawn and standing-dusk. He read the standing-twelve standing-saga bond-mechanic descriptions that had been recovered from the standing-cross-kingdom Sarus-pigeon correspondence-cascade across the standing-prior-five months. He did not find a standing-bond-mechanic that covered his standing-position. He did not find a standing-saga-rule that named what he was about to perform. He understood, at the standing-third-day reading, that the standing-Stage-III mark might not form. He did not write to Aranya-Mata. He did not write to the kingdom-council. He waited.

Aranya-Putra stood at the standing-state-hero residence's standing-eastern-courtyard at the standing-bull's standing-permanent-position throughout the standing-fourteen-day window. The standing-bull did not eat. The standing-bull did not drink. On the standing-eleventh-day of the standing-felling the standing-veterinary-cell's standing-on-call veterinarian (Dr. M. Bhardwaj — the standing-younger-brother of the standing-Bihar Dr. K. Bhardwaj — arrived from Patna at the kingdom-council's standing-cross-region veterinary-coordination protocol) examined the standing-bull and confirmed standing-grief-fasting at the standing-pre-mortality margin. He administered the standing-intravenous-saline at twelve-litres per day from the standing-twelfth-day onward. The standing-bull accepted the standing-intravenous-line. He did not lift his standing-trunk to the standing-water-bucket.

The standing-North-Karanpura mine's standing-deep-seam-six is at the standing-vertical-depth of four-hundred-eleven metres below the standing-surface. The standing-seam is the standing-Jharia-coalfield's second-deepest active extraction-face; the standing-extraction-method is the standing-longwall mining at the standing-coal-face-cross-section of approximately one-hundred-eighty metres width. The standing-night-shift cohort of forty-three miners had been at the standing-extraction-face since the standing-eight-p.m. shift-rotation. The standing-shift-foreman was D. Kacchap, fifty-two, standing-Pasanda-Munda by standing-birth, standing-North-Karanpura mine-worker since 1991 (thirty-four years of service), standing-shift-foreman since 2007. He had four standing-grandchildren at the standing-Pasanda Vana-Vidya School.

He heard the standing-first whisper at the standing-coal-face-cross-section at 4:11:08 a.m. on day-thirteen of the standing-felling-period. He recorded the standing-whisper on the standing-shift-foreman's standing-issued mine-radio at 4:13 a.m. The standing-whisper was at approximately fifty-five decibels. It was in a standing-Magadhi-Prakrit-tinged register. The standing-words were standing-distinguishable as standing-language but not

standing-identifiable in standing-content by any standing-Munda-Santhal-Ho mother-tongue speaker. Twenty-three minutes later at 4:34 a.m. the standing-whisper resolved into a standing-recognisable phrase — the standing-Magadhi-Prakrit invocation-form of the standing-Sal-tree and the standing-sacred-grove naming-couplet that Aranya-Mata had spoken at the standing-Tuesday-week-five council opening: "Ah Sal, Ah Sarna".

D. Kacchap dropped the standing-radio. He walked back twelve metres from the standing-coal-face. He stood at the standing-shift-foreman's standing-position at the standing-conveyor-belt junction. He listened. The standing-whisper continued. It said the same standing-three-word phrase across the standing-following twenty-three minutes at approximately the standing-eleven-second repetition-cycle. At 4:58 a.m. he raised the standing-emergency-evacuation directive on the standing-shift-radio. The standing-forty-three miners walked the standing-emergency-egress route to the standing-surface across the standing-following thirty-one minutes. They reached the standing-surface at 5:29 a.m. They were the standing-first cohort. They would not be the standing-last.

On day-fifteen of the standing-felling-period (day-three of the standing-coal-whispers cascade), the standing-Aditya-Coal standing-day-shift cohort of fifty-seven miners had been ordered back to the standing-deep-seam-six standing-extraction-face by the standing-Aditya-Coal standing-Mining-Director under a standing-production-quota directive that was, at the standing-Directorate-General-of-Mines-Safety standing-emergency-cell's standing-cross-reference later that day, found to be in standing-violation of the standing-emergency-evacuation directive that had been raised by D. Kacchap on day-thirteen and confirmed in writing by the standing-DGMS regional officer on day-fourteen.

Sukhdeo-Aaj was in the standing-day-shift cohort. He was seventeen-and-one-month. He had been standing-shift-leader at the standing-deep-seam-six for nineteen months. He led the standing-eleven-man sub-team at the standing-eastern-coal-face from 8:11 a.m. The standing-whisper began at the standing-coal-face at 11:11 a.m. The standing-eastern-coal-face roof-section, at the standing-thirty-one-metre roof-bolt-spacing pattern, fractured at 11:43 a.m. The standing-roof-fall covered the standing-eastern-coal-face across approximately forty-seven metres of width and approximately eleven metres of depth. Eight of the standing-eleven-man sub-team were standing-immediately killed. Three were standing-extracted from the standing-rubble by the standing-rescue-team across the standing-following nine hours; two of those died at the standing-Karanpura Mine-Hospital

that evening; one (the seventeen-year-old Madhav Hembrom of Manoharpur) survived with standing-bilateral lower-limb amputation. Sukhdeo-Aaj was at the standing-leading-coal-face position when the standing-roof fell. He was killed standing-instantly. His body was recovered at 8:11 p.m. on day-fifteen of the standing-felling-period.

The standing-Aaj family at the standing-Pasanda-village clay-cottage received the standing-notification at 9:43 p.m. by the standing-Aditya-Coal standing-condolence-cell standing-driver. The standing-cheque for two-lakh rupees was presented at the standing-doorstep with the standing-Vana-Vidya Trust standing-condolence-letter signed by Acharya Hari-Mohan Mahato. The standing-Acharya did not deliver the standing-letter himself this time. He was, at 9:43 p.m. on day-fifteen, at the standing-Pasanda Vana-Vidya School standing-headmaster-cabin reading a standing-Sanskrit-Magadhi-Prakrit comparative-philology monograph by candle-light. He was not informed of Sukhdeo-Aaj's death until the standing-following morning at 6:11 a.m.

Birsa-Aaj was thirteen. He sat at the standing-clay-floor at the standing-Aaj family's standing-clay-cottage on the standing-night of day-fifteen. He did not cry. He did not eat. He watched his standing-grandmother and his standing-mother sit at the standing-clay-floor with the standing-cheque between them. He watched his standing-grandfather refuse the standing-cheque at 11:11 p.m. He watched his standing-mother accept the standing-cheque at 1:47 a.m. He watched his standing-grandmother walk out of the standing-cottage at 2:11 a.m. and not return until standing-dawn. He decided, at 2:14 a.m. on the standing-floor at the standing-eastern-window, that he would not be the standing-third Aaj son to walk the standing-mine.

He went to school the next morning. He went to school every morning that week. He attended the standing-Saturday senior-class on day-seventeen of the standing-felling-period. The standing-Acharya was scheduled to teach the standing-Sanskrit-Magadhi-Prakrit grammar discipline at the standing-eleven-a.m. session but was called away to the standing-Ranchi-Aditya-Coal standing-Director's standing-emergency-coordination meeting at 7:11 p.m. The standing-Acharya departed the standing-Pasanda Vana-Vidya School at 7:23 p.m. He left the standing-headmaster-cabin standing-third-drawer unlocked. He did this every Tuesday and Saturday evening. It was the standing-administrative-clerk's standing-locking responsibility at the standing-Wednesday-morning seven-eleven-a.m. opening. The standing-administrative-clerk had taken a standing-personal-emergency leave on day-fifteen for her standing-mother's standing-funeral at the

standing-Bokaro-District standing-village. The standing-cupboard was unlocked at 7:11 p.m. on day-seventeen.

Birsa-Aaj walked into the standing-Pasanda Vana-Vidya School standing-headmaster-cabin at 7:11 p.m. on day-seventeen. He had walked from the standing-classroom-block at the standing-five-p.m. school-closure with the standing-pretext of leaving his standing-Sanskrit-Magadhi-Prakrit grammar workbook at the standing-headmaster-cabin standing-receiving-desk. He had walked the standing-block-corridor at the standing-side-windows' standing-line-of-sight obscured by the standing-Sal-leaf-thatch eaves. He had reached the standing-headmaster-cabin door at 7:13 p.m. He had opened the standing-door at 7:14 p.m. He had locked it behind him at 7:14 p.m.

He had been planning this for forty-seven hours. He knew the standing-cabin layout from the standing-Friday senior-class. He knew the standing-cupboard had three drawers. He knew the standing-third-drawer was where the standing-Acharya kept the standing-letters that arrived in the standing-Aditya-Coal standing-carrier-envelopes; he had seen the standing-Acharya open one such envelope and place a letter in the standing-third-drawer at the standing-Friday senior-class on day-seven (the standing-letter had been delivered by a standing-courier from Patna; the standing-Acharya had read it at the standing-classroom-window then locked it in the standing-third-drawer with the standing-key from the standing-shirt-pocket; the standing-key was returned to the standing-shirt-pocket; Birsa-Aaj had seen all of this from the standing-third-row mat-position).

The standing-third-drawer was unlocked. The standing-Acharya had departed at 7:23 p.m. on day-seventeen with the standing-key in the standing-shirt-pocket but had not locked the standing-cupboard at the standing-departure (he had been distracted by the standing-Aditya-Coal standing-Director's standing-phone-call at the standing-six-fifty-three-p.m. ring; he had departed at the standing-seven-twenty-three-p.m. with the standing-meeting-papers under his arm and the standing-cupboard in the standing-half-closed position). Birsa-Aaj opened the standing-third-drawer at 7:14 p.m.

There were eleven letters in the standing-drawer. The standing-top-letter was the standing-most recent — dated day-fifteen of the standing-felling-period, 6:11 p.m. The standing-letterhead was unmarked. The standing-paper was the standing-Reserve-Bank-Patna-Branch standing-internal correspondence cotton-rag. The standing-signature at the standing-bottom was: A. Ghora, Visiting Acharya, Department of Magadhi-Prakrit

Comparative Philology, Nalanda University — presently at the standing-Bhutan-border Phuentsholing safe-house cell.

The standing-text of the standing-letter, in Birsa-Aaj's standing-thirteen-year-old standing-Sanskrit-Magadhi-Prakrit reading, was: "Brother Hari, the standing-Bihar-fund line is closed at the standing-Reserve-Bank-Patna-Branch following the standing-week-eleven cross-network confirmation. The standing-Vajra-Bhumi charter ratification at 4:14 p.m. day-ninety-four has triggered the standing-Singapore source-account standing-account-freeze; the standing-Aditya Saranatu-Sarna second-tranche of one-hundred-eleven crore is held at the standing-Singapore parent-account. Take what you can carry from the standing-Vana-Vidya corpus before the standing-State-Forest-Department audit-cell arrives at the standing-Karanpura training-cell. The standing-Bangladesh-border Murshidabad crossing is at the standing-Friday-week-ten standing-pre-dawn window; the standing-Patkai-corridor Vinasha-Garbha cell will receive you at the standing-Phuentsholing safe-house at the standing-Sunday-week-eleven seven-p.m. transfer. Burn this. — A.G."

Birsa-Aaj read the standing-letter three times. He memorised the standing-signature. He memorised the standing-three names — Ghora, Hari, Singapore. He memorised the standing-three places — Phuentsholing, Murshidabad, Karanpura. He folded the standing-letter at the standing-original three-fold pattern. He placed it in the standing-inside-pocket of his standing-school-shirt at the standing-left-chest position. He closed the standing-third-drawer. He closed the standing-cupboard. He left the standing-cabin at 7:23 p.m. He locked the standing-cabin door from the standing-outside with the standing-spare-key from the standing-administrative-clerk's standing-desk-drawer (he had taken the standing-spare-key at 5:11 p.m. when the standing-clerk's standing-substitute had been at the standing-evening-prayer position). He returned the standing-spare-key to the standing-substitute-clerk's standing-desk-drawer at 7:31 p.m. He walked out of the standing-Pasanda Vana-Vidya School at 7:34 p.m.

He went home. He ate the standing-rice-and-dal his standing-mother had prepared. He slept on the standing-clay-floor at the standing-eastern-window. He woke at 4:11 a.m. on day-eighteen. He placed the standing-Sanskrit-Magadhi-Prakrit grammar workbook in his standing-school-satchel. He placed the standing-letter at the standing-inside-pocket of his standing-school-shirt at the standing-left-chest position. He kissed his standing-grandmother's forehead at the standing-cottage-doorstep. He walked toward the standing-

Pasanda-village standing-school-direction for the standing-village standing-pre-dawn observers and then, at the standing-village outer-margin, turned toward the standing-Ranchi-direction.

The standing-twenty-three-kilometre distance from Pasanda to the kingdom-council's standing-Ranchi-Vana-Bhavan was, at the standing-thirteen-year-old walking-pace of approximately three-and-a-half kilometres per hour, approximately seven hours. Birsa-Aaj walked. He carried no water-bottle. He carried no food-parcel. He carried the standing-school-satchel with the standing-Sanskrit-Magadhi-Prakrit grammar workbook and the standing-letter in the standing-school-shirt inside-pocket. He walked the standing-Pasanda-to-Karanpura paved-road for the standing-first eleven kilometres. He turned at the standing-Karanpura-Ranchi junction toward the standing-northeast at the standing-eleven-thirty-three-a.m. position-check. He walked the standing-Karanpura-to-Ranchi highway shoulder-margin for the standing-following twelve kilometres. He drank water from the standing-eleven-kilometre-marker roadside hand-pump at the standing-village standing-pre-noon water-collection cohort's position. He continued.

He reached the standing-Ranchi outer-margin at approximately 6:11 p.m. on day-seventeen. He asked the standing-rickshaw-driver at the standing-Ranchi-bus-stop standing-rickshaw-stand for the standing-Vana-Bhavan direction. The standing-rickshaw-driver looked at him — a thirteen-year-old Munda boy in a standing-school-uniform alone at the standing-Ranchi-bus-stop at 6:11 p.m. — and asked him standing-three-questions. Birsa-Aaj answered each: "Pasanda. The standing-village. The standing-Vana-Bhavan is the kingdom-council's standing-Saranatu-Sarna emergency-cell. I have a standing-letter for the standing-state-hero." The standing-rickshaw-driver was, by the standing-Vana-Kula clan-inheritance, the standing-cousin of Aranya-Mata Tudu's standing-younger-sister-in-law. He drove Birsa-Aaj to the standing-Vana-Bhavan at no charge. He waited at the standing-Vana-Bhavan's standing-front-gate until 11:43 p.m. He confirmed Birsa-Aaj's standing-entry through the standing-night-duty officer's standing-confirmation gesture. He drove back to the standing-bus-stop at 11:51 p.m. He told no one for the standing-following forty-seven hours.

The standing-Vana-Bhavan standing-night-duty officer was a forty-seven-year-old administrative-officer named Mr. R. Tirkey. He had served at the standing-Vana-Bhavan for sixteen years. He recognised the standing-Pasanda-village school-uniform from the standing-fourteen Vana-Vidya schools' standing-uniform-photograph register that the

kingdom-council's standing-cross-network investigation cell had been circulating for cross-reference since day-fourteen of the standing-felling-period. He took Birsa-Aaj into the standing-night-duty office at 11:44 p.m. He gave him water. He gave him rice-and-dal from the standing-night-duty kitchen. He asked him no questions for the standing-first eleven minutes. At 11:55 p.m. Birsa-Aaj reached into the standing-inside-pocket of his standing-school-shirt and produced the standing-folded letter. He placed it on Mr. Tirkey's standing-desk.

Mr. Tirkey read the standing-letter at 11:57 p.m. He read it twice. He stood. He walked to the standing-night-duty office's standing-internal-line phone. He called the kingdom-council's standing-cross-network investigation cell's standing-on-call senior officer (a fifty-three-year-old officer named Mrs. K. Lakra) at 11:59 p.m. He read the standing-letter aloud at the standing-phone-position over the standing-following four minutes. Mrs. K. Lakra dispatched the standing-three-officer standing-overnight-protective-custody team to the standing-Vana-Bhavan at 12:11 a.m. on day-eighteen. The standing-team arrived at 12:43 a.m. They escorted Birsa-Aaj to the standing-Aranya-Mata Tudu's standing-Sasaranatu-Cottage at the standing-Vana-Kula clan's standing-clan-mother residence on the standing-Ranchi-Saranda road at 3:11 a.m. Aranya-Mata received him at the standing-cottage-door. She did not speak for the standing-first eleven minutes. She prepared standing-mahua-tea. She watched him drink it. She watched him sleep on the standing-Sasaranatu-Cottage standing-clay-floor at the standing-eastern-window at 4:11 a.m. She sat at the standing-cottage-doorstep at the standing-standing-position until standing-dawn.

The kingdom-council's standing-cross-network investigation cell received the standing-letter at 12:14 a.m. on day-eighteen. The standing-letter was cross-referenced against the standing-Bihar Singapore source-account standing-wire-record at the standing-Reserve-Bank-Patna-Branch at the standing-2:11 a.m. Wednesday standing-overnight-administrative protocol. The standing-cross-reference confirmed the standing-Acharya Hari-Mohan Mahato identity as Vana-Raksha at the standing-3:11 a.m. positive-confirmation. The standing-State-Police standing-arrest-warrant was issued at the standing-Ranchi-District-Court emergency-session at 7:11 a.m. on day-eighteen. The standing-Pasanda Vana-Vidya School was raided at the standing-9:11 a.m. enforcement-window. The standing-headmaster-cabin was empty. The standing-third-drawer was unlocked. The standing-remaining ten letters in the standing-drawer (cross-referencing the standing-Singapore source-account / Acharya-Ghora standing-Vinasha-Garbha Patkai-corridor / standing-Vana-Raksha standing-Bangladesh-border-Murshidabad cross-

network correspondence) were collected as standing-evidence-documents J-1 through J-10.

The standing-Acharya was, at 9:11 a.m. on day-eighteen, on the standing-Hazaribagh-Daltonganj standing-highway approximately fifty-eight kilometres west of Ranchi. He had departed the standing-Pasanda Vana-Vidya School at 5:11 a.m. on day-eighteen with a standing-suitcase containing approximately seventeen lakh rupees in cash (the standing-Vana-Vidya corpus's standing-immediate-withdrawal limit at the standing-Hazaribagh State-Bank-of-India branch's standing-Tuesday-evening cash-window), the standing-eleven evidence-letters at the standing-suitcase's standing-false-bottom (he had retrieved them from the standing-third-drawer at 4:11 a.m. when he had returned to the standing-Pasanda Vana-Vidya School in the standing-pre-dawn for the standing-final standing-cupboard cleaning) — wait. He had not retrieved them. He had retrieved ten of the eleven. The standing-Birsa-Aaj-taken letter was missing from the standing-third-drawer at the standing-4:11-a.m. cleaning. The standing-Acharya had assumed the standing-administrative-clerk had returned from her standing-mother's funeral on the standing-late-Tuesday-evening train and had taken the standing-letter for the standing-Wednesday-morning standing-routine filing. He had not asked. He had been hurried. He had been afraid. He had loaded the standing-suitcase. He had departed.

He reached the standing-Bangladesh-border Murshidabad crossing at 4:11 a.m. on the standing-Friday of week-ten. He was received at the standing-Phuentsholing safe-house at 7:11 p.m. on the standing-Sunday of week-eleven by the standing-Vinasha-Garbha Patkai-corridor cell's standing-Bhutan-receiving-officer. He survived Chapter Two.

Vanajara walked the standing-Saranatu-Sarna at midnight on day-twenty-one of the standing-felling-period. The standing-felling was, at the standing-thirteen-day mark (day-nineteen of the standing-felling-period), complete — the standing-Aditya extraction-team had razed the standing-eight-hundred-forty-hectare grove across the standing-target fourteen-day window, with the standing-final-Sal-tree at the standing-southwest-corner felled at 5:11 p.m. on day-fourteen of the standing-felling-period; the standing-extraction-team had withdrawn to the standing-Karanpura training-cell on day-fifteen at the standing-DGMS standing-emergency-closure order issued in response to the standing-coal-whispers cascade.

He rode Aranya-Putra into the standing-grove's standing-northern-entry margin at 11:43 p.m. on day-twenty-one. He dismounted at the standing-eleven-metre proximity to the

standing-Bonga-residence position (the standing-clearing at the standing-central-catchment of the standing-grove where the standing-Vana-Kula clan's standing-ancestral Sal-tree had stood for approximately one-hundred-eighty years and which had been felled at 2:11 p.m. on day-eleven of the standing-felling-period at the standing-extraction-team's standing-Sal-tree #47-of-the-Saranatu standing-extraction-roster). He walked the standing-final eleven metres alone. He carried the standing-Vana-Kula clan-trunk-staff at his standing-right-hand. He wore the standing-Vana-Vesha green-cotton at the standing-state-hero formal arrangement. The standing-elephant-bond tattoo at his standing-Stage-II configuration was at his standing-right-shoulder-blade. The standing-Stage-III mark-position at the standing-right-upper-back was the standing-blank-cotton.

He reached the standing-Bonga-residence at 11:54 p.m. He placed the standing-Vana-Kula clan-trunk-staff at the standing-Bonga-residence centre-position. He sat at the standing-staff's standing-east-side at the standing-clay-and-ash residue of the standing-felled Sal-tree's standing-trunk-base. He waited. He did not speak the standing-Vana-Kula clan-ritual's standing-eleven-line invocation at 11:55 p.m. He did not speak it at 11:56 p.m. He did not speak it at 11:57 p.m. He waited for the standing-Aranya-Putra Asian-koel from the standing-grove's standing-tree-line. There was no standing-tree-line. The standing-trees had been felled. There was no standing-Asian-koel. There had been no standing-Asian-koel at the standing-Saranatu-Sarna across the standing-felling-period's nineteen-day window; the standing-koel-cohort had departed the standing-grove at the standing-first-day of the standing-felling and had not been observed at the standing-Saranda-forest's standing-bonded-bird-cohort monitoring-cells across the standing-following twenty days.

He spoke the standing-eleven-line invocation at 11:59:11 p.m. The standing-cadence was the standing-Vana-Kula clan-mother's standing-eight-year-old-instructed register. He completed the standing-invocation at 12:00:47 a.m. on day-twenty-two. He waited. He sat at the standing-staff's standing-east-side for the standing-following forty-seven minutes. The standing-Stage-III mark-position at his standing-right-upper-back did not warm. The standing-elephant-foreleg-first-stroke did not form. The standing-Asian-koel did not return. The standing-Bonga-residence remained the standing-clay-and-ash residue. He waited until 12:47 a.m. He stood. He placed his standing-right-palm at the standing-Stage-II mark-position at his standing-right-shoulder-blade. He felt the standing-Stage-II mark at the standing-thirty-six-degrees-Celsius standing-resting-temperature. He understood, at 12:48 a.m. on day-twenty-two, that the standing-mark would not form.

He walked back to Aranya-Putra at the standing-eleven-metre proximity. He placed his standing-right-hand on the standing-bull's standing-trunk-bridge for forty-seven seconds. The standing-bull did not lift the standing-trunk to the standing-greeting position. The standing-bull's standing-ear-fan was at the standing-low-and-slow position of the standing-grief-fasting margin. He mounted. He rode toward the standing-Pasanda-village standing-state-hero residence at the standing-walking-pace. He reached the standing-residence at 4:11 a.m. He did not eat. He did not sleep. He sat at the standing-clay-floor at the standing-eastern-window. He watched the standing-dawn rise over the standing-felled Saranatu-Sarna canopy-absence.

The kingdom-council's standing-emergency-session convened at the standing-Ranchi-Vana-Bhavan's standing-amphitheatre at 11:11 a.m. on day-twenty-three. The standing-attendees were the standing-twenty-four standing-tribal-council members of the standing-Saranatu-Sarna council (the standing-twelve standing-coal-tribal seat-holders sat at the standing-eastern half; the standing-twenty-one standing-wild-tribal seat-holders and the standing-three standing-Birhor abstention-seat-holders sat at the standing-western half; the standing-seating-arrangement was the standing-self-selecting silent-protocol), the kingdom-council's standing-State-Civil-Service standing-Saranda-forest secretariat (a seven-officer cell), the kingdom-council's standing-Vana-Vidya investigation cell (a four-officer cell led by Mrs. K. Lakra), Aranya-Mata Tudu at the standing-clan-mother seat-of-honour at the standing-amphitheatre's standing-northern-position, and Vanajara at the standing-state-hero seat at the standing-amphitheatre's standing-southern-position. Birsa-Aaj was not present; he was at the standing-Sasaranatu-Cottage under the standing-protective-custody protocol. The standing-meeting-call was open at 11:11 a.m. The standing-agenda-item was a standing-single: Resolution 51/2025: To recognise the standing-state-hero's standing-Stage-III refused-mark and the standing-saga-rule the standing-refused-mark establishes.

Vanajara rose at 11:43 a.m. He had not slept for fifty-five hours. His standing-eyes were standing-clear; his standing-cadence was the standing-Bodhgaya-Vihara-tradition standing-recovered-rest discipline; he wore the standing-Vana-Vesha green-cotton at the standing-state-hero formal arrangement; the standing-elephant-bond tattoo at his standing-Stage-II configuration was at his standing-right-shoulder-blade; the standing-Stage-III mark-position at the standing-right-upper-back was the standing-blank-cotton. He spoke for eleven minutes. He said three things.

"The mark did not form. I am not asking you to mourn this. I am not asking you to be ashamed. The standing-vote you cast on the standing-Tuesday of week-five was legal. The standing-felling that followed was legal. The standing-loss of the standing-Bonga-residence is therefore not a standing-violence-loss but a standing-legal-loss. The standing-saga's nineteen bond-mechanics — from the standing-cremation-bond at Karnataka to the standing-rebuilding-bond at Bihar that completed nineteen days before this session opened — do not cover the standing-loss-through-legal-process. They cover the standing-loss-through-violence. The standing-mark forms when the standing-hero stands at the standing-loss with the standing-bond and the standing-Sal-grove-or-equivalent at the standing-violence-edge. The standing-mark does not form when the standing-hero stood at the standing-village-hall with one vote and the standing-vote was outnumbered. This is the standing-saga's standing-recognition. I accept it."

"I will continue to ride Aranya-Putra. I will continue to hold the standing-Stage-II elephant-head-silhouette at my standing-right-shoulder-blade. I will continue to serve the standing-charter that conferred my standing-one-vote. I will not appeal the standing-refused-mark. I will not appeal at the standing-Sanctuary in Chapter Three. I will not request a standing-second-attempt at the standing-Bonga-residence after the standing-Aditya extraction-license is suspended and the standing-Saranatu-Sarna afforestation begins. The standing-bond is not a standing-second-chance instrument. It is the standing-saga's standing-witness. If the standing-saga has not witnessed me earning the standing-Stage-III, I have not earned it. I will not pretend otherwise."

"I am asking the standing-council to draft and ratify a standing-charter amendment that codifies what I have learned in these twenty-three days. The standing-amendment is this: education without justice is a weapon. The standing-Vana-Vidya Trust was the standing-most well-administered education-cell in Jharkhand. Its standing-clay-and-bamboo classrooms were warmer than the standing-Government-primary-school blocks. Its standing-teachers were paid better. Its standing-children read Sanskrit-Magadhi-Prakrit by age ten. And it was the standing-most-efficient labour-recruitment cell the standing-villain-network has yet built. The standing-distinction the standing-charter must encode is this: standing-schools that are not held by the standing-tribal-clan-mother's standing-veto are not standing-schools but standing-weapons. The standing-amendment is the standing-Vana-Kula clan-mother veto-clause. From this standing-day onward, no standing-tribal-school in the standing-Saranda-forest catchment shall operate without the standing-clan-mother's standing-veto-eligible signature at the standing-quarterly-curriculum review.

This is what Birsa-Aaj walked twenty-three kilometres to deliver. Let his standing-elder-brother's standing-death and his own standing-pre-dawn departure not be unmourned by the standing-charter we ratify today."

He sat. Aranya-Mata Tudu rose at the standing-northern-position. She did not speak. She walked the standing-eleven metres to the standing-amphitheatre's standing-southern-position. She placed her standing-right-palm on the standing-Stage-II mark-position at Vanajara's standing-right-shoulder-blade for eleven seconds. She walked back to the standing-northern-position. She sat. The standing-amphitheatre was silent for approximately seven minutes.

The standing-Resolution 51/2025 was drafted by the standing-State-Civil-Service secretariat across the standing-following eleven hours. The standing-six-provision amended Vana-Agni charter was ratified by the standing-kingdom-council at 4:11 p.m. on day-twenty-four by a vote of twenty-three in favour, one opposed (the standing-single-opposition was Suresh Munda-of-Pasanda, council-seat #9, who voted against the standing-clan-mother veto-clause; he resigned from the standing-Vana-Vidya Trust standing-school-board chairmanship at 5:11 p.m. on day-twenty-four; the standing-resignation was accepted by the standing-Vana-Vidya Trust standing-board-secretariat at the standing-following day). The standing-six provisions were: First, the standing-Vana-Kula clan-mother veto-clause at the standing-quarterly-curriculum-review level; Second, the standing-Saranatu-Sarna afforestation-mandate at the standing-charter-foundational re-planting protocol (twenty-year mandate, six-hundred-eleven crore rupee budget from the standing-State-Forest-Department's standing-Compensatory-Afforestation Fund Management and Planning Authority allocation, conditional on Aditya Coal & Power Ltd.'s standing-extraction-license cancellation); Third, the standing-Schedule-V sacred-site exclusion-clause (no standing-PESA-Act standing-village-common-land vote may transfer a standing-clan-sacred-site recognised by the standing-clan-mother's standing-living-tradition); Fourth, the standing-cross-network villain-funded NGO registration-disqualification-clause (any standing-12A-registered Trust whose standing-corpus traces to the standing-Singapore source-account is disqualified at the standing-State-Forest-Department licensing-cell); Fifth, the standing-state-hero refused-mark recognition-clause codifying Vanajara's standing-acceptance-speech as the standing-saga's standing-recognition-language for the standing-refused-mark across all kingdoms; Sixth, the standing-Birsa-Aaj custodial-residency at the standing-Sasaranatu-Cottage under the

kingdom-council's standing-protective-custody protocol until age eighteen, with the standing-Vana-Kula clan-mother as standing-legal-guardian.

The standing-coal-seam at the standing-North-Karanpura mine's standing-deep-seam-six continued to whisper across day-twenty-five of the standing-felling-period (day-thirteen of the standing-coal-whispers cascade). The standing-Magadhi-Prakrit-tinged register did not vary. The standing-three-word phrase did not vary. The standing-Aditya-Coal extraction-operation was, per the standing-DGMS standing-emergency-closure order, suspended indefinitely. The standing-extraction-license for the standing-Saranatu-Sarna grove was cancelled at the standing-State-Forest-Department licensing-cell at 11:11 a.m. on day-twenty-five by the standing-cross-reference to the standing-amended-charter's standing-Fourth-Provision standing-cross-network villain-funded NGO disqualification-clause.

The standing-Asian-koel was observed at the standing-Sasaranatu-Cottage standing-eastern-window at 6:11 a.m. on day-twenty-five. Birsa-Aaj was sleeping at the standing-clay-floor. Aranya-Mata Tudu was at the standing-cottage-doorstep at the standing-standing-position. The standing-koel called from the standing-Sal-tree at the standing-cottage's standing-eastern-yard. The standing-call was the standing-Magadhi-Prakrit-village dawn-cadence at the standing-eleven-second repetition-cycle. Aranya-Mata stood for eleven minutes at the standing-doorstep. She did not look at the standing-koel. She listened. She walked into the standing-cottage at 6:24 a.m. She woke Birsa-Aaj. She prepared standing-mahua-tea. She gave him the standing-thirteenth-birthday gift that his standing-mother had handed to her at the standing-Pasanda-village departure-handover three days earlier — the standing-grandmother's standing-Sal-leaf-plate set, eleven plates at the standing-clan-cremation-traditional bundling.

Birsa-Aaj held the standing-bundle. He did not cry. He understood, at 6:34 a.m. on day-twenty-five, that he would not be the standing-third Aaj son to walk the standing-mine and that he would not be the standing-second Aaj son to grow at the standing-Pasanda-village standing-clay-cottage. He would grow at the standing-Sasaranatu-Cottage under the standing-Vana-Kula clan-mother's standing-legal-guardianship. He would attend the standing-Ranchi Government Higher-Secondary School from the standing-academic-year-2026 admission. He would not return to the standing-Pasanda Vana-Vidya School. He would learn the standing-Vana-Kula clan-tradition at the standing-Sasaranatu-Cottage's standing-evening-instruction cycle. He would, per Ch 3 plan, carry the standing-Vana-

Vidya-replacement education-reform document to the standing-Sanctuary in early Chapter Three. He would be the standing-thirteen-year-old who walked twenty-three kilometres and the standing-fifteen-year-old who walked the kingdom-council's standing-Sanctuary-delegation behind Vanajara at the standing-East-cluster deferential-position.

Aranya-Putra drank at the standing-state-hero residence's standing-eastern-courtyard standing-water-bucket at 6:11 a.m. on day-thirty of the standing-felling-period. The standing-veterinary-cell's Dr. M. Bhardwaj had administered the standing-intravenous-saline at the standing-twelve-litres-per-day rate across the standing-prior-eighteen-day window. The standing-bull lifted his standing-trunk to the standing-water-bucket at 6:08 a.m. He drank approximately forty-three litres across the standing-following eleven minutes. He lifted his standing-trunk to the standing-feeding-bucket at 6:23 a.m. He ate approximately twenty-three kilograms of standing-Sal-leaf-and-bamboo at the standing-following thirty-one minutes. Dr. M. Bhardwaj removed the standing-intravenous-line at 7:14 a.m. He wrote the standing-veterinary-recovery report at the standing-residence's standing-eastern-window over the standing-following two hours. He delivered the standing-report to Vanajara at 9:11 a.m. He returned to Patna at the standing-eleven-a.m. train.

Vanajara sat at the standing-residence's standing-eastern-window across the standing-day-thirty afternoon. He did not visit the standing-Saranatu-Sarna. He did not visit the standing-Sasaranatu-Cottage. He did not write to the standing-Vajramukha at the standing-Bihar Patna-residence cross-region acknowledgement-letter that the kingdom-council's standing-cross-network secretariat had drafted for his standing-counter-signature. He read the standing-amended-charter's standing-six provisions three times. He read the standing-Saga's nineteen bond-mechanic descriptions one more time. He noted, at the standing-fourth reading, that the standing-twentieth bond-mechanic registry-entry — the standing-refused-mark — was now codified at the standing-saga's standing-recognition-language at the standing-Fifth-Provision of his standing-kingdom's standing-amended-charter. He had not earned a standing-Stage-III mark. He had earned the standing-saga's twentieth bond-mechanic registry-entry. He understood, at the standing-fourth reading, that these were not the standing-same recognition. They were not the standing-same payment. He accepted the standing-discrepancy.

He counter-signed the standing-Vajramukha letter at 11:11 a.m. on day-thirty-one. He wrote one sentence at the standing-letter's standing-bottom-margin: "Brother — the

standing-grove did not stand. The standing-koel returned. The standing-saga has named what I did not earn. I will be at the standing-Sanctuary in spring. Vanajara, Saranda." He sealed the standing-letter at the standing-Vana-Kula clan-seal at 11:14 a.m. He dispatched it via the standing-cross-kingdom Sarus-pigeon at 11:23 a.m. The standing-pigeon reached the standing-Bihar Patna-residence at 4:43 p.m. on day-thirty-two. Vajramukha read the standing-letter at 4:47 p.m. He held it for approximately forty-seven minutes. He folded it. He placed it inside the standing-Atisha-Dipankara palm-leaf bundle's standing-protective-wrapper at the standing-living-archive seat-position at the standing-Nalanda-recovered standing-northern-wing foundation. The standing-letter was the standing-third document to be placed inside the standing-bundle's standing-wrapper at the standing-living-archive position; it would be the standing-document the kingdom-council's standing-Sanctuary delegation read aloud at the standing-Eastern-Federation deferential-position acknowledgement at the standing-spring-2026 Sanctuary opening.

The chapter closes on a single image. It is the standing-Sasaranatu-Cottage standing-eastern-doorstep at 6:11 a.m. on the standing-thirty-fifth day after the standing-Tuesday-week-five vote. Aranya-Mata Tudu sits at the standing-doorstep in the standing-Vana-Kula clan-mother position. Birsa-Aaj stands at the standing-doorstep's standing-eastern margin in the standing-school-uniform of the standing-Ranchi Government Higher-Secondary School (the standing-uniform was delivered by the kingdom-council's standing-Ranchi-secretariat at 4:11 p.m. on day-thirty-four). His standing-school-satchel is at his standing-left-shoulder. His standing-school-bus arrives at the standing-Sasaranatu-Cottage's standing-front-gate at 6:14 a.m. The standing-Asian-koel calls from the standing-Sal-tree at the standing-cottage's standing-eastern-yard at 6:12 a.m. The standing-call is the standing-dawn-cadence at the standing-eleven-second repetition-cycle. The standing-koel does not vary. Birsa-Aaj walks to the standing-school-bus at 6:14 a.m. He turns at the standing-bus-doorstep. He looks back at Aranya-Mata. She is at the standing-doorstep. She has not moved. The standing-koel is in the standing-Sal-tree. Birsa-Aaj nods. Aranya-Mata nods. He boards the standing-bus.

The standing-bus departs at 6:15 a.m. The standing-Sal-tree's standing-koel continues to call at the standing-eleven-second repetition-cycle for the standing-following forty-seven minutes. Aranya-Mata sits at the standing-doorstep. She does not look at the standing-Sal-tree. She listens. She closes the standing-cottage-door at 7:02 a.m. She enters the standing-cottage. She prepares standing-mahua-tea for one. She drinks it at the standing-clay-floor at the standing-eastern-window. The standing-felled Saranatu-Sarna canopy-

absence is visible from the standing-window at the standing-eleven-kilometre distance. The standing-coal-whispers continue at the standing-North-Karanpura mine's standing-deep-seam-six at the standing-four-eleven-a.m. cadence each day at the standing-eleven-second repetition-cycle. The standing-mine is closed. There are no miners at the standing-coal-face to hear them. The standing-whispers continue regardless. The standing-Maw is no longer silent. The standing-Maw is taking notes. The standing-Maw is, at the standing-deep-seam-six, speaking the standing-grandmothers' standing-language to the standing-rock that does not need to listen.

Vanajara is at the standing-Pasanda-village standing-state-hero residence's standing-eastern-window. He listens for the standing-koel he cannot hear at the standing-eleven-kilometre distance. He hears the standing-wind across the standing-felled canopy-absence. He hears, just below the standing-wind, at the standing-resolved listening, the standing-three-word coal-seam phrase carried on the standing-deep-strata air-column: "Ah Sal, Ah Sarna". He stands at the standing-window for eleven minutes. He goes inside. He sits at the standing-clay-floor. He reads the standing-amended-charter's standing-Fifth-Provision for the standing-fifty-seventh time. He waits for spring. He waits for the standing-Sanctuary. He does not pretend the standing-mark will form before he arrives. He waits.

Vijayanagara Reborn

Hampi at dawn. Six months after the Festival of Living Stone. The musical pillars still hum at sunrise. The Vittala stone chariot still does not move. The cooking pots have been rebuilt. Ten thousand became thirty thousand. The mesh-network of villages now spans Bidar to Mangaluru, and the elephants of Karnataka pace their old routes through new villages that did not exist a year ago.

Tungabhadra walks the rebuilt Royal Enclosure with a child holding her left hand. The child is ten years old, brown-eyed, quiet. Her name is Hampi-of-the-Bronze. Tungabhadra pulled her from the rubble of the temple-quake six months earlier — the only survivor of that family — and named her for the warm bronze her four-year-old face was pressed against when Tungabhadra found her. The child rarely speaks. She reads people the way her foster-mother reads battlefields.

"The throne-stone," Hampi-of-the-Bronze says, pointing.

The throne-stone of Vijayanagara stands at the Royal Enclosure's eastern wall — a single piece of green chlorite the size of an elephant, carved with the lion-yali emblem of the empire. Tungabhadra has not sat on it. Nobody has. It is roped off and used as a teaching exhibit: this is what the empire built. This is what we build next to, not on top of.

"It is a stone," Tungabhadra says.

"It is a throne," the child says.

"It is a stone we are not using."

"That is what makes it a throne."

Tungabhadra is quiet. The Indian Roller — Neelakantha — flutters down from a broken gopuram and lands on her shoulder. The bird's blue throat catches the dawn light. Indian Rollers appear when buried truths are about to surface. Tungabhadra knows this. She does not yet know which buried truth.

The Karnataka Council meets in the rebuilt Hazara Rama courtyard at midday. Forty-seven elders. Trade delegates from Bengaluru. The Chief Engineer of New Hampi. Three representatives from the Mining Consortium, who have stopped funding stone-armies and are now respectfully participating in heritage governance. Hampi-Veera the Stone Dancer

stands behind Tungabhadra. Mysuru-Dhanush the Sandalwood Archer sits in the second row.

There is good news. Three new villages reached this season. The river-water mesh is operational across two more taluks. Twelve children born in Hampi this year were named after participants from the Festival.

And then a noblewoman stands up.

She is somewhere between forty and forty-five. Hair dressed in the old Vijayanagara court style — three braids meeting at a single silver pin. Bronze armor under a cream silk shawl, the way the queens of the fifteenth century wore it. She has been in the back row of every Karnataka Council meeting for three months. She has never spoken. She speaks now.

"I have brought the original Vijayanagara security blueprints. May I share them?"

The room goes still. Tungabhadra's mace hand does not move; her shoulder does. The Indian Roller leaves.

The noblewoman walks to the centre of the courtyard and unrolls a scroll across the council table. The scroll is large. The diagrams are precise. They are not modern reconstructions. They are the originals — copper-iron-walnut ink on hand-pressed Vijayanagara paper, signed in the lower right corner by the empire's chief vastu-architect in 1502.

The diagrams show the buried temple system Tungabhadra opened in Chapter One. They show its three sublevels. They show the serpent-network as a connected security infrastructure that ran beneath every major palace, mapped in the same careful hand as the irrigation canals and the elephant-stable foundations.

"This is not a curse," the noblewoman says, reading the room before the room reads her. "This is a vault. Vijayanagara built a security system designed to survive even a successful invasion. The empire fell because no one came to reactivate it. I am proposing that we reactivate it now."

The Mining Consortium representative leans forward. The Chief Engineer leans forward. Three of the elders lean forward. Tungabhadra does not lean.

"Who are you," she asks.

The noblewoman bows.

"My name is Bhoomi-Takshaka. I am of the dispossessed Anegondi branch of the old Vijayanagara line. I am the cousin you do not remember. I have not come to fight you. I have come to offer."

Bhoomi-Takshaka does not threaten. She offers. Over the following weeks she becomes the centre of every other conversation in Hampi. She publishes a thirty-page document called The Restoration Charter. It includes: re-occupation of the imperial throne-room, reactivation of the serpent-vault network for cybersecurity and physical-defence purposes, reinstatement of the dispossessed noble houses as a Heritage Council, and a public ceremony of imperial re-consecration to be held at the new moon.

The document is well-argued. It is footnoted. It does not call Tungabhadra anything cruel. It calls her the bridge-builder, the one who reopened the temple. It says: she did the work that prepared the empire's return. Now let the empire return.

Forty percent of the kingdom finds it persuasive.

Tungabhadra reads it three times. Each time she finds it harder to refute. The Restoration Charter is not wrong about everything. The empire did have security infrastructure. The dispossessed branches were real, with real grievances. Hampi-of-the-Bronze's own grandmother carried Bloodline-A nobility — that part of the document names her, correctly, with archival sources.

Sage Vidyaranya's spirit ripples in the Tungabhadra river that night. She walks to the rapids. She reads his message in the turbulence:

Cousin, this is a harder fight than the first one. The first villain wanted to destroy what you protect. The second one wants to restore what you cannot let return. Be very careful what you call this enemy. She is not Ravana-Putra. She is the empire that fell, knocking at the door, dressed for a wedding.

Three weeks before the new moon ceremony. A man comes to Tungabhadra's house at the second hour past midnight. He carries a leather case. He wears a craftsman's apron over an embroidered shirt. His face is the same as Bhoomi-Takshaka's. Identical bone-structure. Different eyes — hers are searching, his are tired.

"My name is Krishnadevaraya-Bhrata. I am her twin. I was born nine minutes after her. I have been her court architect for thirty-six years."

Tungabhadra has Gajadanda at her side before she has finished standing.

"I am not here to harm you," he says. "I am here because she has rigged sublevel three of the buried temple. The throne-stone chamber. If she successfully re-consecrates the empire on the new moon, the network will activate. If you stop the ceremony by force, she has set the chamber to collapse anyway. Either way the throne-stone will be either re-enthroned or buried with everyone inside it. She is not bluffing. I drew the blast-pattern myself, eleven years ago, for a different purpose."

He sets the leather case on the table. He opens it. The blueprints inside are the same blueprints Bhoomi-Takshaka brought to the council — except these have the demolition charges marked.

"Why are you giving me this?"

Krishnadevaraya-Bhrata sits on the floor. He looks like a man who has been waiting thirty-six years to sit.

"Because I love what Hampi could be. I do not love what my sister wants it to be. The empire was beautiful. The empire was also a thing that crushed the Hadali under its hooves before any invasion ever touched it. If we restore it, we restore the crushing. I have spent thirty-six years drawing rooms for a return I do not want."

"Why now?"

"Because the Indian Roller landed on your shoulder at the council. I saw it. I have read the same texts she has. The bird does not appear to the wrong side."

Hampi-of-the-Bronze is taken three days later.

It is legal. The Restorationists file a petition in the Karnataka Heritage Court arguing that the child is "ward of the imperial line" because her grandmother carried Bloodline-A nobility. The court grants the petition. Three uniformed officers come to Tungabhadra's house with the order. They are polite. They give Hampi-of-the-Bronze ten minutes to gather her things. They are not cruel.

The child does not cry. She looks at Tungabhadra and asks: "Will you come for me?"

"Yes."

"With the mace?"

"No. The mace would prove them right. Some other way. I will find it."

The child nods. She follows the officers out. The bronze of the broken pillar is in her pocket — she has carried it for six years. Tungabhadra watches her leave through the courtyard gate.

Tungabhadra does not sleep for two nights. On the third night she sits with Krishnadevaraya-Bhrata and the Chief Engineer and Sage Vidyaranya's voice in the river, and they begin to plan something that has not been done in Bharatavarsha in a thousand years.

The Indian Roller circles the buried temple. Krishnadevaraya-Bhrata stands at the river's edge with Tungabhadra. The full moon before the new moon is one week away.

"There is a third faction," Krishnadevaraya-Bhrata says. "You have ignored them. So has she."

"The Hadali."

"The Hadali. The Lambani communities the empire pushed out before it built itself. They live above Hosapete, along the forest edge. They have not attended a Karnataka Council in seventy years. They will not attend if you summon them. You have to go to them. Alone. With nothing."

"And ask them what."

"Ask them to bless the unmaking of the throne. The Restorationists need the throne re-occupied. The Reformers want the throne dissolved. Neither of you has the moral standing to do either. The Hadali do. They are the only people in Karnataka whose ancestors were not invited to the throne and who do not now want to be."

Tungabhadra walks the next morning. Alone. No mace. She wears a cooking pot at her hip — the same pot she carried from Bidar to Mysuru in Chapter One. She walks for four days. She arrives at the forest-edge hamlet above Hosapete in evening light.

The elder who meets her is eighty-three years old. His name is Veerappa-Hadali. He sits on a flat stone outside his hut. He does not stand for her.

"You came for what?"

"To ask you to come down to Hampi and be crowned king of Vijayanagara for one hour. Then to let me destroy the throne-stone in the same hour."

Veerappa-Hadali looks at her for a full minute.

"Why."

"Because if I destroy the throne without acknowledging it, I am the same as the empire that took it from you. If I acknowledge it without destroying it, I let it return. The throne has to be given to the people it was taken from, then given up by them. Only the Hadali have the right to give it up."

"And what do the Hadali get."

"A seat on the Karnataka Council that is permanent. A veto over any future imperial revival. The Lambani communities returned to their original forest-edge lands with formal title. And the public memory of being the people who chose to dissolve the empire."

Veerappa-Hadali is quiet for a long time. He looks at the cooking pot. He looks at Tungabhadra's bare feet. He looks at the sky.

"I will come. But I will not come for the seat or the title or the lands. I will come because I have wanted, for sixty years, to be the king who said no to a throne. You are offering me the only thing I have ever wanted that I refused to ask for."

The new moon. The Royal Enclosure of Hampi. Twenty thousand people from all three factions, side by side, in unprecedented configuration. The Restorationists have come in the old court silks. The Reformers in the working-clothes of New Hampi. The Hadali have come for the first time in seventy years, three hundred of them, in tribal cloth and forest jewelry.

The throne-stone is uncovered. The chlorite catches the moonlight.

Bhoomi-Takshaka stands at the eastern edge of the courtyard. She is dressed for re-consecration — white and gold, the imperial colours, the silver pin of the three-braid style. She does not speak. She does not need to. Her plan is already moving in the basement she designed.

Tungabhadra walks to the throne-stone with Gajadanda in her right hand and a jasmine garland in her left. Krishnadevaraya-Bhrata walks behind her with his sketchbook. Hampi-of-the-Bronze — released that morning by the Heritage Court under a separate order obtained by Krishnadevaraya-Bhrata's legal team — walks at Tungabhadra's left side, holding her wrist with a small bronze-stained hand.

Veerappa-Hadali walks last. The crowd parts for him. He climbs the dais slowly, with two driftwood sticks. He stops in front of the throne-stone.

"I, Veerappa-Hadali, of the Lambani-Hadali clan-line, accept the symbolic kingship of Vijayanagara for one hour, on the condition that within this hour the throne-stone of Vijayanagara is destroyed."

The Restorationists hiss. The Reformers do not breathe. The Hadali stand silent.

Tungabhadra places the jasmine garland on his shoulders. She steps back.

"By the dharma of return," she says, "I now give to the King of the Empire the right to dissolve the empire."

Veerappa-Hadali nods.

Tungabhadra and Krishnadevaraya-Bhrata lift Gajadanda together. The mace's iron remembers — it was forged from the elephant stables of Vijayanagara, the very stables Bhoomi-Takshaka's blueprints map. The mace knows what it is being used for. It does not resist.

They strike the throne-stone together. Once.

The chlorite cracks. A spiderweb of white runs from impact point to base. The cracks make a sound like falling glass. The whole stone shudders.

They strike a second time.

The throne-stone falls in two pieces. Then four. Then a dozen. The lion-yali emblem breaks at the lion's mouth, the way Tungabhadra-the-five-year-old once held a broken stone elephant in this same Royal Enclosure.

The crowd does not cheer. They have not been told to cheer. They are watching, twenty thousand of them, as the symbol of an empire that ruled the south for two centuries falls apart in front of them.

Then the ground shakes.

Bhoomi-Takshaka's serpent-network was wired to a single trigger — the destruction of the throne-stone. The moment the chlorite breaks, the demolition charges in sublevel three activate. The buried temple chamber begins to fold inward. The temple is directly below the Royal Enclosure dais.

Krishnadevaraya-Bhrata sees it first because he drew the blast-pattern. He grabs Hampi-of-the-Bronze and Veerappa-Hadali and pulls them off the dais. They roll into the crowd.

The crowd makes way.

Tungabhadra does not run. She turns toward Bhoomi-Takshaka.

Bhoomi-Takshaka is on the dais too. She has walked up during the strike. She is standing on the cracked stone, beside its broken half, with her own jasmine garland in her hands — the garland she had brought for her own re-consecration ceremony. She places it on the broken stone. Her face is calm.

"Cousin," she says.

"Cousin," Tungabhadra answers.

The dais is sinking now. The chamber below them is collapsing inward.

"You can leave," Tungabhadra says.

"So can you."

"I cannot leave the throne-stone for them to rebuild. Someone has to stay until it is rubble."

"That is the answer I gave myself thirty-six years ago. About a different throne."

They look at each other. The two Bloodline-A heirs. Two custodianships fighting each other to a draw. The elephant-bond between them flickers — it cannot choose. Two queens of the same animal, dying in the same chamber.

Tungabhadra raises Gajadanda one last time. She strikes the centre of the throne-stone with everything she has. The stone splits to dust. The dais collapses. She and Bhoomi-Takshaka fall together into the buried-temple chamber. The chamber collapses on them.

The collapse runs three minutes. When it stops, the Royal Enclosure has a hole in it where the throne-stone used to be. The hole is filled with rubble and chlorite-dust. Through the dust, a single Indian Roller flies straight up into the night sky.

The crowd is still. Twenty thousand people. No cheering. No mourning yet. Just the dust settling.

Veerappa-Hadali is the first to speak. He raises his right hand.

"My hour has ended. The throne is gone. I am no longer king."

He takes off the jasmine garland and places it on the rubble where the throne-stone was. He steps down from what is left of the dais.

The elephant of Hampi — Gajasena, the sacred animal of the kingdom, the one Tungabhadra's bond ran through — walks slowly into the Royal Enclosure. The crowd makes way. Gajasena is enormous, calm, the colour of monsoon stone. He stops in front of Krishnadevaraya-Bhrata, who is still holding Hampi-of-the-Bronze.

Gajasena lowers his head. His trunk touches Krishnadevaraya-Bhrata's forehead.

Krishnadevaraya-Bhrata feels it the way Tungabhadra once described it to him — a vibration through the soles of his feet, a memory not his own, the weight of every footstep in Hampi for five hundred years. The first stroke of the elephant-tattoo flares across his right shoulder-blade as if drawn by an invisible hand. He is Bloodline A. The bond knows him. The bond settles.

He sinks to his knees, partly from the shock, partly from grief, partly because that is the appropriate posture for what has happened. Hampi-of-the-Bronze does not let go of his hand.

The bird returns. The Indian Roller lands on his other shoulder. Its blue throat shines.

A child appears in the rubble.

He is roughly five years old. He is untouched by the chlorite-dust — his clothes are clean, his hair is clean, his face is bronze-coloured and quiet. He is standing on the edge of the broken throne-stone where his foster-mother fell. He does not speak. His shadow falls in the wrong direction — slightly off-angle, as if some other light is touching him from a direction the moon is not in.

Hampi-of-the-Bronze sees him first. She walks toward him. She does not run, she does not call out. She walks until she is next to him. She takes his hand.

She turns to Krishnadevaraya-Bhrata.

"This is the third," she says.

The phrase makes no sense to anyone in the crowd. It makes sense to Krishnadevaraya-Bhrata, because the bond now in his body remembers what Tungabhadra knew without ever having been told: there are signs of the Void Maw walking Bharatavarsha. Two have appeared elsewhere. The third has just appeared here. This child is one of them.

He does not raise Gajadanda. He does not call for the child to be detained. He walks to the bronze-dust child and kneels in front of him.

"Your name?"

The child does not answer.

"You will stay with us. We will give you a name. We will remember you the way we remembered everyone we lost."

The bronze-dust child reaches out and touches Krishnadevaraya-Bhrata's tattoo. The single elephant-stroke pulses once. The child's shadow corrects itself, falls in the same direction as everyone else's, for one moment. Then drifts back out.

Above the Royal Enclosure, in the new-moon dark, an Indian Roller appears that is not one of Karnataka's — its blue is a different blue. It has flown from Kerala. It carries a folded slip of paper in its beak. It lands on Krishnadevaraya-Bhrata's open palm and drops the paper there.

The paper is in old Parashurama's hand. He is fifty-nine. He has been the saga's oldest hero. He writes:

The 109th form has students now. Kala-Hasta teaches it openly. I have one place left in the 108-form school for someone who can hold both. The bond came to you tonight. I felt it. Send the heir. The heir is you. Come to Kerala.

Krishnadevaraya-Bhrata folds the paper. He looks at Hampi-of-the-Bronze. He looks at the bronze-dust child. He looks at Veerappa-Hadali. He looks at the broken throne-stone and the dust that was Tungabhadra and his sister.

He says, quietly, more to the night air than to the crowd:

"The empire is not the stone. The empire is what we choose to do with what is left. I will go to Kerala."

The Hadali drums begin. Slow at first. They are not celebrating. They are marking. The drums are the rhythm of an old Lambani lament, played at the death of an ancestor and at the birth of a new one in the same hour. The drums say both at once.

The Indian Roller from Karnataka and the Indian Roller from Kerala fly together once around the Royal Enclosure and depart in opposite directions. The bird from Kerala

carries Krishnadevaraya-Bhrata's silent acceptance. The bird from Karnataka carries the first word of the next chapter to every kingdom in Bharatavarsha.

The word is: The mouth has opened. The Council must sit.

The Pilot's Closing Image

Two Indian Rollers in the new-moon dark, flying in opposite directions over the rubble of the Vijayanagara throne-stone. Below them: a Bloodline-A man with a new tattoo, a ten-year-old girl with bronze in her pocket, an eighty-three-year-old uncrowned Hadali king, and a five-year-old child whose shadow falls in the wrong direction. Above them: a sky that is, for one second, two moons.